The Siege of Alexandria

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31048928.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Julius Caesar/Cleopatra, Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Cleopatra, Julius Caesar, Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Cleopatra VII of Egypt

Additional Tags:
Canon Lesbian Relationship, Canon Lesbian Character, Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Developing Relationship, Drama, Drama & Romance, Action & Romance, Slow Burn, Strangers to Lovers, Action/Adventure, Adventure, Adventure & Romance, Road Trips, Melancholy, Drunk Adora (She-Ra), Drunk Catra (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Real World, Ancient Egypt, Ancient Rome, Ceasar & Cleopatra, real history, History Lessons, Inspired by Real Events, Ancient Politics, Minor Violence, Forced Marriage, This Is Not Going To Go The Way You Think, Slowest slow burn ever written, A lot of ancient goddesses, Unbelievable many footnotes with history stuff, i wrote this for me but you can read it if you want, Alexandria AU

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The Siege of Alexandria

by 21st_tikonda

Summary

Adora Diana Minor is a young patrician woman of the influential Roman *gens Julia*. The daughter of the governor of Syria and niece to Caesar is sent to Egypt to strengthen the Julian bonds to the important Roman ally through an unwanted marriage. Can Adora find a way out of this?
Catra Meritamun is an Egyptian noblewoman of Nubian heritage. She rules a settlement and fortress at the Nile on behalf of Pharaoh Cleopatra. She is called to the Egyptian royal court to fulfill her duties to the realm. Soon, Catra will have to make a terrible decision.

This is a heavily drama loaded #Catradora in Ancient Egypt AU. It's about their paths through a turning point of history, and they'll witness, and take part in some of the most important events of this time. How did Cleopatra and Caesar met? Was Alexandria the only thing to be besieged? How can Adora and Catra prevail against the forces that helped empires to glory and turned them into ashes?

And did Catra set the world on fire?

(It is relatively fandom-blind, so you can read this even if you don't know anything about the fandom.)

Notes


1

Hello there!
This is the second story I'm putting on AO3. The first one is here. As before, I wrote this story for me, but you can read it if you like.

Beside a necessary explanation in the next prelude chapter, this will be the only foreword I'll do, and beside a lot of footnotes, you won't hear from me again until the end. This is a book and not a telenovela. I won't ruin your experience by making fun of you and steal away suspense with my oh-so-clever remarks.
Because of language and tonality, this work is rated "M", with a leaning towards "T".

That being said, here you have background in a tolerable form, but it's totally skippable. I's background, but really not important.

I came up with the idea for this story because of a picture by Ooka, who I also commissioned with drawings. Give her a like or follow because she really deserves it for making stunning art).
My thought was: Adora in something that looked like a legionary's uniform? How could that happen? And what possibilities would that mean for me to boast around with ancient thesaurus words? Oh, good goddess, I couldn't let this opportunity slip. I began to research: How could Adora and Catra fit into our ancient world? In what era and which place? And I quickly discovered that the best site and time would be the one point where the Greco-Roman world mingled with Ptolemaic Egypt. Exactly, at Cleopatra's time. Catra as of Nubian heritage, while Adora clearly being a Roman patrician. Hah! That would fit well. And now for some drama? Easy pick. And some action? Let's see… and all was quite easy.

The Siege of Alexandria is well known to historians, but less so to the public, despite being one of the turning points of history for the Roman Republic and later Empire as well as for the (Ptolemaic) Kingdom of Egypt. Know that the alliance and relationship between Caesar and Cleopatra had its origin in this event. The only eyewitness report still available today is "Commentarii de bello Alexandrino", written by Caesar and his generals, so, a rather one-sided view and a military account of the events.
Cleopatra was 21 at the time, maybe not an overwhelming beauty but a vivid young woman, intelligent, witty, and, most important, a Pharaoh of Egypt. Due to mostly Roman propaganda and general victor's justice, there are no longer any primary sources, such as letters from Cleopatra, which would allow a firsthand clarification of her personality. As always, actions speak louder than words: at the age of 20, she rallied an army on her own, spoke more than six languages and turned out to be a strategic mastermind.
When he met her, Caesar was 52, marked by decades of politics and 15 years of constant war, a titan of his era. He was the most powerful man of the period, threw away old traditions and turned the Roman Republic into the Empire.
This story will use accurate history as a background. But I will condense and narrow the events, and I will take some liberties due to plot and dramatic reasons.

Be not scared! This will be a Catradora-centric, relationship-focused drama with action and adventure, mutual bantering, boasting, giggling and such. We have melancholy, history lessons and high politics. There will be violence, because a fucking war is going on, there is racism and total patriarchy because the Romans were like this and of course people swore and weren't any decent. But this stuff will be non-descriptive and without gore and such. This work is supposed to be gripping, but all in all it will be light-hearted, and despite the slow burn, it will have pace. Imagine it like a road trip, because it fucking will be one.

So, have fun while I noodle out, how Adora and Catra could have influenced the events of the time, against the odds and the most powerful people on earth?
And how they could - maybe - gonna win in the end.
The tides for all the ancient world are turning, and nobody will come out of this unharmed.

Prelude - The actual work summary

Chapter Notes

> Please note: this chapter is the actual work summary, because AO3 has a character limit for summaries and notes. So, this is kind of an introduction, a setup. Picture it like a mix of a random Star Wars intro with the intro of Gladiator (2000).
> And a last hint, before we dive into it: if I'm linking to a certain music, it is especially mentioned to work for the immediately following scene, to support the intended atmosphere. Use it, if possible. Do not wait to put it on, it's useless later.

("Secrets", Deezer / Spotify / YouTube)

The year is 48 BCE.
The Republic is in turmoil.
The Great Roman Civil War is spanning the length of the Mediterranean world.

One year prior, Gaius Julius Caesar crossed the Rubikon and set everything on fire. Under the lead of Pompeius Magnus, the Senate of the Roman Republic battles the former Consul and most admired General all across the Mare Nostrum. Rome is divided, and its many legions are torn between the two former friends and relatives.
At the same time, a sibling's war for the reign ravages the glorious and wealthy Kingdom of Egypt, where the Ptolemaic dynasty fights a bloody war for the throne. Cleopatra VII Thea Philopator, 20 years old, rightful Pharaoh of Egypt alongside her brother Ptolemy XIII, was forced to flee out of Alexandria and her land, after she rebelled against the influence of her brother's puppeteers. Now she returns to Egypt, with an army behind, to claim the throne again. The land is as divided as Rome is, and both empires are shaken to their foundations and on the edge of doom.

The most famous and decisive incident of this conflict will play out during the **Siege of Alexandria**, in the greatest city of the time. Caesar and Cleopatra ally, outnumbered and beleaguered by the rebelling Egyptian army, led by Cleopatra's brother and his infamous councilmen.

At their side, **two young women** struggle with the demands of their families and their obligations to their heritage and future alike.

Adora Diana Minor is a young patrician of the influential gens Julia, daughter of the Governor of Syria and a niece to Caesar. She is sent to Egypt to strengthen the Julian bonds to the Roman ally through an unwanted marriage. Can Adora find a way out of this?

Catra Meritamun is an Egyptian noblewoman of Nubian heritage. She rules the settlement and fortress of Buhen at the Second Cataract of the Nile on behalf of Pharaoh Cleopatra. She is called to the Egyptian royal court to fulfill her duties to the realm - and to her sister. Soon, Catra will have to make a terrible decision.

Welcome to the Siege of Alexandria, the turning point of the ancient world, where we see the wonders of the time. We see Alexandria the Great. We see the Lighthouse of Pharos and the Temples of the ancient Pharaohs. And we see Adora and Catra, who stand against all odds and against the forces, who helped empires to glory and turned them to ashes.

Welcome to 48 BCE. Please, enjoy.

Is this a joke?

Chapter Summary

Adora is surprised. Her father is no help.
The Vanguard of the End Times sends a ship.
And said ship is sailing.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Antiochia, Syria & the Mediterranean Sea - July / August, 48 BCE

Adora

...and this is why the death of Ptolemy VI is important to the current state of Egypt. When we see Ptolemy XIII and Cleopatra VII struggling for the control of their realm, then this is foremost —"

"Adooooora!"

I sighed and lowered the scroll I just read. Why couldn't I be left alone for even one hour? Hadn't I had my share of lessons and chores for today? But no, of course not. Instead, *this* woman was after me, always. For years, since she had moved in with my father. Or rather since she had clawed herself into his life and started to strangle said life out of everyone under his authority. Unfortunately it was mostly me who was object to her torment. Frankly, it was exhausting, even for me.

"Adooorra!"

Time to go, I realized and propped myself up from sitting on the balcony, where I had found doubtful shelter for the last hour, with my feet hanging down and my head against the balustrade. I'd been reading and looking at the outside from time to time. It was nice to watch between the little columns of the balustrade, because of the beautiful sight over the fields and outskirts of Antiochia. Sometimes, when I was bored to death from the never-ending nothingness my life consisted of, I sneaked outside, climbed a rock just outside our estate, and looked over the great city. It soothed me. The balcony didn't have the same good view, but it was a good place to study - exhibit A: the scroll I just read, still in my hand!
Besides the daily chores of a loving daughter, a loving *stepdaughter* and my training, I lived the life of a child of a wealthy and influential Roman statesman. With all its perks and disagreements.

And it felt like ash. Boring. Like a life wasted. Like something was missing.

"Adorrrra!"

Ah, she was getting angry. Every time the 'o' started to vanish and was replaced by an 'r", the situation got worse.
"I'm coming!" I shouted dutifully, and fixed some strains of my hair with a few hairpins. *Mother* hated it when some of them were hanging loose in my face, and I *hated* it when she touched me to brush them away. So I always tried to avoid that in the first place. Not really a concession. Maybe I wasn't the most clever girl in the world, but so much I knew. All in all, I actually was a dutiful daughter to my house - and wanted it to be.
I hurried through the Peristylium, the large courtyard in the middle of our house- or rather 'estate' because nothing in this oversized Villa Rustica had the decent scale of a normal house. It had a water basin in the middle of it, used for cooling and - occassionally - refreshing during the many hot days and nights. My way lead beside the basin and over to the rooms of my stepmother. She had three, just for her own.

“Mother,” I greeted her when I stepped through the door arch and, upon the realization, immediately stopped and bowed tightly, as was appropriate in the presence of strangers. Because such a stranger was sitting across from her at the small, round table right beneath the window on the other side of the Cubicula[1]. An unusual place for meeting guests, it shot through my mind. “Apologies. I wasn’t aware that we have visitors. I would’ve dressed more appropriate then."

The tall and elder man, clothed in the habit of a well-equipped traveler, rose and bowed, speaking: “I'm devastated to contradict you, young domina, but there is nothing you could have done to suit and present yourself in a better way.”
His speech contradicted his military haircut, which showed an incipient bald head. I wondered why I noticed it. I also wondered about his words. My clothes consisted only of a simple tunic, I had well-worn sandals on my otherwise bare feet and just a golden bracelet on each arm as jewelry. A few hairpins kept my hair from hanging loose, but in my opinion, I must’ve looked quite… ordinary, I thought.

And of course *she* did as well, judging from the way she ogled me. But she also hadn’t given me any warning upfront, so this had been her intention all along. *Smug bitch,* I thought by myself and waited for her to speak up.
As the youngest daughter of my father - my elder sister already being married to a wealthy Roman plebeian - I was just Adora Diana *Minor*, the younger child. And despite being 23 years old, according to Roman law I was still under his guardianship. And that of my stepmother, as far as she was concerned. Ugh!

“Adora, dear. Please welcome our guest, the honorable Alexas of Laodikeia, Emissary of the rightful queen and Pharaoh of Egypt, Cleopatra IIV Thea Philopator.”
Bewildered, it just blurted out of me. “Pharaoh? Cleopatra? Really?” I drew it out a bit. “Isn’t she battling for the throne right now and still stuck in the Nile delta for the time being? While her brother, the *actual Pharaoh* is sitting on the throne in Alexandria?"[2] I didn’t really think about my words, they just

slipped out of my mouth. Maybe the topic of my previous studies was still lingering in the back of my brain.

Ptolemies. A bunch of murderous occupants. Preyed on the land for 300 years, bringing little more than oppression to the Egyptian inhabitants. And with us before their gates, they got desperate. Besides, my words were the pure truth. My stepmother froze upon them and narrowed her eyes in anger. "Adora! Apologize immediately. Cleopatra is the only rightful Pharaoh, and it must not be questioned with unneeded contradiction."
Upon her scolding, my hands fisted instinctively, and I felt it. Alexas, however, waved a hand to her and replied: "Never mind. It's true, and it was a precise description of the situation. You seem to be well-informed about the… geopolitical situation in my land." His smile seemed to be genuine, but the look in his eyes didn't really match up.

I bowed my head again. "My apologies. I just might have lost the… overview in the constant struggles of the Ptolemaic dynasty to create something like a regular working process when handing over the reign to the next generation."
That was also true. Nobody had an overview because of the speed the respective Ptolemaic relatives kept murdering each other. Even Berenice, Cleopatra's own elder *sister* , had been beheaded just a few years ago. By her own father. She was 22.
He smirked, and his reply was not unexpected. "Understandable, young domina, absolutely understandable. They are quite… busy, one can say. But - I would like to add with all due respect - isn't the same true for the current struggles the great Roman Republic is going through?"

I had to admit he had a point there. From the outside, the current state of Res Publica was a mess. And from the inside… it was a mess too. Of course, we were behaving like a drunken squad of legionaries in a tavern and all of that bullshit was below our whole Dignitas and Gravitas[3]. The Republic was severely struggling in these years and my own family played a huge part in it. A very huge part. Most of all, my uncle.
But I would never admit that to some half-barbarian Ptolemaic,

who somehow had been able to learn to read and write and to speak properly in this barbaric land.
Because, after all, we were SPQR! We were the Senate and People of Rome, the mightiest nation on earth, ruler of the Mediterranean world under the grace and favor of the gods. And not some lousy river-based tribe at the edge of the known world.[4]

"We will sort it out, as always. The Senate—" I was cut short by her.
"...is nothing of our concern right now. We should focus on the topic at hand and upon the reason Alexas of Laodikeia had made his way to us."
I furrowed my eyebrows and ogled her. "And what might that be?"
Alexas sat still and looked at her, a bit uneasy maybe?
And so was I as I asked: "Mother?"
She cocked her head and pulled out the most terrifying weapon she had. She was smiling. It sent shivers down my spine. "Your father and I think it is time for you to consider a more… serious relationship in your life."

My mouth said "What?" and my mind yelled '*WHAT?*'

Nooo! That can't be. This isn't serious or is it? No, never!
She continued despite my internal dispute. "Alexas is a tutor and confidante of Cleopatra. Your father discussed the matter of your still unbound status with the family council and decided that a… stronger connection of the *gens Julia*[5] with our Egyptian allies would be helpful in the upcoming times. We need a family bond with the one of the future ruler of this land."

Family council, of course. Pah! He had discussed it with uncle Gaius.
Uncle Gaius Julius.
As in Gaius Julius Caesar.
As in Pontifex Maximus, Praetor, Propraetor, Consul, Proconsul, Consul again and Imperator Gaius Julius Caesar.
The conqueror of the Gauls and butcher of millions.
The one who refused disbanding his legions after his office ended.
The one who crossed the Rubicon with them.

The one who’s battling the armies of the Roman Senate, led by his former ally, friend, and even son-in-law, Pompeius Magnus, in this very moment at Dyrrhachium.

That one.

Despite my first reaction, I was to bewildered to come up with a well-thought answer and so my next question was: “Does Cleopatra need some noble Roman women for her harem?”
There'd always been rumors about Cleopatra, but I didn't take them serious and my father would never allow something like this. Dignitas and such. I was just doing bad jokes to distract my troubled mind.

My stepmother’s face got sour, but Alexas chuckled about my antics and said: “No, Adora, that won’t be… necessary. But in fact, I’m here under Cleopatra’s order and on behalf of Psamtik IV, governor of the wonderful and mighty Thēbais at the Nile, ruling upon and under Cleopatra’s kind reign, praise be to her."
I frowned: “Psamtik? Never heard of him. And isn’t Thēbais a mere ruin today, vanishing in the sand?”
Alexas smirked and replied: “Oh no, Thēbais is thriving again under Psamtik’s reign. He’s building a completely new city there and does great things. Before Cleopatra was forced to flee out of Hut-Ka-Ptah, she took refuge in the Thēbais and ordered the beginning of several projects. Psamtik is the one carrying them out. Maybe you’ve heard of him under his epithet. He’s mostly called *Hordak* by his peers and subjects."

Oh!

I had heard of him, though.

I turned to *her* : “Is this a joke, mother?” My face must have betrayed my emotions clearly enough because I could see the amusement in her eyes.
She let her voice sound concerned when she answered: “I wouldn’t joke about something important like that, Adora. An alliance of our family with an important governor, who is on the

rise under Cleopatra's reign, will do enormous good on our behalf. Egypt is of the utmost importance for the supply of the empire. And it's not like that you have many… admirers today."
That was nothing to ponder about. I didn't need any admirers.
"This is ridiculous. I won't be married to some Egyptian guy. This contradicts our whole traditions," I insisted. "I won't be given away like a present to some barbarian."
"These aren't the times for obsolete traditions anymore. Rome will starve without the Egyptian grain supplies. And Caesar wants to avoid having the land… integrated into the republic. If a marriage between our family and an important Egyptian governor can be of help, he would be an idiot to turn this possibility down. And with Cleopatra back on the throne, you'll be spending more time in Alexandria than anywhere else."
"Maybe. But that's got nothing to do with me. Uncle Gaius can't just order me to marry someone."
His eyes were calm and steady. "I assume that you should talk to your father before cena[6] then?"
She couldn't be serious there, could she? That wasn't just possible. But this Alexas guy seemed to be absolutely confident. What kind of charade was this? My heart was racing and I was too agitated to think clear. I needed to calm.
"I will, mother. Of course, I will." I bowed my head to Alexas, and muttered: "I apologize, I have duties." Then I rushed out and left in the search of my only friend, the Iuvenis Sagittarius, our master archer. Or just 'Bow', as I called him.

After searching around for some time, I finally found him in the frigidarium, where he was sitting and stretching his limbs, after cooling down in the cold water of the basin. I took off my sandals and settled down beside him.
Bow opened his eyes and threw me a little smile, unaware of my current problem. "Adora, what a pleasure."
"Hmm," I muttered. The tonality in which I did it gave it away.
"What's bitten you?"
"The vile bitch," I whispered. Not too loud, because she had her eyes and ears everywhere.
"By the gracious Diana, Adora. What did she do this time?" he

asked, a bit unmotivated because he was used about my complaining about her to him.
I splashed my feet in the water and pondered how to tell.
“Come on, Adora, you will tell me anyway, won’t you?”
Sighing, I opened my mouth, only to shut it again like a fish. Speaking of of m it felt like acknowledging it. It didn't feel good.
“She wants me to marry some Egyptian governor for the sake of the gens. And all I’m thinking is to throw up. This just can’t be true. She must be joking.”
Bow joked too, not taking it seriously. “Wouldn’t that be a good thing at all? You’ll have an important husband, seldom at home, not a care in the world?”
“That’s just dumb, Bow. If I’m taking this seriously, I would be a slave! A slave to the diplomatic forces of powerful men![7] Of my own family! Ugh!”
He nodded, now concerned. “Can she do this? What’s with your father?”
“She said it was his idea.” I didn’t believe a word of what she said, I noticed. This must’ve been some kind of lousy joke of hers.
Bow nudged my shoulder. “Hmm...so… you should talk with him first?”

“Of course I will, right before cena. He’s outside, somewhere in Antiochia, I think. I just wanna pass the time until he comes back. Otherwise, I think I’m going crazy.”
And that was right, actually. He nodded again. “I see. Sooo, tell me, what’s frightening you most?”
“That I’m gonna be married to some scary old dude with needs, maybe? And I don’t want to live in Egypt, bona dea! They are murdering each other over there.”
He still hadn’t bought into the whole thing. “Okay, relatable. But we keep murdering ourselves here as well, right? And, honestly, is this so surprising? It’s not that something like this is… totally unexpected, is it?” his casualness about the topic didn't come from being unconcerned. Such marriages were to be expected. It was pure luck I wasn't already.

And he was right. Me being married in a political maneuver had always been a possibility. I had just had the stupid hope my father would somehow… forget about it, forget about me being used as a tool, like my sister. We hadn't spoken about the matter for months now, and that had given me false security. Only now I realized how stupid I had been: of course, the nasty bitch had schemed behind my back and persuaded my father on this. Did he give in?

For a young woman, daughter of a Roman patrician and a member of an important gens, being used as a connection to other mighty families was common. Most of the important Roman families were related to each other. Not that this strategy had helped in any way. They kept slaughtering each other for centuries and right now, they were even playing with the entire Republic. With my own family on the forefront.

"Adora?"
Bow pulled me out of my train of thought and I smiled weakly. "Yeah, I'll talk to him," not responding to his answer.

We went for some training in the gymnasium, despite him having already done his exercises for today. But it helped me getting distracted until I could talk to my father, and Bow never hesitated to help me. So the afternoon went by quickly. We did some light defense and attack routines as well as some archery. This clearly wasn't the typical education for a typical daughter of a Roman nobleman, but my father wanted me to be able to defend myself, at least to some extent. Courtesy given to our frequent travels and relocations. I got pretty decent in mastering bow and arrow, throwing daggers and things like that. Bow, of course, lived up to his name and profession and could even shoot an arrow through mine, if he wanted. Most times, he spared me the embarrassment. Most times.

It must have been the tenth hour when my father finally entered the villa, accompanied by two of his legionaries. They stopped beside the stables and ge just got off his horse when I had already stormed at his side and asked, or rather insisted: "Is it

true?”
Of course, he knew what I was talking about. He didn’t look me in the eye while he briefly groomed the horse and replied: “Filia.”
By speaking the formal word, he not so subtly reminded me of my place and furthermore his place, as holder of the Patria Potestas[8].
“We shall talk in my room, I suppose.”
I composed myself, bowed briefly and said: “Of course, pater.”

I followed him with a drooping head to the cubicula he used for work. It wasn’t a large room, just a desk, three chairs and a window to the peristylium. After he shut the door behind us, my submissive expression disappeared.
“Father, how could you?” I already knew from his behavior that he’d been hiding it from me. It was upsetting.
He didn’t reply immediately, obviously pondering about a fitting and calming answer. But he surprised me when he said: “I have no apology for you. In fact, even I don’t want it, but Caesar—” I cut him short.
I never did that.

“It’s always about him. Always about Caesar and his great plans. He will plunge the whole family into disaster, that much is certain.”
I pulled my hair. I felt my blood rushing and somehow my vision darkened. So, it was true, they'd schemed behind my back, to sell me like cattle on the market, on behalf of the oh-so-important gens.
“Possible.” His reply was short and nailed it to the point nonetheless. “But he is the current and formal head of the gens Julia, and we have to obey. I wouldn't be here if it wasn't for him. And now, the fate of our entire familiy is on the edge. If he loses this war, we'll all be doomed. So, yes, he ordered me that you have to meet Psamtik, while he and Cleopatra will discuss a marriage. Also, Adora, you have to admit that time has come.” He didn’t elaborate, but I knew where this was going. I just was trying not to collapse.
“Bona dea, father, really? You also? Isn’t it enough that… this woman wants me out of the house as soon as possible?”
I really hated her, now more than ever.

He shook his head. “This is barely her doing. You know very well that women of our family are simply not allowed to stay alone and be unmarried, not until they consecrate themselves to the service of Vesta. Our gens is not the largest, but we have duties and obligations. And tell me, do you want to join the college of the Vestals, Adora? Be a priestess for 30 years?”
I folded my arms with a - hopefully - grim look. “That doesn’t look so unattractive right now, father. Being in Rome, even as a sworn virgin, sounds way better than marrying some horrible old Egyptian who sweats all the time.”
I may have sounded a bit sarcastic, but to be honest, the thought itself wasn’t so far-fetched. Noblewomen could avoid being married by serving the gods. At the cost of 30 years of their life, living in the temple of Vesta in Rome. It wasn't an unattractive life. And would it be so different from an unwanted marriage? The thought alone made me sick again.

“Hordak is no Egyptian, he’s a Greek. He's an alien there, just as you would be," my father retorted, as if that made anything better.
I sighed. “My point still stands.”
He got a little unnerved. “Adora, I think it would be best to settle the matter for the time being. Caesar was sincere in his order and as pater familias, he’s the one to decide. Yes, I could oppose him, but the cost would be tremendous - for *all* of us - and so, I won’t do it. You will meet him and then we'll see. Maybe Gaius and Cleopatra develop other plans in the meantime, maybe the circumstances will change, maybe the gods will intervene. Who knows. But what I know is that you can't stay in this house for the rest of your life, and you can't stay unmarried as well."

I was upset. I was angry. I had to avoid clenching my fists. After a few deep breaths and upon his words, I did a closer look at him. His strong figure was the same as it has always been, but his hair had... grayed. I never noticed it before, but he looked a bit tired. And despite my despair about something I didn’t want and possibly couldn’t avoid, I felt a bit of compassion.
Maybe he had fought against uncle Julius’ demands and couldn't tell me because he lost?

How could he even dare to try that, if a million Gauls hadn't succeeded in that either?

And my next thought was, could I?

He managed a weak smile before he continued. "Try to look at it that way, daugther: you and her will no longer be able to torment each other on a daily basis. And leading your own household could be… interesting. It's not like you have to fulfill the role of a loving wife and to anticipate his every wish. Maybe you don't even need to see him much. He's a politician, a governor. He'll be away most of the time. And you'll have a household on your own, I think, overseeing all the people and servants, maybe even the guards and so on. Maybe you can take a larger role, even? Give the thought a chance, Adora. It could be worse."

That was right, actually. High-born marriages amongst the noble families of Rome often consisted of both spouses ignoring each other as well as they could. And with women being excluded from political offices, men had their own playground. Mostly messing it up. But it meant that women took charge of nearly all other family-related matters.
My father went on with his too obvious praise. "I heard Psamtik is doing great things in rebuilding Thēbais. Reinventing the means of agriculture, reform of production and similar. Maybe he is an interesting man? He is even not that old at all, in his late thirties, as far as I know. And he's influential."

I blocked the thought from deep inside. Even the anticipation of some man touching me made me uncomfortable, and I didn't really understand why - beside all the forced-marriage-thing.
"But father! I don't even know him. I heard he's some kind of… creepy? And what about actual love?"

That was no argument, I saw it in an instant. And of course, I could've known, dumb me. This pitiable man had been locked in an unloving and unwanted marriage for more than a decade now - with my *beloved* stepmother, Ugh! - and hadn't complained even once. Family first was his whole motto, when he had complied

with the family council then. The good old Roman virtues, yay!
"Love is no concept for families like us, Adora. We serve. I don't think I have to emphasize on that matter, or do I, filia?"

I winced at the word. It was the second reminder of my position and his rights to determine about myself - or rather about my own rights to determine about myself, which amounted to exactly *nothing* .
I could argue, yell, pout or beg.
In the end, my father was to decide upon my every fate, and he would do it. Maybe not without hesitation or an apology. But he would do what he thought had to be done and if uncle Julius pressed him on that, he would comply for the sake of the gens.

I sighed. "As you wish, father." It wasn't the time to argue further. I would back off for now, hopefully being able to undermine his plans - uncle Julius' plans - later. I'd done that before. Maybe I could find a way out? I just needed some time to think. To make up ideas.
"Good girl," he said and gave me a gentle kiss on the forehead. I frowned upon the unexpected and rare display of affection. But while I was leaving his cubicula and walking back to my room, I realized that he had meant it as some kind of apology. He never did that, and I was a bit disconcerted.

Not that it helped, in any way.

Back in my room on the first floor, I sat down at the balcony and let my feet hang loose. The view over Antiochia had always been a good distraction. Our villa lay in the northwest of the city, beside the small river Orontes and on a terrain that was a bit elevated. So I had a fine overlook over a good part of Antiochia. After the Roman occupation — eh — *incorporation* of Syria as a province into the Roman Republic, Antiochia started to grow quickly. With around 200,000 citizens, it was now one of the largest cities in the eastern Mediterranean, only surpassed by the great Alexandria in Egypt and maybe Korinthos in Greece. All of them were only surpassed by Rome itself. And under the leadership of my father, Antiochia had been thriving again.

But today, the view wasn't calming. It was just frightening, with glimpses of sorrow, because I was going to lose all the familiar view very soon.

Cena. Dinner.
I sat between my father and Bow. Today's dinner was a bit more generous and lavish than usual. Having a guest was always the most important reason to have a long-drawn cena. And honestly, Alexas was a good entertainer. He talked about minor events at the palace of Alexandria, rambled about the struggles of the government to keep a plague of locusts at bay, and told an insanely funny story about the time he once brought a honeycomb and a jackass to a brothel, [9] to the surprise of the madam. Everyone cackled upon his vibrant tales except *her*, of course. She looked as sour as she always did, but anyway, it wasn't very hard to enjoy the evening, despite the lingering doom of being sent away all too soon, and I was surprisingly relaxed. Maybe it was still just too far away.

Bow leaned over to me and asked quietly: "You seem to be good. Have you changed his mind?"
I shook my head in denial. "Of course not. He isn't glad about the whole thing either, but uncle Julius pressures him. He can't deny his wishes and I doubt he really wants to. However, it doesn't seem to be settled for sure. I think the least thing I'll have to do is to meet this guy. Until then we'll see. Maybe there will be some opportunities to… avoid all of this." I really tried to convince myself of that.
"Oh," was his whole reply. He considered it a bit, then came back: "I assume we have to travel to Thēbais then?"

I hadn't really thought about what the next steps would be, but I blamed it on the state of shock and confusion I still was in.
But while pondering about his words, I realized that meeting with Psamtik would mean to travel to Egypt, actually. But not Thēbais at first. My foremost aim would be the Nile delta, where Cleopatra had set up her campsite. I had to present and introduce myself to the woman who had been and claimed to be Pharaoh again. She controlled enough of Egypt, that even without sitting on the actual

throne, she had the influence and power to thread this.
Without her personal permission and approval, no further ado would've been necessary. A possible way out, also, if I could make up some good plan to convince her to send me back to my family.
And there was one more chance to meet another man, who also had a say over my fate. Because I knew who would be heading to Egypt too - if he'd survived the next weeks.
I pulled a corner of my mouth and said to Bow: "We'll see, my friend. We'll see."

And I saw.

A week later a message arrived. Uncle Julius had fought his battle against his former friend and now sworn enemy, Pompeius, at Dyrrhachium in Illyria, and it had ended in a tie. Other times would've seen it as a victory because Caesar's 15,000 men withstood Pompeius' 45,000 there. But finally, due to treason, bad luck and miscommunication, he had to withdraw and was now on the run to Thessalía, to rest and regroup.

It left me in a weird state. On one side, I was afraid. If the senate beat Caesar, no one was to say what would happen to us. My father was governor of Syria, of course, and therefore a powerful man with thousands of legionaries under his command. But they were guarding the borders to the Parthian Empire, and it was very unsure if they would follow a call to arms on behalf of my father if he was forced to oppose the Senate. We'd better avoided that, so much I knew. A possible outcome could be that he would be stripped of his ranks and could lead the life of a normal Roman patrician afterward - out of Rome, of course, but alive. Another outcome would be our mutual death. Marius, Cinna, and Sulla could tell us.

On the other hand lingered the possibility that, without Caesar's pressure and orders, I wouldn't have to marry some Egyptian douche at all. A tempting alternative.

But the same messenger also brought a note, that father should ready everything for my departure to Egypt. Caesar expected

another decisive battle with Pompeius any day and - in case of his victory - he wanted to waste no time. The man was incredible. Never giving up, never resting for a minute. Cleopatra would send a ship on my behalf, to guide me to Alexandria. She had been in Lower Syria the last months to hire an army and rally support for her struggle with her brother, but now she was back in Egypt, in Pelousion, facing a superior army just across a Nile arm. I assumed this had something to do with this whole plot.

Caesar's next aim would be Egypt too, before returning to Rome. Without securing the wealthy and grain-supplying kingdom under his control, a victory over the Senate would not be complete enough and so, it was just obvious that he would be heading for it.
Admittedly, this man was a master of strategy and plotting. While he was preparing for the largest battle in the civil war he'd started, he was also corresponding with his allies throughout the Imperium, giving orders, seeking advice, gathering knowledge, forming alliances.

For him, my own fate was just a very small move in a very large game.

Another week later, I was in her clutches and winced upon her touch. "This is so ridiculous, mother!" I sighed.
The black-haired menace did the same, even in the same tone. "You may see it this way, Adora. However, and to my pity, your opinion doesn't matter here." She continued to brush my hair.
I scoffed. "Pity, of course. As if you'd care." I only mumbled this lowly.
Given my inevitable departure, my manners became slightly worse, I had to admit. But with the date in clear sight, I'd started to become a bit… gritty.
"Adora, Adora. I really do not know why you despise me so much. I'm not the one to blame for your family's decisions."
Maybe that was true. But she also couldn't deny how lucky she was, to see me leaving soon. And she clearly supported my uncle's decision.
"We will travel for two weeks. I think my hair can be done when

we arrive."
She discovered a knot and willingly brushed through harshly.
"Ouch!" I yelled.
"Don't be dumb, Adora. Every impression counts. Cleopatra sends one of her own ships to take us up at Seleukia Pieria. So there will be Egyptians watching you from this time and point on. You have to present the family in the best possible way at every time."
"Ita Ita."[10] I sighed again and submitted to the inevitable. Which was being brushed further. Just a little stricter now.

But then I realized what she'd just said. "Us?" I asked.
She scoffed again, and I felt the smirk behind me. "What? Did you think your father would let you travel on your own? Of course, I will accompany you. And maybe if only to keep your honor after all."
I tried to process the thought. Having someone known by my side sounded a bit reassuring, I had to admit. My father couldn't leave Antiochia, not in the middle of a civil war, where he desperately tried to keep both sides in check enough, so his area of responsibility didn't turn into a war zone. He was a man of strong will, sure, but not one of war.
On the other side, being forced to be with her the whole journey, day and night, with all her manners and sarcasm and spite? Not a pleasing thought.
The words tumbled out of my mouth before I even considered them: "I want to go on my own. Bow as company should be enough. I'm 23, I don't need a watchdog."
Her movements died down. After a few moments of obviously considering her answer, she spoke: "I fear that's not up to us to decide."
There was no withdrawal or rejection in her words, and so I knew, I had just to convince my father about this specific matter. Maybe she would leave me alone, after all.

The same evening, we had one last family dinner together before my departure. My mood was rather depressed, and I was up to let everyone feel it also. So I wasn't a good company. I made plenty of snarky comments and *mother* was boiling in anger. Should she!

Tomorrow I'd be gone and leaving her was the only good thing about all of that misery. Persuading my father to let me travel on my own, only with an escort of soldiers and Bow as their commanding officer had turned out to be surprisingly easy. I suspected he was secretly relieved not to have to worry about the two of us being forced together for such a long time, possibly going for our throats. He promised to meet me in Egypt as soon as uncle Julius had either won his war or lost for good.

But despite or maybe because of this little victory of mine, my father lost patience with my antics some time later in the evening and called: "Adora! You will stop with your self-pity now. This is res publica, and it is our responsibility to fulfill our duties to the gens. I'm done with your behavior."

He sounded harsh, but I saw the look in his eyes. He didn't want this either, but as always, he'd put the demands of the gens before his own. Or his daughter's ones. I inwardly sighed. For years, it had been always about the demands of uncle Gaius. It was just like that I wasn't a part of this family at all, but a mere tool, to be used on other people's behalf.

I hated it. But I obliged. After all, and despite my internal struggles, I was a dutiful daughter.

Luckily for everyone, the next morning came quickly, and our travel began at sunrise. Bow had already saddled our horses and gathered the escort, two decuriae of mounted infantry, 20 men altogether. They would accompany me to Alexandria and further to Thēbais. Egypt may be our ally and Roman patricians were typically untouchable. But as both realms struggled with their internal… disputes about leadership, it seemed like a good idea to not leave anything to fate. A little protection against bandits and insurgents was always a good idea.

In private, I sobbed into my father's toga for minutes, until I finally composed myself. He patted my head and was quite the statesmen, calm and unaffected. But his eyes were watery when I kissed him on his cheeks and whispered some nonsense into his

ears. Later, under the eyes of our whole household, saying goodbye to my stepmother was much easier. A short hug and a quiet “Farewell” was all that it took. With something I considered at least not too ungracefully, I mounted on my horse and waved at the freedman, servants and slaves that stood around, many of whom I had known for years and everyone waved back.

Then we rode through the gate of my father’s villa with four soldiers up front and Bow and my side, the rest of the men behind us. This short part of the journey would only last for a mere day, because the harbor city of Antiochia, Seleukia Pieria, was just a day ride away from the province’s capital. We should arrive there in the afternoon and immediately board the ship that was already waiting for us. Or rather, for me. Under better circumstances, I would normally be delighted at the prospect of such an adventure.

But given the final goal of my journey, this wasn’t just a fun road trip.

Riding down the sandy road was unimpressive. Syria was an important Roman province, yes, but its landscape was nothing like Italy. Where our hills were green and wooded, it was a monotone shade of sand reigning here. I hadn't understood why people actually lived here. But Antiochia was the most important city in the east of the Republic, and it grew despite my disbelief.

We reached the harbor of Antiochia in the afternoon. Our ride hadn’t been too fast, and we were still in good shape. A look told me that the port was busy, to say the least. Around a dozen war galleys of the eastern fleet bobbed at anchor in the sea before the harbor dams, six large trade ships unloaded or were being loaded. Many little fishing boats lay beside the shore and quays or were sailing in and out. People were hurrying here and there and talking in languages I didn't understand, selling fish or fruits, groceries, and livestock at market booths scattered all over the place. It wasn't large, but it was a vibrant place.

Bow guided me to a large galley that lay beside the quay. It looked different from our mundane roman war galleys. This one was longer and wider than ours and elevated higher with three decks of rudders. The railing and the upper deck were embellished with golden plates at the side. The two sails in a bright yellow and with intricate Egyptians ornements on them, and not the usual sandy tone like ours. A beautiful golden figurehead at the bow showed a - presumably - female Egyptian goddess. I made a mental note to ask Alexas about it.

Everything about this ship looked like abundant wealth. Perhaps, I shouldn't have been surprised. Cleopatra surely'd want to make a immaculate impression. Yet, I was.

When we arrived at the ship, Bow helped me to dismount and kept me from rushing onto the ship. At his order, my escort formed a row left and right to the gangway. Upon the galley, a squad of servants and shipmen hurried down the ramp to the quay, and lined up alike, all of them paying attention… to me. Then, slower and with dignity, Alexas of Laodikeia went down and bowed before me, then posing and speaking up:
"Adora Diana Minor of the Julii, beloved daughter of the most honorable Sextus Julius Caesar, admired niece of Consul Gaius Julius Caesar, pearl and gift of the Senate and the People of Rome!
Egypt greets you with joy and reverence. We welcome you on behalf of Cleopatra VII Thea Philopator, Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods, Messenger of on High and Vanguard of the End times, the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt, the Mistress of Sedge and Bee! Where she goes, she brings forth the infinity of the gods." [11]

I was admittedly impressed and felt that I was blushing. I hadn't expected *such* a show on my behalf. A typical Roman greeting consisted mostly of a simple "Ave", and that was pretty much it. But all these Orientals had always taken a delight in more opulent and overflowing speeches and chatter.
And Alexas obviously had adapted that. "We humbly offer you the

services of this ship and its crew to guide you safely to Pelousion. Cleopatra longingly awaits your arrival.”

I knew a trap when I saw one.

Maybe I wasn’t a worldly woman in the more mundane, trivial affairs. Growing up under the thorough protection of my father’s guidance and in the household, I hadn’t interacted with people that much. I knew I was still naive and in good faith against everyone. But I'd had a good education, training, and been able to gather knowledge by sneaking all kinds of documents from my father's correspondence and reading them. So, maybe I was still an oblivious child.
Nonetheless, I knew this was for real. This was something more than just a humble invitation to get to know.

It wasn't the time and place to ponder, as I was ushered up the gangway quickly. Presumably, they feared that I could get lost - on purpose - or being stolen or whatever. On the ship, I was greeted by the captain less enthusiastically. He just didn't make such a show of it and was quickly gone to order the ship to be cast away as soon as possible.

Most of my escort was dismissed under deck, only leaving three of them as well as Bow beside me. I leaned over the railing of the ship and watched the harbor again. It was a wonderful view of buzzing life, a swirl of *doing* , and I let it sink in in awe. When looking at it from above, I just wanted to dive in again.
If it was on me, I would’ve just lovingly scurried around the port and explored all of it. All the little market stalls and stores. Maybe a talk with a Latin-speaking person. I craved for a simple conversation with normal people, given the total lack of possibilities to do so in my father's villa.

But the ropes were already drawn in and the ship started to leave the quay. The captain yelled a command and his first officer repeated it, adding more orders. Oars moved us slowly and carefully out of the harbor, between other ships, and around the outer quay walls. I watched the scene with certain anxiety.

Everything happened so fast now. For the first time in my life, I was traveling without my father on my side. All on my own. My hand took Bow’s in a firm grip, and he squeezed back, understanding what was going on in me. Soon, we would be on the high seas and then…

I sighed silently and watched the oars fastening as the drum under deck fastened, now that we had left the inner port and were moving forward to open waters. Another large trade vessel from the left was coming in, passing us, the headland on the right hand was rushing by and then, suddenly, only the infinite sea was ahead of us.

The rowers' drum quickened again. Steady, stable, constant. Relentless.
Whum. Whum. Whum.

We were on our way to Egypt.

For some time, I just stood at the railing and watched how our ship plowed through the water. It hardly soothed my troubled mind. The ocean was calm today, its surface just a little wavy. Despite the blue sky above and the sun starting to set, bathing everything in an orange glow, my mood got cloudy. Luckily, my wavering gaze caught the bow of the ship, and made me remember my question from before. Or rather... unluckily, given the answer I was about to get.

I watched out for Alexas. Since our departure, Cleopatra’s advisor had withdrawn, obviously aiming to give me time and space to get used to the situation. I was on his ship, and we were on our way to his queen, so he’d been successful with his mission and therefore, he could relax.

His look turned at me when I strolled over, asking: “Honorable Alexas, do you know about the figurehead at the ship’s bow?"
His eyes glistened when he replied: “Yes, young domina, of course. I’m glad to be of help. You probably know that most of todays Egyptian population still admires and worships the ancient gods?"
That was true. While the Ptolemies with their Greek origin brought their own gods with them, they hadn't been overly succesful in replacing the Egyptians beliefs. A lot of the more rural population still nothing changed. And Cleopatra was the first Pharao who actually spoke Egyptian, so it was a logical conclusion that she would use such ornaments.
I nodded, and Alexas continued: "It is a representation of Heket, the Egyptian goddess of water and birth."
That didn't sound so far-fetched. “Ah, water. I see how this makes sense," I nodded. "So, do all Egyptian ships have such… lavish decorations and this figure on them? Is it a common feature of the fleet?”

He frowned a bit, clearly noticing my lack of knowledge, but his answer was in a kind tone: “Apologies, domina—"
I cut him short. “Please, call me Adora. All this ‘young domina’ here and ‘young domina’ there makes me even sicker than the possible upcoming seasickness itself. I have a name.” Me snickering shortly made Alexas considering his obvious rejecting just for a moment, while Bow had difficulties hiding his chuckling. Quite the diplomat that he was, he bowed his head and replied: “And a beautiful one, Adora.” He seemed at least honest this time and a bit more relaxed.
I smirked. “Look, it works. Now, about the figurehead?”

Alexas cocked his head and went forth: “Right. See, I hadn’t noticed that no one told you about this, or about Heket. It should be worth mentioning that this is the only ship in the Egyptian fleet - or rather in the fleet of ships in the personal possession of the Pharaohs - that has the beloved goddess as its icon. It is very unique.”
Very slowly in the back of my mind, it began to dawn on me. “I consider this means something… special then?”, I asked.

He nodded, more serious now. “Of course it does. Heket is the goddess of water *and birth.*” He emphasized the last two words. “When an Egyptian Pharaoh is pregnant, she only travels by this ship and this one only. It is believed and proven to protect the beginning life and the one of the mother as well, under the grace and favor of the goddess, praise be. No harm will happen to them here. Nobody besides the ruling female Pharaoh may use this ship."

He made an artificial pause before his next words. "And it has never occurred otherwise before.”

Oh!

Ooohhh no!

I was stunned. Because I understood. “So, what you say is, that —" and now I was cut short by him.
“Yes, the Messenger of on High, Cleopatra VII Thea Philopator sent her most personal and unique belonging, to safely guide *you*, Adora, to her realm.”

It was such a simple and honest revelation, yet, it left me devastated. Because I knew I should’ve felt honored, of course, I should. The eye of the — presumable, soon to be again or whatever — ruler of the wealthiest and most productive nation of the known world besides our own, lay on me.
On me.
Cleopatra had made a gesture, an enormous and significant gesture. That meant nothing less than that she was personally interested in me and my becoming. With the sending of this ship, she already had signaled her approval to a marriage that was now increasingly likely.

I grabbed the railing of the ship, to keep me up and to stop the shivering of my hands. The rowers had already driven us far out to the sea. The coast of Syria as well as the protection of my father, even if only minimal, had long vanished behind the horizon. Before me, lay a unknown and scary future.

Actually, I was frightened to death.

Chapter End Notes

[1] Cubicula: a normal room inside a villa or house, used for different purposes. ↑

[2] Alexandria's real name was Alexándreia-by-Egypt Despite my favor to use native names as far as possible, for the sake of readability, I will stick to the English writing. ↑

[3] Dignitas: Dignitas was the influence a male Roman citizen could gather throughout his life. It refers to his whole personality: moral standing, reputation, his treatment of others, ethics and the standing of his family, also fitness. Gravitas: another virtue that denotes to something like 'seriousness in all your doing', being taken as a responsible person by others. ↑

[4] The Senate and the People of Rome, Senātus Populusque Rōmānus, SPQR, which means nothing less than the Roman Republic itself upon its formal title. "SPQR", "Rome" and "The Republic" are synonyms in common tongue. ↑

[5] Gens: It was the most important social structure in the Roman Republic. All members of a family that shared the same name and who claimed descent from a common ancestor belonged to it. A possible modern translation could be *clan*. The *Julia gens* had been one of the most important Roman families over the centuries and transformed into the Julio-Claudian dynasty, making up the first five emperors of the Roman Empire, starting with Augustus, Caesar's nephew. ↑

[6] Cena: Dinner, but the main meal in Roman culture, could last from later afternoon until night. ↑

[7] This sentence is a citation from "Savage of the South", Chapter 3 ↑

[8] *Patrias Potestas* refers to the unrestricted power the male head of the family, the *pater familias*, held over all members of the family. ↑

[9] Just give us the whole joke, Tyrion! Goddammit! ↑

[10] “Ita Ita.” ~ Yeah Yeah. ↑

[11] With kind permission of the original author, Jezmatron, this is a modification of the lunatic phrase Catra uses in “Grace and Favor” all the time. Said insanely funny and well-developed story is the word embodiment of a wordsy slow burn and I recommend it highly. ↑

This is my duty

Chapter Summary

> The end of the world is not so bad.
> But alarms must be heard!
> The Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods orders me to bathe.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

This has to be a cakewalk, was my literal thinking. Nonsense, of course, but I was confident enough to persuade myself of it. We'd been chasing these damned raiders for three hours now and still, they were alive and running. I was sweaty, and tired, and I ached for something stronger than water. Much stronger. The merciless sun burning down from the always cloudless sky made me crave for water, surely, but the perpetual tension in my gut craved for more.
Our little game of hide-and-seek should now come to an end. The group of bandits had been on the run before my horsemen since morning, and the exhausting chase must've left its mark on them as well. Now, they were led straight into the trap I'd laid out. We'd circled them and hidden right behind the top of the dune in front of them, disguised under our sand-colored coats. And they hadn't seen us. Now they were only around 50 meters before us, on the other side of the hill ridge, and my cavalry was right behind them.

On my mark, my warriors jumped up, freed themselves of their coats, drew their scimitars and lined along the ridge. Now the bandits were encircled, but still not outnumbered. Six of my horsemen and six of my warriors against around 20 of them. I scolded myself for underestimating their strength when I rallied my troops for the chase hours ago. But I'd been just too eager to

not allow them to escape another time, and so I hadn’t waited for more soldiers to assemble. A dumb move, too fast, too hastily executed. I inwardly sighed and straightened myself, then encouraged my men: “Good chances for all of us to gain a part of the glory! Go!"

Upon this, my cavalry charged and rode down four enemies at both the sides, while the guards and I crashed into their center. I jumped forward and, in a spin, stabbed my scimitar through a chest. The man was dead before he could even react. Crouching, I used the force of the drawback to lower myself and turn it in a circle to slit open the thigh of another one who was towering over me. Some protection of the veins there would have been clever, I smirked, and the bandit may have thought the same when he looked down on me with a surprised expression. The pain was clearly visible on his face. He was already dead, he just hadn’t realized it. An open artery, in the middle of a battle in the desert? Death sentence.
I grinned and stood up, then kicked his stomach with my foot, so he fell over behind. A cut at my right arm pulled me out of my self-adulation, and hurt flooded over me. The incision was deep enough to bleed. Like a fucking waterfall. Luckily, one of my men took out my attacker, and I quickly tore off my headscarf and used it to tie up the wound. Despite being in the middle of a fight, that had to be done immediately, otherwise I would share the fate of my previous victim.

Due to the surprise and the two-sided ambush, the odds turned to our side. After my horsemen had wheeled and charged the third time and with half a dozen bandits already dead on the ground, the remaining surrendered one by one. After the last ones gave up, we quickly rounded them up. Just two losses on our side.
My squad cheered, and I bid them a salute. My brown curls flew around when I took off my headscarf and joined the laughter of my men. This *had* been a cakewalk and I enjoyed our little victory. My victory.
Mine, of Catra Meritamun, the only female governor of an Egyptian settlement in Upper and Lower Egypt. Even if Buhen was just the ass of the world.

("Ibelin", Deezer / Spotify / Youtube)

A few hours later we arrived back at said Buhen. The town and fortress which I'd ruled for around a year now, lay beside the Nile and just a little below the second cataract. The cataracts were whitewater rapids, where stones and boulders broke the water surface and made shipping the usually calm river at least difficult, if not impossible, depending on the water level. The second one was also known as the great cataract, because of its length and the large rock formations that stood beside the shore. I'd been sent here by Cleopatra herself, to rebuild the large fortress of Buhen in the first place and as a sign of warning against the Kingdom of Kush. But the original plan had quickly developed further. Upon the struggles for the reign and throne between Cleopatra, her brother Ptolemy and her sister Arsinoe, keeping me behind the veil and concurrently securing the southern border of the Egyptian sphere of influence, had seemed to be a good idea to Cleopatra.

And I did a good job here. Since the downfall of the old kingdom, Buhen had been some kind of idle outpost for centuries, with just some dozen buildings and maybe three hundred inhabitants. Under my leadership and with the influx of workers and money for the reconstruction of the fortress, the sleepy town in the desert lands began to thrive again.
Two hundred soldiers had been stationed under my command, and with them, an entourage of people flowed in. Workshops had opened, the local market grew, a workforce had to be recruited. We started to built more houses for the new citizens, and I'd ordered, that every child should be taught to read and write before it became ten years old. When without duties, I ordered my troops to dig canals and trenches, with which we led water from the Nile to newly developed fields for irrigation.
This year the small city would be reaping its first own harvest of wheat in hundreds of years.
All of this made Buhen the most attractive settlement up and down the Nile for more than ten iteru.[12] Every day, a family or

some lonesome nomad decided to settle down here, and they all contributed to the growth of the place. Of my place.

Surely, with the growth, problems arose as well. The recent raid by some Nubian warriors had been the third in the last month. And it'd started to become more than annoying. With today's success, we should at least have worked out some advantage and gathered a respite. Six dead and 15 captured, that was a base for a bit more security in the area. But I also knew that more trouble was on the rise. The Kingdom of Kush hung around our southern border and kept a watchful eye on us. I hoped that their leaders would decide to leave us alone. We weren't strong enough to withstand a serious attack by Kushite forces. They could've easily assemble an army of maybe up to five thousand men, if they wanted. But Cleopatra's messengers had negotiated a diffident truce for the time being, and I hoped, the Kushites would stick to their word, as we didn't pose a real threat to them.

After giving my orders to place the prisoners, I went over to the barracks to visit my troops. I distributed a little praise, being aware how much a normal soldier was susceptible for any acknowledgment by his leaders. I was good at this, my subordinates were loyal and everything worked out fine so far. The repairing of the fortress had come far enough too, only some towers still had to be done, as well as the temple of Horus. Despite the priest's protests, I'd put the repairing of the temple into the backlog. It just wasn't the most important part of our current doing and needs. Having a secure and guarded settlement that was able and ready to defend itself against raiders and - hopefully not - light attacks from Kushite troops was much more relevant.
And while Cleopatra secretly would've seconded my decision without batting an eyelash, she must have spoken otherwise in public. Because the priest continuously annoyed me with his demands about how important the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt had deemed the rebuilding of this temple - the temple of Horus - and that I had to pay attention to this project immediately.
Well, well. Cleo obviously wasn't here and obviously hadn't dared

to send me any messages on this topic either, and so she'd left it for me to deal with this… nuisance. How nice of her. I made a mental notice to express my deepest thanks to my patroness the next time I saw her.

Despite my unwillingness, my path lead me to said temple of Horus. It lay at the southern side of the fortress and settlement, and it was one of the buildings I really hadn't touched or even got into since my arrival a year ago. Religion was a difficult matter for me and I always wanted to stay away from it as far as possbile. The local priest'd obviously eagerly awaited me, because he hurried down the stairs of the building the moment I set foot on the first steps up the temple entrance.
"Greetings to you, priest of the most beloved god under the Egyptian sun," I said in the hope to catch him on good terms. Inwardly, I already rolled my eyes, because his sour face told me everything I needed to know.
He heaved a deep breath and droned: "Your ladyship Catra, it's good you finally took your time to address this issue. We need to pay the rebuilding of the temple our utmost attention."
He got straight to the point, so much was for sure. I almost liked him for this attitude, because I had never been able to stand the protracted chatter of priests. It took too much time without gaining anything. This one was different. Maybe this was also the reason why the high priest of Horus had sent him here. Into the nothingness of the desert, sand, and only with the Nile beside. So, no reason for me to not get straight to the point either.

"Amenemhet, is there any reason why I should divert the workers now? We are around three months away from completion of the fortress, and then you can have at least half of them for your temple. But the fortress itself must stay our top priority until then. It would be a bad idea to leave us defenseless against possible raids from larger Kushite forces, or don't you think so?"
Obviously, he didn't. "We aren't defenseless. The walls are ready, and the towers can be done later. Our main problem is that you have started to irrigate fields and grow wheat."
"Huh? Growing wheat is a problem? You should… elaborate on that." He looked at me like I like at some of the more dumb

people under my benevolent rule.
“Of course, your ladyship. The workers deem it unfitting that they can’t worship the one god, responsible for the fertility of the land. And they come to me to beg you to quicken our works. We have to do something about this situation soon!”

Hmm. I had to admit that the annoying priest had a point there. Even if I didn’t believe in any of the religious talks and in the old gods at all, common people did. And that mattered as well. If I didn’t treat the beliefs of my workers decently and respectfully, they would soon start to look out for other opportunities. Buhen wasn’t exactly the center of the world, to put it that way. The town was thriving now, but it also was just a dot in the desert, only able to live because of the Nile and Cleopatra’s will to expand her influence.
I couldn’t afford to lose people to such a nuisance like religion. My reply came sincerely: “I see your point, priest, and would like to offer a… compromise. The fortress is our most important project, nonetheless—"
“But your ladyship—" he raised his voice.
I waved a finger and cut him short also. “Na Na Na! Let me speak! I was about to say that I see the necessity to give the people a place for their worship of the gods, the sooner, the better, right?”
“Of course, your ladyship, and preferably this should be done before the harvest.”
“Good. Listen, I will assign 15 men and a master-builder to help you clear up the debris and ready the central room. Meanwhile, you will gather volunteers to help them. True believers won’t refuse such noble work, right?”
He furrowed his eyebrows, but he let me speak.
“And for every volunteer you gather, I will send another man to assist your works after the first tower has been readied. You know that we need them for signaling and lookout."
"How long might that take, your grace?" I crossed my arms and assured him more serious than I actually was: " I think we can achieve that within the next two or three weeks.”

Because actually, it was at least four or five weeks ahead, but it would buy me some time and give him the motivation to rally his own support. The idea with the volunteers was pretty good, I congratulated myself. Should the believers work a bit for their own interests too, I inwardly laughed into my sleeves.
"15 men, you say?" He was pondering about it.
"15 men. And additional after the tower is ready," I assured.
"It's not much," he half-heartedly complained, and I knew I had him. If he had been up for real resistance, he would've outright denied my proposal. "I don't think we will get much done with so little help."
I made a desperate grimace and said in a suppressed voice: "Good, 20. But not even one more until the tower is ready. Cleopatra would behead me if I neglect my duties even more." I would've given him more, but as long as I could get away with less, fine by me. My first and foremost interest lay in completing the fortress and strengthening the city in general.
A temple was for the weak only. And there was no place for the weak in the desert borderlands between Egypt and Kush. The desert was a harsh mistress. This was a place for strong people, for survivors.

For people like me.

Our conversation had come to its natural ending, as he'd reached at least a part of his aim. The priest reluctantly thanked me and I promised to send one of my master-builders tomorrow to make a list of needed things and supplies. He would have to pay any material out of the temple's purse, but the labor force had to work for free then. One of the perks of having a Pharaoh at your side, I thought. Cleopatra could rally as many workers as she liked, given her godlike status. What a pity that the Ptolemies were so busy in killing each other rather than in building something longlasting and worth for real. But on the other hand, as long as they kept going on each other's throats, they didn't do more stupid things. Like the Romans, for example.
After the discussion with the priest, I decided to head back to my rooms for sleep. The day had been long enough, and I really needed some recovery, exhausted from the long ride. The thought

of having a drink with some of my men shortly stroke my mind, but I disregarded it. When I laid down on my bed, I pondered about the day. The victory over the bandits would spread some word that we weren't an easy target. So, smaller groups of raiders and even the little tribes that tended to improve their livestock and food supplies from occasional forays would consider more easy places to go than this one.
But it also meant that the next assaults would be better planned and executed with more men. And if I knew anything, then it was that the next fight was always just around the corner.

July passed by quickly and our works around the settlement went forward. The first tower of the fortress had been put into operation two days before. It would allow us to communicate with further beacons down the Nile when the missing small towers to Syene[13] had been repaired. The chain wasn't complete, and had a lot missing pieces, but even right now, it meant more protection. Our view over the second cataract had extended, and it would be much harder to surprise us from now on. The visible reconstruction of the fortress alone was a strong reminder to everyone that Egypt laid claim to this land again.
To the priest's delight, I'd sent him 40 men by now, while he'd been able to gather some volunteers to help also, and so he wasn't complaining *that* much anymore. The temple would be ready for a first mess within some days and that should be enough to silence any grumbling. And in two weeks, we would harvest our first self-grown wheat. All in all, I was content with my work and liked it here. Even if Buhen was just some city-by-accident and nobody in lower Egypt even knew the name or about its mere existence, it was my duty, and it was my town.

I wouldn't have swapped with anyone.

I hadn't thought like that when Cleo approached me around a year ago. She wasn't warring with her siblings then, but equally ruled Egypt with her brother Ptolemy XIII. Or rather, with his advisor and regent, Pothinus. Both of them fought about topics now and then, about how to execute and share the reign between

the two siblings, but it wasn't like now, not a deadly confrontation. When she called me to court, I was surprised, to say the least. Usually, we avoided contact in that formal and official surroundings. Our mutual past had formed a strong bond between us, but I wasn't a good fit to the standards and requirements a stay at the royal court in the palace of the Pharaohs demanded. I was rather a stray cat, despite my noble lineage. My tan skin outed me as a hybrid between a Nubian and someone from the Greco-Roman world. My wild, brown curls didn't match either of them. And my most distinctive feature, the heterochromatic eyes, were the icing on the cake usually making people frown on me.
Not that I wasn't pretty. I was. I was so damned pretty that I had to use daggers to defend myself when staying at Cleo's palace for a month because I was always mistaken for a slave of the harem. And as a slave, I should have bowed to such desires.
But as me, Catra Meritamun, the Halfmoon Princess, I was not to bow to anyone. Maybe to Cleo, on official occasions. But of course not to some courtier on his search for easy entertainment. He quickly saw it my way when my first dagger was on his throat and my *second* one was… a bit further down below. I cackled aloud when he hurried away and everyone in the surrounding hall was shooting scared looks. Allowing myself a smug grin, I left them to their confusion.
An hour later Cleopatra had called me over to question me about what happened. She had been told that I was about to slaughter some of her most loyal and humble men. We giggled when I told her the story in detail and I knew again, that nothing would come between us.

After all, she was my sister.

My younger half-sister, to be exact. We shared the same mother, and I was the elder child. My or rather our mother had been a lower priestess who'd joined the priests' quorum of Memphis two years after my birth. So I grew up with my father, the chief of a small Nubian tribe, hence the princess. Another two years later, our mother became the wife of Pharaoh Ptolemy XII Neos Dionysos. Until his downfall, he was more commonly known as

Auletes, “the Flautist”, because he loved playing the flute in Dionysian festivals.
In my opinion, he’d always been an idiot, a weak leader, and as so often those turned out to be the most gruesome ones. He produced Cleopatra with our mutual mother and the three other younger siblings with another poor woman. The luckily dead bastard. And because of all these strings into the highest nobility, my family matters were a mess, so to say.

Yet, Cleo and I always kept our backs. Our common ancestry was some kind of bond, but we took it far beyond that. Due to reasons.
So it didn't surprise me when she proposed a new assignment for me. That would lead me into… nowhere? Buhen, really?
She tried to paint my exile in more lively colors, though. He face was practically shining with persuasion when she gripped my upper arms and held me firmly: “I need someone whom I can trust, Catra. The kingdom is in trouble and the Kushites may see it as the excellent opportunity that it is. They always wanted to expand their borders to the first cataract again. And I can’t let that happen. We cannot deal with an invasion from the south, the Roman intervention, and our… family struggles at the same time. I need to keep them in check. I need that front to be secured, and out of my mind. With the least possible effort, because we've already stretched our means.”
I shook my head and bit my lips. That wasn’t what I’d expected when she had called me over. An assignment to some almost deserted settlement in the no man’s land between actual Egypt and actual Kush? Not very promising, I thought, and I also said that: “That sounds like a boring job, like something for an overachiever from your court. Why task me? I'm not even a skilled governor. And I really don’t want to spend a year in the desert, working my ass off for nothing.”
“Because I trust you?`, Cleopatra tried, grinned and her black eyes begged me from under her melon hairdo. She couldn’t hide the silliness, though.
“Try harder, youngling” was my rightful, deadpan reply, and crossed my arms to my signature pose.

She sighed but shot back: “Don't brag about your age, old lady. You don’t have a clue how hard all of this is. Ptolemy's advisors are plotting against me, and they gather support from the court. My brother is too young to stand against them, and he's a man. Or will be some time," she added, then continued. "They want to take away the power of government from me, Catra. Or even more.” She fell silent, not able or willing to elaborate on that. Wasn’t necessary.
I knew.

Berenice.

Cleopatra’s older half-sister by paternal side. Her mutual father had her beheaded a few years ago at the age of 22, in one of the ever-ongoing Ptolemaic quarrels and confrontations for the throne. True, he was also dead by now, and his son, Cleo’s brother, Ptolemy XIII her formal co-ruler.
But history just tended to repeat itself and the siblings didn’t trust each other and rightfully so. Cleopatra was 21 now, still a very young woman, but also already experienced in the difficulties to survive in this murderous environment. She must have had reasons for her approach.

“Why me? Why Buhen?” I asked, already on the path of retreat. She shrugged her shoulders. “There are different reasons, you know? First of all, we really need to secure the southern border. There’s no denying it. But more importantly, I don’t have the necessary supplements and troops to do so and my brother won’t do anything. His advisors won't let him send troops loyal to them away. And I don't have them either. So it needs someone skilled in achieving something meaningful, but with too few means. I need someone whom I can trust. And I need you to vanish from the court for some time,” she blurted all at once.

Ah, now we got to the point. “Why that? If Pothinus and that pig Achillas are plotting against you, keeping me here would be a good idea, or wouldn’t it? I could be of help.” Actually, I was eager to help because I didn't like any of them.
Cleopatra shook her head. “Unfortunately not. I assume that the

little truce with my brother will soon come to an end. Then I will retreat to upper Egypt or Syria to gather support. I'm already talking to allies there, just in case. Psamtik secures the Thebais for me, and works on rebuilding Thebes as a new center for the nomes around. It will be a stronghold for me, but with little troops on our side. I still have some hope to solve it without a massacre. Or an actual war. And in this… delicate situation, having you here just adds up to all the tension around. You aren't the most...", Cleopatra paused shortly to weigh her words, "easiest to deal with, are you?"
I raised the corner of my mouth and torn between being annoyed, rightfully judged, caught and grumpy. She was right, I'd to admit. My usual antics hadn't made me many friends. But on the other side, I didn't need friends at the fucking court. My duties led me away often enough and so, I usually didn't give a shit about what the courtiers thought of me. They were useless, when all power just came from my sister.
But this time it was different because I deemed Cleopatra's life in actual danger. "Sister, this isn't the time to care for some stupid fortress in Nubia or for my safety. I can take care of myself. But you should clear this up right away, preferably today. Kill Pothinus, and Achillas too. Get rid of them and let your brother be a kid. He's thirteen. Rule alone. You can do that, without a doubt. You can send me if you like."
Cleo smiled a weak one but shook her head. "It's not that easy. If I get rid of my brother's council today, the priests and the larger part of the army won't follow me. Instead, they will rally up the citizens of Alexandria to provoke a riot, and then - unluckily - I will be killed while they put it down with their deepest regrets. Then they can install Arsinoe, who would be happy to help out." She sighed audibly. "I need more time and allies before I act upon that."

Cleopatra's younger half-sister Arsinoe, 17 at the time, would be an easy prey for the influential courtiers. I nodded. "I see. And I see that you want me out of the line of sight for now. But Cleo, promise, you will send for me when the time comes. I will stay at your side no matter what, do you hear me?"

Maybe I was the older one, but she was the one destined to be the Pharaoh of Egypt, the Lady of Upper and Lower Nile, the Messenger of on High. My role would be to keep her safe, and I was okay with that.
Cleo gently squeezed my hand, and we put our foreheads together when she said: “Please think about doing this for me. I won't command you anything, but I beg of you, Catra. Please!”
I sighed and nodded as a sign of approval. Well fell into a short conversation about the details of my assignment, but I felt tired and readied myself to leave soon. When standing up, I asked: “When I’m on my way out, and I run into this moron from before… would you miss him?” I was only half joking.
She smirked and replied: “Please don’t. It’s always such a mess with getting rid of the bodies." She pointed out of the window, to the river. "The crocodiles are very well-fed these days, you know?”
We giggled a bit, but we also knew the halfheartedly hidden truth behind her words.
When I left the palace, I carried a scroll with my royal orders, a purse with enough money to buy a small pyramid, and an uneasy feeling in my gut. Cleopatra had sent me away, of course. But I didn’t miss the look in her eyes when we said goodbye.

She was afraid.

And here I was. Buhen, at the second cataract of the Nile. In the middle of the desert. The middle of nowhere.
And to be honest, after I got over my grudge to be sent away to the world’s ass, I slowly - very slowly - accepted the fact that I liked it here. Giving me full authority over 200 soldiers and even more men of labor force, some of them really skilled, was the largest responsibility I’d ever had. And I came to the conclusion that liked it.
On our ride to Buhen, I requisitioned materials and tools from several building sites along the way, always covered by Cleopatra’s authority. We would mine the more heavy building materials on-site, but we took tools and certain goods with us on barges while sailing up the Nile. And it was funny to snatch well-made devices like cranes and to take them away, always to the despair of the

local architects. But if Cleopatra didn’t want to hear complaints about me, she shouldn’t task me with anything like that. I took my inner pleasure as a little compensation for the assignment.

And when we arrived at Buhen, it got even funnier. Over decades and even centuries, the former fortified city had shrunk into a mere village, half the buildings swallowed by sand, the surrounding fortress only a shadow of her former self. Their gates had been removed, the walls and towers partly crumbled, the temples and barracks mostly devastated.The harbor was still working, and fishermen used the large stream to catch their daily food. But that was about it.
I saw the potential immediately, and my first move was to get rid of the previous governor of the settlement.
Or rather the scoundrel that'd tortured the citizens with his pestering. He’d done little for improvements but much about taxes, so far I noticed on the first day.
I noisily deliberated about getting him beheaded - Cleo’s authority was absolute in minimal matters like that, and she’d transferred the necessary amount of this power to me on behalf of this mission.
After taking place on his chair behind desk in a display of powerplay, my comment about his upcoming execution accompanied by the soldiers that rallied outside on the courtyard underlined my authority perfectly. After letting him stew for two days, I just ordered him to take care of the construction of sewage systems and with construction, I meant that he did the digging by himself. A fitting job, I declared publicly, for someone like him, while cleaning my fingernails with my knife in a childlike manner. But that’d been fun, and it was only the first few days. And so, I dug into my duties. Because that was the best way to prove myself worthy.

The next months flew by quickly, and before I knew it, a year had passed. The settlement made great progress and over time, I became familiar with my work. Meanwhile, the conflict between Cleo and her brother had escalated, just like she predicted it. She fled to Thēbais at first, then to Syria where she started to gather an army to fight back. She’d always been like that. Fighting back.

Meeting resistance? Fighting back more until the resistance was gone. But her advance back to Alexandria had been stopped in the delta swamps of the eastern Nile, at Pelousion. Ptolemy and his general Achillas had assembled a large part of the Egyptian army behind them and so, Cleopatra set up camp in Pelousion and had been stuck there for some weeks now. We exchanged a letter now and then, her making only one clear statement: I should stay where I was and go forth with my work.
This had continued for weeks until, at the end of July, another messenger rode by. You could tell that he had gone to extremes. His horse nearly collapsed, and the man was a mere shadow when he approached me.

I'd been sitting at my desk that stood under a pergola before my chambers. I often used the noon hours to do paperwork, because it was just too hot to do anything else than sitting or sleeping. With a merciles sun burning down on us, heavy work could only be done in the morning or evening hours, but reading and writing? Anytime. And I liked sitting at the table and watching the courtyard. People were less hesitant to come over to me and discuss something when I was out here than hiding behind a desk in some dusty and dark chamber. I got to know more, and they didn't avoid me. Win-Win.
The messenger held out a scroll, his face covered in sweat and dust and his hands shaking. I took it and waved to a servant to take care of the man.
"I thank you," I said. "Is there anything you should tell me?"
He shook his head. "Her ladyship wrote it personally and told me to deliver the message as fast as possible."
"Where is she now?" I asked immediately.
"She's still in Pelousion and facing her brother's army. It's some kind of stalemate, but…"
"What?"
"Rumor has, that Caesar won an important battle over Pompeius or that it's nearly over. We don't know for sure, the message approached a mere hour before Cleopatra sent me here."
"Oh." That reminded me of the scroll in my hand. "I thank you, good man. Have a rest. We'll talk later." He bowed and was led to

a chamber. I checked the seal, which looked untouched. Not that it meant anything. I knew three ways to break and reattach a seal without noticeable traces. So I just opened the scroll and began to read.

"Hey, Kandake." Oh, what a fun start. I wasn't a Nubian queen. It was just some kind of pun - a very low one - we'd developed over the years. Using it in this scroll and context, Cleopatra was assuring me that it was her who wrote this letter and that she was doing it voluntarily.
"The events are overturning now. If the rumors have it right and my assumptions are correct, Caesar will honor us with his visit soon. Only the gods know if he takes a side. Luckily, when I'd been in Syria, I was able to already prepare a possible alliance with the gens Julia. But it is fragile. I need you at my side, now, to take care of someone. Come to Pelousion as soon as possible."

That was a typical Cleopatran letter. To the point, without any fuss, clear orders, not even signed. The salutation had said everything necessary anyway. I sighed, but I also felt excitement rising in my gut. My time of exile down here had come to an end. I yelled at an assistant to ready everything for my immediate departure. I knew there was currently no ship in port and it was unclear when one would arrive. So, a ride it was. It was shortly after noon. If I rode off within an hour, I should be able to reach Syene the day after tomorrow. And from there I could order a fast rowboat down to the delta. Maybe eight days, if I took them hard.
While I was shoving my stuff into a backpack, my assistants pestered me with questions. What happened? Where was I going? When would I come back? The prospect of losing me made them nervous. Though, I ordered or rather growled at them to rally the officials of Buhen at the courtyard, NOW, and proceeded. I checked for my Pharaonic plaque, a small gold disc on a chain. The plaque identified me as the bearer of said power. Cleopatra gave it to me, so I could demand support from all loyal citizens of Egypt anytime, anywhere. The bearer of this all-encompassing sign of the Pharaonic will spoke on behalf of the gods. I'd used

them while we traveled up here and would use it again while going donw. I put it under my top.

After readying myself, I went outside, where my two main advisors, a local spokesperson of the guild, the commanding officer of the soldiers, and the priest had gathered.
I cut everyone short by saying: "On the order of the Pharaoh, I have to leave immediately for important duties."
I didn't say which Pharaoh I meant, because it was obvious, and continued: "I will leave this city and citizens in your capable hands. I've written down orders on how to proceed over the next two months, but I also encourage you to take every measure fitting to reach the aims I already set. Be aware: I expect nothing less than overwhelming progress upon my return and every one of you will be judged. I will send messages when I arrive in the lower lands, and I also demand reports every week. You will send them to the archive in Coptos, from where they will be forwarded to me."
Some of them gulped and all complained about my sudden departure, but there was no denying Cleopatra's orders or alternative either and so the discussion ended quickly after I'd answered a few more questions.
Then I mounted, bid a farewell to everyone, and spurred the horse. While I rode outside the fortress and town and onto the path alongside the Nile through the desert, I was already ruminating about Cleo's orders and thought about what would come next. And I thought about her. Over a year, since I saw my sister last time.

She'd been 20 then, but already a political mastermind. And the recent events must've only strengthened these senses and abilities. She commandeered an army now and clearly gathered more experience. I smirked. She and I, together, in an upcoming battle against her brother, her sister, most of the Egyptian army, and possibly all the Roman Republic?

Pah! The idiots should've brought more support.

It took me until the morning of the day after tomorrow to reach Syene. I was sweaty, dusty, and tired, only having slept for four hours or so and otherwise been in the saddle for more than a day. Luckily, the Nile had provided my horse with enough water, otherwise the poor mane would've just died due to dehydration. As would I.

The large trade city lay right below the first cataract and had been the lighthouse-like southern border of the upper kingdom for centuries. Today, it was the southernmost large city with a constantly manned garrison until Buhen. And they had docks as well as rowboats. We hadn't gotten that far yet there.

Right below Syene, the river valley widened a bit and started to become fertile enough for grain cultivation. So, Syene was the logical endpoint of the early realm and had been a venue of different cultures through the times. From Syene on and downwards, villages and cities sprinkled the shore left and right of the Nile, while upwards, it was mostly deserted land with very few and very little settlements.

I hesitated to reveal my wishes to the station commander. Chances were good that he supported Ptolemy and just would ignore me in the best case. So I tried my luck directly at the docks instead. Although these were formally subject to the garrison also, as the Pharaoh's envoy, my authority was superior. I just hoped that nobody would question it too deeply.

"Where is the overseer," I asked a young boy, who loitered around the port jetty. The sight of me dusty and dirty was probably not particularly impressive, because all I earned was a shrug. I tossed him an obol and asked again.

The boy jumped up and led me to a barrack between others, knocking at the door. A muffled "What?" was heard from inside.

"Someone asks for you, old man," the boy mocked.

The door opened after a few seconds and a bald, mid-forties man came out. "I really want to know what I did to the gods to deserve you."

The boy shrugged and went back to his previous outpost. I realized that he did this as something like his job, earning himself a bit of money. Not at all stupid, the little one. Good for him that the overseer seemed to hide himself.

“What do ya want?” the man asked, seemingly not overly impressed by my appearance, too. I should dust myself off, I thought. And take a bath. But instead, I took off the Pharaonic plaque that hung around my neck. “You recognize this?”
His appearance changed. He immediately stood to attention and stuttered: “Apologies, honorable lady. I wasn’t aware—"
I narrowed my eyes and cut in. “Yeah, obviously not. Spare me the apologies. I need a ship to the delta. Fast. Best of all yesterday.”
He frowned at the demand but did not deny it. “That’s… difficult. We have a boat, but we need to man it with soldiers from the garrison. You should speak to the commanding officer there.”
Shit, exactly what I tried to avoid in the first place. But maybe…
“How many men do we need?”
“Ten. More, if you want to be faster because you can alternate the rowers then. It's a long trip.”
I smirked. That I could afford. “So tell me, do you have some laborers here who want to earn an extra drachma? ”[14]
His eyes glistened because he sensed a deal. And after some bargaining, he went off to rally some men for manning the ship. Within one or two hours, everything should be ready, he promised.
And kept his word. Two hours and a bath later, we were on our way down the Nile, to Pelousion at the easternmost reach of the delta, right across to Judaea. After laying down on a stretcher, I fell asleep minutes after we’d left Syene and only woke up hours later, at late afternoon.

The row master had kept a steady pace and did a good job in handling his crew. Upon my question, he answered: “We will reach Thēbais at the evening, in four hours maybe. We should make a rest there to resupply, just a few hours.”
I shook my head. “This takes too much time for me. I need to leave a message for the archive in Coptos, but I don’t want to linger around in Thēbais for the night. We can rest in Coptos for two hours, but not any longer.”
He was up for some protest but swallowed it when he saw me playing with the plaque. “Good. Coptos it is,” was all he replied.

To show some mercy and goodwill, I allowed him to hire four additional men and made the rest three hours. It took me a bit of time to find the chief archivist at the archive, who led the institution. He was a short and fat man who clearly hadn't done any physical work during his lifetime. Nonetheless, he had an important job in running the archive, which served as a messenger station for larger parts of Upper Egypt as well - and they were still loyal to Cleoptara, which was the most important reason for me. He invited me for lunch and I only accepted it, when he started talking about Hordak's - eh, Psamtik's - actions in Thēbais.
"It is extraordinary work, what Hordak does there. He had been laying out a new settlement beside the old town. The houses are still under construction, but they are built of clay, stone, and wood in equal parts. Wood! I wonder from where he gets so much of this precious material. It's not like — hehe — we have many forests around, or do we?" He wiped his forehead with a sheet and shot an apologizing glance. "And he digs wells and installs fountains, so people have easy access to water." Looks like Hordak got a little fan in this man.
"And he started to dig out one of the old temples. Most of them have drowned in the sand today, but it seems that he wants to revive one of the old worships. Hundreds of men are digging from day to day. This must have been what it looked like, in the great ancient times of the old Pharaohs, when Egypt was at the height of its power. Not like today—"

He stopped short when he realized what he had just said. I waved it off. "Don't worry, I understand what you mean." His relief was palpable. Cleopatra's father, Auletes, would likely have him beheaded upon the unintended insult.
But it was only true, and I really didn't care about such idiotic cruelties, so I continued. "It's not that I deem the ancient times a proper idol to emulate. You know, all these plagues here and plagues there and the slaughter of thousands on behalf of some priest who believed he had visions and such. No, that's not for me.
But it must be a sight in Thēbais, I give you that. Now I regret

just rushing by in the morning. I saw some of the cranes above the shore, but nothing else."
The archivist continued to tell about the works in Thēbais. I listened carefully, because every piece of information was valuable, as I knew that Cleo deemed Psamtik as an ally. I frowned upon the revelation that he also started to rally troops. Most of the former units stationed had been withdrawn to Alexandria on the order of Achillas, Ptolemy's general. Others had joined Cleopatra's forces. Our entire nation was to be torn apart by their struggles. But Psamtik seemed to have his own plans and raised men on his own. That was interesting because usually, this was a privilege of the Pharaoh — and his court. I made a mental notice to ask Cleopatra if she ordered him to do so.
After a few minutes of more chatter, I handed him over a sealed scroll with the order to forward it to Buhen. There were no important instructions in it, just some assurances and the admonition to report properly every week to Coptos, as the connection was established now.

I thanked the archivist and left for the dock. As expected, except for the two men who had to stand guard, everyone on board was asleep, just lying around where it was reasonably comfortable. A malicious smile formed at my face when I put a finger to my lips and motioned for the guards to remain silent. Then I tiptoed to the middle of the boat and formed a funnel in front of my mouth with both hands.

"ALARM! ALARM! Enemies on board! Enemies on board!"

Everyone jumped up in an instant and shook off the sleep. A few men raised her fist, looking around wildly, the row master drew his dagger, ready to defend himself against… absolutely nothing. I cackled aloud, patted my knees and found myself absolutely funny. The two guards fell in quickly and quickly, everyone eased. After a few moments a few other men fell in, but most of them were still busy composing themselves. I strolled over to the row master. Me saying "That was funny" earned me nothing but a grumble, but then he readied everything, and we cast off quickly afterwards.

The journey to Pelousion lasted seven days, which was quite fast, I had to admit. Usually, it should have taken at least nine, but the row master did a good job in balancing rests and swapping the tired men. The incentive of a bonus from me did the rest.
I wasn't really worried about any struggles with men from Cleo's brother or Achillas. Patrolling the large river was something we always did, but rather due to taxes, and not for surveillance. There was just way too much traffic to really guard it. Instead, we tended to guard the ports, and tax the tradesmen, not the traffic. Plus, the river was wide, and it would've needed a really good crew to catch up to a boat as fast as ours. So, traveling down the Nile was an easy trip, and going with the river flow was of course much more satisfying than rowing against the current. The irrigated fields, little villages, settlements, and the greater cities just flew by the whole night and day. Sometimes, a pyramid was to be seen. We made short rests now and then, to requisition water and food, but besides that, we constantly moved down the mighty and life spending river.

When we approached the delta behind Giza, the river split up into several branches, and soon, the ever-present desert was no longer to be seen. Here, every square foot of the land was used to grow crops and fruits, with farms and villages occupying every piece of arable soil. The delta of the Nile was one of the most productive regions in the world, the yearly flood providing it with fertile earth for thousands of years now. Most of our wheat stemmed from here. We turned eastwards, traveling further down the Pelousion branch[15], passing the city of Per-Bastet. The great temple in honor of the cat goddess Bastet had been destroyed for hundreds of years and its stones had been reused in other buildings. Nonetheless, I held Per-Bastet in dear memory, for being a former center to honor my namesake. And because of a night of heavy drinking and some cheerful memories. Not worth speaking about, for sure. Crocodiles lay sleepily in the reeds as we rowed by and lazily blinked at us. They were used to the presence of these ever busy two-leggers since ever, and they didn't really care about. We would pass by, as always. It was an eventless trip.

And a day later, we arrived at Pelousion. I thanked the crew and handed over the promised bonus to each of them personally. Then I said goodbye and jumped ashore.

Pelousion was a city under siege, that much was clear on first sight. On the western side of the river shore, between devastated fields, most parts of the Egyptian army, presumably under the command of general Achillas, had set up their tents and suspiciously eyed every movement of Cleopatra's troops on the eastern shore. Cleopatra's army consisted of some loyal contingents of the Egyptian army, mostly from nomes of Upper Egypt, and the reinforcements she'd been able to gather in Judaea and Syria, mercenaries mostly. And behind her army, Pelousion.
Luckily, I had ordered to let me off-board a good part before the military camps and therefore, I could easily walk towards one of the roads that led to the city and that weren't blockaded by Cleopatra's forces. After all, a city had to be supplied with everyday's needs and none of the parties wanted to starve their own citizens to death.

At least, not yet.

I approached the southern gate of the city wall, a not too impressive structure. I could easily climb it. Again, and slightly scolding myself, I realized that it would have made sense to freshen up a little, because the guards weren't impressed with my appearance. Already done with the bullshit, I just took out the plaque and asked: "Where is the Pharaoh?" I got puzzled looks until one of the guards hesitantly replied: "In the temple of Amun, your grace. Shall I call for a guide?" I shook my head. "No, just show me the direction. I'll find my way."
When I reached the temple in the center of the city, business there was in full swing. People ran up and down the steps of the temple and when I went inside, I saw that a little crowd had assembled around a table in the middle of the great hall. Did Cleopatra really set up her war room within the temple of Amun? This woman was just weird. And really, really stubborn. Even I wouldn't have had the courage to do something like this in Buhen,

because Amenemhet would've whined at me the whole day and night.
I jostled between some folk and arrived in the inner circle of people. Where Cleo stood, her back to me, and listening to a general or something. He rambled about supplies for the troops and some incidents around the river shore the night before. Nothing important, so much I guessed immediately.

The discussion ebbed for a moment and I decided to not wait, because I was already bored. "Greetings to you, Morning and Evening of Upper and Lower Egypt," I called.
Everyone turned to me, some frowning upon my dirty appearance, others recognizing me, already backing down. Cleopatra didn't turn around but just said audibly: "We adjourn for an hour. Leave."
Many of the attendees were baffled, but no one complained. And soon, we were all alone. Cleopatra had some problems with their siblings. But she ruled this place on her own authority.

Finally, she turned over to me, letting her glance wander up and down my whole presence. Her face was still the same as when we saw last time, but her eyes were looking tired. And amused. "You look a bit… dusty, Catra. Wouldn't you mind a bath or something?" A smirk formed on her face.
I deadpanned. "Later. You said I shall come, here I am. What's up?"
The Pharaoh of Upper and Lower Egypt, still a young woman, looked at me, eyes wide, now really baffled. When she shook her head in laughter, her dark hair flew around and made her look even younger. "You're priceless, sister. I really love you, you know?" Then she threw herself into my arms, obviously this being the reason why she had sent everyone away in the first place. A Pharaoh never hugged anyone.
"It's so good to have you here, Catra," she muttered into my dirty cape. "How have you been? How is the situation in Buhen? Please, tell me. I really need some good news."
I was surprised by the sudden and nearly public display of affection. We'd seldom even touched each other, with her being something like a god-like being and me just… a normal human.

But I assumed that the recent months couldn't have been easy, and so I hugged her back, despite the result of dusting her with all the sand on me.
She coughed and let me go. "You should refresh yourself. Really."
"What? Are you afraid of a little dust?" I teased her.
She wave a hand before her face. "It's not about the dust. You stink."
I sniffed at my sleeve and nodded. "Maybe. It's called sweat, Cleo. That's how real people doing real work smell. Maybe you'll get used to it some time."
Cleopatra ogled me, then said: "No hurries. On behalf of the Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods and the Messenger of on High - which is me - I oblige and send you to take a bath. Now, little Bastet!"[16]
I raised my hands in defeat, secretly grateful, and replied: "Well, your majesty. But in the evening you'll tell me everything and I want to know why I have struggled through Egypt for days now.

Cleopatra called for a servant to guide me to the baths, but before I left she said: "Prepare for a long night, sister. We'll have to talk about a lot of stuff. And I have a very special… duty for you."
She pulled a corner of her mouth, then clapped her hands, calling some other folk for further discussions. And she was right, actually.

I needed a bath.

Chapter End Notes

> Have a little teaser and watch out for MariaSeelie's full, colored drawing in the next chapter.


Adora, Cleopatra, Catra

[12] Iteru: Egyptian length measure ~ 10,5 km ↕
[13] Syene is the city of Aswan today, right below the Aswan High Dam. ↕
[14] The drachma was a coin in the Hellenistic world and widely used as a means of payment. ↕
[15] This branch of the Nile is believed to have sanded up in the 3rd century BCE. Nonetheless, Pelousion stayed the easternmost fortress and city of Egypt towards the Sinai and its port was rebuilt some times, because of also being silted. ↕
[16] Bastet, the old Egyptian goddess of protection, cats, fertility, pregnancy, children, music, the arts, and warfare. Actually, Cat-Ra would be a nice translation too. ↕

Adora, this is Cleo

Chapter Summary

Catra should shut up more often.
The Pharaoh is really busy.
Adora knows how to keep her dagger.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

After six days onboard Cleopatra's galley, the initial awe upon her gesture had worn down, at least to some extent. Of course, it still was something to be on a ship this size, manned with so many people rowing it and all of that just for me. But I just... got used to it. After all, it was only a ship. A glorified, overly decorated, magnified version of a ship.

Other ships we crossed paths with were clearly curious. It was visible how some of them eagerly kept their distance in the presence of such a mighty vessel, while others obviously tried to take a closer look. The captain had raised both a Roman and a Pharaonic flag, so we weren't afraid of any encounter. Today, the Mediterranea sea was little more than an oversized Roman playground, a mean to transport our legions all across the known civilized world and bring back goods from our provinces to the heart of SPQR. Despite we didn't see ourselves as a seafarer nation, we, in fact, were one. Most of our provinces bordered the Mare Mediterraneum and like we built our streets everywhere we set our foot on to mark it as ours, we did it alike with this ocean by calling it Mare Nostrum, Our Sea. As far as we were concerned, every land touching it was ours to govern - except for Egypt, of course.

Our journey went by uneventful, and on the morning of the seventh day, sunlight found Bow, Alexas, and me leaning on the

railing and at one of our discussions about the current state of Egypt and the struggles of Cleopatra and her brother in particular. But despite being a confidante and mentor of the current most famous scion of the Ptolemies for a decade now, Alexas wasn't just a blind idiot. He clearly saw the reasons for the ongoing conflicts weren't just the fault of one side only. During her reign the two years before, Cleopatra had blatantly tried to sideline her brother, and as far as history taught him and his advisors, it could've easily been the prelude to getting rid of him completely. In a severe, final way.

"I didn't find it surprising that Ptolemy allied with Achillas and Pothinus. Or rather that Pothinus took his side against her. Cleopatra is quickly becoming a strong sovereign and she tried to push her brother's advisors aside. Pothinus clearly must have felt threatened. And as his regent, Pothinus has massive influence over Ptolemy and is more acting on his own. Don't forget, the boy is a just thirteen years old by now, merely a child. So, this is not his doing, but that of his councilmen, mainly Pothinus, general Achillas and Theodotus of Chios. Anyway, she lost ground to this council and the court, and after they got her exiled, everything went south very quickly."
Bow nodded. "I can understand that. Cleopatra didn't back down, but instead she gathered military supply. What an achievement for such a young woman, if I'm allowed to say."
Alexas nodded, looking over the sea and pondering about his answer. "Yes. From a more… elevated point of view, I admire her for her persistence and strength of will. She is a born leader and unbelievable clever, given her age. That's clearly the reason why many at the court see her as a threat to their sinecures. Ptolemy will be easy to steer. She won't. If she comes out of this as queen, she'll be the strongest Pharao Egypt has since centuries." He bowed forward, bent his index finger several times to lure us closer and whispered conspiratorial: "But don't tell her that I said that. It just goes to her head, and I'm already having a hard time to keep her grounded." We snickered, and somehow, the atmosphere of our conversation seemed to be a little lighter.
"The Ptolemaic struggles are… legendary and this generation

looks like they are no exception, hmm? But Cleopatra seems to be different than her predecessors," I said, and added: "I mean, learning all these languages has to mean something, doesn't it?"
Alexas nodded. "The first Ptolemaic Pharao to learn Egyptian."
Then he turned to me: "Actually, I have to apologize to you, Adora."
He got me by surprise. "Have I missed something? What did you do?"
He tilted his head. "When we first met, I was pretty biased. Your stepmother hadn't given me an… accurate depiction of you and I deemed you as the typical, arrogant, and pretentious Roman patrician."
Huh? That was a very honest revelation, but after the first surprise, I managed a smirk. "Ha! That's not so far from the truth as you might think. At least I am a patrician. But of course, the vile… woman didn't do anything good on my behalf."
He nodded. "Maybe. But I quickly got that you didn't fit my prejudice. You are interested and well-educated. And you might hold your own in a fight as well, as far as I've been told. Actually, I'm quite impressed so far." He bowed his head shortly in acknowledgment and I blushed a little, barely visible. Bow laid a hand on my shoulder and stepped in. "She is an exceptional woman and the most precious scion of the Julii. No one should underestimate her."
Alexas nodded. "For sure."
I winced a bit about all the acclaim. "That is too much praise, on my behalf, to believe or take it. Better stop it."

I rose from the bench we were sitting on and walked around the deck. Like the previous days, the rowers had kept a steady, constant rhythm and took us nearer to Egypt with every minute. I strolled by the first officer, a dark-skinned, older man, who was able to speak Latin. Unlike the captain.
Because of his language skills, I had talked to him once in a while during our journey and became at least somewhat familiar with him. "How long do we need until Pelousion?" I asked.
He grinned because I'd asked the same question twice today already and the answer stayed the same the third time. "We will

reach the harbor at around noon, domina. Don’t worry, you’ll surely be received immediately by her.”
The circumstances of my arrival weren’t what worried me in the first place. It was the very fact that the trap closed slowly now. Maybe it would close when I faced the Pharaoh, maybe a bit later. However, my time was running up.
So I just smiled weakly and replied: “I should prepare myself then, to make a proper appearance, right?”
The smile of this simple man was warm, despite him being the first and foremost gaffer on this ship. “Don’t worry, young lady. You’re shining like the sun and your mere presence is a delight for everyone.”
I playfully slapped his forearm and giggled, while he lightened up like a candle. “You just wanna make me blush.”
He gripped my hand and squeezed it, then he quietly said: “Don't let these royal fools treat you badly, do you hear? They are a bunch of murderous idiots, and you deserve better.”
I was baffled by his frank words, and so I just nodded and squeezed lightly back. He smiled, then his gaze fell upon two of the rowers that had become too slow, and he was back into his normal tone when he shouted orders and swung the whip again.

I had readied myself, wearing my prettiest stola and palla[17] and a pair of embroidered calcei muliebris, women’s shoes made of soft leather. Luckily, the palla was only a thin silk cloth, otherwise, I would’ve drowned in my own sweat, as the day was hot and the sun still burned.
But the white stola and deep red palla also completely covered the bandages around my left leg, where I’d always hid a small dagger. It wasn’t only for the looks. A bracelet around my wrists were the only jewelry I’d picked out, because I didn’t want to overbear it on first sight. I was a Roman, none of these exuberant orientals.
And after I had packed my stuff, I met with Bow at the deck

again, and we just stood at the railing, watching the ocean flow by at the ever-steady pace of the galley.
"Nervous?" he asked and I nodded. His hand laid on my shoulder, squeezing it gently.

Morning went by quickly and the sun was on its way to its zenith, when we spotted the flat shoreline of lower Egypt. The rowers didn't slow down their rhythm until we were around one mille passus[18] away from the harbor.
Pelousion's port wasn't very large, because it was mostly used for military purposes as well as the supply of the city itself. With the rise of Alexandria in west of the Nile delta, the other cities at the shoreline became less important for trade, and Pelousion had always just been something like a garrison to guard the east of the kingdom, rather than an actual place to live in. It was neither a large nor an important city, it was just the point where Cleopatra set up her camp.

We were approaching the port which was just a couple of piers stretching out into a half closed-off basin from a stone dam guarding them from heavy sea. Above, seabirds greeted us with song and dance.[19] The galley slowed down, and every other boat around quickly got up and away, because of the appearance of Cleopatra's *most important ship,* I sighed to myself. At the port, the largest jetty had already been cleared and a troop of soldiers hurried by and stood at attention.
The oars were retracted on my side as the ship elegantly swung sideways to get alongside the quay. Ropes were tossed from the land side and quickly, the ship lay still, and the gangway was lowered. Everything had happened unbelievably smooth and quick, being testament to the expertise of the crew and I watched it in awe - and maybe my mouth stood a little agape. The Ptolemies might be unable to hand over their reign properly, but their servants understood their craft well.

When everyone on land turned their attention to the ship, it dawned on me that they might expect the Pharaoh herself. I quickly withdrew from the railing upon the realization, a bit frightened and feeling uneasy now. Was was I supposed to do

now? Gratefully, Alexas walked at my side and offered me his arm, mumbling: "Just follow me, Adora. There's nothing to be afraid of. You're welcome here." Bow and my escort rallied up behind us. Down the gangway, a small contingent of people had gathered, some officials and the troops to accompany them. I saw a commanding officer, obviously, because of the military look, a well-clothed courtier, an advisor maybe, and… a composed, slightly bored looking woman with tanned skin in a white and gold dress. She was beautiful and radiated an aura of self-confidence that I immediately admired. Everything about her caught my attention and I couldn't take my eyes off this woman. It felt like something… important had happened, from which I understood nothing of it.

Alexas guided me down until we stood before the reception committee. Then he posed like he had done upon my greeting in Seleukia Pieria and called:
"I present, Adora Diana Minor of the Julii, beloved daughter of the most honorable Sextus Julius Caesar, admired niece of Consul Gaius Julius Caesar, pearl and gift of the Senate and the People of Rome!
She wishes and demands to be received by the only true Pharaoh, Cleopatra VII Philopator, Lady of Upper and Lower Nile, Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods, Messenger of on High and Vanguard of the End times."

He had to clear his throat afterward, but I was as impressed as I was the first time. His voice was so stately, but the woman he spoke to obviously didn't care. She made that clear by her answer: "Oh, spare the praise for the palace, Alexas! This is too much for now. It's just the port here. And just us." Her face was stern, but there were some sparkles in her eyes and her voice sounded mostly teasing.
Alexas chuckled lowly and turned to me. "Adora, I may introduce you to Catra Meritamun, beloved sister—"
"Half-sister!" the woman insisted with a raised index finger and an instructive voice.
"Beloved half-sister of Cleopatra—"
"And I would doubt the *beloved* also," Catra interjected again,

waving it off.
"Oh, now shut up," Alexas replied, now seemingly annoyed with her casual manners, "nobody loves you. I'm just being diplomatic, you pain in the neck. Why did Cleopatra send *you,* of all people?"
The other advisor pinched his nose with his fingers, obviously trying to withhold a groan.
I was stunned, too. Was this the usual tonality between the both of them?
Catra seemingly wasn't offended, as she chuckled. "Because she deems our guest important enough, maybe?" Her voice sounded a bit haughty, but, maybe, as Cleopatra's sister, it could be okay, I assumed.
"She should've come herself then, and not send some dopey and ill-mannered nuisance." His words were harsh, but his tonality didn't seem to reflect it.
"Alexas, if the poor woman could stand your boring presence for a week, she can clearly stand mine for a day," Catra retorted lightly.
I eyed the beautiful woman before me and tried to put together a picture of her. Her manners were… questionable, to say the least. She had some feline attitude, fitting to her name and the mane she wore. A tight and stringy figure, the mane consisting of fluffy, brown curls, and… heterochromatic eyes. The one of a shady yellow, the other some kind of turquoise and they were intriguing. I stared at these eyes and couldn't take mine off of her.

"Adora!" I felt Bow nudging my shoulder, snapped back, and asked "Yes?"
"Maybe we should continue?"
I felt so embarrassed. I had been ogling Cleopatra's sister like a creep, and she must've noticed it because she'd stared back intensely. Oh Bona Dea, please let this moment pass. Fortunately, my wish was heard as Alexas introduced the other two men, whose names I had already forgotten because my thoughts were drawn to this mysterious woman.
Catra seemed to be in command of the delegation, because she ordered everyone to mount and head for some temple in Pelousion, as far as I understood her words. I had tried to learn some Egyptian words, but of course, pronunciation and

articulation had been none of my business until now. Catra offered me her arm and guided me to a palanquin. Only the both of us took our seats inside, while the others mounted on horses that stood by. Alexas rode by and looked inside. “I leave you in the capable hands of Catra, Adora. She is not the friendliest, but she will get you to your destination unharmed. We’ll meet again at the temple.”

My escort as well as Catra’s troops lined up at the top and end of our sudden procession. She beckoned me to enter a palanquin and quickly, twelve servants heaved it up and then, the whole caravan started to head towards the city.
I had been used to litters in Rome, of course. There, they were usually for one person only and carried by four slaves at most. Many patricians used them as a mean of transportation, because the streets were often dirty. Here, it was a bit more overdone, seemingly. I looked outside and saw that we would need a bit of time to reach our goal, as the harbor was a few hundred meters away from the next settlements and the city wall was even behind. Weird, I thought. Usually, cities were directly built at the sea and spread around a harbor. Here, it was different.
My pondering was interrupted as my company spoke up: “Did you have a pleasant journey, Adora Diana Minor?”
Her Latin was quite good, just a small accent was audible. Just enough to make it sound interesting, given her rough, husky voice that rolled the r’s like a little purr.
“Yes, thank you, your highness. And please, call me just Adora.”
Catra chuckled and her curls teetered. “I’m no highness, I’m also just Catra.”
I was surprised. “But Alexas said, you were Cleopatra’s sis—"
“Half-Sister! And only by the maternal side. So no link to the Ptolemaic line of heritage. We’re connected by our mother."
I understood. Catra was not really a part of the Ptolemaic family, and due to that, she must be older than Cleopatra.
"My mother was a priestess," she added.
That was interesting. “So you are a member of the religious… caste? I don’t know that much about the Egyptian religion, my apologies.” I shrugged my shoulders a bit.

But her face was relaxed, her eyes a bit amused, and her informal manners eased me. “No harm done. I’m also no priestess and such. I’m just Cleopatra’s sister, whom she tasks with the more… difficult matters, to put it that way.”

I furrowed my eyebrows. “I am a difficult matter?” What was that supposed to mean?
The sarcasm was audible, and she smirked way too much. “Oh, you’ve no idea. I assume, if Ptolemy knew about your presence here, he would order a full-scale attack on Pelousion immediately.”
“What?” I didn’t get that. Was she serious? That couldn't be true.
My expression must’ve been readable because she explained. “It’s not about you in person. It’s about what you represent: a possible connection between Cleopatra and the most influential Roman gens of our time, and therefore, with the might of the Roman Republic. He would be an idiot to let that happen. It's a direct threat."
I shook my head. "Maybe Cleopatra overestimates my standing in the family or that of my father."
She repeated my gesture by shaking hers, underlined with a serious grin. "I highly doubt that. Cleo is pretty clever, and there aren't so many of your kind. If your family is going to sell you to some of ours, it must be serious." Still this smug smirk on her face.
My eyes must’ve been as wide as plates. “Did you really call the Pharaoh ‘Cleo’?"
Catra chuckled, her beautiful eyes sparkled with joy. "Don't try that yourself. She gets it hardly from me and that's only because I'm having none of this "Pharaoh here" and "your highness" there."
I barked out a laugh. The resemblance to my words to Alexas was just too funny.
"What's so entertaining?" she asked. I just shook my head and mumbled "Oh nothing, it just reminded me of something."
She didn’t insist, and we stayed silent for some minutes, while our convoy was nearing the city wall.

“Is the city beleaguered?” I asked when I saw several troop units scurry around, obviously guarding it.

Catra nodded. “Yeah. For a few weeks now. After Cleo returned with some… backup from Judaea and Syria, she took Pelousion and Achillas set up his camp right across the river. Neither of them want to launch a full scale attack until now, so it’s a boring stalemate while they’re ogling each other like idiots.”
Disregarding her super casual manners, I replied: “Hmm… I see. So we aren’t in imminent danger or such? It's not that they'll attack tomorrow?”
Catra shook her head in denial.
I wondered. “But how does she do it? I mean, financing a private army this size when she isn’t in control of the treasury?”
Catra smirked, but didn't really explain it. “As I said, she’s pretty clever. She’s got the means necessary. And at least half of Egypt loves her. She’s the first Pharaoh of Egypt since Alexander's conquest to actually speak Egyptian, and she traveled it back and forth, unlike her brother. The common folk is mostly on her side. She controls the Thebais and most north of it. The Hellenes are obviously not so much in her favor, and the court is divided. The Roman… influence makes everything more complicated, too."

There was so much I didn't understand. I had read much of the history of the Ptolemaic struggles and all in all Cleopatra and her brother seemed to be no exception, except perhaps that Cleopatra was even more ambitious, clever and forward thinking. Or maybe she just wanted to be on top to survive. Unlike her siblings. Unfortunately, previous times hadn’t seen a colossal realm like ours struggling with similar problems at the same time right before their doorsteps. All of this made up an explosive mixture with so many parties involved.
Catra herself was also a mystery. Her casual and informal manners distinguished her from all the other officials I got to know. She seemed to be very relaxed - unlike me. But also unlike me, she wasn’t up for marriage to some weird Egyptian noblemen, so I credited myself with that.

“You and Alexas know each other?” I asked, because their contact felt very familiar.
“Yeah. He’d been Cleo’s tutor for a decade, I think. And he and I run into each other on every occasion. I would call it a love-hate

relationship. He deems me hot-headed and too confident, given my origin and lack of education, and I think he's an old weird dude too formal for modern times. We love each other deeply, as you can see.” Her tone was amused, she was joking.
“And why did she send you, of all people, to welcome me, how he put it?” I tried my luck a bit, to catch up with her playful nature.
“I shall be your companion until the formalities have been cleared. And to introduce you to Egypt, maybe to show you around until…”
She fell dry, but I understood.
But having Cleopatra’s sister as a companion seemed a bit much.
“Isn't that below your dignity? Don’t you have... more important stuff to do, than to babysit someone like me?”

She waved it off. “Hmm, nah. I commanded a settlement at the second cataract of the Nile the recent year. It was a good assignment, but Cleopatra needed me and so, I’m here. It got boring anyway. I mean, it was in the middle of the desert.”
It sounded like there was more to it. She’d been a commander of a settlement. So, more like a governor? Which governor would like to exchange his post for something like this? And the relationship between Catra and Cleopatra seemed to be interesting, to say the least. Again, I inwardly sighed upon the realization that there was so much I didn’t understand at all.
While I was still pondering, we must’ve reached our goal, because the palanquin came to a halt and was put down. Catra looked outside and exited immediately, then she offered me her hand. When I laid mine on hers for getting out, it was like a shot of warmth that rushed through me. Was she stroking my hand lightly with her palm, or was that just an illusion?
The whole touch was short and formal, but it was also intimate.

It made me blush a bit.

Luckily she didn’t notice and guided me up a few stairs to a temple. The building wasn’t very large, obviously only a minor one, because the city itself wasn’t very important either. The front of the building was equipped with columns and a large arc led to the inside. And there were soldiers guarding it, many of them, everywhere around the building. A clear sign.

Catra was obviously known, because we could pass without being questioned. When we entered the not overly large main hall of the temple, there was a heated conversation going on between two men of the military, two more informally clothed men and a young woman in a white gown and matching sandals. They stood beside a large wooden table with maps and scrolls on it, in the middle of the hall. The soldiers, presumably generals, given their behavior, and the other two seemingly wanted to convince the woman of something she didn't want to hear or do. She shook her head repeatedly and her black hair flew around. In some archways at both sides of the rooms stood several people, obviously waiting for the discussion in the middle to play out. A little like an arena battle.

Catra laid her hand on my wrist and whispered: "We wait. It won't last long."
I stopped beside her and, after a few seconds, I asked quietly: "How do you know?"
She chuckled silently and whispered: "Cleo is already pissed. She will start yelling soon, and then she will dismiss them. Just watch, it could be funny."

The relationship between the two seemed to be very close. And so, this was the first time I had a look at Cleopatra VII Philopator, Mistress of Sedge and Bee and Pharaoh of Egypt. One of the two. She wasn't very tall, maybe Catra's size, who was half a head smaller than me. Cleopatra's hair was raven-black, shiny and silky, her figure slim, almost graceful. She wasn't ethereal or so, but she had a strong appearance that radiated strength. And she was young, younger than me, I remembered. She must be 21, I calculated, and despite her age, she had an authority that was unrivaled in this hall. This woman was clearly the most powerful person here, without a doubt. Four men, each at least twice her age, pestered her, and she just firmly stood there with her arms crossed and shook her head. Suddenly, I envied her a little, wishing that I had that much control over my life, but ever since that fateful day back in Antiochia, I rather felt like a sacrificial lamb. This woman clearly wasn't. Not really a predator, but not far from it either.

Before us, the discussion had turned into an argument. The men pressed on her, but she didn't seem to give in. Cleopatra pointed wildly around and a minute later we saw her making a gesture that shut everyone down, and I understood the yelled word "Enough!"
The men immediately backed down. The generals bowed, the advisors shook their heads, and all of them withdrew, leaving an angry Pharaoh behind. Cleopatra was panting a bit, but after a few moments she ran her hands through her hair and straightened it. Like a wave running over her appearance, she calmed and started to look around. Her gaze fell on Catra, where it visibly softened, then on me. She waved curtly and Catra grabbed my wrist again, saying: "Now we can meet her. Don't be formal. It isn't the time and place for exaggerated greetings. This is just a war room. She's not a goddess."

I was confused. This should be my first encounter with Cleopatra? I tried to straighten my palla while walking, and failed miserably. All of this was going so fast, but then I already stood before the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt - and didn't know what to say. The face of the young woman was composed again, only a little of the heat from the previous argument left over. After a few moments of rather uncomfortable silence she pulled a corner of her mouth, barely visible.
Luckily, Catra helped us out, somehow. "Oh goddess. Hey, Cleo. This is Adora. Hey, Adora. This is Cleo… patra." She drew out her sister's name on purpose and said Pharaoh, Queen of Egypt, rolled her eyes.
When she replied, her voice was melodic and fetching. "Thank you Catra, for your inimitable service. The Messenger of on High and Vanguard of the End times is delighted by your devotion. We are so delighted to have you in our service."

It sounded so sarcastic that I couldn't hide my laughter. The sound just blurted out of me.

Immediately, I clapped my hands before my mouth and muttered: "Apologies, your highness."
Cleopatra turned her attention to me. "Never mind. She'll never

change, and she's the only one who's allowed to talk to me like this. It's somewhat grounding, given all these 'your highness' here and 'my lady' there. Sometimes I just wish she would learn what is appropriate and what's not."
"Never, morning and evening of all of Egypt," Catra replied dryly with narrowed eyes.
Cleopatra scoffed quietly. "Don't you have anything to do? Over there, maybe?" She pointed at a corner of the temple where absolutely nothing was.



(Commissioned work of @MariaSeelie)

"Please, Adora, come with me." Without paying further attention to her sister, Cleopatra gestured to me to accompany her and

turned around, not really waiting for an answer. We walked through the temple and another hallway and reached a courtyard at the inner side, surrounded by arcades and cloisters. It was silent here, and no people were to be seen. She sat down at a stone bench and patted at her side when I just stood before her, not sure what to do. I slowly lowered myself and folded my hands, a bit nervous because of… all this.

"Thank you for accepting my invitation, Adora. I know this has been a great step for you," she said, and it sounded honest. Her voice got even warmer than before and was all welcoming. But I frowned upon her words. As if I've had a choice. My face must have betrayed my emotions because she asked: "What?"
I considered my alternatives. Telling the truth could probably help me find a way out of this mess, maybe sabotage the whole idea right now. She seemed to be genuinely interested, but she'd also played an important role in negotiating the whole plan in the first place. Could she be trusted? I was not sure about that.
And on the other side, my father's been right on one point: being away from my stepmother and on my own for the first time was exciting. My main aim was to draw out the whole process for as much time as possible. Because time was what I needed. Within time, everything could change. The circumstances could change. The deciding people could change. Their opinions could change. I needed as much time as possible.
And was intrigued by all the new experiences I made. Even now, I sat beside one of the most powerful women in the world, and she was asking about my… what had she been asking anyway? I snapped back out of my train of thought and peeked over at Cleopatra.
"Apologies, your highness. I… I'm afraid that I got lost in my… thinking."
She laughed quietly and replied: "I could see that. What is going on in this mind of yours, Adora?"
I tried a path in the middle.
"Actually, I'm overwhelmed and unsure, your highness. All of this is new, and I don't really know what to make of it."

Cleopatra leaned back a little and she smiled reluctantly. She was obviously pondering her answer, and came up with this: "I understand. All this must be overwhelming for you to some extent. I've been used to acting quickly and decisively for years, because at any given moment it's not just my position that's at stake, but often enough my life. The history of many of my predecessors shows this clearly. That's no secret. But my struggles are not of your concern. Instead-"

She was cut short as one of the generals from before hurried by and grimly called: “Achillas is attacking, my queen. We have to react immediately.”
Effortless, in a flowing movement the young Pharaoh stood up, cursing “The damn idiot,” her voice all cold and grim now, then she threw me an apologetic look and a “Sorry”. She rushed away, her general in tow. I was left behind, and stayed seated on the bench. I felt a little lost at first, but I quickly felt the wish to go after her, to find out what was happening. No matter what she said: remembering Catra’s previous comment, these developments affected me too. Still indecisive about what I should do, suddenly Alexas rushed over, explaining: “I shall guide you to Cleopatra’s and Catra’s quarter. You’ll be safe there until this… situation has been cleared.”
All of this seemed to become more and more difficult by the minute.

Alexas guided me outside the temple. While we passed the great hall in one of the archways at their side, and I saw Catra standing in a round of people, including Cleopatra in a hectic discussion. After leaving the temple, strolled over to another building only two minutes away that looked like a luxurious Roman villa urbana. He twisted the corners of his mouth. “It belonged to a rich Roman merchant. Cleopatra requisitioned it for herself during her stay, because it’s just right beside the temple. You should feel familiar there.”
A troop of six guards kept watch in front of the villa, but let us through immediately. Alexas led me through the hallway and the atrium[20] on the first floor, through an archway and into a room. It

was already prepared for housing a guest. “I beg you to stay inside and wait until we reach out for you. The current situation may be uneasy, but you should have nothing to fear. I’ll send for your companion, so he can join you.”
I just nodded and felt a bit relieved. The events had happened so fast, that I already forgot about Bow’s whereabout. I now realized that we hadn’t seen each other since our departure from the harbor.

After waiting uneasily for a few minutes, I started to look around. It was afternoon now, and the day had been full of exhausting events. But I didn’t feel tired, instead I felt restless. Various thoughts swirled through my mind, about the ongoing attack, my situation, the encounter with Cleopatra, her sister… Catra. These captivating eyes, the dry and grounded humor, her firm grip when she’d touched me. All of it made my stomach feel giddy, but I didn't understand why.
I looked outside my door into the atrium, but only the occasional servant hurried by, doing his duties or whatever. I wandered around the balustrade around the first floor, more being curious - and bored - when suddenly some kind of tumult was to be heard from down below. It was coming from somewhere inside the building, and it sounded like muffled shouts or screams.
That didn't bode well, and I reached out to my leg and drew the dagger. Whatever was going to happen next, at least I would know how to defend myself. Armed with my dagger in hand, I stepped out the door.

Catra

My new assignment, to put it that way, seemed to become more and more difficult by the minute. When I saw the Julian girl, well, woman for the first time, walking down the galley, it was as if Hathor herself wanted to sweep me off my feet. She was more

than beautiful, a mixture between a shining goddess and a clumsy girl.
I was only able to take my eyes off her with difficulty. And she had noticed my staring, judging by her look. I thanked the goddesses to let this moment pass when her companion intercepted and stopped me from making a creep out of myself. Luckily, our ride in the palanquin hadn't been as embarrassing as it could've been, because she didn't pay me much attention, besides the obvious. I defaulted to my usual harshness to overplay how tenous I felt in her presence. Adora seemed to be a bit overwhelmed by the whole situation, kept looking around and was apparently a little intimidated. Either that was some kind of very good acting, or she was just the poor woman, up for marriage on behalf of those with power over her.

In my opinion, she looked like a deer in a trap from which I knew it was one. Because Cleo's little duty consisted of nothing less than to spy upon her. I should keep an eye on the whole Roman mission, but mostly on Adora. Was she really just a young woman, up to being married away to an ally? Or was there more to it? Cleopatra, despite her courage and cleverness, was deeply insecure about forming a bond with the Julian gens and Caesar's relative especially. She didn't even trust most of her own people, and given all the history of underhandedness and betrayal of the Ptolemaic-Egyptian royal court, she was right to be. Also, Caesar was known for his excellent strategical mastermind-games with allies and enemies alike, and so, of course, she didn't trust the Roman either. She would be an idiot, otherwise. Cleo practically begged me to befriend the woman and gather intel upon the intentions of her father and Caesar. All of her talking made me admittedly nervous, so I was nearly expecting some master spy or similar.

But when Adora suddenly laughed, while I introduced her to my sister, my heart just skipped a beat. It was such a genuine and happy sound, that I had a hard time not patting her on the shoulder and fell into it for some mutual giggling.
This woman was either the worst or the best actor and spy I'd ever met, and I tended to assume the first one.

Because I remembered how she'd blushed a bit, when she took my hand for exiting the palanquin. Making a fool out of myself even more I couldn't resist stroking over it with my thumb, too short to be offensive, barely noticeable, rather like a breeze of air. *But* she blushed and that couldn't be feigned.
Cleo stole her from under my nose and immediately afterwards, the attack began. I was still waiting in the temple hall and chattered with Alexas. I begged him to guide Adora into our rooms and rushed to my sister's side.

Like always in similar situations, her playful and witty tone had vanished. Now she was the leader of her army, serious and composed, despite the threat from I knew it was a very damn personal one.
"What's the situation, Palmedes," she asked the older one of her generals. The gray-haired and scarred man nodded and reported: "Achillas troops have started an attack on two points of the river, around 20 chet[21] apart. They try to build wooden bridges from shore to shore, and they use a fleet of little barges with archers on them to prevent us from countering. Our troops have advanced to our side of the shore. We cover them with arrows, but the soldiers give the bridge builders quite a good shielding. So right now, it looks like they will reach our side in around half an hour. Then we'll fight them there."
Cleopatra considered what she heard, and I asked: "Any other movements in the outback? Could this be a trap, kind of red herring?" Palmedes cocked his head. "Doesn't look like. At least 5,000 men are attacking, and they bring on a bunch of material. That's way too massive for a simple distraction, and it's a large part of their troops.
I nodded in consent. "That's right. Nonetheless, we should have a watchful eye down and up the river, if there are other units passing. Send out scouts to the harbor and the south for reconnaissance." A few nods settled that.

Another advisor cut in: "Should we move forward the ballistas from the city walls? They could help against the bridge building?" Palmedes denied. "No, it will take too much time and I don't think

we'll need them. But the idea is good. We will ready them for transport, we don't give away anything by doing so. If the battle reaches the walls, we can still set them up in time."
Cleopatra made a single nod for approval, then asked: "Is it likely that they can form a bridgehead on our side?"
Palmedes shook his head. "Not very much. We have at least 6,000 men of the infantry and 500 of the cavalry in action. They would need to double our contingent for a successful attack. And we have another 3,000 as reinforcements in the city, if necessary."
Cleo frowned. "Then why? They know all of this as well as we do. It's not enough, and they know it."
"Do not take this lightly, our grace. If they manage even a partial breakthrough, they might be able to adapt or surprise us with something. Achillas forces outnumber us by two to one, and maybe they got reinforcement of which we don't know," the general chidded.
"I know, I know," Cleopatra replied. "Nonetheless, there must be something else going on. And I want to know what it is!" She hit the table with her hand and nearly yelled the last sentence.

Her next question surprised me: "Where is our guest?"
Immediately, I replied: "I ordered Alexas to bring her to our quarters. It's guarded, and she mustn't—"
She cut in, her voice way higher than usual. "No! Bring her back! She is the most important person within the city walls besides me. We must always keep her in sight. Do you understand, sister? Never let her out of your sight! Never! Get her!" Cleo was truly upset. I wondered about her seriousness and hesitated shortly. Why was she so worried about Adora? She should be safe where she was. But Cleopatra wasn't in a patient mood and repeated: "Do you understand, Catra?"
I started from my musings and nodded. "I'll fetch her immediately."

My steps were wide and fast when I rushed outside the temple. Did Cleo have a premonition? I cursed inwardly for my ignorance of the current intrigues at court. Was there something going on at the inside that I wasn't aware of? Could there be someone traitorous?

When I reached the villa, the guards that should have watched the entrance weren't to be seen, making me hyperaware in an instant. Fuck. Fuckfuckfuck! I immediately drew my scimitar and a dagger, and was about to enter the building, when I heard my name from behind.
"Catra? What happened?"
I swirled around and recognized Adora's companion, Bow, not a second too late. I gestured to him to keep quiet and closed the distance between us. "Pshht. Something's going on. The guards are gone. Adora's inside."
He lived up to his profession, and acted quick and without any fuss or question. The man just nodded, drew his bow and nocked an arrow. I frowned. "A bow? In a house fight?"
The tanned man with the not-so-friendly-anymore face just smirked and replied: "You'll be surprised. Now go. I'll cover your back."
Good man. I moved forward and peeked inside. It was immediately clear what had happened to the guards, because they lay left and right on the floor of the hallway, obviously dead. Small pools of blood accentuated the obvious. "Shit." I muttered. "Shit Shit Shit."
No one was to be seen, but I heard noises from further inside. Heavy panting, short barked orders. I moved forward, with Bow in my back. When we reached the atrium, two masked attackers stood in our way, with drawn swords, eyeing the entrance.

The first one immediately got an arrow in the face and tumbled backward, already dead before he hit the ground. The second charged at me, but I parried his blow. Another arrow from behind missed him by a hair's breadth, but distracted him long enough. I lunged forward and cut into his side, and with a opening in his defense, kicked him down to the floor with a hard step in the gut, while already having him out of whack. He tried to roll around, to move out of my reach. Too late, because my blade found its way into his chest. I've never been afraid to kill when necessary. It was a skill I learned early, while hunting with my father, and it hadn't been particularly difficult to transfer this ability to humans.
After we got rid of these obstacles, I recognized the loud screams

from the upper floor. Bow already ran up the stairs, now me behind him. When we reached the level, we saw three men attacking Adora at the opposite edge of the colonnade that surrounded the atrium on this floor. She'd been cornered by now, defending herself with a dagger in her right hand and some piece of wood in her left, maybe a chair leg.
I briefly admired the view, because she got lost of her palla and stola, now only having her undergarments on, which showed her bare arms and legs.
Her face was an expression of pure determination, but also concern. She'd obviously kept her ground so far, but was losing it now, due to being only one against three.
We noticed three other attackers that ran towards us from the left side of the hallway, to keep us in check. Bow fired an arrow and got one of them down, but was then caught in front of the other two. Because of the narrow hallway, I wasn't able to help him from behind.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the archway, Adora was under heavy attack. I decided to let Bow handle this and ran to the other side to help the more important target. Adora was cornered from two sides and seemingly, they wanted her alive. Her own intentions were… more serious. I approached one of the attackers from behind and the second he was aware of my approach, he tried to turn around to defend himself. A dire mistake, because Adora used the chance immediately. With a long jump forward, she hit him with the chair leg on his head, and the guy screamed in pain, tumbling towards me. I ducked out from under his arms and pushed him with my shoulder over the parapet. With a scream and rowing arms, he fell down to the ground and didn't move anymore.

Two left.

Adora panted heavily. She was trained, obviously, but a real fight was something else than just sparring. It was demanding, exhausting within minutes. The heart raced, and the mind slowed everything down. Your breathing pumped faster, flushing your body with agitation and agility. Put together, your entire body and

mind were on a short high, but this state could also wear out in minutes. And this woman hadn't been prepared for an actual, physical ambush.
"Adora, behind me!" I yelled at her, while she still kept the other two in check with her dagger. The attackers made a hesitant impression, fighting at even odds now. It must've been their mission to capture Adora alive, which seemed very much unlikely now. I just hoped that no other aims were on their list… like killing her if they weren't able to catch her.

But seemingly, that wasn't their mission, because after a moment, both of them turned around and ran towards their mates who still struggled with Bow. Upon the sudden attack by four attackers, he withdrew behind the staircase into another room, while I and Adora behind me started running after them as well. One of the men lunged forward towards Bow who parried the strike well, but then he was hit by a knife that was thrown at him from another attacker behind the one he was dealing with. It pierced his side, right above the stomach and went in deep.
"Bow!" I heard Adora screaming, as he tumbled backwards, while the masked men rushed down the stairs. I briefly considered following them, but deemed the idea dumb. One against four, into unknown territory in the middle of an attack? Not a good idea.

After I assured myself that our attackers had fled the house, I turned back to Adora and Bow, who was lying on the floor. He bled out of the wound on his side, but was conscious and groaned. Adora knelt at his side.
"Take it out, get some cloth and press it on the wound. The bleeding must be stopped," I ordered her and looked around for some fabric. Then I heard voices on the first floor and yelled down: "We need bandages. And call for Alexas at the temple. NOW!"
Someone was running. Good. I positioned myself at the stairs to prevent any surprises.
Meanwhile, Adora had torn some cloth out of her own garments and pressed it on the wound. The devastated fabric left her upper thighs bare, and they were strong and perfect. The were so perfect that I couldn't... Bow panted and growled upon the

pressure she exerted while she bandaged the wound while apologizing. "Sorry, sorry, but it's necessary. Everything will be okay, Bow, we got this. They're gone," Adora muttered unhappily. He made a grimace.
"It's okay. It's not like that I haven't signed up for things like this, right," he pressed out, trying to let it sound casually. "But I think you need some other fellow for your protection for a while."

Adora leaned back, and let herself fall against the wall behind her, heaving a deep breath. After a few moments of staring, she looked at me, clearly unsure what was about to happen. I stepped to her and squeezed her shoulder. "Hey you two, we'll have help soon. You'll be treated by the best doctors we have, I promise." It earned me a grateful nod by Adora, and she laid her free hand on mine. "Thank you."
There were words left unsaid, words of grief and fear [22], I saw it in her eyes. But her skin felt soft, and there was a warmth building in my gut. I didn't have it in me to break the contact. And she didn't move.
Only when I heard a noise frome below, I withdrew my hand. Help had arrived.

An hour later, Bow had been taken care of, and it was certain that he would survive. Adora's escorting guards had manned or rather flooded the inner rooms of the villa and were supported by a contingent of 20 further soldiers around and on the roofs of the building. Noone would enter this building unauthorized without fighting through a wall of defenders. Meanwhile, the general attack by Achillas had died down and resulted in a slow drawback to their encampment. All of this smelled like a fucking trap or ruse of which I still understood to little.

Night had started to fall when I'd guided - or rather dragged - Adora back to the temple to talk with my sister again. She didn't

want to leave Bow's side, but after he fell asleep, even she understood that nothing could be done by her for the next few hours. In the meantime, my mind was racing. The attack couldn't just have been a distraction to easily attack Adora, right? Back in the hall, Cleopatra outright ignored me and grabbed Adora by her wrists, pressing out: “You are unharmed?”
Adora nodded and Cleopatra sighed, raising her hands above her head in supplication, intonating, “I make an offering to the gods tonight." I assumed this was only half for show. We'd never discussed it, but I assumed she wasn't really religious. She certainly understood the use of religion and respected belief in it. In public, she always tended to act like she believed in the ancient gods. I, on the other hand, didn't believe in anything. I was only interested in the relationships between people - although I hadn't quite got it yet.

Cleo got right back to business when asking Adora: "I heard that you defended yourself pretty well?” Adora frowned and Cleopatra nodded at me. I looked back at the blonde woman and shrugged my shoulders. Of course, I'd given Alexas an overview over what happened, and maybe I’d exaggerated a little on how good Adora had kept the attackers in check. Adora looked a bit embarrassed, but then she just lifted her stola a little to show the bandages around her lower leg, which now held the thin sheath with the dagger again.
Cleopatra whistled at the sight. “Wow. That’s… unexpected and impressive. Catra, remind me that we have to search the female guests for weapons too. It will be just too easy to assassinate me otherwise.”
I chuckled. “As if I’d need a dagger for that, Cleo.”

Her eyes pierced me, but she didn’t fire back. “Adora, please be assured that I will personally take care that your companion is treated by my best physicians. And I will station the Medjai around the villa, for your security.”
The Medjai were Cleopatra’s personal guard. Since centuries, since the old kingdom of Egypt, they had served as guards and keepers of security to the realm. Often they had served as personal guards to Pharaohs and Cleopatra had gathered a loyal

corps of them. She continued: “I think we should use the evening to dine together and talk about the next events. It will—"

Like a repetition of before, she was interrupted by an Egyptian servant who rushed from the inner rooms of the temple. The man was panting, and his eyes flickered in fear, when he came to a halt right before Cleopatra. Again, that didn't bode well. “Your highness, my lady. The seal! The seal of the Pharaoh has been stolen!” She froze and I gasped. Around us, several advisors and courtiers threw us worried looks, and somehow the atmosphere seemed a bit darker. The messenger threw himself to the ground, maybe fearing punishment for being the bearer of bad news. As if Cleo would do something stupid like this. I called him to stand up and gather himself with a scolding look.

Losing the seal was indeed terrifying news and suddenly, the attack on Adora looked like a secondary problem. The Roman woman looked questioningly at me, but there wasn't time to tell her now. The Pharaonic seal was an important sign of Cleopatra’s power to govern Egypt. Due to the conflict and ongoing quarrels with her brother, she needed it more than ever. A good part of the land, mostly the Thebais, Upper Egypt between Memphis and Syene still obeyed her and listened to Cleopatra’s demands and rulings. Partly, because she had many supporters in the more rural and common settlements outside the larger Hellenistic cities in the delta. But also partly because of the seal that she took with her when Ptolemy forced her to retreat from the Alexandrian palace. The seal was an important mean.

Adora looked baffled and was seemingly lost at the scene, when Cleopatra started to call for her advisors and other people. I grabbed her at the wrist and pulled her a bit into the background. She followed me without hesitation. “Hey, Adora. This is a serious situation, even more than the attack from before. I think this it was they were after in the first place. Attacking you might have been just a bonus. Or a distraction. But losing the seal can seriously damage her ability to fight for the throne. Please, just stay here and wait. You’re safe here. I’ll join you as soon as I can, but we’ll have to talk about this. Okay?”

Adora’s face had a confused expression on it, but she wasn’t scared. Then she nodded and crossed her arms, obviously allowing me to return to the table. I worried a bit about leaving her behind, even if it were just a few meters. She was clearly uneasy because she'd been thrown into a situation which was overwhelming while she was also condemned to do exactly nothing.

Back at the table, the discussion was already in full swing.
“...can’t give orders to the more distant towns and garrisons then. They can just refuse it. And half of them will. And the taxes—"
“Aren’t the main problem here,” Cleopatra cut in, waving it off. “But of course, Ptolemy shall not have them either and this can become the more serious problem then.”
“Any findings how it happened?” Alexas asked, and another advisor replied sourly: “Not at all. Two guards securing the room were killed, and the thieves must have used the roofs. At least we assume that, because there are no other entrances beside this hall.”
“Perfect,” I scoffed. “Not securing the roof… gracious gods. Why the hell was that seal there anyway? And not here, with you?”
Cleo’s inflection was just a *bit* scolding. “Because it’s a bad idea to let it lie around in an open space while I run around the whole day? Plus, it's not exactly a lightweight.” I rolled my eyes, because it looked like a bad idea to let it lie around in the keeping room also.
Cleopatra sighed. “Doesn’t matter anyway. It’s gone, and we’ve to deal with it.” Then she looked back at me, grinning maliciously. “Or rather, you will.”
I was surprised, a bad feeling already building in me when I asked suspiciously: “What?”
The voice of the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt was veryserious when she said: “I have another job for you, Catra. You won’t be delighted.”

Chapter End Notes

> Give “https://twitter.com/MariaSeelie” a hug and follow for her amazing art! And look at the little Sphinxes she draw.

Little Sphinxes! So cute.

[17] The Stola and Palla were the formal women's outer garments they wore when leaving the house for most occasions. All in all and even in the end times of the Republic, they were rather simple and not overly decorated clothes. ↑
[18] Mille passus, a Roman mile. Corresponds to 5000 paces and equals 1.48 km. ↑
[19] This sentence is a variation from one in "Savage of the South", Chapter 14 ↑
[20] The atrium of a Roman building was an open-air space surrounded by a building. Even in the larger, up to six-story-buildings within Rome, Atria were used to provide the rooms with light and fresh air through ventilation.The transition to the peristylium was fluent. ↑
[21] Chet: One chet equals 52.4 meters. ↑
[22]: This part of this sentence is from "glory and gore", Chapter 3 ↑

An unexpected guest

Chapter Summary

> Speaking of the devil!
> Catra has a thingy and Adora is just too clever for herself.
> At day's end, everyone has to watch his own back. Because you can trust no one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

When Catra returned from the discussion, she looked worried. The usual amused or snarky tone was gone, her face closed off and repellent and instead, she was quiet. Even if I only got to know for a day, so much wasn't hard to see. She led me back to the villa in silence, and this time we were guarded by half a dozen men for the ridiculous two-minute-walk. Back, I went up to our floor to look out for Bow. He had also been accommodated in a guest room next to my own. Both our chambers weren't very large, as this was usual in these types of buildings. But having a room of your own was some kind of luxury by itself. In a Roman household, life tended to take place in the atrium — or the kitchen, like in every civilized society, anyway. These personal rooms had a window to the upper archway around the atrium and enough space for a large bed, a drawer, some chairs, a table and a wash basin.
Bow was alone and sleeping, which I deemed as a good sign. I sat down on a chair and watched him. His breaths came steady and deep. I laid a hand on his forehead to check for fever, but his skin felt normal. I felt relieved, it was a good sign, and I shortly stroked his palm with my thumb. He sighed flatly, but didn't wake up.

Sitting there, beside my eldest friend, and eventually calming down from the ongoing high of this day made me feel how tired an exhausted I was. I started to shiver. It was a sign of weakness, surely, and I only composed myself when I heard soft steps behind me and then Catra's soothing voice: "He'll live, don't worry."
I nodded, but it came out cawing. "I know. It's okay. I'm just… I think I'm just tired. This day'd been very intense, and I nearly lost my only friend here. It's… I'm just... feeling a bit overwhelmed, I think. Maybe lonely. Don't know."
And that was true. Without Bow, I had only my escort, and they were rather more my father's soldiers than mine. I didn't know them well. And all the uneasiness of this day made me feel weak and vulnerable.
Behind me, Catra seemed to step closer, then I felt her hands on my shoulders. The touch felt so soft and made me only tremble more. She squeezed a little.
"Hey Adora. You're not alone here. We all care for you." She gently squeezed again and I felt my eyes widening. It wasn't hard to believe her words. But her touch derailed my thoughts, so I just couldn't help and scoffed quietly: "Yeah, sure. Your sister needs her bargaining chip in her battle for the throne. And for you, I'm just a difficult duty."
Her hands left my shoulder and for a moment, the loss of her touch was overwhelming. I didn't want to drive her away, to be so harsh, I knew it was unkind of me, and I wanted to apologize for my words. But then her graceful figure stepped before me, lowered herself on her heels and put her fingers under my chin to lift my face. "That's not true," Catra said, and caught my gaze with her eyes, with these beautiful mismatched eyes and a look that I could not let go. I stared at her, nearly lost myself in the enticing colors of her look.
I cleared my throat, trying to speak again, but then, nothing left my mouth. When I exhaled, I suddenly felt just completely exhausted. My vision blurred, and I had to hold myself onto something. My body felt like he wanted to betray me, all my strength gone and replaced with weakness. I reached out for Bow's bed, but found myself embraced by some arms. Catra held

me by my shoulders. Her voice was soft. "Hey, you're tired. It’s been a long day. Go and rest, tomorrow will be… just a new day,” she said. I just want to give in, to embrace her, let myself be embraced. But I couldn't. It wasn't appropriate.

My head hung low, my vision still a mess, and so I just nodded slowly and let her guide me to my room next door. There, I lowered myself on my bed and just sat, unsure what to do with myself. Pictures from the fight flashed through my mind, from me being cornered by three attackers. Yeah, I’d been able to defend myself and quite okay so, but nonetheless: the first time when I was away from home on my own, and then this. That could have turned out differently, deadly even.
Again, shivers ran down my spine and I felt how I was trembling. I didn’t even realize that Catra was still here, until the woman quietly settled down beside me and laid an arm around my shoulder, drawing me in. On instinct, torn between fighting such an unexpected intimacy with a nearly stranger, I still put my head on her shoulder. Then, trying to keep my sobs down didn't really work. Two, three times, it just bubbled out of my chest. I felt so embarrassed, for having a breakdown in front of this strong, steady woman, who I only knew for a very long day.
“It’s okay. There’s nothing to worry about. You’re alright. Your friend is alright.” Catra’s voice was soothing, calming me and despite my urge to drag myself out of her arms and this mortifying situation, I just could not.
Despite knowing this woman for a mere day, her touch felt familiar, and I understood nothing of this.
“It’s… it's embarrassing,” I stuttered. “I’m breaking down like a little child. I’m sorry.”
She gently stroked my hair. “Don’t be. This day was hard, and I can only imagine how you must feel. It’s okay. You did well.” Why did this feel so right, to be petted by her like a child?

We stayed quiet, did nothing but to sit there, in much too close togetherness. After a few minutes, I straigthened myself. I didn't shiver anymore, my trembling had stopped. It was hard to leave her embrace. I wanted to lean back, but then I just thanked Catra and started to ready myself for going to bed. I thanked her and

she told me she would wake me up in the morning for breakfast, then left the room like a ghost vanishing into thin air. I was unhappy that she was gone, but I was also barely able to untie my hair and put on a silk tunic for the night before everything faded. When I laid down on the bed, I was already asleep.

I woke up to the sound of knocks at the door. Loud knocks. I blinked my eyes open and mumbled something, clearly inaudible to anyone outside the room. After the second knocking, I sat up and put my feet on the floor before I cleared my throat to answer: "Yes? Come in."
A woman opened the door, obviously a servant or slave. She was dark-skinned, of middle age and size, and she carried a tablet with two jugs and a mug on it. She bowed, and I waved her in with a grateful nod. "Thank you," I said, and the woman just bowed again and left the room. I didn't even know if she'd understood me at all.

One of the jugs contained water, the other one orange juice, obviously, after I tried a little sip from it. I poured myself several cups and drank them eagerly. It only made me aware of my hunger, judging from the rumble of my stomach which quickly followed. I tried to remember the last time I ate something and realized, it must've been on the ship, for yesterday's breakfast. At least, I couldn't think of any meal afterwards.
I washed myself with water out of a washbowl that stood on a dressing table before a mirror. Somebody must've brought it while I was asleep. Down from atrium came the busy noises like a normal day, and I guessed it had to be well into the morning. I'd rarely slept so long, but I excused that with yesterday's endeavors. Then I dressed in a more casual way. Yesterday, I had worn the formal, decorated stola and palla. But as Catra seemed to be absolutely relaxed and Cleopatra would be busy with handling her stuff like war and such, I assumed that it would be

appropriate to set them aside for today. Instead, I put on a pair of soft trousers under a bright red tunic and a fitting belt. It was a rather unusual wear for women, but I just felt more secure in clothes that were ready for action. Yesterday had already proven it was necessary. I didn't miss to put my dagger back in place.

After I was convinced of my presentability, I went over to visit Bow. Luckily, he was awake, although he still seemed to be exhausted, and looked at me with sleepy eyes. “Adora! It's so good to see you. Have you slept in?” he asked weakly.
I hummed. "Very much. I outright collapsed on the bed and slept until now. Very unpatrician. But how about you? How do you feel today?”
He bobbed his head lightly. "Not so bad, I think. My side hurts, but the doctor said, I'll live." He gave me a thumb up, but just with his hand and I noticed he didn't dare to move his arm. I still grinned. "Yeah. You better not gonna leave me to all these mad Ptolemies on my own. I'll kill you myself if you dare to die before me."
He made a lopsided grin and chuckled lightly. “Yes, domina, I'll keep that in mind." We shared a short laugh, but he winced upon it and stopped quickly.
"And now?" he asked. "What's happening next? I assumed that we should travel further to Thēbais, but I think I'll need some days to recover."
A short ache gripped my heart and I nodded eagerly. "Of course we’ll wait. I won't go without you. Cleopatra wanted to talk to us yesterday, but she was occupied with some other trouble again, so I assume, we'll catch up on that today. I'll keep you informed, but I don't know when."

Bow grinned smugly when asking: “What’s with you and Catra?”
“What?” I was stunned.
“I couldn't fail to hear your brief *conversation* last night.”
“What? You sneaky little—"
“Behave! How could I not? I am just in the next room!"
“You pretended to be sleeping!”
“I was. Until I wasn’t because you girls woke me up. She was… unexpected friendly, wasn’t she?”

Feeling, how a blush crept onto my face, I inhaled deeply two, three times. He was right. Catra had taken care of me in a very gentle manner, and I'd felt sheltered in her arms. "Yeah," I just managed, pondering what was about her that made me feel so connected. On first sight, there were the obvious points: her beauty was unrivaled. Her eyes, two-colored and intense, sparkling but guarded. Her voice, rough and velvet-smooth all at once. The way she moved, like she was made of water and fire twined together. She was unpredictable and surprising, but I had never felt anything but safe with her, protected. Everything about her was a beautiful paradox that I desperately wanted to unravel.[23] On the other hand: these thoughts were deeply inappropriate, and by no mean I should ponder to follow this train of thought any further.

"'Speaking of the devil!" [24] Bow suddenly said and looked over my shoulder. I hadn't heard the door swing open, but just when I was about to turn around, someone called with a deep voice:
"Wuhuuu! Be warned. The mad Ptolemies come to claim your soul and devour them, unworthy mortals."
I rolled my eyes. This woman was just… How could she be so easygoing? And she openly overheard us! Ugh!
But then I straightened my tunic and stood up, not until before Bow threw me an amused look. I turned to her. Like yesterday, she looked pretty good this morning, but different. Her formal dress was gone and replaced with some airy, silk pants and a tunic-like top that loosely covered her undergarments and arms in a cross-shaped form over her chest. Everything she wore was sand colored, beside a golden belt. Her feet were bare, to my surprise. All of it put together an astonishing look.
"Are you having a good time, Catra, while listening to private talks?" I snarled.
"More than others, I guess," was her dry reply, but there were still some sparks in the corner of her eyes.
Bow joked: "I'm sorry, but I'm not dying today."

Catra fake-coughed: "That's unfortunate, I must say. I think I'm going for some slaves or other pitiable folk to torture them. We

have a reputation to lose, after all."
I stemmed my arms in my hip. "I thought you weren't related to them?"
She faked surprise and put her hand on her forehead in a dramatic gesture. "Oh no, the betrayal! I forgot! To be honest, it isn't madness on my behalf. I just like it. Cleopatra will surely go mad if she makes it long enough. Like all Ptolemies. But I'm just having fun living out my worst as her evil minion."

I shook my head in despair and opted for a topic change. "I'm starving. Can we have some breakfast?"
Catra glanced at me until she replied: "It's noon."
"Whatever," I waved it off. "I think the concept of breakfast at noon is also known in this godforsaken area of the world, isn't it?"
Here she was, the superior Roman nobility and dignity that I could pull out wherever I wanted.
Bow chuckled lowly. "Speak for yourself, Adora. I was already well taken care of." He patted his belly. "Besides, I think I will sleep again for a while. Go, fetch some food and visit me later."
I turned back to him a gently squeezed his hand. "You're sure?"
"Absolutely. I need some rest and leave you and Catra to your… pleasures, okay?"
Said Catra just groaned and called: "Why me of all people? I'm not a babysitter."
Then she pointed with a movement of her head to the door and signaled me to come with her. "We'll fetch you some food, Adora. And we should talk, actually. There's been a… development." She didn't sound so playful anymore.

I looked warily at her, but followed her down the stairs and to the kitchen of the villa. Unlike the typical style of Roman kitchens, this one was large enough to fit two huge tables in the middle, obviously often used for work. But now, only three female servants were doing some business. At our appearance, they bowed and seemingly expected to be ordered something, but Catra just waved it off and asked one of them for a plate of breakfast stuff. The woman bowed again and in no time I'd been pampered with a large selection of bread, fruit, buns, several sorts of cheese, two sorts of porridge, cold cuts of different meat and

so on. A jug with an exotic tasting milk completed it.
I stuffed myself well and my eyes must've sparkled of satisfaction, because Catra laughed while she nibbled at a bun. "Glad you enjoy it," she said.
"Oh Bona Dea, I was starving. Thank you," I replied chewing.
"Don't thank me. I didn't do anything. I may not be able to help you with your larger… problems, but you shall not be starved to death under my watch."
I smirked, but then I remembered her words from before and asked: "What for a development did you mean?"
"Right. Okay, let's see. I'm in a bind there. Cleopatra assigned me as your companion for the time being. But she also has a little… mission for me to solve in the next days. So I have to leave Pelousion for maybe a week. But I'll be back eventually."

That was… unexpected. Even if we just met the last day, I liked her company. Like it very much. And with Bow being out of the game for some days, I deemed Catra the only person here that was actually capable and willing to care for me. Of course, the house was guarded, but being trapped inside until her return almost felt worse than dealing with an attack. And Cleopatra herself obvioulsy had to deal with other stuff to be of real help, I assumed. And what should I even do without Catra? Bore me to death here?

"What do you have to do?" I asked out of pure curiosity, while still munching on some melon-like fruit.
Her face was unreadable, but she obviously pondered about how much she could tell me. "Eh, Cleopatra got an important token stolen, and I shall get it back for her."
I frowned. "Huh? Really? Are you… some kind of spy or thief?"
She giggled and it was… kind of adorable. "No, am not. But I have some useful abilities and, most important, I know exactly where to look for it. Should be an easy catch, because security isn't… a real concept in the royal palace."
Royal palace. "Do you mean that you have to go to—"
"Alexandria."
"But... ehm… isn't Alexandria in the hands of Cleopatra's brother? Won't they take you prisoner there on first sight?"

Catra shrugged her shoulders way too casually and way too beautifully. “Maybe. But, Alexandria isn’t Antiochia or some of the other little villages you’ve seen before. Alexandria is the largest city of the world, larger than Rome itself." Her voice rose in company with her finge, making her look like a teacher lecturing a child. "More than 350,000 taxpaying citizens live there, and at least the same number or even more slaves. And every day visitors, merchants, sailors, traders flood the city. On a busy day, maybe a million people are within the borders of its wall. The Mouseion of Alexandria inhabits the world's largest collection of knowledge. It is the largest city of the civilized world, and nobody surveils it for real." She made a short pause to fall back to her normal manners. "No one will notice me. It's just too much traffic and people and stuff."

I understood that. Rome was the exact same thing. An incredible 300,000 people lived there today, but governing the city had become more and more impossible. Nobody could watch who entered or left the city for real, even with our city walls. Like Alexandria, which just grew and grew, surpassing the old city walls around it, and having no significant fortifications as of today. Due to the vast and busy harbor, it was rather an open city to the sea and the land alike in this time. I got what Catra was saying.
“I see. So, you just walk in, get what you need and come back without being noticed, right?” It was just a question.
“That’s the plan, right. Should be a cakewalk, if nothing bad happens. I know this city in and out.” She seemed pretty confident about that statement.
“How do you get there?” I asked gingerly.
“By boat. I’ll take a fast ship this evening and should arrive the day after tomorrow.”
A thought formed in my mind, just a flash. It must have been visible on my face, because Catra asked: "What?"
I quickly hid my face behind a mug of milk. "Nothing," I mumbled and turned the conversation away from it. "When do I talk with Cleopatra about the further proceedings?"
"Anytime you like. She isn't so busy today as yesterday. We can meet her at the temple.”

I didn’t know if I should feel relieved or frightened upon a real conversation with her sister. Yesterdays attempts had been interrupted twice. Anyway, it had to be done. "Good. Let me finish this, and then we'll go,” I mumbled, while stuffing myself with some more oatmeal. Despite Catra's revelation to be gone for some days, the quite delicious treat let me still feel my hunger, and I didn't want to go hungry before the Pharaoh.

Having an escort for an actual two-minute-walk felt slightly exaggerated, and ridiculous, and overachieving. So I was glad when we reached the temple, where the guard stayed in front of it at the broad stairs, looking bored. As the day before, we walked them up and entered the hall with the archways. Cleopatra was sitting on her own in a chair that stood under an arch at the top end and that was overlooking the courtyard to the inner. She read a scroll, while some of her advisors were talking, standing around the table. It was a scene of simple and quiet bustle. I noticed Alexas, who greeted me with a warm smile and a nod, which I retorted with a light bow of my head.

Catra and I walked over to the young woman who was still deemed as a god-like being by half the population of her country. The other half might want to kill her, but power and glory obviously had its price. "Hello, sister," Catra said.
Cleopatra lifte her head and smiled lightly. "Hey sleepyhead. Nice that you're here. And it is good to see you are well, too, Adora." I bowed my head, deeper now than with Alexas.
Herself, she looked overtired. Catra noticed it too, because she asked: “Haven’t you slept?” Cleopatra slowly shook her head in denial. “I dozed a bit. The night was… troubled.”
“Why haven’t you come over to the villa, Cleo? It’s not that you can do much only by yelling at people until I return, right?” Catra tossed two other chairs closer, so that they built a small triangle and gestured me to sit down. She leaned forward and took her sister’s hands into hers, who let it just happen.
I remembered the feeling of her touch from yesterday. We hadn’t spoken about my nervous nearly-breakdown today, but somehow I felt that she'd meant what she’d said. Below her playful and witty, sarcastic attitude, there seemed to be laying a deeply

serious personality. Catra was surely more than met the eye, more than a pretty courtier.

Cleopatra and Catra stayed silent, still holding hands, and I started to feel like I was disturbing them, like a third wheel on a chariot. I straightened my tunic — a habit that I'd developed to do when I was nervous — and was about to speak, that I could leave them for a while, when Cleopatra said: "I haven't been scared the whole time, you know? The whole last year consisted of nothing but battling my brother, his treacherous advisors, Achillas — that pig — and so on and on. And the Romans, of course, are just in the middle of the whole mess and stirring it up. The Gabiniani[25] made everything worse." She gave me an apologetic look, which I dismissed with a hand gesture. I knew that for myself. My people had always had a favor for using internal quarrels of other nations to their own advantage. We were a master in that.

"But now I'm scared. Without the seal, I might lose control over the parts of middle and upper Egypt which are still loyal. I don't fear about my army here. Most of them are mercenaries, and they'll follow as long as I pay them. The other troops are loyal. But without the support of the bureaucracy and people out there, the cause might be lost too. When Ptolemy and Pothinus start to expand their control beyond lower Egypt, it will become… difficult, to put it that way." Her face didn't look scared, but her voice was low and fell nearly silent at the end.
Catra laid both of her sisters hand in the middle of her and put them to her lips. She kissed the back of her hands and said: "You'll get this, sister. You have all that it takes. And you have me at your side. I'll get your seal back, do not worry. If they wanted to beat you for real, the stupid morons should've brought more support."

Cleopatra chuckled shortly. "Thank you."

Just the two words of her were so persuasive, spoken with such charm that I wasn't sure, I'd been able to deny her anything. This woman was convincing, a born leader, I instantly understood. People must not be forced to obey her, they just wanted to do it.

She continued. “When do you leave?”
“Tonight. I’ll take a small and fast merchant ship from the harbor and sail straight to Alexandria. Nobody's going to recognize me at the port, I was almost never there and never on an official mission. Our connection is not well know. So, this is the fastest and easiest way. I should need two days, then one day in Alexandria and two days back. You’ll have the seal back in no more than six days.”

“Good,” Cleopatra said. Then she seemingly checked off the subject and turned to me. “Adora, I’m sorry to let you wait. The matter with the seal is… it is important to me, but I’ve been a bad host. May I invite you to dine with me tonight, at the villa? It will be a presumably short evening, given my state, but I’d like to discuss the further handling of your matters with you in person. Given the events of yesterday, I assume that things are speeding up a bit now. We shouldn’t wait for too long.”

It was more than I liked to hear, but it had to be done. “Of course, your highness. But, I’d like to remind that my companion and leader of my guard was injured. He needs time to heal, and I won’t go anywhere without him. It would be considered inappropriate for me, and I won’t annoy my father or the lares[26] under any circumstances.” I tried to sound humble.
She furrowed her eyebrows upon my answer, but did not reply immediately. Was there a slight annoyance behind the friendly face? Was it a mask? As fast as it appeared, it was already gone when she replied: “Of course you won’t leave your companion behind. That’s out of the question. We can delay everything for a week or so. That won't be a problem."
“That is a relief, thank you,” I quickly replied, eager to secure at least that much time until… until further deeds had to be done. A lot of things could happen in a week.

“May I ask what I shall do until Catra returns? I’m not used to being completely feckless and just hanging around,” I asked.
Catra and Cleopatra peeked at each other, seemingly surprised by my question. Catra shook her head, Cleopatra pulled a corner of her mouth, I looked back and forth between them, desperately

trying to catch the meaning of the silent conversation. But to no avail. Finally, Catra said. “I’m sure, we can figure something out. Just come with me.” She turned back to the tired-looking pharaoh. “And Cleo, get some sleep, at least an hour. You are of no use if you’re just weary. Do it now.”

She nodded, and when Cleopatra rose out of her chair, it became quite clear how exhausted she was. After her first step, she shivered a bit, but composed herself again immediately, straigthening her back. Only Catra and I saw it. Then she walked towards the interior of the temple, quickly surrounded by her servants again, and vanished between all the people. She wasn't very tall. But it was always clear where the center of the attention of all people lay.

I looked at Catra, unsure what was to happen now.

Catra

Holding the Julian woman in my arms the last evening did nothing to easy my troubled state. When she trembled and laid her head on my shoulder, I felt the need to embrace her to the fullest, to pet her, to whisper assuring words into her ear. The struck from seeing her first at the port had still not worn off completely.
But anything more than holding her for a little comfort was out of the question, it surely was. Even holding her like this was probably overstepping. For both of us, but most for me. We simply weren't playing in the same league. She hadn't hesitated when I drew her in, though. So I just held her at my side, until the feeling turning from being smooth, and warm, and comforting into overstepping, and inappropriate.

I had to admit, Adora'd kept up with the entire situation very good so far. If at first glance I'd regarded her as the typically useless Roman noblewoman — a godess-like beautiful noblewoman — I was refuted at the latest when I saw her defending herself against

three attackers.
She'd looked glorious, with her blonde hair swirling around, when she pushed forward and retreated with the dagger to keep the soldiers in check. Her hit with the chair leg'd been an excellent move, too. She was trained, that much I could see. And it raised suspicion in me. Could a normal patrician noble girl be in such excellent shape? Trained in the art of physical combat? Was she just playing a game of deception and, maybe, enticement?
She wasn't a usual figure, so much I could see. And of course, the whole experience finally caught up with her afterward. I felt compassion when she started to sob, but I couldn't do anything else beside just being there and holding her. Still I had Cleopatra's words in mind: "Be careful around her. Maybe she's real and acting on good faith. Or maybe not. We just don't know yet. The Julian's are known for the excellent mind games."
However, Adora'd calmed and gone to sleep. But I still had her scent in my mind, this beguiling scent of lavender and something else I just couldn't place for real. Was it musk? Cedar? I wasn't sure. It just occupied my mind.

And I realized that I didn't want to leave her for my mission. But why? I'd known her for a day, and still, she had made a lasting impression on me. Maybe it shouldn't have surprise like it did. Even Cleopatra'd been impressed by the reveal of the dagger, and also by her request to do something useful with all her time. But it'd also raised our suspicions.
So I pondered about how to use the remaining hours until my departure for the best. And given all I knew, I thought that she wouldn't mind spending some time outside, in the city. And for me, it would be a possibility to watch her closer and get ready for my departure as well.
"Listen, I've some time left and haven't a lot of preparations to do. I want to look for a few things at the market. How would you like it to stroll around a little? The city isn't big, but the market is lively."
Adora's eyes lightened up like candles, her mostly composed face showed a flush of excitement. "We could?, she nearly gasped.
"Of course, why not?" I asked bewildered. Why was she so

excited about a simple walk around the market?
"I thought… because of the guards and the attack…"
"Eh, no. That won't be a problem. We can have a small squad guarding us. But nobody will attack us in the open, at daylight, in the middle of the city." I stood up and offered her a hand. "Come on, Roman, we need some girl's time."

Strolling around the market with Adora turned out to be surprisingly funny. She obviously hadn't been to public places like markets much, and of course had never seen an Egyptian market. The constant, loud, overbearing chatter and yelling made her to proceed gingerly at the beginning. I'd ordered our guards to keep a bit of a distance and give us some space. Her eyes were wide, like a child watching something for the first time.
But she wasn't scared, not at all. Adora relaxed and dived into the mood of the setting. She didn't understand much of the calls and shouts that wafted forth and back from everyone at the market stalls. But I explained her some praises and offers that were yelled, and she quickly recognized them. Sometimes, she just stood before a market stand and watched the merchants doing their transactions, persuading possible customers, bargaining for the price. One time, she watched how a little boy stole some coins out of the pocket of a well-clothed man and did absolutely nothing. She just looked at the scenery with her mouth fallen agape and when the boy ran away, she tugged at my sleeve and asked quietly: "Shouldn't we have done anything about that?"
I shook my head very slightly. "Of course not. Thievery is punished hard, he would get maybe 100 blows with a stick. Sometimes, judges will order cutting off the hand that did it. I'm not up for that only because a rich man can't keep an eye on his money." Her look was thoughtful after that, but nonetheless, the lively atmosphere had gripped her and I wondered what a life she must've led until now, if she was so easily overwhelmed by a simple market day.

She caught my amused gaze, and it wasn't hard to get what went through my mind, jugding from my expression. I smirked into her pretty face when she said: "You know, on the one hand, it's not sooo different from our markets in Rome. I mean, they all sell

bread and fruits and vegetables and stuff, so it's the same business. But on the other hand, this just so much more… it is so alive, so excited. Everyone is buzzing with energy. It's like a whirlwind, even if they are just doing their work." She turned and point around. "Just look at their faces, Catra! I like this so much, it's magnificent," she rambled, enchanted.
I nodded and smiled, just a little teasing. "I can see that, princess."
"What?" She turned to me. "Did you call me princess?"
"What? No! Never would! You are my admired guest," I replied, dead-serious, waving it off.
"Eh, you're a bad liar, little kitty," she retorted.
"What?" Now I was puzzled. "Kitty?"
She smirked. "Oh, I haven't… I haven't said anything."
"You called me kitty!"
"You called me princess!"

We stared at each other with narrowed eyes, pouting, then giggled at the same time and again started to walk around the stands for some time. On one of them, where a woman with her daughter were selling fruits coated in honey and crushed nuts, we stopped. I fished some coins out of my purse and asked her for some dates and figs. The woman clearly noticed that we were noblewomen and quickly handed over two servings. They were wrapped up in palm leaves and contained several fruits. I handed one serving to Adora, unwrapped mine and picked a date with my fingers.
"Just try them, they're sweet and delicate," I said while shoving one in my mouth.
Adora's look was flabbergasted. "You know that we import thousands of tons of this from the whole southern realm to Rome every year, don't you? You can get them everywhere in the Republic."
"Oh, do you?" I snarkily replied with a smug grin. "And I was thinking you just stick to your ugly moretum and push this even more ugly garum over it." It was nice to shove it into her face that I knew about their disgusting food habits.
Adora rolled her eyes. "Ah, don't be so condescending, Catra. Of

course, we have a bit more to eat in our kitchen." She poked me and I didn't shriek. I never did this, nope.
"Eh, whatever princess. Just eat your dates."
"Hah! You did it again, kitty!"
"Why do you even call me kitty, princess?"
Adora shrugged. "Because of this… Catra-thingy? I mean, Cat-Ra. Like Ra? Like your god Ra? Isn't that supposed to have something to do with your cat-goddess and such?" [27]
I nearly fell over a basket behind me because of my guffawing. "Oh goddess, Adora, you really got it, that's amazing! It's not that like, let me think, every second Egyptian forename is derived from some ancient god's name, isn't it? Who would even do that?" Sarcasm dripped of my words while I made big eyes and a goofy look, then continued to josh her. "I'm really proud of your Egyptian knowledge. You will clearly make a good princess. Maybe we shall search for a more fitting name for you as well, don't we? Something that suits your goddess-like appearance—"

I clapped my hands before my mouth and shut up. That was embarrassing. My damned mouth had been faster than my brain. Adora's eyes were as wide as plates, while I blushed. Then her smug smile returned, as she patted me on my shoulder, saying: "Oh, so you find me pretty? How embarrassing for you."
I really couldn't allow myself to be derailed by her beauty the whole time, I scolded myself and quickly retorted: "It's not because I like you!" but she only scoffed and triumphantly tried one of her own figs.
Luckily, it distracted her because she looked absolutely surprised, switching her look between me and her hand where she held them. It was almost comically to see. "Wow. I mean... that's… WOW! They're so much better than ours, that's incredible."
And the next thing I witnessed was a Roman patrician woman, shoving a bunch of figs and dates into her mouth and munching them like she'd been starving for days, murmuring: "Hmmm… thasss sooo goood!"

I laughed right in her face. "You're the embodiment of the Roman concept of dignitas, Adora. I'm sure your father and all of your

ancestors would be delighted upon your sight."
"What?" she mumbled while munching. "It's not that somebody's watching, or?"
I was still giggling. "I am, Adora, I am."
"You don't count, Catra. Why are you even called Cat-Ra? You're so little, I should call you Kitten-Ra[28]," she teased back, chuckling like a madwoman, whereupon I started to poke her vigorously upon the absolutely unjustified nickname whereupon she fled between two market stalls, her mouth still full of food. It was a marvelous sight to watch, undignified and utter childish, and I had a very hard time stopping my cackling. Somewhere from the corner of the market place, our guards watched us, unmoved by our antics.

The afternoon went by, and the glistening sun started to set when we finally returned to the villa, a bit exhausted and carrying some stuff that Adora practically begged me to buy. It wasn't elaborate or expensive stuff, just a little puppet in the form of a unicorn, some pieces of desert glass who shone pretty in the sun and a grindstone "to keep my dagger in shape", as she explained. "I forgot mine back at home."

I had to ready myself for my departure to Alexandria in the night, while Adora mumbled something about visiting Bow and her need to bathe herself, because she felt sweaty.
I was glad to leave her to her wishes, so I could deal with my own matters. It wasn't like we wouldn't see again.

The whole day, I'd felt a weird pull inside me to keep her my side. My awkwardly blurted compliment about her beauty didn't come out of nothing. A weird attraction had started to nag at me, because there was more to Adora than I'd expected. I clearly knew it could lead nowhere, so I desperately tried to stomp upon that unwomanly crush. She was either something like a bait by her family, used upon us to spy - as unlikely as it sounded - or she was up to be married with Hordak. Both scenarios left me with no reasonable possibility for an approach in her direction. I didn't even know if she was into women or men. Or both. Romans were probably not as relaxed regarding their interpersonal relationships

as the Greek were.
But nonetheless, the thought to be at least six days away from her didn’t please me, to put it that way. So I was relieved when Adora disappeared into her room and the bath of the villa afterwards.

After I packed my things, I instructed the headmaster of the villa how to handle things in my absence regarding our guests. Of course, Cleopatra would send over Alexas to take care of them, but I wanted to add some more personal directions, so Adora shouldn't bore herself to death while I was away. After finishing my preparations, I walked up the stairs and knocked at her door, but she wasn’t there. I found her in Bow’s room, sitting beside his bed. Now she was clothed in something that looked like a hunting dress for women. She wore tightly fitting, dark green trousers and a tunic of the same color that covered her arms and until right above her knees. It was tied at her waist with a brown belt. Her boots came up to her lower legs and were made of seemingly soft, dark leather. He knees were bare, and they looked as perfect as her face. Her hair was made up into a tightly tied ponytail.
“Are you pretending to pass as Artemis’ likeness now?” I asked to hide my surprise.
She shook her head in denial. “No. It’s just comfortable. And looks good. As a patrician, we always have to impress the lousy barbarians, you know?” She sounded amused, but it didn't quite reach her eyes. Did she hesitate for a moment?
“It takes more than a puny Roman to impress an Egyptian. We built the pyramids thousand years before you built your first bonfire. Rome might see itself at the height of the modern civilization, but you weren't even a thing when we invented building the right way."
“The Egyptians did, you lousy Hellenistic occupant,” she retorted all too kindly.

“I'm half Egyptian, thank you very much. Anyway. I’m going to leave soon. Is there anything I can do for you?” and hastily added, “For both of you?”, to let it sound less needy and more casual. I wasn't very good at all this 'caring for other people'. Beside Cleo, maybe.

Bow denied, but mentioned: “Less unnerving nightly attacks would be appreciated. Otherwise, I’m fine. I feel in good hands." The man really had an unshakably sunny disposition. Terrible. “Noted. That should be taken care of. Your and our guards are doing well and Cleopatra will keep an eye on everything. You’ll be fine. And you have Adora at your side.” I grinned, but again, Adora seemed to look right beside me, not really at me. Something was surely going on with her, but I had no time left to care about her antics. I only laid a hand on her shoulder, saying: “I’ll be back in six days. Try to have a good time here. We’ll catch up when I’m back again.”
Adora just nodded and replied without turning around: “See you, Catra.” The emphasis of her words was strange, but I shoved it aside and left. On my way out of the villa, I convinced myself that all security measures and guards were still in place. No one should accuse me of not having taken care of things properly, and finally somewhat relieved upon my findings, I went over to the stables and required a horse for my ride to the harbor. A servant readied one of them immediately, and quickly, I was on my way.

When I rode out of Pelousion, there was a constant stream of people coming from and going to the harbor. There weren't many, but it was noticeable. A few pedestrians, merchants with carriages, some fishermen on their way to their boats and such. Behind me, another rider or two, and two troops of soldiers, securing the outback of the city in their steady lockstep.
I needed only a few minutes to reach the port, where I left the horse at the garrison. I also left instructions to the commander upon how to act in case if I was not returning, and handed him a few letters for my people at Buhen to forward. We discussed the matters shortly, then I left for the boat.

Its name was “Dragon’s Daughter II” and it sounded cheesy. But the captain was blatantly proud of his ship. “It is the best and fastest merchant ship at the delta! Where the usual trader needs three days, I need two. We’re always going where adventure awaits us!”
“Maybe you should go somewhere else then, because adventure clearly doesn’t await you here, that much is certain,” I retorted

and his facial expression imploded. I snickered and ordered him to take off as soon as possible and set course to Alexandria. “Maybe adventure awaits you there, captain,” I added. He lightened up and went to work with enthusiasm. A strange guy. But capable, according to the harbour master.
A few minutes later, we’d left Pelousion’s port and were on our way along the coast of the Nile delta. Even at this late hour, it was clear that this was a densely settled area. Small villages were indicated by a few torches. Larger places by many of them. The distant chatter of cranes, herons and gooses filled the otherwise quiet environment with a comforting background noise. "Two days, maybe less," we'd need, according to the captain. I had to admit that his crew understood their work. The ship sailed fast, very fast, and despite the nightly hour, nobody yawned or slowed down, instead they always trimmed the sails in a trained way to keep our speed.

Night had long fallen when I retreated to my cabin, or rather, the captain's cabin. He'd practically forced it on me while telling “Any self-respecting captain would leave his best bed to a real lady!” Fine by me, and of course I didn't say no. On a ship this size, the captain’s room was the only one that offered at least a little comfort, and if only the comfort of a room for yourself and a bed that didn't consist of a hammock. The Dragon's Daughter was designed for speed, not for comfort. And comfort was okay for me, because I needed rest before the endeavors of the coming days. And from the ones of the days behind. The arrival of the Roman patrician had pretty much turned my life upside down. Sleep was in order.

I closed the door behind me and took off my cape, throwing it on the bed. There was a larger window looking out to the rear of the ship, which could be closed by a wooden screen. I trotted over and put my hand against the wooden beam that connected two parts of the window to steady myself. It was dark outside, and only sometimes I caught a little glimpse of light, when a nearby ship passed us. As this part of the sea was right in front of the Nile delta, traffic was always dense, even at this time.

Suddenly, I heard something like… a sneeze? I flinched and looked around, putting my hand on the hilt of my dagger. The cabin had the size of a normal room, occupiying the entire width of the ship's hull, but it wasn't very deep. It just contained a desk, a well-sized bunk bed for one to two persons, a dining table with room for three people and drawers built-in into the hull of the outer sides left and right. And that was that. Not a large place.

But the sneeze came from inside the room, and I registered that I wasn't alone here. Despite the constant creaking of the ship, I heard, or rather felt another presence now. Under the bed, I assumed, in the large shelf. I pretended to be oblivious, because I didn't assume any ambush. There'd been easier and more promising ways for that. No, this was just some dumb, blind passenger, probably a kid or a teenager on the run. So I just threw myself on the bed with full force and immediately, I heard someone yelling under me: "Ouch! Bona Dea!"

I froze.

No, that couldn't be. That was impossible.

Chapter End Notes

[23] The whole paragraph is a variation from ""Please take it out on me", Chapter 3 ↑

[24] Of course, this saying wasn't known until Christianity, but the Romans had similar ones. But I must not plaster you with every finding. ↑

[25] The Gabiniani were a Roman army stationed in Egypt by Roman general Aulus Gabinius in 55 BCE after reinstating Ptolemy XII Auletes on the throne again. The 2,000 Roman legionaires and 500 cavalrymen were left to protect the king and stayed there after his death. Over time, the former Romans adapted to the Egyptian culture and blended in, even married Egyptian women. In 48 BCE they helped Ptolemy XIII in his conflict with Cleopatra. ↑

[26] Lares were guardian deities in the ancient Roman religion to protect the family. Lares were believed to be the collective spirits of the ancestors of a family and influence all that happened to a gens. ↑
[27] I mean, of course she's written and called Catra here. But we could easily translate her name into an Egyptian derivation of the cat-goddess Bastet and then Catra's name would be something like *"Pasht".* And I really like the sound of it. ↑
[28] I totally stole "Kitten-Ra" from "home is whereever I'm with you", Chapter 5. ↑

Alexandria the Great

Chapter Summary

Hey Adora!
I will make you moan.
3,000 years look upon us. And a lighthouse!

Chapter Notes


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Gate of the Sun
Royal Quarter
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Campus Mag
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Alexandria, Egypt - September, 48 BCE

Catra

I jumped up and stepped back a pace, before I finally put up the matress to look into the shelf under the bunk bed. There was only the wooden board on which she lay. Inspecting the front of the bed revealed a small round hole in the middle of the sideboard, presumably to pull— A flap at the long side openened, and out of the storage clambered an angry, tousled Adora in her dark-green dress, quickly rising to her full height. And she was scolding. "Dammit Catra, how could you classless beast… You did that on purpose, didn't you?" she accused me while rubbing her stomach, angry.
"Wha—" was all that left my mouth, because my brain was still desperately trying while failing to process what happened right before my eyes.
Meanwhile, the blonde beauty straightened herself, and stood before me, her hands at hips, grimly staring at me. It was outright breathtaking. Her hunting dress, which accentuated her body so well, was a perfect disguise for hours at night, I realized. And it suited her so fine, the more feral part of my brain kindly supplied, while my gaze wandered over her, tracing the oh-so-well defined lines. What a difference to when she wore her tunic. The contrast between the dark green fabric, the bright hair of her ponytail and her sparkling, blue eyes was…

Ugh! A distraction! That's what it was. An unneeded distraction. Like her entire presence. How could she even! And Cleo…? Only now the thought hit me with full force: she was supposed to dine with Cleo right now. Oh no, by Wusa![29] *Cleo will kill me.*
I heaved a deep breath before asking: "What are you doing here, Adora?" It was maybe more croaking than speaking. I needed to stomp down this helpless and overwhelmed feeling in my gut.
She crossed her arms before her chest and smirked.
"Accompanying you. Obviously.” She sounded self-confident, but I

could hear the shakiness dripping of her words as well. She wasn't half as self-assured as she wanted to look like.
“Are you nuts? What do you think this is? A pleasure trip?” My voice grew hard.
“Of course not. But I just thought... I could come with you. When you talked about your mission, you made it sound like a not too difficult thing, rather ‘go there, get it, go back’. And I… I was curious. I wanted to see Alexandria, and I wanted to accompany you.”

She couldn't mean that for real, could she? Adora was certainly naive to some extent, due to her lack of wordly experience. But this was nuts.
“That is outright stupid, Adora. Alexandria may be safe for me, but not for you. The city is under control of Cleopatra’s brother. You can’t just go there on a whim."
She gestured in defiance. “Why? Nobody knows me there. I'm just another foreign woman, which shouldn’t be so extraordinary. In Rome, nobody would notice.”
By Thot[30] , that naivety! Like she didn't stand out of any crowd in this god-forsaken world everywhere she set her foot on. Right now, I wanted to strangle her, to put my hands around her throat and put my—

Breathe. Just breathe. Do not strangle her.

Strangling the adorable woman in front of me would perhaps be a bad idea. Cleo wouldn't be pleased if I was the cause for another war, I reasoned, and...
Well, Adora wasn't completely in the wrong. Alexandria was way too busy to care about two random strangers. Nobody knew her there. But she was also not really right. We had to consider the city under hostile control, by Ptolemy's henchmen and therefore, dangerous at any time. All of this felt odd. Very.
“Why didn’t you just stay in Pelousion, Adora? It would have been absolutely okay there, to wait some days. Why this stupid thing?”
Locking down the floor, she replied: “I just wanted to.”
That sounded totally childish, but I sensed an undertone. Adora wouldn't just do this out of curiosity. I pressed again: “That’s no

reason. I won’t take such bullshit from you, princess. Tell me what’s going on in this big, empty brain of yours. You can’t just join me on a mission without telling me the truth. If I mean anything to you, then you have to talk to me.” Only after finishing my words, I realized, how they must’ve sounded. But there was no taking them back, and I also saw something crumbling in her expression. Still, she didn’t give in and stayed silent.

After a few moments, I tried my luck. “I think I’m gonna tell the captain to turn back,” and started to turn around and walk to the door.
The next thing I heard of Adora was her yelling: “I don’t feel safe there without you.” Her blurting made me stop, partly shocked, partly off. She clasped her hands over her mouth and looked at me with wide eyes. Then she turned around, looking out of the window to the rear.
“What?” I had difficulties to process what I’d heard. “Safe?” I repeated with disbelief. “Why do you say that?” I asked. Nothing of this made any sense.
Adora still stood with her back to me and her hands were clenched to fists. The ship made a good trip now, and I felt it swaying left and right - or rather port and starboard - while it dove through the waves of the Mediterranean Sea. The view outside the window at the nightly sky was a star-studded beauty. If I’ve had an eye for the marvelous sight, sprinkled with lights from far above, I would’ve enjoyed it. But I only looked at the woman before me.

I trudged over to her, leaning against the window frame as well, looking outside along her. “Hey, Adora.”
She kept her silcence, her gaze still fixed at some point far away, both hands firmly gripping the wooden beam of the window frame
“We need to talk about this, Adora. You can’t go to Alexandria with me,” I said calmly and laid a hand on her shoulder. She didn't move a bit. “This isn’t a game for wealthy patricians.”
“But why?” she asked quietly. “You said that nobody would recognize you. And of course, nobody knows *me* there. Why would I be in danger at all?"

I sighed. “It just increases the risk of being discovered.”
“You said that Alexandria is the largest city in the world. No one will take any notice of me. I didn’t want to stay back for days and days with nothing to do than to wait, until someone else decides over my fate again. That’s sooo… arrrr… disgusting! I want to have a bit of life, at least for the little time I’ve left. I want to see things, a large city. I want to have you—"
She fell dry and closed her mouth, then turned away again. After some breaths, she lifted her chin. “I want this. I want to do what you can do. And you can’t do anything about it.” When she looked back at me, her gaze was serious and firm.

“I can’t do anything about this?” I repeated, dangerously quiet. “Beside, maybe, order the captain to turn and go back to Pelousion?”
She didn't buy it. Adora scoffed: “You don't want to sacrifice that much time. It would cost you a day or even more.”
Given the current winds, she was right. I knew it was a weak threat. But I had other possibilities too. “I can have you locked into this cabin during my time in Alexandria.”
Her mouth, already open to shoot back, clapped shut, then she gathered herself. “You wouldn’t dare to lock me in. I’m not some kind of slave. You have no command over me.”
“Oh, maybe we just find out what I dare to do and what not? It’s not like that you can do anything against me and, let’s see, ten sailors under my command, right?”
“I could tell your sister about this treatment.” Now that sounded more like whining.
“And I would happily leave this problem for future me to deal with. After all, it’s my sister and I know her better than you. You'll find that we're both pretty pragmatic people. "

She retreated a step from the window, her hands balling to fists, making it obvious that she felt threatened. I decided to ease the tension and raised my hands in a calming gesture. “Let’s set this aside for the moment, Adora. But we need to talk about how to handle this in a serious manner. Cleopatra will certainly freak out when she discovers that you’re gone. Which has already happened. Right now, she's probably turning every stone in

Pelousion."
Adora shook her head, stating. “No, she won’t," and I was just about to interject when she continued: "I mean, maybe she will freak out, but she’ll know my whereabouts. I told Bow to tell her that I’m going with you, to help. She’ll even know by now."
This! Was a hair puller. “Ugh! Good goddess, Adora, can you imagine what position you are putting me in? Cleopatra will kill us when we come back.” Now I pulled my hair for real. “Ah, scrap that! She’ll kill just me, you’ll be fine, obviously.” Damn that conniving bitch. How could she just sneak after me in this easygoing manner as if it were nothing? Cleo would throw a fit.
Adora tried to defend herself, realizing that she might’ve caused some actual trouble. “Maybe it won’t be that bad. It’s six days or so and she’ll have cooled down by then, right?”
“Oooh, you don’t know her. She can hold to a grudge for some time. Even with me.”
Her look was worried now. “Then… maybe… if we are successful in gaining the seal, she’ll just skip it?”

I eyed her intensely, and she slightly winced under my stare.
“We?” I asked. “WE? We are doing nothing. YOU will stay at the ship, safely guarded by my men, in this very cabin, and you’re not going anywhere. If something happens to you, Cleopatra will never forgive, not even me. Never, Adora.”
Even if it wasn't my fault, Cleopatra would happily put me on duty at Buhen for the next ten years. Or for the rest of my life. Beside the obvious, there was also that spike in my gut that just wanted not to let anything happen to her, a wish that went far beyond my duty. This strange attachment that had developed and of which I’d hoped to cut it away during these days. But no, here the woman was again, following me like a happy loyal puppy.

Well, not so happy right now, I realized when seeing with what expression Adora was watching me. “Anyway. I can’t let anything happen to you.”
“I can take care of myself,” she repulsed.
“Oh yeah, and all these caring led you straight to here. That didn’t work out so well, Adora.” I let it sound annoyed and actually, I was. Having her here was a problem I’d to deal with now. And

afterward, I'd to deal with Cleopatra's wrath about all of this. Fetching the seal suddenly looked as just a secondary problem. My only security was, that I must not leave Adora out of sight. Which could turn out to be difficult for the next days.

Adora

As the evening went by, Catra calmed down. And to my surprise, the ship did not turn to bring me back. Two hours later and in the middle of the night, we were still on our way to Alexandria. After our argument died down in a mixture of exhausted option, me falling silent, not shooting back at each other anymore and her having spit out most of her anger, she stormed out of the cabin, leaving me behind in a rather timid state.
I felt uneasy upon her obvious discontent and not knowing what she was about to do. Yes, I'd said the truth when I blurted out, that I didn't feel safe without her. Or Bow, not to forget. The entire situation back at Pelousion, being ambushed on the first day, with Bow severely injured and the only person that at least had shown some minimal personal interest in me suddenly gone again let me feel just *bad*.
Plus, I *actually wanted* to see Alexandria. Our walkaround at the market had shown me how little I knew and how much there was to discover. From her descriptions and all that I knew about it, Alexandria just sounded… amazing. I wanted to see the largest city that ever was.
For a while I restlessly walked around in the cabin, looked outside, fumbled with my stuff, but all of that only kept me awake for so long. I sat down on the bed, and realized how tired I was. The events of this long day finally caught up with me. I didn't undress, because I was already too dozy and a little part of my mind supported me kindly with thoughts of "be ready for anything", and "you don't have a proper nightgown with you" and so I got stuck in my useless pondering until I dozed away.

It was still dark outside, when I woke up again. I slowly blinked my eyes open and tried to see something. Only a small oil lamp that was dangling from the ceiling of the room, spending a little light, but the scanty illumination left the most of the cabin in the dark. It took me a while to see the familiar shadow that was sitting at the captain's desk.
Looking at me.
"Have you been watching me sleeping?" I croaked, again rubbing my eyes.
"Obviously, Adora," Catra huskily answered.
"That's creepy, to be honest." I retorted with the slightest hint of annoyance.
She coughed: "I see your point and like to offer a counter-view: I don't care."
I rolled my eyes. "Ugh! You're so… weird."
"Welcome to my world, because I can only return the compliment, Adora. All of this could've been a quick and easy mission, but you decided it to be otherwise." Still, she sounded annoyed. I rubbed my temples and shook my head to wipe off the sleep that lingered in my head. We hadn't settled our argument from before I flaked out. And I silently admitted that she was right. Honestly, I didn't even have a plan on how to proceed after I snuck on board and into the captain's cabin. It had been a surprise that everything I had to do was carrying a large bag with a ducked head, murmuring "Things for the lady" and walking under deck. Nobody had paid me any real attention. Security measures were obviously nonexistent, but I also knew I would've been discovered within time. I'd only hoped that it wouldn't freak her out as much as it actually did. Her concern and anger seemed genuine, and the prospect of having a still furious Catra before me, was frightening. And I couldn't think of how to proceed from here on.
"Have you come to any conclusions?" I warily asked.

Catra didn't answer right away. She stood and looked outside the window, the shutters still open, letting a warm breeze to blow in. It lightly tousled her curls, and even from behind, it was a beautiful sight. *She* was a beautiful sight. Why attracted she so much of my attention? I wanted to touch her by her shoulders, to

trace her lines with a finger or maybe even my whole hand. It was a pull.
The urge felt weird. After all, Catra was a woman and I shouldn’t feel attracted by one, right? I was a Roman patrician, and not some decadent, voluptuous barbarian from the east. Everyone knew that it was our dignitas, gravitas, nobilitas and the other virtues which made us strong, and the Roman civiliziation the ruling power in the known world. We were born to rule. And that meant to make sacrifices, to restrain ourselve, to not give in to any egocentric need.
I pushed the feeling back into a corner of my mind and watched her face from the side. She didn't look angry anymore, but composed. She pulled a corner of her mouth a few times, thinking. The lines in her face seem to flicker in the candlelights, it was just barely visible in the gloom. Obviously, something went through her mind. I tried to catch her gaze, but she did not react until minutes later, and I just stood beside her, sharing the silence, while under us the sea rushed and gurgled.

Her voice was serious and calm when she finally spoke: “Adora, you’ve put me in dire straits. I haven’t turned the ship, because time is of the essence. A day may count in this conflict, so Alexandria it is. And I wouldn’t have a good feeling to leave you behind, at the ship, even guarded by my men. That leaves me with difficult choices. I like none of them, and damn you for making me do this. But I’ve thought of a plan that might work out for both of us. But I need you to help me."
A weight lifted off my chest. She wasn’t angry anymore, but instead she made up a plan. That was… cool, actually?
“Everything,” it tumbled out of my mouth.
Catra chuckled lowly, her face a mischievous grimace. “So eager to help. Hear me out, Adora. Then we’ll decide. Maybe you regret your doing very soon.”

“I mean, if I’d known this earlier, I would’ve brought my formal dress instead,” I complained. "And a better brush."
Behind me, Catra scoffed and brushed through my hair again. Her harsh style reminded me of previous times, with *another* person doing that. “If I’d known this earlier, I would’ve locked you up in the villa until my return.”
“Fair point,” I replied, grinning smugly which she couldn't see. “But still I think we should look out for something more… representative at the market. This disguise won't get us very far.”
“I know,” she agreed. “We’ll get you a fancy dress then, pretty lady. We just didn’t plan on having such a noble and well-mannered guest with us. Please accept my sincerest apologies, also on behalf of the Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods, Pharaoh Cleopatra VII Thea Philopator.” Her sarcasm was very, very audible.

After Catra’d explained her plan to me the last night, we got to sleep. Thanks to the bunk bed, both of us could lay down side by side without discomfort. Or at least, without more discomfort beside the thoughts that pestered my mind. It summarized to absolutely ridiculous ideas like ‘She’s only the lengths of an arm away, so why don’t you stretch out yours and touch her?’ I mentally kicked myself and forced my thoughts away to other realms. It was hard. I desperately tried to fall asleep, while Catra was gone since long. Hearing her evenly breaths so near was mortifying. But somehow, after a while, listening to them felt soothing, lulling me into a comforting cover of... companionship, until I finally fell asleep.

The next morning was a sunny day, and as we would have to sail until the next morning to reach our goal, we hadn't any hurry. However, I was hooked on her proposal, it made me giddy, and my attempt to hide my childish excitement failed miserably. Catra poked me not too softly upon my lightened eyes, the wide grin, the excitement that clearly radiated out of me, and she scolded me harshly for it. “Do not take this too lightly, Adora. It shall be easy, but it mustn’t. No plan survives contact with the enemy. It depends on too many factors we can’t foresee. And in case anything happens, you have to go directly to the Roman emissary.

You can’t trust or rely on anyone else in Alexandria now. Many people won’t even understand you. Nobody in the common population speaks Latin. If somebody does by speaking Latin - or Greek - he’s probably a Hellene and maybe on Ptolemy’s side. Remember that.”

I nodded, but it didn’t really register. I was just too excited to be able to do something useful, and to see Alexandria, instead of being locked up in this cabin. “We should… maybe… study our roles until tomorrow?” I said, after thinking about it. “I mean, it’s not that I have much to do to imitate a Roman patrician. It’s just what I am. But you on the other side…” I hesitated and fell dry.
Catra’s voice was sharp like a sanded knife: “Speak freely, Adora.”
“Oh nothing!” I tried to hide my light blush and looked at the floor. That had been a bad idea.
“You think I won’t be able to disguise like a submissive servant, aren’t you,” she insisted, arms crossed.
I scratched my neck and smiled weakly. “Maybe? I mean, being obedient and humble doesn’t sound like something that fits you, or does it?

With narrowed eyes, Catra considered my words. She didn't give me an immediate answer. After a while, she said: “Well, maybe. What would you recommend?”
“Practice is always the best. How about we just try it, right now? At deck and in front of the others? It would help us to have some… valuable feedback, I assume.”
And so the afternoon went by with Catra and me ridiculously trying to act like a Roman domina and her servant. I walked around on the deck and did nothing more than to be an overly stepmotherly version of myself that was blatantly discontent with her servant.
Which wasn’t difficult, because Catra didn’t get any of my hints. When I made these little winks with the fingers, extending and drawing them together twice to gesture her to scurry away, she just looked at my hand and did nothing. If I furrowed an eyebrow to show that she did something wrong, she asked “What?” way too harsh to pass as the humble question of someone feeling guilty. And me sighing to motivate her to fetch me some water got

no reaction at all. After I'd sighed the third time, she just asked: “Are you feeling ill? Do you wanna rest?”

I used the later part of the afternoon to explicitly explain to her as much as I could. Some habits where the same in the Egyptian and the Roman culture, but others obviously weren’t. The amount of control an Egyptian nobleman had over his servants was, to some extent, larger than ours. The Roman concept of patrias included the obligation of a pater - or a slave owner - to care for the actual wellbeing of his family members, servants and slaves alike. And slaves, despite being *slaves* , had rights that amounted to a similar meaning as for normal citizens, which was ‘being treated as valuable beings that should not be damaged because otherwise you had no dignity’, to put it that way.
In Egypt, slaves were seen just as tools like a hammer or a horse. Slaves had to be given verbal instructions, and even light disobedience would be treated with a whip. In Rome, such a handling was seen as degrading for the owner. Slaves there tended to adapt the habits of their owners to some extent and react on much more subtle notes. There were also much more integrated into the normal household life’s, often being treated as normal family members. And the ultimate thread, that the owner of a slave could put him to death anytime? This was also true for the power a pater familias had over *any member* of his family, even his wife, his children or grandchildren. There wasn’t much difference in that. These rights were seldom used anyway. We weren't barbarians.

After working through all of this, I decided that I would mostly stick to short verbal instructions. I wouldn’t be understood by others at all, and Catra could adapt my commands to fit into the surrounding. I had fun with yelling at her to “GET THIS!” or “DO THAT!”, and Catra’s angry gaze didn’t stop to burn holes in me until we ended our little play when it was finally time for dinner.

Catra was unusual silent during it. The captain, a tall man with a mustache who was obviously no Egyptian, told us a few adventurous stories about his previous journeys. His Latin was quite good, and so I understood most of it without having the

need of Catra to interpret him. At the end of the evening, I found myself arm wrestling with him a few times, and I beat him every single attempt. But Catra did not partake in our antics and just sat there, often looking away or outside the window. I didn't understand why her mood got so gloomy, but I decided that giving her some space would be the best.
Dinner went by, and afterwards I retreated to the cabin while Catra stayed on deck. We would arrive at Alexandria tomorrow morning, and she obviously wanted to be prepared as good as possible. I readied myself for sleep, but stayed awake by looking outside at the open sea. As it was regular during this time of the year, it was warm and cloudless night, the ocean lay still and the gentle breeze blowing in came only from our own speed.
My mind was restless. What would happen in Alexandria? Was the touch of adventure worth all of this? And was I up to it? The idea to stay on the ship didn't look so dire anymore. My mind filled my gut with a strange feeling, and nervousness kept me awake until Catra entered the room. She found me sitting at the bed, helplessly fumbling with my necklace.

Obviously she'd expected me to be asleep because of the expression on her face. "Still awake? What's with you?"
I gave up with the necklace, answering: "I don't know. You seemed to be very quiet at dinner and that… Did I do something wrong?"
She sat down beside me and shook her head in denial. "That's what was bothering you? No, you didn't do anything wrong. Our little exercise just reminded me how much I hate being pushed around. I can't imagine a life where you've no other choice. I just needed a bit of time to cope with it."
While I was trying to think about her words, I realized how much they resonated in me. The entire day I'd been able to completely forget about my situation, and even during our play I hadn't spent a thought about it. But now it hit me strongly.
I turned sidewards to directly look her in the eyes: "I understand exactly what you mean. Possibly more than you even can image."
She raised a hand and laid it on my knee, her face a picture of genuine worry. "I forgot, Adora. I'm really sorry, I hadn't—"

I waved it off. “Don’t apologize. I know."
“But nonetheless. It hadn’t been my intention to… make you feel sad.”

Whatever sad feeling I’d had, it was blanketed by the heat that her hand radiated into my thigh and upwards from there. I looked at her hand and, out of a whim, I laid mine on hers. She winced like she’d been struck by lightning, but she didn’t withdraw. Gathering all my courage, I gave in to the urge to lay my head on her shoulder as well. And she didn’t withdraw.
I said nothing and instead allowed myself to sink into her soothing presence, feeling guarded and safe there, so that I nearly reached out with my other hand to cup her face. I fought down the desire to do so, as nothing of this would've been appropriate, even given the lax Egyptian rules regarding adequate behavior for women of the nobility. And with Catra clearly being none of them. And, of course, Gravitas. So I just breathed in the beguiling scent, that lightly lingered in the air all around her and enjoyed the mutual silence.

A while later, she squeezed my hand, got up and put on sleeping clothes. As she stood before me again, ready to scramble into her bed, she laid her hand on my head and silently whispered: "Sleep now, Adora. Tomorrow will be a long day, and we’ll need a clear mind.”
I needed some time to fall asleep, with the feeling of her hand on my thigh still in my mind and her scent still in the air next to me. Again, her even breaths lulled me in.

Sun had already risen when I woke up in the morning, and Catra wasn’t sleeping anymore. In fact, I was alone in the cabin. More interesting was, that I wavered between relief and regret about that. On the one side, it would've been nice to be able to talk to

her in this private environment. We could plan the day, we could help each other dressing, I could touch… Ooof! On the other side, not having to deal with this weird pull, would be helpful. Very much indeed.

I stripped out of my nightwear and poured some water out of a pot into a bowl to wash myself with a washcloth. Beside taking a bath in the open sea, this was the only possibility for a wash. You could also let yourself be dumped with a bucket of seawater on deck, of course, but I would prefer the ocean then. After rubbing me dry, I dressed myself in my usual undergarments and the made up tunic and stola we'd prepared yesterday. Then I tried my best to look presentable. To my surprise, the captain possessed a small mirror made of polished bronze that shone like gold. I used this possibility to put my hair up and to form an overly confident and pretentious looking poof at my forehead. Putting on my shoes and bracelets completed the picture, even if it was just a meager appearance, at least compared to our usual standards when wanting to be representative.

I went up the stairs onto the deck and found Catra standing at the railing, watching for the shore. Even from behind, she looked amazing. Her firm standing, the composed figure, the lithe form. She hadn’t put on her disguise, but wore some outstanding beautiful dress that let her stomach free. There were golden bracelets around her upper and forearm and a skirt down her waist to her ancles. Her curls floated freely, like a mane. The sight alone made me washy. I pulled myself away from the intriguing sight and watched over the railing.

We were already much closer to the shoreline than yesterday, where it had been only a barely visible line at the horizon. Now, we could see settlements and little ports. The Nile delta was vast, stretching over 200 passi along the coast, inhabiting the largest part of the Egyptian population. The majority of all the harvest that had made Egypt such a rich nation, stemmed from here. This area had been settled even before the reign of the ancient Pharaoh's, which resulted therein that the most part of this landscape was in usage by humans for grain cultivation since time

immemorial.
Everywhere where small fisher boats and larger sailing ships cruising around, fishing, delivering goods, and only occasionally one or two larger war galleys of the Egyptian fleet were visible. Fishers had their nets thrown out and now pulled them behind. Seagulls circled overhead, screeching, waiting for their opportunity. To complete the picture, the sky had an intense turquoise blue without any cloud.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said, and I wondered how she could’ve noticed me, because she was still with her back to me and looking forward over the bow.
I cleared my throat: “Catra. How long will it take us to reach Alexandria?”
She bobbed her head. Maybe two hours, not longer. How did you sleep?”
Was there more to her question than the obvious? Her voice sounded a bit thick, but I couldn’t imagine why. So I just replied: “It was fine. Thanks for letting me sleep. How long have you been awake?”
“Eh, some time.” Her reply was curt.
We heard a sailor at the bow calling and pointing forward. Our gaze wandered along and then, right at the horizon, I saw a gleaming spot.
“What’s that?” I asked Catra, and she just casually replied, “The Lighthouse.”

Of course.
The Lighthouse of Alexandria, on the isle of Pharos. Over 120 meters high, illuminated by fire at night and equipped with a mirror for reflecting the sunlight at day. The building only grew slowly, and I wondered about its weird appearance until I realized, how far away we still were. A quarter of an hour later it was already rising high above all of its surroundings despite us being at least 10 passi away, given the captain’s words. “Antipater of Sidon added Pharos to the list of the Seven Wonders of the World,” he said. "Watch it."
“Wasn’t that Herodotus list?” I asked mentally absent, because the tower occupied nearly all of my attention.

“Right,” Catra threw in, “but he didn’t mention Pharos in his version. Only after the destruction of the Walls of Babylon, Antipater wiped them of his one and put Pharos on it, because it was built after the first version of the list. He deemed it the tallest building in the world. It might still be. The Great Pyramid of Giza is the second tallest one, just… just so you know. I think nobody knows for sure. But both are ours. We did this.”

("Troy", Deezer / Spotify / Youtube)

Catra obviously tried to let her words sound parenthetical, and shrugged her shoulders to underline it, but it was blatant obvious that she was proud of the achievements her land had made. She was right. Egypt as a nation had a consistent history of kingdoms and dynasties for over 3,000 years until today. So, more than 3,000 years of development, struggling, growth, fighting, rise and decline were looking upon us. Rome merely existed since 700 years by now, even founded long after the great pyramids had been built. We played a major role in the Mediterranean world for the glimpse of around 300 years or so. Compared to Egypt, we were like children, that played in the garden of eternal beings that were just sleeping for a while. Sometimes I thought, that if we were just loud enough, we would wake up the elder gods and would be chastised for damaging their toys. Maybe we would just be wiped out bei them either. How could we know about the desires and whims of these old beings? What if the old tales of the Greeks weren’t just tales? What if even the gods could get jealous - or annoyed - and wipe out Rome like they did it with Troy?

The nearer we got to the harbor of Alexandria, the larger the lighthouse towered over the whole scenery. We had still half an hour to sail, but Pharos already outdid everything. It was a huge, tripartite building, divided into different layers above of each other. On the top of the tower stood a statue showing the old Greek god Zeus. He held a large mirror made of Bronze that reflected the sunlight to all ships that were incoming from the ocean side, guiding them safely to the harbor of largest city of the world.

The nearer we got to the port, the denser the traffic became. I saw at least two dozen ships coming in right with us, while the same amount left the harbor before us. Large galleys, two quinqueremes, merchant ships, three fast courier boats, dozens of small ships, sails and rowboats. It was a stunning quantity. “Wow,” I said to Catra, “That is quite a sight. There are… so much… I’ve never seen so many ships at the same time coming and going, not even in Ostia.” Ostia was the main harbor of Rome, and as the mighty center of the Roman Republic and ruler of the known world, it should have the largest port in all the western Mediterranean Sea, shouldn't it? Ostia was a sleepy nest compared to this.



We were around one passus away from the port entry, with the Lighthouse on one side, and a dam on the other one. The Lighthouse dominated the scenery with its ridiculous size. All around us, other ships maneuvered to get in and out of the harbor, and all the movement was a stunning sight, at least for me. It was like a chaotic dance.
While I just stood with my mouth agape and watching the growing traffic, I suddenly realized that Catra was gone. A light breeze of panic struck me as I looked around and didn't find her. She'd been beside me since I came on deck, but obviously she'd left without notice.
I walked back into the captain's cabin, but she wasn't there either. I used the opportunity to put my dagger back into his usual place and bent a purse at the belt under the stola. As far as I knew, we would use the same ship for traveling back, so I left my other dress where it was. Otherwise, I hadn't brought anything with me and went back on deck. Still no Catra. I asked the captain, who just mumbled something about her being gone under deck. Maybe she was somewhere with someone from the crew? I nervously scurried around the deck while the ship moved into the harbor, directly behind the great tower, with a trained expertise.

Again I looked up at the tall building and couldn't believe it's size. Then I started when someone laid a hand on my shoulder, and exhaled in relief when I saw Catra standing behind me.
Now her hair was bound in a bun at the back of her head and her sandals were well-worn. She'd replaced the beautiful dress from before with a normal clothing that spoke 'servant' from head to toe. But despite the inconspicuous clothing, her posture and appearance spoke for themselves. I pondered, if that would be a problem.
"Where've you been?"
"Scared, princess?" She smirked, clearly aware of my giddy state. "Don't be. I just had to take care of my dress. We're good to go. When we have disembarked, we first visit a friend in Rhakotis and get us some more fitting clothes for you. You shouldn't look so ridiculous, when we… when we head for our main aim."
"And that would be?" I asked.

“Let yourself be surprised. It will be… interesting, I promise.” She smiled slyly and I didn’t press further. She would tell me within time. There was no use in pressing her, I assumed.

Our ship neared a pier and was quickly bounded with ropes when it lay beside. A ship’s mate dealt with the inevitable port fees, arguing with some harbor master very loudly, while Catra and I walked down the gangway, unbothered by such trivialties. Now she wore a headscarf covering most of her face, and followed me, mostly looking down to the ground. We walked beside the arguing couple and over to the port facilities. Having firm ground under my feet felt unfamiliar. I got used to the constant rolling of the ship without any seasickness. Missing it now felt surprisingly odd. There were a lot of market stands right beside the embankment, selling fish, mussels, shrimps and much more products of the sea and land. Everywhere people were trading, talking, waving hands, exchanging money for goods. It was invigorating, but the sheer mass of people made it also frightening.

Because I understood nothing and no one.

Catra clearly sensed that I was going to be overwhelmed, and so she leaned to me and whispered with her husky voice: “Just follow me, Adora. Everything is okay. No one pays any attention to us. Keep calm.”
She moved in front of me and acted like a humble servant clearing the way for her mistress. I tried to look as bored and dignified as possible, but it was hard to pretend not to be overwhelmed. This was much more than Pelousion. Alexandria's harbor was its own city.
“Here, Domina,” Catra said from time to time and pointed with her arm into a direction to show me the way. We left the harbor and this quarter of Alexandria behind, and dove into the district of Rhakotis, how Catra called it.

While parts of the harbor quarter had been clearly built and managed by Egyptians today, Rhakotis was a solely Greek part of the city. The roads followed a strict square pattern, the stone buildings looked all the same, mostly three to six stories high,

with white facades and small windows to keep the heat outside and the cool air in. When the street we were walking down opened to a wide place, I froze in awe upon the sight of the Serapeum of Alexandria. It was the largest and most opulent decorated temple in all of Alexandria. It stood on a lightly elevated rocky plateau and dominated this part of the city easily. The Greek origin was unmistakable, given all the pillars and colonnades, archways and porticus. Overlooking Alexandria, the temple building itself stood on the top of three levels, each connected with a broad flight of stairs made of limestone and with richly decorated pillars on both sides. This was made to impress, to intimidate, I understood immediately, because we did it the same way. Just not... so large.

Catra touched my wrist and said: “Domina, this way, please.” I shook out of my freeze and followed her further. She’d played her role very good so far and just a few minutes later, we arrived at her goal. It was a small shop in one of the usual, white-painted buildings that seemingly sold knifes, daggers and similar stuff for everyday's usage. There was a workshop beside, showing a forge and an accompanying block for pounding, a grindstone and similar equipment. Parts of different metals lie around, and a pile of firewood was neatly stacked beside the wall next to the forge. When we went in, Catra greeted the woman behind a workbench who was sanding a knife. As she looked up and straigthened, it became quite clear that she was taller than even me, with short, white hair, and - wow! - was she muscular. That was some biceps, no questions asked.

Both of them clearly knew each other well, because they hugged and then fell into a comfortable, casual-sounding discussion in Egyptian. I stood behind, and tried to look not too silly. Or curious.
A minute later, Catra gestured at me and the woman smiled smugly, then Catra shouted something at her and her counterpart raised her hand in mock defeat. It was a weird conversation from which I understood nothing, but I had the feeling it was somehow about me.
Catra gestured me to come closer again, and then she said in

Latin: “This is Adora. Adora, this is Scorpia, an old friend of mine.”
Scorpia seemingly pouted a little, but she still held out her hand. It took me a moment to struck it, and her grip was firm. We teased each other shortly, both strengthening our hold, but then Scorpia let loose. It was a dumb, childish duel, and I clearly lost it on that front, as I realized only now. Not very dignified.
“I am honored to meet you, Scorpia,” I said in an attempt to make a better impression.
“Likewise,” she just said and surprised me with her perfect pronunciation. “Catra, why didn’t you give me an early notice about this? I would’ve found some more fitting dresses for this beauty.”
Was I blushing upon the blantant praise? No, of course not. But my body betrayed me. Perhaps.

Catra cackled and patted her thighs upon my deep red face and answered: “Thank you, Scorpia!” It took her a moment to calm down from her guffawing. “But I assume, the usual Roman formal wear will just fit. Don’t overdo it. We need to keep a low, professional profile. We don't want tons of admirers after her. We don't need unneeded attention. Pull out something well-made, but not overly stylish."
“What—" I was interjected by Scorpia who cut in.
“What a pity. We could have done marvelous things with her. Look at these arms. And her hair! But if you say so, Kandake.” Scorpia replied with open regret, slightly teasing though.
Catra grimaced in faked pain. “Ugh! Cleo’s bad jokes won’t get any better on repetition, okay?”
Scorpia patted her shoulder kindly. “I really don’t know why she sticks to you. You’re nothing but trouble, Catra.[31]”
“I know. But what can I say? She loves me. And I love her… most of the times. And she’s Pharaoh! There are some perks coming with it, you know?”
Scorpia giggled and said something in Egyptian, which made Catra loosing her temper again, blushing deeply, then she gestured Scorpia to go and look for her goods. Scorpia smirked and winked at me, but again, the meaning of the conversation was mostly lost on me. Catra shouted a few short words again and earned a pat

on her shoulder before Scorpia obviously had enough of the banter and changed to a professional tone. “Alright Catra, I need a few hours to organize everything you need. Come back in the evening and I have it ready.”
“And this is as fast as possible?” Catra asked, impatient.
“Hey, some of your demands aren’t… the easiest to fulfill. Have a little patience. I'm doing my best."
Catra nodded, obviously not very satisfied. “I get it. We’ll come back at sunset.”
I stepped back outside and waited for Catra. She joined me quickly, then said: “We’ve plenty of time left. We can go back to the ship, or we can just stroll around and see the city. What do you think?” Then she remembered her role, and added a humble “Domina?”, putting her head down again.
Nobody was around us.
And so I just replied smugly: “What do *you* think?”

Catra

Why was Adora so incredibly attractive? It was hair-raising. The oblivious idiot ran around the market stands like a little child that’d never been anywhere in the open. Adora’s eyes beamed the entire time and her face shone like the mirror of Pharos in the sunlight. After she got a bit acquainted with the lively atmosphere and didn’t look over her shoulder every two seconds anymore, she just... opened up. Nobody threw us a suspicious look, but by Hathor[32], this woman clearly drew attention, however dressed she was.
We strolled around a minor market of the city, where barkers called out and praised their goods like there was no morning.
"Shampoo for any type of hair! Use it on cows, horses, or yourself! You want to keep your smelling fresh. Get it now!"
"Take a look at our headscarves, lady! Now two for the price of one! The most elegant scarves in Alexandria! Only made of camel

or fennec hair. They are sooo soft!”
"The best and juiciest fruits from all over the delta! Even the palace buys from us! Don't waste your time by looking further!"
“Knives! Knives! The sharpest knives! You slice a date without any pressure. You can even cut the throat of your cheating husband, ladies! Be prepared!”

Adora couldn’t understand much of what was called, only a few words were known to her. But I whispered some meanings in her ears, and she clearly got what was going on. She was a good-looking woman, and out of a whim, I bought her another, more fitting headscarf made of camel hair. It was a decent piece of cloth, rather traditional woven with a beautiful pattern, but not dyed, so it didn't stand out. She shyly slipped the cloth through her hands like a child that got his first present ever, and I pondered, if I’d made a mistake there. Immediately, she changed her current with my new one in a fluent movement and looked even more beautiful. On my advice, we dusted ourselves with a bit of sand - not much, just enough to not shine like too well-equipped easy prey - and then we just blended into the crowd of people that was known as the largest city of the world.

The longer we sauntered around the inner city, through smaller and larger markets, the more Adora transformed into the endless wellspring of joyfulness that seemed to be a profound part of her personality. This woman didn’t even behave like all her conspecifics. Blasé. Arrogant. Vain.
Nothing of it. Instead, she was overflowing with sheer enjoyment and gratefulness, and the sensation poured out of her every fiber. A playful, competitive arrogance was one of my most specific features, and Adora was competitive too. But she was always good-natured about it and that was a new experience for me. When I asked her to take part in a ridiculous contest at a children's game, she was instantly hooked. One had to toss little rings made of willow wood over a stick a few meters away, with everyone having five takes. When I asked the children if we could use their toy for a minute, they hesitated, but then I tossed them a drachma and we had an agreement. But when they watched Adora, the tall, blonde, exotic-looking woman, desperately trying

to beat me while she stuck out her tongue and licked her lips every time she threw one of the rings, all the children began to giggle and laugh in an eruption of joy.
“What?” Adora asked me, disconcerted. “Why are they laughing?”
I smirked and replied: “They can’t believe that someone like you doesn’t hit with every single ring.”
“What should that mean? Someone like me?” Oh dear, she was so oblivious of her own attractiveness. I didn’t answer her, but told the kids - in Egyptian, of course - that the beautiful lady wasn’t used to games like that, because she was the reincarnation of an ancient warrior-goddess that had fallen to earth and must now find her way back home to where she came from. My culture had plenty of similar tales, and they were passed from generation to generation.
They soaked it up easily. The kids looked at her with awe and soon surrounded Adora like butterflies. After the initial surprise, she started to glow like embers, sank to the ground on her heels like a dandelion and let the children touch her, while chattering about some nonsense none of them could understand. She petted their heads with soft gestures, and the children squeaked in delight. Her friendly voice filled the little place between the house blocks where we’d played, and it was a delight to watch her.

I stepped back to give her space. Some onlookers, maybe parents or relatives, shot charily glances at the unusual sight, but I calmingly waved and gestured to them to hold back. I leaned on a house wall, in the shadow, and let the picture of her sink in. It was a marvelous sight, seeing her, with all the dark-tanned and mostly dirty children crawling around the tall blonde and shining beauty from another world. Her laughter was light, full of vibrant mirth, and it was obvious to anyone how much she enjoyed this. Just watching her made my heart beat faster, and it brightened my mood. Adora played with the children for maybe a half an hour, spun them around, showed how to count to ten in Latin, told where she came from - they didn't understand - and shared a nursery rhyme with them.

When we walked away, she was blushing and so lively. “That was… awesome, Catra. They were all so… friendly, so alive. I wish

we could've stayed longer. Just playing with them." She sighed and was radiating warmth like a bonfire, still caught in the moment.
I nodded and laid a hand on her arm, chuckling a bit. "I know. I saw how you liked it. It looked like you've never been in a public market or been playing with children before."
Suddenly, her muscles went stiff and when I looked up at her, I saw her face falter.
"What?" I asked. What had happened? Adora hesitated, opened her mouth, just to close it again, the light mood from before gone now. It was a complete turnaround.
"What have I said?" I asked. Then I remembered what I actually had said, and it dawned on me. "You... haven't? That's it, right? You haven't." It struck me as a surprise.

Adora stopped walking, and I could see her hands that had turned into fists and her jaw had clenched.
"Why is this so different from our visit in Pelousion? Or walking around markets in Rome? You said you'd done that. I assumed—"
"I haven't!" Adora shouted. She gasped once and quickly covered her mouth with both hands. Then she backed down a few paces, sat down at a low wall that surrounded a patio in front of a house, and put her face in her hands, that sat on her knees. The change of her mood left me baffled. How could that be? After a minute or so, I sat down beside her and… just waited.

"I haven't," she repeated after a while, trying to compose again. She nervously brushed her hair back, but then she just blurted everything out: "I've moved around with my father for years, but I was mostly raised and educated in our villa. At home. Always at home. I didn't attend school with other children of my age, because he deemed it unsafe, not secure enough, and we were always on the move anyway. And because we often stayed in places where schools for women just weren't an issue. Just me. Mostly. And I wasn't allowed to stroll over markets like this. On my own. I've never been free like you. Never. It's a wonder that he allowed me to go to Egypt without him or… my stepmother, after all this time. This is the first time in my life that I'm out with

anyone other than my closest family or Bow. It’s the first time I’m just—"

Her rambling came to a screeching halt, when she realized what she’d just admitted. And it didn’t get into my head. That couldn’t be. She was so well-educated, so funny, even witty sometimes, in her own, naive way.
“I don’t… Adora, this is… I don’t get it. What?” The disbelief in my voice was tremendous. It just didn’t go in my head.
“Yeah, it’s unbelievable, I know.” She fumbled with her fingers in her lap and obviously was embarrassed about having revealed such a private part of her life.
“But you’re so—" I cut myself short before the word ‘adorable’ left my mouth and urgently searched for a better, less meticulous ending of my sentence. I came up with “... well-educated and smart.”
She scoffed. It was a haughty noise. “Yeah, smart, haha. Of course, I’m smart. I’ve been taught by excellent tutors the whole years. I’ve read scrolls over scrolls. And I even read… my fathers letters to many of his allies and the family. I am not as good as you might think."
That was a revelation, but it just fitted into the picture. “Adora, you little spy.”
She waved it off. “Nah. I’m just curious. And bored. I'm so bored. See, it’s all book knowledge. All of it. I was free to study everything I wanted. But I was never free to go where I wanted. Always guarded, always kept safe until the day would come to trade me in for the greater good. I'm smart, but I'm not the master of my own fate. I'm a tool." She fell dry.

Oh!
Yeah. That made sense.
Cleopatra’s words came to my mind. What if the Romans just played some kind of game with us? What if Adora was just a bait, to keep us in check or, worse, to spy upon our highest ranks and pass all this to Caesar?
I had to laugh about that assumption. Indeed, that problem was solved, as far as I was concerned. I hadn’t had the feeling that she was capable of doing things like that the whole time, even

unconsciously. Otherwise, she had to be the best actress that had ever been walking under the sunlight. Now I was sure. That wasn't acting. She wasn't a spy, or something ridiculous like that. She was just herself. Adora. Her family's tool.
With that realization came another one. This whole planned marriage was real. She should marry Hordak, the strange and mighty governor of Thēbais. And whatever feeling I might have, just wouldn't count. Had I lived in the blurry delusion that she and I possibly could have had some weird and nice affair, while both us were doing our spy-thingy, this was off the table now. At least, I could give her a few nice days as her guide, but that was pretty much it. I needed to put her out of my head, the sooner the better. This could lead to nowhere.

I didn't want to continue that kind of conversation in the public. Luckily, both our stomachs grumbled, and when I looked at her, it was clear we had the same thought. Fortunately, the next best food stalls were never far away in Alexandria and after a little stroll, I bought us some millet porridge first, and afterwards roasted dates in skewers, wrapped in bacon from another stand nearby. They had a lot of different snacks to offer, but these were the best. "Here, Adora, try some of these bacon and dates." I handed her a dish. "I'm going to make you moan." Adora dropped her skewer with big eyes, staring at me, making me to stare back at her while I mentally replayed my last words. When I realized what I said, I choked and croaked weakly: "THE FOOD! The food is going to make you moan."[33]
She tried to hide her laughter, but didn't very well, while I was blushing furiously. I slapped her shoulder and called "Shut up you idiot," instinctively, but it only made her laugh louder. I sank into my shame and stuffed more dates into my mouth. Oh dear Isis, this was so mortifying.

After I was able to think and speak without choking again, a look at the sun made it clear that we had a few more hours to pass. I made a dumb proposal without thinking too much about it. The words just tumbled out of my mouth. "Would you like to see the Library?"

Her pupils dilated like she'd never seen something like this before. Maybe she hadn't. "The Great Library of Alexandria? Can we do this? Is it open for… you know… everyone?"
I chuckled. "Of course we can. It's the Museion, and it's a public building. Everyone can go there."
She was weirdly impressed, and the thought was obviously enticing for her, but she replied: "Oh, okay, good. But, aren't you afraid of being recognized then? I mean… at least some people should know you here, or?"
I waved it off. "Nah, don't worry. I've never been in the Library or the Museion itself. That's just… not my thing."
We were already walking in the direction where it lay, near the eastern part of the harbor, along the Canopus way, Alexandria's main street and between the palace grounds and the Heptastadion. Technically, the Museion was a part of the royal quarter of Alexandria, even if only at its outer skirts and not inside the inner and better walled fortifications of the original complex. But an outer wall had been built in later times, extending the premises, and this, indeed, made me nervous. Sometimes there were guards watching the gates, but not always. It depended on how nervous the current ruler was. I put my head down and pulled the headscarf in front of my eyes closer, now trying to avoid looking people into their eyes. We passed a part of the city that had preserved more than a touch of the Egyptian flavor. Here, everything looked different from the Hellenistic district from before. The streets were narrower, the buildings mostly a few stories high, everything was more colorful and not so bright looking than at the harbor or around the Serapeum. Everything was even more lively here.

"What's your thing, then?" Adora asked, picking up my last sentence.
I tilted my head, because… yeah, because that was a tricky question to answer. After all, Adora wasn't stupid.

Chapter End Notes

> You remember when Adora found the sword? This here is the same. She just wants to discover what lies ahead.

[29] 'Wusa' is the word for the Goddess 'Isis' in the Meroitic language, which was used in Nubia, Catra's language from maternal side. Isis was one of the most influential Egyptian goddesses, and the cult of her worship even spread via Greece in the Hellenistic era over to Rome in the late Republican time. At the height of its expansion, there were even temples of Isis in Londinium (London) or Spain. ↑
[30] Catra calls for Thot, because he was the god of wisdom, and that's clearly needed here. ↑
[31] Funnily, this is an unintended citation from "You make me see stars", Chapter 19. I wrote my own stuff first, then remembered that I super liked this exact sentence in the regarding scene and even commented about it to the author. So, credit where credit is due. ↑
[32] Hathor, the Egyptian goddess of love and beauty. What else? But Hathor, as a sky deity and protector of Ra, was also more. And now, listen carefully, dear reader, because here you have the only foreshadowing you'll ever hear from me: in some myths, Hathor rebels against Ra's control over her and rampages freely in foreign, distant lands. Ra sent out Thoth to bring her back. He actually pacifies her, but the main point are the two aspects of Hathor: dangerousness vs. joyfulness, reflecting the Egyptian belief that women encompass both extreme passions of fury and love. We will see where this leads us soon enough. ↑
[33] I totally stole this scene from "Food Fight", Chapter 5, but I made modifications. ↑

Of Thieves and Seals

Chapter Summary

Maybe this wasn’t a good idea.
Uhm, what are you doing with this whip, Adora?
What? It can blink?

Chapter Notes


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Gate of the Sun
Royal Quarter
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Campus Mag
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Still Alexandria, Egypt - September, 48 BCE

Catra

"What's your thing, then?" Adora asked.
Spying upon you surely wouldn't have been the best answer, I assumed. And her blatant, honest question caught me off guard.

What was my thing? I mean, I'd had fun ruling Buhen for the time being, but now, with this duty presumably off my shoulders, this here wasn't so bad at all. I liked strolling around the land, visiting places and talking to people. Or ordering them to do things. Because being the witty, sometimes bad-ass half-sister of the actual Pharaoh helped a lot in getting people to do what I wanted from them. I like it. It felt good to be on the top of the food chain, even if it was just on behalf of my mighty sister. I wasn't jealous of her. Even if Cleo matured a lot in the recent three years, since she took reign, I still remembered the days when we would play hide and seek together as children, running through the palace when I was there, and dreaming of the adventures we would one day embark on when we hid in chambers to evade our teachers. Cleo'd always been an earnest child back then, like she was an earnest person now, but I always knew how to tease her to make her do something silly or goofy back then.
The burden of ruling Cleo carried on her young shoulders was nothing I wanted for myself. I didn't have the same drive to rule as Cleo had. The thought of being in charge of the entire realm, the necessity to forge alliances at court and beyond, dealing with the everlasting Roman expansion was also nothing I wanted to be pressured into. These obligations would never end, that much I knew from our discussions and the lectures Cleopatra's teacher's taugth me as well. Cleopatra always had the will to do all that, to pour her entire existence into it. I was surely proud of her, even grateful, because better she than anybody else. But not me. It was enough for me that she included me in getting to her aims.

Which was quite fine, since I had none of them.

I still wasn't sure where all of my own doing aimed. For the recent years, I mostly tagged along, followed her wishes and occasionally friendly-begging orders and begging me she could. All in all, it had worked good for me.
My current assignment from Cleo - beside getting the seal - was like babysitting some overly adorable girlfriend-material, and—
Ooof! Have I really thought that? Girlfriend material? Oh, Hathor you damned troublemaker, you vile messenger of feelings unwanted. My whole ruminating about this woman had just brought me back to the one point where I shouldn't go. I dammed Cleopatra for this damned task of hers. I had to stay away from these trains of thought. Far, far away.

"I'm good at bossing people around, Adora. And babysitting, obviously." I pretended to cough, and Adora quickly retorted: "You aren't good at neither of that, it seems. I didn't do what you wanted, and now I'm here, which you didn't want either. Looks like you're falling short of your own claims." She smirked sneakily.
"I'm teaching you a lesson here, you blonde goof ball," I pretended haughtily, crossing my arms and baring my teeth.
She laughed. "Ahh, what lesson might that be? Looking like an idiot who's not able to keep her babies in check? You've mastered that very well, oh mighty Catra." She made a little curtsy while stretching her arms to both sides, and it looked adorable.
I groaned, and the blonde menace to womankind giggled. "I should've left you on the ship. Really."
"Nah," she playfully slapped my shoulder, "Admit, you like keeping me around, don't you?"
Oh, so true, Adora, so true. "I would rather keep Hyenas with fleas in my house."
She still giggled. "That's so embarrassing for you, Catra."
Luckily, we'd reached the place where the Museion stood, and it gave me an excuse to end this playful battle of retreat.

From the outside, the Museion looked like a large temple complex that stretched far behind into different attached buildings, with many arcades and archways, red roofs and an overall imposing

impression. Left and right of the entrance, columns of white marble held two porticus[34] that went around the whole building. It was easy to guide Adora up the broad stairs. There wasn't anyone hindering us, and, so far, I hadn't met anyone whom I knew. We walked past the towering columns of the entrance into a large hall with archways at both sides, leading to more rooms. In the center of the hall stood a statue of Pallas Athene, the Greek goddess of wisdom, holding an owl on her left arm and looking above everyone, unconcerned, her gaze focused on the distance, maybe at a future unknown to anyone but her. Between the columns we saw scholars with their disciples walking around, engrossed in muted discussions or reading while walking, sitting, standing. Their busy yet quiet chatter added to a lively and very sublime atmosphere.
We wandered around, passed study rooms and lecture halls, even a little amphitheater in the center of the complex that was probably fitting no more than 30 people and presumably used for larger discussions or lectures. We went by many rooms where people sat at large workplaces and wrote. Up to eight scribes were crammed together in small rooms and wrote down stuff from other scrolls. The sound of quills scratching against papyrus had been a little grating at first, but we got used to it quickly, and it turned into a rather soothing noise.
"What are they doing?" Adora asked quietly, and I quietly replied: "Copying. The old papyri must be copied every around 100 years before they get unreadable. Some of these scrolls have been copied a dozen or more times."
"That's… wow. Really?" She looked stunned.
I nodded and shrugged my shoulders. "Nothing lasts forever," I replied, and to a little more emphasis, I added, "Within these walls lies the greatest wealth of knowledge and wisdom of the know world." It sounded a little pathetic, even to me, so I dragged her further, turning around a corner. I ran into some weird pigtails and a bunch of scrolls, coming from the other side. We crashed into each other, my ass bumped to the ground, and a second later I heard a surprised croak. "You?"

Oh, fuck.

I gulped down my imminent shock upon the reveal. “Entrapta? What a… pleasure to see you…” Ugh! Shit! That wasn’t good at all. She knew me.
The woman that had also fallen on her butt beamed at me. “Oooh. So you have set your quarrels with Ptolemy aside? Given that you’re here, that's the logical assumption, isn't it. Was about time! It is sooo good to see you again, Catra. I really need—"
I laid a finger on my lips and shut her down by stomping on her foot. She shrieked, and Adora stood a bit struck beside us, watching the scene with furrowed eyebrows and a concerned face. “Shut up, Entrapta.” I pulled her up, and we quickly gathered the dozen of scrolls she’d carried. Then I dragged both of them into a small chamber nearby and closed the door behind us. Luckily, no one had watched the scene.

We stood in a storage room, with nothing more than shelves over shelves with scrolls, papyri and leather-bounded maps on them. Nothing more than a dusty storage room.
“Why exactly are we standing here, Catra?” the middle-sized woman with the incredible long pigtails called Entrapta asked, glancing at us, looking a bit uneasy now.
“Because I’ve NOT reconciled with this imbecile, Entrapta. Why would I? He's a boy, and his regency council is a collecting of fucking assholes. To put it mildly."
“I wouldn’t put it that way—", Entrapta started.
“Pfff, of course you wouldn’t. As long as someone grants you access to the library, you will sing their praises, right? Meaning no offense,” I scoffed and obviously meant it like an offense. But the nerdy science girl got nothing of it and just replied: “Of course! Gathering all this knowledge is beyond such trivialities that you and your family like to pleasure yourself with. There is much to learn."
I was only a bit baffled, because she was always like this. “I wouldn’t call it pleasure, really. It’s more like mutual torturing until the last one of the Ptolemies is wiped out. Then, other folks can take over and repeat. At least that’s what history taught me.”
Entrapta looked at me with a weird expression. “Why are you here then?”

When I thought about how to explain my mission to her, I winced a little. I didn’t want to harm her, because Entrapta and I had worked together in the past, and secretly, I liked her. She was just an excellent scholar, a bookworm, responsible for teaching kids of noblemen or nobles themselves at the royal court - and some more secretive stuff. She hadn’t one malicious fiber in herself and was just interested in observation and truth. Unfortunately, she was also unable to keep any secret - and she was a terrible actress.
She’d seen me. If I let her go, my presence would soon be known to, well, too many people. To our luck, Adora hadn’t said anything and tried her best to be as inconspicuous as possible. My possibilities were nonetheless limited.

“Entrapta. I think it would be safe for you to stay in this room for a while. Maybe, until tomorrow?”
“Really?” she asked, as oblivious as ever. “What’s going to happen? Is the library in danger? Is Cleopatra advancing with her troops?”
I shook my head. “Nope, Entrapta, sorry. No battles today.” Was she really disappointed about that? Her face looked like. “But I can’t have you run around and talk about me. You understand?” I looked around. “Why… why don’t you settle down in this nice room and stay the night?" I pointed at the shelves. "There are so many scrolls that need an investigation for lost knowledge, right? How about you go through some of them? While I'll go and fetch you some water." I could sound so nice if I wanted to, but internally, I begged that she didn't object. Knocking her out was something I wasn't fond of, but I would do it if I'd needed to. Entrapta looked around, then put her own scrolls down and drew another one out of a shelf nearby. She began to whisper to herself and mumbled something, I didn’t understand, because, yeah, nobody understood middle or late Egyptian today, because of it being 1,000 years old and such. But of course, Entrapta did.

“Entrapta?” I asked. But to no avail, because she was already lost in her reading, tracing hieroglyphs with her finger while speaking to herself.
I dragged Adora out of the room and silently closed the door

behind me. Adora shot me questioning glances and frowned.
“She’ll have a good time as long as nobody kicks her out or searches for her. Reading and gathering new knowledge is everything for her. She can read the whole day long.”
“And if she… you know… needs to… use the latrina?”
“Then be it. What options do we have? Shall we go back and knock her out? Or worse?”
“What? No! Of course not,” Adora pressed out, trying not to look too shocked about my proposal. She was really a much too nice person.
“Yeah, well, then our options are limited. In a few minutes, she'll perhaps have forgotten about us. That’s absolutely possible, you know?”
Adora sighed. “Maybe it wasn’t a good idea to go here. We should leave before we run into another acquaintance of you. This sightseeing isn’t worth it.”
I agreed with her. As the encounter with Entrapta showed, I had been a little careless. “Right, we should head back to Scorpia. We can get something to eat on the way. There will be no time for it later, I assume.”

We left the library and made our way back to Scorpia’s shop. I introduced Adora to some more Egyptian finger food that we bought from market stands, and the effect was quite similar to from before. I also realized, that Adora loved food. She stuffed herself with such celerity and quantity, that it was a wonder that her body was in such a good shape. Still, her eyes nearly popped out on every new food she laid her hands on, and it made me giggle while I teased her relentlessly. She didn't really care aboutr it, it just rolled off of her when she had better things in mind - or her mouth, in this case.

We arrived when the sun’d started to set. Scorpia closed the door of her shop and led us behind a curtain to another small and stuffed room at the back of the shop. She handed me a new dress and I ordered Adora to put it on. She didn’t hesitate, starting to undress herself on the spot, which got Scorpia and me to turn ourselves around very quickly and admire the greatness of a bunch of trivial looking scarfs that piled at the wall. But not

without shooting a glance to a mirror that stood beside me and let me catch a glimpse of Adora's nearly bare back, arms, and thighs. [35] Even in the bad mirror, she look great. I felt a shiver of arousment running down my spine.

Scorpia sensed my state and asked with a fake concerned tone: "Is everything alright, Catra?"
I cleared my throat and mind alike, and rubbed my suddenly sweaty palms before my waist. "Do you have what I asked for?"
She winked. "Of course I have. You should know better than to ask such a question." It was a joke, but there was also some underlying truth to it. Scorpia was one of my oldest friends, since years ago, where we'd met at a mutual mission on Cleopatra's behalf. She quit her duties as a guard a while ago, but we tended to talk once in a while and to help each other if needed. Scorpia rummaged in a little box she drew out under a pile of others and handed over a small silver-golden plaque. There was a sign engraved, the shape of a cross, but with a teardrop-shaped loop in place of an upper bar. The Ankh, a traditional sign of power of the old Egypt dynasties since long ago. Today the palace used these plaques to grant access to the royal court and other premises of the Pharaohs, and they only updated the writings around the Ankh, at the corner of the plaque. Here, the year of reign of the current Pharaoh, his name and a word of encouragement was written in. And of course, Ptolemy had quickly issued his own plaques to prevent any infiltration of the palace of Cleopatra's allies.

The plaques were rare, maybe only one or two hundred emitted during a year of regency of a Pharaoh. So, it wasn't easy to get hold of one of them and I wondered, how Scorpia had achieved it.
"I think I don't want to know, right?" I asked.
Scorpia's gaze was as open as ever, but she shook her head in denial and replied: "It's nothing of your concern. Just know, that the previous owner shouldn't have had it in the first place, and that he doesn't it anymore either. You have nothing to worry about."
I pulled up a corner of my mouth. "Always doing the good deeds,

don’t you?”
“Yeah, what can I say? You know me, wildcat.”
I stepped forward and reluctantly hugged her. If Scorpia was surprised by this rare and sudden display of affection of mine, she didn’t show it. But she fervently hugged my back and I got a few pats on my back, crushing as always. Then we separated again.

Meanwhile, Adora had finished her changing and stood before us, dressed like a true Roman patrician again, like I saw her the first time. Her bright stola was covered by a dark red and purple striped palla, her headscarf an alike color. She’d added a belt around her waist, which flattered her figure very well, becaused it made her form stand out. A veil of silk was looping around her throat, laying loosely on her shoulders. And as it was her nature, she stood tall and upright and looked like she was up to rule an empire - if it hadn't been for the uncertain look on her face, that ridiculously counteracted her appearance. “Is this okay? It’s difficult without a mirror… or help.”
I cleared my throat and ignored Scorpia’s glancing. “You look incredible beautiful—" Huh, too much, full stop, retry, “I mean, you look like you belong there, everything’s fine, Adora. We should pack our stuff and go.”
She looked around, as finally her gaze fell onto something, and she grabbed it in an instant.
“Ehm, Adora? What are you doing with a whip?” I asked. Adora just smugly grinned, as she mounted the whip on her belt. “Let yourself be surprised, kitty.”
Scorpia looked pretty amused upon my bewildered look, and when I looked back at her, she winked with sparkling blue yes. Oh Isis.

Adora

We left Scorpia’s shop and Catra guided us back to the palace district. She informed me how the palace guards would handle

visitors and told me not to show off any insecurity. With me being an obvious Roman patrician, and her acting as the humble servant, they shouldn't question us too sincere. "Act as you belong there. Just stay calm, be the most arrogant version of yourself. It shouldn't be that difficult, right?"
There'd been a sharp spike in her voice, and so I tilted my head and furrowed my eyebrows: "What's that supposed to mean?"
She sounded like she was rolling her eyes. "Eh, just be the Roman noblewoman that you are. Like, you know, because you already own the world and such."
"Hey, we are not like that." Actually, I felt a little offended. From where did that come from?
Catra scoffed: "You are exactly like that. Just look at your people, occupying nation after nation around the great sea. I mean, you even call it Mare Nostrum, 'our sea', as if there weren't living twenty other nations at the shores of the Mediterranean too. It's so arrogant. Conceited. Pathetic. Ugh!"
"But—" I tried to interject but was cut off by her rambling gone mad.
"And you walk around and everyone has to oblige to your demands. And if they don't, you send legions."
"We don't!" I retorted weakly. I mean, we did. Often, at least.
"Oh yes? Tell that to the Gauls. Tell it to the people of Alesia." [36]

Her harsh tone pushed me back. Mentioning the Gauls was a clear reminder of my own family's involvement in the most important recent events of Rome's spreading. Conquering the divided and ever-quarreling Gallic nations and adding two full provinces to the Roman Republic had made uncle Julius rich and, more important, much more powerful. Powerful enough to cross the river Rubicon with an accompanying Legion instead of disarming there, before going back to Rome. The Gallic war had been the basis for his rise as an Imperator. But he willingly broke this sacred rule of our nation, and I haven't looked at him in the same way as before ever since. Only that no one else in my family saw it the same way as me.

I realized, too, that Catra wasn’t bantering or teasing. She sounded serious, and I was a little taken aback by her accusation. Was my uncle’s doing my fault? I felt accused despite I wasn't responsible any of his actions. I Just ended up suffering from them too. Didn’t she see that? It was unfair.
I stayed silent, and didn't reply, not wanting to heat that argument. When I shot a glance over to Catra, it seemed that she tried to compose herself, hands clenched, jaw pressed, eyes staring forward. Minutes passed while we wallked through the evening city, and none of us took up the stick of the conversation again.
Eventually, I couldn’t hold back any further. “Do you really think like that about me?” I asked, my voice wavering between anger and concern.
Catra sighed. “Not of you. I… I’m… I shouldn’t have said that.” She stopped and turned around. “I’m not good at this.”
I frowned. “At what? Talking?”
“No, you idiot. Apologizing.”
“Oh.” I looked at the ground, but then I smirked. “I mean, I didn’t say anything.”
She turned back and didn’t look at me anymore. “I’m sorry, Adora. Accusing you of the sins of your uncle was wrong of me. You aren’t responsible.”

I nodded, stupidly, because she couldn’t see it. There was so much I wanted to talk about, so much I wanted to ask her. But few of it had anything to do with my uncle and something of it with all the weird feelings for her. Being accused of genocide the one second and looking into her wonderful eyes, full of regret the next one didn’t help me to clear things up. Trying to keep myself together ended with just a nod, then I asked: “Shall we, you know, just keep going with what we are here for and… talk about this later?”

Catra nodded. “Good, noble spy.” We brushed over the plan curtly a last time until we reached the outer premises of the palace district, then it got serious. Catra held me back in the shadow of a building and watched over the place before the front gate. We

waited for some minutes until she saw a palanquin crossing the place, heading for the gate, too. Then she dragged me further.

The palace of Alexandria was a large complex of many buildings, smaller and taller, high-rising and flat ones, but all in the style of the late Hellenic period when they'd been built. White marble, columns, archways, statues, temples, governmental buildings, all of it guarded by a manned wall that surrounded the entire area. The surrounding enclosure was rather for guarding the area from unwanted guests or thiefs than to stop an army or else. But there were guards patrolling the wall, and it wouldn't be easy to snitch outside, if necessary. We approached the front gate, Catra right-hand side in front of me, holding the plaque in her hand.
One of the four palace guards raised his hands and stopped us, while two others dealt with the palanquin. Catra held out the plaque, and the guard suspiciously eyed it, then Catra, then me. I tried to make a blasé face, looking around slowly, seemingly bored by this annoyance. The guard asked something, Catra replied, and I only understood my made-up name we'd agreed on, and then she held out the plaque again. The guard nodded, then stood beside and waved us through.

We sauntered into the premise, making it clear that we were in no rush and didn't have a worry. I was in fact very concerned about our current display, but Catra, however, was confident and in control. She knew the area well and navigated us through the complex with ease, me in tow. Along the way, we passed several smaller buildings, including a middle-sized temple and a smaller one. They still commanded a certain degree of respect due to their architectural beauty and their religious significance. We continued on and reached a wide parade ground in front of a massive palace. As we crossed the parade ground, I couldn't help but feel a sense of awe at the grandeur of the palace behind. It was a symbol of power and wealth, and I couldn't imagine what kind of childhood it might've been to grow up there. I wanted to ask Catra about it, but it wasn't the time to talk.

Eventually, we arrived at a low gate at the front of the palace. Another group of guards were stationed there, and their attention was immediately drawn to us. Unfortunately for us, no one else was trying to enter the palace at that moment, so we had the full attention of the guards. They looked at us warily, clearly unsure of what to make of us and our presence there. Despite the guards' suspicious gaze, Catra remained composed and continued forward, leading me with her. I couldn't help but feel grateful for her unwavering confidence and her ability to guide us.

Catra held out the plaque again and two of the soldiers eyed it. They recognized it, but nonetheless asked Catra questions, to which she responded with a lowered head. She gestured at me and bowed, then continued to blabber something in Egyptian. However, we were not yet been let through. The conversation went forth and back to no avail, and it made me flippant.
I decided to quicken the game, laid my hand on the whip and took it off the belt, then called "Enough." In Egyptian. One of the words I already learned. Everyone turned to me, and Catra did it with her mouth agape. Then I pointed with the whip to the ground before me, indicating her to come beside me, and said harshly: "Translate for me."
She nodded, hesitant.
"Tell them to call the Roman emissary. Tell them to do it now!"

Catra faltered, but finally interpreted what I had said. She'd just finished her sentence when I added. "And tell them to not inform his *wife*, if present."
Catra's eyes bulged a bit, and she cleared her throat before translating my last words. I just stood, straight, and with my face still partially covered by the silk veil, I clearly knew what for an impression that must give, and I was trying hard not to blush. The guards looked insecure now, aware what would happen upon a breach of confidential, or rather *delicate* secrets, if the Roman emissary to the Egyptian Pharaoh would be compromised in the current situation. beacuse of such a trivial, yet personal matter. Ptolemy needed, urgently needed the backup of the Senate and would be… ungrateful upon any disturbances. The men looked at

each other, searching for a solution until we were finally waved through.

"Why didn't they let us through immediately?" I asked and Catra replied: "They didn't recognize you. There aren't as many plaques out there and usually, the guard know at least the face of the holders. But your little trick was excellent. Courtesans and their customers might change, but certain needs stay the same, regardless the person." She coughed, and I shivered a bit when the high of excitement wore off.

Catra reached for the largest palace within the royal quarter, and we went up a few steps on a broad flight of stairs. The inner hallways of the palace weren't busy, but also had not fallen completely silent. They never would. Servants and members of the royal court strolled or hurried around and nobody paid us special attention, and nobody would. The area inhabited hundreds, or rather thousands of people, and everyone had his own worries to care about.
Catra lead us through several archways, a courtyard, more hallways until we reached some kind of study room. It wasn't a large one, housing just four tables with a stool each, and some shelves at the walls and obviously not used very often. Catra dragged me in, closed the wooden door behind us, and walked over to one of the shelves. There she crouched down on her heels and fumbled with her hand behind some of the bent papyri and other stuff that filled it.
"Ok, help me brush that aside." We leaned against the side of the shelf, and it silently moved aside, to reveal a thick wooden door. Catra draw a key out of a pocket and opened the lock with a smug grin. "Now we have to be quick, Adora. We can't move the shelf back to its place from the inside, and you can't stay here on your own. We have to come back as quick as possible."
I nodded, followed her into the small passageway behind the hidden door, which we closed and locked immediately. It was mostly dark, but there were little openings in the walls here and there that let through some light. Just enough for it to not be completely black. "Speak silently. One could still hear us. This corridor leads us to the seal room. I'll fetch one of the seals, then

we head back immediately and sneak out.” Hopefully undiscovered, I thought.
“I’m not sneaking, I’m gracefully walking,” I teased quietly and nudged her shoulder.
“Whatever, princess,” she murmured and skulked on.

We passed several other doors and I realized, that these corridors obviously ran through a larger part of the palace. “How large is this? Is it known?” I asked. Catra bobbed her head back and forth and said: “It’s not completely unknown. But only a few people have keys, mostly the female members of the royal family. The corridors were built with the palace upon its erection, providing escape routes for the first inhabitants. But soon after, the women of the Pharaohs started to use it for their own purposes and kept the secret away from their men. I know five other keyholders as of today. Berenice had one, Arsinoe hasn’t.” She snickered to herself.
“So we probably won't run into anyone here, right?”
“Unlikely,” she just answered, "three of them aren't in Alexandria these days", and it made me feel a little bit better.

We had been walking for only a few minutes, then Catra stopped before another door, this one being rather little, maybe just the size of a kid. “You stay here. Do not move. If you hear that something goes wrong, walk back to the room where we went in and then search for the emissary. He will be able to protect you. Understood?”
I nodded, and she put her ear on the wood and listened. She made no noise, but after around two minutes, she very slowly put the key into the keyhole, and opened it ever so quietly.

Light fell into the corridor, but only dim and flickering, like from candles or torches. Catra crouched, sneaked into the other room, and now I only heard her silently tiptoeing.
A little croak.
A soft sigh.
A quiet scratch.

Then, again, tiptoeing, audible only to someone who listened for it.

Catra reappeared and closed the door behind her. As she straightened herself before me, we locked our glances and exhaled vividly at the same time. I smirked, she smirked, then she nodded and held up a round disc the size of a head, made of gold, heavily engraved with an Ankh and other signs of the Pharaonic power.
"Done," she just said, put it into a flat bag hanging around her neck, below her cape, as we started walking back to the chamber. We reached it without any incidents, Catra again listened at the door for a while, then she opened it, and we crept into the room.
"Phew!" I said, grinned, and wiped my sweaty hands. "Don't call it too early. We still have to leave the palace," Catra warily retorted.

She opened the door to the hallway, and we were just closing the door, when someone called to us. I didn't understand it, but of course it wasn't a good sign, and Catra immediately spun around. The voice belonged to a middle-sized, well-built man in his best ages, eyeing us suspiciously. Catra quickly bowed and answered something I didn't understand, while I just stood, saying nothing, like always. The two played a short question and answer game, with Catra bowing again.
It didn't work out, because suddenly, the man paced back a few steps, turned around, and started to yell. In an unbelievable gracefully and swift move,Catra reached for her leg, drew out a throwing knife and flung it in his back. He choked, tumbled and fell to the ground, not dead, but already seriously wounded. And the yelling had stopped.
She paced over to him, drew out the dagger from his back and wiped it on his clothes, put it back into its hold and started dragging the groaning man to the chamber. "What?" she asked upon my staring. "What should I've done, Adora?"
I shortly shook my head, trying to regain my composure, and opened the door to help at least a bit. Even so, I was still too shocked by the sudden burst of violence this woman was capable of.

After she put him down and closed the door behind him, his noises were still audible, but not very much. “Go, now. We have to be quick now, before someone discovers him.” She shoved me forward, and we hurried through the hallways, forward to the front gate. I tried to comb through the whirlwind in my head. “Is he… dead?” I asked, shivering upon the likely answer.
“Not yet,” was her reply, with not too much compassion.
I insisted: “But he will be?”
“Probably.” Dry. Short. Disinterested?
I let out a noise of discontent, whereupon she scoffed. “What, princess? Too bloody for you, too real? You wanted adventure. Here you have. This is a war, if you haven’t got the message. Why should he be handled different? He serves the enemies of my sister.” She didn’t hesitate, her eyes didn’t flicker, her voice was calm and steady. I felt irritation, some kind of guilt, despite my situation. She just dragged me further.

We slowed our steps when we reached the main gate, and graciously walked down the great flight of stairs, passing the guards in a decent manner. Thankfully we weren’t questioned again. Outside the palace, leaving it quickyl behind, we passed the buildings on our way back to the outer gate, and inside me, the angst roared. Killing someone hadn’t been part of the plan, but Catra had been obviously prepared. She was deadly dangerous, I reminded myself, not just a pretty face.

Behind us, inside the palace, someone started yelling, shouting, obviously alarming the guards. Catra cursed unrepeatable words and shoved me forward not too softly. We had around 50 passi until the outer gate, when she called at me: “Scream!”
“What?” I was too puzzled for a better reaction.
“Scream! Like you’ve been attacked. Scream for your life. I will make up something. Just scream!”
The first noise that left my throat, was a pitiable croak, not worth mentioning. Then, after heaving a deep breath, a high-pitched scream left, and then more. I screamed like an idiot. Catra let out a single chuckle, but then she had to keep her breath for running. When the guards at the gate before us took notice, most of them started running towards us. I deeply hoped, the disguise worked

so far. Catra shouted in Egyptian, pointing behind us wildly. Luckily, the main gate and flight of stairs to the palace weren't visible, the line of sight blocked by some buildings in between. When the guard met us, we stopped running and I didn't have to fake that I was panting. Catra gestured with dramatic moves behind us and sounded like a scared dull one. I just breathed heavily, readying myself for the next catastrophe. The guards shot us a short glance, then hurried further to the main gate.

We rushed forward to the outer gate, Catra dragging me, while I desperately tried to keep my palla together. Such clothes clearly weren't made for running, and I cursed my ancestors for not inventing more practicable wears for women. Grrr. The only two guards left there dealt with a group of nightly strollers talking in Greek who demanded entrance - *immediate entrance* - to the Pharaoh himself because of something I didn't understand, and then… we were outside.
We'd rushed by in unexpected luck, were outside the palace grounds and slowed down to a reasonable, inconspicuous pace when on the street. I cursed my Palla again, this impractical garment, that wasn't designed to be worn during thievery. We walked over the broad Canopus way, until we reached the corner of the next buildings, slipped in a smaller alleyway between, and got quickly lost in the nightlife that was set up by the largest city in the world. Only minutes later, we were back at the harbor.

Even at this late hour, it was a lively place. Many of the docks and jetties were lit by the glow of torches and lanterns, casting flickering light on the water. The sound of waves lapping against the hulls of the ships mixed with the occsional shouting of sailors and merchants as they went about their business. The docks were lined with a variety of vessels from all over the known world, from small fishing boats to large merchant ships. The war galleys of the fleet were lined at the east side of the harbor, where the palace lay. It was mostly quiet there.
We hurried along the docks and finally scrambled onto our ship, more stumbling than walking. Catra immediately ordered the mustached captain to cast off, and he followed her orders without making any of his usual fuss.

As the crew started to maneuver us out of the harbor, I watched the bank and the dam in the west, leading to the lighthouse with its ever glowing top. There wasn’t much going on over there, mostly everything was dark, despite a few groups of people with torches marching forth and back of the Heptastadion, the dam that connected the headland in the west with the tower isle. But I didn’t pay much attention to the stunning, nightly sight of the great city or the tower itself.
The last few hours - or rather hour, given the speed in which all of this had happened - made me unsure about Catra, casting a new light upon her. Of course, I already’d realized that she was a skilled and dangerous person. When I’d been attacked in Pelousion a few days before, she’d been quick, fierce and skilled. But she hadn't had to kill someone cold-blooded, her only casualty being the one guy whom she pushed down over the railing. Perhaps rather an accident when defending me, but not a planned murder.
But now? A precise, calculated, quick-handed action, executed cold-mannered.

Additionally, her little outburst during our walk. Ranting and accusing my family - me included - of war crimes and genocide felt repelling. Her apology sounded sincere, but nonetheless, the whole thing gnawed at me. My family, mainly my uncle, was of course responsible for all of this, and also of course, I wasn’t personally.
But yes, my gens *had* played an important part in getting Res Publica to where it was: the mightiest nation in all the Mediterranean world. And despite my situation, I couldn't help but to feel - at least to some extent - proud of it, and so I didn’t take her words lightly.

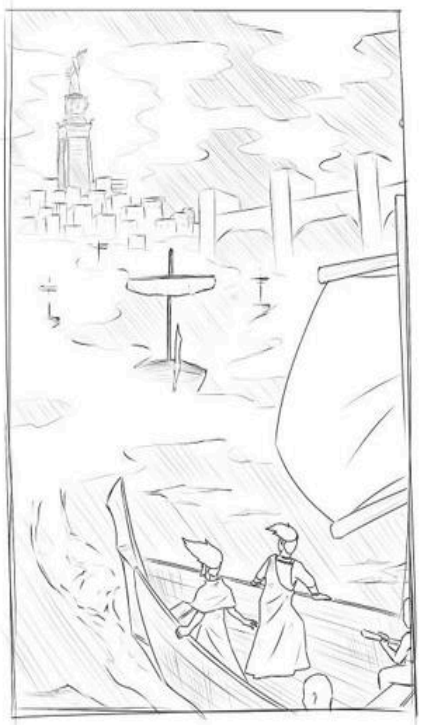
Suddenly, Catra stood beside me. She put a hand on my shoulder and squeezed it gently. “That was something, Adora. You did a good job there. Can’t believe we got out of there so easily.”
I wasn't in the mood for an answer, didn't want to spark any argument, so I didn’t say anything. She, maybe, sensed my mood and stayed silent while leaning beside me. Meanwhile, we’d left the inner port and rowed beside the lighthouse that now again

towered over us. Sailors started to set sails. I put my head back to catch a full view of the fire at night. But from nearly directly under the structure the view was rather mediocre.
Again I looked at the Heptastadion. Where now several detachments of soldiers or guards with torches hurried to the Lighthouse. And as I led my gaze back to the harbor of the palace, I saw that there was also movement. It looked like…

"They are readying a ship… no, rather two ships. Galleys, they are manning galleys, Catra!" I shouted.
"Captain," Catra called immediately.
"I see it," he shouted back, ordering the rowers to sped up the rhythm and the sailors to hurry. We already made a good pace, and the Dragon's Daughter was a fast ship, presumably faster than a typical galley. But we mustn't underestimate their ability to grapple us from two sides. We quickly passed the Lighthouse and the outer dam of the Great Harbor now, setting course for the open sea, away from the shoreline. The captain ordered to extinguish all lights and quickly, we were just a shadow in the night. Behind at the harbor the galleys started to move, gathering speed quickly if we judged by the rythm of the drums. They weren't as fast as us, and we already had a good lead of maybe one mille passus or more.







We reached open waters, where we quickly got hold of more wind. Only the large fire of the Lighthouse of Alexandria cast some dim light on this otherwise moonless night. But suddenly, the fire of the Lighthouse wasn't only shining like always, it started *blinking* .

Catra looked struck and the captian goggled: "Whoa! I haven't seen this since… never. I've never seen this." He sounded nearly delighted, and Catra added: "Fuck. Fuck Fuck Fuck! That wasn't included in my plan."
"What does that mean, Catra?" I asked, pleading.
She turned to me, looking dead serious. "It's like a beacon for all ships of the fleet that are out here. They shall return to Alexandria, on the watch for escapees or enemies. All ships will be seized or sunk upon any resistance. Soon it will be teeming with galleys here, Adora." [37]
I watched rearward, the Lighthouse already fallen back around two kilometers or more, but now the persecuting galleys left the Great Harbor too, picking up speed as they went into the wind. Our course was set for the northeast, presumably to vanish into the open sea and head back to the shore only when we were sure we had shaken off our pursuers. The further we got away from the shore, the more the wind picked up. Before us, the ocean was dark, only the omnipresent little lights from other ships visible. We were only a dark shadow in the night, but still…

… but still, we were visible. The night was two or three days after new moon, and the ocean was calm, its slowly rolling waves were a gentle up and down, not hiding us in the slightest in the trough of waves. And if an observer could spot a dark ship against the slightly lighter horizon…
"We need to put on the lights again!" I said, more to myself. And because I stood alone. Searching the deck for Catra, I found her speaking with the captain at the rudder, so I hurried over, and cut in on their conversation: "We need to put on the lights again!"
"What?" was the mutual reply.
"We are visible against the horizon in this calm sea. And when without position lights, we are just suspicious, if spotted."

“Yeah, and if we have position lights on, we are going to be spotted for sure, then boarded by the next galley,” Catra scowled.
“Maybe. Probably. But what would they do? It’s not that anyone beside these two,” and I pointed back to the two galleys that had set course beside the shoreline now, “has a description on what they should look for, right? They won’t know, and we just have to look as innocent as possible. And not like we’re sneaking away, bona dea! Hide in plain sight!”
The captain looked hesitant and twirled at his ridiculous mustache, while Catra was considering my idea. “I have to admit that the fair lady has a point there. If we are out of sight of our hideous pursuers, we should try to look like an affable trader. We'll probably meet another galley, but they won’t know what they’re looking for, and we won’t surely betray our beloved guests. By my honor!"
Upon her agreeing with me, I felt a bit of common ground with him and smiled at Catra. The captain pondered about the idea and finally nodded. “We’ll need to leave the sight of these first,” he pointed at them, “but then we’ll follow your advice. I feel a bit… dirty by doing so, it’s clearly uncommon practice, but maybe it will buy us the time and advantage my lovely ship needs. And no one shall say that I denied a little adventure!"
I grinned, and went back to the railing, from where I could spy at the galleys. We were still heading northeast, into the open water, and the dark shoreline as well as the lights of Alexandria slowly faded into the darkness. Only the Lighthouse was still fully visible, or rather, it’s nightly fire, that still continued to send its blinking signal out into the distance.

Three hours later, and with the morning approaching, I retreated to the captain’s cabin that Catra and I still gratefully occupied, to finally catch some sleep. I was exhausted. We’d been passed by at least four galleys, but all of them quickly hurried by without giving any sign of noticing us. Catra had been restless, switching between talking to the captain, staying beside me at the railing, and our cabin, where she presumably wrote a part of the mountain of letters that piled up on the desk now. Maybe angst kept her productive while it kept me giddy.

Despite evading an encounter and heading eastwards back to Pelousion now, my mood hadn't lightened up much, and my thoughts were twirling. The events of the day - the night - were still rumbling in my head, keeping me awake and nervous. But while the fear to be caught wore out while I sat on the bed, another one raised its ugly head.

What was it, what pulled me to and simultaneously pushed me away from Catra now? The last days - with *her* - belonged to the most exciting ones in my whole life. I'd seen so much, talked so much, sneaked on board this ship, played with children, ate new food and tasted new spices. I had disguised myself as a spy and robbed— *erm… rightfully* got a seal back! And I fled the Ptolemaic fleet - still did - and the whole time, this unbelievable woman was just by my side, always knowing what to do, being awesome, looking enticing. At least, most of the time, when she wasn't scolding me, or killing people, or bossing me around.

After readying for sleep I was still too uneasy to fall asleep and absently fumbling with some garment. And only when Catra suddenly laid a hand on my shoulder, I noticed her presence and started from my rumination with a jump.
"Whoa, Adora, keep cool," the composed woman said, drawing back her hand immediately.
I looked up at her. She was so near. "Yeah, sorry…" I replied in a desperate attempt to calm myself.

She sat down beside me, and instantly I felt the warmth of her presence. Too much warmth. Could I, maybe, scoot away a bit? But maybe she would find it offensive? While I got stuck in my ridiculous considering, Catra obviously had asked something that I didn't get. "What?" I asked, confused, bedazzled.
"Why aren't you sleeping? You must be tired. The night is mostly gone by now. It's nothing left to do for now, Adora. We're on our way back. They won't get us."
I shivered upon her nearness. What was I supposed to do with the urge to raise my hand and touch her cheek? All my chill from the previous days gone, leaving behind only a version of me that

needed to be touched by her. I felt so pathetic for not being able to suppress this weird urge.

She misunderstood my trembling. “Hey Adora. It’s over, we’re safe now. We did it and will be back soon.”
As if that’s supposed to help me. Here, I was safe. With her, I was safe. Back in Pelousion, my path to an unwanted future was as good as determined, set already, and I was just obliged to walk it down. The demands of family tore me apart. On the one side, my father’d been right: I had it coming and knew what was going to happen the whole time. Some day I had to be married, but it had always seemed to be in a very distant future. How dumb I’d been. Because on the other side, nothing of this knowledge made it any better. I was just a tool, in the hands of people mightier than me, to be used as a weapon, as a gift, not as a human being with its own will. Just a tool.
“It has been like that for hundreds of years,” my father’d said one time. “And it worked out for us, for all of Res Publica. Rome stands on the shoulders of the deeds of the old patrician families, the gens Julia, Aemilia, Fabia, Cornelia and all the others, Adora. Our whole worth depends on passing this legacy from generation to generation, from the first ones to the next ones. Sacrifices have to be made in the pursuit of the greater good. And so we do. We do it with honor, and without complaining.”

Yeah, the greater good.

And I?

What about me? Wasn’t I also—"

Why was it so comfortable now, so warm and soft?

Recognizing that my shivering had nearly stopped also meant noticing, that Catra had drawn me in, holding me firmly in her arms, while my side leaned against her whole upper body. She whispered calming words into my ear and despite she got the reason of my fears totally wrong, it soothed me nonetheless. “It’s okay Adora. Everything’s fine now. You can rest, I will look out for

you. Shhsss.”
I wanted to pull her in. I wanted to pull away. My body betrayed me as I finally clung to her, wrapping my arms around her waist, surprised by my own doing. Warmth dwelled in me, and my shivering stopped, when I silently mumbled: “You don’t shush me.”
She chuckled lowly and replied, nearly purring as she whispered: “I can shush you all day long,” while she petted my hair.
“No, you don’t.” I tried to tease her with my nails at her chest, but she just gripped my hand at its wrist and held it. I should tear myself away, but I hadn't it in me to fight her back.
It felt nice. It was so… close.
I was completely at ease now, my eyes were shut, and I was just drinking in her presence and listening to her heart. Why was her heart pounding so loud? Or was that mine? I wasn't sure.
I nuzzled my head into this sound, breathing in her scent, this mixture of lavender - where did you get lavender from here, my dumb brain asked - and cedarwood. And sweat. Oh yes, she was sweaty and dusty, but instead of disgust, I wanted to trail her chest with my finger and lick the salty—

Oh, bona dea, no. this had to stop. I had to stop this thinking and the demanding and all this longing. She was a woman. A woman! This was against my dignitas, and of course, I wasn’t for her. It was laughable. Cleopatra’s sister was clearly off limits. And of course, I wasn’t for a woman at all.
What should I do? I was so confused, and nothing of the whirlwind in me made any sense. Being held by Catra felt good, just so good. If this was so wrong, why did it feel so right?
Without finding a meaningful answer, I clung to her until I’d fallen asleep, still in her arms, because I wasn’t able to let go of her.

I did not want to let her go.

Chapter End Notes

[34] A porticus (portico) in Roman architecture is a porch extended as a colonnade. A roof structure is supported by columns and sometimes enclosed by walls. Today, a portico is rather only the entrance to a larger building. ↥
[35] The concept of modesty was pretty much nonexistent in ancient Rome. Of course, people didn't run around naked. But being nude in places of public use, like baths, saunas, the beach or clothing stores was pretty common. So, Adora obviously didn't care very much about being seen half-naked. Touching, of course, was something completely different. ↥
[36] The last decisive battle in the conquest of Gaul - today mostly France - took place at the fortress town of Alesia, with tens of thousands of casualties, mostly on the Gallic side. It would be considered a war crime today, because of the many civilian casualties that both sides were responsible for, but that were unneeded for the victory Caesar ultimately won. ↥
[37] No, the Lighthouse couldn't do this, of course not. Technically, given the means of the time, it might have been possible in a slow mode, using mirrors, apertures and such, but I've never heard or read of something like that until modern Lighthouses. ↥

Shots in the light

Chapter Summary

Catra is not pouting!
Adora may be dangerous.
Both may have to work on their communication skills.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pelousion, Egypt - September, 48 BCE

Adora

To my great displeasure, I woke up alone, not being held by Catra any longer. I vividly remembered how she'd embraced me, and on a second thought how I'd clung to her. And despite still feeling a bit embarrassed about that, I couldn't bring myself to not wanting to repeat it. Looking at the ceiling of the cabin, I gave myself a second to collect. This longing was so much against my dignitas, it had to end.
I sighed, while I swung my feet out of the bed, still feeling a little numb and dizzy. When I rose and looked at the bunk above mine, there she was. Sleeping, curled up around a pillow like a cat. Looking awesome, even in this state, with her messy curls hanging down over her face and still in all her clothes from yesterday. Had she just fallen down on the bed after she let me go? For how long had she done it?
I leaned against the frame of her bed and put my head on my crossed arms, and watched her quietly. *Like a creep* , a silent voice of reason told me. Her facial expressions were calm and at ease, and her smell was still the same. Cedarwood. Lavender. A bit salty. Something else I couldn't decipher very well. But the composition smelt nothing less than just 'You're safe here. You're home.'

After making a fool out of myself for some seconds - minutes? - I drew back and got undressed, then started to put on fresh undergarments which I pulled out of the little bag I brought with me. I was disctracted while peeking out of the window to the rear. The weather looked cloudy today, a gray sky, but no rain.
“What a nice sight at the morning.” Only in the last moment, I stopped myself from turning around, being nearly naked except my loincloth. Was she purring that?
“Are you enjoying yourself?” I asked, amused, while wrapping up my strophium[38.] Of course I didn't flex my back and arm muscles. Not very much, at least.

“Yeah, it’s quite okay over here. Since when you’re awake?,” Catra replied, moaning and stretching herself on the bed.
"You're changing the subject!" I called and maliciously decided upon immediate warfare.
"No you're- mfph!" Without warning, I'd turned around, picked up a pillow and shoved it into her face, then smugly said: “Are you still enjoying yourself?”
"Mmpphh fmmh!" [39]
Eventually she shoved me back, and I stumbled over a pile of rags that lay on the floor, bumping down on my ass.
“That serves you right,” Catra crowed happily while I rubbed my lower back.
“Meanie,” I whined.
“Dork,” a still amused Catra replied, while hoisting herself up and jumping down from the bed. She held out a hand and dragged me up, which caused both of us to face each other. Very, very close. Too close not to recognize the radiant heat that had emerged between us, with me still only in my underwear. She didn't wore more, and still held my hand. After staring into our eyes for too many seconds, I recognized that my hand trailed her forearm, gently, touching her ever so slightly. Catra looked down at my hand, frozen, not doing anything. With my mind delivering nothing, my hand wandered up her arm, towards her chest. When my fingers touched it just above her breasts, I felt a gentle tremor run through her body. But she still did not step back. Instead, her

other hand raised to my shoulder. Did she want to stop me? To push me away?

In hindsight, didn't know how long it took me to realize what I just did. First, I furiously blushed. Then I pulled back and turned around, not any longer able to look her in the eyes. This was so embarrassing! I had to get this desire out of my head. And to apologize for this unacceptable overstepping of boundaries.
In a desperate try to collect myself, I continued to dress, mumbling something about getting decent and stuff.
I put on the same dark green hunting dress from the day when I sneaked onto the boat, tied my hair into a ponytail and put on my boots. And all the while I eagerly tried to avoid Catra's sight to not make an even more babbling idiot out of myself. When me gaze touched hers, she looked grumpy, and disappointed. Of course she was! I was making a fool of myself, and using her to play around she wouldn't forgive lightly. She shouldn't. "I'm sorry," I breathed before leaving the cabin without looking her in the eye again.

Back on deck, the captain informed us that we had made good speed and were halfway to Pelousion. We shouldn't worry, unless Ptolemy was up for a blockade of the Pelousion harbor as well as the entire area. But that we'd see tomorrow morning and until then, nothing could be done at all.
And so, after all the rush and hurries of the last day, we found ourselves in the nerve-wrecking position that we didn't know what to do with ourselves. At least I had no idea. The tension from before still hadn't lifted, hanging in the air like fog, while Catra's gaze wandered over me again and again, eyeing me with suspicion, it seemed, and making me giddy. She had to think that I'd been assaulting her for my personal use. Oh, goddesses.

I decided to walk over to the caboose, asking for something to eat. Feeding myself had always been a good distraction, and the ship's cook turned out to be a fat and kind man who was always in the mood for jokes. While preparing lunch, he pushed some leftovers from breakfast over to me, added a sliced pomegranate, and quickly I found myself sitting at a stool, peeling potatoes,

chit-chatting and laughing upon his silly jests.
“It was hilarious, my lady, the funniest thing I’ve ever seen. The mighty and noble governor of Tamiathis, climbing up the tree, the jackal howling beneath him and the whores were screaming all the time…” He wiped some tears off his cheek, still laughing upon his own story, and I snickered and giggled as well. His lively manner clearly helped me to forget my embarrassment.

Morning went by, and after I finished breakfast, I actually enjoyed being distracted by something as dull as peeling potatoes, while also being entertained by an endless stream of anecdotes the cook had in his quiver. Catra hadn’t entered the caboose, presumably avoiding me also, and I was torn between being grateful and something else. I scolded myself for being an idiot, because she'd clearly every right to avoid me.
Lunch came and went, and Catra had obviously withdrawn to the cabin. In the middle of the afternoon, I was a nerve-wreck, decided to at least look after her, apologize again, and went down to the captain’s room. When I silently sneaked through the door, I found her lying in her bed, staring at the ceiling and trailing the wooden beams with a finger. She stopped upon my presence, but didn’t look at me.

I stood in the room and didn’t know what to make out of this.
“Hey Adora,” she said, but this time it sounded neither playful nor teasing, but rather… tired.
“Hey Catra,” I replied with a shaky voice, fumbling with my dress.
After an awkward silence, we spoke up concurrently “Why—" and fell dry alike.
“You first,” Catra said, reacting quicker than me upon our mutual surprise. I heaved a deep breath.
“You've been hiding here the whole day?” I asked warily.
She turned her gaze back to the ceiling. “I’m not hiding, I’m just tired.”
It irked me the wrong way. “Pfff. Doesn’t look like you’re tired, but all like hiding.”
“You mean, like you in the caboose or what? Where you peeled potatoes for the first time in your life the whole afternoon?”
“What? No! I just… got stuck there. The cook was funny!” The

explanation was really lame, even for me.
She snorted. “Of course. Here, see, the noble Adora of the Julii, doing the cabin boy’s work, just for the jokes of the cook.”
Arrrrg! This woman! “And here, see noble Catra Meritamun, pouting in her bed upon not being the center of attention.”
“I’m not pout—"
It got out of control. I cut her short. “Of course you are! When was the last time you laid in a bed, voluntarily, staring at the ceiling? What’s wrong with you?”
She called, angry: “What’s wrong with yourself? First all this touching, and then pulling back? Why do you even care about what I’m thinking? I’m sure your honorable family doesn’t want you to be seen touch some ran along, stray cat of a barbaric nation at the edge of the world, right?”
I fell silent and didn’t know how to fire back. That wasn't what I was thinking about. Not at all! Did she...
I grunted, loudly, stomped over the chair of the captain’s desk and stormed out of the room. Was she baffled upon my sudden retreat? Happy? Ashamed, maybe? Slamming the door shut deprived me of any possibility to find out, but I knew for myself that I wasn’t clever. I was just angry.

Ugh! How could one person be so annoying? Disgusting! Again, I leaned over the railing at the rear of the ship, one of the quieter places on board and besides the helmsman, no one else was up here.
Catra drove me crazy. In many ways. Every time I touched her or was being touched by her, I felt an ingrained pull to drag her as close as possible and to nourish my nose into her collarbone and to inhale her beguiling scent. Never in my whole life I’d felt such an urgent need to be so close to someone, while also being so easily upset and flustered by the same person. And that just couldn’t be. It had nothing to do with her being an Egyptian woman or her multiracial heritage. Such considerations were for idiots only. I was to be bestowed upon an Egyptian governor, and I wasn’t into women. It should be as simple as that.

I jumped out of my train of thoughts when a hand came to rest on my shoulder.

“Is everything alright with you, my dearest?”, the captain asked. Leaning back on the railing, I mustered the middle-aged man. We had barely spoken during the trip, but he’d seemed to be familiar with Catra and beside some weird antics, he’d behaved capable and did a good job so far. I shrugged my shoulders. “I don’t know. This whole trip is pretty exhausting.”
“Is there anything wrong with the quarters? I assure you—"
“No! No, it’s not that. Your cabin is fine, and I thank you very much for leaving it to us.”
He leaned beside me and watched the ocean too. “Then what else?”
“It’s rather the company,” I mumbled, clearly not thinking what I was saying. Immediately, I clapped my hands before my mouth. “No! I didn’t mean that.”
The captain looked amused. “Hmm, I'm feeling some tensions here, and I'm nearly sure you meant it exactly like you said. But I'm not wondering, just sayin' my dear.”
"What?" I pressed the words out between my fingers.

He snickered and twirled his mustache. "The both of you are not the subtlest types, and anyone with eyes in the head can clearly see what it is. I for myself hardly ever saw two fellows in a similar longing. My dearest wife and I had a journey alike, until she was finally able to confess her undying love to me. Honestly, it is an adventurous journey until today."
I shook my head in denial. "I don't even understand what you mean with that. It's not like that between Catra and me."
He didn’t buy any of my words. "Hahaha. Of course, it's like that. She hardly ever speaks of someone else. And your eyes never leave her when she's around. Like hers. I am deeply sorry to be the one to have to break the truth to you, but to me, it seems that you have quite an adventure waiting for both of you."

Wha— What did she say about me?" I was just curious. Deeply.
"Oh, nothing embarrassing, if it's that what you think. She admires your stubbornness. To sneak on board and so. I think in secret she’s glad you're here.” He suspiciously looked around and put a finger on his lips, whispering: “But don't tell her that I said anything. She would outright deny it and maybe challenge me. I

can armwrestle her in a fair game anytime, but she's hideous." He winked. "Let me finally assure you, that you won't find another soul who knows the treacherous route to your heart as well as she does. And that's all I have to say." He turned back to watch the sea, obviously thinking that he'd already said too much. And when I continued asking him questions, he excused himself with his duties.

But he left me with enough material to ponder about. Catra admired my stubbornness? Well, I'd helped her, and we also had been a good team. Now, back on our way to Cleopatra, maybe was she regretting to let me come with her into the city, and fearing consequences. Maybe that was partly the reason for her mood, too? But no, that wasn't all the captain'd said. He also mentioned something about us not being subtle. Subtle upon what? We hadn't done anything inappropriate, at least not in public. And it was just clear that she eyed me warily, after I'd overstepped.
All my pondering led to nothing. When evening came, and I was back in our mutual cabin, she was or pretended to be asleep, and I couldn't bring myself to wake her up… for what? Talking? That hadn't gone very well the last time, and it wouldn't be much better the next one, I assumed. After watching her for minutes to no avail, I finally went to bed as well, and exhaustion from the events of the last days quickly took me away. Only one time, in the middle of the night, I woke up from my sleep and had imagined that I had been touched. But nothing was to be seen, and I soon turned around and fell asleep again.

The next morning, Catra was already up and away and quickly after I'd readied myself, the captain came and told me that we would reach the harbor soon. I packed the little stuff I'd brought with me into my bag again, and went on deck. The crew was already in the final stage of mooring the ship at that time, and Catra came over from wherever she'd hidden and shortly asked: "Are you ready? I want to hand over the seal to Cleo as quick as possible."
I nodded, a bit unsure how to take her now, but then I decided to

leave yesterday behind. If she was willing to ignore it, I was also willing to comply.

After we said our goodbyes to the crew, we got horses from the garrison and rode off for the city. What a difference compared to my first arrival. Catra dashed ahead, and I had difficulties to follow her. Luckily, it was just a few minutes ride, and we quickly reached the temple. The guards informed us that Cleopatra was visiting the villa, and so we rode the few meters over to it. We charged a guard to take care of the horses, and went to look for Catra's sister. When we entered the atrium, a housemaid told us to go to Bow's room, and so we walked upstairs.
When approaching it, we heard laughter coming out of the room. Female laughter. Then, someone talked and, again, laughter. We trudged over, and I quietly peeked through the half-opened door. The view was… surprising.

Cleopatra sat beside Bow and was giggling, while he beamed at her upon her reaction. They seemed to have a good time and hadn't noticed us until Catra asked demandingly: "What's going on with you two?"
Cleopatra immediately composed herself, straightened her gown and turned to us. "That's nothing of your concern."
"Ah, really, Cleo? As your trusted sister, every state *affair* is of my concern." Her emphasizing of the word 'affair' did little to silence Cleopatra's irritation. And when her gaze fell on me, she narrowed her eyes, and suddenly I felt like back home and being ogled by my stepmother immediately before a scolding.

But then, Catra just held out the seal. Immediately, the raven-haired Pharaoh lightened up, rushed over to her sister and hugged her vigorously. Catra gasped and yelped: "Air! I need air!" Her eyes had gone wide upon the sudden attack. Cleopatra finally let her go. At least, her mood had lightened up visibly and it loosened the clamp around my chest a little.
Bow giggled lowly, but then I trudged over to him and took his hand in mine. "How are you?" I asked. I felt a bit sorry for leaving him behind for so many days. But his face looked much better, not so pale and lifeless as before. "Good, actually. I would've gotten

up today, but she forbade it," he said, pointing to Cleopatra, winking.
"You found a new nurse?" I snickered, whereupon Bow shook his head. "No, it isn't like that. She's here just the… third time, I think. When I called her about your message, she came over immediately." He wave me closer. "Honestly, Adora, she was pretty pissed off in the first place. But in the meantime, she got mostly over it, and we just did some talking. She's really interested, and she can talk a lot." He pulled a corner of his mouth in a little smirk.
"Huh? What's that supposed to mean?"
"Eh, nothing special," and he winked *again*. What was going on here? But before I came to press further, Cleopatra laid a hand on my shoulder from behind and asked: "May I have a word with you, Adora?"
I gulped, then nodded after turning around. "Of course, your highness." Bow gave me a thumb up, and Cleopatra pointed at the door. "In your room, maybe?"

Instinctively, I looked at Catra, who threw me an appreciative look - the first one since yesterday's disaster - then I followed the young Pharaoh over into my chamber, and closed the door behind me, feeling very insecure.
Cleopatra stood in the middle of the room - my room, that I'd just used once - and when she turn to me, she crossed her arms and had a concerned expression on her face.

"Adora, the following shall not sound like scolding, except that it obviously is. I apologize, but your father entrusted me with your health and even with your life, and I had to vow that I would take care of you. Running away in the middle of a war doesn't make it easier. I'm sure you understand that I'm not delighted with it."
She sounded composed, and a little scolding, but not without reason.
"Of course," I just replied.
"Then, why did you do it?" she insisted, and her whole pose was all pharaonic, imposing.
I thought about my answer, not really sure which part of my reasons to tell. I couldn't reveal that I mostly just wanted to live a

little. Maybe she would understand, but it was too risky, and it would be dumb to talk about.
“I had the strong feeling that I’d be safer around your sister than anywhere else. She'd done a good job during the attack and I trust her. You're too occupied to spend me constant attention anyway.”
Cleopatra looked a little puzzled. “Is that so?”
“Yes, your highness.” I looked down at the floor, with folded hands.
She rolled her eyes. “Ah, skip the highnesses, Adora. It’s not like that you don’t belong to the most powerful Roman gens and your uncle being the most important Roman as of today.” I tilted my head and expectantly looked at her. “I share a secret with you. It's not like you can't think of it yourself. I need you and this alliance as well. It's important for both our realms, but for me more than for your family. Therefore, I can’t have you harmed. Or worse.”
I thought about her words for a second before coming back. “It was careless of me, I admit.” And that was as far as I wanted to do something like an apology to her. I was still a person of my own.

Despite her calm tonality, Cleopatra’s hands were balled, and she tried to let them lose. I had to remind myself that she was younger than me, and despite all her experience, education and unquestionable skills of leadership, we were just young women. With all the perks.
“My uncle wouldn’t blame you for my mistakes. He’s not like that," I added as a peace offer.
Cleopatra scoffed and waved it off. “Your naivety won’t help me if he comes after us because I lost you.”
“Eh, nobody would fight a war because of me, because of one woman. That would be ridiculous. The Republic doesn’t work that way.”
Her voice was nearly pleading now, beguiling in a frightening sort of way, and her eyes war large and dark. “Adora, your uncle will rule your pretty empire all alone soon. And he will happily use every fitting reason to conquer Egypt next. My Egypt.”
“He couldn’t do that. Egypt is an ally and the Senate would never

allow anyone to conquer it. Your nation is just too rich and important. And he wouldn't crown himself a king. The Senate—"
"Inter arma enim silent leges," Cleopatra cut me short, catching me off guard with Cicero's phrase that I just repeated: "The laws are silent under arms."
I looked her deep in the eyes. "Do you really think like that?"
She threw her arms in the air. "Have I any reason not to? Julius Caesar, your uncle, has been fighting wars for 15 years now. 15 years! Warfare is what he knows. He's a master of war, of persuasion, and strategy.The Lusitanians, the Germani, the Celts. He conquered Gaul, and don't you dare to reason with me about that being just a war of conquest. It was a fucking conquest and nothing else. They didn't threaten you in any way. And now, that he'd won against the Senate, what's going to stop him from conquering Egypt next?" She walked forth and back, gesturing with her hands and raised voice. "We are your main supplier for grain and gold, Adora, and our own struggles only have weakened us. He has slaughtered a million Gauls, crossed the Rubicon, battled your own Senate and fought against his own son-in-law. What should stop him from just picking up Egypt like a ripe grape? And if he has a reason because of you, he would be happy to pick it up. And maybe that's even his plan."

What? What did she say? Uncle Julius had won? The implications of this only started to pelt down on me, and I was stuttering. "I… I didn't know that. He won… against Pompeius? When? How?"
Cleopatra stopped fiddling and looked at me. "You don't know? It's been two weeks ago, at a Greek city called Pharsae… Pharsa… "
"Pharsalos?" I threw in. "It's in Thessalía. Oh, that would make sense."
"That's it, Pharsalos. The message came the day before yesterday, and it looks like that your uncle made an overwhelming victory against a superior opponent. Again! It's incredible, how lucky the man is." [40]

It was the first time I saw her nearly panting, and now she scurried around the room, radiating restless energy. "Don't make

a fool out of yourself, Adora. In your family's eyes, everything is a good reason to declare the next war of conquest. And if I don't want to be the next prey, I need an alliance with him. Caesar must be my friend, at all cost. That's a no-brainer, not some kind of elaborate conspiracy to get you married. You're just-"
She fell silent, but her outbreak depraved me of any clever responses too, and thus, I stayed silent, while Cleopatra calmed herself by straigthening her gown.
Maybe I understood her a bit better now. The always composed and fierce-looking woman was also scared by the possibility of a Roman invasion. And rightly so, I had to admit. Egypt was the last large and mostly independent nation at the Mediterranean Sea. It just looked ripe for the taking.

"I understand. Explaining it like this, things look a bit different, yes. Coming back to the beginning of our conversation, I just want to add, that Catra kept me perfectly safe, and we achieved her mission. Given all the events since my arrival, I've only felt secure in her presence. And I would choose that again, if needed. "
Her look pierced me. "I hope that won't be necessary. Actually, I will send you with her directly to Thēbais, for you to meet Hor—Psamtik. Catra will overlook your developments there and if everything works out well, you'll be betrothed to him within a month and married within a half a year at most.

Ooof. So much for my plan to undermine *this* development. The trap closed slowly, but it *fucking* closed.
"What about my father's decision? Or uncle Julius? Wasn't it their plan to get to know each other first?"
She shook her head. "I fear, your father handed over some very explicit orders on how to proceed, Adora. And with your uncle victorious, everything has sped up, obviously. He will come to Egypt, Adora, I sense that coming. It's the logical next step for him, given our situation and yours alike. Then everything will develop quick. So, sending you to Thēbais now makes absolutely sense."
I felt the walls get closer, and my composed demeanor started to crackle down. This was happening too soon.

“But this is… this is—"
“See it that way, Adora: at least, you can have another nice road trip - or rather river trip.” She actually smirked. “Catra will accompany you again, and so, it could be some fun along the way.”
A shiver ran down my spine. What? Another journey with Catra? Fun? She’d evaded me since yesterday, obviously pushed back by my unneeded overstepping, she hated my family, and now, with uncle Julius victorious and presumably on his way to Egypt, where I was nothing less than a visible beacon of an alliance between her family and mine *and* of the Roman presence in her country at all, this was NOT going to be some funny road trip. It would be a nothing else than a huge mess.

That whole idea had one word carved in stone over it: Catrastrophe.

Catra

When the Julian woman walked out behind Cleopatra, she left me in nothing less than a growing confusion. My desperate attempt to fight it down was like scooping up water with a sieve. Every time I tried to push the thoughts… pah! *thoughts, how ridiculous* ... the longing for Adora back into the deepest pit of mind, she quickly crept back and occupied my every thinking again. What was about this dorky goof that had sunk its hooks into my heart so deeply? When we touched each other yesterday, it was like Hathor herself had touched my heart and laid her hand around it. Her fingertips made my skin heat up in fire and when I started to trail her cheek, it was all the same. Actually, the tiny little part of my brain that screamed ‘STOOOP’ had been grateful that she was the one to broke contact. Because I didn’t know if I would’ve been able to. Luckily, she withdrew, but it made me feel like a lusting idiot.

Despite her look had signaled something - and that *something* never left my mind at all - I was unsure. The glance from her

intriguing, candid eyes made my heart melt and let my defenses crumble. I felt besieged, in a certain way. But nonetheless, after that *incident* I just tried to avoid her, for sure, and she did all the same.
Maybe she was embarrassed about touching someone like me, a non-Roman, below her status and without all the gravitas patricians were so fond of. Or maybe she wasn't into women at all and that little clanger was just some weird attraction, created from her loneliness and all the bewildering events of the past few days. She was just confused, probably.

I realized that I was still standing in Bow's room, saying nothing, obviously lost in thoughts, and her fellow looked at me. "Is something with you?" he asked in his kind manner. Of course, I couldn't talk with him about my specific problems, regarding his domina. But maybe… "What was that with you and Cleo? Where you two… flirting?"
He laughed a bit nervously and coughed into his fist. "No? That would be ridiculous. We just had a good talk because it's boooring here. She won't even let me get up," he complained, lightly.
"Yeah, listen to her. I mean, you got stabbed and need to heal, but that's the easy part. Ignoring Cleo's order could be much worse. She always gets what she wants. Or mostly always," I winked.
He snickered. "I figured that out. So, what's happening now?"
I tilted my head and twisted the corners of my mouth. "I don't know, but I'm sure Cleopatra has a plan, as always. Just wait and enjoy the time."
I couldn't have been more right, because after half an hour or so, Cleopatra and Adora returned. Adora's sight made me shudder, because she looked like being guided to the slaughterhouse.

Cleo turned to me: "I decided, that Adora shall meet with Psamtik as soon as possible. You will accompany her on her way to Thēbais and guarantee her safety. Stay with her there and I will send for you when the situation requires it."
"What?" I was not so much surprised as rather completely lost. Another trip with Adora? Not that my heart ached exactly for that, but I couldn't give in to that idiotic feeling. I'd used the whole

fucking last day to try to draw myself out of exactly this growing attraction. To no avail, but still. And now, even more of her close company? "Another time of babysitting? Really? Don't you have something more meaningful to do for me? Maybe, beleaguering Alexandria? Conquering Memphis? I could do that. Give me a few ships, and we could even invade the Cyrenaica or Cyene." Adora's eyes flickered, and I asked myself what that should mean.
Cleopatra waved with her left hand in a low move, a clear sign of silencing everyone. "I don't have time for your antics, sister. The alliance with the Julii is of the utmost importance to the Egyptian realm, and I won't trust anyone else with this delicate task. Will you comply, Catra?"

Ugh! She knew that I would always comply with her if she really wanted it. Would always want to prove myself worthy of her trust and tasks. Cleopatra had always treated me as a special, most reliable person in her life and given her family and all their quarrels, that was a wonder. And with me having no greater aims, it was a perfect match in terms of our relationship. I'd always been her first choice for special missions and problematic assignments, and I'd always carried them out perfectly, because I wanted to.
Only that this mission was very problematic in a very certain way. Said problem was standing right before me, peeking with her beautiful gray-blue eyes and compressed lips. Adora looked like she was about to cry, and I just wanted to take her in my arms and hold her tight, pet her hair and mumble assuring words into her ear. It was such a ridiculous sweet feeling to want to care for her, it was outright mad.

I heaved a sigh. "Of course, beloved Messenger of on High, of course. When shall we leave?"
Now that she had her way, Cleo beamed again, completely the grateful and ever-friendly queen. "Rest for the day and collect yourself. I'll have a bark ready as of tomorrow morning, so you can travel by the river. It won't be demanding," laying a hand on Adora's shoulder, who winced shortly and barely noticeable at the touch, but said nothing.
She hadn't winced when I'd embraced her, some part of my

troubled brain noticed.
I spent the rest of the day working through messages from my subordinates from Buhen and wrote them back curt notes. Until now, everything seemed to work well, there'd been no further attack from bandits - or the Kushites - and so, I was content with the matter from there.
Later in the evening, Cleopatra, Adora, Bow and I dined together at the villa, being it the first time for Bow to be let out of his bed. Since Cleo and Bow had an amicable conversation, where stupid sayings flew back and forth and both giggled like teenagers, there was much time for Adora and me to spend the larger part of dinner with awkwardly peeking over the table at each other, mostly when we thought that the other one wouldn't notice it. It was embarrassing for both of us, but we also had no idea what else to do.

After this one-hour-long torture, Adora excused herself to accompany Bow back to his room, while Cleo held me back to follow them with a small shaking of her head. She sounded dead serious when speaking up. "Listen, Catra, guiding and protecting Adora isn't the only reason I'm sending you to Hordak. He's my most important ally in Upper Egypt. He controls the Thebaid now. Given the reports a got, he's striving to surpass the regional capital Ptolemais Hermiou. I also heard some disturbing news about his rallying of troops, and I want you to investigate that." She shot me a fierce look. "Catra, do you hear me?"

I snapped back to Cleo, because I'd been looking beside her and had listened only half-heartedly. I'd been still pondering about Adora, and the prospect of being out with her for more days was exciting and terrifying at the same time. Should I tell Cleopatra about my emotional confusion?
Probably not.
Despite our relationship being open and honest the most time, we didn't talk much about feelings and personal needs. Cleopatra hadn't even ever mentioned such a thing as having a crush on someone. But on the other hand, how should she? She'd been formally married to her own brother - the Ptolemaic way to *keep it in the family* and with "it" meaning the reign of Egypt - and with

whom she was in a fucking war *right now* . Bloody idiots, all of them.
So I just stayed silent about the very rare, very covered, very short-lived affairs that I've had in the recent years. This just wasn't common ground for us, and I was well advised to stay silent about that special topic, presumably.

"I hear you, sister. As always, I hear you," I sighed.
"What's with you?" she asked, obviously puzzled about my lack of snarkiness or clever comebacks.
"It's nothing, morning and evening of Egypt. I will do as you say. I'm just tired, it's been a long day and I want to sleep. You're not making it easy for me right now, are you?"
Cleopatra hesitated shortly, before replying: "You're right. I won't apologize, because all of this not for my own, but in the interest of the realm. We need that intel and we need that alliance. But I understand your discontent and promise, I'll make it up to you another time. Is this good enough for you?"
I understood her, but I also found it remarkable that the interest of the realm was - what a coincidence - the interest of Cleopatra, too. Maybe I was hypocritical, because I wasn't the responsible Pharaoh here. Because a ruler was clearly hard, and I always tended to overlook how young she still was and under which pressure she always had been.

I nodded and after our conversation ended as she left to hold another meeting and I decided to go to sleep and headed for my room upstairs. When I passed Bow's room, I heard them talking and wondered what their topic could be.
After a quick wash I was lying in my bed and expected sleep to come quickly because of the exhausting day. Instead, I stared at the ceiling, and my mind wandered to the person in the next room, the one I couldn't seem to get out of my head. Adora was admirable, sweet even, sure, but were my feelings for her perhaps just a fleeting crush, that will eventually pass? I hoped so, because she wasn't for me.
But, every time I was around her, every time I heared their laughter or saw her smile, I felt it tugging at my heart. I closed

my eyes, took a deep breath and tried to quiet my mind. All of that had only one headline: catastrophe.

The next morning was filled with preparations for our departure. Adora suited herself in a similar outfit to the night when she sneaked after me. This time, she wore a loosely hanging tunic over a tight pair of trousers. How unusual for a woman of her class and origin, I thought, but she seemed to like that kind of outfit when traveling. But instead of a dark green, this time she had chosen a set of bright and shining red, and it suited her just perfect. Now she'd only need bow and arrow and could totally live up to her second forename. The half-high laced sandals completed the impression of the goddess of the hunt. She was damn pretty, and it was clear that she herself did not know how much.

We left the Villa before noon and headed for a port at the river, a few kilometers upwards of the Pelousian branch of the Nile. We rode on horseback, and were accompanied by a 20-man squad. It should be enough since this side of the Nile was controlled by Cleopatra's troops. We passed the city walls to the south, and left the sparse settlements around them behind us, traveling on the same road I'd used when I came down from Buhen. It seemed to be months away, despite it being only a bit more than a few weeks. East of the road, the desert of the Sinai began, west of it lay the river with some rare, green acres on our side. The green and irrigated fields of the Nile delta only began on the western side of the river shore, and they stretched as far as the eye could see, til Alexandria in the far west.

Not even half an hour later, we approached a little port jetty that was a few hundred meters away from the main road and obviously seldom used. Only half a dozen warehouses made up this trade outpost in the desert, serving the caravans towards the

east. They stood beside the river and around the pier, with just a few people scurrying around. Here, the bark should be awaiting us there. This time, it was just one of the normal river ships that were regularly used for moving people and goods up and down the one lifeline of our nation. I deemed it a better idea to go rather unnoticed, than in one of Cleopatra’s giant and overly emblazoned river barks. That would’ve drawn the attention of too many eyes in no time, and a normal ship should be doing the job just as good. The bark was already lying beside and ready to be boarded, and we rode down the last hundred meters rather carelessly.

The scenery before us became quiet. It made me feel warily in an instant, and I fell into a slow rot. We’d reached the first warehouse, and the dockworkers we’d seen a minute ago suddenly vanished behind and inside the warehouses. and I immediately screamed “A trap! RETREAT!”
I leaned over, grabbed Adora’s reins, drew them back, and turned both our horses on the spot. Our guards surrounded us in a circle, spending us protection. Everyone had drawn his scimitar, and some put out shields and knives.
But the attack was well-planned. Two dozens soldiers emerged from the next warehouse and the same amount started to flood down from the bark, too. Quickly, we were surrounded from three sides and only the way back was still open. I whipped Adora’s horse with the reins and yelled “Go!”, whereupon it sprung and sped forward. Having a free hand again, I also drew my scimitar and rode down one of the attackers who had been too eager in his approach, while drawing the blade over his face. That was the signal for my men to charge.
We fought on our horses, trying to ride down our attackers. But as surrounded as we were, without a possibility to speed up, it was mostly useless. Four of our guards were already down on the ground and the others were in distress. Meanwhile, Adora's horse had gotten to the edge of the small cluster of the settlement, all alone now, and it was clear that she was hesitant to ride away. It was clear that she wasn't up to do what was necessary.

A quick glance around told me that no one had taken up her pursuit yet, but that was about to change now. Half a dozen soldiers started to move into her direction.
I screamed "Run! Get help!" She was obviously torn between following my order - which would've made absolute sense - and not leaving us behind - which made absolutely no sense. The damn idiot.
Adora wouldn't have been Adora if she was up for the easy and totally safe-for-her solution if she had a chance to be useful, I assumed. And so I watched her in awe, as she reached for her leg, took out her dagger and threw it into the throat of the nearest pursuer in a fluent movement. The knife perfectly met its aim and threw the spluttering man to the ground. It made the others stop shortly, while Adora spurred her horse and vanished behind the warehouse, with at least four a little more hesitant enemies in tow. They clearly didn't expect her to be armed and able to defend herself.

Meanwhile, my own situation became dire. Nine men of our escort were down and the rest was being charged by at least twenty attackers. The bodies on the ground began to stockpile, hindering the movements of our horses even more. And the second I counted, another of my men to my right side was being hit by a spear in the shoulder and pushed off his horse. We had to retreat. "Form and fall back!" I yelled, and the remaining men quickly drew our circle closer, then we pushed against the side of the enemies' formation where the fewest attackers stood. We rode down two of them, but the reactions of the others were swift. Immediately, they followed us, and we were not fast enough to escape them, now being trapped between the three-quarter circle of the soldiers and a depot in our back.

I wanted to give the order to dismount and fight them on the ground, when an arrow shot down at one of the pursuers in front of me, hitting him in the throat. While his mates were still looking at him, another arrow hit the man beside the first victim with force in the chest, taking him out also. For a short time, the entire attack came to a hold while the soldiers searched for the shooter. I used the possibility to draw my blade over the thigh of one of

my own distressers and then to look up at the roof of the warehouse behind us.
There, Adora stood, with bow and arrows - from where did she get a bow, I asked myself - while already shooting her third one. She was a blonde messenger of wrath, concentrated anger marking her face and she was clearly up for more blood.

Now, she looked like Artemis, and not Diana. [41]

Shaking myself out of the stupor Adora put me in, I reminded myself that we had to use this element of surprise! Quickly I yelled "Charge!", mounted and spurred my horse and moved forward to trample down the next ones. Out of the corner of my eye, I saw how Adora notched another arrow from her quiver and aimed at a nearby enemy. But behind her, a soldier had entered the roof also and sneaked up on her, just meters away. "Adora, beware! Behind you!" I yelled. She started a little, but then she spun around, stepped back a pace with the applied and drawn arrow and shot the attacker directly in his chest in a fluent movement. He stumbled back and fell down where I didn't see him anymore, but I saw how relieved - and smugly - Adora grinned at me, waving a grateful hand.

What an awesome bitch. She was acting so different now, so absolutely determined and confident. Strength radiated from her, and if she'd just taken over command, I wasn't sure if I just would've submitted to her.
I shook off these thoughts, jumped off my horse and pushed my scimitar through an unlucky guy from behind, then stomping him in the back, so he tumbled to the ground where he lay still. The tides had turned, thanks to Adora's attack from above. Despite I had only seven guards left, Adora's shooting took out another two enemies and now, there were only around a dozen left of them. We were still outnumbered, but we had support from above, and the attackers were on hold now, reassessing their chances.

I eyed their formation and tried to identify the commanding officer. It seemed to be a middle-sized man to the left of me, who fiercely looked at Adora and shouted short orders at the others. I

shot a look at her too, and luckily she captured it. Barely recognizable, I tilted my head and eyed in his direction. She needed a second or two, but then she understood what I was trying to say. She notched another arrow, drew and aimed in one single move. It pierced the air at his head, actually touched his hair, but passed without damage. Adora *cursed*, loud and clear. Hearing that for the first time nearly made me chuckle. It was so unwomanly, so unpatrician, so not Adora.
The officer barked out another order, whereupon the soldiers charged again. I held them away with my blade, but the numbers still weren't in our favor. On the roof, Adora put on the last arrow, obviously, because the quiver was now empty. She aimed for seconds before letting it fly.
The sound the arrow made through the officer's skull was surprisingly quiet. His facial expression was a bit surprised, before he got limb and crumbled to the ground. The remaining soldiers hesitated upon the loss of their leader, and I used the opportunity. I ordered all my men to charge upon one side of the encirclement, taking out as many enemies as possible there in one swift attack. And after we overwhelmed another two of them, the others decided to call it a day and started to flee towards the river shore.

I held back my five remaining guards, and ordered them to catch our horses. We would ride back to the city to gather reinforcements - and a quick searcho of the bark told me that we would need another crew for it.
Looking up at Adora, she'd now sat down at the edge of the roof, still a little panting from the struggle, but she had her feet hanging off, and after she caught my gaze, she looked very content with herself. I put my hands on my hips before calling loudly, "You don't take advice, do you? And no orders either?"
The blonde above me only grinned. "Looked like you could need some help from my perspective." The content tonality of her reply really made me angry. She didn't take this serious enough. "From your perspective? You should've run away and gathered help. We were here to protect you, not the other way around!"
Her face turned a little redder when she yelled back: "A simple

‘Thank you’ would’ve been sufficient, you know? Because to me, it lookes like that I literally saved your ass right now, Catra!”
“We were doing fine, thank you very much,” I retorted to not have her let the last word.
“Fine? Fine?” She drew it out and pitched it higher. “Tell that to the… what… fourteen, fifteen men you lost! You weren’t doing fine, you were about to lose! So yeah, I thought you could use some help. Be welcome!” she etched, furious.
“That’s NOT THE POINT!” I yelled back, “The point is that I ordered you to retreat, and you didn’t follow—"
Adora had stood up - in all her glory, a feral part of my mind supplied - straightened herself with running down her hands over her dress, glared down at me like an actual goddess that had just emanated of on high, and she looked absolutely gorgeous when she cut me short with a simple move of her hand and a raised voice: “I’m none of your subordinates, Catra. I am Adora Diana Minor of the Julii and I—"

“I CAN’T HAVE YOU KILLED, YOU IDIOT!”

When I frantically yelled at her, the otherworldly beautiful woman took a step back, looking thrown off her game. She opened her mouth, but closed it again, then her hands fisted into her weapon. After staring at each other for too long, I managed to compose myself, and I finally pressed out in an overly friendly tone: “Please come down, we have to ride back and regroup.”
After a few breaths, Adora hesitantly nodded and turned, vanishing to the other side of the roof. Meanwhile, my men had fetched the horses, so I mounted and rode around the building. There, the blonde jumped down to a canopy and from there to the ground. Where two other, dead soldiers laid. I frowned, she saw it and immediately snapped at me. “What?” Again, she flared at me like a bonfire.
“Oh. Eh, I didn’t say anything,” I innocently replied while glancing at her. But I made a mental note to reconsider her dangerousness, while she smugly smirked upon my sudden retreat. I stayed silent, while Adora got on her horse, and we quickly were on our way back to Pelousion.

This was getting out of hand, I thought, and wasn't sure what exactly I meant with that.

Chapter End Notes

[38] The strophium is just the forerunner of the brassiere, consisting of a band of soft cloth that was slung around the chest. It was in no way meant to look alluring or even pretty. It was practical, and nothing more. ↑

[39] This is a rewrite of a similar, hilarious scene from "Last Night Drinks". ↑

[40] The Battle of Pharsalos was the decisive fight of Caesar's civil war, where his 23,000 men beat Pompeius' of around twice as much. Caesar had luck, of course, but he also made use of it. Pharsalos is a masterpiece of strategic wit and courage to take little chances and make an overwhelming victory out of them. It is also a strong reminder, that you can gamble away any advantage, if you listen to bad advice, like Pompeius did. ↑

[41] 'Artemis' is the Greek version and origin of the Romanized 'Diana'. In both mythologies, she is the goddess of the hunt, the wilderness, wild animals, but also of chastity. She is one of the twelve Olympians and therefore a major deity in the Greek mythology. She was said to be a wild, cruel goddess without any chill, remain to be a maiden and sworn never to marry. Artemis was clearly a killer. Artemis' temple at Ephesus was one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World, her symbols including, bow and arrow, a quiver, and hunting knives. However, her Roman version Diana was displayed to be a lot softer. You may remember Adora's second forename. ↑

One night in heaven

Chapter Summary

The best tavern along the Nile!
Adora is not a lightweight. Not at all!
And then you fell into my purrrfect trap.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pelousion, Egypt & along the Nile to Thēbais - September, 48 BCE

Catra

Surprised faces from the city guards searching for answers upon our unexpected arrival greeted us at the gate of Pelousion, but they got none. Adora and I rode straight to the garrison, where I ordered the commander to reinforce us with a contingent of at least half a century of cavalry - and a new crew for the bark - and not to tell anything to Cleopatra. I didn't want her to intercept or notice that I'd been not vigilant enough to notice the trap early enough.

Adora had been quiet during the ride, but the blonde menace to womanhood threw me a quizzical look now. After making some fuss and acting childish for just a bit too long, I finally got over myself and decided to explain the tactical situation to her. "If Cleo gets to know, she will just be concerned and ready a cohort so that we have to move by horse. That will slow us down to an unbearable amount.[42] We just need to leave the delta as soon as possible. There won't be another attack like this in the middle lands behind Memphis. Ptolemy got nearly all of his troops out from there, and Upper Egypt still mostly stands behind Cleopatra. She's well settled there, loved even."

Adora seemed to consider what she'd heard. While I talked with the commander, she scurried around, listening in the background, until she approached us again. Her voice was calm and serious. "It's jJust a thought, but: wouldn't it be a good idea if we went just with the smallest troop possible. A few riders only? Maybe, even just the two of us, on fast horses? Can we change horses on the route to be even faster? In the Republic, there are mansiones[43] along our roads everywhere, where messengers can change them. We could be very fast by horse."
I stood dumbstruck. What? That was just… "Are you- are you brain-damaged?"
"What? Why do you say that?" Her face was an expression of genuine surprise, and I scolded myself - lightly - for my harsh words. Nonetheless, the idea was ridiculous.
"Because traveling without protection would be a bad idea, maybe? As evidenced right now? I mean, don't you remember what just happened?"
She scoffed, and looked down on me. "You didn't think this through. If we are going with a century of your men, it's like a beacon. You can also shout out my name loud and clear or send a messenger to this guy Achillas and tell him," Adora retorted lofty. The commander as well as I stared at her. Then she just shrugged her shoulders and added innocently: "Just saying. I only hope you have more men free to escort me for a month of whatever then. Their next ambush won't be so light-weight. Might be fun even." And with that being said, she backed up and started to scurry around the courtyard of the garrison again, pretending not to be there.

I looked at the commander, who first shot her and then me a thoughtful look and shrugged his shoulders. "You don't consider this, or do you?" I asked warily. The scarred man snorted, scratching his head: "She isn't so wrong, you know, my lady? Two riders can be swift. Half a century or even a troop is slow by definition." He twisted a corner of his mouth.
"But just the two of us, without backup, in the delta? I mean, I am always up for a risky mission, but this sounds downright crazy."

“Well, nobody would expect that. And you shouldn’t travel along the delta. We could do some camouflage, by sending a large troop up the river branch while you ride south through the desert to the Crocodile Lake and the Bitter Lakes, and from there back to the Nile upwards of Memphis, I think. From there on, you should be safe. There is a garrison in Maidum that is fiercely loyal to our beloved sovereign.” He smirked just a little. “The commander there will surely help you. Or you can hire soldiers again. If they don't catch what you’re doing on the first day, you would just vanish in the vastness.”
I was still not convinced. Cleopatra would absolutley behead me, if I lost Adora. Perhaps rightfully so. “That just sounds horrible, you know?”
Again, he shrugged his shoulders with the experience of seasoned commander who'd seen bullshit and crazy stuff since long ago. “Maybe. But do you really want to command a whole cohort, while you march just 20 kilometers a day for three weeks? Just saying.”

I brutally stared at him at his repetition of Adora’s words, but said nothing. I left him where he was and went over to the canteen to fetch something to drink. Adora’s suggestion sounded like madness. Maybe it was just an attempt to avoid going to Thēbais at all? But no, she wasn’t like that. She always concentrated on the task at hand, and seemingly had accepted her general fate. Looking back, she could’ve easily used the ambush to flee. Instead, she had risked her life to help us. To help me, I silently admitted to myself and sighed, sipping at some water. Why couldn't all this fucking task turned out to be a lot simpler?

While I was sitting at one of the long benches outside the canteen, beside the courtyard, Adora finally strolled over. She’s like a loyal puppy, I thought, always confident and open. Not like me, I admitted inwardly, sighing another time. The tension of the last days had morphed into an unsure uneasiness. After we’d touched, nothing else had happened. But still, I hadn’t forgotten the heat of her fingertips on my skin.
Adora stood before me. “And now?” she asked, demanding, with her arms crossed.
“Now I’m drinking water, obviously,” I deadpanned.

“That wasn’t my question, and you know that.”
“Too bad for you that I’m not answering other ones.” She just drove me crazy. Why couldn’t she go away and pester other people?
“So, you wanna wait until your commander raises his cohort, then talk to your sister again, and then we’ll leave the day after tomorrow, travel 20 kilometers a day for the next four weeks or so? Alright, go for it. But may I go back to the villa then, until you finish your business? In some days, presumably. Because it’s boring here, and I’m tired waiting for you to do what’s needed.” She actually raised her voice in the end.
“What?” I croaked. Her sudden outburst caught me off guard. She drew out every word like speaking to a little child, and her face was… cutely annoyed. “I - am - bored. I - wanna - go - back - to - the - villa! Until - you - are - ready! Do - you - understand?”

Oh gods, this woman was surely going to be the death of me. I wet my head with water from the jug in front of me, then put my forehead between my hands I'd propped up on the table. She was right. I hated the conclusion, but she was right. If we didn’t go on our own, now, we would need at least a day to rally the troops, and talk to Cleo - which would be a horror - and it would be a fucking and ugly slow trip. With Adora always at my side. The one Adora I couldn’t have under any circumstances. Every day and night. For weeks then. Oh by Hathor… no! By Thoth, I had to avoid this.

Torn between my different desires, my mind snapped, and I decided in a split second. “Good, Roman. We’ll have it your way. But don’t come back to me and whine around when the trip isn’t going as easy as you think. The deserts of Egypt aren’t for everyone, and I don’t wanna babysit you. Understood?”
At first, Adora looked surprised, but then she folded her muscular arms before her chest again and glanced down at me like some glorious being. “Egypt has nothing in store that I can’t endure.”

Somehow, I believed her.

Adora

I didn't feel a bit as strong as I pretended to be when I boasted my clever words at Catra. All in all I was just more afraid by the prospect of hanging around, doing nothing than by riding through the desert, and desperately tried to cover it up by acting tough. It seemed to have worked, when Catra - to my surprise - agreed with my mad plan and ordered the garrison commander to ready a troop of around 50 men, that should move out for a maneuver in the evening for two days or so. At the same time, we would steal away southwards into the desert and see that we could get as far as possible in the night. Four different squads of two people each would do the same, in case of any traitors or spies, creating as much confusion and cover as possible.

Catra's behavior struck me as strange, though. Until we'd touched at the ship, she'd acted like a friend, like she cared about me. We had a constant communication and been teasing each other all the time. I felt… acknowledged and protected even.
Now, she was repellent and cold and had kept her distance as far as was just acceptable. The prospect of a week-long journey through Egypt with her was unsatisfactory, to say the least. And the prospect of a day-long ride with just Catra on my side was making me angry. Or giddy? No, angry. Angry it was. And anger was better than dissatisfaction, presumably. Was it?
Ugh! Why wasn't I able to figure out what bothered me? When we were ambushed at the port jetty, and she ordered me to run away, this hadn't even been an option in my mind. My only desire had been to help her and take care that she wasn't hurt - or worse. Everything I did then just worked on its own, like I'd been steered from outside.
Or from my heart?
Heart. This was ridiculous and pathetic. I knew exactly what my father would say. And why did the thought even jump to my mind in the first place. Catra was a woman. I was a woman, too. She wasn't for me, even if I wanted to. And I didn't want to want her that way. Obviously. Reality forbade that.

Again, we packed stuff, now more than before. We filled saddlebags with water hoses, a blanket, carefully packed food and clothes for changing, and a few tools, tool. I fetched a fitting bow and a quiver with arrows as my personal gear from the armory, but beside approving my request and shooting a quizzical look, Catra said nothing. She admonished me not to overdo it, though, because additional weight meant a slower ride and speed was of the essence. I didn't like her patronizing, but she was right anyway, so I tried to contain myself and ended up with two half-empty bags that held as few as possible. When she looked into them, she frowned on me, then put more water bottles in, until the bags were full. “Cleopatra will surely kill me, when she finds out what we are— what I’m doing here. But maybe I can avoid the torturing before my inevitable passing if you didn’t die of something mundane as thirst, princess.”
I rolled my eyes and retorted: “Then why are you doing this?”
Catra stared at me for too long, her beautiful two-colored eyes piercing me intensely. “I don’t even know. Maybe I’m brain-damaged, too," she retorted and scurried away only to stay silent again afterwards.

I stood on top of the wall of the garrison and watched while the sun had started to set over the Nile delta. As the flickering orange disc began to dip below the horizon and cast long shadows over the lush and fertile landscape, it painted the sky in shades of orange, pink and purple, creating a breathtakingly beautiful scene that was both peaceful and awe-inspiring. The Nile delta had been a thriving hub of human activity for ages, dotted with small villages, bustling markets, and sprawling temples dedicated to the gods of the old ancient Egypt kingdoms. But as the sun set, the human bustle subsided and the area would come to life in a different way, as nocturnal animals like crocodiles emerged from their hiding places to hunt and forage for food.
The lush vegetation of the delta provided a rich and varied habitat for all manner of flora and fauna. Tall reeds and papyrus plants lined the river's banks, providing shelter for a variety of waterfowl such as ducks, geese, and herons. The tall grasses and

undergrowth offered ideal hiding places for smaller mammals like jackals and hyenas, while the towering trees of the delta's forests provided perches for birds of prey like eagles and hawks.
As the light faded, the sounds of the delta changed, too. The calls of the birds grew softer, while the chirping of crickets and other insects became louder and more insistent. In the distance, I thought I heard growls, perhaps from predators like lynx or even panthers as they roamed the grasslands in search of their next meal. Despite the danger posed by them, the Nile delta was mostly a tamed place today, a place of natural beauty and human presence alike.

When all were ready to move out, I joined Catra in the courtyard again, who had a final talk with the commander. Afterwards, both of us mounted on our horses. We'd been provided with two light brown stallions that looked powerful and persistent. With their color, they would fit smoothly into the environment of the southern desert we were about to ride into. And Catra and I, as well as our impostors, had been given capes with only a bit lighter shade.
At first, the large troop marched off towards Sele, a town upwards the Nile, then every few minutes one more squad left the garrison also, all of them heading in different directions to the south and southwest. Catra and I'd been the third one, and we quickly left Pelousion southwards, on our way to the Crocodile Lake.

After a few minutes, we fell into a reasonable trot so as not to exhaust the horses too fast. And so we rode for around two hours until we made a short rest, watered them and ourselves and rode on. Sun had set a while long ago, and we rushed forward, the landscape always the same. A mostly flat and sandy, but sometimes rocky, hard surface that we tried to avoid for the sake of our horses. I panted from the effort, and was already sweaty, because it wasn't easy to stay in the saddle. I felt the muscles of the stallion working beneath me at a steady pace. And my butt hurt.
Night had fallen, it was still warm, and above was nothing but a clear sky full of glistening stars. Catra slowed her horse down and made a remark that we would rest for the night at a small oasis

that lay beside the sand track we'd ridden along for the last half hour.

The oasis in question was merely one. Like a cliché, in a depression in the surrounding landscape, a dozen palms and some bushes stood around a small water hole, the size of a normal villa, maybe. The small water body was bordered on three sides by man-sized rocks with the rocky plateau rising higher behind, while one shore was sand. Nobody was there except us.
We leashed the horses to a palm tree, looked after them for the night, then started to care for ourselves. When I spread the blanket to lie down, Catra nodded at me and spoke for the first time again: "This oasis is hard to find, if you don't know about it. Even then, it's easy to overlook. We should be safe here for a few hours. We rest, one of us sleeps while the other one keeps watch. When morning comes, we'll ride on and will make another rest during noon."

"All right," I curtly replied and laid down, unsure how to pick up more of a conversation with this cold and withdrawn Catra that I got to know for two days.
She walked over to a palm and leaned against it for a short time, then started to stroll around. I lost sight of her shadowy figure when she sneaked up to the elevated terrain around the oasis, presumably to get a better sight and to watch out for pursuers. We hadn't noticed any of them the whole time, so I assumed that we either hadn't been followed or that they'd lost our track.

I was still too excited and heated from the ride and couldn't sleep. Plus, I felt sweaty and dusty, which didn't help me to fall into a comforting mood either. I didn't like going to sleep so dirty, so I got up again, went over to the pond and scooped up some water with my hands into my face. It was pleasantly cool, but not cold, and in an instant I decided to bathe myself. I undressed quickly, stripping down even my strophium and underwear, and jumped into the lake naked. It felt awesome and immediately I was refreshed. After splashing around in the shallow water for a few minutes, I scrubbed myself and got out again.
Only to run into a Catra that stood between two palms like frozen,

watching me in the eyes and seemingly not moving even a finger. I was torn between also freezing and squeaking, but then I noticed her distress and felt my grit returning.
“You saw something interesting over there?” I grinned. “Or maybe here? I already noticed that you like watching me when I’m… uncovered,” I playfully said while wringing out my hair. My teasing got me no answer, but after a few seconds of glaring into my eyes, she grunted, turned around and stomped away. Snickering, I washed out the undergarments that I had worn today and hung them to dry. Then I wrapped myself into a new set and my tunic and laid down on the blanket.
I thought about why seeing me naked was making her so angry. Nudity wasn't such a big deal in the Greco-Roman societies of the Mediterranea. Our sense of shame was quite extensive, and we didn't tolerate excessive promiscuity or breaking of marital vows, all the more in the noble families. The virtues of prudentia and severitas called us to honor matrimony and the promises coming with it. But it wasn't unfamiliar to see each other nude in public baths or sometimes during religous ceremonies. And the Egyptians weren’t any more prudish than us.

She couldn't be angry just because she saw me naked, could she? Given Catra's behavior in the recent days, she obviously went from liking me to… something else. What was her problem with me?

My ruminating got me nowhere. I looked upon the nightly sky. The soft sparkling of the stars had always amazed me. Most just shone ever-steady and with a constant brightness, but some tended to change their luminosity in some kind of rhythm and I wondered, what caused them to do so. A few of our philsophers said that these luminal lights were fires far away in the sky, circling the earth like the sun. But I also heard one of them talking about that it was not so, but instead these bodies were like the sun, with their own earths orbiting them, and that these were the homes of other deities, like ours, that the sky was their home, a playground for them like earth was ours. While I was busy with

these idle thoughts, my eyes closed, and I slipped into a much-needed sleep.

When I woke up, I sleepily tried to blink my eyes open. Sun hadn't risen yet, but at the horizon a glimpse of dawn was arriving, and I realized what had happened. I looked at Catra's sleeping place, but it was as abandoned as when I had fallen asleep. When I looked around searching, I found her leaning at a palm, watching to the north. I pulled myself up and walked over, already not in the best mood, when I accused her: "You didn't wake me up."
She glanced at me, looking a bit tired, but didn't say anything.
I insisted: "You said we'd split the watch!"
She pushed herself from the palm and started walking over to our camp, asking without looking at me: "Is this leading to something, Adora?"
The bitch had nerves, really. "You just let me sleep! That wasn't what we agreed on."
She turned to me and dramatically raised the back of her hand to her forehead, calling "Ohhh, nooo, betrayaaal. I was allowed to sleep! What a crime, Catra, what a crime." Then she deadpanned, and started to ready her stuff.
I stood, struck upon her harshness. Grrr. Why didn't she take this seriously? And why was she like that? That was so rude, so mean. And her behavior derailed me. We had such a good run until… until we'd touched in this special way, and now she was all cold and rejecting and everything was so uneasy. I felt how I started to fall apart. That wasn't what I'd wanted, and the unpleasant atmosphere overwhelmed me, when I called: "What's with you the whole time? Why are you like this?"
Still she didn't look at me, but on her backpack and had a low voice when asking: "I am like what? A professional?"
Her cold demeanor sent me over the edge, and I screamed: "A vile bitch! You're treating me like shit. What… what have I done to

you? What?" When I realized that tears streamed down my cheek, I quickly turned around and wiped them away. Making such a fool out of myself was embarrassing enough, but it didn't have to get any worse by showing her even this. I heaved a deep breath and tried to compose myself, to stop the trembles. When I turned back again, Catra stood right before me, her face nearly… soft, for the first time since days.

So very close.

I yelped in surprise and jumped back. She raised her hands in a calming gesture. "Whoa, Adora. It isn't your fault. You did… nothing wrong."
"But what is it then?" Oh bona dea, I hated the sound of my voice, this pleading tone, I hated it. But at least, it got me something like an answer.
Catra hesitated and actually stuttered: "I… don't know how… to phrase it. But it has nothing to do with something you did. You did nothing wrong, please believe me. It's just me, trying to… make the right decision, okay?"
"Can't you tell me what it is?" I asked. She had a very worried look, and didn't speak for a while until she replied slowly:
"It's...eh... just some Egyptian stuff and nothing of your concern. I'm just… worried and distracted, okay? You did nothing wrong."
She laid a hand on my shoulder and on her touch, the urge to drag her into an embrace became nearly overwhelming.
"We should mount and ride further. The sun will rise soon and here, in the desert, we should rest in the heat of noon, to protect the horses," Catra informed me before I could make a fool out of myself. I wiped away the last wet spots on my face and in the corners of my eyes, then nodded. Her face didn't give away her feelings, but at least, she wasn't looking as distant and cold as before anymore.
Anyway, whatever moment we just had, it was gone. I reluctantly agreed, and soon, we were on our way again.

The landscape we rode through was a mostly sand-colored, rocky desert with very little green. Very rarely, we saw a palm or a few bushes, but overall, the godforsaken stretch of land accompanied

our ride until noon, where we took a break in a small village beside the so-called Crocodile Lake, as Catra told. She informed me not to try to drink from its water, as it was brackish. Later in the afternoon, when the worst of the midday heat was over, we set off again. The peaceful ride came to a quick halt, when we were ambushed just a few minutes behind the village. The stony path led through a shallow valley that didn't deserve a name, and Catra was already hypervigilant. Still, we were surprised, when we were suddenly surrounded by four, no five shabby looking figures that stood on the plateau to the left and right above us and looked down, their hands equipped with daggers and scimitars, glaring menacingly. I felt my heart start racing. Were they scouts, having troops behind?

Catra yelled something at them, she got yelled back, I understood nothing, but drew my bow and arrow out of the quiver and applied one, while obvious insults flew back and forth.

"They are bandits, they only want valuables," Catra hissed towards me.

It was just a slight relief, because we were outnumbered and they had the higher ground. "Shall we fight or give in?" I asked, and got myself a furious reply. "No way I will give in. I will rather kiss the feet of a Roman before I get robbed by such lousy amateurs," Catra growled loudly, then shouted something that sounded very much like 'Last warning motherfuckers'. The bandits chuckled, and their leader actually started another joke, when Catra threw a dagger at him with an unbelievable quick movement of her hand, shouting at me to "Shoot them down." The tall, dark-skinned man stared wide-eyed at the knife sticking out of his chest before falling over backwards. The other bandits were shocked upon the sudden loss of their leader, and I took aim at another one of them. I had been unwilling to shoot first til now, but with Catra's order I complied as we were still only two against four. Catra jumped off her horse and quickly climbed up the man-high wall like a cat to get her dagger back, while I covered her by firing an arrow at one of them. I missed, but it was their clue to take cover behind the rocks. I warily searched for any movement.

It didn't seem that another one was up for taking over command. Catra jumped on the back of her horse from above and waved at

me to charge forward. I spurred my mane, and we started galloping through the cleft. The bandits didn't follow until we got out of sight. We fell into a quick trot for an hour. It was enough time for my heart to calm again.

We reached the very much larger Bitter Lake another hour later. Our little encounter wasn't already bothering us anymore. For some while we traveled along the western shore of the salty tasting lake and Catra admonished me not to drink from it, "because it's brackish water and would make you even dumber." I rolled with my eyes and replied, that I had already thought that too because of, yeah, the taste and such. Then she also rolled her eyes and mentioned that "Princesses must be handled carefully, because they are so brittle", then I said that she was more of a princess than me, and she said I was a petty princess and then we both giggled because of our mutual stupidity. Which was the first time since days we'd done something like that, and it felt like a weight had been lifted a little.

We'd arrived at a very small settlement with only four houses and a well, beside the lake. There we watered the horses and refreshed ourselves. Afterwards, Catra got dead serious when she talked about the next part: "We have to leave the lake shore soon and head mostly westwards then. It's a two-day ride and the trek I'm searching for will lead us directly through the desert, until we reach the Nile again. There is only one oasis until then, and we must hit it, because otherwise our horses will get into trouble."
"Can't we water them with our bottles?" I asked, naively, whereupon Catra shook her head. And her curls flew around ever so beautifully. "No, not enough. We will ride until deep in the night, they need dozens of liters then. We ask a lot of them, and they need a lot of water."
That didn't sound so well. "I see. Any other recommendations?"
"Just do as I say and everything will be fine," she replied, and her eyes were glistening a bit.
"We'll see, Kitty, we'll see," I replied, not without a little eye-roll.

We rode off from the lake shore, leaving the little, unnamed settlement behind, and immediately found ourselves in a stony,

rocky desert with low hills and small valleys. And that was that. Nothing of the monotonous landscape around us changed. This was a part of Egypt where absolutely nothing lived or could survive.
Sun started to set, and it became darker by the minute, while we still rode on. For the last hour, Catra led us along a barely visible trail that must have been there for decades or centuries and was just a bit safer than the rest of the land, because it was not blocked by crevices or larger rock plateaus every single step. But even given that, our pace was slower than last night, and we had to be careful, especially for our horses not to break a leg or similar. So we rode at a steady trot until light was gone, and it became too dangerous to go on. We, and our stallions as well, became noticeably tired. Or it was just me, because Catra seemed to be doing just fine. She was still sitting straight and graceful on her steed and paid attention to our surroundings.
Three times I had been on the edge to speak up and ask for a rest, and three times I clicked my mouth shut, because my pride prevented me from doing it - and I wanted to spare myself her annoying sayings. A little later, I was just about to give in and, to swallow my pride and ask, when she suddenly let out a little sound of excitement and pointed into the desert. “There it is. Gracious Isis, I nearly missed it.”
I saw nothing in the nightly, rocky landscape that looked ever the same.

But Catra led us confidently along a trail that might or might not have been there, and after a few minutes, we arrived at an oasis that lay in a small gorge, beneath some rocks. The ravine was just a cut in the otherwise craggy plateau around, maybe around ten meters deep and five meters wide. An elongated waterhole was squeezed between the rock walls and the only possibility to reach it was from the head side of it, where a small, beach-like strip of sand nestled the long pond. No greenery beside a few, small thorn bushes was to be seen. We chased away a few small animals seeking water and made camp after taking care of the horses.

“This looks like a good place for an ambush,” I said, when we’d settled down at our blankets after a quick cat wash, and pointed to the edges of the crevice. Catra bobbed her head and replied: “Yeah, maybe. But I wouldn’t spend too much time scaring myself. We weren’t followed, and this place is mostly known to locals. And with locals, I mean literally nobody, because nobody lives here in these abandoned lands.”
I felt some relief, because despite the beauty of this small gorge, being surrounded by its walls felt like a trap, and it made me uneasy. So, I made an offer: “I can take the first watch. Also, you must be tired.”
She sipped at one of her bottles, and nodded, then laid herself down on her back, curling into the blanket. She was so near, I could’ve stretched out my hand and touched her.
“Yeah, I can use some sleep. But don’t overdo it. We must’ve exceptional bad luck for someone to come here.”
“Better safe than sorry.” I teased, but meaning it.
“Yeah, yeah, princess.” She already sounded tired and yawned. “Wake me in two hours. Or when you’re afraid of the snakes…”
I jumped and looked around wildly. “Snakes? What snakes?” I didn’t like snakes. Not that I was scared of them. Of course not! Who would be? But I didn’t like them. Very much didn’t like them.
Catra’s voice grew more silent, as she mumbled: “Oh, who knows, princess, who knows… they might be everywhere. Snakes everywhere. Snakes… chrrr.”
I looked around, eagerly searching for movements in the surrounding sand. But nothing happened, and the only noise I heard then was a quiet snore.

I watched out for a few minutes and calmed down. She’d made a joke, of course. I didn’t understand why, but as I watched her, laying beside me and with this content expression on her face, I couldn’t resist putting a hand on her curls and reluctantly touched them. They felt so soft, so absolutely not-like-Catra.
My hand froze, when said Catra moved a bit and then her hand fell onto my wrist. She mumbled something I couldn’t understand, but her touch burnt like embers on my skin. After a few moments of luxuriating in the touch, I gently moved her hand back to the

sheet. I was just about to lay it down, when she suddenly gripped mine and nuzzled her nose into our intertwined hands. Her eyes were still closed, and her breath was steady, so she was still sleeping. But her grip was still something.

My heart fastened, and not only out of sheer embarrassment. I pondered if I should get up and walk around for the rest of my watch, but I couldn't even bear the thought of letting her hand go. Thinking about leaving the sleeping woman just tugged at my heart. How could I let myself develop such feelings her, for a woman. For this unbelievably fierce and clever woman.
I sighed and laid down on my back, looking into the part of the sky that was visible from down here. Cloudless, the stars blinked as ever steady as they were and spent us a little light, making the still water beside us look like a perfect, dark mirror.
Around us, the desert was absolutely quiet and minutes later, I was convinced about Catra's judgment from before: we were all alone here. Quickly, my eyes fell shut, my fears soothed by her quiet, assuring presence. But my mind was still twirling. Having Catra so close to me did nothing to calm this special part of my unrest, but rather the opposite. And so I laid, her hand still holding mine, ruminating in my fantasy about her and me, and I got carried away like a teenager.
I pictured Catra, standing next to me, her arm on mine. She wore a white and gold dress, while I had a bright red tunic and stola on, my arms and shoulder bare. Next scene, she would hold out her hand and guide me to an event at the royal court of her land, and I would happily follow her, while she smiles back at me. We would be together, and not only in a metaphorical way. My stomach tingled and everything would be like out of a perfect dream. And somewhere between this weird and unbecoming fantasy and still holding her hand, I fell asleep.

I woke up with Catra curled into my lap and nuzzling into my chest. Somewhere in the night, she must have crawled over and put herself into my arms. Unknowingly, of course, because she'd never do that willingly. Of course not. Even given the warm-up from yesterday, she wouldn't, not after her behavior of the last few days. Ridiculously enough, and a little overwhelmed, I realized that this was the closest to peace I'd felt in a long, long time. Still a bit sleepy, I basked in it for a while.[44]
When I untangled myself and scooted a bit away, she growled lowly, but didn't wake up. I crawled the few meters to the oasis, scooped a bit of fresh water from the little lake into my face, stood up and strolled around. Our horses stood beside quietly, seemingly snoozing. I could make out their form against the first light of dawn. Walking around, I'd made a short lookaround at the stony plateau above us and saw… nobody. We were still alone. It was completely silent here, not even noises from little animals were to be heard, as there were so little. Only every now and then something cracked, like if rocks were being split. With the sun starting to rise above the horizon, the rocky desert began to gloom in orange, red and yellow colors, becoming brighter by the minute. Despite the lifelessness, it was a marvelous, pacifying sight.

I was calm and confident, eased by the surrounding when I trudged back and rattled Catra at her shoulder, waking her up not too gently, grinning at the sleepy woman. She yawned, caught sight of the dawn above us, and immediately started to stare at me. Her two-colored eyes pierced me, but I just looked back with a friendly face. "Adora, what have you done?", she finally asked me with a rough voice. A so pretty rough voice.
"Eh, paid you back?" I smirked and found my reaction obviously great.
"That's not funny, you idiot. I can't have you falling off the horse because you're tired." She brushed down her curly mane in a blatant attempt to calm herself.
"Ohhh, nooo, betrayaaal!" I imitated her, and my hand patted her shoulder. "Everything's okay, Catra. Nothing happened the night. I slept with you…" What?. What did I just say? On no, I haven't said

that, have I?
Stuttering, "I mean, you slept with me—", made absolutely nothing better. Oh, dear Venus and Vesta, that couldn't have left my mouth. "Nooo! Ugh! We just slept, okay? We slept. Side by side. Nothing happened! Nothing!"
Upon my ongoing mental breakdown, Catra turned from staring to shooting me a very amused look, but she luckily spared me the embarrassment of an answer. Without any other word, I started to pack my stuff, in a deep need to unblush.

Without breakfast or anything, we rode on in grateful silence. Somewhere in the morning, we ate and drank in the saddle, but didn't stop. At noon we finally reached the end of the desert, when suddenly below us the the green Nile river valley opened. Riding down the slopes of the dale, we passed fields, acres and plantations, watered by the lifeline of Egypt, spreading left and right of the great river that flew down calmly and steadily as if unmoved by all the human quarrels. The valley itself stretched at a width of maybe five kilometers and was home to many small settlements here and there. Date palms, olive trees, pomegranate bushes, wheat fields and lemon trees lined our way left and right, again making me understand why Egypt was such a fertile nation.
"Now it's going to be easier," Catra told me. "We will ride along the outer valley roads. There is not much traffic, because most of the folks travel by boat or along the river towns. When we reach Maidum, we'll seek for a ship at the garrison. Then it's just a nice boat trip to Thēbais." A cold shiver ran down my spine as she mentioned our aim. The aim where my inevitable fate would be fulfilled, and suddenly, all the uneasiness from before crept back into my conscience.

We arrived at the garrison of Maidum early afternoon, whichs commander was loyal to Cleopatra. The tall and bald Egyptian had the looks and traits of a lifetime soldier, and had always acted upon his reputation as a staunch ally of Catra's sister. When a messenger from Achillas, Ptolemy's General in his war against Cleopatra had threatened him to obey to his orders and sent his troops to the delta, he'd stripped the courier of his clothes and

sent him back to Alexandria, naked. Coincidentally or not, no further messengers from Achillas arrived after that, and luckily, he needed his troops otherwise than to subdue a defiant commander.
Catra joked around with him, obviously liking the guy, then commanded him to ready a boat for us. She was informed that it would need until the next morning. By having a safe accommodation with the garrison, we were in no hurry. So we decided to stay for the night. Or rather, Catra decided to spend the evening in a tavern beside the garrison. And that would come at a cost, as I would quickly see.

After a small refreshment and a changing of our clothes, we left the garrison again to walk over to the small settlement. The garrison lay between the Nile and the Maidum pyramid, with a few irrigated fields spreading around both of them, and there was a small settlement on the other side of something that might have been a plastered road in previous times. The pyramid was an uncompleted and strangely looking one. Its height was nowhere near that of the Great Pyramid of Cheops at Tipersis[45], but it was still impressive, towering high above the little village that nestled between it and the river shore. The upper body showed a step pyramid, while the lower body was hidden in rubble and sand, making up some kind of plateau and giving the impression of abandonment - which was quite right. Despite its greatness, it *was* only an abandoned grave of kings, dead long ago, their tombs ravaged and robbed several times during the centuries, until nothing beside the bare stone was left. Even the stones were slowly taken away for other purposes. It was a depressing thought, that all the efforts of these ancient kings left nothing behind than a large stone building that was of no use for anyone beside being a quarry.

But before I could fall into a gloomy mood, Catra dragged me with a mischievous smile around a corner of the next houses and the pyramid wasn't any longer to be seen. There she eagerly said: "We'll have some fun tonight. I'm done with the water from oases in the desert or a well in the garrison. This evening, I'll show you

how real Egyptians drink… eh, dine!" Then she cackled like a madwoman.
I was nowhere in the mood for some Catraesque escapade. Our sort-of-reconciliation from yesterday had lightened up the mood between us, but I was still hesitant. And maybe a bit grumpy, despite the unintended mutual snuggling from this night. And was she even allowed to tow me into some dirty, unworthy and presumably dangerous tavern, given the previous events? I assumed we were safe enough here, but who knew. On the other hand, a bit of real life wouldn't be so bad, I quietly admitted and followed her expectantly. I still felt like an overstepping child.

A minute later, Catra shoved me through a little archway that led into a house. Nothing indicated the presence of a tavern, but when I stumbled forward, I soon realized that we'd just entered the inner courtyard of the surrounding houses that formed a square. Several large cloths in different colors spanned over the place, giving shelter from the cold of the night, as well as the sun by day and maybe the very rare rain. A few little palms also provided shade and completed the beautiful sight. I just stood and stared, taking in the lively scene. Wooden benches and tables stood around, wildly spreading across the place with its ground of large stone slabs. Lanterns spent a bit of flickering light. People of all colors and origins were sitting, talking, drinking, eating. Never had I seen such a vivid, casual, normal scene of life, and I drank in the whole atmosphere in awe. Above us, sun started to set, and dipped everything in an evening mood.

"I think we should get a bit more comfortable, you boring patrician." With that being said, Catra reached out for me and grinned underhandedly. Then she plucked at my stola, ran around me while cackling, and tugged it away quickly. When she'd finished unwrapping me to my normal, white tunic, she took her red-and-beige scarf to cover my bare shoulders. All of this happened within seconds, and I was too shocked to actually do something against it. She ogled me, mumbled something that heard like "adorable" and then ushered me to a table between some kind of bar and a palm. A minute later she returned with

two mugs of a suspiciously looking substance, served me one and toasted "On our journey, Adora. May it be long and prosperous."[46]

I sipped at the strange tasting drink and asked: "What is that?" which got me the deadpan answer "Beer."
"Doesn't taste like beer. And it's too strong," I replied, taking another sip.
"It's not too strong, you lightweight. It's just the right stuff for real Egyptians. Might not be something for puny Romans."
That was it. "Whom do you call puny, you tiny midget?"
"I'm calling puny Romans puny, because they can't take a stand. See my first evidence A… dora." She took another sip as to underline her teasing. I nipped at my mug, and it still tasted hard.
"Ugh! I will not dignify that with any answer, you stray cat."
Her eyes glistened of joy. "Oooh, stray cat you say? Didn't you know that cats are deemed holy beings in Egypt? Bow to me, puny Roman, otherwise my wrath will be terrible."
"Then maybe it's time to show them the strength of Roman eagle, the mighty", I pushed back, grinning.
"Pfff, mighty Roman eagle. It's rather a sparrow, in my clutches," she fired back and then crowed: "Whoever empties his mug first wins!" Without waiting a second, she grabbed her mug and downed the still half full thing in one large gulp. I did nothing, I just stared at the mad woman. That was incredible. How could this classless beast—
"Adora, your beer! Loser!" she crooned while I was still frozen, but startled when she put her mug down with a loud clack. "That was unfair! We hadn't even agreed on this stupid shit!" I complained.
"You fell into my purrrfect trap, Adora. Now deal with it," Catra cooed while smiling happily, and I nearly pushed my mug off the table. Oh bona dea, the husky, beguiling voice of hers made me twitch. Down below. I felt how my eyes dilated, and I quickly hid my reddening face behind the jug and stared at her over the rim of it. It was a mistake. While the alcohol slowly settled in me, looking into her beautiful and maliciously sparkling mismatched eyes just made the tug in my heart grow stronger. All that came to my mind was "*Uh-Oh*".

Catra

Of course, I'd put up a show this morning, when I woke up at the oasis. Because I knew that she'd slept beside me the whole night. And how could she even have done otherwise, when I'd locked the blonde idiot into my grip, and nuzzled into her all the time. I knew what I'd done, even if nothing of it was planned or properly thought about. I'd always been impulsive and hot-headed, but curling up into the arms of Adora had been something different, something I just couldn't withstand.
When laying beside her in the night, and noticing that she was about to get up for her watch, I instinctively grabbed her hand — which was dumb — and didn't let her go — which was even dumber. But I couldn't stand the thought of her being away from me. Maybe the abandoned surrounding, the loneliness of the nightly desert or the intimacy of our camp, guarded by the surrounding rocks, contributed to my snap reaction. But also did the tug in my heart, that wasn't able to let go of her. I needed her beside me, I needed to feel her warmth. Just for this one, lonely, single night. I knew it was stupid of me, and I couldn't do different though. And so, I listened to her breaths calming down and felt how a tremble went through her body when she relaxed and how she fell asleep at last. Soon after, I curled myself into the embrace of this stunning, earnest, but sometimes also insanely clumsy and funny woman.
I knew nothing good could arrive from this. I knew she was about to marry an ally of Cleopatra. And of course I knew that she wasn't for me. I knew all of this, I grimly thought, while falling asleep in her arms and feeling incredibly sheltered, ignoring all of these dumb thoughts as good as I could.

And ignoring it was sooo easy, given this beguiling scent of hers. Adora smelt like a meadow full of herbs and flowers, lemongrass

and a bit of salt and earth, something that I'd only seen and smelt in my younger years. During a revolt against her fathers, I'd accompanied Cleopatra, then eleven years old, to a journey to Greece, which would eventually end in Rome. The Greek villa above Athēnai[47] where we had stayed for a month was surrounded by a very extensive garden, devotedly tended by the owners. The wealthy couple had collected flowers, ornamental plants and herbs during all their travels around the Mediterranean world and beyond, and had created a wonderful garden to preserve and grow them at home. They terraced it around the existing terrain and built irrigation channels, small crevices and mounds to create perfect micro conditions for the different plants. They used different soil types to create the right environment for all their collections. It took dozens of slaves to water all the plants during the summer, but the effort was worth it, and it was clear how proud everyone who worked on this marvel was. The magnificent colors were still well in my memory and even all these years later, I remembered the smell of the meadow in the middle of the grounds. The whole area had been buzzing with insects, bees, little lizards that took a sunbath on the stony walls that separated one layer from another. It was rich, lively, vigorous, full of expectant joy in the morning, while exuding a calming undertone in the evening. Rarely in my life - all the more as a young girl being around Cleopatra - I'd been able to sit still and relax. In this garden, I just could. It radiated nothing than peace and beauty. And here, in Adora's arms, I could too. She smelled like this soothing meadow from my past.

So, I knew all of this, I grimly thought, while watching Adora graciously sipping at her mug of beer, being adorable, trying to behave like someone could expect it from a Roman patrician, but always just that little bit off to be real. It was just stupidly making me smile. When I strolled to the bar to fetch another drink, I saw three soldiers sitting at the table next to ours and quickly, a thought crept through my head. I bumped against their table, throwing over two of their mugs on intention, then went for some dramatic excuses and fetched all of us new jugs of the tipple.

I gestured Adora to sit and behave like a good girl, while joining the patrons at their table. After I introduced myself and toasted to everyone, we chatted shortly about their duties and stuff, until I smilingly wiped my mouth and asked the men: "I heard that Hordak is doing good at rebuilding Thēbais, but that he also rallies troops. Isn't that a bit… much for a simple governor?" I let my voice sound inconspicuous, but if my eyes were narrowed a bit, the guys didn't catch it. Because the officer just nodded, his look a bit unsteady because of the alcohol. "Hah, you could say that. But you could also say that this guy is pretty ambitious, right? I mean, he has even more men rallied than we have here and in Coptos and Syene together. The chief says that he's an ally, but I'm… just unsure. He's a strange guy." He looked around. "Don't tell him that I said that."
I patted him on the shoulders. "Don't worry, my friend. My lips are sealed."
He looked at me, gratefully, then his eyes fell on my lips. "And you have such beautiful lips, lady" he said with an honest smile. "Would you mind putting them to some better use than only drinking?"
I must've looked a little stunned upon the frank approach and Adora started to giggle, clearly overhearing everything, while I simultaneously got frustrated over myself. Why couldn't I do such nice and easy, plain compliments? Without the tease or stuttering. Not at Adora, of course. That would be stupid. But maybe on other people? Ugh!

"Thanks, but these are taken," I retorted and the soldier sighed. "What a lucky man, then. My apologies."
"No offense taken," I lightly replied. I was in a good mood, but when I looked over to Adora, I found her staring tipsly back at me, dreaming. No, at my… lips as she quietly sighed: "Yeah, what a lucky man." Her face fell apart when she realized I'd heard it too. She hid her reddening face behind her hands and looked down at our table, avoiding my amused yet scrutinizing gaze.
I wanted to laugh at the poor and desperate woman, but then the realization sunk in. What? Did Adora think that I was… into men?
After last night? You're such an idiot, really.

On the other hand, I realized that we'd never spoken about this special topic. I should've perhaps given her the benefit of doubt. Or was this just her way of testing the waters, being too reluctant to talk about such personal matters otherwise? Unfortunately or fortunately, the beer - or rather the alcohol in my system undermined my reason to leave her alone. So I *also* tried to test the waters and threw in loud enough for her to hear: "Sorry fellow, these are for Sappho's friends only."
I casually leaned back on my chair and took another sip, searching for *her* reaction at the corner of my view. The man didn't get the hint, obviously, because he just shrugged his shoulders and nipped at his beer, clearly not knowing anything about Sappho. [48]
But Adora got it, judging from her blush - and maaaaybe from her sudden spluttering also. She put back the jug she'd been nipping on, coughing hard. I inwardly smiled and thought, that that was something I could work with. Maybe that I also decided to throw all my previous hesitations about the Julii over board - at least for this one evening. Maybe I was just stupid.

Said evening went on, the night was mild, and the beer - what a surprise, huh - flowed freely. The other patrons got drunk and funny, and we did as well. The mood was light and poor Adora obviously wasn't used to alcohol, because one and a half beer were enough to make her very tipsy. And handsy. Very. Handsy. Not that I complained about the continuous touches of my hands and arms, even my cheek two times, but I really needed a way to distract the drunk girl from showing too much public display of affection in this very tavern. It wasn't hard to come up with a solution.
Because her competitiveness still made her an easy prey. When I proposed a silly shooting competition with bow and arrow, she agreed immediately. Luckily, said equipment was hanging over the bar for this exact purpose.
So I yelled at her, too loud and eager, to catch up in a little contest. We would battle each other and the winner "can claim a free wish from the loser. Ha!"
I knew exactly what I wanted, and was dumb - or drunken -

enough to think I could get it that way. Funnily, the two and a half beers inside me knew it also, making me clumsy and giddy alike.
"Oooh, Catra," Adora called or rather growled, while leaning over to me, "That was your final mistake, you lousy barbarian. Surrender now, and I will be generous upon your defeat!"
I giggled while rolling my eyes. Even now, she behaved like she was conquering a new province for her stupid Republic. Gods, I really hated these arrogant Romans. I would feast on it, exorcise that innate arrogance from her, if I could get her under...
"This isn't Qart-ḥadašt my pretentious princess.[49] So prove it, you pale lass, prove it." And with that being said, I drew an arrow, aimed at the target and shot in a single move. It hit right beside the center, just a finger width outside it, and the other folks hollered in approval. It was a good result, given my tipsy state. Topping me would be hard for her. When Adora stood up and fetched the weapon out of my hands, she lasciviously grinned at me and whispered: "I think you *hicc* forgot something." My expression must've been readable, because her grin only got wider. "Just remember the roof."
Oh. Ooohhh, yeah, she had a point. Fuck. She' already *proven* that she was a skilled archer, but that damned fact had just slipped my drunken mind when I suggested this stupid contest. Fuck fuck fuck.

Maybe I'd miscalculated?

And then she was like a damn goddess again, dimming everything around her to a pale reflection of the truth. She pulled the scarf off, showing her bare shoulders, flexed her muscles and fetched an arrow out of my limp hands while I stared in awe. When she stood in the middle of the tavern, aiming at the target, she looked like personified Diana, the goddess of the hunt, fully making up to her second name. Not only that, Adora was a female Ra, emanating warmth and brightness, bringing light upon us paltry humans. She shone like a female goddess of the sun, strong and kind alike.
Bobbing with my head left and right, I didn't know from where the thought came from, that struck me. But there it was, and drunken

as I was, I happily crowed it out: "She-Ra!" My fists bumped the table. And again. "She-Ra!" *Bump* . Again. "She-Ra!" *Bump* . Repeat. “She-Ra!” *Bump* . Again.
Other patrons fell in, getting the joke quickly. The tavern was crowded now, and I had the slightest inkling that this wasn’t happening all the time.
In the middle of the attention, adorable Adora just smirked, her confidence perhaps boosted by the beers. She notched an arrow. Her vision had to be shaky - it damned had to be! - but her arms and hands weren't. When she drew back to take aim and released the arrow in one flowing and gracious move, the spectators fell silent.
And the arrow hit the center of the disc.

I’d miscalculated.

“She-Raaaaa!” The crowed hooted and hollered, Adora raised her hands, the bow still in her right hand while beaming victoriously, being patted on her shoulder and cheered by admiringly glancing young men. Her gaze fell on me and I just smiled into these intense, now happy looking blue eyes. She walked to our table, fetched her beer mug, and downed everything in one large gulp. Again, the crowd welcomed the entertainment warmly, until one of the men shouted “The price!”, and his loud organ unfortunately drowned out the others. Quickly, he got support. “Price! Price! Price!” the crowd shouted, and everyone turned to me.
I stood up and waved with my arms and hands up and down to calm everyone a bit. I was just a little tipsy. Just a little! “Alright, alright! I admit my defeat! The admirable She-Ra might claim her prize!”
Uh-oh!
What was that for a look of hers? I’d never seen her smiling so… lascivious? Was it that? It was a bit hard to judge, because everything was a bit dizzy now.

Adora stood upon a stool, trying to keep her balance, and nearly fell over. The clumsy idiot, I giggled inwardly. Swaying, she held herself at a wooden beam beside her at the last moment. Then she waved at everyone for silence. “I demand *hicc…* I demand to

be *hicc* ... Ugh!" She bowed forwards and tried to breathe, only to find herself hiccup more, then broke out into an insane and nervous giggling, whereupon most of the patrons fell in and hollered again. It was so funny to watch her, I nearly broke out in laughter. Someone screamed, "Take your time, lady! We can wait the whole night," then everyone wooed again and half the mugs were raised in crazy laughter, klinking together loudly. The friendly drunken atmosphere was absolutely insane.

Finally, Adora put herself together and crowed: "I demand to be kissed by the most beautiful woman in this tavern!" While again some folks translated her words, the surprise wavered through the tavern like expanding circles on the water from a thrown stone. Most of the patrons fell silent, surprised, and some of the more tipsy women turned their heads, unsure, insecure. No one had a real clue what that was supposed to mean, but I clearly saw two or three of them shooting around considering looks. They were obviously *considering* their fucking sexuality upon the well-shaped, good-looking, and just admirable blonde goddess in front of them.
I snickered shortly, but became fucking serious then, because *fuck them*!
My drunken mind worked faster than the rest of me. I stomped on the feet of the officer next to me, and, upon this surprised look, tilted my head twice towards Adora while eye-pointing at her, and silently begged him to understand what I was demanding.

And he did, he fucking did, thank the whole overflowing Egyptian pantheon of too many gods for it. He shot up and yelled "Cat-Ra! Cat-Ra!" Then he raised my arm and dragged me forward with a strong grip. I nearly stumbled into Adora. If looks could set something on fire, I would've been molten under the angry gazes of at least three other women in the tavern. But the men, knowing that they were out of the game, already picked up at the officer's supportive shouting and quickly, the whole crowd bawled "Cat-Ra! She-Ra! Cat-Ra! She-Ra!" It was just crazy, but despite the few outmatched women, everyone else had a good time.
Said She-Ra, personified in the adora-ble form of the beautiful Adora, hopped off the stool, triumphantly sauntered over to me

and leaned forward, with her hands folded on her back like a little girl asking for sweetened fruits and with pursed lips. Her blonde ponytail hung down over her naked - naked! - shoulder and completed the cuteness of this charming woman. I was damned! Daaaaamned! God, I was so drunk.

My first try to keep it decent and well-mannered was followed by many *booos* from the audience. Because I tried to duck away by brushing just a light kiss upon her cheek, which got everyone rightfully disappointed by my cowardice. Adora was pouting - pouting! - but didn't move otherwise. Her lips where still pursed. My next try was a bit more belligerent.
And even more so as at this moment Adora turned her head so that her lips met mine—

And when we touched, it was all I ever dreamt of.

She leaned fully in and dragged me closer by laying an arm around my waist. This half-or-full-drunken goddess wasn't hesitant. Not even in the slightest. My eyes went wide open for a second, a last piece of my reasonable mind protested, but the moment the warmth washed over me, they closed by itself and I just melted into her embrace, forgetting everything. Her grip got even stronger, welcomed by my body pushing forward on its own. As if by themselves, my hands rose and cupped the cheeks of heaven. Our lips touched in longing and very quick, nothing of this was gentle anymore. Because She-Ra wasn't the constrained Adora. Instead she was wild and demanding, taking what she wanted, and around us, the other patrons bawled and cheered again.
Adora's arms pressed me in, her fingertips dug into my back, and despite the firm grip, I nearly collapsed because my legs got weak. Her saliva tasted a bit like the beer - or was this mine? - but her meadowy scent overlaid everything, assuring me of THIS. She wanted this, me. It was intoxicating and swept my reason away. This was what I'd dreamt of when thinking about Adora, the perfect woman, holding me in her arms and kissing me. Wild. Demanding. Yes. Fucking yes!
One of her hands was at the small of my back, pressing me into

her, the other one at my neck, fondling my hair from behind, now lightly *tugging* at it. *Ah!* When my mouth opened in a loudless gasp, she eagerly slipped her tongue in, and I repeated the favor easily, because of her own little and adorable heavy breath, moans even. Her tongue met mine with dedication. Wet, exploring, demanding. She pressed me into her.
And we just kissed. Kissed. Kissed.

We parted after maybe a minute or maybe an hour. My drunken state and Adora's kiss had killed every reason I might have had in my brain. I felt like it was talking in ancient Egyptian - WHICH NOBODY FUCKING UNDERSTOOD TODAY - until I let go of her, and she drew back her arms, that had tangled me. But still we looked at each other, both of us unwilling to break eye contact, both still hungry for more. Staring. The stupid staring contest didn't come to an end and just continued, when I finally tucked a strain of my curls behind my ears. Only then her eyes followed my hand, then she rose hers and laid it on mine, obviously not thinking about anything. And who was I to stop her?

Who was I to stop her? The thought raced my mind, occupying it, bringing me a little down from the high of heavens.

I was…

I was...

I should…

This could not be. It was doomed. All of this had only one word written over it: Catastrophe.

When I saw Adora's desiring and demanding look lingering on my lips, I was frigthened. I had to stop this. Now. Because Adora obviously wouldn't. We could, at least, have this one evening and that would be it. I already convinced myself to draw back, when tipsy Adora babbled: "Wow! That was… unbelievable good. I... want... more." Her voice was low, hungry, desiring and pure *want* radiated from her.

It overwhelmed my weak decision to draw back Aasily. And so I said to myself that one last kiss would be okay, only one last kiss, nothing more.
“You can’t say shit like that and leave a gap between us, princess," [50] I cooed at her and Adora was happy to meet my lips halfway as their drunken owners clumsily crashed them against each other in a wet and eager disaster.
It was a more than okay ending for an evening like this. Almost a happy ending.

The unhappy ending came in the morning.

We’d left the tavern and went back to the garrison. More uninvolved observers could also have said that we were fortunately helped and led by the officer from the next table and two of his men. The two of them held Adora, who stumbled and tripped every second step, slurring incomprehensible stuff and occasionally giggling silly nonsense, while the officer lent me a supporting arm to put my hand on. I wasn’t as ruined as Adora, but I clearly had my share.
We’d been provided with a room for guests, with a bed for each of us, and Adora slept the moment she laid herself down, still fully clothed. Snoring slightly in a very unpatricial manner, she was a beautiful sight even then. I pecked a gentle kiss on her forehead and went to bed too, arming myself for the next day.
Ruminating in my own forbidden desires, I asked myself how much suppressed lust and desire had built up in her to behave like that. This drunken version of her hadn't been constrained, but a whirlwind of overwhelming strength to which I had no defense.
Had I been her first real kiss? The first like that? Given her confession about her upbringing, it wasn’t so unlikely that she had no real experience with men. Or women, to stress the point. I put the pillow over my head and hit it with my fists to distract me from these thoughts. It didn't really help.

When I woke up, Adora still slept, laying on her side and drooling a little. Sleeping so long was not her usual trait, because she typically woke up earlier than I. But I assumed that she had to wore off her intoxication and so, I let her. It wasn't that we were in a hurry, clearly not depending on when to leave. The garrison was safe enough, and a day more wouldn't matter anyway. I could need the additional rest too. So I just stayed in my bed and dozed a bit, or looked at her from time to time.
When she blinked her still tired eyes open an hour later, she spent a while staring at me, then started to rub her eyes and temples, letting out sounds of groaning and whining. "Oh bona dea, that is… awful, Catra. Why haven't you warned me? This beer is… Ugh!"
I poured her a mug of fresh water which she gratefully drank. And then another four. After that, she looked a little better, but still sat on her bed, holding her head in her hands.
"I never had something like this the next day," she admitted. "How can you do that freely?"
"What do you remember?" I asked instead of an answer, fearing the possible fallout from… making out with this gorgeous woman, I inwardly sighed.

She frowned and looked up at me, her face still an expression of a severe hangover. "Not much, I assume. Something about bow and arrow? Too much beer, obviously. And what is a She-Ra?"
Oh, blessed be the gods. Adora didn't remember the kissing. She would've said something, or at least act differently, right? Funny enough, I felt torn between relief and being grumpy about it. Had it been so forgettable? Had I been?
I mentally scolded myself, because that was exactly! what I wanted and according to my beautifully crafted plan to act like an adult, this was for the best. So, why was I so reluctant to be happy about it?
My pondering got me nowhere, and so I just decided to move forward.

We readied ourselves - a little slower than normal and with Adora a bit clumsy and groaning the whole time - for our departure to the boat by noon. We still weren't in a hurry. While I scurried

around the yard of the garrison, waiting for Adora for the first time, the officer from yesterday crossed my way. He shortly bowed and asked, a little smiling: "What a nice morning, your grace. I hope yesterday's events haven't taken a toll on you?" I rolled my eyes and shook my head in denial, then replied: "It's good. Thank you for your help. The lady appreciates it, too." He frowned shortly, clearly pondering to which lady I might refer to. But then he just tapped his forehead and went his way. I wondered about this short talk, but, well, who really cared? Adora was still not to be seen, when a guard at the front wall shouted something, then the gate was opened and a messenger ride on. Or rather, it was more that he dragged himself in on a completely exhausted horse - and with him, news of turning tides.

With a shaky voice, he demanded to deliver a message to me and was pointed towards were I stood. The man was spent. I fetched the scroll out of shaky, sweaty hands and sent him to seek rest. Unwinding the string that held it together, I was worried about what that would mean. And I quickly found my anxiety approved.

Gaius Julius Caesar had arrived in Alexandria.

Adora's uncle, the victorious general and gravedigger of the Roman *Republic*, had arrived or rather practically invaded the Egyptian capital with the ridiculous small force of half a legion at this side, which had sailed with him. This was just a fraction of the army he had under his control now, after his success over Pompeius Magnus. So why had he done such a foolish move? The man wasn't an idiot!
With the full force of the Egyptian army right before Pelousion, just a few days away, Ptolemy and Achillas could easily return to Alexandria and throw him out. Or kill him. What for a blod game did this man play? Was he already on his way for an alliance with Ptolemy?
The facts were too vague, fuzzy. But not to my surprise, upon this unexpected fast development, Cleopatra ordered Adora and me back to Pelousion IMMEDIATELY. Cleo had underlined the glyph

three times, as if I hadn’t been able to catch her order good enough without them. Ugh… Cleo, really?

Because I understood it very well. Cleopatra wanted to have Adora by her side now, to possibly use her to gain access to Caesar, who was in fucking *Alexandria* , where her fucking *brother* sat on the throne, his puppeteers at his side, making the poor boy do what they wanted.
That changed everything. If Caesar joined her brother’s side, Cleopatra was finished, despite all her cleverness. Her forces would be easily overwhelmed by the combined one of the main part of the Egyptian army and as much of the Roman legions it would need. The Romans had hundreds of thousands of men mobilized and under arms right now, and the only thing that kept them from conquering what was left of the Non-Roman-world around the Mediterranean was that they fought each other instead of, for example, us.
All of Egypt had a fraction of this force, only being able to keep its independent status because we’d behaved like a good ally all the time and sent grain to the hungry Moloch that was the Roman superpower right before our gates.
If Caesar sided with her brother, Cleopatra only option left was to flee. She could maybe retreat to Upper Egypt then, to Syene perhaps, to seek for shelter and to stay alive there until better times. Maybe the Roman’s literally wouldn’t go to such lengths just to kill her, and her brother's men wouldn't be able to do it either.

Lengths. The word triggered something. *Lengths* … it lingered in my mind, making me think. Then I got it. Oh, wow! I stood dumbstruck in the yard of the garrison and nearly tripped over my feet. I hit my forehead and all the pieces of knowledge already there suddenly fell into place.

Of course! She could retreat to *fucking* Buhen, and sit it out there, in a newly renovated and strengthened fortress outside the reach of the Roman's. Because the first cataract between Syene and Buhen sheltered it pretty good from being approached by ships from down the Nile. From the delta. From ships with… legions on

them. Buhen was her fallback place!
How could I not have seen that? Upon the realization, I barked out a loud gasp and balled my fists. Had this been a part of her plans all the time? Sending me to Buhen to prepare the godforsaken nest as her ultimate place of retreat in times she would need it? A fortress beside the Nile, but so far away that it wasn't really of interest to our current realm?
Oh, goddess, this woman was unbelievable. She had *planned exactly this scenario two years ago*. A possible alliance of her brother with superior Roman forces. Of course, she'd planned in advance! I pulled my hair when checking how unbelievable clever Cleopatra had acted when sending me there, giving me just enough means to achieve the task at hand - preparing the fucking fortress and gather a workforce and such - but not enough military power to actually make anyone suspicious. Because who would care about 200 men in the desert? Nobody would!
And I idiot had worried about the damn Kushites all the time. Holy shit! The Kushites were fucking fine and content. They never sent any emissary or scouts. They hadn't even cared about our presence in this abandoned part of the Nile shores. Any why should they? 200 men? Laughable, ridiculous! No, they stuck to the treaty Cleopatra already negotiated with them and did nothing more mischievious than looking grim.

Dear gods, Cleopatra, you would pay for this deception, for sure, I grimly swore to myself while admiring her strategic cleverness at the same time. [51]

Then I searched for Adora to tell her about the situation. And to order the commander that we would have to redirect the ship, obviously. Fuck. Dealing with Adora and her likes was a menace to every plan.

Our boat was taken downriver by trained rowers and I was really glad I didn't have to do that. Other women with a different inclination than me might have been aroused by all of these men's strong, bare chests, but I didn't give them a second look. It wasn't my cup of tea, and I knew that for a while. As so often, while I leaned at the railing and looked forward, Adora suddenly stood beside me. Usually, her presence would delight me, but aside from last night's events, I was also moody, and didn't notice her for real.
"What's up with you?", she asked after a while, nudging me at the shoulder gently. "Reminiscing in yesterday's events?"
"What?" I startled, frozen. She sounded so smug, did she? Had she recaptured what happened between us yesterday? When I shot her a glancing look from the side, she didn't look embarrassed or so, letting me assume that she still hadn't.
I replied warily. "No, doofus." *Oh, yes, I had.* "You got too drunk," *and I as well* , "and it was an embarrassment for your ancestors. Shame on you, Adora, shame on you." Mine would be proud, actually. Desperately making out with a superb looking Roman patrician in a lousy tavern on the road to Thebais? That would've been a story for telling at the campfires, getting everyone giggling. For ages, actually! Only that I couldn't under any circumstances. I would keep that to myself.
"Then why are you blushing so much, Catra?" she asked, capture my look with her eyes, with her… beautiful... intense… blue ones. Ugh! That was a failure. I felt how my brain got mushy and how my reason got lost under this stare. And her lips...

I playfully shoved her away, scolding her lightly. "Get over yourself, Adora. It's not always about you!" *Of course, it was about her,* I inwardly sighed. This whole inner monologue was only getting more ridiculous over time, and so I returned to watch the river, away from her beautiful eyes and lips.
Again, Adora nudged me, more softly this time, maybe getting my sudden withdrawal wrong. "Hey, I was just teasing you," she said apologetically. "But… but if you just wanna talk, then I'm here for you. I mean, it's not because I like you or anything." She hesitated shortly, shrugged her shoulders and looked cute as always, until

she added. “I’m just a little nervous.”
I didn’t reply upon that, because I didn’t know what to say. Of course, all I *really* wanted was to drag her in and kiss her again, inhaling her scent, tousling her stupid hair poof, nuzzling into her neck. The desire was so ridiculous, and yesterday’s event did everything to strengthen it. Her last words, instead, pushed it back a bit. What was she nervous about? All was going well for her, wasn't it? Her damned uncle was probably here to take over Egypt for good, and there was no way we could hold off a full-scale invasion of his forces now that he had defeated his main adversary.

Funny, how thinking about Adora turned over to think about her family. To some extent, I was grateful for the distraction. Our sudden recall and its root cause bothered me too, and I was deeply concerned about the upcoming events. The yearlong standstill in the struggle for power between Cleopatra and Ptolemy and their respective allies was presumably nearing a crucial phase. And no matter how this would end, the Romans had lingered on our doorsteps for decades now. They clearly wouldn’t leave us alone anyway, but try to expand their influence with or without force.
Cleopatra was a realist. She already dealt with the Romans, as Adora’s example proved. She dealt with the Kushites, the Syrians and presumably every other invested party. Since her coronation, she considered Egypt fully her kingdom, which she did not want to share with her brother's advisors. Egypt was hers, and hers only. In an extension of this trait, all of her doing was aimed to strengthen her kingdom, her *independent* kingdom. She was looking forward and was a strong leader, a strong leader her younger brother obviously couldn't be due to his age.
Unfortunately, I had a slight clue which leader Caesar would prefer on the throne. Rome wanted an Egypt weak under his strong grip, a subservient ally.

I eyed Adora, trying not to see her as a part of said Romans but as just a person, a woman, maybe a friend - but never more than a friend - and she frowned upon my ogling.
“What?”, she asked, curious.

Sighing, I said: “I fear that our time comes to an end.”
She looked baffled, clearly not expecting that answer. “Our time? What do you mean by that?”
“Well, the reign of the Ptolemies, the Hellenistic era of our country.” I pointed to the bank, the settlements and green fields that flew by. "This here, the rural towns and villages along the Nile and even in the delta have always been just Egypt. But the larger cities are a mix of the Hellenistic and Egyptian culture since centuries, they have mingled long since. Alexandria is practically a Greek city, as you have seen for yourself. But most of the Hellenistic influence and heritage in the world has been surpassed by the Romans now. The Macedonian and Seleucid realms are gone, and Egypt is the last of the kingdoms truly left over from Alexander’s empire. It's not that I'm so fond of that by itself, but it's the only world I've know ever since. And now Rome is lurking around, while our dumb ruling dynasty is fighting each other as always. We are not united and that makes us weak, Rome does what it always does, and if Cleopatra doesn't find a way out of this, soon, we will become a province of yours, like so many others. Then all of this will change into something else. The Egyptian culture was here for 3,000 years. 3,000 years, and now, everything is coming to an end, I think, because Rome just can’t leave us alone, and we are too silly to look beyond the table.”

Adora swallowed, clearly haven’t seen it that way before. Typical Roman arrogance, it raced my mind. I knew it was unfair to her. Because on the other side, I realized that also Adora was just a tool of the more powerful forces that controlled her life. When I looked her in the eyes, I caught a glimpse of the thoughts and fears that might race her mind as well, and a spike of pity mingled with my own devastation, disturbing my anger and spite, derailing me. Maybe, she understood me just as good? "I'm not really blaming you. You're just a..."
I fell dry, not wanting to finish the sentence, not wanting to say 'symptom' or 'pawn' or anything alike. She didn't deserve it, and maybe for the first time in her life, she didn’t say anything in return. We just mutually leaned at the railing, watching the river shore flowing by. As always, the sight was beautiful: green, lush

fields near the large stream, with settlements and villages between them, and behind, the yellow-white desert, sometimes just sand, mostly rocky, a temple or statue, and now and then a pyramid. Some time later, Adora laid her hand on mine and squeezed it lightly, nearly just featherlight brushing over it, but I understood the full meaning of the gesture nonetheless. It wasn’t because of physical affection, lust or desire. It was assurance, kindness, compassion. That's just how she was. In that quiet moment, it was wonderful to have her by my side. And strangely, I felt sad that it couldn't be that way all the time. That we couldn't.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah, I like doing footnotes, I really do. And I really like this chapter and hope you do as well.

Buuuut: the next chapter is called - whuhuuu! **"The Siege of Alexandria I"** and will be published on Friday, July 16, 2021. And it has 13k of nice words waiting for you.

[42] A cohort at the time of the late Republic was generally composed of 480 up to 600 men, with the first cohort of a Legion typically consisting of 800 soldiers. A cohort can be considered as the equivalent of a modern military battalion. Ten cohorts made up a legion of around 5,000 to 6,000 men. More fun with military info? Here we go: because of the width of the ancient streets, one should rarely have had the opportunity to advance with more than four men in a row. Under this condition, a marching century of around 100 men has a length of around 60 meters, a third of which falls on the pack animals. For a cohort of around 800 men, that's 360 meters, but probably rather 400. The typical marching speed could be assumed with around 3 km/h. And so, a cohort leaving a garrison would typically need around seven to ten minutes to fully do so. ↕

[43] The military parts of the Roman road net were equipped with *mansiones*, road stations, every about 25 to 30 kilometers, as an ox-drawn cart or a pedestrian could travel this distance per day. Often mansiones were built in the form

of a villa with a fort or camp around. The villa could be used by civilians for rest and refreshment also, but they had to provide a passport for identification. Many mansiones developed into *tabernae*, taverns, and even towns. There were also the smaller mutationes, changing stations, where drivers could change horses, carts, wheels and ask for other services. The Roman road net was a key game changer in governing a large empire. It is therefore no coincidence that Adora makes this suggestion. ↑

[44] These two sentences are a wild variation from "A mountain to climb, for your love", Chapter 15. ↑

[45] Tipersis is today called Giza (Gizah). ↑

[46] I didn't do that. It wrote itself, your honor! ↑

[47] Athēnai ~ Athens ↑

[48] Find a longer introduction to and information about *Psapphō* in the afterword of the 21st chapter.↑

[49] Qart-ḥadašt ~ Carthage ↑

[50] This fucking awesome sentence is from "Drawn into the music", Chapter 7.↑

[51] Please look into the notes of the next chapter. I reached the character limit here. ↑

The Siege of Alexandria I

Chapter Summary

This is the dumbest thing I’ve ever seen. Appearing twice. And this siege is not what you think it is.

Chapter Notes

A few hints about accuracy and stuff:

- To clarify: I am narrowing and condensing the actual events of the Siege, according to Caesar’s "Commentarii de bello Alexandrino", due to plot reasons and dramatics and stuff. This is not a history book, and I want to take liberties when needed. I won’t deviate from actual history too much, though. After all, nobody knows about the details of these times, because sources are scarce, and the existing ones are biased.
- Another remark I forgot: I refer to the Hellenistic realms as 'Greece' only. In fact, there were different kingdoms and realms, making up what we know today as Greece. But I didn't want to elaborate on that matter also, so I just stick with Greece.

And a footnote from the previous chapter, due to character limits:

[51] In case you wonder about the strategic background, look at the actual location of no-longer-existent Buhen. The next large Egyptian city was Syene (Aswan), below the first cataract. It is 350 kilometers down the Nile, and therefore around a month of travel time by feet for an army. And given the remote location, it would've taken a considerable logistical effort to get enough troops to Buhen to beleaguer it effectively.
A trade outpost existed at the site of Buhen since around 2700 BCE. Around 1860 BCE, the unusual large fortress was

built by the old kingdom as the last fortification in a line of forts in signaling distance to each other along the Nile. Around 1470 BCE, famous second female Pharaoh Hatshepsut built a temple for Horus there. It is unclear when the city and fortress have been abandoned, but it changed ownership several times over the centuries. Today, Buhen alongside the larger parts of historic Lower Nubia is submerged under Lake Nasser after the construction of the Aswan High Dam. I reference some more background in the sources in the final afterword. ↑

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Nile, Pelousion and Alexandria, Egypt - September, 48 BCE

Adora

I remembered our kiss. Of course I did. The kiss was unforgettable, its memory had burned itself into every fiber of my brain and mind, with a relentless sustainability. For the first time in my life, I'd kissed a woman in desire, and it was everything, all the - very rare - kisses before hadn't been. Kissing Catra hadn't been soft. It had been wild and demanding, and I knew it from the first moment that I, that we wanted it that exact way. I wanted to do it again, so much. Exactly this, just... to kiss her again. And maybe… to do more. When thinking of her, it twitched between my legs. I felt a weird desire rising in my belly, my heart, my chest, a strange warmth I'd never felt before and which couldn't describe very well. It wasn't that I was hesitant about that feeling - it was far from that. It was rather that I had no clue what was going on with me. Wasn't this feeling what should happen between women and… men? Between people who were about to marry? And now, a woman was the one who made me feel like that? Perhaps Sappho would approve, but despite her merits in poetry, she was a rather disputed figure regarding being

an idol to emulate, as many lessons in ancient poetry and philosophy taught me. And I could clearly hear my father disapproving of all of this. Not to speak of *her.* She would go mad. It could not be.

All I did was to hide my longing the whole day, stored it away behind my hangover. That, indeed, wasn't faked, because my head ached and everything was much too bright and shiny. I tried to stay under deck for most of the time, but my simmering unrest drove me up sporadically. Luckily for me, Catra clearly didn't remember what had happened, and it was good as it was for the time being, given the circumstances. Because it could not lead anywhere, and ignoring what had happened was the best way to try to keep myself together. Yes.

It didn't work very well.

When she spoke of her worries about her land, I tried to come back with a smart remark about that uncle Julius wouldn't do something like that. But luckily I could stop making a fool out of myself for blabbering such nonsense.
Because we were exactly like that. The Roman Republic had conquered city state after city state, principality after principality, kingdom after kingdom. We even - it was ridiculous - we even inherited a whole province, because the last king of Bithynia, Nicomedes IV, bequeathed his entire kingdom to us, discontent with his other options and impressed with our ability to build infrastructure and a working bureaucracy. The Roman Senate quickly acknowledged everything and annexed it as a new province - maybe too quickly, because it directly led us into the Third Mithridatic War with a king, who wasn't very pleased to find himself surrounded by the enlarging Roman enem— erm… Republic!
It was the most stupid thing I ever heard of being the reason for a full-scale-war, dragging the entire east of the Mediterranean and large parts of Asia Minor and others into the conflict. In a result, the Pontic Kingdom of Mithridates as well the Kingdom of Armenia became client states of Rome until today and meant nothing more than trouble. It had happened 26 years ago and in the meantime,

conquering by war or political pressure had stayed our main way for expansion along our borders. Rome grew, it seemed just inevitable. Even if we just *inherited* a kingdom, a war had followed!

I sighed, more to myself. Her explanation made me realize that even Catra wasn't just playing around and having some kind of weird, personal fun as Cleopatra's minion. I remembered that she had successfully ruled a settlement for more than a year and proved herself a skilled leader in governing and battles alike. And that was more than I had to show as of now. She was admirable beyond her sheer attraction, which in itself was insanely appealing. Maybe it was the combination. Fuck me.
All of this was a strong reminder of my current situation, being trapped in the maneuvers of the mighty powers that ruled my life. Catra seemed to have at least some kind of freedom, because everything she did for Cleopatra, she did on her own free will, it seemed. That was some kind of freedom that I wanted for myself more and more, the longer I got used to it - in her presence.

While standing next to each other and sunken into our separated but mutual ruminating, I laid my hand on hers. I just wanted to signalize that I understood her, but couldn't find the proper words. She seemed to get it, but nevertheless our conversation didn't live up again. We just stood there, and watched the shore flowing by. Soon, I again withdrew into the little cabin the boat had to offer for it's commanding officer. I needed the rest and more sleep, because my headache started to throb again. After nestling into the bunk, it took me only minutes to drift off again. I would be wary to drink with her again, that was for sure.

I woke up to a soft ruffling of my hair. While slowly opening my eyes, I saw Catra crouching on the floor beside the bunk and absently patting my head as she stared at a scroll. A low "Mmmnn…," escaped from my lips and immediately, she withdrew her hand with a quick move, and denied any comment by ignoring my sleepy, but questioning look. The loss of the contact left me

wanting it back.
"You're awake. That's… good. How do you feel?" she asked instead.
After needing a second to collect my ability to speak, I replied huskily: "Better, actually. I think I'm not drunk anymore. But *ugh* , this taste. Bah." The weird Egyptian beer was clearly as strong as our wine.
"You're such a lightweight, Adora," Catra teased, wrinkling her nose a bit. "I drank twice as much as you, and look at me." She proudly gestured at herself and smirked way too much, so her words earned her a low rumble out of my chest. She didn't continue with her antics, and her look went back to the scroll. My head lay on the side, my one hand tucked under, and I watched her with interruptions, because my eyes fell shut again a few times. While not really awake and not really asleep, I just listened to her breaths, an occasional clearing of her throat, a little rustling with the scroll. It was a comforting, mutual silence, and I wallowed in it.

While I tried to wake up, I thought about what had happened. About kissing this fierce and strong woman. And maybe because I was still a bit drunk or maybe the intimate situation in the little cabin made me brave enough, my arm moved forward and touched her shoulder ever so lightly. Catra twitched, but I did not withdraw my hand.
"What is this, Catra?" I asked with the quietest voice I ever used. She said nothing, her gaze was frozen to the scroll, her body still, giving no response. Maybe I had been mistaken? Maybe this was only my misjudged, one-sided urge for something Catra didn't feel in return? But why'd she kiss me back? Why'd she touch me even right before? I pulled out every piece of courage I had, clearly making a fool out of myself - again - but I just had to say this. I needed this, and I was aching for answers. "I'm not… an experienced woman, not like you." Now her head and eyes shot around and intensively stared at me. My will crumbled under her look and with my last piece of strength I said: "But I know there is something. Between us. Something I never felt before. And… and

I’m… lost, because I don’t understand it. Please… can you… tell me, if it is the same for you?"

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and heaved a deep breath. Her refusal to talk made me insecure, anxious, and I didn’t know how to move on. I withdrew, getting none of the answers I’d searched for, and tried to apologize: “I’m sorry. You don’t have to say anything. I just wanted you… to know…” My voice fell dry. There was still no reaction from her as she just sat and neither did nor said anything. After another minute had passed without any word, I finally withdrew my hand. “Ugh! I’m not doing this right, I know. I’m sorry, Catra. Please… accept my apology… won’t bother you with this again.”
I turned around in the bunk, lying still, and stared at the wood that made up the hull of our boat. Catra also hadn’t moved, because it was dead silent. She might even have stopped breathing, judging from the silence behind me. My hands were fisted in a desperate attempt to stop my eyes from watering. My stomach hurt. I’d been such an idiot. Of course, all of this was just playing out in my dumb mind. Ugh! How could I've thought that she would return this strange feeling that I had started to harbor. Catra and I had made a drunken mistake and she, wiser than I, just forgot about it. As should I.

How could I?

After a while of something between feeling stricken and sulking, I fell asleep, and when I woke up again, I was alone.

We didn’t speak again until we arrived at Pelousion the next morning, using the already known, small port jetty outside the city, the one where we’d been ambushed a few days earlier. To my surprise, I didn't feel bad about the remembrance of it, or nervous to return to place where it'd happend. The events weren't really there for me to grip, my memory mostly blurry, maybe because it happened so fast. In principle, nothing reminded us of what happened here few days ago. The bodies and weapons had

been cleared away and the sand had been trampled over dozens of times. My look fell on the roof from where I'd shot. A small spark of... excitement rose in me, making me feel a little proud that I'd been able in... helping to defend myself, Catra, her soldiers. That I hadn't been a burden, but useful instead. But should I feel that way? Was that really me, a woman with a warrior attitude?
I didn't realize that I'd stopped in my steps when I set my foot on the ground after walking down the plank from the ship. But I heard Catra asking: "What is with you? Come on."
Today, it was clear that nothing like this would happen. The port facility was encircled and secured by at least two centuries, each one typically consisting of around 100 men, obviously awaiting us. On the other side of the river shore, where the Egyptian army under Ptolemy's control had taken place, we saw huge clouds of dust rising into the air. It looked like that larger parts his troops were moving, perhaps exercising - or preparing for something more dangerous. It was no wonder that Cleopatra sent that many troops to guard us.

Alexas of Laodikei led the men, with Bow at his side, who was back in the saddle and in charge of my guard agai. Both nodded with a smile at us, and we were immediately provided with horses. Alexas renounced his former mannerisms and wasn’t as composed as usual, but unsettled and obviously wanted to have us with Cleopatra in no time. I gave Bow a questioning look, but he just shrugged, obviously not knowing much more too. On our way to the temple in the middle of the city, where Cleopatra still headquartered, we were *only* accompanied by one century, leaving the rest at the port.
“What’s going on with Achillas?” Catra asked Alexas, while we trotted.
The man looked uneasy. “He’s sending a good part of his troops towards Alexandria, we assume. The largest part of them, actually. We haven’t gathered more information right now, they just started moving this morning. I think we will know more by the evening, when our spies return.
“Why would Ptolemy need his army at Alexandria, if he’s going to

make friends with Caesar?” Catra got right to the main point.
Alexas shot her a bewildered look, then his facial expression changed into like he got something. “You don’t know?”, he finally asked.
“What? That Caesar occupied our capital? I got it pretty good," Catra pointed out harshly. She wasn't very pleased with the back and forth.
Alexas shook his head. “Not that… but- Oh, I think I will leave this for our Lady to explain to you. I don't want to upset her. She's mad enough anyway.”
Now, Catra was even less amused, and made it clear in her reply. “What? Spit it out, you damn old bastard! This is not the time for this."
But he stayed silent the rest of our ride, and even I could tell, that Catra was boiling. When I looked over to Bow, he shot me an apologizing smile. I could read it in his face that he'd been left in the dark too.
I tightened my grip on my horse's reins and pressed the spurs a little harder, making the mane speed up its trot. If only Cleopatra could tell us what was happening, we had to be faster.

Cleopatra wore a scarlet tunic-like dress, that nestled tight around her upper body, but fanned out below her waist. A broad yellow-gold ornamented scarf covered her shoulders, neck and fell loose around her upper body down to her hip. The piece looked a little ceremonial. A white belt and sandals in the scarf’s color complimented everything. When we approached her in the temple hall, she, like so often, stood at the large table in the middle of the great hall and was in a heated discussion, gesturing wildly around.

This time, Catra didn't bother to worry about manners or general human behavior at all, and simply interrupted everybody by shouting from still a few feet away as she charged forward: “What happened, Cleo? What’s so important that your idiot of an advisor couldn’t tell us?"

Cleopatra, quite a Pharaoh, didn't erupt like a volcano at being interrupted so harshly. Instead, she steadied herself, and smoothed her hair in one elegant, flowing motion with both her hands. She then turned to us while Catra and I came to a standstill at the table. Cleopatra's face looked tired, horror written all over it. I expected terrifying news. "What happened, my lady?" I asked in a calming tone, and was sure I didn't want to hear the answer.

Cleopatra deadpanned, heaved a deep breath and informed us: "My brother has killed your former Consul and general, Pompeius Magnus. At the shore, here at Pelousion."
"Oh, bona dea, that's not true," I gasped, clapped my hands before my mouth, and goosebumps ran over my back. Every single hair on my entire body straightened. Catra stood just frozen. Cleopatra nodded. "That was my reaction also. It's the dumbest thing I've ever seen." She wildly shook her head in disbelief and huffed. "Pompeius wanted to land near the camp of Achillas' army, presumably seeking for shelter after his defeat by Caesar. He disembarked his ship, and was lured into a trap. He got stabbed and killed, on the advice of my brothers' idiotic counselors. His fleet fled immediately. And two days later, Caesar arrived in Alexandria. This is the situation."

I tried to process the news and failed miserable. I'd known Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus for my whole life. He had been the most important man of the Roman Republic for as long as I'd been old enough to speak. Him being gone sounded like some fairy tale from a distant future. In his younger years, he single-handedly wiped out all piracy in the eastern Mediterranean Sea. He'd led tens of thousands of men into war, paid and equipped *entire legions out of his own pocket.* Until today, he had been the only rightful *Consul sine Collega,* a Consul without counterpart the republic ever had in hundreds of years. And until the death of his wife - and Caesar's only daughter Julia - he had been my uncle's most important ally for *decades*. He was the reason Gaius was where he was. The man had been a *titan* of war and politics for more than 20 years, a *Consul* of Rome three times, who fought wars for longer than even Caesar and won the most of them. He'd

always been there.
It could not be.

Cleopatra obviously had had enough time to further her conclusions. Her tone was nearly light, when she said shrugging: “On the upper hand, this ends the possibility of an alliance between my brother and Caesar. So much for the good news. On the lower hand, the Romans and Caesar especially will never forgive us for this. He must be mad about it, and honestly, I don't blame him for this bestiality."
"How could they think that Gaius would like that?", I blurted out.
"I don't know," Cleopatra admitted a little quieter than before. "Getting you back here was kind of a panic reaction. I needed to know you're safe, under my protection, because I can't forsee the coming events. Frankly, I don't even know what to do now."
Catra frowned upon her sister’s words. “Why that? I mean, Pompeius is… was Caesar’s enemy. Shouldn’t he be grateful? And you did nothing. It was your brother—"

Cleopatra and I shook our heads in mutuality, and we both smiled dryly when we recognized it, but then I replied quicker, because this was exactly my domain. It was the first time since yesterday - in the cabin - that I directly spoke to Catra. “You don’t get the context right. Yes, they were enemies at the end. But they’ve been friends too, allies, for twenty years till the events of the last two years drove them apart. Pompeius had been the husband of Caesar’s only daughter years ago, in an attempt to strengthen their alliance. It was a cruel twist of fate that he also loved her, and when she died in childbed, he deeply mourned her death. Pompeius held enormous games in her honor, pleasured Rome with immeasurable festivities, spent millions of denarii on that.[52] And even after that, and despite all their disagreements, he was still loyal to Caesar. In this war, he didn’t even want to confront Caesar until the whole Senate practically begged him at his knees.[52-1] They were no real enemies, but they had different opinions and wishes how to rule the Republic. I am sure, that Gaius would have pardoned him upon his victory. He clearly won’t take the murder of a Roman citizen, of a former friend and

relative and foremost, of a Consul lightly, that much is certain. Your king has made a grave mistake."
"He isn't my king," Catra retorted curtly looking very uneasy like I was targeting her, obviously trying to process all of this.
Cleopatra just nodded as she sighed heavily. "Yes, that's pretty much it. The Romans and Caesar especially won't have that some barbaric tribe at the end of their world killed one of their most beloved and admired leaders, a Consul of Rome, who was seeking shelter. In their mindset and regarding their virtues, only Romans are allowed to murder Romans." She smiled and huffed weakly, clearly knowing that any joke on that topic would fall dry. "The whole Senate will cry for our blood when they learn these news. And I wouldn't be surprised if they, Caesar, Marcus Antonius and Metellus Scipio will set their struggles aside for the time being and try to salt the Egyptian earth with our very blood upon that. They won't care about our family quarrels. They'll just kill us all."

Silence fell upon our conversation.

Cleopatra was completely right with her analysis. I had to admit that I had still underestimated her until now. She was pretty clever, and completely understood our concept of the virtues, including much more than Dignitas and Gravitas. These virtues also not-so-subtly included the very fact that a Roman citizen stood above everyone else. Regardless of the color of skin or being rich or poor: a Roman citizen was only to be judged and, in case, killed by a Roman magistrate. Point. Not by some barbarian.
And certainly, a Roman Consul must not be slaughtered like cattle at the shore of some soon-to-be province of our realm.
So I dared to speak out what literally went through my mind: "Killing Pompeius can easily be the prelude to the final of the Ptolemaic quarrels for the throne. Because possibly, you and your siblings as well as all of Egypt might find themselves at the other end of a formal declaration of war of the Senate and the People of Rome." I shortly stopped to breath and to take in the shocked faces around me.
"Maybe within days. With Pompeius gone, it all depends on

Caesar's reaction. He must be furious and has his legions right across in Greece. He only needs some ships to get them here. Just remember the Gauls." [53]
Catra clearly understood my innuendo to our own conversation. "Okay. I have goosebumps now," she said dryly, and Cleopatra grimaced at her. I scratched my head. This wasn't all good.

With noon approaching, Cleopatra decided upon a break and ordered that something to eat and drink would be served in the courtyard. We settled down on the benches between little palms, flowering bushes and lemon trees, and I hesitantly nibbled at some of the delicacies which were arranged on fine plates neatly. Cleopatra stuck to water only - how did this woman even survive - while Catra dug in as if there was no tomorrow. When she realized my baffled look, munching, she etched: "What? You never know what this menace has in store. I've to be prepared. She's surely making up something for me to do." Said menace, Pharaoh and half-sister of chewing Catra, rolled her eyes and supressed a sigh. She clearly wasn't in the mood for jokes and teases.

When watching the raven-haired ruler, I realized that for the first time I saw her uneasy. She stopped walking and said: "Actually, I have nothing in store, to put it your way. I just… don't have a clue. I was thinking about going to Alexandria to meet Caesar in person, but chances are high that I'm captured by either Pothinus or Caesar himself. We had some exchanges by letters, regarding Adora's matter, but after Pompeius' murder… I'm not sure where we stand and how he's going to react to that. I obviously can't sent him letters now, and I can't let myself be captured by Ptolemy. They would kill me without hesitation."
I pondered about it. "I don't think my uncle will take you prisoner. As far as of now, you didn't do anything to make him mistrustful, or did you?"
Cleopatra bobbed with her head, her black hair flowing around. For a moment, she looked a little uneasy, as if she was pondering about something, but it went by quickly and vanished when she replied: "I don't think so. But I also assume that he's not very

pleased with Egypt at all. At the moment, I wouldn't bet my life on such vague assumptions."

She sat down, lent back against a tree behind the bench and sighed. "Why hadn't this idiot come to me? The bloody moron. I would've happily captured him alive and handed him over to Caesar as a gift. And he would've been merciful, I'm sure. He would've pardoned him!"
I interjected. "He obviously thought that your brother was still an ally, holding the power and able to help him against Caesar. I don't think he even considered talking to you, as you aren't—"
She cut me short, yelling hot-headed: "I know! I know!" then pulled her hair and muttered more to herself than to us. "Ugh, my brother, this idiot. Why are men even allowed to rule? For them, everything looks like prey that must be stabbed to death. Bloody idiots, all of them." Cleopatra continued to talk herself into some kind of rage and rushed around in the yard, nibbling at her fingernails. Now she looked like the 20-year-old that she actually was.

We were still talking the topic forth and back, when one of Cleopatra's advisors walked by, bowed, and held out a formal looking capsa[54], that contained a scroll. The Pharaoh took it and waved him off ungratefully, unrolled it and began to read. Her face turned from reddish to sour and when she finished it, she just held it over to me with a harsh move.
"Huh?" it slipped out of my mouth.
Cleopatra nodded and growled: "Look for yourself, what your uncle, the great Caesar, has to say."
I fetched the scroll and was about to read it, when Cleopatra started yelling like I never heard it before.

"IN MY KINGDOM! HOW DARE HE!"

She was angry, her face ever redder than before, and she shook her fists. There was a short silence and everywhere around us, at the archways of the temple, people froze and watched out for us. Some hid behind columns.
"Technically, he's in your brother's kingdom," Catra injected

casually and was met with brutal stares from her sister. Cleopatra panted and growled: “Get lost, Catra. I can’t stand your wickedness now.” Catra shot up from her stool and hurried over to her angry sister, her face an expression of guilt and worry. “Sorry Cleo, I haven’t meant it like—"
The Pharaoh straightened herself and held out her hand with the palm outside, keeping Catra away. “Leave me alone. Both of you.” Her voice was nearly composed again, but there was plenty of suppressed anger underneath the surface. Catra looked puzzled, nodded slowly and waved at me to follow her. I raised and bowed shortly, then also rushed away. I caught up with Catra in the great hall, where she waited for me. “Woah. That happens rarely. What made her so upset?” She pointed at my hand. Realizing that I still held the scroll, I unwound it again, and we mutually began to read my uncle’s letter.

Greetings, Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt,

I am pleased to be a guest in your great city of Alexandria. There are urgent matters to discuss with you and your brother, so your presence is needed. I ask you and Ptolemy to meet with me at the palace of Alexandria as soon as possible. Both your armed forces shall stay behind, because I look forward to assisting you in reconciling with each other, so Egypt can thrive again, and with Rome’s friendship. Your kingdom must be at peace.
I await your presence in confidence.

Vale!

C. IVLIVS CÆSAR

Unsurprisingly, Gaius wrote his letter in Greek, a language every one of us could read and write, as it was the most common tongue among the educated Romans, the Eastern Mediterranean and the Hellenistic Egyptians. Typically, he wrote in Latin, so using Greek here was an acknowledgment of Cleopatra’s origin and education. But beside that, it could only be read as a formal order to bow to his will, and I found it pretty understandable that she was *pissed off* .

Catra just chuckled in loud amusement, letting out giggles. “They could be siblings. Cleopatra’s letters sound exactly alike.”
“Really?” I asked surprised. “Shouldn’t she be like, let’s say, exaggerate everything a bit with ancient words and Pharaonic overstatement?”
“No, no," she waved it off. "She loves to write short and precise, without any fuss. It’s the same style as his." She pointed at it. "You have to admit that your uncle isn’t very accommodating, or is he?”
I huffed a short laugh, on the edge of giggling. It was embarrassing, sure, but also funny. “Absolutely. He practically orders her to await his judgement, in her own realm. I mean, that’s… that’s really upsetting, you know? He would rage if anyone would dare to talk to him like that.”
Now Catra giggled, and by doing so, she laid a hand on my forearm. I didn’t think she realized it, but for the first time since our kiss, it felt like we got something back that we’d lost since then. I tried not to let it show, but a shiver ran down my spine upon the touch, and I felt a bit better, the knot in my stomach loosening a little.
She just rambled on. “It would be funny, if it isn’t so serious. I’m always down for teasing her, but that’s really different. I think, we should leave her alone for a while and think about what to do next.”
That sounded like a plan, because when looking back to the courtyard, we saw that Cleopatra had picked up beating the bushes and trees in the courtyard with a stick, grumbling out her anger while muttering unintelligible stuff to herself. That was a really angry woman.
“Yeah,” Catra picked up my thoughts, “let’s leave her to herself. We’ll pick her up later.”
I nodded, and Catra waved over at Alexas and the other council members that stood aside and were watching their furious ruler with growing concern.
“I assume, the news have been… underwhelming?", Alexas asked curiously, and general Palmedes seconded him with a curt nod.
Catra smirked and gestured at me to apparently make me to explain the situation. So I did. “My uncle practically has ordered

Cleopatra and her brother to come before him and await his judgement for resolving their quarrels. But he was nice. He wrote it in Greek.” I shrugged my shoulders, because, well, I wasn't the one pushing Pharao's around.

Alexas’ eyes went wide open, while the general just growled: “Is the man crazy? Who does he think he is?”
That pulled a spike of defiance out of me. Despite my understanding, the crazy man was still my uncle, someone of my family and gens, and so I wasn’t just teasing when I coolly replied: “Fair point. But maybe he’s the one with around 30 legions under his command right now. You have what? Two?”
There you have it, Roman dignitas in your face, hah!
Catra barked out a loud laugh upon my mannerisms and quickly, Alexas and I fell in. Even Palmedes managed a dry smile as he said: “Okay, fair point too. Power creates its own right, I'll give you that. Caesar might have so many forces under his command, but they aren’t in Egypt, right? How many men has he brought with him? One legion? A half one?
I shrugged my shoulders. “How should I know? I haven’t spoken with him, and he obviously didn’t lay out his military tactics in this letter,” and waved with the papyrus.

“So, what do we do now,” Catra asked and Alexas shrugged his shoulder. “Waiting for your sister to calm down and not doing anything stupid, I would say. If she is in this mood, she might as well order a full scale attack on Alexandria just to prove her point, whatever it would be." He grinned, adding, "Which would be dumb, for sure, but you know her."
Catra seconded: “Yeah. Don’t fear, she’ll be alright in one or two hours again. Caesar’s letter would’ve upset everyone, but she's not stupid. Goddess, even I’m upset about his lack of manners. What a dude, honestly, Adora, what is this with your family?"
Surprised that the attention came back to me, I snarked: “What? It’s not that I’m asked about anything, right? You remember why I’m here, don’t you?"
Catra’s face turned sour, and here one could see the kinship between her and Cleopatra. I laid a hand on her arm and said: “Hey, don’t worry about that now,” but immediately asked myself

why *I* was comforting *her* right now?
A thought struck me, and I blurted out: “You know what? Maybe I can talk to him, now that he's in Egypt.” Another thought followed, one a little more crazy. “Hey, what about if Cleopatra speaks to Gaius in person? I mean, she is persuasive, right? She can try to persuade him that she had nothing to do with her brother's doing."
“Didn’t you listen to her?” Catra replied. “She already considered it, but she doesn’t want to be captured in Alexandria? And your uncle demands her there as well as her brother. Who has most of his army there, in a few days? Doesn’t look like a good plan to me.”
“Not like that, you idiot. She could go with me, directly to Caesar in the palace. As my servant perhaps. I am his niece. Nobody would hinder me to talk to him. And of course, I need servants on my way. She wouldn’t even be noticed, if we make up some disguise.”
“That sounds ridiculous.” Palmedes retorted, and I shot back: “Why?”
“Because… because… it’s dangerous,” he stammered, lacking a better counter.
"And sitting here and waiting isn’t?”, I shot back. I just knew that my idea wasn't that bad. Cleopatra needed my uncle's support, now more than ever.
“At least she’ll be alive and safe enough," the general tried to cut the discussion short.
My voice grew louder. “I don’t think that’s what she wants, or is it?”
“She wants to be back on the throne, and not beheaded like her sister,” the general insisted.
“Then it doesn’t sound like a good strategy to hide in some desert frontier town while my uncle integrates your little kingdom into Res Publica. If Pompeius' killing gives them a reason to really clean up here, they won't stop my uncle. And Egypt is like a ripe pomegranate. One just has to pick it. Caesar obviously can. Or can you stop him?” I gestured wildly. “Can you? No, you can’t. You can’t do anything against the forces of my uncle or the might of Rome at all. He will just wage war on you and that’s it. It

wouldn’t even be a war. He can just sit in Rome and sent legion after legion from all over the Mediterranean until your land is burnt down to ashes. Just like Carthage. If she wants to have any chance, she must talk to him! Quick!” I felt how I panted after my heated speech, and only when I fell dry at the end of the tirade, I realized what I’d been saying and mainly how, namely yelling, and that everyone around us had heard it. Catra threw me an illegible look that I wasn't able to decipher, while everybody else just stared angry at me.

I winced in shock when a dangerously friendly voice from behind asked: “And what has the Julian gens decided upon my fate, Adora?" Cleopatra's voice was all sweetness and way too friendly. "Shall the Pharaoh of Egypt bow to your uncle? Shall I wrap myself up in a carpet and be delivered to him? Naked, preferably?”
I spun around to her and the comment slipped out of my mouth before I could think: “Would you do that?” Everyone looked at me, baffled, and the uneasy silence stretched and stretched and made me grimacing in embarrassment, gritting my teeth before the scolding.
Suddenly, Cleopatra and Catra began guffawing like madwomen at the same time. I watched them in disbelief until they died down, then asked: “Have I missed something?” Catra laid an arm on my shoulder, still chuckling, and whispered: “Oh Adora, you have no idea what she's capable of.”

Seeking for further answers from the other attendees of our little stand-up-meeting got me nothing more than evasive looks. I let it go and picked up the thread from before, now speaking directly to Cleopatra: “Your majesty, please consider what I proposed. Meeting my uncle in person might the best and probably only way to resolve this situation with neither doing it with a war you can’t win nor you being captured or worse. He is a reasonable man, despite his manners of writing. His dignitas is of most importance to him. Keeping it was even one of the reasons he started this war. So if I visit him and ask for a meeting among relatives, take you with me and put you under my protection, then he will not harm you, I promise. You will have safe passage afterwards.”

Everyone gaped at me, as if I was an idiot. But I was convinced that this was the only viable solution for her. And behind that, it could be a solution for me also, because if a direct alliance between the both of them would be successful, then my betrothal and subsequent marriage to some weird Egyptian wouldn’t be necessary any longer. A win-win for all of us, in my humble opinion, which wasn’t any biased. Absolutely not.

Only that Cleopatra had to make up her mind now.

Catra

This woman was unbelievable. Had she just suggested that Cleo should pull nearly the same stunt that both of us did two weeks before when we sneaked into the palace? Well, it sounded possible, given that we’d already done that, but now it must be absolutely dangerous, because of Caesar’s presence and the tense situation it created there. Yet bringing Cleo into the lion's den would be an outright crazy move. Even I wasn't that mad. On the other side, Adora was right, too. Cleopatra needed an alliance with her uncle. Desperately though and regardless the circumstances. If Caesar took a hostile stance towards her, she was done.

We discussed the matter for two hours, talked about other options, disregarded them, considered more idea, while Adora mostly just stood and listened, only throwing in an occasional comment when it came to Caesar himself, or the possible reactions of the Roman Senate. Otherwise, she just waited for the round to inevitably accept her advice. Hesitant, begrudgingly in Palmedes’ case, but nonetheless. And I was already mentally preparing myself for *another* journey to Alexandria, while inwardly sighing. Somehow, a few days of rest would’ve been fine, but fucking fate decided otherwise. In the end, an unnerved Cleopatra

threw her arms in the air and called: “I’ve heard enough, and nothing of this will work out. There is no denying it. I’ll have to speak with him personally anyway.”

And that was that.

The captain’s lower bunk bed was large enough to hold Cleopatra and me, while Adora slept in the upper one. It wasn't a comfortable accommodation for the three of us, and maybe a little weird, but it was what we were dealt as we obviously couldn't use any of Cleo's own ships.
Cleopatra still was on deck, talking with Alexas and the weird shipowner with the ridiculous mustache, but Adora had withdrawn for sleep a while ago. She'd looked exhausted, and I wasn't really sure why.
When I inevitably went down to the cabin too, my thoughts were drawn to her. Her odd half-confession had been three days before, and we’d barely spoken with each other ever since. When she opened herself about her feelings towards me, she left me in nothing but despair. When she spoke, I just froze, unable to do or say anything. I wanted that to hear. I wanted it so much, so desperately. But when I heard it, I was terrified of the consequences. As she finally fell dry, audibly shaken and rightfully misjudging the reason for my silence, embarrassed by my unresponsiveness, I was in a state of total conflict.

All in me wanted to tell her the same, the exact same. I wanted to jump on her, drag her in, and never let her go again. To caress her strong face with my hands, drawing lines over her soft skin and hard muscles, from her head over the defined arms to her chest. I wanted to nuzzle into her collarbone and inhale her, deeply, while not letting her firm body out of my grip. My heart ached to tell her that I felt it too, this bond that'd started to develop between us so quickly, and that made me awake and lively like I’d never been before.

Only, that I did nothing of this. Because Adora wasn't for me. Because someone had to behave like an adult. Given what she confessed, it was clear that she was inexperienced in matters of love, and I had the strong suspicion that she was still a virgin. I wouldn't dare to be the one to take that away from her, not like this, not in a hasty affair without a future. Not with me. I wasn't worth that. And never would I've taken advantage of her adorable, clumsy inexperience. She should've been worshiped, and gently guided, to be able to discover her desires and needs in a relationship with someone whom she love…

Oh, goddess. What the hell was I thinking? The poor woman would never get that chance.

When I saw her lying in her bed, so calm and quiet, almost innocent, the urge to touch her only grew stronger. She lay on her side, head towards the cabin, and, stepping a bit closer, I traced her face. Something worked in her lines, her jaw was clenching from time to time, her eyebrows twitched. She was dreaming.
With some effort, I freed myself from Adora's magnetic attraction, undressed, and got ready for sleep. About to lay myself down on the lower bunk, it was when I heard Adora muttering and I pricked up my ears.
Still incomprehensible.
I sat up again and brought my head on her level… oh dear, her face was so close, her lips were moving slightly, parted a bit, mumbling stuff.

"No." I heard. "Don't…" She looked uneasy, as if having a nightmare, and maybe that simply was it. A normal nightmare.
"No, I don't want…"
But it didn't sound like a normal nightmare.
I moved my ear closer to her, when suddenly her expressions softened. It looked like she was calming down and... was she sniffing a little? Whatever it was, her little movements died, her muttering stopped, and she obviously slipped into a gentler sleep.
A finally mumbled "Catra" was so quiet, it was almost impossible to hear.
Only that I heard it good enough. She sounded content.

While trying to fall asleep, I had to force down my arm that rose to touch the snoring woman right above me several times. It was a Herculean task. I hated myself. I hated her. No. I didn't. But I needed to not like her like it did. Why was she like that? So... desireable. I put my pillow over my face and punched it multiple times.

Never in my life I'd assumed that the responsible person would be me.

We reached Alexandria at the evening the next day. While the ship steered towards the harbor, Cleopatra, Adora and I stood at the ship's railing to discuss the next steps in detail. Adora's best idea was to directly go to the palace, hiding Cleo's and my faces behind veils and a submissive behavior, carrying her goods, and demand access to her uncle. Cleopatra scurried around as eager as a tiger, sneered at the term "submissive" and just wanted to get over it and to follow Adora's nothingness of a plan. This wasn't like she usually acted, but given the general situation, she was nervous and upset, and that clearly made her careless.
I was more hesitant. It didn't look like a good idea to sneak into the palace without proper preparation or even something like an escape option, so I put in kindly that "I think both of you are idiots" if they really considered this as an actual strategy. They didn't take my hidden hint very well, and I continued: "The plan is, to barge ahead into the heavily guarded palace to find Adora's uncle in hope that he somehow will help us to defeat Ptolemy?"
Not to my surprise, I was outvoted by Cleo saying "Yep, that's the plan," and Adora added a simple "Yeah!"
This was ridiculous. I rolled my eyes, replying "Honestly, what did I expect?" [55]

When we'd landed, Adora already had put on her best clothes and looked like a female Roman Consul, ready to conquer Alexandria. Only that Alexandria'd already been conquered. Damn Romans. Cleopatra and I sneaked after Adora, as she walked down the gangway and were heading for the way towards the grounds of

the Alexandrian palace. She and I were dressed in unobtrusive wear, our faces half masked with veils which also covered our hair. Cleo was perceptible grumbling beside me, and I struggled not to burst into laughter upon her antics. It was just too good to see the high and mighty queen of Egypt in that dress. “Now shh,” I whispered at her because she huffed again. We didn't need any attention to us. It earned me an angry “You shush,” from her. It got me to reply with another “Shhh” and so it went on for a half a minute until Adora turned around, her expression quite a Roman patrician, and called at us in Greek “You are very loud travel companions! I might have to look for other servants soon. This market seems a good fit for that purpose, even if it is only an Egyptian one."
Some passers-by around us shot amused or frowing looks, mostly directed at the angry yet beautiful looking woman in front of me, but nothing more. Nobles berating their servants in the public were thourougly common and even if only a quarter of them actually understood her, it was absolutely clear what just happened.
Cleo did her best to bow, mumbling a very half-hearted excuse, and I followed her example quietly, still trying to hide my chuckling.
Adora let her scolding gaze slide over us one more time and said in a bored tone: "The servants today are no longer what they used to be in the greater times of Res Publica. It is a shame. Maybe a few lashes are in order. Remind me of that when we're in private, will you?"
She turned back around and resumed her serene stride towards the palace, looking perfect as she was. Clearly, we should’ve taken this more seriously. I really tried hard not to snicker, while Cleopatra had an alike hard time to hide her anger. It was hilarious.

We reached the heavily protected outer gate of the palace grounds, where guards were overwhelmingly present. Be it because of Caesar's presence in the areal, our recent break-in, or the upcoming war in general, the security had been notably ramped up. Adora had put on her best Julian face, which meant

nothing less than a tremendous amount of arrogance, pouring out of her right now. She could come across really arrogant, you had to give her that.
She stopped before the guards and proclaimed: "I am Adora Diana Minor, daughter of Sextus Julius Caesar, niece of Consul Gaius Julius Caesar, and I am here to see my uncle. Report my presence to him immediately."
Oh goddess, I loved and hated it when she talked like that. Gone the insecurity that had tortured her when she made her confession to me and afterwards. Gone the cultivated restraint of her usual manners. Now, she was just a born leader, speaking to her subordinates, and I admired her stance. It was hard not to gawk.

The guards looked a bit overwhelmed and insecure, clearly not understanding all of what she'd spoken, but soon, one of them hurried away to call for assistance from higher levels of the food chain. It was clear she wanted to see someone from the Roman embassy or Caesar's entourage. It took a few minutes - rather because of the long distances than anything else - until a formal looking Roman approached us. Adora was tapping with one of her feet and crossed arms, grimly giving shits about the looks of the guards. The other Roman was clothed in a usual white tunic and sandals and was a rather small, nearly bald-headed and well-fed man. Obviously no soldier, but maybe an advisor or household slave to Caesar himself.
It became blatant that Adora and he knew each other when she loudly called "Posca!" and he replied with a relieved "Adora!" [56]
She hugged him shortly, an unusual gesture in the public, but they seemed comfortable with it. "So it is true, uncle Gaius is here? I only heard of it and came here immediately to see him," she asked.
Posca collected himself, obviously not expecting Adora to be here. "Apologies, domina. I had no idea you were in Alexandria. We thought you were still in Antiochia, with your father."
"Huh?" Adora let out. "But… my father and Caesar sent me here? I mean, how could he not know?"
"It is a mystery to me too, honestly. I mean, you know I'm

reading most of your uncle's letters, and writing the better part of them. So I should've known. But he didn't say a word to me, I promise."
"That is… strange, actually. But only another reason to talk to my beloved uncle."
Posca pointed with his head to us unusual quiet, humbly looking servants and asked: "Have you pleasured yourself with some Egyptian slaves while strolling around, Adora?"
Adora impressed me with her witty reply: "When in Egypt, do like the Egyptians, right? Both of them are trained in the arts of defense. I thought it could've given a wrong impression if I walked around with two contubernia of legionaries behind me, right? But I obviously misinterpreted Gaius' intentions, and I vow to behave in the more common Roman style of these days."
Posca was shortly baffled, then started laughing. "Yes, he may have gone too far. But the situation is also pretty dire, and he needs to look strong. We haven't even enough—" He cut himself short, considering his words, and it felt weird to listen to Posca's little slip-up. Adora quickly cut in. "So, where is my uncle?"
"Uhm… in the guest house of the palace, of course, studying some plans of action. May I lead you there?"
"Of course, immediately," she replied and started to walk on.

The chief of the guards stopped us by putting himself into our way. "Wait, who are your servants? We have to examine every visitor for weapons. They must reveal themselves."
Adora frowned and Posca shrugged his shoulders. "I mean, it's still Ptolemy's palace, isn't it?"
"This is ridiculous, they are my servants, and I'm not to be questioned by simple guards." Adora insisted, furiously. She tried to brush the request off, but I already had a bad feeling about where this would be heading. Nestling with my hands inside my sleeves, I got hold of the dagger I'd concealed there.
The chief repeated his demand with an added "On the Pharaoh's orders" and Adora folded her arms before her chest, just saying "No." Posca looked confused, not understanding the reason for Adora's stance. I tapped Adora on her shoulder and whispered: "Go! Take her." She turned her head, her eyes widening, but she

quickly understood that this wasn’t the time for debates. This plan had been our little secret, hers and mine. In case of difficulties, Adora should bring Cleopatra to her uncle, at all cost, while I would do everything necessary.

It happened very quick. Adora dragged Cleopatra to the side, clearing the way for me to jump on the chief guard, drawing the arm of the surprised man around to his back, and pulling him aside with me. The three other guards just stood shocked upon my crazy action. But it turned away their attention from Adora, who was dragging Cleopatra further, while I yelled stupid stuff to distract them. “Don’t move you fools, or I’ll kill him. And your mothers, bloody stupid idiots. How can one be so dull, to be overwhelmed by a woman. Your ancestors will be ashamed. Hey, what's that?" I pointed wildly at something behind the guards, and at first they were puzzled upon my nonsense.
Adora and Cleo had already made a good way and now vanished around a corner. Only Posca still stood aside, not understanding what mad action happened before his eyes. With my knife on the throat of the chief, I held them in check for a short while, cursing them and their relatives as well as their whole lineage of ancestors in ridiculous sayings like a sailor, until I was halfway sure that Adora and Cleopatra must have reached the guest house.

The guards had overcome their surprise and now formed around me, their eyes scrutinizing every move I made. My heart raced as I struggled to keep calm, knowing that any wrong move could possibly mean the end of me. Before they were ready to do something drastic, I let go of the man and the dagger at his throat as well, dropping it on the floor, and raised my hands in surrender. The guards seemed even more perplexed by my sudden submission, and I could see the suspicion etched on their faces.
When the chief approached to unveil me, there was no sign of recognition on his face. So, at least, they wouldn't draw an immediate connection between me and my sister. I tried to keep my breathing steady as I waited for their next move. Upon Posca's urgent pleas and his not so subtle hints about Adora's status, they

took and tied me up. The ropes cut into my skin, but I didn't flinch.

The chief guard didn't even try to interrogate me, instead, he ordered two of his men to lock me up. They shoved me harshly over to a bunch of barracks where the soldiers of the royal guard were accommodated, and up into a cell. It lay in the corner of the building that was devoid of staff or troops, and looked like it was commonly used for disciplinary action. The cell itself was small, with just enough room for a wooden bunk and a bucket for my waste. The walls were cold and damp, and the air was thick with the smell of old sweat and dust. Locking the door after them, the men vanished, laughing, perhaps about the crazy woman they just took in.

As I sat down on the bed in the darkness, my mind raced with all the possible scenarios that could play out. Would they torture me for information? Would they execute me for attacking royal guards? Or would they keep me locked up indefinitely, forgetting about me in their haste to deal with Adora? The cell wasn’t a deep hole in the cellars, just a room with a hardened door and bars before the only little window and a wooden bunk without a mattress.
For hours, I lay on the cold, hard bunk, staring at the ceiling and listening to the sounds of the guards outside. The only thing that kept me going was the thought and worries about Adora and Cleopatra and the hope that somehow, someway, they would be able to get me out of this alive. Finally, exhausted from the stress and the lack of sleep, I drifted off into an uneasy slumber.

The next morning, my attempt to draw any attention to me by calling into the empty hallway found an unpleasant end when a bald, tall and massive man approached my cell, two guards in tow. He was dressed in a long sand-colored cloak that covered him from neck to feet. A eunuch, obviously, and unfortunately a well-known one to me. Pothinus, Ptolemy’s regent, the main

responsible man for the ongoing war between the siblings, had finally figured out whom his guards had captured.

He grinned at me through the barred window. I would have liked to punch him in the face. “So it is true. Catra.” His voice was a normal low one, nothing like an Eunuch should sound, his arms were folded, and he blatantly enjoyed his view. "I didn't believe it until now."
“Pothinus, when it rains, it pours,” I casually retorted, acting more confident than I actually was. Of course the bastard reckognized me on first sight.
He huffed. “What brings you here, you half-bastard? You could've asked me for an invitation, your grace. I would've gladly granted you safe access.” Sarcasm dripped of his lips and his words only fueled the fire in me to punch him. I didn’t give him anything.
“Personal matters. I was just strolling around and wanted to show my company my former rooms in the palace. Trying to impress the girls and such with all the gold and plush. They were always a good mean to get under their dresses, you know?" I smirked at him. "But, eh… actually no, you don’t,” referring to his state as not-quite-a-man.
My antics left him unimpressed. It was clearly not the first time he'd been insulted like that. “Unfortunately, these are Arsinoe’s rooms now, and she seems to like them a lot. You didn't need them anyway."
“I couldn’t care less.” I yawned and propped myself up into a sitting position, trying to look unfazed.

“Why are you here, Catra?” His voice was all soft and gently, but he could neither hide his curiosity nor his concern very well. Considering his question, I came to the conclusion, that they hadn’t caught Adora and Cleopatra. That was a massive relief, making me inhale deeply. I tried to make some use of this feeling, lent back against the wall, put my head on one of my knees and replied sweetish: “I’ve come to confess my undying love to you.”
He actually chuckled. A little. “Always these manners, Catra. It's so disgusting. We could've been friends, if you hadn't been such a defiant little brat. But I can wait. You are going to talk, anyway.”
I lauged dryly. “Can you actually wait? I don’t assume that killing

Pompeius pleased Caesar like you thought it would, or did it?”
His look flickered a little when he answered. “We will see, Catra, we will see. So, tell me, where is your bitch sister? I would be glad to talk to her too.”
Never would I tell him anything about Cleo, not on my dying bed.“Fuck yourself. You’ll see her soon enough, she’s right on her way to get you, old dude."
Pothinus crossed his arms before his chest. “Oh poor Catra, her army is still in Pelousion and hasn’t moved a foot. So, no, she isn’t. There's nobody coming to save you."
His easyness irked me. I knew I should just kept my mouth shut, but my anger got the best of me. “Maybe she doesn’t need an army to get hold of you and your minions. She was always more clever than anyone of you. But you already know that, because that’s the reason you wanted to get rid of her the whole time, right? You just couldn't stand that she didn't let you talk over her."
He glanced at me with narrowed eyes, and I knew exactly what he was thinking. A loud cackle broke out of me, and it finally derailed him. “You lousy Nubian bastard. You’ll pay the price for your continued insolence soon enough. The day we'll behead-"

I cut him short. “I know you can do better than ‘Nubian bastard’. Don’t hesitate.” Then I coughed, because my throat was getting dry.
He picked up on it immediately. “Thirsty, princess?” His eyes were hard and cold now, and I could clearly see, where this was going. They would deprave me of food and, far more dangerous, water, until I would speak. And maybe even then. I knew he wanted to get under my skin, and it fucking worked, because I narrowed my eyes before answering: “You idiot. Have fun with this for the little time you have. Cleo is coming.”
His eyes searched mine and somehow, they found a hidden truth behind my boasting, or he simply put one and one together. “She’s here, isn't she? She’s in Alexandria, right? You want her to meet with the Roman general. You treacherous bitch, that—"
“You are the traitor, you gutless viper. My sister will have a lot of fun thinking about proper means to put you to death, that’s for sure.” He was about to reply, when metallic noises and shouting

from outside the barracks were to be heard, making us both to pause with our forth and back. Pothinus listened up. Loud calls and screams wavered through the windows, sounded of calls of officers and swords clashing, like a large fight broke out. “What —", Pothinus started, then turned at his feet and stomped away, his guards following him quickly.
“Come back any time,” I yelled after him, leaning forward, “I really enjoy our little harassment for the little time you have.”

After they’d left the barrack, the building went silent again, but assumed that not all of them were used all the time and maybe today’s guard was just understaffed, compared to previous time. Perhaps Achillas had drafted many of them away to his army. Anyway, being left alone wasn’t so bad at all, and I tried to put a picture together, judging from the noises I heard. A battle seemed to have broken out. There was shouting, mostly, orders being yelled by commanding officers, in Greek and Latin alike, but they weren’t comprehensible. But also metallic clinks from like people fighting with swords. The noises and battle went on for some time, maybe half an hour or so, but then it fell silent again, leaving me to my pondering and with a growing headache. After it was quiet again, I tried to get attention to me, and called for help through the barred window at the door of my cell. It didn’t work. My calls faded away in the otherwise silent building.

Somehow I fell asleep for a few hours, and when I woke up again, my mouth was dryer than before and my first thought was to get water. My dehydration wasn’t life-threatening yet, but that was coming, and I was definitely very thirsty, having had nothing to drink for a day now.
Keeping in mind what my father’d taught me when I was young, I tried to slow down my breathing and kept my mouth shut. Exhaling through the mouth was far more draining than through the nose, I heard him always saying. He hadn’t been an overly loving father, me being only one of several daughters and many sons. As one of this female scions with a later estranged woman, I wasn’t at the forefront of his fatherly care. But sometimes, on a few occasions, he took me on a hunt or a gathering with others into the desert, and taught me how to survive by simply showing

me things or how-to's. I liked those rare times of togetherness with this always closed and composed man, who never spoke about himself, let alone feelings. When I grew older, I understood that his duties demanded much of his time and attention.

With so much time at my hand, I fell into a train of thought that ridiculously quick turned out to reach world-shattering destinations. Because I realized a very big problem: no matter how much effort I had put into convincing myself that Adora wasn't for me, it just didn't help. The amount of attraction that this woman exerted on me was undeniable.
Adora had two sides: when in the public, acting around the people that had power over her life, she was kind, formal, polite, didn't argue much and was determined to please others, to come up with solutions disregarding her own needs or wishes. She always wanted to get things done and to deal with any problem that someone else threw upon her. This side of her had already accepted her fate, or at least didn't do anything to avoid it. It was likeable, but also drove me crazy because of the fatality with which the poor woman complied.
Her other side was the one, I got to know and like much better. This one was goofy, rough, lively, often relaxed, a bit clumsy and sometimes self-confident to an amount that it was almost obnoxious.[57] This side was the one that I had fallen for, the unpatrician, the one that was just *Adora*, a young woman like me. The one that I couldn't get out of my head and heart. The one that might have a crush on me, but wasn't sure of herself in any way to act on it.

I tried to roll around on the wooden stretcher to ease my aching spine, but the only position that didn't hurt even more after one minute was laying straight on my back again. Staring on the ceiling I asked *Oh, Cleopatra, what have you done to me?* Didn't you anticipate what could happen when you assigned me for babysitting… accompanying Adora? It couldn't have been a secret to you that I liked women *in this way.* And now I not only liked Adora, but maybe more already.

Love was a hard word, and I wasn’t ready but scared to use it, even if only in my thoughts. Speaking it out was unthinkable, of course. Maybe even thinking it was unthinkable. But the longer I laid on the hard stretcher and the more my mind got troubled, the harder it was to deny.

Evening fell over the world again, and despit it got dark outside, the heat of the day still roared on. It would take hours to get to a point where the temperature was moderate. I was still alone. Since Pothinus left, nobody had entered the building - or at least not while I was awake. Sometimes I heard some tumult from outside, but I wasn’t able to decipher it. It had been more than a day since I’d been captured, and in the meantime, something should have been happened between Cleopatra and Caesar. And Adora, of course. At least, a meeting, a conversation. And shouldn't they be looking for me? The guards had reported to Pothinus, and they should’ve also reported about Adora and another suspicious servant who made it, but then… nothing more happened. Maybe I was just… forgotten?

My headache strengthened over the day and the evening, which was a serious indication of my worsening dehydration. I didn't even have to pee anymore. My mouth and throat dried out, and I couldn’t even yell anymore. Any attempt to swallow hurt, as there was no moisture left. Knowing that soon my mind and vision would begin to blur, I tried to lay still, breathe flat and use as few physical activities as possible. And I tried not to fall into panic. Which didn’t work so well.

Over the next few hours, I felt how my state slowly deteriorated. While laying and doing nothing, I was clinging to one specific thought: *Adora will come for me.*
Of course, she will. Because unlike me, she wasn’t afraid to act upon her feelings.
She would come for me. She would come. For sure.

Adora.

Adora?

Adora

While I dragged Cleopatra forward to the guest house - or rather little palace - I feared for Catra's life. I hadn't questioned her order because getting her sister to Caesar alive and unharmed was the most important thing now. I'd agreed up front to do anything to achieve it, even if it meant to leave her behind. Catra made me promise it more than only once. She actually pressed me to swear it, or otherwise she would never speak to me again. I believed her, did as she said, and nonetheless, I felt horrible.

Cleopatra was a good runner, I had to admit. I didn't think of her as a very athletic person, but she kept up well, despite panting hard when we approached the building where my uncle resided. Her movements looked enticing, even under the cape, telling something about the tight, flawless figure beneath. When we reached the doorsteps of the guest house, we found it guarded by a contubernium of Roman legionaries, while others patrolled around the building. I greeted them with a formal "Ave!", accompanied by waving my right hand, proclaiming as formal as needed: "I am Adora Julia Minor, daughter of Sextus Julius Caesar, and I need to see my uncle. Now, it is most imporant."
None of them had ever seen me before, but they clearly knew to identify a Roman patrician woman and her stance. No sane person would use a lie like that. The leading legionary snapped with a finger, and a servant from inside the house hurried by. "Lead them into the Atrium and wait for Posca to return. He will decide." Two of the legionaries went behind us, as we were guided to the inside.
Cleopatra looked very uneasy now as she realized, that she'd de facto left Egyptian territory and entered Roman one. We'd agreed that she would keep her disguise until I explicitly told her to unmask herself, keeping the deception going as long as necessary. I assured her that I would keep her under our families' protection

at all cost, but her look was hypervigilant nonetheless. Which was… understandable. Probably for the first time since years, she was all on her own, with a woman she barely knew, her overprotective sister caught by her brothers men. She was vulnerable like seldom before.

We waited for a few minutes until Posca entered the Atrium. I nearly jumped on him when asking, “What about Catra?”. He narrowed his eyes and tilted his head a bit, but asked, “You mean the mad woman? They captured and took her away. I do not know where. But she's alive, or at least, she was when they took her. Now, you have to tell me: what was this all about, Adora? Your whole appearance here is quite strange, to put it mildly.”
I explicitly avoided looking at Cleopatra, who stood still behind me, eyes down to the floor, and pretended not to be there. “I will explain myself to uncle Julius. Can I speak to him?” My curt reply earned me a concerned look, by him, obviously weighing options, but he finally nodded and led us into another part of the building. We entered a small hall. It was decorated with ornaments and hieroglyphs on the walls, candles enlightened it, and at the other side of the room stood a wooden desk.
Behind it, sitting in a chair, my uncle.

Gaius Julius Caesar.

The controversial de facto ruler of the Roman Republic.

His head went up from reading a scroll on the table, and his surprised but steady voice called, “Adora!”
He didn't sound upset, just surprised, and I lightened up a little. At second glance I noticed how tired he looked. His hair had grown remarkably gray since the last time we saw each other, around two years ago, and more furrows ran through his face. But he still radiated his usual and calm strength, maybe more than ever, now, that he was in control of the larger parts of the Roman legions and the Republic. I rushed forward and let myself been drawn into a short and formal embrace. His gaze wandered over me, seeking for answers. “Niece, I'm wondering. What are you doing in Alexandria? I assumed that you were still in Antiochia.”

Straight to the point, as always. Like his letters, he wasn't a man of more words than absolutely needed.

I couldn't but to tease him. "And greetings to you, dear uncle. I am so glad you're alive. And well. And that you didn't set Alexandria on fire yet. So grateful, really." If a little sarcasm accentuated my tone, it was probably barely audible. Probably. Cleopatra let out a low chuckle and Caesar needed a second to come back: "You are right, Adora, apologies for my manners. My time is scarce, and I didn't expect you to be here. And handling all of this," he gestured around us at the whole scenery, "is a mess. But tell me, why are you here?" He treated Cleopatra like she wasn't there. That was to expected. We always did that with slaves. In this case, it was very helpful.
"About that, I'm deeply confused. My father told me that I was sent on your urgent request, the sooner, the better, to meet my future husband to be. I've been in Egypt for weeks now and assumed, it was on your behalf."
He frowned. "Hm! This isn't exactly what we discussed. I wanted you in Egypt *after* the situation had calmed down and not right now. This alliance is important, yes, but traveling in the middle of this war seems unnecessarily dangerous. I told your father this."
"He might have misunderstood you?" I asked, confused about the weird situation.
His frowning only grew, and he twirled the quill, that he had still between his fingers. "This is very strange. I think I should write him. Until then, you shall stay with me, under my protection."
I didn't want to discuss the delicate topic that stung me within the first few minutes. For that I knew I had to wait for a good occasion, without any rush and with some time to consider, so I went for the obvious: "Why are you even here, after your victory over Pompeius? Wouldn't it be more logical to head back to Rome and secure the Senate and the city now? I thought that would be the most important aim."
He chuckled lowly. "Pompeius did the same after his great successes of the past, and how did it serve him? Rome is our mother, but it is a capricious and treacherous one. The mob cannot be controlled. But my legions can. And the one who has

them, rules Rome as well, even if an ocean away. I actually went after Pompeius to capture him. Maybe we could've reached an agreement, so I'd been able to grant him a pardon, but this idiotic advisor of Ptolemy, Thod… Theo…
"Theodotos." Posca threw in.
"Yes, Theodotos advised to murder Pompeius to gain my favor," he scoffed, "and now he's just gone, slaughtered at the shore by these barbarians." His hands had turned to fists and his tone grew bitter. Exactly as I had assumed, the man had really meant something to him. Caesar took a deep breath and continued: "However, it is how it is. Pompeius is dead. The quarrels between Ptolemy and Cleopatra have to be solved. We need Egypt to be stable now more than ever. And I don't need a nation in rebellion behind the front when I turn to the western provinces. The Senate is weak, but not beaten. Metellus Scipio and Cato are still strong enough, commanding the western legions that weren't present at Pharsalos. They perhaps retreat to Africa and will rally again. And these Ptolemies can't handle their own kingdom well enough, it seems. So I'm here to settle all of this, before I can return to Rome."
I choked, because his words made me aware of the very reason I was actually here. "I see. So, if you - hypothetically - were able to talk to Cleopatra, you would like to do? It doesn't sound like you want to ally with Ptolemy."
He glanced at me with narrowed eyes. "Of course. I already asked her for her presence here, but she didn't answer yet. And her brother… is just a boy and his advisors can't be trusted, obviously."

"Uhm… good. Uncle… therefore, I might have a little surprise for you." I turned to Cleopatra and made an inviting gesture. "You can unveil, your grace."

So she did.
With an elegant and gracious move, the young woman brought down the fabric around her face and hair, and also took off the cloak, that had hid her figure. It fell on the ground, while her long, raven black hair flew down her back and fanned out. She wore a long white tunic that hugged her waist and barely reached

below mid-thigh. Her feet were in sandals. Without doing anything at all, her emanation turned from a humble looking servant into a majestic posture, radiating confidence and strength and something… else I didn't quite catch. When I turned back to Caesar, he seemed struck upon the sudden shift of weight in the room.
I took it as my sign. "Uncle Julius, the reason why I'm here," and gestured with my hands at her. "I have the honor to introduce you to the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt, the Mistress of Sedge and Bee, Cleopatra VII. She came on her free will, and with mine and the honor of the gens Julia, I promised her safe conduct. I am sure you will not dishonor me, as I consider her a friend of our family."
The lord of 30 legions turned his eyes to me shortly and narrowed them, understanding the full extent of the promise I'd made. I had bound him as well to protect her, while any consequences of her doing would hit me alike. Luckily for me, he was still stunned by her sudden appearance and his gaze quickly moved back to the very female Pharaoh, who now took the initiative.

"Egypt greets you, Consul Gaius Julius Caesar," It was a susurration. Cleopatra spoke with a friendly voice, warm, full of expectancy, soothing. Wow! How could she… even I was charmed by only such a few words. Her eyes shone as if she was about to see the most admirable thing that she'd ever seen in her life.
When I looked back to my uncle, I was catching a glimpse of shock and awe in his facial expressions, until he'd composed himself again and put on is usual stoic stance, replying: "What an unexpected honor, your majesty. I am delighted that you made the effort to come in person."
Cleopatra... fluttered her eyelashes. Really? What the fuck… I inwardly scolded myself for thinking like that. Some of Catra's manners must've rubbed off on me. But was Cleopatra really doing that?
"Unexpected? Your orders were very… precise it seemed to me. You demanded my presence, and here I am, at your mercy."
Cleopatra folded her hands before her lap, and I was sure she was half teasing, half serious upon her words.

My uncle clearly got the message right. The master of war he was had an amused glint in his eyes and the tiniest smirk at the corner of his lips when he replied: “I apologize for my rude invitation. It surely wasn’t an order. My intention was only in the best interest of Egypt—"
She cut him short, reciprocating his smile with big, dark eyes and her voice was just *melting* : “It certainly was, and I have no doubt that Adora’s word is not taken lightly.”
Now they emanated a certain graveness, like two predators, circling their prey in a playful yet earnest manner. Caesar nodded. “Of course, your grace. Adora spoke for the gens Julia and I gladly oblige. You are a guest, and I as well as the Senate and the Republic of Rome are bound to it.”
“Oh, are they?” She only teased him lightly, and it looked like Cleopatra understood the message and got less tense upon his assurance.
Caesar, now deeply earnest, replied: “They surely are. Take my word for it.” Everything regarding his honor and in extension the honor of his family had been of the utmost importance for him, ever since his first steps on the ladder of power. Wisely, she decided not to poke him further, and tilted her head very slightly, just a little more than a simple nod, but not a bow. And they looked like they had a certain kind of understanding. My instinct told me that something important had shifted in the surrounding atmosphere, like a significant event had taken place, a victory had been won, a conquest had been successful. I couldn't make out what it was, I only knew that it had happened.

Nonetheless, I eased and mustered the courage to speak about my now most urgent matter. “Uncle, there is another topic to be handled with haste. In order to get into the palace, we kind of… lost Cleopatra’s sister, a woman named Catra. According to Posca, she is in custody of the Egyptian guards now, but we don’t know more. We need her to be freed before Ptolemy or Pothinus get a hold of her.” I glanced over to Cleopatra to seek for assistance. If there was a short hesitation to step up, it was barely noticeable, then she nodded, adding: “Yes. It would be… difficult if Catra can be used as a bargain. It would allow them to put pressure on me.

We need to find a way to get her back."
I had to restrain myself from turning to her and frowning too openly. Was that all that Catra was to her? A potential leverage?
Caesar slowly nodded, obviously trying to process it, then he looked over to Posca, who had followed the entire conversation hidden in the background, picking up the hint immediately: "I don't know more than already told. The guards captured the other woman, Catra, I now assume, and presumable brought her to a prison. We don't know where, though."
I looked forth and back between Caesar and Cleopatra. Both of them shared looks that I didn't understand, and I was confused. Despite my own wishes, getting Catra was the important matter right now. And when my uncle started to talk, it only confused me more.

"My original plan was to execute the testament of your father," he nodded assuringly at Cleopatra, "and to have you and your brother on the throne of Egypt again, in mutual regency."
Cleopatra didn't look very pleased, started to open her mouth in an attempt to speak up, but Caesar tilted his head a little, raised his hand, palm outside and gestured her to wait. Interestingly, she did, clicking her mouth shut. It was remarkable to see that even she behaved like a girl by the authority of my uncle, a man branded by decades of warfare and political tactics. "But after what his faction has done to Pompeius, I'm not so willing anymore. It is an unforgivable barbarity." He turned his hand around to invite her to speak: "What would you recommend, your highness?"
Cleopatra had narrowed her eyebrows. It was visible that she was annoyed by his exertion of dominance, yet she needed him.
"What do you want to hear from me? That this was a bad idea from the beginning? Because it was. Mutual reign will only end in a disaster. There's plenty of proof throughout our history. Egypt has to be ruled by *one* leader. In this case, by me." Now it was her turn to cut him short. "But! But, if it is what is needed to get my throne back, I am willing to try, as long as my brother is freed from unneeded and ill advice."
"And with that, you mean…?"

“That Pothinus, Achillas and Theodotus have to be stripped of their ranks and best be executed. Without their influence, I can handle my brother then. After all, he’s just a thirteen-year-old, a mere child. He hadn’t dared to question my power if it hasn’t been for his councilmen, his regent Pothinus foremost.” It was just a glimpse of Cleopatra’s nature, to be seen at this very moment of pressure and vulnerability. She had nothing at hand here, no real power, no troops, no guards at hand. Even I didn’t matter in this grand scheme, because all power in this room solely belonged to my uncle. He could even take Egypt, if he wanted. Nevertheless, somehow she made it look like that she was the one in charge, leading the conversation with ease and gracefulness on her own authority. Despite her age, the woman was sheer willpower.

Caesar tagged along for the moment. “Let’s say, I side with you for the time being, would you secure the grain deliveries to Rome, and keep your kingdom at peace? You must understand that it is of importance that I have not to be worried about a rebelling nation in my back. Your grain ships must keep sailing."
The underlying question was, if Cleopatra would act like an ally to him. Not to the Roman Republic in general, but to Caesar in particular. Because for him, both seemed to be the same, but him being the more relevant and stabilizing factor there, at least in his own assumptions.
Cleopatra stood straight before him, had crossed her arms before her chest, and smirked. She wasn't amused, though. “Again, what do you want to hear? Of course, I would. What other answer could I give, here, where I'm completely at your mercy.”
“Fair point, your highness,” he replied coolly.
She waved with a hand and rolled her eyes, sighly loudly. “Ugh! Spare me the highness. I am Cleopatra. Don’t call me Cleo.” Had she just blinked at him?
He huffed a single laugh. “I will surely remember it, Cleopatra,” Caesar retorted and both shared a weird looking smile. All of Cleopatra's doing had been an act, I clearly recognized that. Women did that all the time when dealing with men. But it hadn't been an act of deception, rather of enticement, and all of it was

aimed at my uncle. Was he too playing this game? He never seemed to be the type to.

However, I'd followed the whole exchange with a growing unrest and confusion. How was all that idle political chat going to help Catra? We had to act now, before worse things would happen to her. Barging into their stares, I voiced that to both of them. Very loud.
“I’ll come to that shortly, Adora, just a little patience, I beg you,” Caesar insisted. I nodded, knowing how grim my expression had turned. The slow talk of the two started to unnerve me.
He turned back to Cleopatra. “Your army is at Pelousion, right?” What had that to do with Catra, with anything?
Cleopatra perked up, nodded, her arms still folded, and Gaius added: “And your brother has how many men before Alexandria now?”
“Around 20,000 by foot and 5,000 of cavalry, we assume,” she rattled it off with easy, now firm, like a commanding ruler.
Caesar nodded. “So, around four legions. And this is the main point. I have one understaffed legion, 4,000 men, of which around 3,000 are ready for battle. I cannot defeat the Egyptian army in an open fight, but have to use other means of winning this. Thus being the reason for me trying to negotiate a treaty or solution without a battle or war. I'd need two months or more to bring enough of my legions."
“You have me,” Cleopatra deadpanned, shortly, "and I can have 10,000 men here within three days, too."
He bowed his head just a little. “This is assuring, but it might not be enough, your grace. I think, we need to get a quick hold of the palace and secure the area with my men. Then we can try to cut your brother off of his advisors and transfer the power back to both of you. With the palace under our control, we can try to gain control over more parts of the military and political assets. And we can possibly search for your sister as well.” It was clearly a second thought to him, but he looked at me, and actually... it was more than I had expected. “Wow. I mean, wow! Are you… are you really considering taking over the palace of Alexandria? Today?” I asked.

He nodded. “Tomorrow, but of course. Fortes fortuna adiuvat, Adora.[58] This situation will develop quickly. We need to be ahead of it.”
I maybe needed time to let the realization of my uncle’s doing sink in, but Caesar lost none of it. He quickly rallied a few of his commanding officers at hand and ordered them to gather his troops and to made camp east of Alexandria, right before the Gate of the Sun[59] at the eastern entrance to the city no later than tomorrow at sunrise. Then they should enter the city and occupy the palace grounds immediately.

Coincidence or not, only minutes after his men had left, another guest was announced by Posca.
Pothinus was ante portas, accompanied by half a dozen of his guards. Without any word, Cleopatra immediately put up her veil again, covered her face and hair and retreated into the shadow of the left archway. She was only a dark figure there, still visible if looked upon, but nothing more than another slave. Caesar shot Posca a confirming look, whereupon the bald slave went to let Pothinus in.

Ptolemy’s regent, the main force behind the current war between him and his sister, wasn’t the most impressive man regarding his looks, nothing like my uncle. But still, the tall eunuch had a firm presence and clearly acted as if on his own territory. Which was true, technically. “I apologize for the late interruption, Consul. But a minor incident came to my attention and I have to investigate it. Two women, with the help of a third one, have sneaked into the palace grounds and one of them used a name of your family as a disguise. You don’t know something about this happening or their whereabouts?”
My uncle’s gaze was bored and his voice annoyed. “If this incident is so minor, why does the chief advisor of a king have to investigate this at this late time?"
Clearing having expected the question, Pothinus quickly replied: "It's a personal matter."
Caesar sighed, waving his hand at me. "Well, I actually do. My niece, Adora Minor, wanted to see me and was hindered by your

incompetent guards."
Pothinus was all diligent: "Ah, my apologies. But she wasn't. She only refused to let my guards check her company, as instructed. Everyone—"
"Then this is maybe just a misunderstanding," Caesar cut him off, overly polite and sarcastic. "But let me help you clear this up. Roman citizens aren't to be examined by your people, Pothinus. Roman's aren't even to be touched by any Egyptian. We don't want to give the Senate even more reasons to doubt the loyalty and imperturbable friendship of the Egyptian nation, or do we? Because the Senate is very concerned about the well-being of every Roman citizen in Egypt at the very moment." Had he sounded sarcastic at the beginning, he'd turned grim at the end. This was nothing but a threat, and I liked it. I didn't like what he'd planned for me, but I was enough of a Roman to like this display of power.
If it got me Catra back, I liked it very much.

Pothinus on the other side… didn't. The regent narrowed his eyes and considered his next words, obviously up for a hard response. But still, I had to know where Catra was and couldn't hold myself back, so I cut in: "Where is my companion?"
Pothinus focused on me. "We will look after her and deal with her in the morning, after everyone had time to calm down. Besides, we don't have a hurry. It is late."
I nearly cussed at the slimy creep: "It wasn't late enough for you to pester us here, and there is nothing to calm to down. You shall release her. She belongs to me, she is *my* property."
That was a bit stretching, and the possessiveness in my own words made me feel weird, but whatever.
He didn't back down, just hissed back: "The crazy woman attacked a guard. Usually, slaves that do that are beheaded the same day. She's only alive because your adlatus begged us." He spoke to Caesar at the end. "I apologize for the disturbance. We'll take care of that matter tomorrow."

Caesar slowly nodded and waved dismissively. I wanted to protest, but Posca nudged my shoulder not too gently and that threw me a little off track. I barely waited for Pothinus and his

men to leave until I asked: “What was that supposed to mean?” Upset as I was, Caesar’s reply didn’t register in my mind the first time, and so I had to ask again. “What?” He laid a hand on my shoulder. “Calm down, my dear niece. He wouldn’t have done or said anything tonight. He just wanted to check for our reactions, and perhaps take a look. That's just tactical. It doesn’t serve her if you draw too much attention to the matter. Maybe he doesn’t know who she is right now. We will free her tomorrow, when my men take over the palace. He will surely make his own moves right now, and given my reaction, he has greater matters to deal with than one prisoner.”

It made me furious. I hated waiting. But I knew, he was right after all. We wouldn’t have a chance by running around and trying to free Catra with only a century at hand, while Pothinus’ palace guard could easily overwhelm our forces. But everything in me resisted to wait until tomorrow. Somewhere in the palace grounds, maybe just a few hundred meters away, Catra was being held captive, maybe suffering due to torture. My hands were cold and my breathing was getting harder, because an iron fist clenched my chest. All of this was a nightmare.
Catra was in grave danger, as she’d willingly sacrificed herself to keep Cleopatra and me going. Trying to stop myself from spiraling into panic, my hands turned into fists and I focused on tomorrow morning, where we would try to get her back.

I had to. I couldn’t lose her.

Chapter End Notes

> All footnotes have been linked now. This works best when you read this in an eReader like ReadEra. There, all the footnotes are displayed at the bottom of the respective page, and also at the end of the chapter, and you can jump forth and back with these in-page-links. Which is quite cool.
>
> The chapter count has risen by 2 to 17 (18 with the prelude).

The next chapter is called **"The Siege of Alexandria II"** and will be published on Friday, July 23, 2021. With it's 16,5k of words, it will presumably be the longest chapter of this fic.
[52] The 'Denarius' was the standard Roman silver coin for around 500 years, stretching from 211 BCE until at least 250 CE. Every trade could be denominated in denarii. At the time of this story, a soldier or unskilled worker was paid around one denarius a day. ↕
[52-1] This scene of the series "Rome" gives you a good glimpse into the heated debates and the loyalty Pompeius still held for Caesar, mere days before Caesar decided to march on Rome and to cross the Rubicon with an army.↕
[53] I believe that this scene of "Rome" is an accurate depiction of Caesar's reaction upon the revelation. I wrote it before remembering about the episode, but the resemblance is pretty clear. I'm convinced that if Caesar had had more troops present in Alexandria then, nobody knows what he would have done at that moment. It is disputed that he honestly mourned Pompeius death, but given what we know about their relationship, it is highly possible. Caesar was as generous in victory as he was skilled and ruthless in warfare. Furthermore, Caesar strongly believed in the Roman virtues, especially the Imperium, and he didn't take it lightly or just as a tactical advance that Pompeius was killed by foreigners. This part is as much important, as I am sure that Caesar didn't want Pompeius dead. It's very possible that Ptolemy's council drove Caesar into Cleopatra's arms with that misjudgment. The scene also gives you a good image of Ptolemy, regarding his age, as well as of his advisors. Unfortunately, the series doesn't handle Cleopatra as good, because it depicts her as a woman in her early thirties, which is again just utter bullshit.↕
[54] Capsa, basically a roll that contains scrolls and can be sealed for protection. ↕
[55] Gnihihi… ↕
[56] The name "Posca" is another nod to the HBO series "Rome" of 2004, where Caesar's personal slave holds this name. He has a remarkable wit there and gives a good

impression of the relationship Roman educated household slaves had with their owners.↑

[57] This paragraph is a strong modification of a similar in "play me out", Chapter 6 ↑

[58] Fortes fortuna adiuvat ~ "fortune favors the brave", a Latin proverb referring to Fortuna, the goddess of luck and fate, but also life's capriciousness. Which is an absolute fit to Caesar. He only stressed it too much at the end. ↑

[59] The Gate of the Sun and its opposite, the Gate of the Moon were connected via the Canopus Way, the central axis through Alexandria which was around 2,300 meters long. We

will hear more from this later. ↑


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Gate of the Sun
Royal Quarter
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Campus Mag
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

The Siege of Alexandria II

Chapter Summary


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Gate of the Sun
Royal Quarter
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Campus Mag
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Alexandria, Egypt - November - December 48 BCE

Adora

A restless night lay behind me. I eagerly awaited uncle Gaius to take action and all my nervous energy hadn't let me sleep much. Half the night I rolled around and felt just like shit. Not that I used that word, but maybe I'd allowed myself to think it a few times. My worries about Catra spiraled out of control, to thoughts about her being tortured, injured, or worse. I tried to persuade myself that they wouldn't kill her, they would not, not if they could use her as a bargain against her sister. But not being able to fix this, to do anything meaningful until morning, was like being imprisoned.
When it dawned, I readied myself in a shorter second-best tunic and a messy ponytail, put my dagger in place and gathered Bow to drag him for us to meet my uncle in the same large room with the desk as yesterday. Never-sleeping Caesar was already there and spoke with an alike wakeful Cleopatra. The two seemed to have found a very mutual understanding of the actions they were upon to take. The spoke forth and back to each other, and his few officers standing by were just listeners. It was a little like two souls found each other, and I found it a bit scary. They seemed to… harmonize, so to say, even if she was decades younger than him. As we approached them, I heard Cleopatra explaining while pointing on a map, "…my troops to advance westwards, here, Hermopolis Mikra. It's near enough to Alexandria and Achillas' camp so that it will threaten him. It should force him to not enter Alexandria with the entire Egyptian army immediately. At least, he will have to split his forces."
Caesar nodded. "A wise move, your grace. However, my troops

will take over the palace today. We can’t let Pothinus and Achillas use the power they have over your brother any longer. The palace is an important symbol, too.”
“Agreed. I hope that your men can capture my brother and defend us long enough for your reinforcements to arrive. If Achillas ignores my forces and lays siege upon us, we won’t be able to withstand very long.”
“That’s why we have to act fast and without hesitation,” my uncle replied. “We need this conflict over.”

After some more talks, the meeting ended and Caesar waved at me to come over. “Adora, niece. How are you today?”, he sincerely asked.
I answered monosyllabic, and just wanted to get over with the small talk, but he surprised me with his next words. “I wanted to thank you for taking the risk of bringing Cleopatra to me. That was very clever and will probably help to end this situation without too much bloodshed.” His praise was nice, but my most urgent desire was to get Catra free. Even my own struggle had somehow vanished into the back of my mind, because I was so focused and desperate to free her. All of me longed for her to be safe, dreading the thought that anything could’ve happened to her in the hours of her absence. I was a giddy mess, and I needed something to happen now.

Caesar continued, unfazed by my torn expression: “But while we wait for my men to arrive and to take over the palace, I wanted to use the opportunity to discuss your presence. Because I didn’t order your father to send you to Egypt immediately. The matter of your betrothal has been discussed by us, yes, and I motioned for the alliance between the family and Egypt in order to get a better hand onto the land beside going into the next war or annexing them. But I didn’t want you to enter a war zone as of now. I would've never put you in such a peril.”

Of course, he would, he'd done that with our entire family since decades, I thought. But his open address let me wonder about the whole matter. Still, it was put into the back of my mind. Hadn’t I been sent to Egypt, I would’ve never met Catra. I vividly

remembered her lips on mine and with every passing hour without her, my desire just seemed to grow stronger. Ever since our kiss, my longing for her just soared and I-

Gah! This should not occupy my mind so much. Since we kissed at the tavern, she avoided me. So bona dea, why was I so torn? I was so confused.
"Adora?"
I startled out of my train of thought and focused on my uncle again. "Sorry, I was just… thinking. I suggest writing to my father to seek clarification? To me, it looked like he was convinced that you'd insisted on having me here as soon as possible, as you wanted to deal with Egypt without having to invade it."
The master of war nodded. "Yes. I actually don't want to take over Egypt as a province. You know for yourself that this nation is not like any other of the realms we integrated into Res Publica. Egypt is too rich and too powerful to be a simple province. Any governor or proconsul who rules Egypt would have a strong base of force at hand and could take over the eastern provinces with ease. The last decades have clearly shown us what can happen."
60

He nodded encouragingly and, strangely, completely missed the irony of his own words. Oh yes, dear uncle. You've shown us what can happen, I thought. It's exactly what happens when someone conquers a whole land, like Gaul for example, and rules it for years, away from Rome, able to built a home base when acting like a king for such a long time. Like you did. Or maybe he didn't miss the irony but thought that he only he would handle such a power in the best interest of Rome. My inner conflict between the pride I took in my gens' accomplishments and my aversion to his disrespect for the laws of the Republic had been always confusing me. It was a constant and strong reminder of my own family's involvement in the downfall of the institutions of Res Publica. They acted like they were the First and only Ones to rule us all. It made me doubt all of them.

He continued. "Egypt is an important ally, and we depend on its goods and wealth, mainly the grain supply. Their grain ships must

keep sailing, otherwise Rome will starve. But it is better to leave it as an independent, allied kingdom though, and not to become a province. The effects could destabilize the rest of what is left of the Republican institutions, and I'm not striving for that to happen." He strongly emphasized his last words, and somehow I believed him. In fact, in his odd way, Caesar deeply believed that the Roman state with its power distribution amongst the members of the Senate and popular assembly was the most superior way of handling a nation. It showed how he'd always tried to legalize his doing according to our laws and traditions. His problem was that he identified himself with the Roman Republic and the other way around. And that wasn't what a Republic was about. It was about sharing power, and Gaius clearly didn't want to. That was what my father'd said not long ago, in an unusual outbreak of his about Gaius' manners, and I'd remembered that.

"For sure," I seconded. "About my betrothal… wouldn't it be sufficient to have Cleopatra on our side? Why do we need the bond to some of her governors, however powerful he may be?" Weighing his next words, he pondered before speaking: "I understand your hesitation, Adora. But let me explain, and make you see the greater picture. Cleopatra might or might not stay Pharaoh for a while. She seems clever and competent, sure. But history shows us that the Ptolemies seldom die of old age. Why should she be so different? The governors, though, often rule their province for decades and Psamtik is a rising force in Egypt. My reports show that he will be a leading figure for the next decade and even longer, no matter who sits on the throne in Alexandria. The Pharaohs might change, but the governors will stay. Your presence here will secure the Roman connection to this force, and to this land." And with *Roman* he meant *his*, as our pater familia. "Beside Rome, Egypt will be the second most important place to be, remember that, Adora. Alexandria is the greatest city in the world. Egypt is the most productive nation we know. This is not a burden, it is an honor, for both sides. It will also keep you away from the murderous slaughterhouse our mother is today." He lay a hand on my shoulder, encouraging, but I couldn't stop a shiver running down my spine. "If you execute

this relationship well, Adora, it may result in governing an entire province like your father does it with Syria, only without the limitation of his term. You will be here for decades, Adora, and while you grow and enlarge your influence, this will give you and our gens power beyond your imagination. I have no doubt about that."

He sounded very earnest, and I suddenly understand a lot better why he was so successful as commander of his legions. But his words were also a clear reminder that all of this was just business for him. I might rise to that position, but he saw my marriage as an alliance of convenience, just as my family had always done it. He was just more strategical in handling it.

I could think about that now, and pushed the thought away. Too distracted by my worries about Catra and too giddy because of what would happen in the next hours, I couldn't hold a proper conversation about what my fate might or might not be in the long run. It was too far away, and there had to be time for that, later.
Caesar insisted: "I'm wondering about your little opposition, Adora. Not that I'm complaining, but why is that?"
THAT question caught me off guard, actually. The entire time, I'd wanted to get to my uncle to talk him out of this stupid idea of his. Now, that I was able to, I was just distracted by a matter that somehow looked even more important to me. Voicing that, I couldn't, it would've sounded ridiculous to him. The realization of the amount of attraction that Catra had cast over me was crumbling.
"I… I'm… I just want to solve the problem at hand first. When we… have freed Catra, we can talk about this matter. I owe it to her."

I felt the weight of Caesar's regarding look on me, possibly lingering for a bit too long[61], as he was obviously trying to read my words and maybe interpret the deeper meaning of them. But I couldn't talk to him about the weird feelings that I had developed for Catra - for a woman – because that was just not possible. Caesar would've reacted just like my father, only without his little

paternal understanding. Love was just no concept that played any role in their considerations. Neither did I for real. Ah, screw that! Love wasn't even a concept that had played any role in *my own* considerations. Until now.
But as all my thinking circled around Catra at the moment, I slowly understood that there was more to it. And that… that had to mean something, didn't it? Maybe I could talk with Bow about that, because on my part, I'd clearly reached the horizon of my wisdom. I filed that thought away for later, clearly trying not to dig too deep into that muddy ground.

Because suddenly, without a warning, the fighting started. It got noisy outside. Messengers arrived every few minutes, providing us with reports about the ongoing events. Caesars tarnished legion had marched down the Canopus way of the great city and directly approached the palace gates. They quickly overwhelmed the surprised troops that guarded the area in a trained manner, just like they always worked. These were some of his best men, marching across the known world for years, and they knew their work. And clearly no one on the Egyptian side had expected that the Roman general would take such a decisive and quick action, despite he was known exactly for this trait. As always, everyone underestimated his courage when it came to war. Messengers told us that his men already breached several gates battering rams, and now the cohorts started to take over the royal quarter.

Another hour passed by, as we waited, now from the landing of the flight of stairs at the entrance, to get a better picture. Caesar stood in the middle, Cleopatra right beside him. I was on his other side, Bow at mine. Two centuries of legionaries had already surrounded the guest house and guarded us, so we were safe from all but an arrow. The men looked sweaty and dusty, as they rallied around the building and cleared the area. Caesars listened to the reports of his officers that came and went, seldom adding something. His officer knew how to do their duties, and resistance was already crumbling. The palace guard had clearly been heavily outnumbered by half a legion. As the reinforcements from the regular infantry from the Egyptian army were at least one day's march away, we quickly gained the upper hand for now. Only the

large building of the royal palace was still being held by the guards, fiercely so, because Ptolemy was there.

I fisted my hands. We would get this under control quickly, and then I'd be able to find Catra, I promised myself, tense as seldom before while I tried to look unfazed, and not to scurry around the archways of the hall, trying to calm down. Bow took my hand and pressed it. It helped a little, but I was just too nervous.

The next important thing happened two hours later, and I was near a mental breakdown, shouted at uncle Julius to get his shit together and finish the fucking task of taking over the palace. Under Bow's scrutinizing look, I apologized to him only minutes later, embarrassed over losing my self-control.
"I very much beg your forgiveness. My nerves got the better of me. It won't happen again", I murmured with red cheeks and while looking at the ground. Luckily, Caesar was just too occupied with the ongoing events, so that he hadn't paid me much attention of making an idiot out of me.

Finally, finally, came the report of his officers that the Roman forces had succeeded, and the palace ground were under their control. But still, we should stay inside the guest house for some time, because hostile forces could still be hiding in several of the buildings. The palace of Ptolemy was still held by the royal guards, and Caesar wanted to take it over without bloodshed and to capture the young king alive.

The situation there hadn't changed in the afternoon, but we could start searching for Catra at the areas that were already cleared. No information of her whereabouts had reached us. No result in the sacked prison cells and the nearby barracks of the palace guards. There were other facilities too, but unused, and we needed to focus on the more important places, as the whole area was just too large to cover it with the few men we had at hand for a search party. Still, Caesars legion had swarmed out over the entire area, looking for undiscovered troops or guards of Achillas' men. More essential was, that the walls had to be manned and all the captives to be guarded, and several wall gates to be rebuilt as

soon as possible. So, I led my own guards and searched the palace guard barracks, while Bow led another troop of legionaries and explored the cellars of the accessible palaces.

But to no avail. Then I searched with Posca for captured guards that hadn't fled and to question them upon Catra. So far all without success and slowly, panic began to built in me. What if she'd been abducted to the army camp? Or maybe even worse, what if Pothinus found out about her identity and put her into some cell outside the palace or even outside of Alexandria? Or worse? The insecurity of her being constantly nagged at me and slowly drove me crazy.

I couldn't lose her. No way.

Evening came and still, no Catra. That she'd avoided me in the last days didn't play any role in my mind anymore, and I also didn't care that she obviously didn't repeat my feelings. All I knew was, that I had to save her, at all cost. But with night fallen and without any sign or trace of her, Bow forced me to lay down and to get some rest. "If we haven't found her already, it is very possible that she'd been taken by the guards and brought to the camp, Adora. You need to rest anyway."
"But we haven't searched all the palace. There are still places we can look for her," I tried to recoil. But I had merely slept the night before, and now I was exhausted, and he clearly saw it. "Lay down, Adora. There are still search parties underway, and they comb the area. If she's somewhere at the palace, we'll find her. You can't do this all on your own."

After running around the whole day, I felt how my limbs got weak, because I'd drank and eaten too little. My body just needed the rest. But even when Bow gently put me on the bed and sat beside, I nervously looked around and didn't know if I should try to sleep or to stay up and watch further.

He sat down beside me and put his hand on my shoulder to keep me down, asking: “What is this, with you and her, Adora? It doesn’t look like a normal friendship anymore.”
I winced at his words and felt so caught. “It’s not like that,” I whispered.
I could tell from his look that he didn't believe a word I said. “Oh, is it? Because it looks exactly like that, you know?”
It was nothing I could admit. “I just want her to be safe,” I desperately tried to argue, almost pleading. “She did so much for me, and now she’d been captured while she was defending us. I owe her.”

He completely ignored my denial. “Sure, Adora. But do you even know what you are getting yourself into? I mean, she’s Cleopatra’s sister and your situation isn’t so… untangled, too.”
I blushed heavily. “Bow! It’s—”
He cut me short. “Adora! I’m just saying that maybe having this kind of… experience with her is a really bold idea. Not because she's a woman. But because both of you are what you are.” He grinned lopsided and nearly apologetically, clearly uncomfortable with the topic. I opened my mouth and shut it again, and he continued after some mutual silence. “Hey, I’m not saying it’s a bad thing to feel like that. I just wanna tell you to be careful. She seems to care about you, as far as I can see. But that might be just a professional habit of hers, because personally… she seems to be very guarded.”
Oh, she hadn’t been so guarded back in the tavern, I thought, and maybe I smiled lightly at the reminiscence, but I also found truth in his words. Especially because of the time since then. “I… know. Or rather, no, I actually… have no idea what I’m doing here.” My words made me laugh awkwardly. “I only know, that I have to help her.”
And then I just blurted: “Have you… have you ever felt like being drawn to a person that is in your mind the whole day? You just want to be with this person all the time, and take care of her? Because with Catra, it’s like that, and I have no clue what that should mean. Really.”
He took his time and eyed me carefully before answering: “Adora,

are you talking about what I'm thinking you are talking about?"
"I… I…" I fell dry, not being able to voice what I was thinking. Deep inside, I might have already known, but…

Love was such a heavy word. Love was something from the 'I've read about it, but haven't experienced it' part of life. It was a thing, that happened to other people – sometimes – but not to me. I knew what it was, but at the same time, I knew nothing about it, because there hadn't been anyone to whom I felt attracted my entire life. My lack of experience troubled me now more than ever before.
"I like her so much, Bow. I won't— I can't lose her."
His hand gently squeezed mine, his look full of understanding. "I see. And I think, you already know what this means, Adora. If you feel what I assume you do, then be careful. We'll do all we can to find her. But being together with her… you know what I mean."
I tearfully nodded, sniveled, and took his arm. "I know. I know all too well. But first things first, alright?"

Darkness still enveloped the palace and its grounds as we stepped outside well before sunrise, the only lights coming from flickering lanterns and torches that were everywhere. Despite the early hour, the sounds of the Alexandria were anything but calm. There were densely populated areas around us, and the royal quarter itself was also full of people, and therefore, loud. All that was never quiet, even in this wee hours of the morning. The sounds of ships creaking as they swayed in the harbor, the clang of metal from dockworkers loading and unloading cargo, and the chatter of sailors and merchants already bargaining for goods filled the air. The sound of horses' hooves clattering on the cobblestone streets echoed through the air, messengers perhaps, carrying orders or weapons to the next battles. They were underlined with the rhythmic pounding of blacksmiths' hammers in the distance. Despite the palace's sturdy walls shielding us from most of the commotion, all these noises still seeped in, all the people radiating

them seemingly unaffected by the struggles of the forces that would ultimately decide upon their fates. If not now, then maybe another day.

Again, we searched a barrack in the back of a complex of buildings that had already been cleared. But somehow I had a bad feeling. I couldn't quite grip what it was, but it was there. The building looked like it hadn’t been used for some time. Dust was everywhere, the doors weren’t even locked or barricaded. We'd just walked through a few floors, when I suddenly realized what made me feel so insecure. “Bow, look at the ground. Before us.” For a second, he glanced at me, trying to catch the meaning of my words. But then he looked at the floor, and it was like if a light went on. There were only the footsteps from the typical Egyptian sandals in the dust. But none from the hobnailed Roman legionaries. And that meant…
“They didn’t search the building properly. Bloody idiots. I should whip them. I will,” I grumbled at Bow, and he knew I wouldn’t, but then again, on the other side…
Concentrate, Adora! Focus on what matters! Finding Catra matters! If she’s somewhere here, she might already die of thirst because of the temperatures. “Yeah, maybe they just opened the door, looked inside and saw an empty building.” We moved through the building and Bow found a staircase to another floor. “Let’s have a look, I bet that they haven’t searched there also.” We ran up the stairs and before us, the corridor split to the left and right to more rooms, some of them barred. “You left, I right”, Bow said, and we parted. I walked along the floor and looked, opened every door, searched every room, went behind corners. The last door was locked, but it had a little window, barely the size of a hand, to look through.

There she was.

A wave of relief washed over me when I peeked in. She lay on a wooden stretcher, seemingly unharmed, but there was no sign of life. Upon my call, Bow rushed over with a pair of keys and fumbled around with the lock until one of them fitted in. I nearly pushed him aside and kicked open the door. When I crouched

down beside her and touched her shoulder, Catra didn't respond. Her face was pale, the color of her skin had an unnatural gray shade, and there was no reaction of her at all. I felt no pulse, but then I laid my ear on her nose and mouth and registered a shallow, flat breeze coming out. I thanked the Roman deities for that she was still alive.
"Catra? Catra? Are you there? Hey, Catra."
Bow stood beside me and held me a water bottle, his face clearly worrying. "She must be dehydrated, Adora. Try to give her something to drink." I slowly lifted Catra's upper body by placing her on my lap while sitting down on the stretcher beside her. Then I put the bottle on her lips and dripped a few drops of water on them. She gave no sign of life. I tried to slip a finger into her mouth and open it a little. After some resistance, her dry and cracked lips parted. I put the bottle to her lower lip and ran a little water into her mouth. Immediately, maybe on instinct, Catra started to gulp it down, then she coughed lightly. After it died down, I repeated the procedure and let the half-conscious woman drink in many very little sips. After minutes, she coughed again and finally fluttered her eyes open. I was so relieved that I hugged the surprised woman to me without asking. Sheer gladness settled in me.
She licked her dry lips, and my reasoning just stopped when I saw it. Something in my mind snapped. I lowered my head to hers and brushed my lips against the chapped ones of Catra, softly, without force, only gently touching them while keeping my eyes open to watch her. After a moment of stiffness, she finally eased and kissed me back, weakly, without any demand or lust. But she kissed me back!

I heard Bow clearing his throat behind me. I heard it, but I couldn't care less. In this very moment, I decided that I wouldn't and couldn't care. Having her in my arms was everything that mattered. I waved a hand at him, signaling that he should leave us for a moment, and judging from the disappearing noises behind me, he just walked away.

"I was so afraid," I whispered. "We've searched the whole time, for two days. This fucking idiot of a regent wouldn't tell us

anything where he kept you. The fucking idiot— I could kill the bloody bastard—”
“Adora,” Catra croaked weakly, hoarse, and I’d never heard her voice being so little, so small, a sound endangered to be overheard.
“What?” I asked, while still caressing her cheeks, fearing every possible hard word.
“Are you learning to swear?” Her sunken face pulled the tiniest smirk I ever saw from her, but it was enough. I burst into tearful laughter and needed much too long to compose myself after. “Oh bona dea, I missed you so much.” Still, I hugged the weak woman in my lap and petted her hair. “I missed you so much, Catra.”
She didn’t move very much, just shifted a little to get more comfortable, her head lay against my stomach and upper arm, her upper body in my lap. Her eyes kept falling shut, and the whole time I gave her small sips to drink.
When she had enough, Catra looked up at me again, with her big, dark, mismatched eyes. Her gaze seemed to roam all over my face. How did she even manage to look so beautiful, after her ordeal? A faint but still smug smile appeared on her mouth, as she asked. “Do you like me or what?”
A laugh bubbled out of my chest, relieved, a little embarrassed, happy to have her in my arms. “You're such an idiot,” I replied, smiling broadly, and we continued doing nothing than staring at each other.

After a long moment, Catra quietly asked. “How long have I been here?”, evidently not having gotten what I already mentioned.
“Two days. Pothinus didn't say anything about you and all of his guards are gone, fled or dead. We had looking for you, but the stupid idiots screwed it up. They didn’t check the building properly the first time and so… you were just overlooked, until we’d checked it again.” My voice grew quieter and quieter the longer I spoke, and Catra glanced at me with wide eyes. “We?”
I winced a little. It shouldn't have sound like that.
“Bow and me. We went through the buildings they'd already searched,” I admitted, not really knowing why I felt so caught.
“We should've been faster.” Still, her eyes were wide. Maybe we

both understood the unspoken.
“What… What else happened?” she asked, hoarsely.

A small laugh bubbled out of me, I just couldn't help. “It's utter madness, you won't believe it. Caesar had his legion ordered to take over the palace. They overwhelmed Pothinus guards and drove them out of the grounds, Cleopatra took charge, and here we are. The palaces of the Ptolemies belongs to us Romans now.”
I playfully nudged her nose with a finger and smirked at her. “You are my prisoner, Catra Meritamun. Surrender to me.” The last words I spoke softly while cupping her cheek, smirking. Her look was something between amusement and mischief, and… a different emotion that ghosted her face just for a moment.
“Never, puny Roman”, she teased weakly.
“Stray cat,” I retorted.
She laid a hand on mine, the one still cupping her face, and said: “I think I’m gonna need a while and I might fall asleep again. Will you be there, when I wake up?”
I nodded earnestly and kissed her forehead.
“Promise?” she asked, tired, but her eyes searched for an answer, and I willingly met them. “I promise.”
She sighed lowly, and her eyes fell shut again, having used all her strength for the little exchange. I let her sip more water from time to time, but stayed silent otherwise and just waited for Bow to return with help.
In my opinion, it could've taken him longer, because while I sat there, enjoying the peaceful silence, I had Catra in my arms and lap and could continue to pet her hair.

When he finally came back with some men and a stretcher, Catra was fast asleep. It didn’t worry me too much. I had her back, and that was all that mattered.

We’d carried her back to the palace, where Cleopatra now had taken residence, after Caesar’s men overwhelmed the guards and took Ptolemy in their custody. We were given two rooms next to each other, but I just settled down beside her bed, where we had laid her down without waking her up. A physician looked after Catra, but his not overly empathic diagnosis was, that “she has to

drink water in little portions and shall stay in bed for a day or two otherwise.” Wonderful advice, I thought, because I clearly did exactly that since hours.
I’d been sitting in a chair beside her bed and had passed the time reading occasionally, feeding her little sips of water, or chatting with Bow, who looked after me from time to time. My mind had eased, now that I had her back, and I was just content with sitting next to her. Sometimes I found myself smiling at the sinewy, sleeping woman, to whom the color of her skin was slowly returning.
Cracking a weak grin, her voice was still raucous and a bit sleepy: “You stayed.”
I slowly nodded. “Of course, dummy. I promised to look after you, didn’t I?”
Somehow she looked a bit overwhelmed, as if she hadn’t expected me to keep such a simple pledge. “Shouldn't I watch out for you?” she teased. I wasn’t in the mood for her antics. In my opinion, she easily could’ve died of thirst because someone just didn’t do his job right. And the thought of losing her was… just of the question.
I put sincerity and earnestness into my answer: “You watch out for me, and I watch out for you. As long as we have each other, nothing bad can happen.” There was an underlying meaning to these word that I didn't want to explore in its full meaning by *really* wording it. But I squeezed her hand with strength and hoped that my eyes could transport the rest. So I tried to catch her gaze.

But after a few seconds, her smile faltered, and she looked down at her lap.

And then she withdrew her hand.

The rejection swept over me like falling rocks. I didn’t understand why, but it felt just *wrong*. *Why are you like that, Catra?* Why did she always withdraw, every time we’d made a step further? The damned woman looked like as if she wanted to pick up the exact same behavior as before. Oh bona dea, should somebody understand her, but I obviously didn’t.

Reluctantly, I took back my hand too, and was self-consciously aware of the ache that was clearly written over my face. It was just that I didn't care about that anymore, because I already'd made a fool out of myself. What harm could that do, then?
"But that feeling isn't mutual, or is it, Catra?" I desperately searched for something she was willing to give, for a reply, for a hidden hint that would help me to understand, that indicated that I wasn't alone with this feeling, that I hadn't been mistaken by my own weirdness and inexperience. I silently screamed for any sign of affection.
But there was just a blank face and a woman looking down into her lap, not willing to give me anything. There was no mutual feeling. There was no *us*.
"Whatever," she mumbled.

I couldn't take this anymore. Two days of little sleep, and a mad state of my mind because of my worry and anxiety about *her* wellbeing, clearly took a toll on me. But it was so unfair! I hadn't expected any praise or even a 'Thank you' for it. But I also hadn't expected this cold and repellent manner, again.
"Always closing down when it comes to the real thing, aren't you? Where is your courage now?" I asked, as coolly as I could manage, and thought I was barely able to keep myself together. And with my eyes watering, I stood up and went away without another word.

Catra

Three days later, Adora still hadn't visited me again. A servant had taken on the duty to watch over me, but with a lot of water and a little sleep, I recovered quickly. Cleopatra had visited me, too, even hugged me in the absence of any other people, then started to rattle about how well everything went with Adora's uncle so far in an excited, effervescent tonality. Absentmindedly nodding to

her chatter, my conscience was away, and I didn't really listen to her stories. Despite that I regained my physical condition quickly, I felt miserable more and more.

Of course, the feeling was mutual.

Deep down, I was sure that all I had to do was to go to her, to say that I was sorry. I was sure she'd willingly forgive me, as the kind and always conciliatory wellspring of sunshine and cordiality that she was. Then I could fall into her arms and let me be embraced, cuddle into her chest, and she would gladly and gently stroke me. I would whimper under her touches and while our lips would willingly meet, she would let out one of the soft little moans that she'd done when we kissed, back then at the tavern. It had been so wild, and demanding, and yet kind and caring. Of course, she would, because she was just like that. And of course I could do that, and I wanted it so much.

Only that I couldn't.

Her accusation had been absolutely right. I was… a coward. I hid behind my duties, behind her duties. But admitting how deep I'd fallen for this woman would cost me too much. We had no future. There was nothing to gain from giving in beside pain and grief, when she would be finally gone.

No, for the sake of Bastet and Osiris, I scolded myself! I was doing the right thing! We weren't meant for each other.

She had her duties and I had mine, and there was no use in denying them. I was doing us a favor in resisting this childish, unwomanly desire, and I was even more right not to give into something that of course could be more.
Still laying in my bed, I pulled my hair. Oh, dear Pasht, what have you done to me? Why me, of all people? Why her? I put my head between my palms and gritted my teeth. It just fucking couldn't be, that the one woman that I desired was already taken. Oh, Hathor, you cruel, callous goddess, why did you let that happen to Adora. She was such a lovely—

A short, stocky woman around my age peeked into my chamber and interrupted my self-pitying. Her bob hairstyle had a strange color, mainly brownish but with a slight hint of pastel pink in it. It looked a bit like it was sparkling. She wore a short white dress in Greek tunic style, her skin was pale, and her whole attitude was somewhat cocky.
"When you're done pitying yourself, Cleopatra would welcome your presence, your grace." Her voice was surprisingly full and not at all silent, and so I startled from pitying mys… from thinking and snarled an annoyed "What?"
"Her words, not mine." She let her scrutinizing gaze wander over me, obviously neither impressed nor content with what she saw.
"Not that I'm disagreeing." She furrowed her full eyebrows, obviously bored with the exciting job of getting me up.
"Now?" I asked while rubbing my temples.
"Of course not. Next year," the woman snorted, rolling her eyes and gesturing with both hands for me to rise. This day had an obvious good start.
Groaning and still with my head in my hands, I replied. "Haha, very funny. Who the fuck are you, annoying girl?"
"I'm Andronika. But you can—"
I cut her short. "You know, I don't even care. Tell Cleo that I'm on my way."
"Sure, your lowness." She was gone in an instant, and given the sound of her voice, she could also have spat in my face, I assumed. That was some sassy little freak, and I wondered where the hell did Cleopatra get someone like that from?

A short while later I found Cleo, Adora, and an older man who looked like carved out of stone, sitting around a desk in a smaller hall. He wore the uniform of a legionary, but with several insignia that showed his high rank, presumably a general. Numerous servants stood around to provide them with necessities, information, or to take orders and carry them out. Some of them were Cleo's, but just as many obviously belonged to the Roman general. The sassy little girl was another one, and Adora's friend Bow, too. Both glanced at each other with weird looks upon my appearance, irritating me.

“Catra,” Cleopatra welcomed me with warm affection. “I’m so relieved to see you alive and well again.” She didn’t hug me, but we weren’t alone, and therefore it wouldn’t have been appropriate.

“Yeah.” I brushed a lock of hair out of my face and sat down at the only free chair at the table. Then I mustered the man and recognized that I knew him. No, that wasn’t right… but his face looked familiar, to some extent. The shape of his eyes and mouth were…
I looked over at Adora, who hadn’t met my gaze the whole time, blatantly willing to avoid looking at me by studying a scroll – or pretending to. My eyes wandered over her lips – lips that I’d kissed eagerly – then it clicked, and I immediately voiced what struck my mind: “I am honored to meet you, Consul.” I actually didn’t know if that was the right form of address, but it couldn’t be *so* wrong.

Gaius Julius Caesar slowly bowed his head in recognition. “Catra Meritamun. I’ve heard many interesting and fascinating things about you and your accomplishments. I’m glad you are well.”
I tilted my head and replied: “The praise belongs to Adora. She hadn't given up looking out for me. Without her, it could’ve been worse. So, thank you.” And with that I’d turned my attention to her.
But said Adora just waved a dismissive hand and didn’t look at me still. It was like a little pinprick. Her denial hurt, and despite I might deserve it, I didn’t welcome it. Cleo shot me a weird, questioning look. I realized she’d noticed it too.

“What happens now?” I asked, and maybe only to draw the attention from this thing between us. Adora looked like she wasn’t too eager to jump in and stayed silent, fumbling with her scroll. So Cleopatra picked it up. “Caesar’s men are holding the palace. Achillas is moving the army before Alexandria, I ordered mine to follow, my brother has fled, but at least Arsinoe was captured. So far, nothing on the lighter news front, sorry kitten.”
In my opinion, that was quite enough. “Whoa. Looks like I missed some action.”

Cleopatra chuckled lowly. “Huh… just wait a few days. At the rate things develop, you’ll have a full-scale-war in no time. Then the real action starts.”
A quick “A bit cocky today, sister?” came easy. Then the information registered. “What do you mean with war? Has the Consul decided…?” I hadn’t forgotten Adora’s words about Caesar’s possible intentions for Egypt when learning about Pompeius’ fate. But the whole situation here looked different, and I was sure I missed some important parts. My eyes wandered over to him.

Gaius Julius Caesar bowed forward and let his hand move over the table in a gesture that could be interpreted as something like ‘tabula rasa’.
“No, Catra. I won’t invade Egypt only because the advisors of Cleopatra’s brother had bad judgement. I want Egypt to be a thriving ally of the Republic, no more or less.”

I narrowed my eyes. After all, it was good to hear that no imminent annihilation of my nation was lingering upon us by the possible invasion of 30 legions. But the wording of his sentence was… interesting. He’d said ‘no more or less’, by which he subtly emphasized the part of the sentence where the word ‘ally’ stood. Caesar wanted a *loyal ally* and *nothing less*, and he didn’t give a shit about Egypt thriving or not. Fair point, given that he was the de facto leader of the *Roman Republic*. But he also made his intentions clear. At least, to me. I met his gaze, he tilted his head just with the slightest margin, and despite I was decades younger and far more inexperienced, I knew that we’d understood each other.

And I understood something else too: this man was dangerous.

Somewhere in the ragbag of knowledge about the Roman world in general and Adora's family in particular, I already knew that. Caesar main business in the recent 15 years had been war, often outnumbered or at disadvantage, and yet he was *still here*, in the game, winning battle after battle and mind game after mind game. His strategic abilities were already legendary, and he’d

fought more wars than most living men would've even heard from. He *had* to be dangerous. But it's one thing to know and the other one to understand. Seeing him, I understood in an instant. Below the courteous and polite surface lay a man capable of any violence necessary to get what he wanted.

I nodded and replied casually: "I am relieved to hear that, really. It would've been… strenuous to rebuild Egypt for the inevitable revenge afterward. Such a waste of men, material and time. And think about all the inconveniences: building and sending out a fleet to ransack Rome, slaughtering people, ravaging Italian cities, burning down fields left and right, what an arduous effort, wouldn't you agree, consul?" Inwardly, I wasn't as chilled as I tried to sound, but I also wanted to get a better picture of this man. And Caesar didn't fail to meet my expectations, as he replied, grinning: "Sure, your grace. I assume there are plenty of other nations we can free from their incapable leaders before." He was joking, but it was thinly veiled, and the joke came from a man with 200,000 other men behind him. In him manifested most of the military power of our time. For the first time Adora looked up, only short, and traced my face, seeking for something I didn't know. Her eyes fell down on the scroll again, but I also noticed the little pull in the corner of her mouth.

She got it too.

An officer, presumably a centurio, approached Caesar and saluted with the typical gestured, waving his right hand from the chest towards the one to greet: "The regent of Ptolemy, Pothinus, wants to speak with you, consul."
Adora's uncle straightened himself and stood up. "Let him." The legionary saluted again and hurried away. Cleopatra and Adora stayed seated, and so did I. It wasn't like that I gave a shit about what the fucking creep had to say, and I would try my best to ignore him.

Pothinus entered the room with two bodyguards behind him, as always, the careful bastard. His signature dress, the sand-colored cloak, was as clean as ever, but otherwise, he made a rather

sloppy impression. He nodded shortly to Caesar, then his gaze fell upon the people around the table, and he visibly turned pale when he saw Cleopatra.
"You! How did you come here? Why…", he turned to Caesar and snarled: "Why are you letting her be here, that treacherous petty snake." Cleopatra said nothing, she just folded her hands before her chest and looked at Caesar, her face an impenetrable mask.
"She is my guest," Caesar interjected, "and I must insist that my guests are not talked about like that in my presence."
"This woman is a traitor. The Pharaoh himself had her removed from power and—"
Adora's uncle only lightly raised his voice. This man was clearly a gifted speaker. "The will of the father of the two clearly stated that they should rule together. What is your objection to that?"
"That is nothing of your concern, Roman. Ptolemy XII is long dead and current times are different. We have a Pharaoh and one is enough. She isn't even fit to rule."
Caesar folded his arms before his chest before stiffly answering. "To me, it looks like she has proven more common sense than your majesty, when he decided to slaughter the valued Pompeius Magnus like a low thief, a man seeking for shelter at your shore."
Pothinus hissed: "We apologized for this misunderstanding of your intentions. We thought it would be in our interest."
"Well, you judged wrong. Furthermore, as Pompeius and the Republic had lent your majesty and his father a large amount of money, I will now collect these sums on his behalf." He was met with wide eyes, and I laughed up my sleeves, as Caesar continued. "Egypt owes the Republic 17 and a half million drachmas, so it is of course of our concern that you are able to pay the credit back. Cleopatra had given me the impression that a repayment could be done soon. Do you have a different view? Or maybe an objection to *that* ?"
Wuuhuu… 17 million drachmas? That was much. As in *super very much*. As in so much that one could buy whole legions with it. A province even. A large one. Maybe Gaul. Or the one of Adora's father, Syria. Demanding the instant repayment of such a large sum, was… more than just threatening.[62]

Pothinus didn’t look afraid.
Instead, he rather started to look like he was in a bazaar.
“Potentially we could speed a partial payment up? Not that I want to tell you what to do, but this would of course need a significant action by you, consul. We’d need full authority of the capital and the palace, as well, to organize this. We need to be able to send out tax collectors without worrying that they are robbed. Usually, they are guarded, but with the current situation here… ? I’m sure you see the problem. If you could withdraw your troops from Alexandria, that topic would be easier to handle. Is this a possible course?”
He tried to make it sound submissive, but wasn’t doing so good at it. Now and then he shot glances over to Cleopatra, who still sat and just watched at the staredown of the two men. And Adora hadn’t looked up the whole time, had glued her eyes to the scroll. She was clearly listening the entire time, I could tell from how her head tilted, and her hands hadn't moved the scroll since Pothinus entered.

I sighed. It was ridiculous. Before me, two men argued in a discussion that was presumably leading all of us into a war, and I just ached for Adora's attention. When watching her, I noticed that a weird feeling had built up. I tried to grip it, but it always slipped away. It felt different from the constant pull that drew me to her and which I so desperately tried to get rid of and just couldn’t. *And wouldn’t, you idiot.* Like in the morning, somewhere, deep inside, I’d already realized that this was more than a simple attraction. I desired her, yes, but I also wanted to keep her safe, to make sure she was alright. To take care of her, at least, as far as I could, given the circumstances. But… what… if I could change the circumstances? Maybe there was a way out of this for her? Perhaps I could talk to Cleo and persuade her to let Adora off the hook? Without Cleopatra's approval, nothing regarding this stupid marriage would happen at all.

No. She wouldn’t back down. She’d initiated the whole idea with Adora’s *uncle*, both of them selling the poor woman like cattle on the market and when the thought registered, I recognized that my view of them both shifted a bit. Cleopatra was my sister – half-

sister, but screw the *half – and* we'd always had a strong bond. But her Pharaonic side, the stately one, the one that wanted to rule – at all cost – was something I'd never really understood. It was a colder personality that had never hit me, because there had been no reason for her to do. I'd followed her, all the times, because honestly, I just had nothing better to do as there was no other course for me that I wanted. Following her felt like following a meaningful purpose, and not a bad one.

When she entrusted me with a first mission, four years ago, I took on the task with enthusiasm. I want to prove her that I could be trusted, that I was an ally, and I didn't like her brother's advisors back then. Since then I just got used to do her bidding and honestly, I liked it. It gave me something to do, something to prove myself, to gather respect and to show my worth. Cleopatra was younger than me, right, but she was so much more born to rule that the age difference could tell. It was rather the other way around, or even more. She was the one with the greater plan, she was the one who knew how to scheme at court and beyond, how to plot and foremost, how to survive in an extremely *problematic* environment. I'd mostly been playing around and tagging along, sometimes executing her smaller tasks. Ruling Buhen on my own, without her constant influence and oversight, might have changed that point of view to some extent, but I was still just *Catra*, Cleopatra's sister, executor of her more difficile matters. And somehow I asked myself now if this was enough. Was it enough? Was I enough?
Would I even be enough for someone like Adora?

I startled from my ruminating when I realized that Pothinus and Caesar had begun shouting at each other, the former one yelling in rage: "If you ally with her, we will kill every last Roman in Alexandria, Consul."
"Enough of the big words, little idiot," [63] Cleopatra interjected for the first time, condescending in a way that expressed nothing but pure contempt. It was obvious that she really hated him. As Caesar didn't interject instantly, Pothinus took it as the sign that it was, then stormed, taking his guards with him.

Caesar wasn't pleased with her intervention, instead upset because he hadn't reached any agreement. It wasn’t quite clear at whom his anger aimed, but Cleopatra looked back at him, a little uneasy. I understand. Without him and his support, she was in grave danger. As we all were.
Adora’s look was unmoved, as if all of this didn’t matter to her. She let her eyes wander between Caesar and Cleopatra, then to me, then back to her scroll without any reaction. Her whole appearance felt somehow different, cooler, more absent than ever before. In my eyes, it was a wonder.

“And now?” I asked, hoping to be informed what’d happened.

“Now it's getting ugly,” Cleopatra replied, grimly, looking at the consul, and I couldn’t shake off the feeling that this had been exactly what she wanted. Caesar clearly wasn't pleased to be pushed like that.

The rest of the day went by in a strange blur. Caesar organized his men to guard the palace and Cleopatra sent out messengers, ordering her army to keep her brother’s one in check. Meanwhile, before the palace gates, a growing mob of Alexandrian citizens had started to gather. Word, that the Romans had occupied the royal quarter and that pharaoh Ptolemy had been forced to flee or held captive, spread around the city, and the citizens didn’t take it well.

And soon after, the real Siege of Alexandria began.

The smoke was annoying.

My unrest had driven me onto a watchtower behind the wall, and while I watched flames and smoke before us rise, I couldn't help but feel frustated. And hate. I hated its acrid smell in the air, how

it lingered and coated my skin and hair, my clothes, everything with its *stink*. It was suffocating. The memory would never leave me alone. It was as if the smoke was taunting me, daring me to take a step closer to the chaos that was unfolding before my eyes. Why the fuck had the dumb people of Alexandria chosen to set the buildings before the palace grounds alight? Made that even sense? Were they simply acting out of blind rage and desperation? Or did they want to prepare a clear field for war machines? In the city? Within firing range of our archers and scorpii[64]?

Not that we had many of them. Caesar's understaffed and underarmed legion had set up within the palace area, erected a makeshift camp, and now patrolled before and on its walls. Currently, they were not letting the mob of Alexandrian citizens get to close to the fortifications. I watched as workers scurried around, repairing the walls where they were damaged long ago, sometimes even risen when possible, and constructing ballistae and scorpii to defend against the impending attack.[65] These large war machines were intended more as a deterrent, useless against small troops, but they did have an devastating effect against larger groups of people. Like centuries. Armies.

But all in all, we were low on supplies, ranging from food to armor, weapons and machinery. And around us, in the city, a good part of the Egyptian army was moving in at this very moment. At least, Cleopatra's threat had worked so far, as Achillas hadn't brought the *whole* army, but only *half* of it. Which still outnumbered us by three to one. And the palace walls were by no means intended to withstand an actual siege against real siege engines like catapultae or towers.

Yesterday had already been a near breaker. Two assaults, not really well coordinated, but with a fierce and chaotic power had been just short of overwhelming the guarding troops at the southeastern gate. The citizens of Alexandria had been agitated and incited by Pothinus and his agents, and they raged against the Roman possessor of the palace. Now they started to erect fucking siege towers! Two of them had been pushed forward. Only in the eleventh hour a sortie of a battalion, that went - or rather

run - through another gate, then crashed into the side of the inexperienced attackers was able to stop the attack, or to let it rather falter into a turmoil of violence and utter madness. The towers came down and were burnt to ashes while Caesar’s legionaries withdrew when the immediate danger had been banned. But the mob still continued to burtn houses before the palace. It became clear that urban warfare in a large city was something a legion wasn’t very used to. But as we were all to find out, they would have time to learn. It had just been the start.

Two weeks had passed.

The siege had continued and transformed into a standstill, with only minor incidents happening every day. Skirmishes on the streets, between Caesar's men, Ptolemy's men, the citizens of Alexandria how chose the one side or the other, and other factions seeking advantage of a situation that could at best be called chaotic. But still without a single, decisive battle from the opposing parties. Cleopatra's army eyed her brother's face to face in the Nile delta, keeping him from invading the capital, but could not attack on her own without the troops of Adora's uncle. And Caesar looked like if he was willing to wait as long as it would take for his summoned reinforcements to arrive while he corresponded with his entire realm through an endless stream of couriers. His estimations wavered around one to three months, depending on the time his messengers needed to travel, his troops to assemble and gathering or building enough ships to travel. A land march wasn't an option for such a large army and would've taken twice the time. The continuous state of siege resulted in Cleopatra running around like an eager panther while Caesar remained as stoic as one could expect, and Adora… Adora avoided me. I couldn’t even remember the last time we’d exchanged more than a few, formal words at some meeting. Or rather, I knew exactly

the last time we'd spoken, because that'd been the day after she saved my life and when I showed her a cold shoulder.
I sighed.
We could've used the time in so many ways…

But still, I stood by my decision. Neither Caesar nor Cleopatra had made any indication regarding a change of their plans, and despite I understood the reasons from a strategical point, I wanted to puke about their motivations and was barely able to talk to Cleopatra on that topic anymore. Or about something else, for all it mattered. It was a new experience, to disagree with her to such an extent and on such an important matter, for the first time in my life. We weren't used to disagree.
Because only one time I'd approached her about it, and it didn't end very well. Since then, a few days ago, our relationship had cooled down. We'd been sitting in her room, one of the few occasions I caught her alone and without any of her councilmen, or the Roman Consul, which whom she tended to spend much time since they met.
I sipped at a mug of water, trying to put together some not too overly patronizing words. Again, I realized, how different I was from the whole high and mighty royal court stuff that Cleopatra'd practically inhaled since her birth. A wonder that she stayed such a normal person, relatively considered.
"Catra, why don't you just tell what bothers you?", Cleopatra asked, glancing over from her table where she sat to write orders, and it startled me out of my thoughts.
I caught myself from just rattling down about the very special topic that plagued me, because I knew she wouldn't understand.
"The situation is a bit… dire, right?", I began warily.
"You're talking about the siege? I think we're holding our stand quite good until now, given the odds." Cleo replied, somewhat relaxed considering the three times superior army lurking at our gates.
"No, I mean… with Adora." I pressed the words out, not sure where to go next. She looked surprised. "Might want to explain? What's with her?"
I sighed, not wanting to talk but having to. "I told you that she's

genuine. Her father and the Consul are serious about their offer.”
The Pharaoh hummed. “That much we knew already. But you have to admit that my worries were legitimate at the beginning. It was just too good to be true. It still is, to be honest. She's worth her weight in gold now that Caesar will soon rule over the entire Roman Empire.” She shrugged her shoulders playfully, but she meant it dead serious.
“Sure,” I agreed. “But why is that marriage necessary, then? You are on good terms with Caesar, aren’t you? Isn't that enough? Why do we have to force her?”

Cleopatra’s eyes narrowed, and her gaze pierced me for the search of deeper meanings. “Why are you asking this, Catra?”
Even her voice was a bit less casual now. I tried to brush it off.
“Because it looks unnecessary to put her into such a thing? I—”
She cut in, harshly. “It isn’t unnecessary. We need the formal bonds with the gens Julia, now more than ever. Caesar won't be here for the rest of his life. And Adora will be used by her family in one way or another. For her, there is no way out. The Romans and especially the Julian’s won’t waste such a valuable asset like her in a less important relationship. She doesn’t get to choose her fate, Catra, she just has to serve it!”

I spit it out and sounded bitter. “Is that all that she is to you? A tool? A weapon? Someone not allowed to decide upon her own fate?”
Cleo sounded all stately now, her Pharaonic side on full display. “It doesn’t matter what she is to me, sister. It matters what her family is going to do with her, and therefore, it’s better that it serves us than anyone else.”
Closing my eyes and taking a deep breath to gather some chill again didn’t work so well. I surely got the logical reasoning behind her words. It wasn’t that hard to understand. Nonetheless, it was totally unfair. It made me furious, angry, and the realization the Cleo wouldn’t back down made me fall into the dark, and I panted.

“Why are you so interested in this, Catra?” Cleopatra asked, her voice searching for an answer. I stuttered, and it was painful to

hear myself: “Because… She’s…”
Her eyes dilated, and I knew immediately that she got it.
“Do you like her?”
“What? No, it’s not because I like her. She’s—”
First, Cleopatra put a hand before her mouth to stop a laugh, then she clapped her hands in excitement. Her usually composed expression derailed into a smug yet playful laughter. “Of course you do. Oh, by the grace of Hathor, you really like her, don’t you?”
“Cleo! Shut up.” My reply was as weak as my limbs, and Cleo surely didn't back off, as she patted her knees and started to cackle. “Oh Catra, this is so embarrassing for you. You’re crushing on the poor woman. How could you?” She continued laughing and didn’t really get how my face grew sour more and more. “I can’t even remember that someone got your—”
“This is NOT FUNNY, Cleo!” I yelled, embarrassed, yes, but angry too, and my face was heated. Because this wasn’t funny. Adora wasn’t just some anonymous pawn to be moved, she was a person. A person! At least, for me. I cared for her, even if I hadn't been able to admit it to anyone until now. Or ever. Cleopatra didn’t look at her the same way I did. She barely knew her, while I had kissed…
Cleo stopped laughing. “Hey, calm down. Why are you—”
“Because she’s a PERSON, Cleopatra! She’s a fucking lovely person, and everyone just sees her as some good to be traded at a market stall. The fuck!” I yelled at her. “It’s disgusting to do this to her.” I panted. Heavily. My hands were fisted. Anger poured out of me, my vision was blurred.
Cleopatra stared at me for a long moment, then visibly cooled down to a more formal and less personal attitude. I already hated what she was going to say. “Of course it is, Catra. You think I don't know? I know. I'm still formally married to my brother, if I might remind you. All that doesn’t change anything. High-born Romans” – she didn’t have to add the word *female* to make it clear – “are not free to choose. Their concept of forming ties via marriage is not so different from what we do here with our brother-sister-thing. It’s just more formal and patriarchal and includes all the patrician families. Rome is basically a clan-run-

empire if you think of it like that. You should really know better than to crush on her. She is not for you."

Her last words hit me like a punch in the face, and my eyes widened because of her chill, analytical voice. I understood her words, but locked my gaze with hers and pointed with my index finger. "You talk like all of this is inevitable. As you don't have any say in this, Cleo. But you have. You could do something about this. You just decided not to because you don't want to. This is on you." My voice also grew cold at the last words. The whole talk had gone downhill since the beginning, and this was just another brick in the wall. We'd never disagreed or argued like that before.

Cleopatra trembled upon my accusation and clearly tried to compose herself to not burst out in anger. She clenched her jaw. Her hands fisted into her gown. I was still breathing heavily and searched for words, trying not to get handsy with her. I didn't know what to do. She *deserved my anger,* I thought. She deserved to know what I thought. But when Cleo replied, she barely contained her suppressed anger. "You don't have the full picture, Catra. That's okay. I heard your complaints and understand them. But don't you dare to voice them in public." After a few more seconds of staring, she walked back around her table, sat down, and grabbed a scroll, pretending to start reading. Then she added: "Maybe you stay away from her for the time being. It doesn't seem you're able to handle this childish crush otherwise." She waved with her hand like she released a servant.

This talk was over, that much I understood.

I needed a minute to calm down enough to finally rise and leave the room. When I said "Your highness" as a salutation, it might have been the first time that I used this phrase on her. I noticed how she stared after me. Back in my room, I sat on my bed and tried to calm myself by staring at the wall. It didn't really work. Punching the bed didn't either.
When I recalled Cleo's cool dismissal of myself, just waving her hand without any sign of affection or even care and how that had *hurt*, I realized another thing: This was how Adora had to feel

when I pulled my hand away. I'd done the exact same thing to her.

"Hey Catra. You look a bit… broody. What's going on with you?" The other day, Bow found me sitting under an awning in one of the smaller courtyards that were sprinkled over the entire palace grounds. Here, a few palm trees, flowering bushes and neatly arranged pots with different colored plants loosened up the all bombastic pillars-and-archways-buildings. I'd withdrawn to this rather remote yard to get some peace and be able to think. And to not run into Cleo. Or Adora. The nice view over the ocean should've supported that honorable task, but unluckily, it didn't help much. After I'd left Cleopatra we had not reconciled, and our argument nagged on me. We'd always had a relationship of the more defiant, come-hither side, seldom stressing the differences in rank. Usually, she asked me for help and I just did it, lacking any other motivation and because – very often – I had fun with it. She was the one with a plan, and I carried it out. That had worked for us.

One time, she wanted to discredit one of her brother's advisors and get rid of him – nicely, meaning, not murdering him. So I organized a little evening event and later *incident* with the man ending in a rather compromising situation, including a goat, a well-known drunkard, and the royal nightgown for the day. He was now overseeing a tax office at the Moeris basin, because he was in fact an excellent bureaucrat. Not clever and strong enough for the court, but too good to waste his talents.
Pondering about the past led me to a realization: I didn't remember if I ever demanded anything of Cleopatra in return. Should I've even? Of course, no. She was Pharaoh, I was her sister, she had a plan, I had none. It should be and stay that

simple.
But nonetheless, this time it felt different. It felt… *wrong*.

I winced and shrieked when Bow laid a hand on my shoulder. He immediately withdrew, and I noticed that he must have spoken a few times. I managed a somewhat amicable smile. "Sorry, I was just… thinking."
He must've searched for me, because there wouldn't be another reason to walk around *here*, in this particular part of the vast palace. "How are you?"
I sighed. "It's fine Bow, everything's fine."
"Sure," he answered flatly and after waiting for a few seconds to make his disbelief obvious. He folded his arms before his chest. "So, Catra. About the brooding, what's going on with you?"
"Ugh! Repeating yourself doesn't make it better."
"Oh, I don't know. I can be persistent if needed. And it's not that we've anywhere to go today, you know, because of all this 'being-besieged' and stuff." He winked. For someone caught in the same trap as I, he took it a bit too light.
"Yeah. Sorry for the inconvenience of having a hostile army right before the walls during your visit. I'm devastated. I would make an offering to the gods, if it would help, but somehow, they don't seem to listen to me." I shrugged my shoulders.
"To me, it seems, that the hostility inside the walls is pretty much enough, isn't it?" Bow said, but his voice was still friendly, despite the rather harsh words. "Catra, I can clearly see that something between Adora and you must have happened. I can only assume what it is, but one of you has to talk to me. Because the tension is killing me."

I closed my eyes. Even if I liked him and even if he was Adora's companion, this had nothing to do with him. We barely knew each other. "Then talk to her. You know her better than me."
He nodded. "Yeah. And I know when she won't say anything. And she doesn't. You may have noticed that she's usually pretty talkative? Now she barely talks at all, and that's nothing like her."
"Doesn't sound so bad if she's a bit quieter than usu—"
"She doesn't even sleep anymore, Catra," he insisted.
What? "What… what does that mean?" I stuttered.

His gaze scrutinized me. “She often tosses and turns in bed and is too adjusted to sleep peacefully. She denies it, but I've caught her doing it a few times. Haven’t you looked at her?”
“No? Adora’s avoiding me. She's always hiding somewhere and when we see each other at dinner, she doesn't speak at all. At least, to me. So you see, it’s fine. Everything’s fine.” I scoffed.
Bow made an understanding nod before replying: “And… you are wondering why exactly?” Huh, that was some frank answer, but I was beyond caring about my words. “I’m not wondering, not really. I know I deserve it. But we didn’t fight or argue. All I did was being… protective, you know? I didn’t want to hurt her!”
“And? Did you? Hurt her?” His eyes seemed to pierce me.

I faltered at the question. “I… I don’t know. Not… intentionally. It’s one thing to actively reject someone and another thing to just not go further with something that could've been… in development?” My voice pitched way too high and this inquisition was going way too far, so I started to look around for some, for any distraction. Maybe I could just get up and go? I was a fast runner, wasn’t I? I could perhaps climb the roof.
Bow looked skeptical, his eyebrows quivering. “And instead of… developing it further, your words, you just stopped talking to her, everything?”
“NO! She stopped! I just didn’t… I didn’t want to… Ugh!” I put my head between my hands, propping my elbows on my knees. Why did I feel so weak?
“All of this is really looking weird, you know?” Bow’s face was an expression of nonunderstanding. And how could he even.
“Ugh… I know, I've been… an ass. She did so much and I… just hadn’t the guts to meet her halfway, I know. But I didn’t mean it in a… bad way. I’m just trying to be a grown-up here. Ugh, this is really hard. I’m not good with… feelings.”

He sighed and crouched on his heels in front of me. “Feelings? Look, Catra. We don’t know each other very well, and maybe I shouldn’t tell you this, but I’ve known Adora for years and I think it would be good for you and her to know what’s going on with you. She's mostly open and always up for a challenge. The whole time since she heard about this arranged marriage, she tried to

find a way around, to get it undone. It wasn't like she was plotting something against anyone, but she rather tried to solve the need of the entire thing in the first place. That is her way to counter it, because she has no other means without dishonoring her father or family. Do you understand that?"
I nodded, slowly, and he continued: "On the one side, she wants to follow her family's demands, because she is just like that. She would do nearly everything for the people she loves, also to her own detriment. On the other side, she found something of maybe equal importance to her. And, I assume, you can imagine what that is, do you?"

Some of the pieces I knew about Adora fell into place. Bow was right. Adora was a problem solver, and she handled her own situation exactly alike. It was an issue to be handled until a clever solution was put in place. He continued: "But now she seems to be confronted with something she can't solve. Her normal strategies don't work, and she's… helpless, I think. She feels alone. And trapped. The problem is, that all her overabundance of energy she has is now turning against her. She can't put it to use. And that makes her restless."
My head hung, because I knew whose fault that was. "It's because of me…"
"Have I said that?", Bow asked.
"No, you haven't. But I know what the reason is. I'm not an idiot, though."
"Says every idiot," he lightly teased.
A dry laugh bubbled out of me. "Haha, very funny." It was quiet for a moment, until I asked. "Did you have any reason to haunt me, beside the mocking?"
He looked all innocent at me with big eyes. "Noooo? I mean, I thought I could help a bit, but it's also enough for me to just kill time by poking you. If it does something to get you out of your sulking, I'm fine." He grinned broadly.
"Sulking? I'm not sulking." Maybe I recognized that my voice was again a tad too high-pitched to sound convincing.
"Obviously not, Catra, obviously not. How about you go and look for Adora then? Right now? Or do you have something better to

do?”
I didn’t answer, but just looked at him. He had crouched before me, grabbed my hands and pleadingly looked at me: “Talk to her. You both need it. If you—”

The annoying, cocky girl from Cleopatra’s court scurried into the yard. She wore a nicely fitting light purple colored dress, some jewelry, and a decent pink make-up. Her appearance talked a lot about how she obviously was one of Cleopatra’s courtiers, the daughter of someone of the higher nobility – which might explain her typically sassy attitude. Her voice was very loud for such a small person as she called: “BOW! Weren’t we supposed… Oh. It’s you!” Her voice grew cold upon my sight, and I was immediately torn between being pissed and giggling. Because she obviously misinterpreted the situation.
Bow jumped up while letting go of my hands and… did he pale?
“Whoa!” I let out.
“Glimmer!” He yelled, shocked, his face an expression of despair.
Glimmer? What absurdity should that be? That wasn't a name.
Not at all. Across of us, *Glimmer* put her hands on her hips and shouted back: “What is that supposed to mean? Holding hands? With her?”
Bow's face got deeply red. “Nooo! It’s not what it looks like! Let me—”
“I can see what it looks like, you idiot!” Huh? There was some pent-up anger glowing – or rather burning – in the girl. She nearly sparkled with fury.

I stood up, made a hopefully calming gesture with my hand and interjected: “Whatever you think, it’s wrong. But you should be used to that, right?” Okay, that wasn't calming.
She fixed me with her gaze. “You might think being related to Cleopatra makes you special? I’m not impressed so far. And now, trying to steal my boyfriend?”
“Hey, hey, I’m not trying to steal… What?” Now the information registered, and my mouth clicked *audibly* shut. “Boyfriend?” I stared at Bow, who stared at the Glimmer-girl and repeated dumbly, “Boyfriend?”
“What? Should I carve it into a pillar for you, as confirmation? Of

course! But when seeing this," and she gestured wildly at Bow and me, getting redder every second, "I was obviously only one of several *arrows* in the *quiver*, wasn't I?"
She fisted her hands and squeezed her eyes. Bow hurried over to the trembling girl, and I couldn't help but to giggle upon the whole mad scene.
"Noo!", he yelled, while Glimmer – what a stupid name, and hadn't she said her name was Andronika – turned on her feet and rushed away, Bow in tow. He called her silly name again and again while running after her.

I was still a bit dazed upon the stupid scene, but only a few moments later, Adora, stupid, dangerous, pretty, sweet, awesome-as-always-looking Adora stumbled into the yard. She came from the same entrance as Bow had, obviously searching for him because she called *his* name. The entire scene was so absolutely insane that I couldn't help but to break out in crazy laughter. My guffawing earned me concerned looks from Adora.
Her hair was a bit tousled, and together with her lightly flushed cheeks, she looked absolutely gorgeous. My heart dropped at her sight, because, on a second look, she looked exhausted.

I couldn't even start to think about something clever to say, something nice perhaps, to say *anything*, because Adora turned at her feet and started to walk after the mad couple.

What? No. No! Wait! "Don't go!" My mouth voiced what my heart was screaming without my brain being involved in any way. I had jumped up to hold Adora back, to grab her by her shoulders, but she'd already stopped and turned back to me, her expression closed and warily. It was the same as on the day we met the first time, and it hurt seeing her looking at me like she'd never trusted me.
"Hey Adora." My voice might've sounded as uncertain as I felt, I couldn't really tell.
"Catra," she replied formally, and for the first time since days I was able to see her in the sunlight and realized how right Bow had been. Adora looked tired. S*he really barely sleeps. And her tousled hair is because she doesn't take care of them like before.*

There were dark lines under her eyes and her whole stance lacked the energetic aura she usually had. Like if something was consuming her. She didn't look as good as before. Why hadn't I noticed that? We had seen each other, even if only for lunch or dinner and only in the presence of others. But I hadn't noticed it until now, where I saw her standing so near.

She'd obviously waited for me to go on and when I made no further move because of my ruminating, she got impatient.
"Thanks for the talk," she said coolly and turned away.
"Adora wait," I called and raised a hand, but fell silent again. My mind was blank, but I knew I wanted to talk to her. Only that the fitting words had slipped my mind.
"What?" she asked, impatient.
"I… You look tired," I guardedly managed.
"It's fine," was her concise answer, and I didn't really know how to pick up a conversation with her. In the recent days, I was thinking about what I would say to Adora, but all the meticulously-composed speeches and clever platitudes seemed to have vanished in a puff of smoke.[66] Before… my withdrawal, everything had been so easy between us. Every talk had sparked with teasing and playful competition, a joke often followed by a touch or a nudge.
Now, I got a deadpan Adora that didn't make any effort to meet my approach halfway, or even with *any courtesy*, and my brain was just mushy.
"Is the… situation troubling you?" I carefully asked.
Adora crossed her arms before her chest and replied: "Not at all. But why would you care, of all people?" Still, her unmoved voice and the ill-concealed accusation also hurt. I rubbed the back of my neck and looked at the ground. "I'm just… I just wanted to know if we should… do anything for your comfort. You're not looking good."
Her eyes became slits, and she pressed her lips together before replying: "I think you've done enough, Catra."
I tilted my head lightly, looking back. "What should that mean?"
"It should mean that you had your fun with the dumb Roman girl. Be happy! Now you can move on to your next prey or mission or

whatever your thing is," she hissed.
"What?" I blinked and took a step back, surprised at the weight of her accusation. That wasn't what happened. I opened my mouth to reply at least *something*, but she already cut me short. "I don't have time for your nonsense. Thank you for your concern," she grouched and disappeared, leaving me behind, baffled. Did she… did she believe that I had been just playing with her?
"Adora!" I shouted, knowing it was too late.

She didn't come back. And I realized that I lacked the courage to run after her.
It shouldn't have gone that way.

In the evening, Cleopatra and Caesar held dinner together, as so often. For the first time since our argument a few days ago, Cleo invited me to join them, and I was torn between hesitant and expectant to go there. Hesitant, because I feared the possible or rather probably awkward atmosphere and expectant because I sensed an opportunity to make up with Cleo – as I just didn't dare go to her. The one time I tried, she'd locked the door and didn't open it upon my knocking. Which was – what a funny coincidence – exactly the same that happened when I knocked at Adora's door the next day.
After being trapped in this palace for weeks now, it started to feel like a prison, and not because of the situation outside. More and more doors seemed to be closed, at least, to me.

It was a rather informal event, only Cleopatra, Caesar, Alexas, and Adora were present. Whereby Adora was actually only physically present, but not participating for real. She looked absentminded, didn't speak much and ate nearly nothing, while we discussed the ongoing siege.
"I must admit that Ptolemy's move to rally and agitate the city

population was very clever. I hadn’t expected the citizens to act so fierce and with something like a strategy,” Caesar said.
“This is Pothinus doing, and they're supported by Achillas and the army. It's not that difficult to spark anger amongst citizens about foreigners seizing their palace,” Alexas cut in. “They are provided with materials, and we've seen officers advising and even leading them. Good that you had the nerves to calm the mob down during their first rage. I don’t think we would’ve been ready to defend the palace then. My appreciation for your speaking skills, Consul.” He raised his mug and nodded to Caesar. Adora’s uncle waved a dismissive hand. “Wars are not won with the sword alone.” [67]
“Truer words were seldom spoken,” Alexas replied delighted, and as he took a sip of his wine, his gaze fell onto Adora and lingered on her for a moment. Was there a hint of regret in it? The longer I thought about it, the more I realized that it looked more like compassion. Or pity.

Dinner went on, and I only exchanged a few words with Cleo, who was paying most of her attention to the leader of the Roman Republic. She acted like nothing had happened between us. Maybe she was a bit cooler than usual, and we weren’t bantering like usual, but as she spoke to Caesar most often, it didn’t feel so off. I assumed that it made sense for her, because having Caesar on her side must be her top priority now. What did a little argument with her sister in love matter, then? I felt sidelined, though. When my eyes fell on Adora, she looked withdrawn and picked around on her plate with a fork, only occasionally eating something and sticking with her eyes to the table otherwise. I asked her how her day was, and got a blank look. The courage to insist another time left me afterward, and I fell silent again. Adora returned to her not overly exciting activity of picking at the plate. All of this was excruciating. And while the reason for my decision was still valid, I felt my strength to hold to it crumbling more and more each day. Soon after, she stood up, formally excused herself and was gone before anyone else could say something. Only Alexas shot me a questioning look, while Cleo and Caesar didn’t seem to notice anything, all holed-up in their own conversation.

I returned my attention tho their conversation. They'd moved over to discuss how the presence of the Egyptian fleet in the harbor of Alexandria hindered the Roman reinforcements to arrive. Caesar just said: "…it is luck that the thirty-seventh legion has been able to react so quickly, but now they have anchored before Chersonesus[68] because of the ill winds. They can stay there, but disembarking is not feasible on these shores. And they are of no help on the ships either and soon, they will run out of water and food." Unloading 10,000 men at a tidal and often rocky coastline during strong winds would be torturous at best and murderous at worst, that much I knew. Losing ten percent or more of the men due to insufficient means of disembark sounded just bad, even to cool strategists like Caesar and Cleopatra.
"We need to take the Egyptian fleet out of the game. I assume, some action at the port would be best to achieve this. Maybe we could damage the ships enough, so they can't leave the harbor and engage? Or barricade the port entry?" Cleopatra suggested.
"It would help if we had precise knowledge of the port facilities. We could plan something then," Caesar threw in. They were rather chit-chatting than developing actual plans, which was something for the daily war council they held. But it seemed that they were comfortable by spinning ideas.

Cleopatra smirked, leaned over to me and asked with mischief sparkling in her eyes: "Remember when we escaped the palace and played at the navalia[69] when we were young?"
That was my cue. "Hah! Alexas was furious, he sent out the guards to search for us, literally combing the city by dozens of them, while we were just sitting at a pier and threw stones into the water. It was sooo dumb!"
Said Alexas smirked, "I'm right over here, your grace, and I can hear you very well."
"Oh, do you, old man? Your ears still good enough to overhear? You wanna lock us up another two weeks because we hurt your sensitive feelings?" I teased him.
"You weren't locked, your grace, you were *carefully guarded with the utmost attention*", he replied with dramatic exaggeration. "And the palace was hardly a prison! We didn't even remove the

cushions from your rooms. Furthermore, if I'm remembering the situation correctly, I had you grounded for *four* weeks. Well deserved, and only in your best interest, of course." I could literally see him laughing silently up his sleeve while he fake-coughed.
"Well deserved?" Cleopatra shouted. "Well deserved? Four weeks! We did nothing! It was just a walk to the harbor, by Isis and Osiris! It was—"
"…just an unplanned, unguarded and perfectly unsafe trip to harbor by the ten-year-old heir to the Egyptian throne and her untrustworthy sister."
Cleo puffed up her cheeks. "Uh! Uh! Heir to throne. PAH! I wasn't even the first in line then. Why did you have to be so cruel? It was so boooring." She groaned dramatically, while I giggled alongside Alexas upon her antics. Caesar looked unmoved, a bit sidelined for the first time this evening, and I noticed that it didn't suit him.

"Untrustworthy?" I asked, after Cleopatra calmed herself down. Alexas raised his hands in defeat. "Maybe this term was an unlucky pick. Please accept my sincerest apology. How does "utterly irresponsible" sound instead?", he fake-offered.
"Oh, that's better, thank you very much." I toasted him with a smirk.
Cleo followed up. "Why had Catra even to be grounded? She was there on her free will the whole time, wasn't she?"
"Nah, sister, I couldn't leave you on your own. Berenice would have strangled you in your sleep without my protection."

The words had just tumbled out of my mouth, because it'd been a joke between us until… Berenice's death. We fell silent when the memories kicked in, because – actually – Cleo's other elder sister hadn't been so bad. She took over the reign at the age of 20, after her mother's death and at a time while our mutual father and Cleopatra'd been in Rome. He'd been expelled from reign and Egypt by his former wife, Berenice's *mother,* and begged the Romans to help him regain power. When he succeeded with that task and returned to Egypt with a Roman army behind, he had Berenice beheaded *before Cleo's eyes*, without even giving her a chance of redemption or even for arguing in her own defense. His

own, 20-year-old daughter.
There, I recognized for the first time under which pressure Cleopatra had to live, who was only a girl of thirteen years at the time, while I was seventeen. Some nights after Berenice's execution, still little Cleopatra sneaked into my room and bed and clung to me as if her life depended on it. In those nights, I held her the trembling girl, my half-sister, in my arms and whispered assuring words into her ears, sometimes or more often only to reassure myself. Even for me, an older teenager, the world seemed to be a darker and dangerous place now, where parents murdered their own children.

Berenice had just mainly followed her mother's wishes, not paying enough attention to her father's doing, who was *away and not there*. She hadn't plotted against him to take over his throne, she'd just been stupid enough to tag along. Her death had been so frightening that I refused to see Cleopatra's father for more than a year afterward. And he scared me until he was luckily gone.
Cleo didn't have that grace, and every encounter with him left her in anxiety and trembling sometimes. She was relieved upon his passing – as nearly everyone else was – and taking over the reign as Pharaoh alongside her brother was an act of liberation for her. Where others would've seen the burden of power and responsibility, she enjoyed exertion of said things because it made her *safer*. On that day, she took power over her own life, and vowed to never let it go again.

For me, it was just natural to stay at her side.

"I'm sorry," I said, laying a hand on hers. "She wouldn't have. She wouldn't have done anything to you. Berenice liked you. Maybe she would have strangled me," I joked lowly, "but not you."
"You always teased her," Cleopatra said, her voice without any accusation, but rather a hint of friendliness towards her dead sister.
"And rightfully so," I replied softly.
It was silent for a moment, as nobody at the table spoke anything, Cleo and I caught in reminiscence about a childhood

gone early and that had often been frightening, Alexas well aware of our mutual past and Caesar not really understanding any of this. Somehow in the awkward quiet I lost my train of thought and my mind got stranded on the previous topic, the discussion of the Egyptian fleet. I wanted to move on anyway.

A thought ran through me. "We should burn them down, right in the harbor."
"What?" Cleo asked, obviously surprised that I even proposed a tactical idea.
"The best thing would be to set the docks on fire," I continued to reason out loud, without realizing what I actually said. "The docks are all made of wood, instead of stone, like all the other buildings in Alexandria."
"So, you know the docks?" Caesar asked temperate, but obviously not brushing the idea off.
"Hah, like my own fortress, I would say. I used to stroll around the harbor more often when I was older and Cleopatra was… away. It's been a while, but they shouldn't have changed so much. It's still a lot of wood."
"And burning them down could work?" he insisted, while Cleopatra just sat there, with her mouth agape now.
"You could use the Pyr, that is stored in the arsenal," Alexas threw in, and I picked it up immediately. "Oh. Oh, the pyr, yes. Holy shit, the docks will burn like tinder if we deploy it well."
Alexas nodded and smiled, then glanced at my sister, who'd followed the conversation with growing horror in her face. Before she could say anything, I spun it further: "You could also try to set all of it on fire in the arsenal, this—"

"Catra, NO!" Cleopatra yelled. "This is our harbor! We need it."
Caesar looked at us, questioningly, but with growing interest. "What do you mean with *Pyr*? Should I've heard of it?"
Alexas explained: "It's like a fire accelerator. We put it on our projectiles that we use on our ships, to set the enemy ones on fire."
"Ah, so like our tared phalarica[70], I see. That could work quite well, wouldn't you say?" he asked, looking at me again,

deliberately ignoring Cleo.
"With ease," I replied. "As I said, it's all wood, the docks, the ships, the piers, the warehouses, storage. It's old, dry wood. When the docks are burning, they can't even man the ships to row them away, because… yeah, the fire and such? The docks are between the piers and the barracks of the crews. When we set enough of them on fire at the same time, half the fleet would burn down along the piers before they even know it."

Caesar rolled a mug around in his hand and pondered about the mad idea.

Cleopatra looked at me with horror.

I understood her, because that was her harbor, her city, *her nation's fleet*, after all, even if commanded by her brother now. The 22 quadriremes and 5 quinqueremes in the Great Harbor were not a vast fleet, but they were enough to block it against any intruder and able to hold it as long as needed. The quinqueremes alone were vast juggernauts that required 300 rowers only to move them. At full speed, such a ship could break any Roman galley in the middle by just piercing through them with their ram spur. The large ships were supported by a great number of small open barks that were able to move around fast and execute quick maneuvers. All in all, the Egyptian fleet was strong enough to hinder the Romans from safely landing their troops as long as required.

And all of that I wanted to set on fire?

I didn't even know why I came up with it. It just jumped to my mind and now, it didn't sound so unrealistic. If burning the fleet was necessary to keep us safe, to keep Adora safe, I would burn it. Adora's uncle obviously came to the same conclusion for different reasons as he said: "So, it looks like you would be a perfect fit for leading a party to set them on fire, won't you, your grace?"

The next quarter of an hour was a premiere, as it was the first time that I saw myself siding with Caesar and against Cleopatra. He laid out that his combined fleet of 29 galleys and 5 quinqueremes *maaaybe* could beat the Egyptian fleet in an open battle at the sea, but not in the limited space that the port allowed. It would've been a massacre on both sides. So, either the fleet had to leave the harbor, or other means must be taken to clear the port for the Roman legion to disembark at Alexandria to strengthen our troops.
Cleo stubbornly resisted during the whole argument: "Catra, this is an Egyptian fleet. If we burn it down, we've nothing left of our naval forces! We will need at least two years to rebuilt it, if we can at all, given our financial resources. It's madness to sacrifice them just for a tactical advantage."
"Right now, this fleet belongs to your enemies, sister, for Isis' sake! It doesn't do us any good," I held against. "This fleet only serves as a tool to keep you from the throne, Cleo. And that won't change until Achillas and Pothinus are gone."
We went back and forth until she finally, grumbling, pulled back and didn't resist anymore. When Cleopatra's opposition had crumbled, Caesar switched in again: "Time is of the essence now, if we are going to execute this plan. I must inform my troops and fleet that they will manage to approach before Alexandria in the morning. Do you think you can carry out this plan tonight?"

Those were heavy words, given what depended on them. If I failed, the efforts of the Roman fleet would be useless at best and could lead to being attacked by a fully aware and battle-ready Egyptian fleet at worst. Given Caesars ships were mostly transporting troops, an open naval battle would be disastrous. I felt his look laying on me. Cleo's too. This was the first time I was to do something that she didn't want me to.

Nonetheless, I felt capable of carrying it out and so, I nodded.

But soon after, when Dinner-turned-strategy-council ended, I was troubled. Caesar, as always, was none to wait for long. He'd already called for his generals to lay out orders, while I should go and rally a small troop of soldiers that should accompany me to

the docks. The sooner, the better, was the saying of the Roman and after reassuring myself with a questioning look at Cleo, who hesitantly nodded, I stood up and left. To set some world on fire.

As I hurried through the hallway, all that went through my mind was, that I couldn't go without telling Adora what had bothered me the whole day. I wasn't ready to tell her, but I also wasn't able to leave the palace without telling her. I had to.
This mission could get deadly, if we were discovered or, worse, ambushed. Ptolemy's, or rather Achillas' soldiers had checkpoints everywhere, patrolled the entire city and especially the harbor. So, the possibility of not coming back was real and If I was not coming back at all, Adora had to know that I didn't use her for my own weird gratification or hadn't played games with her. At least, so much I owed her. With that thought in mind, I rushed to her room.

Adora

Catra pounded against my door and it was loud. Like, shattering loud. To make her presence clearer, she shouted too. "Adora! Open the door! Adora! Let! Me! In! I don't have time for this bullshit!"

I heaved myself off the bed where I'd been lying since the exhausting dinner, already dressed in my nightwear. Seeing Catra there – and in the courtyard before – was nothing but painful. The last weeks had passed in some kind of blurred, slow-downed agony. Self-inflicted, surely, because it was all my fault. But her rejection – after I'd saved the damned woman – had pushed me into a spiral of self-doubt, and I chastised myself for having no single fiber of self-control and restraint against it. Half my days had consisted of me trying to get Catra out of my head. *Or heart.* The other half, I tried not to completely drown. Of course, on a

rational level, I knew I was behaving overly dramatic and that I was acting childish. It was nothing like me. But reason just didn't offer any of what I needed to put myself together. Reason didn't help my troubled feelings turn away from Catra and to something else less… torturing.
She. Had. Rejected. Me.

It was as simple as that, and it had been my repetitive formula which I'd been saying to myself, over and over again to accept it. It hadn't worked well, but it was all I could manage. Beside feeling tired and agitated at the same time. And I was tired. I craved for a night of uninterrupted sleep, of not waking up, not drowning in sweat. Not aching for Catra's presence, surely. Not when startling out of something that didn't resemble a good sleep in the slightest. Not. Damned woman.

I pushed the bolt of the door aside and opened it. Catra looked agitated and breathed heavily. It was beautiful, how her chest rose and fell, while her hand tried to steady herself at the door frame.
"Another round of not saying anything meaningful?" I asked a tad too coolly. The malicious words just tumbled out of my mouth. She stepped forward, and I instinctively took a few steps back. What was she up to? Then she closed the door and turned to me. Her face had a determined expression on it, and her voice was steady when she spoke: "I wanted to say something the whole time, and I'd have to say it, before it's too late."
That didn't sound so good. "What do you mean with *too late*?" I hated the needy sound of my voice. Ugh, her presence alone made me washy, and it was embarrassing.
She waved it off and took my hands in hers instead. I was too surprised to react and just stared at her. "Doesn't matter. Listen Adora, you were right. You were right when you said that there is something between us. I just didn't want to… admit it to myself. And to you."
Ooof! "But—"
"Shut up, Adora. I don't have time. Please believe me when I say that I know what you mean when you told me, that we watch out for each other. This! This here is me watching out for you, okay?"

“Catra, what's the meaning of all of this?” Nothing of this felt good, but what happened next, did, actually. Because the beautiful woman in front of me raised her arms and grabbed my cheeks, drew me in and kissed me gently. I felt my eyes dilating in surprise, when her damp and soft lips brushed over mine. But I didn't withdraw. Instead, I softened, just let it happen and for the first time in weeks, my stomach stopped hurting. My eyes were on their way to flutter close, and a sense of relief ran down my spine. When she broke us apart, I was dumbstruck and my hand, on its way to cup her face, was lingering halfway in the air, frozen. It felt like my brain had jumped out a window and took all my rationality and reason with it. Wow! Catra’s kiss was just that good.[71] “Wha__”
She shushed me by laying a finger on my lip, and I had a hard time to keep myself from kissing it. Or licking. Both options were tempting. “I wish I'd had more time. So I just wanted you to know that… I feel it too, Adora. I do! Take care of you!”

That being said, she let go of my hands that she’d still been holding, turned on her heels and ran out the door. When I finally pulled myself out of the shock of this encounter, I already heard her jumping down the stairs. I ran behind, stopped at the railing and called after her: “Where are you going?”
I only heard her shouting back “Ask your uncle!” and she was gone.

What the fuck was going on?

Quickly I changed back from my nightwear into a formal tunic and went down to the dining room again. There, only Cleopatra still sat, alone, and she looked absentminded, and maybe a bit tipsy. She held a knife in her hand and shoved some of her food around the plate. Uncle Julius was gone, as was Alexas, only a servant stood in the back, ready to take her orders anytime. I shortly wondered about Bow, whom I might have seen leaving with this other girl, Andronika, during dinner, but I wasn’t sure.
For now I focused on the Pharaoh. “Your grace?” I asked gingerly. Cleopatra looked up at me, and made a reluctant smile. It seemed more like trying to be kind than that she was really pleased with

my presence. Understandable, as this must have been the first full sentence I had spoken with her since… well. I continued: "Would you mind explaining to me what happened? Catra stormed off and said something about my uncle…"
Cleopatra laughed softly, but I quickly noticed it was rather scoffing: "Eh, my genius sister and your uncle decided it would be a good idea to burn down the Egyptian fleet in the harbor to get his troops at land."
That sounded like she didn't like it. Not at all. "Isn't this a good idea? Don't we need his reinforcements? Am I missing something?"

She dropped the knife, leaned back in her chair and eyed me, then sighed before speaking. "You don't really know what it costs to build a fleet this size, do you?"
It caught me off. I hadn't thought about it, but my honest guess was *a lot*. I shook my head and she continued. "It is a good idea, tactically spoken. Though, this is *my* fleet, even if it's currently listening to my brother's command. The day will come when I'm back on the throne, but then it will be without these ships. Burning them down is weakening us again, against everyone, and foremost, you." At the last word, she sluggishly pointed with her index finger at me and made a grim smile.
The blatant accusation made me feel odd. "Me?"
She chuckled and rolled her eyes. "Not you in person, dummy. You as a Roman, as the personified example of the almighty superpower at our doorsteps, that is always just one bad decision away to conquer Egypt as the next nation." Her eyes pierced me. "We both know that your senate is thirsting for the grain and wealth of my country. It's sheer logic that your uncle doesn't want to occupy us. He could, but the man is smarter than I expected." She waved her hands in the air in exasperation. "But what when he isn't in charge anymore? Or when another power-hungry man decides that we are his next trophy? When my fleet is gone, there is no other naval power left in the Eastern Mediterranean or the Mediterranean Sea at all. You may not have noticed it, Adora, but all the other independent realms around the Mediterranean are gone. They all belong to you, only you Roman's are left. And us. I

think it’s understandable, that I’m not too amused or grateful about the loss of my fleet.”

I wondered about her open address of the topic. Her considerations weren't that hard to draw, now that she voiced them. I could clearly seem them. But talking to me like that seemed to be a bit too downright. Was this some kind of sneaky trick? But to what avail? No. By giving her a second, closer look, Cleopatra seemed rather frustrated, and maybe the wine had just loosened her tongue.
Well, that wasn't my problem. Or maybe it was, because it was another reason she'd wanted to tie my family to her. Anyway, I had to focus, remember why I’d come here and asked: “And what has Catra to do with this? Why was she so… agitated?”

Now Cleopatra eyed me suspiciously, with raised eyebrows. “Catra came to you?”
Had I said something I shouldn’t have? “Uhm, yeah? I mean, she stormed by, told me that she had something to do, said goodbye and that I should ask my uncle,” (*and of course she didn’t kiss me, nononono! She didn’t),* “and then she was away again. I didn’t really understand it.”
A very, very little pull in the corner of her mouth showed up. She fetched her mug and took a sip before answering. “My dear sister is the one leading a party of soldiers to the docks right now, to set my fleet and the harbor on fire. She and your uncle are very quick to implement their decisions, aren’t they? The mighty Caesar is right on his way to meet his fleet before Chersonesus and Catra will pave the way for them into my capital in the morning.” The last of her words sounded bitter, as if that wouldn't be a victory, but I only got the part where she mentioned that Catra was under way in Alexandria.
Right now.
In the *hostile* part of Alexandria.
“What? She’s in the city? But… there are your brother’s men everywhere!”
Cleopatra shrugged her shoulders. “She’s capable. And she’s not alone, by the way. She’ll find a way, as always.” She looked convinced of her own words.

But meanwhile, Catra's saying played repeatedly in my mind: "*before it's too late*" and "*I feel it too.*" While the confession had given me relief, the other part didn't sound so good.

What could I do?

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"The Burning of the Library of Alexandria I"** and will be published on Friday, July 30, 2021. We will burn knowledge, tax work, and something else.

[60] In fact, this assessment is so true that Egypt was declared by Octavian an imperial province, where the emperor ruled directly. No Roman senator was even allowed to enter Aegyptus without the express permission of the emperor himself, because the political, strategical and military potential of Egypt was feared by every emperor since. A governor of equestrian rank was appointed for ruling Aegyptus, being it the only province of all where no senator, former consul or praetor ruled. After becoming prefect of the Praetorian guard of the emperor, the governorship of Roman Egypt was the second-highest office that was available to an equestrian class citizen on the cursus honorum. ↑

[61] This sentence is a variation from "I dig you", Chapter 2, and the context there is completely different. ↑

[62] 30 drachmas can be translated into the equivalent of what a normal worker ears for a living in a month today. So 17 million drachmas can be, for example, something between one and two billion Euros. Which is quite a sum, if you have no functioning banking system and everything relies on gold only. Today, borrowing two billion is easy, because money is overabundant, and we have a well-developed monetary system. In ancient times, not so much. It wasn't just a check then, it was actual coins. ↑

[63] These two sentences are a derivation from the scene where Cleopatra meets Caesar for the first time in "Assassins Creed: Origins". While I don't like Cleopatra's interpretation there, I found the dialogue fitting in quite well. ↑

[64] A Scorpio was a smaller field artillery weapon made of wood for firing large arrows. ↑
[65] A Ballista was a middle range torsion siege weapon of the antiquity, firing arrows or sometimes stones. ↑
[66] The later part of this sentence is from "Above the Vaulted Sky", Chapter 9. ↑
[67] Ptolemy, or rather Pothinus, actually did that and the populace of Alexandria rioted against the occupation of the palace. Caesar then arrested Ptolemy and calmed the mob down with his oratorical skills. The truth of this event is controversial, and the only account we have is Caesar's own report. Caesar didn't speak Egyptian, and the common Alexandrian didn't speak Latin. Perhaps, he did it in Greek, so it may have happened. ↑
[68] Chersonesus, also Chersonesus Parva or Taposiris Parva, was a city east of Alexandria and mustn't be mistaken with other cities of the same name. Today it's a neighborhood of Alexandria. ↑
[69] Cleopatra would've surely used the Greek term for "docks" and "shipyards", but I'm not up to introduce another ancient language and Greek is the worst for writing, so here you have another Latin term: Navalia. They were the Roman military ports, including dockyards, storage, shipsheds, and other infrastructure. The Navalia of the city of Rome itself were called "Navalia superioria", and they lay beside the river Tiber south of the Campus Martius, the Mars field, where in Republican times the legions gathered before moving out.↑
[70] Phalarica, or falarica, were used as incendiary weapons. Combustible material was bound around a metal or wodden shaft, set on fire and thrown or launched. ↑
[71] The last two sentences are derivations from "peace in change".↑

The Burning of the Library of Alexandria I

Chapter Summary

Glimmer is a bitch.
AND CLEOPATRA SEND HER REGARDS!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Alexandria, Egypt - January, 47 BCE


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Royal Quarter
Gate of the Sun
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Canopic Way
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

Adora

"Your highness!" Polykrates called. The younger general, who I recognized from Pelousion, was a man in his forties with a full black beard and hair alike. He gestured wildly as he rushed in. While Cleopatra's leading general, Palmedes, was commanding her troops at Hermiopolis, Polykrates acted as deputy and advised the Pharaoh on the planning of troop movements and general strategy in coordination with his superior. He had one of Caesar's leading officers in tow, a man named Rufio, and both of them looked stressed.
"The Egyptian army is attacking at the Museion. We need to act immediately. I already coordinated with Caesars officers to send a full cohort as first response and to secure the walls, but we need more." Judging from the tone of his voice, this offense was dead serious.

Cleopatra shot up from her stool where she'd idled in the last hour, and rushed over to the planning table. There, amongst a lot of others, a map of Alexandria spread out. "Where exactly?" she asked, and Polykrates pointed at the part of the city where the Museion was, southwest of the palace grounds. The royal quarters lay at around the eastern part of the great harbor of Alexandria, stretching vastly between a headland, the harbor, and the city itself. The Museion with the Library of Alexandria in it was a part of the palace grounds. As it had been built at later times, it hadn't been included into the inner walls of the original fortifications of the area. Instead, a second, lower and not so heavy fortified wall had been built around the Museion and some other buildings, which had been erected in the recent decades only.
"With how many men do we have to deal there?" Cleopatra asked, focused on the map.
"We assume, that around twelve of Achillas cohorts are in action." Which would amount to around 5,000 or more men, I thought.
"And they have incited many of the Alexandrian population to join in. Some of them acceded the army with small centuries, others haven't made real formations and are just wildly attacking us at

the sides of the central line of advance. We assume that around three- to four thousand nonmilitary combatants have entered the battle."
That sounded like a lot. We had three thousand maximum. "Is this… are they a real threat to our lines?" Alexas asked, getting that too.
"Meaning no offense, but everything that distracts you from fighting the soldier before you, is a threat. And a trained citizen is of course able to take someone down as well as a trained soldier. So yes, it is. We are outnumbered by three to one."

"What are your suggestions?", Cleopatra asked, focussed on the map.
Polycrates was swift: "We have six cohorts at hand, from which three should immediately counter the attack at the Museion. The first cohort is already in action, the second and third will follow immediately to support and strengthen the depth of our defense line there," he pointed at the southwest corner of the wall, "and there," pointing to the left and right of it. "As long as we keep the walls, we can make up for our inferiority in the numbers."
Cleopatra nodded, accepted it instantly, and waved a hand in approval, whereupon Polycrates and Rufio looked at each other, then they ordered a subordinate officer to execute the command.
Polycrates continued. "Two cohorts will guard the other fortifications of the royal quarter, in particular here," where he brushed along the street parallel to the Canopus way, "and towards the navalia. The sixth will be held back as reinforcement and tactical support wherever else needed. We maybe need them in case of a breakthrough becomes necessary. If the enemy breaks through a gate or surmounts the wall anywhere, we have only one cohort to stop them."

Cleopatra looked at Caesar's officer for his opinion. Formally, she had no power over the Roman forces, but Caesar had made it clear, that in his absence, his men should follow the Pharaoh's wishes within a reasonable amount, in case of anything like this was happening. It was a real unusual step for him and showed great trust in Cleopatra's abilities, but on the other side, they were

as trappes as she was. Rufio saluted and approved, whereupon Cleopatra nodded again: “Good. Give orders to place the troops as advised and explain the subsequent strategy to me then. And we need to message Palmedes, he must ready a counterattack on their camp as soon as possible. Maybe we can force them to withdraw at least some of their troops.”
“Yes, your grace. I'm sure he will already've considered that.” Polycrates replied. The general spoke shortly with the Roman officer, then both rushed off to give their orders and to oversee the battle. Cleopatra returned to bow over the map and continued studying it.

I had followed the exchange from the back, where I still stood and without any plan what to do now. Caesar was gone to gather his fleet, Catra on a mission to set things on fire, Bow had disappeared with his mysterious girlfriend and Cleopatra was occupied. I was nervous, or rather, I felt agitated and had no clue what to do.

A few minutes later, the Egyptian general returned, and Cleopatra asked him about the placement of the cohorts and where the attackers were trying to overcome the fortifications. Again, they leaned over the table and I approached it too, quietly, because I didn’t want to draw any attention to me. Focused on the map, they didn’t care about my presence, while Polycrates put his finger on several places on the map. “The main force of the attackers is engaging here.” He pointed to a gate southwest of the Museion. “They try to take advantage of the lower walls south of the Library, and because it’s the farthest point from the palace and barracks. If we lose control there, we would have to retreat to the inner walls, which are in a bad shape there and there.” His finger laid on two gates directly east and southeast of the Museion. “We haven’t been able to repair them as much as needed and at these two gates have only makeshift wings to close them, because the previous ones were destroyed by the Romans during our own attack when we took over the palace.”
“Perfect,” Cleopatra scoffed unhappily, and I silently agreed with her.
“Your grace, we had…”

“It wasn’t an accusation, general,” she elaborated. Don’t be ridiculous. Better tell me if we can hold these gates.”
“It depends, your grace. Against foot soldiers? Pretty sure. If they bring on siege weapons like towers, aries or testudines[72], no. The wings are weak, and they won’t hold against them. If they storm through, we'll be overwhelmed.”
Cleopatra straightened and grimaced. “Achillas doesn’t to seem to like me at all. So much attention just for me.”
Alexas cut in with a stoic grin. “Take it as a token of his appreciation, your grace. Being taken serious by your enemies is a sign that they are nervous and fear to lose.” The Pharaoh pulled a corner of her mouth and smirked, annoyed and unnerved. “He could've sent a present. Or no, the bastard could cut his throat as a token of appreciation,” she etched. “If it weren’t for him, all this wouldn’t have been necessary. He’s a fucking traitor and—”
“Language, your grace,” Alexas cut in softly, which stopped Cleopatra from her rant, tangled for a short moment. “Sure,” she murmured and ran her hands over her hair to straighten it. “Where were we?”

Cleopatra, Polycrates, Alexas, and a few more counselors discussed further, while I withdrew. I’d decided to do another dumb thing in my life, to have a closer look at the ongoing attack near the Museion. Maybe I could help somewhere at the Library or near the docks. It was a brain-dead idea, perhaps the dumbest thing I was ever going to do, but I just couldn’t sit in my room or take part in a discussion where I was of no use, when the world around me seemed to fall apart.
But I wasn’t completely out of my mind. Bow had to come with me, and we could get hold of our two contubernia under his command to accompany us. We had men, and could support the efforts of defense. I was unsure if Bow still held power over them or if Caesar took them away, but I was about to find out.

I searched for him in our rooms, but to no avail. Then I remembered that I had seen him walking away with this stocky girl… Andronika? Yes, that had been her name.
I asked a servant where to find her quarter and was guided to the

part of the building where Cleopatra had taken residence. We reached the hallway, from which I knew that the rooms of the pharaoh were also there. Judging from the two guards next to another door, Andronika's room was right beside Cleopatra's, as my guide bowed and pointed with her hand at the entrance. I thanked the woman and knocked.

"Not now!" someone female angrily yelled from inside, and I decided to ignore it and opened the door, not too reluctant.
The sight was… interesting.
Bow was sitting on the edge of the bed with Andronika face to face on his lap, her knees beside his waist and her feet hanging down behind her. Both were embracing each other and they *miiight* had just kissed. When they noticed me, they quickly broke apart. As if that had been of any use to hide what I'd already seen now. I giggled upon their red faces, until Andronika managed a furious comeback. "I said not now! Are you bad at hearing, you goofball?"
Bow looked horrified, and I just watched the disaster before me unfold while he tried to shush her. She didn't take that effort so well, to say the least. "DON'T shush me!" she yelled and slapped his hands away. "She can't just barge in wherever she likes. This isn't her home!"

I looked down at the furious girl, chuckled and folded my arms before my chest before I teased her. "Well, technically it's my uncle's palace now, so… I think you understand what I mean."
The boiling volcano erupted. "WHAT? You presumptuous Roman bitch! You're all the same. Conquering and plundering what isn't —"
Bow waved with his hands at her in a calming gesture. "Whoa! Whoa! Glimmer, calm down. Adora is nothing like this."
"Her uncle—"
"Is her uncle! She's neither responsible for his doing nor can she command him anything! Get this in your head, Glimmer."
That was a little brat, but I had to give her credit for obviously trying to calm. Then I cleared my throat. "Erm… why do you call her Glimmer? I thought her name was Andronika?"
Both of them looked baffled at me about the possibly ridiculous

question, until Bow came back: "It's a nickname. Because of her favorite dresses, that tend to sparkle maybe a bit tooo much sometimes. Cleopatra made it up and it just… stuck."
"Hey hey hey! They are not sparkling *tooo much*, they are just perfect!" Glimmer called and he grimaced. It was obviously not the first time that they had this special part of banter. Both of them seemed to have grown close during the last days, even without me noticing it.
"I understand," I replied, "but however, I need Bow to accompany me. I have something to do for him."
He immediately straightened and got up, coming over, while Glimmer looked with her mouth agape. "You're leaving me just like that? We're not done with each other yet."
He blushed, but denied though. "Ahem… I have duties Glimmer. Just like you, if I may remind you."
She angrily pointed with her index finger at me. "You! This is your doing! You are just jealous, aren't you? You can't stand the thought that he's lucky while you're pining like an idiot."

Huh? "What?" I was baffled, because that made absolutely no sense. I felt how my face turned into a grimace of nonunderstanding. And this Glimmer girl just rambled on. "Don't pretend you don't know what I'm talking about. I know about you and Catra! This endless lesbian disaster is just dreadful. Only because you can't put your shit together doesn't mean that everyone else has to endure the same. Just leave us alone."
Oh, no! "It's… it's not about that," I stammered. What did she know about Catra and me? Had Bow said anything? Were there already rumors spreading? Nothing even happened between us during the last two weeks, so, what was she even talking about? The tavern? Did she hear about it? From whom?
I took a deep breath and collected myself. "What do you mean with Catra and me?"
"Oh, please, Adora. You're a lousy actress, and Catra is just too clever for herself. She can't hide her feelings well. I needed *one look* during the dinners last week to recognize what was going on between the two of you." She scoffed. "All this pseudo-secret glancing and languishing. It's so embarrassing for both of you.

You’re just lucky that Cleopatra and your uncle are too busy with themselves to get what’s going on. This mutual pining is nothing but a mortifying joke, on par with ancient Greek drama. Just get a room together and sort it out, so I won’t suffer from it only because you are idiots.”

I stood frozen, not able to reply anything, and Bow was just milling about, trying to act like he wasn’t here.[73] I was so flustered that only after a few seconds I managed a weak “I need to go. Over there,” pointed to some undefined place behind me, turned on my heels and walked out.[74]
Or rather stormed out, because I was so embarrassed when I left Glimmer's — what a pathetic name — room, walked a few meters away, but then quickly leaned against the wall then for some moments to catch my breath. She thought that Catra and I were a thing! What for an idiotic conclusion. We weren’t. We had barely spoken with each other since we settled down at the palace and… between the two kisses. Of which one of them happened only an hour ago. And it had been so soft, so gentle, so promising. I realized that my hand had risen to my lips and touched them upon the memory, and quickly put it down. *I am so doomed.*

Bow came out of Glimmer’s room, saw me, and walked over. “Adora, don't give too much of what she says. She's just a little upset because of the interruption.”
I shyly looked at him. “Yeah,” I replied. He didn’t even mention Glimmer’s rant about Catra and me. Maybe it wasn’t that big deal? Oh bona dea, please let this be forgotten.
“What is it for what you need me?” he asked.

“Uhmmm, right. The palace is under attack at the Museion. I want to go there and look if we can be of help in case the attack endures. Perhaps at the library. I just can’t sit around and do nothing. So, collect our men, and we march over.”
Bow watched me suspiciously. “What’s the meaning of that? Does this have anything to do with Catra’s mission at the docks? Which are – what a coincidence – just beside the Museion?
“What? No!” *Of course, yes.* “We just can’t do nothing, Bow.” *And I can’t stay still when she’s in danger.* “The docks are nowhere

near.” *Oh, yes they are, just a few streets away.* “Anyway, rally the men and let’s get going.”

All of this was another perfect example of me being a rather act-on-it than think-about-it being. But that's what I was like.

A quarter of an hour later, we marched along a parallel road of the Canopus way that connected the palace grounds with the Museion. Alexander’s astronomers determined the alignment of this road so that it targeted the rising sun on the 20th of July, which was — to nobody's surprise — Alexander’s birthday. Coincidentally, on this day also occurred the heliacal rising of the Sirius star, which marked the birth of the Horus-kings, a famous dynasty of more than 1,200 years earlier. Connecting all this elevated the meaning and significance of Alexandria, and of course Alexander himself.
Conquering Egypt at the age of 24 years, he personally chose the site of the city founding and envisioned the building of the Heptastadion to Pharos that generated the two large natural harbors. Placing Alexandria in the far west of the Nile delta also put it as near as possible to his homeland, Greece itself. And because Alexandria's full name was 'Alexándreia-by-Egypt' and not ‘in-Egypt’ he clearly saw it as an extension of Greece rather than an Egyptian city. Anyway, he never saw what he’d created. Only a few months after the founding, another war, another conquest, another siege called upon him, and he didn’t return to his city for the remainder of his rather short life. He didn't get to see his city growing to the largest metropolis of the Mediterranean world.
Why was I even thinking about this now? Stupid education gone too far, I inwardly sighed and tried to concentrate. *Concentrate, Adora!*

Bow rallied our two contuberniae that had been put on guard duties otherwise. Caesar's men had strengthened the fortifications everywhere in the last two weeks, but around the Museion there were just old city walls that hadn't been in use for a century or more. The openings in the outer wall were without gates due to neglect, and had been walled up in a hurry. They were still weak. We saw legionaries in rapid pace and somewhere before us, battle noises erupted. Despite the late hour and the dark sky, there was light everywhere. Or was it rather… fire? Had Catra already been successful, I asked myself.
No, wrong direction.
The fire was southwards of the docks, near the walls. And it was *behind* the walls, as I noticed.

We arrived at the inner walls of the royal quarter before the Museion, where one of the makeshift gates had been set up. It looked not very convincing and would for sure not hold long against a proper battering ram. Only a contubernium of soldiers guarded it, their shields before them and their spears forward. I noticed the unmanned watchtower beside the gate and ordered my party to hold. "I want to have a look from the above," I said. Bow nodded, hesitant, and we quickly found a stairway at the side of the gate that led up the wall and from there into the tower. Inside, the stairs were narrow and made me feel slightly claustrophobic. The spiral staircase had a tight loop and a low ceiling and when we got out at the top, I breathed heavily, not because of the climbing.

Leaning over the railing and looking over nightly Alexandria could have been calming. The large city was illuminated by the glow of many torches and small beacons on temples and other buildings. It looked pretty. What spoiled the impression, however, was the sight of the battle before us. The outer walls that stretched around the Museion, adjacent block of houses and governmental buildings before us were under heavy attack. They were only a bit more than two hundred meters away, had around six meters in height and were occasionally equipped with a small watchtower here and there. The gates itself had been bricked up days ago by Caesar's men. I saw several small wooden siege towers in front of

the pinnacles, that were slowly moved forward through the streets west and south and over the broad Canopus way.
The turrets creaked and swayed left and right, and they were only a few dozen meters away from the wall. There, legionaries had swarmed out and manned them in two, sometimes three rows when the rare space on the wall allowed it, holding out their shields and spears towards the attackers. Behind them, archers had had lined up as well as on the turrets and were already firing volleys of arrows against the men who moved the siege towers. They fell, but were replaced swiftly. Despite the efforts of the defenders, this looked like a well planned and serious attack, and I wasn't sure if the three cohorts that were already in charge were able to hold them back.

What was Catra doing at this moment?

Had she already reached the docks? When I looked over to the harbor, everything seemed quiet. The navalia were not so far away, only a few hundred meters. I could see the mostly dark buildings and behind them, in the Great Harbor, the better part of the Egyptian fleet under anchor, blocking the port. Beside the lights along the Heptastadion over to Pharos island and the Lighthouse itself, the Great Harbor was dark and silent. Due to the war, all normal trade traffic had been moved over to the Old Harbor west of the Heptastadion.
No, there was no fire at the docks or the ships, and I just hoped that she was alright. Again, the memory of her kissing me this evening, even apologizing, made me angsty and excited at the same time. I wanted her back to talk this out. *Come back to me, you damned woman, otherwise the furiae*[75] *may take you.*
Still, I pondered what to do to help her.

My attention turned back to the battle. That moment, two siege towers reached the wall and gangways unfolded, falling down at the pinnacles of the wall. Through the openings behind, soldiers approached and were vigorously welcomed with a hail of arrows from Caesar's archers. But for every man who went down, another one reached the wall and jumped down on the defenders. The usual tactical strategies of the legions didn't work within the

narrow space on the top of the wall and so, the combat devolved into a man versus man fight immediately. Left and right of the first siege tower, others also reached the wall now, maybe nearly a dozen of them. In between, we saw more enemy soldiers climbing over the pinnacles, obviously coming from scaling ladders that had been attached to the wall the moment the towers arrived. The fighting spread over 200 meters on top of our defenses. We saw the archers retreating down of the wall to make way for more legionaries. They regrouped at the ground and fired over the wall then, still causing casualties, but surely much less effective now.

Everywhere, we heard the whistles of the centuriones blowing, ordering their men forth and back. Swords clinked, men groaned and yelled, arrows buzzed. One of the siege towers was set on fire and started to burn, quickly crackling under the tared phalarica. The battle noise grew, as more and more men were drawn into fights, like a storm that grew louder and louder the nearer it came. Never had I seen something like this before, so near, so close and suddenly, I realized that I was trembling.

Beside me, Bow also watched the fights, and we saw how massive the waiting reinforcements behind the front were. In the streets and alleyways that we could see, more troops had lined up to join the battle. Suddenly, Bow laid a hand on my shoulder ad called: "That doesn't look good. I don't assume that three cohorts will be enough to avoid a breakthrough. If they do, we would need something that keeps them from reach this sorry excuse of a gate," and pointed down on the one below us. "It won't hold for long." He looked around. "We aren't safe here any longer. The gates of the inner walls are not the only weak points. We should go, Adora. This wasn't a good idea."

Still, I looked around and tried to put the events together, to form something like an idea. How could I help Catra? How could I do something useful here? Before me laid the Museion, between the inner and the outer walls. There weren't any of the usual scholars underway, only a few people hurried up and down the stairs, carrying scrolls and other things out of it, through the gate and

towards the palace. Maybe they wanted to secure the more valuable writings before the inevitable looting would start?

The legion still held the wall, but the resistance started to give in here and there. One part of the coping, around twenty meters, where three of the siege towers stood, was already in possession of the enemy. "Adora, we are hardly up to this situation. We need to—"
I remembered something from my visit of the library with Catra and cut him short.
"We can slow them down. I saw wooden beams in the Museion, like from a construction site. We can use them to block the road and set them on fire. The buildings around should be mostly safe, but it will hinder them, at least for as long as the fire burns. Maybe long enough for my uncle to arrive with the fleet, if Catra is successful. When they can't use the Canopus way, it will turn into an alleyway fight, and this, the legion should be able to handle long enough. Their numerical superiority doesn't matter in the narrow streets. And they would need their own men to put it out. We must help Catra—"
"I KNEW IT!" Bow shouted, grim. "I knew that you had this in mind!"
I groaned. "So what, if it helps her? Come on, we do this. Quick."
I started jumping down the stairs, and he shouted after me: "This isn't our duty, Adora!"
"I don't care! We can fix this!", I yelled back. "What do you think will happen when the Egyptians invade the palace? This isn't a game anymore. And now follow my command!"

He shut up, and I felt a spike of sorrow, knowing that we'd have to talk about this later. Through our life, I could count the times when I ordered him something instead of asking politely on one hand. Maybe two now, and it didn't feel good. I pressed my lips together, but I also knew, we had to do something.

I led the men up the flight of stairs of the Museion, through the huge porticus of the main entrance and a few hallways, then we quickly found the storage place. Our troops started to heave the beams, each one carried away by two men, and we brought them

outside. While I looked around for more material to be used, a voice behind me croaked: "Oooh, you have returned."
When I spun around, I immediately recognized the woman with the brown pigtails, which was again carrying a lot of capsae and scrolls. "Entrapta! What are you still doing here? You should have retired to the palace long ago. The library isn't safe any longer."
She glanced at me with eyes wide open, while I watched her face and the gears behind it rumbling and clicking. "But I can't leave all these treasures behind. Their loss would be…" she fell dry, and her last words were just a whisper.

I laid an arm around her shoulder. "I understand. But this place can turn into a war zone any moment. Please, Entrapta, go."
She hesitated, stuttered. "This is… The library… We can't lose all this knowledge."
"We'll help you fetch the most important writings when we're done, okay?" I lied to her.
"Would you do this?" she asked with a hopeful expression, and I sighed: "But only the most important! We have only minutes!"

I towed her back outside to watch the progress. Meanwhile, Bow had commanded the men to erect makeshift barricades over the Canopus way and the two side streets that met before the Museion. They put three beams crisscross at each other and hammered long nails into the joining at the middle to make large spikes and block the construction from falling apart. Then the spikes were put one above the other to form a neatly stacked and pointy wall, that was equipped with further beams all over to strengthen the whole thing.[76]
Before us, only around a hundred meters away, the battle already raged, our legionaries forming a phalanx over the street, still holding, even if barely. We left an opening in the barricade, because somehow the cohorts must be able to withdraw, but I also realized a weakness in my idea.
"If we set this on fire, it will be much too slow. We need to start it fast, immediately, when our troops are through." When looking around, I realized that the solution was right before me. I turned to Entrapta, who stood beside me in awe. The librarian hadn't

listened to my self-talk, but glanced at the fights.
I shook her out of it by putting my hands on her shoulders. "Entrapta, you must have old scrolls at the Library, don't you? What's happening to the ones that are already copied and no longer used?"
Her eyes lit up upon the topic. "Oh! Usually, we clean and use them again, but many of the very old ones are also used to make new ones. I call it 'recycling', because the resources put into the making are used another time again and again like in a circle. Unfortunately, nobody else wants to—"
"Fascinating, Entrapta, really", I cut her short, "can you show us where the old ones are stored?" She nodded, but hesitated, and I got that she was suspecting what I was going to do with them. Nonetheless, she started to lead me the way and I waved at Bow to follow us with his men in silence.

While we walked, she eyed me suspiciously, and finally I asked: "What? Just ask, bona dea."
"What are you going to do with them?" she inquired.
I thought about lying to her because I knew she was going to disagree with what I was going to do. But on the other side, she would find out nonetheless. So I shrugged my shoulders and casually said: "I wanna start a fire."
Not to my surprise, Entrapta panted and yelled, "No! You can't do that."
I deadpanned: "And why not? They are already copied, you said. Nothing is lost at all."
She shrieked. "But… but… burning scrolls isn't right. Out of principle! You can't burn knowledge! What if someone made a mistake while copying it? Or what—"

I cut her short again with a defiant gesture of my hand. "Entrapta, we need something to burn, right now! Or your whole nice library will become a war zone. And nobody knows what will happen then. So, recommend anything fitting, or I swear, I will just take some of your precious papyri by chance if you won't talk quick." Entrapta shrieked again, and it was a sound with the same meaning as "You took my children, how could you!"
After her first shock, she collected herself and pointed to another

room. We trudged over and inside it was obvious that it was used as a simple storage. Thousands of scrolls in every size and shape were neatly stacked in shelves that stretched through the whole room. She looked at the scrolls and said: "Take the notes from these, they are dispensable."
"What's that stuff for?" I asked, curious, which was a grave mistake.
"Tax," Entrapta deadpanned.
"What?" I found myself dumbstruck.
"It's our old tax paperwork. So, about taxes, their collections, deductions, calculations. Egypt has had a very well organized bureaucracy for many centuries. We kept some paperwork for research and justification, when the pharaoh wants to invent new taxes or alter existing ones. For example, when Ptolemaios III went to Antiochia to help his sister Berenice two centuries ago, he invented a tax on locusts, which you had to pay, when you didn't deliver so many dead locusts every beginning of autumn. He wanted to keep the yearly locust plagues at bay and raise money for his war and when— Oh, not helpful, right?"[77]
She must have realized how aghast I stared at her, then at the dozens of thousands of scrolls, then at her again, not being able to compute how much of a paperwork a nation could produce around a triviality like *taxes—this was just ridiculous—while* she was telling stories about ancient stuff *while behind us fucking war was going on*.
I heaved a breath, straightened myself and said: "Okay, I think we can burn the tax paperwork. It won't be missed."[78]

Bow and his men took as many scrolls as they could carry and rushed back outside to our nice barricade. The battle at the outer walls was as fierce as before, but I quickly noticed how the holes in our defenses grew. One cohort, the third, on the left side had already withdrawn to the ground, their archers had taken their stand on the roofs of nearby buildings and the wall behind us, while the infantry secured the streets and the escape route for all of them over the Canopus way.
While Bow's men stuffed the barricades with ancient tax writings rightfully upon to be burned, a tribunus[79], guarded by two

centuriones from the cohort before us, approached. “What’s the meaning of this?” the hard-eyed soldier asked with a tone used to command. Bow replied with a military terse. “We’re erecting a barricade that can be set on fire anytime to block the insurgents from reaching the inner wall.”
“At whose behest?” the man insisted, while behind him the third cohort marched through the barricade and the gate of the inner wall, manning the fortifications there now.
Bow smirked, raised his arm and pointed with his thumb back over his shoulder, directly at me. “Ask Caesar’s niece.”
I gulped, as the tribune stomped over to me. “You! You're a woman.” I held his gaze and he continued: “Who has enabled you to command this? The consul?”
I shook my head. “No. But I saw an opportunity for a defense and took it.” I pointed at the twice as high as a man barricade and the scrolls my men had put in between every pile of wood that we had stacked up. “If we set this on fire, it will burn within seconds and effectively block off the main road for hours. Then they have to split into the narrow alleyways. It will slow the attack down and enable your archers a more effective counter from the inner wall.” I stopped myself from rambling more and to give him the opportunity to let the idea sink in.

The tribune was pretty pissed about my interference, that much I could see. He was one of the old guard, not a patrician pupil, but a veteran soldier who didn’t give a shit on the opinions of civilians. This man did war as a business since years, and I was a stupid nuisance to him. But on the other hand, we'd done something actually useful. And I wasn’t a nobody, but a relative of the man he’d followed against his own senate. As it was the habit of his commander, he came to a quick conclusion and nodded shortly: “Good job, my lady. Now step aside. The first cohort will withdraw to the inner walls now. We will take care of your nice little surprise.” He pulled a corner of his mouth in what would be the most of what I'd get as appreciation. I was torn between protest and obedience. It grumbled in me to be pushed aside. Rationally, I knew I had no business here, a hundred meters away from the actual battle and in the middle of the escape route. But I still

didn't want to go. Only when Bow laid a hand on my shoulder and squeezed it lightly, I finally submitted by simply nodding as well. "Complete the barricade with the leftover spikes right there when you're done," I replied and pointed at the materials beside the stairs to the Museion. "Then just throw some torches in. It will burn long, and maybe long enough for Caesar to arrive." He nodded once in reply, then Bow rallied our men, and we withdrew to the gate.

Whistles blew, all at once. When I looked back at the Canopus way, I saw the first and second cohort withdrawing. The outer wall was now abandoned and in the hand of the enemy. The single centuries—or the remainders of them—retreated in trained maneuvers, always falling back step by step, overturning their comrades by doing so through their lines, then protecting them on their own withdrawal, and repeat. Behind them, the front line of the Egyptian army and a lot of insurgents from the Alexandrian populace advanced, after they were able to open the gate of the outer wall. After the last legionaries were behind the barricade, others, already waiting, closed it with the spikes and beams, under the protective hail of arrows of the archers on the inner wall and the watchtowers.

For a short moment the combats stopped.

Then the tribun yelled and half a dozen legionaries threw torches into the barricade. The fell between the logs and nothing exciting happened, just a few flames gently licked the scrolls. I held my breath in tension, and wasn't so sure anymore if my plan would work.
But then it took just half a minute more and the whole thing went up like a bonfire in rage. The enemy soldiers fell back a few paces because of the enormous heat that radiated from the piles of wood and papyri that we'd torched. And the fire still grew. Behind us, the archers started to fire small salves over the barricade, to prevent any attempt to remove it for the time being.
It quickly became clear that this obstacle would take some time to get rid of, and I clapped my hands for joy. At least, this idea had worked. I turned to Bow to—

What happened next I won't forget for the rest of my life.

Coming from the harbor, a *double lightning bolt* illuminated the nightly sky of all of Alexandria and outshone by far the constant and bright fire of the Lighthouse and of every source of light around us. For the glimpse of an eye it was as glaring bright as if a new but *otherworldly* sun had risen in the firmament, and the whole world was bathed in a ghostly white light. It was a frightening sight, something I had never seen before. Maybe this was Iuppiter Optimus Maximus, Zeus, Allfather himself, and he had enough of us. What if this was the omen of his everlasting, ultimate anger, opening the gates of Tartaros where we were going to receive our divine and final punishment. Did we offend the gods?

It became silent, because everywhere people stopped fighting and were watching the sky. Men with raised gladii stood still in the middle of their strike, archers paused while rising their arrows, officers stopped yelling at their men, and all the noise of war, the sounds of death went quiet. Everything froze.
I was aghast and felt goosebumps as every single hair on my body straightened up. My eyes dilated. “What—”

BOBOOOOOOMMMMmmm…

When the thunder arrived, the accompanying airstrike threw me back against the wall and nearly pushed me off my feet. I whined in pain. Next to me, the same happened to Bow. And to everyone. A storm surge of air blew from the north and the noise of the one-two punch was deafening, earth-shattering. Everything was in turmoil. A few seconds later, the air returned to where it came from, and now it sucked my breath away. Dust swirled, blew out torches and I as well as everyone around me was gasping,

shocked. Many people held their ears in fear and pain, some were even screaming. But the noises were only muffled, as if my hearing had been dimmed. Bits of stone started to rain down on us, mixed with splinters of wood and all sorts of other things, a hailstorm of rubble. Everyone without a helmet and not unconscious sought for shelter, fleeing into buildings, under roofs or shields. Nobody fought anymore.

Nobody could.

The agitated elements were slow to calm down. They came to rest as the wind died after what felt like minutes. It couldn't have been that long.

I was dazed and needed three bumpy tries to pick myself up, still stumbling, then leaning against the wall in my back. My head felt just numb. I held my nose and pressed air back into my ears because my eardrums were sore. My clothes were a mess and partly torn, my hair fluttered loosely around, everything was dirty. Dust hung in the air, and it smelt like smoke and *something else, something I never smelt before.* Still burning scrolls from our barricade twirled around in the air, looking like scary lanterns that slowly fell down to the ground again.
Around me, the picture was the same everywhere. Men tried to gather themselves, Bow held his head but seemed okay otherwise, and some of our soldiers were still sitting on the ground and shook their heads to collect. Across our still burning barricade, it was the same picture. Nobody sought to pick up the fight again. The light was gone again, the nightly sky was back, only that a flickering firelight was now to be seen through the haze, and it came from the harbor.

What the fuck had happened?

Accompanied by sounds of groans and lament, I slowly stumbled through the open gate and to the stairs to the watchtower, climbing it again to gain a better overlook. I needed thrice the time as before, paused because I needed breath, and when I reached its top and was able to look over at the harbor, the sight

hit me like a falling rock. The harbor was illuminated by fires and there was a massive column of smoke, no, rather multiple columns of smoke. Hadn't there been buildings? And ships? And then it became clear that the docks or the Egyptian fleet itself wouldn't be much of a problem from now on.

Because the Navalia were gone.
And half the fleet with them.
The rest was burning.

"Oh Bellona[80], what have you done," I hoarsely croaked, and wondered if anyone around the naval port could have survived this… what had that been? And then the thought struck my mind and I whispered: "Catra?"

Catra

The plan had been simple: walk to the Navalia, sneak into the weapons chamber of the shipyard, fetch the *Pyr autòmaton*, deploy it along the docks and set everything behind you on fire. Quick and easy. And because *Pyr* was an excellent fire accelerator, it should've been a cakewalk. We could've done it while running and throwing torches into it.

The magic stuff was one of the best kept secrets of the Egyptian fleet, its recipe developed in innumerable experiments by some of our best scholars and today hidden in the Library itself within an inconspicuous shelf amongst trivial philosophical matters two dudes talked about ages ago. Nobody would find it there. Only a few high ranking officers of the armed forces knew about it, as well as the acting Pharaohs and their counselors. In better times, we would've used it with ship-based catapults on our enemies, to set *their* ships on fire — and not *our own*. Today, I would use it to burn our fleet, to burn down Cleopatra's fleet. I understood why

she didn't like it, why she didn't want it. The fleet was a valuable asset for anyone sitting on the throne. But none of this whining of hers would really help. It had to be done. We needed Caesar's ships with his men, we needed them now, and that was that.

I'd selected a group of six men from Cleo's Medjai as they were able to keep silent and mostly invisible, and they knew every corner of the city. I equipped myself with a pair of middle-sized daggers, as the scimitar would've been too large and impractical to carry when sneaking around. When we left the palace, there were only a few people out on the streets, mostly Cleopatra's guards, some of Caesar's soldiers, and a few servants and other folk that inhabited the palace area. The tensions and quarrels of the last week already drove half the regular population out of the royal quarter, and the battle of this night only added up to the flight of people.

Still within the palace grounds, we walked towards the docks until we reached the wall to the west. The only gate was down at the Canopus way, but here only a few small and old doors had been. They were bricked up now. On the wall, legionaries of the fourth cohort of the 13th legion patrolled and the officer on duty reported that it had been quiet, at least so far. "We hear that in the south, at the Museion, an attack is underway." I nodded, seriousness in my eyes. "I'm on my way to do something against that, centurio. Count on it. Watch out for the docks and when they are burning, you should be able to support your comrades there." I knew he glanced after me, surely not used to receive tactical advice by a woman.

We used two rope ladders to lower us down from the wall beside one of the watchtowers. That was something I always hated. I was good at running, riding, fighting with blades, yelling at people, scaring people and teasing people. I was good at giving Cleo a hard time. I could unnerve people. Rope ladders weren't my thing, though. When we'd reached the ground, we quickly hid in the shadows of the adjacent buildings. We would have to pass several trade and living houses, most of them four or five stories

high, and of the same type. I hadn’t to order my team much, because everyone knew the plan and what to do.

The first two alleyways were easy, but when our scout signaled that the next crossing was blocked by soldiers standing guard. We had to adapt. I tried several doors in our street and found one open. We sneaked into the building, which felt empty. Many citizens had left this part of the city, because of - hehe - a fucking war was going on. I decided to not care about civilians and waved my men. We weaved through the typical inner yard of the surrounding buildings and reached the other side of the block. One of my men peeked outside, waving all-clear to us, and we quickly rushed further through three, four other streets until we reached the end of the house blocks and the navalia lay before us. I heaved a breath to steady myself and to take a second to take in the surroundings.

The weapons chamber was a low, long-stretched building with stone walls and an alike roof. It faced the port on the short side and had numerous entrances from both of the long sides.
To our luck, the alleys between all the port buildings were stuffed with all sort of goods, boxes, bags, odds and ends. We had a lot of places to hide. Unluckily, the chamber was heavily guarded. Half a dozen men stood before the only open entrance, and I assumed that more would be inside. We slowly climbed the roof and sneaked beside the eastern roof ridge towards the entrance. I peeked down at the guards. They were still unaware of our presence, but we couldn’t wait for too long here. Our moving shadows were just too visible against the darker roof. A searching look up from a little further away, and we would be spotted. We needed to get down.

My men lined up at the eave. On my sign, all jumped down onto one guard each, while I went to the side for support. Strangled noises of surprise were cut down quickly, as daggers found their way into cuts and over throats. I was stunned by the precision with which the Medjai got their work done. I was good with blades, but these men understood their business very well. The six guards lay on the ground and I looked around if anyone had

noticed our doing. In the distance, another squad of soldiers patrolled along the quay, but they moved away from us, and didn’t look back.
One of my men slowly opened the door and sneaked inside. After a few moments, he pushed open the entrance and let us in. It was dark inside, and to my surprise, there wasn’t anyone else guarding there. Maybe all excess soldiers had been ordered to support the attack.

We lighted up a few torches and looked around, seeing dozens of small barrels standing at the walls to the left and right, neatly stacked above each other. When I opened one of them at the side, a black, powdery substance trickled out. It smelled weird and nothing like I'd experienced it before. That must it be, the Pyr!
Now would come the tricky part. We would have to take enough Pyr to deploy it amongst the docks next to us and to set them on fire, while not getting caught by the guards scurrying around. My plan was to set up a trap fire in the western part of the harbor, then working our way back towards the east.

I ordered two of my men to get a barrel each and out of here, when I heard noises from the outside. There were men yelling alarm and from all over the dipping fleet calls were made. At the entrance, two of my Medjai had fought down guards and looked back at me apologetically. Our cover was blown and my nice plan with her. “It’s not your fault,” I grouched, while my heartbeat fastened, and gripped the handle of my dagger.

It got worse. As I saw dozens of torches being lit up on the galleys, I realized my false assumption. The troops weren't at the docks, they were on the ships! The damned idiot of Achillas had put his soldiers on the ships, presumably expecting them to be charged by Caesar’s fleet in the morning, and wanting them to be ready. That could destroy the better part of my plan, because when the crews saw the docks burning, they would just row the ships away, for fucks sake. The fucking ships would be safe and fine, I grimly thought and clenched my hands. Shit, so much for our plan.

There was nothing to be done about that. Not in such a short time and with only a squad. At least, we might be able to take out the docks and the ships on the slips, I tried to ease me. If they couldn't use the port for maintenance, that was a good thing, too.
Little boats started to row over from the nearest galleys, and on them, enough troops to catch or kill us, that much was clear. We wouldn’t stand a chance against half a century or more. What should I do? What could I even do? I hated making decisions under pressure. They were never good.

And so it happened. I made a snap decision. We couldn’t get this stuff away, and there wouldn’t be another try.

“Run!” I shouted to my men. “I set all of it on fire, right here. Seek shelter between the houses, on the ground. I don’t know what will happen when all of this burns at once.” They clearly hadn’t a clue what was about to happen either, and took the hint. I just assumed it would be bad enough, that it would at least set the docks on fire. Nodding, they followed my command and were away immediately.
I cracked open the barrel next to me and overturned by pushing it open with my foot. Then I carefully drew a line with the Pyr, around the barrel and further back to the door. I needed to be quick. When I peeked outside and over to the quay, I saw a first squad of troops climbing up the pier, maybe 50 meters away, with other boats directly behind. It was about fucking time to get away from here. I threw my torch down on the fuse of the fire accelerator.
When I saw the Pyr sparkling and finally inflaming, I shouted in a crazy madness toward the troops: “Cleopatra send her regards!”[81] and laughed madly.

Then I ran.

Chapter End Notes

> Historians might hate me for this. But I like the blow I pulled here.

Originally, the next chapter was one with this. But the story blew up, and I needed time for editing.
Also, the chapter count has been upped one more time.

The next chapter is called **"The Burning of the Library of Alexandria II"** and will be published on Friday, August 6, 2021.

[72] *Aries*, battering rams, were widely using in ancient times until the Middle Ages, and proved to be effective siege weapons against gates and walls made of wood, brick and stones. They were easy to built given enough wood and were made in all sizes, the rams itself often capped with metal heads. *Testudines* were used to shelter the rams (and men) against being attacked from above with wooden roofs or similar. ↑
[73] The second half of this sentence is a derivation from "Wicked Games", Chapter 5 ↑
[74] If you want a nice visualization of these last few seconds, imagine Adora like Beckett here. *giggle* ↑
[75] The Furiae, Furies, or *Erinyes* in Greek, are female deities of vengeance, especially on those who have sworn a false oath or committed murder on relatives. In some myths, Hades and Persephone are displayed as their parents. The motive of the Erinyes has been incorporated in many modern drama works, e.g. Neil Gaiman's "The Sandman" or Percy Jackson and the Olympians. ↑
[76] In case it isn't clear enough, I'm imagining something like the Czech hedgehog.↑
[77] Okay, I made this up. Ptolemaios III didn't do such a thing. But strange and weird taxes had been invented since 5,000 years and so, he could have totally done it. There have been taxes on having latrines in your house (Vespasian), for having a beard (Czar Peter the Great), on sparrows, yes, sparrows, where you had to deliver dead sparrows otherwise you had to pay the tax (Charles Eugene, Duke of Württemberg) or for being a virgin after the age of 20 in Berlin at the beginning of the 19th century, and so much more ridiculous bullshit.↑

[78] I absolutely admit that I stole "burn that tax stuff" from "The Day After Tomorrow" and I'm proud of it.↑
[79] A tribunus at Caesar's time was a high ranking officer between the legate (legatus) and the centurion (centurio). He usually commanded at least a cohort, sometimes a whole legion. I will use the term 'tribune' for easy reading. ↑
[80] Bellona was a Roman goddess of war. Her name stems from the earlier *Duellona*, a derivative of *duellum*, the old Latin word for war and warfare, that turned into *bellum* (war) in classical Latin. Bellona had a temple in Rome, that was mainly cared for by the gens Claudia, that was part of the Julio-Claudian Dynasty, which I already mentioned in Ch.5. ↑
[81] Uuuh…. I'm only partly proud of this. But I did it anyway. I'm not sorry. ↑

The Burning of the Library of Alexandria II

Chapter Summary

That sounds like a you-problem, doesn't it?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Alexandria, Egypt - January, 47 BCE


Lighthouse of Pharos
Palace Harbour
Royal Quarter
Gate of the Sun
Heptastadium
Fleet Port
Canopic Way
Library of Alexandria
Gate of the Moon

Catra

I ran for my life, hurtled around the corner of the entrance, away from the soldiers and the fire-to-be, along the long side of the weapons chambers towards the city. How much time did I have until the Pyr would set everything alight? And what would happen? Would the stockpile of Pyr be enough to create a large fire for the docks to be burn down?
I had no fucking clue, but I ran, and reached the first line of stone buildings a few dozen meters away. Behind me, the soldiers yelled. The possibility to be chased drove me further. I panted but tried my luck, and sprinted into the next best alleyway, the stone under my feet grinding, trying to make as much distance as possible. I reached the next crossing, turned left into the alleyway, then another crossing, even more narrow, into the next alley on the right and here I threw myself into the entrance of a large insula and tried to be as quiet as possible. Behind me, soldiers called, but any moment the fire should start, shouldn't it? I didn’t know what to expect from so much Pyr going up in flames, but I assumed it would create a large fire. A *very large*, nice fire, that would be clearly enough to distract the soldiers from searching for me.

Tere I crouched, like an idiot, and nothing happened. When I raised my head, I saw a man looking out of his window, and wildly gestured to him to draw back. Not a second too late.

The sky was lit by a double flash that bathed everything in a strange, ghostly light. I was blinded by the lightning, and instinctively laid an arm over my eyes. Not a second later, a deafening echo of thunder swept over the block of buildings. Then came a wind surge that nearly blew me away, despite *I was fucking laying on the ground*. But the ground also shook, and it was so loud! I held my ears in pain, but nonetheless I heard how the beams of the roofs above me creaked and rattled heavily, while the thunder rolled. And rolled. A hailstorm of dust, splinters, rubble, and ash started to pelt down. Needles pierced me, and I tried to protect my head with my arms. I didn’t remember fearing for my life so deeply ever before, but now I did. Gone was my

cool demeanor, always-so-controlled. I was lying on the ground like a coward, I screamed, while around me the world blew up in a fire that I had set.
The tumult only ebbed slowly. Dust whirled around, and was still taking my breath away. I coughed hard several times to get my throat clear, trying to shield myself from inhaling more ash by covering my face with a piece of my cloth. It took minutes for air and earth to pacify.

Finally, I was able to gather myself, still shaky from the reverberation of the… what even had that been? Somehow I had the feeling that I lacked the fitting word for what had happened. I stumbled forward to the corner of the building to peek around at the crossing. But there was still too much dust and smoke in the air, I couldn't even see the end of the block. Luckily, one of the doors nearby had been blown open, and I quickly found a stair at the inner yard of the insula that went to the roof. I dragged myself up, slowly, because breathing was still hard, and I coughed more often now.[82]

While slowly climbing the four-story building, my thoughts wandered to Adora. Was she okay? Was Cleo? Cleo, surely. The palace should be far enough away. But had Adora stayed there? Or had she done something incredibly stupid, and put herself in danger again because she just couldn't sit still? I silently chuckled to myself. Adora and her damned attitude to solve everything in her reach. Never back up, never standing down, always trying to fix things. It was just another quality that I loved in her—

Aaah, of course. There it was.

The undeniable, simple, blank truth.

I loved her. I loved Adora.

My steps had stopped, and I had to hold myself at the wall, when recognizing what lay open before me now. Trembling, I stood at the staircase of this empty building, and gasped upon the realization that took me risible long enough.Tears dwelled in my

eyes, and they weren't from the ash.
“I’m such an idiot,” I mumbled to myself. “I’m such an idiot.” Silent laughter filled the yard and the stairwell, and I listened to it in wonder until I noticed that it was me who laughed. It had just needed one giant strike of the gods to make me aware of my feelings towards her. It was ridiculous. I had feared the realization, I had feared it all the time. Now I knew, and there was no use in denying it any longer and somehow, it gave me peace. Yes, I found myself in an impossible position. The Roman patrician would never be able to enter into a relationship with me. And despite the hopelessness, it was a relief just to know. I didn't have to tell her about it, and I wouldn't. But I knew.

Shaking my solidification off, I started to walk further. Saying “I’m so doomed,” was the last coherent thought I managed, before my internal revelations were cut short when I reached the roof. As I turned to the northern side to watch over at the harbor, to the navalia and the fleet, it struck me like a second airstrike. It was still hard to see something through all the smoke, but at least the fire of the burning ships was very visible. Because the fleet burned. Or rather, the remainder of it. With my mouth agape and my mind unwilling to process what I saw, I stood at the railing for minutes, and watched the scenario that lay before me.

A word that went through my mind was *Pandaimonion*.[83] This was how it had to look if the gods would finally punish us for our deeds and sins, when the End times were heralded for judgement to be brought upon us.

Where the docks had been ten minutes ago, there was now a kind of hole in the ground that was still burning, with a mushroom-shaped cloud over it that slowly dissipated in the dark night. Most of the piers and jetties were gone, and behind this nothingness, half the fleet had sunk while the other half was burning, illuminating the sky and scene like a macabre joke. Ships over ships, half sunken, masts broken, sails in flames. On board of the still floating galleys, men of their crews shouted, trying to help their mates or to ready yawls to catch people out of the water. Distant screaming reached me, muffled, dimmed, difficult to hear.

Behind all of it, still the Lighthouse was glowing, guiding ships to a harbor that no longer existed.

Because of me.

I did this.

I must've killed hundreds of people, maybe thousands, with my snap reaction.

The realization hit me like a falling rock. My hands grabbed the stone railing tight. Someone panted heavily, and it took my crunching brain some time to notice that it was me. Tears were streaming down my cheek, and they took my breath with them. Because I did this. I gasped and settled down on the ground when my legs gave in. My hands grabbed something. My head hurt. I hyperventilated. My thinking was falling apart. Why did I have hair in my fists? Deep sobs escaped me as I sat. Trying to clear my head.
I thought winning would be different. Or at least more..., I didn't know, not feel like that. Not so… wrong.[84]

An uncounted amount of time later, I walked, or rather stumbled back to the palace wall, encountering confused people, some hurt, other seeking for answers or simply help. None of the soldiers barricading streets earlier was still there, presumably fled or on their way to help their mates at the port. Finding the place where we'd climbed down before shouldn't have taken so long, but my confused state mistook the watchtower, and so I wasted minutes with the wrong one. My head hurt, and my ears were ringing. I finally got that I was at the wrong place, then trudged along the wall to the next tower. It was still dark, and around me, I noticed how people were looking out of their shattered houses, tumbling across the street in search of explanations for an event unoccured ever before. I didn't speak to anyone, couldn't speak to anyone, didn't dare to, I just ducked my head and walked further.

When I reached the watchtower, I had to lean against the dark brick wall, the fortification looming over me. I felt horrible. And

needed a minute to muster the courage and breath to make the callsign. Above, a soldier threw the rope ladder down again. Slowly I climbed it up and when I reached the top of the wall, I sat down, laid myself with my back against the pinnacles and took another deep breath. I felt horrible, and my side still hurt.
"--- --- -------?" the legionary asked, his question with a somehow caring sound, but I understood nothing. I raised my head and blinked at the man, a few times, and realized that my hearing was damaged or something like that, because it still sounded so muffled, like I had a thick towel around my ears. "What?" I asked, and gestured at my ears.
"Are you alright?" the man repeated, now shouting it, and still, it was hard to hear and understand. I made a somewhat nodding gesture, still disoriented, bewildered because of my lack of hearing.

I stood up, watched around and didn't dare to take another look at the navalia - the *former* navalia, I reminded myself. Instead, I looked at the palace at the other side of the harbor. It seemed to be unharmed, which relieved me a little. As I looked further around, I noticed that the Museion was also burning. Low flames broke out of the building, and that was strange, actually. "What's happening there?" I asked, and the soldier replied: "As far as I've been told, they erected a makeshift barricade over the Canopus way, and set it on fire to block the Egyptian army from approaching the inner wall." He leaned against his spear and looked over at the burning Museion, not sounding too concerned at all. "Somehow the building must have caught fire after… whatever you did at the docks. Maybe due to the air surge." He shrugged his shoulders, obviously not very concerned about the fact how the collected knowledge of humanity was just about to go up in flames. "But I think it was a pretty cool idea of her."

I'd still watched the growing fire and thought about the consequences of losing the Library, as the realization of his words penetrated my slowly working brain. "Her? What do you mean with 'her'?"
He huffed. "Ehmm, the tall blonde? Caesar's… niece, I think? She has a small guard and came up with the idea. They made the

barrier.”
Was she crazy? “What? Did you see her there, Adora Minor?”
“Eh, yeah? I mean, we walked by her and her men when we withdrew from the outer wall. She’s… hard to miss, isn’t she?” He sounded as amused as admiring, and I gritted my teeth. Had Adora already worshipers among the people? I scolded myself upon my instant jealousy. “Is… is she still there?”
He looked at me questioningly. “I think so? She was there, maybe half an hour ago, right before you blew everything up.” By saying this, he chuckled and added. “Well done, by the way. I’ve been fighting with Caesar for five years now, and I’ve never seen anything like this. My ears are still ringing. I think I’m grateful for this fucking thing for the first time.” He patted his galea[85] with his spear in a somewhat funny gesture, and I fell into his chuckling.
“Yeah,” I replied, still too loud. “That was quite a bang. My normal hearing still hasn’t returned.”

I tried to punch down my nagging guilt and the feeling of self-loathing that had taken a seat in my gut, and straightened.
“Thank you. Can I walk over the wall to the Museion?”
He shrugged his shoulders. “Sure. I mean, it’s your city, right? I’m just doing my job or whatever, and nobody told me that you couldn’t. Maybe that it’s too crowded on the wall around the Canopus gate, but you’ll just see it then, right?”
“Right”, I agreed, “Thank you again.”
“Anytime, pretty lady,” he replied, friendly while tipping his galea with the tip of his spear again before he turned back to watch the burning harbor. I couldn't, then started to walk along the wall while trying to shake off the rest of my haze. At least, it was only a few hundred meters.

The nearer I came to the Museion, the clearer it became, that not the whole building was on fire. It rather concerned the front parts of it, along the Canopus way, while the rear one were still unharmed and quiet. More and more soldiers were guarding the wall, and it became more difficult to walk behind them, as all space at the not too broad coping was full. The soldiers mostly didn’t care, but the decuriones and centuriones threw me angry

glances because I distracted their precious order. The most interesting finding, however, was that the fighting had stopped. At least, I heard nothing of the previous battle noise anymore. Finally, I approached the watchtower beside the main gate from the Canopus way and beside the burning Museion. As I drew closer, I noticed how the flames licked at the windows and seeped through the holes in the roof, creating an eerie and crackling noise that seemed to fill the air around. The smoke was thick and heavy, and it was difficult to see much beyond the immediate area. I paused for a moment, taking in the scene before me, and tried to assess the situation. The flames seemed to be spreading, and it was clear that the situation was rapidly becoming more dangerous.

Despite the raging inferno that was consuming the Museion, I also noticed that there seemed to be very little done to keep the flames at bay, even if the former battle had stopped. The Egyptian army had withdrawn to the outer wall and swarmed it, but they didn't advance anymore. Maybe they were also counting their toll from my… whatever it was that I'd done. At the Museion, a few people were running up and down the stairs of a side entry that still was out of reach of the fire. They were carrying scrolls and other stuff from inside the building, obviously trying to save it. I went down to the ground and searched for a commanding officer, until I found a grimly looking tribune, who stood right before the gate and watched the blaze.

I greeted him sluggishly: "Ave tribune!"
He turned his attention to me and rolled his eyes. "By Jupiter Maximus, is this the day when every woman of Alexandria is joining warfare? Can't you let the men do their business and stay at home, woman?"

That wasn't a very good start for our conversation, and I was already unnerved. My ears were not okay, I'd developed a proper headache, guilt consumed my inners, and this man was pissing me. But he obviously knew something about Adora.
"I would, if you guys had done your job better. But since you were just messing around, I just had to take care of it myself."

He glared at me irritated: “Excuse me, who the fuck are you even?”
“Absolutely unimportant.” I wasn’t in the mood for lengthy explanations. “I want to-”
“Then why don't you go back to your kitchen, missy? We have important things to deal with. You know. Keeping your pretty asses alive and all.”
I rolled my eyes. “Yeah, I already took care of that.”
“What do you mean?”
“You noticed the little, very loud noise right before? That sunk the Egyptian fleet? I did this. You’re welcome.”
It was obvious he didn't believe a word I said. “You’re kidding me, little lady.”
“Arrr! Call me that one more time, and I scratch your eyes out and feed them to Cleopatra’s panthers.” Cleo had no panthers. Panthers were a myth. “Now tell me where Adora is, immediately.”
“Who do you think—”
“THAT IS AN ORDER, TRIBUNE!”

The man actually stood to attention, a sign of the Legion's still strict military order, when confronted with a voice that held command and brooked no argument.[86] “Well done, tribune, well done. On behalf of Cleopatra, I demand that you tell me the whereabouts of Adora Minor, Caesar’s niece. If you doubt my authority, get in touch with Rufio. But only after you told me where she is. NOW!” And as he did, it horrified me to get to know. *That stupid idiot.* And I didn’t mean him. “And you let her go?” I screamed at him.
He shrugged his shoulders and pointed with his sword at the burning building. “Who am I to tell Caesar’s niece what to do? I’m not crazy. She was very determined.”
“You should’ve put her under arrest before she willingly threatens her life. What do you think will happen when she dies, and you could’ve prevented it? I swear, if she’s harmed in any way, I will make sure that you end up in the last outpost of your fucking realm, and never come back.”

Without waiting for an answer, I ran through the gate and towards the side entrance along the wall. The area between the inner and outer walls — where the damned Museion laid — was now kind of a no-man's-land, squeezed between two armies ogling each other. Only that at its eastern side, directly towards the inner wall, people were running in and out and trying to save… scrolls. They just threw them down on the street, then ran back into the building. The burning building. I facepalmed myself. They really risked their lives for writing. And among them, of course, the everhelping, superkind, problemsolving Adora of the Julii, that couldn't bear the thought of doing nothing even to save her life. Sweet, stupid Adora. I only saw a glimpse of her blonde hair, but when I reached the stairs to the side entrance she was already back in the building, while the fire grew and took over part after part.

I saw Bow, his arms full of scrolls, running out of the entrance and got hold of him. "Where is she?"
"Catra!" he startled. "You live? Oh goddess, thank you. We—"
"Yeah, yeah, I'm hard to kill. Where is Adora?"
"She's back inside, with Entrapta. They try to fetch some important ancient writings before they… yeah, you know." He looked a little worried.
I didn't hide my disbelief. "Important writings, no shit? Are they going to kill themselves because of scrolls or what?"
Bow glanced at me, trying to process my word. "Uhm, yeah? Entrapta is beside herself, and she tries to save as much as she can. And Adora… you know." He shrugged his shoulders, throw the scrolls he held on the pile with the others, and grabbed my arm. "Come on, we're looking for them."

We ran up the stairs and through the small porticus, then Bow went right, alongside rooms where the fire already raged in our sight. Smoke started to fill the air. Clearly, time was running up for using this way out. He guided us straight ahead through three, four, five rooms, then left through another four rooms, deeper into the building. Even here, smoke wafted around and made breathing difficult more and more. We coughed. "They were in the next room," Bow called as we hurried on.

But as we rushed in, nobody was to be seen. Behind us, the small current of people that rushed around, thinned out. The room had two other entrances, one to the left — where the fire was — and one to the right, away from it.
"And now?" I asked.
"I don't have a clue. They were here, Entrapta rummaged through these shelves, and they shouldn't have needed much time. Maybe there was a different way out?"

Maybe, but I doubted it. Our way was the quickest one, that much I noticed. I wildly looked around, pondering what to do, when we heard someone screaming. Of course, it came from where the fire was. I rushed into the next room, which exited into a small hallway to the right. Further! There the screaming came from. The hallway stretched to both sides and around a little inner yard that was open to the sky, an impluvium. On the right side, I saw Entrapta, yelling, holding scrolls, and before her, burning beams that had fallen down from the roof or wherever. She shouted into the room, but all the smoke made breathing harder by the minute, and she coughed repeatedly. I pulled her back from the fire, and tried to peek through the blocked entry, but the fire was too large, too hot. Fuck. "She's in there, isn't she?" I called at Entrapta and shook her be her shoulders. "Yes! It's… we wanted… she just…"
Entrapta was under shock, I could see. She was of no help here. "Bow! Get her out of here. I fetch Adora." Not waiting for his reply, I turned around to the burning and blocked entrance and yelled: "Adora! Adoraaa!"

After the third call, she answered, coughing. "C- Catra!"
"Are you alright, are you injured?"
More coughing. "I'm… okay. Hard to breathe. Lying on… *cough*… the ground."
"Got it! Hold on." I looked around. What could I do? Could I push the burning beams and cracked stones aside? No, I would've needed half a dozen men to move them. Not to mention the fire. I looked up at the opening of the impluvium. "Adora? Does your room have an opening in the roof?"

Coughing. “There's a hole, where the beams came down.” More coughing. “Can't reach it, already tried. Too high.” Much more chugging. That sounded bad.

“I try to get a rope or something and lower it from there. I get you, Adora. Hold on.” Despite my encouraging words, I felt desperate, because I had no clue where to get a rope. Running back outside to get one from the legionaries might take too much time. Adora couldn't breathe, and was trapped. On the other side of her room, the fire was closing in, and her only way out was blocked. I ran around the impluvium and quickly searched the adjacent rooms for at least something to help, but of no avail. When I ran back to Adora, the fire had grown, taken over parts of the roof now. Time was running out. “Hold on, Adora, I’ll get help.”

No answer.

Fear seized me.

“Adora?”, I shouted again. “Adoraaa!”

There was nothing beside the crackling and creaking of the fire and of collapsing beams. Was she unconscious? Or… I refused to finish the thought and felt panic. Frantic, I stepped forward to the fire, trying to get a look into the room where she laid, but the insane heat drove me back again. I felt despair, was out of ideas, and Adora needed my help, only that I was of no help, and now she already might be dead, but she… she just couldn’t be. She couldn’t. Because I couldn’t imagine a world without her. I just could not.
“Catra!” a voice behind me called. As I turned around, I saw Bow. Behind him, several soldiers, legionaries, carrying a battering ram and shields.
“Thank Isis!” I sighed, and he patted my shoulder, nudging me to the side.
The soldiers made short work of the collapsed, burning beams. They pushed the largest one aside with the ram, and then used their spears to drag the smaller ones to the side. Using their

shields to protect themselves from the burning door frame and the remains, they stormed in and only seconds later they hurried out again, carrying the unconscious Adora. She didn't look injured, but her hair was wildly hanging around, and her face was smeared with ash. She looked like dead, and despite her messy state, glorious.
We were out of the burning Library in a rush, roofs behind us collapsing as we ran through the room. As soon as we were outside I quickly turned my mind away. We had just made it.

I knocked at her door. Even hours later, and thanks to my damaged hearing, I didn't hear her replying anything, so I just opened it. The doctor was long gone and Adora lay in her bed, looking at me. She wore a simple gown for the night and looked unbelievably tired. She hadn't been burnt, but she almost suffocated on the smoke. Her gaze was illegible, but somewhat somber. I walked over beside her bed and asked, "May I?", while patting on the mattress beside her. She nodded, I sat down, and silence fell upon us.

After we'd rescued Adora, everyone else was forced out of the burning Library, and then we just left the building to its fate. Miraculously, the fire stopped somewhere in the middle of the structure, maybe because there were mainly study rooms with few papyri and empty inner yards with not many things to burn. Or perhaps we were just lucky. Both armies stood on their respective walls, ogling each other, but nobody did anything to stop the fire at all. The idiots just let it burn. Not that I cared about the scrolls, papyri, books, whatever. But I knew it had been important to Cleo.

Now, as I sat beside Adora, she avoided looking at me, her eyes wandering around the room restlessly, out of the window, to her

lap, anywhere but me. I didn't take long for the quiet to become uncomfortable.
It finally drove me to ask: “Why did you do this, you dummy? It was nothing but stupid, running into a burning building.”
Adora looked down at her lap and fumbled with her fingers. I got to know that she always did this when becoming nervous — or rather embarrassed. “Hey, don’t be so. Only because I tell you that you did stupid, you don’t have to feel blameworthy.”
She closed her eyes and shook her head.
“What’s really bothering you?” I asked.
Just a whisper, barely audible. “It’s -- -----.”
My hearing was still not great, and I didn’t understand what she was saying so quietly. Hoping it'd help, I patted my ears, and asked “What?”
She repeated, louder. “It is my fault. The library.”
“Huh? What do you mean by that?”
“That it’s burning. I’m responsible for the burning barricade before it. And when this… blast went through the city, the air surge blew up the burning scrolls we’d used to set it on fire all around. It was like a… I’ve never seen something crazy like that. Some of them fell into the Museion and then…” She made a gesture with her hands, perhaps meant to indicate a rising fire.
I blinked, several times. She couldn’t mean that for real, could she? “Adora, are you… are you blaming yourself that the Library burnt?” My voice sounded absolutely infidel, but the adorable idiot just nodded.

I started cackling.

I was laughing so hard that my belly started to hurt, and I nearly fell off my chair. This was so ridiculous. There the pretty, stupid, idiot laid, injured, nearly died while trying to save fucking scrolls because she thought SHE was responsible for something I’d done. This woman was unbelievable.
My guffawing held for a while, until it died down in quieter chuckles. Adora glared angrily at me. “You don’t take me seriously!” she accused me, and she sounded mad. I shook my head and replied: “Of course I don’t, Adora. Because… you know, the blast, that sucked your damned scrolls away and set

everything on fire… that was me. I did it. I started your fire, you damn idiot.” Deep in my chest, my guilt quelled, but now it was pushed away by my laughter that started again. A weight lifted off me.

I was relieved. Relieved, that Adora was okay, that I was okay, that we made it through this night of utter madness and that she was still there. Bowing forward, I laid my forehead on hers, and she didn’t withdraw. “I did it. You did nothing wrong, Adora. And besides, it’s just a building with old texts. It can be rebuilt, scrolls can be rewritten, things can be reimagined. It’s not like it is the end of the world. Maybe some scholars will have to look out for a real job for a while. It's going to be okay.”

Heaving a deep breath mentioned to stop myself from rambling helped a little. Funnily, it just got me enough air to continue, because I wanted to assure her, and didn’t get the downward slope I took while talking. “It’s just a fucking building, Adora, not worth mentioning. It’s only stones and woods and can be rebuilt. Thoughts can be rethought. You did nothing wrong. It wasn't your fault. But what I did at the harbor… it’s… it’s irredeemable. I set the world on fire, and this won’t be the last time we’ve seen this. And now that everyone is aware what the Pyr is capable of, everyone will want it.” I pulled my hair. “The genie of fire is out of the bottle, Adora, and we can’t put him back. We just can’t…“
I shivered and started panting again, while Adora watched my mental breakdown in a kind of shock. It was just a whisper when I said: “I burnt a dozen of ships, Adora. I’ve killed thousands there. Thousands. I just wanted to carry out the plan, to help fulfill Cleo’s dreams, to protect you. But that’s not how I—”

Adora embraced me. She cut my babbling short by putting her face in front of mine. The previous worry over her part of the events was lessened to a mere glimpse of its former self. Her eyes were so near, so teary, so wonderfully blue. I drowned in her look, that was so caring, so trusting, full of… I hesitated to finish the thought, because that couldn't be, it mustn't be. But I let my hand cup her cheek. She laid hers on mine and leaned into it, while closing her eyes. “Thank you,” Adora whispered so gently, with a

voice soft like the winds of the Cyrenaica. “Thank you, Catra. You didn’t do it because you’re malevolent, or mad. You did it because you care. This is a war, remember it. You care about your sister, about your people, even about me. I see it. It tells me all I need to know about who you are. You made a mistake, but that doesn't make you one. You didn’t do wrong, Catra.” She petted my hair while I quietly sniveled into her collarbone. She smelled so good. “Whatever you think you did wrong, I forgive you. To me, you are perfect.”
Never had I heard gentler words. My silent sobbing turned into loud and elongated crying, and I grabbed her shoulders to steady me, to back me, and she just held me and kissed my forehead ever so softly.

My tears stopped falling an unknown time later. It could've been minutes or hours. I found myself still embraced by the woman I knew I was deeply in love with. I hadn’t forgotten the realization from before, because the knowledge had burnt deep into me. Adora’s hand trailed my side and came to rest on my own. I still laid comfortable on her chest and lap, nuzzling into the warmth of her body, to which I heard her humming. And somehow that was all I needed, all I needed to throw my worries away. This here was safety. Adora would never let me down, I realized.

Some people say that all good things come in threes.

I started to relate to the saying when, well, when Adora tilted her head and brushed her lips over mine, with a searching gaze and a smile that was a little cocky. Kissing her the third time was just as wonderful as the first two. Different, but neither better nor worse. Our first kiss had been the one of drunken idiots, eager, desperate, wet, greedy. The second had been hasty, sloppily, nearly too quick to remember.
The third was… gentle, and confident. She drew back a bit and asked carefully: “Is this okay?”
I was perplexed. A short, hoarse laugh bubbled out of my throat. “Are you kidding me? Yes, yes!”
She smirked. “Eager. But I can work with that.” Adora grabbed my neck with a gentle hand, pulled me in, clearly demanding more

closeness as she brushed our cheeks along each other. I shortly wondered about her sudden confidence, but I neither wanted to complain nor to hesitate.

I wanted this.

And I wanted her. Every fiber in me told her to go on. So she did, as she pecked kisses along my neck, leaving a slight trail with her lips. I crooned, while her hand yanked at my curls just a bit, drawing at them softly to tilt my head back and to expose my throat. She couldn't possibly… Oh, gods.
"Ah… Adora," I sighed and must've sounded desperate as she peppered my cheeks and throat with eager kisses. All of this felt so good, so right. It was nothing but… kindness. Explorative, but kind. Despite her being the one laying in a bed, *I* felt cared for when our lips met again. They were so soft, so damp and swollen when they brushed over mine tenderly. We took our time to kiss each other, without any hurry, to find out what the other had to offer. When her tongue poked my lips, I let her in. She wrapped her arms around me and dragged me down, nearly forcing me to lay onto her, beside her, on the bed.

Who was I to complain? Could I even?

It was quiet in the room, just a little light spent from the candles on the table, casting a warm glow over everything in the room. Curtains kept the moonlight out and the scent of incense in, which hung in the air, thought to drive away evil spirits. Together with the woman beside me, it created an atmosphere so serene, and peaceful, that it enveloped us like a soft blanket. For a while, we just lay side by side, facing each other, kissing, petting the other's hair, head, shoulders, cheeks, touching so much and drowning into our mutual glances.

Uncounted time went by until Adora pulled back, and despite her eager actions, her look was now unbelievably shy. She looked almost vulnerable. It made me feel territorial about her, protective. I would've done anything for her, to shelter her, to make her safe, all my doubts and the terrible things that the

future had in store for us buried deep down. Her hand grabbed my upper arm and squeezed it lightly. “Can I ask you something, like a… wish?”
“You’re doing it already,” I chuckled and gently nudged her nose with a finger, “but go ahead, dummy.”
She slapped my hand kindly away before asking: “Would you… stay with me? Here? I don't want to be… alone tonight. I want you to be with me. Would you… sleep at my side, just to be here? Please?” Her eyes were so wide, her voice so pleading and demanding at the same time.

I would’ve done anything for her.

“Everything, my love.”

I answered so fast that my brain didn’t catch up. Only when I saw Adora’s eyes widening, I realized what I’d said. But the word was out in the open, and I didn’t have it in me to take it back.

“Love?” she asked with the quietest voice I ever heard of her. Her eyelashes fluttered like a butterfly. Maybe it was a bit too much for one evening, with my eyes full of tears unshed and my mouth full of words still unspoken. “Just a word, Adora. Don’t ruin it.”
She chuckled, lowly, but she also shivered. I drew her in again and her head came to rest on my collarbone. It took her three attempts until she whispered. “I think… I think I feel something too.”
“Oh, now you ruined it,” I teased, while still petting her hair.
Adora shook her head while nuzzling into my neck and muffled: “I think I do, Catra, really. It’s only… I know… nothing about all of this. It’s so overwhelming, so…” she trailed off.

It was a dangerous road to go, and I couldn't let her go too far with that. “Far be it from me to judge your kissing skills. But they are quite good, I would say. You’re sure you didn’t train them somewhere?”
My praise made her blush lightly, and it was nothing but cute. I put a finger under her chin and lifted it, making her look me into my eyes. “Adora! Everything is alright. I’ll happily stay with you if

you want. This is okay. I like this."
She nodded gratefully, but also looked somehow uneasy. I replayed what we just said, and when the realization dawned on me, I asked. "You haven't been into someone before, have you?" Adora withdrew from my neck and sat up on the bed, facing me. She breathed in deeply, then shyly made a single nod with lips pressed together. I understood her discomfort and laid a hand on hers. "It's okay, Adora. There's nothing to fear nor to judge. I like you just the way you are," I whispered and tightened my stroking just a little to let her feel it. She looked towards the window, where a hint of the dawning morning fell in between the folds of the curtain. Her jaw clenched repeatedly.
"Come here," I said, interrupting her ruminating, "don't overthink this. Please."

Maybe she accepted my words or was just tired enough of the constant overdrive her mind was in, but when she slid over again into my arms, I embraced her willingly and she cuddled herself into my hug.
"Thank you," Adora replied quietly. "I would… I would love to… to do more with you, you know? Just with you." She whispered it, so silent, while her fingers trailed my chest. "I trust you. And there is… so much I would like you to show me." Her words made me shudder and again, I squeezed the wonderful woman in my arms lightly. She *wanted me to* …? I had to ask: "You mean… sex?" Adora hummed amused, then nodded. "I read about these things in letters, or overheard them. But there wasn't anyone to talk to. Sometimes I tried to talk with Bow, but he's rather uncomfortable with these topics… and he's no girl. My mother was of no help, of course, and besides her, there were only servants and slaves and I never felt familiar enough with one of them to talk about… this."
She fell silent for a while, and I tried to give her space to think and roam freely. Only one of my fingers trailed her back, while her head laid on my chest.
"You would be my—"

She stopped herself again, but I knew, or rather anticipated, what she was trying to say. I kissed her forehead. "Thank you." A few moments later, I added: "I would be so honored. Maybe you

overestimate my experience. But I promise that I would never do anything without your consent," I said and kissed her forehead another sweet time.
She stared at me, gratefully, but also smiling.
"I know. I know! I felt that from the first day we met. There was something about you that made me feel so secure. Protected, the whole time. It was like we were meant for each other." Little shivers ran down her body, I felt them. Or was it mine? "Does this sound pathetic?"
I shook my head, humming in denial. "Not at all. It sounds just right. When you walked down the gangway, it was like *seeing* for the first time. I knew it in an instant, that you were the one. *That* may sound pathetic, but by Hathor, I had such a hard time to not just stare at you."
Adora chuckled and straightened up again, poking me on the chest and with a triumphant smile. "You absolutely did, I remember it."
I poked her back. "I absolutely didn't, you idiot. You must be brain-damaged."
"Hehe," she giggled. "Luckily for you that you weren't the only one who made a fool out of himself that day."
"Oh really? What did you do?"
"I? I did nothing. I behaved with dignitas and gravitas, as expected from me. But Bow was impossible," she laughed again.
"You little…" I was cut short by her lips and decided to let her have it for now. We sank back on the bed and continued kissing for some time, but unluckily, exhaustion took over both of us.
Adora yawned. "I'm sorry. I'm just so tired… so tired." She yawned again, and I felt how her body eased into mine. "It's all good. We'll have another day and night, Adora," I assured her, even if a little disappointed.
"Have we?" she slowly asked, and I knew, thinking about tomorrow stung her as well as it did to me. I peppered more kisses along her jaw and chest and mumbled: "I promise. I'll make sure of that."

It was nearly morning, with dawn already approaching. I stood up and took care that the curtains of the only window of Adora's

room were tightly closed. We actually needed sleep. Then I stripped down to my underwear, which only left me in a band of cloth around my chest and hips. I stood before her bed, hands at my hip and noticed her gaze, which lingered over my body, and couldn't resist but to wiggle my index finger to the left and right, saying: “Nah, Nah! You promised! You promised to behave!” Watching her was a wonderful marvel, a delight, a picture for the gods. She got deep red and hid her face in her hands, breathing, “Yes! Yes!”, then she scrambled to one side of the bed and was still blushing.
I couldn’t help but to snicker upon her self-embarrassment, as I settled down at the other side and covered myself with the same blanket. Then we both laid on our sides, looking at each other. When I tucked a strand of her hair aside, she shivered under my touch, and smiled at me. It felt intimate, and we were very well aware of our closeness. But the events of the mad last day and night caught up with us quickly, as judging from our mutual yawning.
Adora laid her hand on mine, that already lay between us, and within seconds, her eyes closed, and the woman looked relaxed for the first time since days. I drew little circles with my thumb on the back of her hand, but only a minute or so later, I also fell asleep.

Beside her. It was wonderful. It was all I ever wanted.

Adora

I woke up in a warm embrace. Sleepily, I blinked my eyes open. I felt so safe, protected, and noticed how close Catra held me as she spooned me. I heaved a deep breath in contentment and allowed myself to nuzzle back into *this*. This was it, what I'd quietly, rather unconscious, hoped for the last weeks, and maybe even… more. Gone was my hesitation about being with a woman,

because this just felt right. I did not want to care anymore about it.
My finger trailed her forearm with a light touch. I inhaled her beguiling scent, and thanked the bona dea for this blessing. *Her skin is so soft*, I wondered, and placed little kisses on her arm.

Besides it must be midday, the room was still dim, only a touch of light fell in from the outside. My mind slowly started to pick up on yesterday's events and the conversation that had led to this. I didn't regret any of what had happened. Of course, I also hadn't forgotten my inevitable fate. But just like during the whole last weeks I wanted to put every day, every hour in this relative, shrinking freedom I had to good use. And this was the best of all. Here, with Catra's arms around me. I wondered what the last night might have brought, if we hadn't been so tired, if I hadn't been so exhausted — and so angsty. Telling her that I wanted her to be my first time had been much easier than I thought. It just came naturally, and that alone told me everything I needed to know. Maybe I was inexperienced, but I wasn't dumb. *Yeah, and I read plenty of letters*, I reminded and snickered quietly to myself. The words and sentences I read had been so… invigorating, some of them even steamy, came to my mind again. I had felt the desire to experience what had just been written since long ago. Perhaps this was finally the right time and place to live it? To actually do it? I wanted it and feared it at the same time. What if I wasn't good enough when… doing it. What if Catra didn't like being with me? Or what if I didn't like it? What if yesterday had just been a slip-up?

Behind me, Catra stirred and soon, her hand started to trace my bare shoulder. I realized that, somehow, I must have gotten rid of my nightgown during the sleep, because I wore nothing more than my undergarments around my hips, not even a strophium. Did I take it off? Judging from the heat that the woman behind me radiated and that warmed me so much, I must've done it. I slowly shuffled around and turned to her. A grave mistake, as I only realized when her half-shut eyes suddenly went wide open and fell on my naked breasts. When I noticed how she licked her lips, I felt very self-aware. But I had always been content with my

own body, and of course I knew I wasn't unsightly at all. So I just let her look, until I finally put a finger under her mouth, shut it, lifted her head and whispered grinning: "Eyes up here, kitten." Had I just been thinking that Catra maybe didn't want me at all? How ridiculous of me.

She started from her initial awe. "You're so… unbelievably beautiful. It's like a dream."
I traced her cheek with a finger. "Thank you. You could've had it earlier… you know? It wasn't like that I didn't—"
"I know! I know!" Catra called and lowered her head. "I was frightened. I still am. You are… What will happen to this, when you're… no longer… free. I can hardly bear the thought that you're no longer there. But when thinking about that someone else would see you like this, will touch you, or has… sex with you… Oh Hathor, it can't be." She grimaced in pain, and her words reminded me of so much that I didn't want to be reminded of. I shook my head. "I don't know. I have absolutely no idea, Catra. But no matter what happens tomorrow or whenever: I'm grateful for this and I want this. So please, at least give me this experience with you, before… before…" My throat tightened, and I realized that teardrops were running down my face. She quickly kissed them away, one by one. "Don't think about it, Adora. I'll give you something else to think about." Her gaze was determined, and there was something else in it, when her heterochromatic eyes pierced into mine.

Hunger. Lust. Desire. Uhh.

She wanted me! Catra lowered her head to my neck, trailing down pecks to my breasts. I felt alive, so vivid, her touches were warming my lap and I started to writhe beneath her, demanding more. More of this, more of her…

Of course, Cleopatra's gentlewoman Andronika — Glimmer — chose the best moment to intercept us by knocking at my door and not even waiting for an answer. Maybe that was the return coach for my interruption of her and Bow earlier this week. As she peeked into the room, her facial expression derailed shortly, but

then she clapped her hands in joy and yelled "HAH! I KNEW IT! You finally made it! Oh dear Cypris[87], what a blessing that I'm allowed to experience this in my life." She sauntered into my room, but she had at least the decency to close the door behind her. Catra and I covered ourselves with the blanket we slept with, and Catra just peeked over the edge with an angry look. But there was little we could do to hide what was obvious.
"What do you mean with *We finally made it*?", Catra asked, her voice dripping of suppressed anger.
Glimmer smirked smugly, and declared alike: "If you'd been under the illusion that the pair of you were subtle, I'm here to inform you that you are not.[88] That lesbian longing you two showed the last weeks was unbearable to witness for anyone with eyes in their heads."
I groaned, and Catra actually hissed like a cat at Glimmer. If she were decent, she would perhaps knock Glimmer's shiny perfect teeth out, I feared. It was nearly funny.

But I eyed Glimmer warily. "And what are you going to do now?" I asked.
Glimmer's face was very staggered. "Huh? To do? About what?"
"Are you going to tell Cleopatra about… this? Or someone else?" That worried me. No one was allowed to know about this. It would be so dishonorable.
She eyed me back with a severe glance: "What the two of you are doing in private is not of my concern. Or Cleopatra's, as far as I can judge. We're not like you regarding such matters. But in your position, Adora, I would be careful, very, very careful about with whom I share some… affection." She mustered Catra with a weighing gaze. "But that sounds like a you-problem, doesn't it? Why should I care? I'm not your chaperone."
"Fair enough," I replied, relieved, "but thanks anyway."
"What are friends for?" Glimmer lightly replied. It took me by surprise. Were we already friends? Was that Bow's influence already?
"Why are you even here, Sparkles?" Catra asked and miserably failed at hiding her growl — if she even tried to.
"Rude kitty! Her highness, the mighty Cleopatra, wants to see

both of you. I have the slightest inkling that she isn't exactly pleased with the fact that you blew up half her city. Actually…", she looked like to ponder, but her dramatics gave her away, "how do I put this right? Ah! She's pissed."
Then she chuckled at her own joke, but nobody else shared her laughter. After her giggling died, the stocky girl continued: "Oh, come on, girls. You can't be surprised by this." She fell in a sing-song. "Now, rise and shine, we don't want to keep her majesty waiting."

Catra and I reluctantly dressed ourselves after we shoved Glimmer out of the room, not too softly. Before we left, I laid my arms around her and drew her in. "I expect more of this later on."
She narrowed her eyes. "Count on it, princess."

It should turn out that it wouldn't be so easy to keep this particular promise.

Cleopatra was sitting on the Pharaonic throne, finally, her head resting at the side in one of her hands that was propped up on an armrest. The chair stood on a pedestal a few steps above the rest of the room, purposefully elevated. It wasn't as crest as I would've expected it, but it made clear who held power nonetheless. Left and right stood two simpler chairs, presumably for her advisors, but the seats were empty now. As well as the rest of the throne room, as I noticed. Behind Catra and me, Glimmer shut the doors while having a worried look on her face, and left us with Cleopatra alone.

"Did you send everyone out, so you can yell at us without being stopped?" Catra asked aggressively while trudging towards Cleopatra in forward defense. Her sister looked up, her eyes dark and full of broody grumbling, the black hair unusually messy and

unbound. I'd never seen her like that.
She heaved a deep breath before speaking. “I was actually planning to yell only at you, dear sister. But it seems, that the two of you are like an unholy alliance and where one goes, the other one isn’t far away to spread disaster? Isn’t it so, Catra?”
Said Catra’d narrowed her eyes. “What do you mean by that? Speak clearly, Cleo, I’m not in the mood for your royal antics.”
That wouldn't go well, but for once in my life I decided to keep quiet.

Dramatically, Cleopatra waved and gestured with her hands. “Oooh, sorry Catra. If that’s the case, I will clearly hold back until you’re in a better state. Sorry for interrupting your plays, and so fucking sorry for my concern about the point that you nearly burnt down my capital. How could I even?” she etched, anger bubbling up.
Catra was not one to stand down, that much was clear, as she shot back angrily. “If one of your useless advisors had given me the slightest hint that something like that would be possible, I would have never done it. I would have fucking drowned the barrels with this stuff in the harbor. The fact alone that it exists is a menace to us all. Did you know about it?”
Her sister-queen did not take that comment too well. “If you had just done like you boasted, nothing of this would’ve happened. It was your plan to burn the docks, not blowing up half the city and my whole fleet.”

Catra had taken her stand before Cleopatra’s throne, looking at her on eye-level, while I was still lingering down in front of the few steps. It was terrifying to watch the two women shouting at each other. It was clear that neither of them would give in. “And that’s the point with plans in wars, Cleo. They change! Nothing ever goes like planned. I had to make a quick decision, and I made it. Maybe the wrong one. It wasn't my intention to kill hundreds, Cleo! Besides, it wasn’t *your* fleet, and you know that very well. ”
Cleopatra brutally stared back at Catra, blatantly not willing to give an inch. “But tomorrow it could’ve been mine, along with a still standing capital. We will need months, years perhaps, to cut

through the chaos you caused and to rebuild what you destroyed. Now I even have to deal with the fact that Arsinoe has fled in the tumult. She will clearly unite with my brother and spread even more chaos."
I had followed their forth and back in growing despair. My manners still forbade me to interrupt a queen, and my senses told me not to cut in too, but my urge to defend Catra was getting stronger the longer the exchange went on. Still, Catra held her stand against her sister. "Arsinoe isn't important, you know that. She has no army, it's just her. And the rest? That's just bricks and stone and wood, Cleo," Catra growled, but raised her voice again at the next sentence. "I've killed hundreds on your behalf on these ships for you! Men, with families, maybe. People who didn't know what was coming over them."

Cleopatra had folded her arms before her chest and looked down at us coolly. "They were my brother's men. They had chosen her fate."
"By Thoth, how can you be so cold-hearted, sister?" Catra yelled. "They were soldiers and didn't really care who gave them their orders. They just followed their leaders, like all of you expect them to, dammit!" She exhaled deeply, looking exhausted now. "Just like I did. Always."

It suddenly looked like some of her anger was fizzling out, as Cleopatra sagged against the chair back. "Perhaps I overestimated your usefulness," she mumbled half aloud, more to herself, but still clearly audible. And despite I was still standing down below and with Catra's back towards me, I could see how deep her sister's words hit her. She winced, stumbled two steps back, and visibly started to tremble. Her one hand gripped the wrist of the other one. She tried to stop it, tried to hide the shaking, failed, and it was the last straw it took for me to rush beside her and grab her by both her shoulders from behind to support the woman.
"You can't mean that seriously," I shouted, too loud to sound deferential. "Everything she did, she did for you. You can't blame her, just because something went wrong. That's not fair. Her whole doing is aimed to serve you. Don't treat her like that."

Cleopatra straightened herself in her throne, leaning slightly forward with again growing fury on her face, and Catra weakly tried to interject. "Adora, don't—"
"NO!" I pulled away from her, fisted my hands and gathered my courage, every bit of it. My anger helped. "Don't silence me! She's doing you wrong, and she knows it. Or don't you, your majesty?" Now I stood before Catra, having put her behind me, as if I was trying to physically protect her from her sister. Somehow, I felt like a bestiarius at a venatio[89], going for a bearfight. Or a catfight. Anyway, nobody could have misjudged the meaning of my pose,—

and Cleopatra clearly didn't.

She stared at me, presumably weighing her words, before talking back. After all, and despite the fate that she and my own family were able to decide for me to be, I was still a member of the Roman family she so desperately wanted to have as an ally. An uncomfortable silence fell upon the room, because I just stared back, still keeping Catra behind me.

It felt like a long time later, when the raven-haired queen leaned back and visibly slumped into the chair, putting her head into one hand, and sighed. "Go. We will… talk about this later, when we've calmed down. Leave me alone, both of you." She gestured weakly with her hand, and I took the sign, grabbed Catra by the wrist, dragged her down the pedestal and out of the throne room. Maybe for the first time, the woman willingly followed my lead without any hesitation.

We stood on one of the watchtowers of the palace walls on the western headland that overlooked the Great Harbor of Alexandria. After the derailed argument with the Pharaoh, I decided that we needed some fresh air, silence, and a good view, and the

watchtowers provided all of it. Hiding in the palace, Cleopatra's palace, felt a little too raw.

Over the course of the last hours, Caesar's fleet had defeated the remainders of the Egyptian in a decisive battle on the sea, and during the morning they approached the island of Pharos. It was right over there, on the other side of the harbor basin, where my uncle's troops started to disembark from the galleys. They quickly took over the Lighthouse and therefore attained control of the harbor entrance. The next hours or day would lead to more bloody fights, because the Roman cohorts would attack the garrison that was sitting in front of the Heptastadion, which led towards Alexandria itself. If Caesar got hold of this castle, he would become master of the entire Great Harbor[90] and therefore be able to control all shipments and to land the called reinforcements easily.

“Thank you,” Catra suddenly mumbled. It was barely audible, but it put me out of my thoughts. I gently nudged her shoulder, not wanting to show more signs of affection in the public than absolutely justified. Deep inside myself, I knew I was just too cowardly to do more, too concerned about my reputation, hers, the expectations everyone had put on me, and still about the fact that our feelings weren't allowed to go anywhere. They never would.
I collected myself. “Don't worry. She was wrong and she knew it. She just wanted to scream out her anger over everything that had happened, and for some strange reason you were the target of it. But nothing more.”
“I set the Pyr on fire,” Catra managed very quietly, nearly whispering, and her face matched her voice.
I wasn’t up for this self-pitying anymore, and so I snarled at her: “Yeah, yeah, heard it, been there, done that, Catra. For fucks sake, drop it. You didn’t know what was going to happen. Nobody knew, and that’s pretty much all that we need to know. You didn’t want this, and if Cleopatra or her advisors had been less hideous about their precious little secret, it wouldn’t have happened.”

Catra looked surprised, and for the first time, a little smile appeared in the corner of her mouth. “Uh… Adora. Do I rub off on you? You’re swearing! Actually, I’m shocked!”
I scoffed playfully and shoved her side. “NO, you don’t, kitty. You’re still brain-damaged. And now, this big, loud bang must have also damaged your hearing.” I playfully gestured at my ears. She smirked. “You puny Roman.”
“Classless beast.” It came out soft, without strenght, and I laid my hand on hers on the railing, and we again watched the battle at Pharos unfold.

At least three cohorts were disembarking and moving all over Pharos island now, then towards the fort. I assumed that their attack would surely be successful over the course of the day, given the outnumbered strength of the defenders. We could already see how individual departments of them left the fortress and marched across the embankment towards the city. Obviously, they shared my reasoning.

It was only then, when our gazes followed the troops, that we noticed a figure standing at the top of the wall below us, watching towards where the Museion stood. I nudged Catra with my elbow and pointed down to the person. “Isn’t that—”
“Yeah, Entrapta,” she mumbled. “She's been standing there for a while now. I’m not sure if we should bother. She is pretty beside herself,” Catra silently replied. She looked very uneasy. “Hmm.” I pondered shortly, but decided to give it a try, and dragged Catra with me.

The woman’s shoulders quivered, I noticed when we came nearer. I cleared my throat to make Entrapta aware of our appearance. She hadn’t taken notice of our presence until now, and I wondered if it was intentional or not.
“How are you?” I asked. She startled from her silent sobbing, still leaning against the pinnacles of the wall, and looked over to the Museion. The fire there had died down a few hours ago, but plumes of gray smoke were still to be seen, and it was clear that the Library had taken severe damage.
“All the lost knowledge. All the lost writings. It is… We won’t even

know what we've lost." She turned to Catra and poked her with her index finger on the chest. "Fortunately, at least the recipe for the Pyr is gone too. It was amongst the rooms that burned." Her gaze wandered back to the building as she turned away again. "I'm not sorry for leaving it behind. This is not like me, but I'm not sorry."

Catra and I stood beside her, silently, letting the woman spit out her anger and sadness. Entrapta continued, her voice sounding so defeated. "People like you always use knowledge for the worst possible purpose. You don't care what your actions mean in the long run. We invent, and you take it and do something horrible." There I cut in. "Don't blame her. It wasn't Catra's fault. She didn't even know what was going to happen. It's not like that anyone has done something like that ever before."

Her pigtails bobbed left and right when she shook her head and replied: "As if that mattered. Now the world has seen what is possible. The generals, the kings, and queens, the rulers, all the ones greedy for power. Now they know something like this is possible. It won't be the last time that we've seen something like this, Adora. Remember my words." I looked at Catra, stunned, because of Entrapta's unknown repeating of Catra's words from the night before. I saw the hurt in her eyes and laid my hand on her shoulder, not daring to show more affection in the public than this.
"I know, Entrapta," Catra murmured, "I know that all too well. If I'd known, I wouldn't have done it." She gripped the wall and looked over to the remnants of the navalia. "Hindsight. What a bitter and useless thing. I only hope that it is gone for good. Some knowledge is better left untouched. Man can do what he wants, but he cannot want what he wants. And it seems to me that we too often want what we should not."

Catra tilted her head and looked at me with teary eyes, making me wonder. What was she really talking about? The power of the Pyr? Or about us and… whatever we had last night? Both, perhaps? I gripped her hand and squeezed it lightly, and to my relief, she squeezed it back.

The west wind blew a few of the battle noises over from Pharos island, and a light touch of smoke also lingered in the air. Some of it came from remainders of the navalia that were still fuming, it was mixed with a resemblance of the blow the Pyr had sent through Alexandria, and which's smell still wafted around. I shivered upon the memory of when the air strike had pushed me against the wall.
Only the future would show how the events of the night behind us would turn the tides for humankind in the coming ages. For better or for worse, I couldn't imagine.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"From heaven to hell"** and will be published on Friday, August 13, 2021.

[82] Real explosives haven't been invented before the Middle Ages, and the stuff I'm imagining here has similarities to an Ammonium nitrite explosion, which is known since the 17th century. Nonetheless, the eldest written source of something similar dates back into the second century CE, only 200 years after our events, and therefore, close enough. Here, Christian traveler and historian Sextus Julius Africanus described for the first time the 'Pyr autómaton'. The original recipe is lost due to altercations over time because of translation and copying. But it is believed to have been a mixture of sulfur, saltpeter, pyrite and other stuff. As far as I'm concerned, the more powerful recipe of its precursor which caused Catra's explosion was lost during the burning of the Library of Alexandria, and you're welcome to refute my working hypothesis. ↕
[83] Of course Catra could speak Greek too. After all, it was the main language of the ruling upper class, to which she also belonged. Pandaimonium describes the totality and whereabouts of all demons. Granted, the term 'daímōn ' in ancient Greek described just the ghosts of the dead that where neither ascended to be a god nor a human anymore. They were seen rather neutral then and only later the term gathered a darker meaning, which seems fitting here. But the

term went also through my head because I'm liking this: https://twitter.com/manzanillapop/status/1368418437043806208↑

[84] This is what you get when not thinking about the consequences of your doing. Am I reflecting on the show here? When Catra pulled the lever? Took down Salineas? Guess it for yourself. ↑

[85] 'Galea' is the Latin word for helmet, and 'the galea' is the standard helmet of the Roman legion. The form of the helmet varied over time and between different types of units. The typical helmet which who know from movies or TV was not invented and widely used before late 1st century BCE, so, around the time this story plays.↑

[86] The later part of this sentence is from "A mountain to climb, for your love", Chapter 11. ↑

[87] Cypris is a less common name for the goddess 'Aphrodite', the Greek goddess associated with love, beauty, pleasure and passion. And Glimmer is of course of Greek origin, so it would not be uncommon for her to use it. Aphrodite's mythology is vast and worth a read, because she could not only be generous to those who worshipped her, but also brutally punished those who didn't. In the Argonauts-saga for example "when the women of the island of Lemnos refused to sacrifice to Aphrodite, the goddess cursed them to stink horribly so that their husbands would never have sex with them" which unfolds to a horrible tragedy. There are numerous fables and sagas about her causing havoc amongst humans for simply ignoring her. ↑

[88] This sentence is from "Gemstones and Oceans", Chapter 13. ↑

[89] A venatio was a type of entertainment. It was typically held in the Colosseum or amphitheaters, where wild animals like bears, bulls, boars, elephants and so on were hunted and killed in the arena. The people engaging in the fight were called 'bestiarius' or 'venator', depending on if they were condemned to death or faced them voluntarily for pay or glory. ↑

[90] This is more or less a direct citation from paragraph 19 of "The Alexandrian War" by Caesar. ↑

From heaven to hell

Chapter Summary

Everyone has to make his decisions now.
No one makes a good one.
Upon victory, everything falls apart.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Alexandria, Egypt - January / February 47 BCE

Adora

The day saw two victories.

The first happened before our eyes.
After Entrapta left us to start recollecting the scrolls she saved, Catra and I went back to the watchtower and witnessed how the Roman cohorts took over the Great Harbor of Alexandria. Ship after ship, galley after galley, started to disembark troops at the island of Pharos as well as in the Royal port. The newly arrived soldiers quickly conquered the fortress before the Heptastadion, and fortified their positions. The armed Alexandrians and the Egyptian were forced to retreat to the part of the city they still held, and to the campsite before it.
Over the course of the next few days, it would become clear that the Egyptians would regroup upwards the Nile to challenge Caesar and Cleopatra in a decisive battle, but for now, the fight for the control of the harbor was over. Everyone was still exhausted from the long night — and from Catra's *explosion*, that had cost Achillas his strategic advantage by taking down the Egyptian fleet.[91]

I learned the term from Entrapta, in one of our weird conversations of the last days, when we talked about what happened that night. She was still sometimes mournful over the loss of so many scrolls and thereby knowledge at the library, but as it was her personality, she didn't hold a grudge for long and moved on with all the other stuff she had to do. Exploring and explaining to herself what made the Pyr go wild, was one of these occupations.
"I think the main point was that all the Pyr was stored in thick barrels, and that they were closely stacked in a building made of stone. It just *has* something to do with the heat and pressure these factors provided. So, if the Pyr had just laid on the ground, open, like wheat bushels to be threshed, maybe… it wouldn't have blown up so wildly."
I wondered. "Do you think so? Why should the form of… stacking should have something to do with the result of how it burns?" I asked only lukewarm interested, but for her, it seemed to be as sure as eggs are eggs.
"Yes! I assume it is the same as when you put a lid on a pot with boiling water. If you hold the lid tight, you can feel how the steam wants to push it off, against your will. Maybe the Pyr wanted to do the same, only faster and more… a lot more powerful."

I thought about that not too long before I replied: "I'm just happy that the recipe is gone."
Entrapta stared at me. "Don't be stupid, Adora. It's gone for now, but some day, someone else will reinvent it and do the same."
Her words just made me sigh. "I very much hope that I won't see that again."
"Oh, me too. This explōsio really scared me."
I never heard that word to describe… whatever happened there.
"Explōsio? Hmm… sounds somehow fitting," I replied, whereupon Entrapta lowly chuckled. "But actually, I hope we don't need a word for this."

The other victory left Catra and foremost me messed up. Our outspoken desire to continue our… mutual night was cut short harshly and effectively by Cleopatra, who tasked Catra with a mission that led her out of Alexandria for some days. She was

gone — or had been ushered away, as it looked like — before we even had the chance to meet again, to say something, to reassure ourselves to each other — or to make any plan for me to join her. It led me to the suspicion that Cleopatra had finally realized that something not appropriate had happened between Catra and me, and so she'd decided to separate us as quick and far as possible by sending her away. When I noticed Catra's absence, she was already half a day away, and I sulked for the rest of the day.
In the meantime, uncle Gaius in his ever-advancing ways had immediately set off to battle the Egyptian army and Cleopatra's brother, and he left it for Cleopatra to take care of me, and to make sure, that everything was going to be in place for my upcoming *duties*.

The Pharaoh had nothing less than a field day when news arrived that her sister Arsinoe had taken over command of the Egyptian army when she put her former general Achillas to death for still unknown reasons and tasked another of her councilmen with the job of leading the army against Caesar.
Cleopatra burst out laughing, and she didn't stop for minutes, still giggling and chuckling when she finally composed herself enough again to continue with the ongoing meeting.
I shot Alexas, who stood nearby, a quizzical look, and he moved over and whispered: "Achillas was the best general her brother had. He knows— knew his men and the land inside out. He lost a battle, but he was a very good strategist. With him being… removed, his successor will likely be no match for your uncle. No matter who it is."
"Huh?" I blinked. That was… good news, right? But why did it feel so hollow then?

Alexas mistook my confusion. "I don't understand Arsinoe's action, it seems to be very—"
"Dumb?" I cut him short unintentionally, but he just shot me a wary smile and replied: "You're allowed to say things like that."
"Your secret is safe with me," I joked quietly.
Meanwhile, Cleopatra had moved the discussion with her officers forward to more mundane topics and I decided to withdraw, as I was of no use in governing a city or a kingdom. With Catra being

gone, I felt insecure and uneasy again, and that feeling wasn't to be going away. Only now, I realized how much I'd started to rely on her physical presence to feel better than I actually felt.
The next few days passed only slowly. A week later, I still had no sign from Catra. When I asked Cleopatra about her at a dinner, the answer was monosyllabic and unsympathetic, and it made me again aware of the fact, what my real destiny should be.

Without Catra, I started to rely on Bow again, who now came in a steady package with Glimmer. The both of them seemed to have picked up in a goodhearted and still not fully defined relationship. Luckily for them, nobody seemed to care. It also meant that Glimmer and I had to sort out our previous quarrels, but — to my surprise — it was quite easy. After she apologized for being a brat the first time we met, we quickly developed a carefree and light-hearted connection. Her focus lay on Bow, but she included me, and sometimes we even walked around for a conversation or just 'women's talk' on our own, how she announced it to Bow.
I was in her room, as so often now, and she rambled about that very topic. "And why should anyone? Cleopatra spends all her time ensnaring your uncle, at least when he's in the palace. It's really… ugh, upsetting, you know? And half of her persuasiveness has all to do with the fact that she has a throne, an army, land, money, and plenty of wheat that Caesar really really wants. She doesn't even hide her reasoning from him. I assume, all that can surely be alluring enough for any general or leader, when accompanied by a slender young woman." She snickered. "I would be allured by that too, for sure. But maybe they're just pragmatic. That'd fit them, to go all the way to—"

Upon my darkening look, she quickly continued. "Anyway, she doesn't care about with whom I spent my time and as long as she doesn't look out for some other fitting noblemen for me, I'm fine with what I got." Upon these words, she stroked Bow's stomach, who laid beside her on the couch and was overly content.
I sighed. "You're lucky. Both of you. I give it to you, really." My gaze fell out of the window of Glimmer's room, that looked nicely over the harbor. Of course the view was nice, because her room

lay next and alongside to Cleopatra's, and *of course* the Pharaoh had a fucking nice view.

I was amused about my thoughts. Catra's casual manners had *indeed* rubbed off on me, and it felt… good, actually. It sometimes felt like if a more natural part of my personality, a part that was less composed and rigid, less restrained and more carefree, a part that had always been there, was now slowly emerging. My whole life I had spoken in tongues, like a Roman noblewoman always should. I had strictly controlled my ways, my speaking, and thinking. But the more time I spent with Catra, the more I found myself to be a… less patrician version of myself, but a more Adora-one. Secretly, I liked that version more and more each day. All the crazy things that had happened in the last months, all the crazy things we'd done… Catra had made me aware of this more adventurous part of me, and I didn't want to let it slip away again. I didn't want to be caught in a position — or a life — where the only freedom I had was to decide upon my breakfast or how to decorate the *fucking* atrium. I was *happy*, at her side.

Happy like I'd never been before.

Bow cut into my ruminating by laying a hand on my shoulder, and he squeezed it lightly. "Hey! Don't be afraid, Adora. No matter what happens, I'll always be there for you. I'll always be at your side! Even if that means to—"
"Hey, hey, hey!" Glimmer playfully cut in. "We don't assume the worst things to happen, okay? Let's… Just let us set this aside and be together for now. There's no need to waste a beautiful day."
I agreed with her. "You're right. A few months before, all I would've done now would have been worrying the whole time and making plans to *do something*, to be useful in any way. But now I think — no matter what the coming day will bring along — we can be happy for today. So, let's see if Alexandria can make us happy."

“Sometimes I think my ears are still ringing, you know? It's really unnerving. I don’t want to experience something like that again,” the chubby elder woman said to her neighbor, a tall and slim one in her best years, who nodded. “Yeah. That was quite a blast. It blew all my vases and my favorite dishes off the table.”
“Huh? Your dishes? You store them in the shelf, don’t you? Why are they gone then?”
The tall one shrugged her shoulders with something between regret and acceptance. “I already set them up for breakfast. You know how much I like to be prepared.”
The chubby one giggled amicably. “That's what you get out of it, sweetie. But I’m sorry for you. I liked the patterns on them so much.” She put a hand on the shoulder of her friend, who replied to the gesture by putting a hand on hers.
“Yeah, thanks. Do you think I can ask Seschet if she can redo them?”
“Oooh! Of course! But talking about Seschet, did you know…”

I walked away from the chatter of the two Hellene noblewomen to whom I’d listened — I wouldn’t say eavesdropped, nope — and resumed my stroll over the market. The location was as lively and vibrant as always. Nearly nothing beside the occasional talk reminded one about the bygone events from just before a few days. Repairs had been made or were underway, people had to be fed, businesses had to be reopened, a life to be lived. Caesar forbade his soldiers any looting of the city. And he also quickly took them to follow Ptolemy and the still loyal parts of the Egyptian army. And so, a normal life had returned to Alexandria in an instant, just like the smell of the Pyr had vanished. Now it just smelled of a thousand scents, as normally.

Making my way through the bustling stalls and vendors, I tried to keep the memory of my first journey with Catra at bay. But the odor of freshly baked bread, roasted meats, and exotic spices filled my nostrils just like before, and it was hard to not connect it

with her. Up on a small platform serving as a stage, musicians played lively tunes on their instruments, putting on a show for a small crowd, adding to a festive atmosphere. One of them juggled fire and a woman danced to the beat of drums, their colorful costumes and acrobatics enjoying the audience.
With a small spark of relief, I spotted Glimmer and Bow at stalls beside the stage and joined them.

"Wouldn't that be a nice present for Catra?", I asked Glimmer when my hands fell upon a beautifully knitted headscarf, hanging down from a rod, where it was presented with half a dozen other ones. The market stand looked a bit odd, between all the others. It had only a small selection of scarves on display, together with — what a weird combination — knives and daggers.
Glimmer's look fell onto the knives, and she took one of them in her hand. "Given her personality, one of these would fit better, won't they?" She checked the edge with her fingernail. "It's nearly as sharp as her wit," she chuckled and put it back.

I let the scarf slip through my fingers, to feel the softness of the fabric and the perfection with which the patterns were mastered, and decided to buy it. "She bought me a scarf on our first visit to Alexandria. I want to return the favor."
Glimmer and Bow eyed me, the both of them mutually sighed. It was amicable, and understanding, but it felt a bit judgmental, too.
I shrugged my shoulders. "What? It's just a gift."
"Of course it is," Glimmer replied with the slightest hint of sarcasm. "But I can't remember that snarky Catra has ever bought someone something. When did she do it, you said?"
Absent-minded, I answered: "On our first trip here, when she stole the seal back. We strolled around a market and she… just bought it for me."
The stocky girl pulled a corner of her mouth in a one-sided smirk, but her eyes were not meeting it. She looked rather stunned. "That long, huh?"
I was neither sure what she really meant with her remark and something in me was afraid to ask, so I just shrugged my shoulders, only one time, while my gaze was fixed on the scarf.

And that might’ve been one of the last happy days I had.

The throne room wasn’t overly huge. Put in 200 people, and it was full, with a good part of the audience having to stand under the arcades and behind pillars. There was a lot of squeezing and pushing behind me, because there were clearly more than 200 Hellene, Egyptian, even a few Romans and other foreign noblemen attending the event. It was meant to officially put Cleopatra back on the throne and informally to show that she was back in power. Fortunately — or unfortunately — I had a seat in the front row. Before me was nothing but the pedestal on which the throne of the Egypt stood, with a richly decorated and adorned wall behind it showing scenes of glorious victories of Cleopatra's predecessors.

It hadn't been a long ceremony. The old, bald high priest of the quorum was just about to put down the Pschent, the double crown of the two lands, on Cleopatra’s head. Symbolizing the unity of Upper and Lower Egypt, they belonged to the eldest crowns of the millennia-old monarchy, a civilization long there before Rome was even founded, and the crown had seldom been used by the Ptolemaic monarchs.[92] Cleopatra, of course, took a different path than her precursors. She wanted to put a stronger focus on the manners and customs of Ancient Egypt, obviously relying more on these parts of her culture for a stronger support by the native Egyptians. In contrast to the more Hellenistic world of Alexandria, she was already quite popular for that in the land of reeds, the part of Egypt south of the Nile delta.

A servant held out a plate to her, his head bowed. The young Pharaoh solemnly took the laying heqa and nechacha[93] in her

hands and folded her arms before her chest with them. I noticed it how she got fully official as she threw herself in a majestic pose and heralded in her commanding voice: “I am Cleopatra VII, Thea Philopator. I am the Herald of the Glory of the Thousand Gods, the Messenger of on High and Vanguard of the End times. I am the Mistress of Sedge and Bee, the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt! Where I go, I bring forth the infinity of the gods.”
The high priest took his crosier and stomped it three times on the floor, sending loud ‘Whumps’ through the otherwise silent hall. “Glory be to the gods and their emanation, Pharaoh Cleopatra VII, the father-loving Lady of the Two Lands! Hail!”

While her court hailed her in acclaim, I pondered about why symbols meant so much to us. With that ceremony, Cleopatra took over — or back — the throne and reign of Egypt at the age of 21, declaring herself the rightful and sole pharaoh again. Caesar stood beside her on the pedestal, just one step beneath her, and carefully watched the Egyptian officials and governors. He looked just slightly bored upon the opulent formalities, and I desperately tried not to laugh. He’d always been like that, and his very pragmatic manner had always been perceived by many as rude. My father always said that Gaius simply didn't care about appearances. Only hard power interested him, a trait they both shared. I dutifully clapped with all the others, but my thoughts were striving back to the conversation I had with both of them a week earlier. Around ten days after Catra had been sent away, I found myself sitting at dinner with Cleopatra, Caesar and a few other noblemen of both their entourage.

Caesar just retold the story of his final victory over the Egyptian army.

Beside him, Cleopatra seemed to be torn between the relief upon the success of her ally, and taken aback by the condescension in which he spoke about the endeavors her defeated compatriots had made. After all, even the soldiers in the army under her now dead brother were her own people, and the remainders of them now under her power again.

“I couldn't believe my luck. We weren’t able to flank the Egyptians the entire time, because their archers always pinned us down when we tried to surround them. They followed our movements on her inner lines, and made sure that we did not outrun them. And behind them, more archers on their barks on the Nile also supported them with swift movements. It was quite a good strategy, and I must say, that your brother did pretty well at commanding them. But not well enough,” he snorted, and toasted acknowledging her, which Cleopatra only reluctantly returned.
Caesar continued his vivid report: “Because then — suddenly! — a gap in the middle of the Egyptian main line opened, and we immediately pushed in. It took half a cohort to exploit it, but finally we broke through. The men fought hard to widen the gap, and they took the soldiers behind the front line completely by surprise. It created panic and turmoil amongst the archers, and soon after half the Egyptian army was fleeing the battlefield and their camp in panic. And the rest is history, to put it that way.”[94]

He looked very pleased with himself, but there was still silence around the table.

“What exactly happened with Ptolemy then, uncle?” I asked, a bit uneasy. Despite him being our enemy, and despite the fact that Cleopatra had never shown any sign of affection for her younger brother, I pitied him. After all, he'd just been a fourteen-year-old boy, and only few of the events leading to his death had been his fault or even on his own behest. He'd just been a tool of the forces behind him, too, and most of them were dead by now. I felt a weird solidarity with him upon that. Upon being used.
My uncle shrugged his shoulders. “When it became clear that the battle for the Egyptians was lost, he fled onto his ship and tried to escape our charging troops. But reportedly and as far as we saw, his bark capsized due to being overrun by fleeing soldiers, and he presumably drowned with it. I let his body be searched for, but he wasn’t to be found in the tumultuous aftermath. I think it is safe to assume that he was either swept into the sea, or that his remains fed the crocodiles.”
He did not sound amused or cruel, for him, it was just another

anecdote to be told as he took a sip from his mug. Maybe he was expecting praise for the won battle, but again, no one spoke up, not even Cleopatra. She looked rather pensive. As the table remained silent, he let the topic go, but unfortunately picked up a more frightening one — at least for me.

He leaned forward and looked at me. "Adora, I think the time has finally come to move forward with your issue. The queen took over full control of her land again, and I will leave Egypt afterward to defeat the remainders of Pompeius' allies and the senate forces in Africa. I can't let them settle down and gather forces for too long. So, I want to have this alliance and marriage in place before I leave. Cleopatra and I have spoken about this, and with the approval of your father still in place, we want to come up with an idea to formalize it." He nodded at Cleopatra beside him, laid a hand on hers — and the closeness of the gesture really made me wonder — and prompted her: "Your majesty?"

That didn't feel good. He let it sound like I had a choice, only that I hadn't a choice. I never had, and never would have. I felt my blood pressure plummeting and had to put my hands on the edge of the table and grip it.
Cleopatra smiled cordially and replied the nod to Caesar. "Of course, consul." Then she turned to me. "Adora, to mark my return to the throne, I will have a formal festival at court in a week's time. In my opinion, this would be the perfect opportunity to announce your betrothal to Psamtik, and to introduce you to him as well. This would make the connection between us and your family known to all important nobles of Alexandria and Egypt at once. Afterward, you should leave with him for Thēbais, while we work out the remaining matters with your father."

My view blurred. What? *One week? Only one week left?*

"I… I don't know what—" I stuttered. Cleopatra's face was nothing but friendly concern. "You don't have to say anything, my dear. All will be taken care of by my advisors and the royal council. We will treat this with the utmost prudence. Traveling is safe now, Upper Egypt is firmly in my hand. You have nothing more to fear about.

You only have to select a nice dress for the festival and look illustrious and pretty then.” She toasted at me. “Which you won't have a problem with, I’m sure.”
Her praise sounded nice, but it made me nearly choke. I couldn't bring myself to protest loudly, I just looked at uncle Caesar to even get any reaction to this. He just nodded in approval, and with that I knew my fate was sealed. My father would never do anything to stop this. Catra couldn’t do anything to stop this. I couldn't.

And the two ice-cold rulers before me wanted exactly what I didn’t want to.

The surrounding walls closed in, my field of vision narrowed, my heart seemed to have ceased working. That couldn’t have been it. “I… understand. If I’m thinking about it, I assume… I’m tired.” I stood up and murmured. “With your kind permission, I will retire for today.” Not waiting for an answer, I slowly walked out of the room and into mine, where I threw myself on the bed. I hadn't even the strength in me to cry. Instead, I just stared at the ceiling while the terrifying world around me closed in.
This time, there was no Catra beside me, holding me tight, whispering assuring words into my ears, spending me warmth.

There was just this cold vision of my future.

And somehow shortly, hours, days after, I found myself partaking at the re-enthronement of Cleopatra, and with the expectation of meeting my fiance-to-be at these festivities for the first time. One could only stare at the ceiling for so long, and of course the tears I quietly sobbed at night had dried. My mood wavered between dazed and capitulating.
Only a few hours before the event, Glimmer had tasked herself

with the duty to get me ready and '*prepping my little girl up*', and at the beginning it felt exactly like back *home*. Wherever home was today.
"Hold still, Adora! These messy hairs won't comb themselves! Why do all these noblewomen have to have long hair? That's… dumb. Look at mine! Short, neat, easy." Then she scolded me again for not holding still, and I was torn between snickering and whining, because it *tugged*. "You could be a bit softer, you know?", I growled and angrily looked at Bow, who sat at the table in Glimmer's room and went through some not overly interesting-looking scrolls. "Hey Bow, don't you have a job? Shouldn't you keep me from all perils?"
He looked at me, smiling warm like he always did. "What? Don't know what you could possibly mean. And I'm still injured." he faked.
"Ouch! Glimmer!" I yelped at *another tug*. "Bow! This! This is a menace to me!" I pointed with my thumb to my back. "Do something! You vowed to protect me!"
"Only from manageable hazards," he trilled, amused. "What's the point if we both perish?" He folded his arms before his chest and watched me, grinning. "Nope, I'm out. Help yourself."
"Traitor," I grumbled, and yelped again as Glimmer brushed through another knot in my hair. She chuckled and continued combing me not too softly, but then she braided three tails and left a few strands to hang loose over my shoulders and into the neckline of my dress. Finally, she put two lovely emblazoned hair slides in, turned me around, retreated one step and skeptically looked at me.



“What?” I asked harshly, insecure under her gaze and grumpy because of her treatment.
She shook her head, with some kind of disbelief on her face. “I’m really considering leaving Bow and making out with you, you know? It’s unbelievable how beautiful one person can be. I think… yeah, I’m officially offended.”
I started to blush heavily upon her praise. Hearing such open praise didn't feel as good as perhaps should have. At the table behind me, Bow fell off his chair because of his laughter.
My eyes went wide because of surprise, when Glimmer suddenly stepped forward, put a little kiss on my forehead and hugged me carefully. It took me a moment to relax. I was still sitting on the little stool, and when I let my rigid posture go, my head came to rest on her chest, as the short woman drew me in for an embrace.
“I know how awful your situation is, Adora, I know it.” she mumbled. “I wish I could help you. You’re the kindest person I ever met, and you don’t deserve what’s happening to you.”
I clearly hadn’t expected this. It… it… felt good to be held, I realized, after accepting it. It felt calming. So kind. “Whatever happens, Adora, know that I’m your friend. I know that we didn’t spend much time with each other. But I’m your friend.”

It was hard to not spill tears. I tried to fight them back, but a few little sobs escaped me, and Glimmer bowed her head to put another soft kiss on my forehead. “You won’t break upon this, Adora, I know it. From everything Bow told me and from everything I’ve seen so far: you will take it, and you will get out of this stronger. This is not the end of the world or your journey. It’s another step on your road. Believe me. And believe in you.”
Something of what she said resonated in me, deep inside the still uncharted territories of my mind and myself. I couldn’t lay my hands on it immediately, but there was some kind of underlying meaning, that felt… familiar. Close, even. Like a force to be gripped if I wanted to. It wasn’t the assurance, that I really needed. It was rather like if Glimmer's words opened a window to an opportunity that I hadn’t been aware it was there at all. Nothing had really changed, but somehow the sharp peaks of my

despair had grown a little duller and been replaced by a feeling that was a tad more… manageable.
"Thank you," I muttered into her chest. It was all I could say, could manage, and after a few more seconds she let go of me. Her thumb brushed away another tear. "I think I'm going to refresh your make-up too. I want every woman at the gathering to look at you and then fall into despair."

Despite being still teary, I actually giggled shortly, because that was ridiculous. Then Glimmer proceeded to get me pretty.

After the formalities of Cleopatra's reinstatement were over, the attendees started to mingle into a crowded mess of chatter and showing off. Of course, the newly proclaimed Pharaoh was the center of attention, but she was not the only one. Some nobles also tried to approach Caesar, which was understandable. By now, he held the largest military power in the known world. But some attention was also spent on me. I talked with a few noblewomen and noblemen, sometimes in Latin, sometimes in Greek, and I also tried some words in the Demotic language that was today's spoken and written Egyptian. It got me kind, yet amused looks.

Half an hour in, Cleopatra finally approached me with a tall and pale man at her side. I instantly knew who he was and remembered my father's words: *"Hordak is no Egyptian, he's a Greek. He's an alien in the Egyptian world, just as you would be. This can be a connection."*
This man definitely looked like an alien. His Greek origin was unmistakable. His skin was even paler than mine, and he had short, frizzy and dark hair. Physically he didn't look really imposing, but in a certain way he seemed frighteningly competent. He mustered me with an impenetrable gaze, and I couldn't help but to stare back. Cleopatra didn't really notice it

and introduced us to each other.
"Adora of the Julii. This is Psamtik IV, governor of Thēbais and the Thebaid. He is my trusted ally." He lightly bowed, but his movement was sharp and without any grace, rather military. His voice sounded barren when he greeted me: "An honor to meet you, domina. I am pleased to see that you are well, given the recent events."
Beside his appearance, a not so bad start.
"Thank you. Please excuse my open question, but what would be the correct address for your position," I asked, because it was the only question I could imagine.
"My subordinates call me 'liege',[95] but you of course won't. I would be glad, if Hordak would work for you."
Cleopatra coughed lowly, clearly not having expected him to use his nickname for himself.
"That is a very… unique name, isn't it?" I asked, and it was an honest question, because I really wanted to know the background of it.
He let out a single chuckle and put a balled hand before his mouth. "I will gladly tell you the not overly interesting story about this on our journey to Thēbais, domina. When it is a bit more private."
"Oh, of course." I hadn't thought about it, but if it was a private thing, that made weird sense.
Cleopatra, Hordak and I fell into a short conversation about the preparations for the journey. It was a mostly formal talk and in hindsight, I wondered how I'd been able to keep up with it and not make an idiot out of myself. But eventually, even that conversation came to an end.

"We will meet later, I assume?" Hordak asked, and his voice pitched a bit higher, as if the question itself was rather a duty than of actual interest to him.
Huh? Later? "What?" My ability to voice anything seemed to be not very good, but he informed me: "Her majesty looked to be very dedicated in getting us to know each other better. So she made it clear to me that we shall meet in a more private environment after these festivities have ended. She was very firm

about that.”
I was too shocked to actually come back with a worded answer. To my own horror, I just nodded slowly with maybe an open mouth and wide eyes, and he took it with moderate interest.
“Good. I look forward to seeing you later this evening, Adora.” His grip was strong when he took my hand and put it to his lips. They didn’t touch my skin when he pretended to kiss my hand, but all I remembered was how cold his hand felt. After letting my hand go, he folded them behind his back, turned, and walked away to meet other guests.

I let out a deep breath. Only seconds later, Bow was at my side and gently put a hand on my shoulder. I had to stop myself from flinching. “Was it as weird as it looked like?”

I couldn't control myself and barked out one laugh of relief. “Yeah. It was.” But then I gulped upon the realization to what I had agreed. “I shall meet him later. In a… private environment. To get to know each other better, he said, on Cleopatra’s behest.”
Bow’s eyes pulled wide. “I don’t assume it should mean what I think it should mean, right?”
“Honestly, I don’t have a clue,” I whispered. “They… can’t expect me to… ugh! No, they can’t! That would be just too… early, you know?” Inwardly, I winced at the thought.
Bow tightened his grip. “Maybe it’s just talking. He didn’t seem to be very eager? To me, he looked like he was completing a duty while talking to you.” he tried to encourage me.
I hummed, but wasn’t convinced. “Yeah, maybe. I think, I can always… you know… run away or walk out of the room or something like that.” I had no idea if I could or had the strength to. A concerned look met mine, but then he nodded. “Yes, you can.” His words gave me a little bit of confidence to get through the evening somehow.

The rest of the festivity went by in a blur, and when the mingling started to die down, a servant walked by and gestured me to follow. I hadn’t it in me to withhold, for it would only delay the inevitable.
He ushered me into a beautifully decorated room, that was

obviously meant as a place of retreat and pleasure. Some seating stood around a low table, every one equipped with lush cushions. The walls were decorated with red, purple, and gold brocaded curtains, neatly draped in beautiful patterns to give the room a comfy atmosphere. There was a door to a balcony at the other side, and another door to some room I hadn't the strength to explore right now. Gold and silver candlesticks with large honey yellow candles were spread across and bathed everything in a friendly light. But they were like a millions candles burning for a love that'd never came. It could have been a wonderful place to… rest. To talk. To become familiar.

Only that I didn't want to. I wanted to curl up in my bed and put a blanket over me. My hands shook. It wasn't the same fear as before a fight — the few real ones I'd experienced — not that adrenaline rush, but a rather deeply settling dread out of my gut, that now wanted to rise its terrifying head. I went to the door of the balcony and stepped outside. It overlooked one of the inner courtyards of the palace, but it was quiet and abandoned down there, dark. A light, warm breeze shuffled my dress and played with my braids, and even I knew that I must have looked beautiful.

Behind me, I heard the door going and knew that someone had entered the room, but I just hadn't had it in me to turn around. I was frozen to my place, not able to move. My hands gripped the railing before me firmly, because otherwise I might have passed out. He came closer, I felt it, but he stayed silent. What for a conduct should that be? And then I sensed the presence directly behind me.

When his lips touched my neck, they felt surprisingly soft on my skin. I hadn't reminded them to be so full, but they were. His hands touched my waist, and I felt that he came a bit closer. It felt not like a demand, but rather like a gentle question. All of this encounter was nothing like before, cold, disinterested, absent. It was rather… amicable, kind even. Deep down, I felt a strange relief, that, maybe, it wouldn't be so bad at all to be touched by him. Nonetheless, I couldn't prevent myself from shivering

though, and my hands gripped at the railing with all the force I could muster, so I didn't jump and run.

Then, an unexpected raspy and warm voice breathed against my ear: “Even from behind, you look beautiful.”

That was not his voice.

Catra

Dirt still crumbled off of me as I rode through the Gate of the Sun. As always, I was instantly struck by the splendid beauty of the large city splaying out before me, filling my eyes with delight in expectancy of their amenities. Both gates, the Sun Gate at the eastern and the Moon Gate at the western entrance to Alexandria, represented the guardian deities that were meant to protect the city. Though it was evening, and the sun had already started setting, there was no sign of night, because of the overabundance of torches that lightened the broad Canopus way.[96]

I wasn’t tired, despite the endeavors of the last weeks. Cleopatra’s sneaky mission hadn’t been difficult, but rather demanding, with regard to dealing with people. I'd always really loved my sister, but that didn't make an idiot out of me. Figuring out why she'd sent me on this stupid, mundane mission was blatant, easy even. Several mental notices and clever saying I'd made just waited for an opportunity to be spit out in her presence. “You lousy bitch!” would clearly be a rather friendly one of them. While making my way to the palace, I pondered how far I was willing to actually go. When I reached it, I was already boiling and a working part of my mind told me to calm down first, before confronting Cleo with all of my pent-up anger. Other parts just wanted to rage at her because of all the time she’d stolen me. Time I could have spent with Adora before… before… Ugh!

I didn’t want to think about. I wanted to report back to Cleo and to see Adora. Maybe I wanted to take a bath before that too, I tittered to myself, because I stank. Weeks on the road did that to everyone.

Before my fury got the better part of me, I went to the bath of the palace and washed the dirt and sweat of days off of me. I clearly couldn’t remember anytime I’d scrubbed myself so thoroughly. But today, it was necessary and would be worth it. Back at my room, I searched for a very special dress and was glad to find it where it actually belonged.
Purple is just beautiful on me, I thought. A color made from very rare sea snails, which the dumb Romans only allowed their highest magistrates to wear clothes with a purple stripe on them. Cleopatra, in her usual manners, used the color to dye the sails of her most important ships with it, I mused, finding it hilarious.[97] But on me, the crimson, close-fitting dress just looked good. Staring into the mirror revealed a version of me that was familiar and unknown at the same time. My look was still as always. A three weeks mission wasn’t going to change that. But something in my face, in my eyes, was different from before. I took me a while to realize that it was *longing.* A deeply settled desire, that had been waiting, wanting, for fulfillment over the course of the last weeks.

I tied my curly auburn mane into a loose ponytail, shot a last look, and left my room to see Cleo. Our conversation wasn’t very sisterly then. She took my report and was generally satisfied, but her first real comment was: “I… hadn’t expected you to be back so soon, Catra. You sure that you visited all the nobles I asked you for?”
I rolled my eyes and scoffed. “Of course I did. I’m just efficient. And I had some luck. The magistrate of Tamiathis was visiting Bubastis, and so, two birds with one stone, how the Romans put it.”
She wasn’t delighted, and I had a clear suspicion about her reason. “I see. What a luck for you,” she answered, warily. “So, now that you’ve mastered this task so well and easily — as always

— I think it wouldn’t be too much to ask you of another favor?”
She wasn't really subtle.

I groaned. “Really Cleo? I’ve been back for what, an hour?”
She shrugged her shoulders. “Many things need my, or rather our attention, now that I’m back on the throne. Just because the war against my brother is over doesn't mean there is peace now. The Kushites—”
“Oh, fuck the Kushites,” I cut her short. “I know about the little trick you played when sending me to Buhen. You know very well that the Kushites are fine. They sit happily in Medewi[98], and didn’t ever intend to threaten us, let alone forcing a war. They know as good as we do how worthless that piece of desert is. The greatest level of threat the Kushites pose to us is that they piss in the river.”
Maybe I could’ve voiced that better. Her staring was… brutal.
“What led you to this strange assumption?” Cleo finally asked.
“It was the only logical explanation why you cared about the forsaken place at the end of the world. I realized it weeks ago, and I’m a damned idiot that I didn’t see it all the time.”

She fluttered her eyes and twitched her mouth in something that looked a bit guilty. After obviously considering telling the truth or not, she finally came back. “It wasn’t meant as a deception, Catra. I just couldn’t talk openly about that special plan. To no one, not even to you. What of an impression would that have been? The Pharaoh, already planning her flight into the desert? And I had to keep it a secret so that no one could plan countermeasures. No. And the reason of keeping the Kushites in check is valid anyway. They are fine for now, but if history teaches us anything, than—”
“— it’s that history teaches us nothing. Yeah, I remember Alexas’ stupid lessons too, Cleo.” I stared at her, still angry. “I’ll give you that, I guess. However, It was shitty of you. Why did it have to be this place and nothing a bit more… attainable.”
Her hands moved to the sides with the palms up while shrugging her shoulders. “Because of this exact reason, Catra, and you know that. A place of retreat that had to be as unreachable as possible, with a strong fortress and direct water supply. And you mastered

it perfectly. I'm actually proud of you, how you achieved so much with so little means. We maybe can develop Buhen further, make an actual city out of it, to mark our claims to the land again. In ancient times, everything up to the second cataract and even further belonged to us."
I scoffed. "Land? You clearly haven't been there, have you? There is no land. It's a fucking desert along the Nile. Nothing grows there. Nobody lives there for a reason, Cleo."
"Oh, don't underestimate your work. Now people do, thanks to you. Buhen is doing good, you said it for yourself. If we support the garrison and put in a capable governor…"
"Who on earth would want to have this job?" I laughed.

She eyed me guardedly, then said: "Well, let's set this aside for today. It's not that important as of now."
I silently agreed with her because I wanted to get the fuck out of this conversation that was a waste of my time.
"Yeah. If that's all, I would like to fetch something to eat from your lush buffet and go to bed. I have a week of sleep ahead of me and can't wait to get it."
Again, this wary look of hers, like she was suspicious. "I still want to talk about your next assignment."
The nerve she had. "Ugh! Can't I have at least one night of sleep until you sent me away again?" I groaned.
It took her a bit too long to reply for it to be natural, but finally Cleopatra nodded. "Sure. Go. Sleep. We'll see tomorrow."
"Oh, thank you, dear sister, thank you so much for allowing me basic human needs," I snarked out pretty sarcastically, and turned to leave the hall in the direction of the festival, when she interjected by calling me again. "Where do you want to go?" It was a bit shrill.
"To the buffet? I'm starving," I deadpanned, pretending not to know anything.
"I can have you something brought. To your room." Too friendly, too loud.
"Don't be ridiculous. The stuff is right over there and I can clearly fetch it for myself."
"You said you're tired and there's no need to—"

I had enough of the ridiculous charade. “Really, Cleo? Isn't this low, even for you? Do you think I don’t know what’s going on in this mind of yours? That’s pretty bold. And derogatory, actually.”
She stood up and pointed with her index finger at me. “I fucking knew it. Okay. I can put it very simple. Leave her alone! Do you hear me, Catra? She’s not your little love toy. Stay. Away.”
“Love toy? Are you… Sister, what do you even know about love? You know nothing, Cleo. Love isn’t even a concept in your world, so don't you dare teach me something you have no idea about. What you’re doing here is wrong, and you know it.”
She crossed her arms before her chest and glared down at me, despite being a tad smaller. “Be it as it may, Catra. Adora is going to marry Hordak, and there’s nothing you can do about. Just leave this weird little fling behind you, I beg you.”
“This is no fling.” Of course, it isn’t. But it’s not like you would understand this.
She looked at me condescendingly: “Don’t be ridiculous. You’ve never been serious with your—”
“SHE IS NO FLING. I FUCKING LOVE HER!”
"What?" The stunned, almost stupid expression on her face was genuine. It could have been hilarious to make of her if the situation wasn't so hair-raisingly embarrassing.
“You heard me good enough,” I growled.
Cleopatra stood silent for a long moment, obviously trying to catch up. “Catra. You don’t… you don’t mean this for real. She’s a patrician and you—” she fell silent, and judging from the expression on her face, she knew what she had been about to say.

But ooof! That stung. I had expected her to say something like “Fucking go out of the way because I need this alliance and your love life is not important enough to risk the sake of the realm.” It was a shitty reason, in my opinion, but it was a reason I could comprehend, because I knew it meant everything to her. But that? Even my sister deemed me not worthy enough to have someone like Adora? Actually, beside the pang, I felt offended.
“Thank you for your frank words. I will keep them in mind when considering taking another task of yours, my dear sister. I’m going

now. Good night.” Turning on my heels, I rushed outside, ignored her calls and went to my room, forgetting to fetch something to eat, because I was fucking angry now. My blood sang in anger and spite, making my body wanting to punch her, knowing that I could not. Most likely, I could not. But I could do something different: I could defy her will.
Should Cleo say what she wanted, as I already decided not to care any longer, at least not for today. Or rather, for tonight.

And if that hadn’t been enough, all the possible reluctance left was forgotten the moment I saw Adora.

I was ridiculously and utterly unprepared when I entered the ballroom and my eyes fell onto her. She looked so stupidly, unbelievably beautiful that it just hurt. I caught her sight while she was standing with a group of noblewomen that seemed to have taken her to their own delight, while she just looked like being held captive. They chattered useless stuff, while Adora was simply too polite and well-mannered to openly display her boredom. Slowly strolling and scurrying around the ballroom, always keeping other people in the line of sight, I approached my unwary prey.

She noticed me when I was only a few steps away. I felt so flattered when I saw her eyes pulling wide and this happy, adorable smile appearing on her face. Was that because of me? She excused herself swiftly, closed the distance between us and now, standing before her, all my clever claims had gone out of the window. To my own embarrassment, all I mustered to say or rather to murmur was, “You are beautiful.” Adora grinned like a little girl. “Thank you,” she said slowly, punctuating the words with a small curtsy, and said: “It’s a beautiful dress.” Her long blonde hair fell down on both sides, draping complimentary over her surprisingly deep cleavage. I shook my head. “I said *you* look beautiful. The dress has little to do with it.” At that, Adora’s eyes pulled even wider[99], and her ridiculous attempt to hide her blush behind a nervous laugh failed miserably. I felt a weird relief about the arousal that my little statement left her in. At least, her feelings seemed not to have changed during my absence.

Mine certainly hadn’t. Now I knew I would carry out my plan. As certain last preparations had to be made, I also curtsied shortly and said: “See you around, Adora.” She looked irritated about my abrupt departure, but I was away before she could say something. Again, I forgot to get myself something to eat.

And there we were, as I locked the door with the attached bolt after I had closed it quietly.

I could’ve taken a moment to admire the room, but my whole attention was already taken. She stood at the balcony, looking down, maybe admiring the view.
I’d always thought Adora was beautiful, right from the moment she walked down Cleo's galley. It was something like an obvious fact of life – water is wet, grass is green, Adora is beautiful. Simple facts.
And I couldn't help but to admire *my* view for a short moment. Her sleeveless white dress with the intricate gold stripes flattered her perfect shape. The toned arms, her long neck between the defined shoulder blades, her strong legs the curved into the rounds of her ass that was so—
Gracious goddess. My heart pounded so loud, she must’ve heard it clear and precise even from over there. But Adora didn’t make any move, she just stood, and her hands had grabbed the railing. Now I noticed little shivers running through her body and I realized: she wasn’t looking. It rather seemed that she was… frightened? Every fiber pushed me to embrace her and tell her that everything was alright, that she was safe, that it was *just me*. And still, I wanted this mischievous little surprise.

She must have noticed my presence — somebody’s presence — but she didn’t move even the slightest bit. Her pose was gracious, but tense. I scurried closer to her and was only an arm’s length

away from her now. Her nape looked so perfectly molded, so vulnerable with the open dress, so *kissable*, so perfectly made for me. I pushed forward.

When my lips touched her neck, her skin felt surprisingly soft. Still drawing it out on purpose, I slowly put my hands on her hip and made another step forward, closing the distance. She tensed, letting out a light sigh, then I *purred* : "Even from behind, you look beautiful."

Adora spun around, nearly knocking me over. The expression on her face turned from frightened-concern to relief to surprise to concern again in mere seconds. "What? Catra? How…" She sounded way too high.
"Shss…" I raised my hands to calm her down. "All is well."
After glancing at me with wide eyes, she finally asked with a hoarse voice: "Where is Hordak? I'd expected—".
She fell silent when she noticed the smug smile that covered my face. "He is perfectly fine, I would say. Looks like he was held up in an urgent conversation about architecture by Entrapta."
"What?" She actually blinked a few times, and was obviously confused.
I snickered. "Yes, believe it or not. Entrapta is a genius at talking. If she's interested in the matter, of course." I shrugged. "It turned out that she and Hordak have a mutual interest in the architecture of cities. And it might be that I hinted that Hordak is building exactly a new one, and maybe she got a bit tipsy because I handed her some drinks, and it also maaay be that she's rambling a lot at him right now. So, Hordak might need some time free himself again. He didn't look so disinterested at all." I grinned as wide as the Nile and found myself pretty smart.

Adora's facial expression radiated disbelief, and the only noise came from her dress, which shuffled around her feet when she retreated a step. "Is… is this a joke to you?".
I realized that my attempt to paint my little trick funnily hadn't gone down very well. Oh dear goddesses, that wasn't "No! No! I'm sorry. I didn't mean to..."
"Are you playing with me, Catra?" She withdrew until the railing of

the balcony stopped her, and she grabbed it with both hands to the side, meant to steady herself, but it let her look even more vulnerable.
I reached out with a hand to her. "Adora, please! I'm not playing with you. I wanted to… I wanted to…"
What had it been that I wanted? Right before I knew I had a plan, but right now everything I knew was that I knew nothing. I was such an idiot. All of this wasn't supposed to scare her.

"What did you want, Catra?" Adora asked, her voice turning from being annoyed to something else. Like searching for an answer. *Come on, Catra, you got this, don't chicken out now.* I cleared my throat. I could do this. "I wanted to steal you away from him for this night. To have you. May tomorrow care for itself, but I won't. And may Cleo say what she wants. I don't care. I want… you."

Adora's eyes went wide. She looked shocked. No, not really shocked, but stunned. I opened my mouth to explain myself in a better way, with maybe better words, but then a strife of anger on her face kept me shut.
"Catra… I… don't know what to say. You… you know what your sister has planned for me. He's even here, he shall meet me right here. And now you're doing… what? Intercepting him? What do you think will happen now? That I'm going to… go with you, spend the night with you? Where shall this lead to?"
I was desperate, wanting to save the situation, somehow, and had no idea what to do. "I don't know! How should I even? I've been away for three weeks and the night I'm back, you're going to… share it with him? With someone you don't even know or want in any way?"
She waved a dismissive hand and looked irritated. "It's not like that, Catra. We shall just talk. To get to know us."
I gestured wildly around, taking the whole scenery of the nicely decorated room into account. "Are you sure? All of this here doesn't really say 'talk'. It's rather shouting 'allure'! You can't be that dense, Adora. I know you aren't."
I could watch her composure falling apart upon my words. Her shoulders sagged, the superficial strength leaving her. "I… What… Don't…" she stuttered, and I knew I had broken through the

defense that had kept her upright through the evening.
"Come on, Adora, you don't want this. I don't want this for you. You must not be here tonight. Don't stay! Stay with me!"

Her entire forte seemed to have left her, as she slumped back against the railing. I wanted to hold her, to pet her. But I also sensed that she would draw back if I approached her now. She needed to get through that decision on her own. But I had to stop myself from wincing when she spoke, because she sounded so defeated while answering: "Why should I even fight anymore? It will happen. Today, tomorrow, in a week. Doesn't matter. It will happen."
I never heard her like this. So small.

"Dammit, Adora. Of course, it matters. It matters to me! You matter to me!"
Her eyes lightened up a little. Maybe like always when I said something nice to her. *This is it, this is the opportunity I needed.*
"Whatever happens tomorrow, Adora, we have tonight. Do you want it?" And while I didn't phrase it "Do you want me?" we understood what I really asked, nearly begged. She closed her eyes, trouble and conflict marking her face. She was still hesitant, doubting, and I decided to make one last approach.
I held out my hand and asked: "Do you want to be with me?" She said nothing, but after what seemed to be minutes, maybe hours, days later, she slowly laid hers in mine, trusting, hoping, and finally, her decision seemed to bring her relief, when she smiled bright and kind, as it was her nature. And I just smiled back.

("Blinding Lights Instrumental", Deezer / Spotify / YouTube)

Adora followed my willingly while I led her through one of the secret corridors of the palace, so that nobody could see us. We must have given a weird impression, sneaking around in our best dresses like thieves in the night, but I didn't care. Because I had a very important aim to achieve, and it summarized to "lead the love of my life securely to a place where we would be able to spend the night together", whatever that should mean.
To my relief, I'd been able to avoid any encounter until we

reached the pier at the royal port. I'd covered Adora's blonde and shining hair with my headscarf, but nobody of importance saw us. Ushering her up the gangway of the *Heket*, the very ship that had Adora brought to Egypt in the beginning, I watched out for any signs of spectators or guards. But my confidant had kept his promise: the soldiers strolled around to the other side of the pier and demonstratively looked at the Lighthouse, and the main cabin of the ship had been readied. Adora shot me a wary look, but I only smirked, when I opened the door for her. "This is ours for the night," I invited her, and held out my hand. "Nobody will look out for us here, sooo… be my guest."

The great cabin, which Adora already knew, was now nicely decorated. The large bed, connected to the floor, stood in the middle of the room, covered with cushions and half-sealed by purple curtains that were neatly draped around, hanging down from the ceiling. The large window to the rear was covered by shutters and veiled with more silk scarves. Two large candlesticks with several arms and candles bathed everything in a dim and kind, golden light. I stood behind her when she unveiled herself, and the candles put a golden glow around the contours of her hair. She looked so otherworldly glorious.

Out of nowhere, I was nervous.

Everything had happened so fast. I was back in Alexandria for a few hours only, but now I was here, alone, with Adora, against the direct order of Cleopatra. I practically kidnapped her from the festivities, let Hordak look like an idiot when he would find out, and I would have to deal with my sister's anger tomorrow. Well, fuck that.
And Adora? What did she expect from me now?
I wasn't prepared for what should come next, hadn't thought it through. Of course, I hadn't. I had only focused on getting it done, on getting her here. But I hadn't thought further, not really, not far enough.
I always had a plan!
Why didn't I have a plan now?

I was such an idiot and started to gnaw on my fingernails in despair.

The next I noticed was that Adora stood before me. Very close. Too close to be unnoticed, and she gained my full attention when her hand cupped my chin and cheek, lifting it. I immediately leaned in on instinct. She smelt so… like home. Like the meadow. Like the winds of the Cyrenaica.

"What are you doing?" I charily asked. My brain had stopped working, because… because… Oh Hathor, she was so close, so beautiful, so beguiling.
"Oh, I don't know," she fake innocently rolled her eyes, then pursed her lips, embraced me lightly and playfully kissed my nose. "Maybe continuing where we left?"
"Really? Just because?" I couldn't believe the wit of this woman.
"I thought you were the one with a plan, Catra? Maybe I'm wrong, but isn't all of this speaking 'allure' to me?" she joked, gestured around herself, and it looked so admirable that my heart must have skipped several beats. Adora grabbed my hands and put them to her lips, slowly kissing every knuckle, while her blue eyes kindly looked into mine. Every strength had left me, I was just melting under her searching gaze. "I'm here," she whispered. "And I won't go anywhere. Not without you."
I gulped at her words and the smile that pierced me. "You... you suddenly seem to be so sure about this. How come?" I hoarsely croaked.
She shrugged her shoulders. "I had three weeks to think about what I want. Enough time to know, I would say."
"Right," I cawed, making an idiot out of myself. Where was my wit now?
Luckily, Adora was a little more able, because she hooked her index finger under the strap of my dress going over my shoulder and looked at me questioningly. I felt like a clumsy imbecile and only nodded in approval. In desperate approval. Proceeding with the other strap, my dress fell down around my feet, leaving me only in my underwear, pieces of gray cloth around my chest and hip. Suddenly, I was very self-conscious, but I somehow found the courage to do her the same favor. Adora giggled lightly, when she

stepped out of her gown, shrugging off her sandals too and looking nothing but terrific, just in her panties. She was personified Hathor in all her glory.

And then she was so close, so near, so adorable, but there was still a bit too much space between us. Clothes had to be removed, reluctance to be overcome, shyness to be kissed away. We took it slowly, in every sense. And then, there was no distance at all.

Kissing the sweat off of her was easy, so good, so *right*. Still in that dreamy afterglow, I softly petted Adora's hair, who lay face down across my chest and with her arms around me, making me feel so comforted and content like never before. The whole night had been pure bliss and I wanted to bask in it forever, in this beautiful silence of still lingering passion and joy. And the scent of sex. It had been a truly amazing experience. I had tried to be tender and gentle, most of the time pressing soft kisses on every inch of Adora's skin. I wanted to make her feel safe, even when she was at her most vulnerable. But actually, this goddess was a fast learner. Her first orgasm didn't satisfy her hunger. Instead, it ignited her with force. She became more demanding, more playful, more rough the next time. And the time after that. I wanted to give her everything. To fulfill her dreams. To mark her as mine. To never let her go. And eventually we were worn out and lay down, draped over each other.

But suddenly, it wasn't silent anymore. She sobbed. Adora sobbed.

I jumped up and looked at her face. "What? Why are you crying? Have I… have I hurt you?"

She slowly shook her head in denial, her blonde hair flying around while she gripped me and nuzzled into my neck. Her voice was all soft and calm. Full of joy. “No! No! I'm… just so happy, is all.” Relief washed over me, and I instantly clung back to her. “That is… good,” was all I could manage.
She giggled upon my obvious loss of speech. “Cat got your tongue, hmm?” I slapped her head gently, but she ignored it and continued: “But… really, I hadn’t expected it — you — to be so… gentle, you know?”
I wiped and kissed the tears on her cheek away. “I wanted your first experience to be… to be… just like that. You deserved it.”
“You are so kind, you secret softy,” she grinned, trying to gain the upper hand. But her next words would’ve swept me off my feet if I hadn’t laid half on top of her. “I’m just happy that… it was you. *You.* And not….someone else. I wouldn't change anything. Only with you, it could have been so perfect like it was. You're perfect, Catra. For me, you're perfect,” she whispered.

The unbelievable amount of trust this woman had in me made me speechless. I burst out in tears, and cried in happiness against Adora’s neck for a long time, while she held me and whispered assuring nonsense into my ear. Over the course of my embarrassment, the happy thoughts turned dark and let me cry more, as all the lingering doom upon her designated fate crumbled down on me. It streamed out of me through my tears, and made me feel like I was the one to be sold away and not her. I finally ran out of tears and even my sobbing stopped.
With a tender voice, she muttered into my ear: “I thank you. This is… was better than I could ever hope for. Thank you for taking care of me so well. Now, I know that it just doesn’t matter that you’re a woman. It is what it is. Thank you.” I nodded eagerly into her chest and stammered: “I'm so sorry, Adora. For what will happen, and for my--”
“Sssshhh, don’t. Don't speak of it. I'm here. You are. All is well.”

And so, after a while, we lay side by side, tangled into each other. Adora smelled sweet like the meadow and dangerous like a legion. Her head lay on my chest again and her hair splayed all over me. My legs were draped and mingled into hers, and it wasn’t

physically possible to have more body contact than we had. More *naked* body contact, I reminded myself again and again, because here she was, the blonde goddess, so soft and sweet, curled into me, slowly killing me with her mere presence. Every now and then she playfully touched my boob in front of her face with her hand, gently nudging it with her index finger, and every single time she quietly giggled like an idiot as it bobbed. It was an adorable little noise and put a smile on my face. It made her happy, and so I was.
While I was dozing off, I felt how her limbs relaxed and when this last little shrug trembled through her body, that always marked the beginning of the brain falling asleep. “I have you, my love. I have you. Sleep. You’ve been so wonderful,” I murmured. Adora hummed softly, but then everything was quiet, and I could only hear her calm breathing. It didn’t stop me from slowly petting her hair and stroking her back until I also dreamt off.

I didn’t want to wake up. Waking up meant standing up, standing up meant getting ready, that meant leaving, then facing Cleopatra, and facing her meant that everything would get ugly in no time. For the first time in my life, I feared her, and didn't even want to see her. No, I didn’t want to wake up, when in the other side, not waking up meant having Adora in my arms.
Her head lay on my chest, she was slightly snoring, and even that was adorable to an unbearable amount. There had to be a ruling against otherworldly cuteness, I mused, and if my relationship with Cleo hadn't been so complicated and tense at the moment I would’ve happily proposed the idea. I put my hand on her hair, just laying it there, to feel her, to assure myself of her proximity, and perhaps that she was real, and no trick of the gods.
Still, it was hard to believe that we’d shared the last night, that I'd

been graced with *her*. I could never tell her how deep in love with her I was, how strong the feeling had grown.
Eyeing Adora, nothing in her appearance seemed to have changed, but still… there was something more mature to her, even in her sleep. She looked confident and relaxed, and radiated an underlying strength that was just about to wake. *Give her a few more years and experience, and she will become a natural leader*, I thought. *Hordak won't even know what's hitting him then.*
Sighing, I threw the thought away and started to strike Adora's head softly. She stirred, a little moan escaped her, then she opened her eyes. She seemed to need a few moments to realize where she was, but then she got it, moved forward, propping herself up on her palms, and pinned me to the bed again.

"I have dreamt of this for a long time," she grinned at me.
"What? Pinning me down? I already knew that, you bossy Roman," I smirked back at the grinning idiot.
"No. Yes! I mean, no!"
It was funny to watch her stumbling over her own words, and I giggled. "A bit confused, princess?"
She playfully tried to shove a pillow in my face — not again! — and I fended it off.
"Shut up, you foul beast. I mean, waking up with you on my side, after… you know… such a night."
I hummed in approval, but my hand already searched for one of her boobs, and squeezed it lightly when being successful. The lustful grin on her face told me everything I needed to know.
"Aren't we a bit eager in the morning?" she asked.
"I don't know what you are talking about," I replied, while gently continuing to squeeze, and Adora started to pepper my chest with kisses. Her hair fell over my face, and, while playing with some strands, it made me wonder. "Why are they blonde? Isn't it unusual for a Roman?"
Adora hummed softly, and while she still kissed me she muttered: "One of my grandmothers was a noblewoman of the Cherusci, a Germanic tribe. They tried to make an alliance. She was said to have been an extraordinarily beautiful woman. I inherited the hair

color from her.”
“Not only the color, my love. You are indeed beautiful, too.”
My praise let her blush, and I immediately cut in: “Don’t let this get into your big forehead, Adora. After all, I'm even prettier than you,” and I poked said big part of her body not too gently.
She stared at me, grinning. “Is that so?”
“Of course, you can ask—”
“Whom can I ask, Catra? Whom?” she called in a fake menacing voice, while poking back and tickling my sides. “Everyone, just everyone,” I yelped and bucked and tried to flee the bed, but found myself again pinned down by the bossy Roman above me. The *naked* bossy Roman, whose very nice boobs were right before my face, and given my current state, my only defense was to *lick* on them.

Adora squeaked and giggled, let me lose, and maybe events could have developed further in very much appreciated ways, when a knock at the door interrupted our little foreplay.
“I know you’re in there and you better stand up and come with me, girls,” a grim, familiar voice said.
“How did she find us?” Adora whispered, frozen and with wide eyes.
I rubbed my neck and grinned apologetically. “Uuuh… that’s on me, I think. I kind of… told her? Just in case something happens.”
Adora stared at me in horror.

Glimmer visibly tapped with her foot, her arms crossed over her chest, when I finally opened the door and let her in. But her face spoke a different language. “Why, by the sake of the whole fucking Pantheon, did you have to choose her own ship, you damned idiots? Why, of all the opportunities you have at hand, you had to pick this? Catra, sorry to repeat myself, but you’re an idiot. She will kill you, and I will gladly hand over the dagger to her, just because you're so stupid.”
“Good morning Sparkles. It’s so nice to see you. What a wonderful way to start a day, won’t you say so?” I overly friendly trilled and bowed to her in mockery.
She stared at me, her mouth agape because she clearly expected me to come back in my usual way, but now she gritted her teeth

and said: “Fine. You’re still an idiot. Now go to your room. She waits for you. I’m taking care of Adora.”

I had no clever answer to that. Leaving Adora didn’t bode well, but what choices did I have? Delaying the inevitable was useless. So I pecked a kiss on Adora's cheek and was on my way, knowing she was watching behind me with a worried look. I didn't need to see it. Didn't want to. The few minutes walk from the royal port to the palace weren’t nearly enough to develop a proper plan or even the start of an idea of how to deal with Cleo. But they were certainly enough to get worked up. As I stood before my own room, I ran down my hands over my hair and my dress to smooth it uselessly and heaved a deep breath, before I laid my hand on the door handle.

Cleopatra was already waiting when I sneaked in and closed the door behind me. The Pharaoh sat on a chair beside the window, and from the half of her face I could see, her expression was stern. But there was also a slight hint of something else on it. Maybe regret? Looking half out of the window and half at the wall, she drummed her fingers on a table that stood nearby, while I crossed the room. I stopped in the middle of it. It still left a distance between us, and I wondered if we would be able to close it in more than this metaphorical sort of way. A silence fell upon us when she stopped drumming, but didn't do anything. It was uncomfortable, and a bit spooky. Neither of us were particularly quiet types.

“This won't change anything,” she finally said, and her voice was unexpectedly calm. So I was too surprised to ask anything else than “What?”
She warily glanced at me with narrowed eyes. “You, dragging her into your bed. Or rather… my bed, right?” She sighed. “Did you think I wouldn’t know about it?”
Chuckling lowly, I replied, my voice a tad too high. “I hoped for it? I mean, how do you know, by the way?”
Cleo made something like an apologetic gesture with her hands. “You can safely assume that I'm not still alive because I'm so pretty. Ruling a kingdom requires attention. And little escapes

mine. Nor should it.” It could have sounded like boasting, but the tonality in her voice was rather weary, almost defeated.
“So, someone told you? And you… did nothing?”
“Someone told me, but only this morning. It was too late to stop you from… whatever you were doing.” Despite our usual casualness, she was a bit uncomfortable with the topic. “Luckily, Hordak seemed not to be too disappointed about Adora’s… severance. I excused her to him. But all of that doesn’t change what’s going to happen. You know I won’t stop this, Catra. I can’t. I need this bond, and everything that comes with it.”

“I know about your great plan,” I grumbled, but got louder as I collected my breath: “Anyway, I wouldn't do anything different. And somehow I’ve got the idea that you owe me something, sister.”
Seeing how her face distorted was almost funny. “I owe you? Who do you—”
“Oh please, Cleo, we're not at court, this is just us. Have at least the decency to pretend to acknowledge that I've never asked for anything in return for all my services to you, you smug bitch.” It was rare that I talked to her like that. And it was well-deserved now.
She needed a moment to think about her reply. “I won't punish you, and I think given the stunt you've pulled this night, this means something.”
“Not enough,” I scoffed, meaning it. It didn't mean enough. Last night was last night.
“However, Adora’s not going to become yours. I need this bond now more than ever.”
“What do you mean with that? You’ve already won. What do you need from the mighty Caesar now?”
“Don’t be an idiot, Catra. Caesar is important, but the whole Julian gens is it even more. With them on my side, I can reach everything in this corner of our world.”
“And you really think forcing Adora is going to help you to get a friend in her and her family?”
“Pfff, she will clear her mind in time. In one or two years, she’ll have come to terms with all of that. The woman will be fine,

ruling happily over the Thebaid with Hordak. In five years, she'll have a few children and won't think of her childish adventures anymore. And I actually don’t need her approval, but that of all the high-handed male patricians in her family. They are the ones with power. She’s nothing but a symbol.”
“She’s… She is… ” Once again I fell dry trying to express what I felt for Adora, but Cleo already knew that from my outburst last evening. It would be of no use to repeat it.

“I’m sorry,” she said, and it sounded honest. “I’m sorry for what I said yesterday. I didn’t mean it in the way it must have sounded. It’s just that…” she trailed off, and I cut in, because again anger fueled me, when I remembered her words. “It’s just what, Cleo? What? Don’t hold back. It’s not like that you haven’t already torn out my heart. So what’s the point?”
She splurted: “Adora won’t marry someone without any titles or power or wealth, Catra. Don’t make a fool out of yourself. Her family is too influential, too powerful, too rich to waste her on a marriage for love. Between two women. That’s… that’s just not possible.”
“Waste her? Do you even hear yourself?” I stared at her angrily, and she stood up and faced me directly: “You know what I mean. Don't turn the words around in my mouth.”
“You send the woman I love into an unwanted marriage she will loathe every day of her life, and you call me a waste on her side. How’s that supposed to sound different, sister?”
She tried to get calmer, more concerned in her answer. It only didn’t reach me. “Catra, I was trying to protect you from this.” She raised a hand in a calming attempt and made a step forward to close the distance between us, but I was already speaking: “Well, you failed. Maybe I overestimated your usefulness.” It was a cheap and petty reply, and I knew it the moment the words left my lips. I damned my cheeky mouth as she stopped, clearly remembering her own words, and I was nearly sure that she’d regretted what she said before. But my vicious payback hurt her nonetheless, leaving her with that, and anger she suppressed quite well.

She lowered her hand, stepped back a pace, her expression closed, her posture went stiff, and she returned to her Pharaonic stance. “I see. Well, I don’t think we’re going to make amends here, aren’t we?” Her voice was chill, distant. A part of me wanted to say sorry for my remark, another part wanted to yell at her. I loved Adora with all my heart and wanted to protect her from this unbearable fate. Another part still loved Cleo, stemming from a life of mutual experiences and a shared childhood that would never vanish. I understood her motivation partially, but I found myself unable to forgive more and more. “No, probably not. Not when you pursue your course.”
She stood before me for a while, saying nothing, just clenching her jaw. Then she finally nodded slowly, cleared her throat and started to walk to the door. Before she went through, she looked to the side, down on the ground: “Meet me at noon in the throne room. Announcements will be made then.”

Silently, Cleopatra closed the door behind her. The room felt empty. Announcements? I feared them already.

My next thought was: where is Adora?

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"My cage"** and will be published on Friday, August 20, 2021.

[91] The Latin word ‘explōsio’ is the origin and predecessor of the modern term “Explosion” and meant something like clapping or throbbing, knocking out. ↕
[92] The Pschent is only one of the several crown types of Egypt, that had been used throughout history. There is a relief of Cleo’s predecessor Ptolemy XIII in a temple at Edfu which shows him wearing it, so I deemed it fitting. ↕
[93] Heqa, the crosier or crook, symbolizing the power of the Pharaoh’s as well as certain gods like Osiris, also symbolizing the cycle of birth and regeneration, aiming at the never-ending rule of the undying Pharaohs.
Nechacha, a flagellum or whip, also symbolizing Pharaonic

power, but had also the power to judge souls. ↑
[94] This is more or less a retelling of the actual events in "chapter 31" of Caesar's commentary. ↑
[95] This works better than a simple "master", despite I know that the language from where it stems won't appear for another 1,000 years. ↑
[96] This paragraph is based upon a similar one in Achilles Tatius' work "Leucippe and Clitophon", which is one of the few surviving descriptions of Ancient Alexandria. ↑
[97] Hihihi… this account used to make so funny and clever comments, but it was unfortunately closed after I took the comment and used it here. ↑
[98] Medewi: the Meroitic name for Meroë, the capital of the Kingdom of Kush. ↑
[99] This paragraph is a variation from a sentence in "forever, if you want". ↑

My cage

Chapter Summary

> You thought their journey was practically over. But it has only just begun.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Alexandria & Thebais, Egypt - March to June, 47 BCE

Catra

"Where is Adora?" I shouted at Glimmer when I ran into her after nearly kicking in the locked door to her room.
"Whoa, whoa, easy, Catra," the stocky girl called while stepping back a few paces to bring some space between us. "Calm. She's having a conversation with Hordak." She waved with her palms to calm me down, but I didn't want to be calmed down, because what the fuck.
"What? Where?"
"Somewhere at the palace, in a guarded courtyard, and you are not allowed to interrupt," Glimmer informed me with an uneasy expression. "Don't think that I'm happy with that. I hate it as much as you do. But her majesty was very serious about it, when she ordered me — and her guards."
Gah! "I don't want to interrupt," I replied, but it was a blatant lie and made Glimmer scoff. Cleo obviously didn't trust me anymore in that matter — and she was absolutely right to do so — but the feeling of Adora being alone with Hordak nagged at me. It wasn't just jealousy, there was much more to it. Couldn't I—
"No, Catra, you can't." Glimmer insisted, firmly.
Had I said that out loud? "What—"

“I can literally see what you think, you moron. Adora is no damsel in distress. As far as I’ve been told, she took out five attackers when you were on your way to Thēbais the first time. Don’t you think she can have a conversation with her husband-to-be in a courtyard, with people around?”

Grrr! I wanted to knock Glitter's shiny, perfect, teeth out.[100]
“That’s completely different, you damn sparkly princess. She can’t shoot Hordak down if he’s threatening her.”
Glimmer just scolded me more: “Don’t be an idiot, Catra. He won’t do anything like that. In fact, he’s condemned to handle her with the utmost respect. Do you think the Romans won’t be pissed if he doesn’t treat her well? Caesar started a fucking civil war against his own senate and comrades, friends even, because his oh-so-important dignitas was questioned, and he couldn’t get over his sulking. So no, he won’t harm her in any way. She will be safe and sound. He won’t even touch her if she doesn’t allow it.”

That might be, but ever-dutiful Adora would do what she had to. The thought of *him* touching *her* alone made me sick, perhaps because the memory from last night was still so fresh. That someone would be able to touch her in the same way I’d explored and roamed her soft yet strong body— Ugh! “As if that’s making anything better.” I felt how I shook as I started to fall apart and how my voice got pleading. “She will be gone, Glimmer, she will be caught in this horrible marriage, without… without any hope. She can't stay *Adora* anymore if she does that. I can't, I can't let that happen.”
Glimmer leaned with her lower back against a table and folded her arms. “I know you don’t want to hear this, but that isn’t any different from the fate of millions of other women, every day, every place, in our fucking world,” she retorted. I stared at her with my mouth agape, which she took as a sign to elaborate. “Oh, don’t look at me like that. I’m obviously not thinking that’s okay, Catra. But it’s reality and nothing less. Every one of us has to deal with this, especially the Roman women. You know how they work and how they run their nice empire. Only because you had this extraordinary childhood, being the privileged sister of a possible

Pharaoh, doesn’t mean that others were free in a similar way. Adora certainly won't. She has duties to fulfill and as it is, she will.”

Between her cruel words, a part of mine realized that her voice wasn’t unfriendly. In fact, she was talking in an even kind way, calm and empathic, despite the content of her words. But I wasn’t prepared for being scolded like a child. All the tension suddenly overwhelmed me, and she fell silent when she realized how I'd frozen and how tears started to run down my cheeks. I fell apart before her, and embarrassment wasn't a strong enough word to express how that made me feel.
“Oh dear Aphrodite, don’t cry… ugh… come here.” Glimmer shuffled forward. “I can’t believe I’m doing that,” she muttered, while putting her arms around me. She hugged me carefully, like I was an angry cat that was about to scratch her and she wasn't half a head smaller than me. But I was just petrified, be it because of the unexpected body contact, be it because of Adora or my confused state. I had no strength left in me and slumped against her. Then I embarrassed myself even more while weeping and wailing into the shoulder of a woman I barely knew.
“It is so unfair,” I sobbed, “it’s so unfair. We… just… found each other.” I shuddered. “How were the odds that a Roman patrician of all people could be the one. That she could be the one. She’s so… ugh… so condescending. And bossy. She always knows better. And how can one be always so… goodhearted. She’s so unreal, as if the world doesn’t deserve her.” I grabbed Glimmer’s arms with my hands. “And now she’s taken away. It’s so unfair!” Again, I burst out into more cries, and Glimmer just stroke my hair gently and mumbled nothing beside “I know.”

Half an hour later, I was better. After thanking her, I weakly threatened Glimmer with unspeakable torture methods to not tell anyone about my breakdown. She winked and meant, “It will be our secret that I pull out whenever we’re alone, and I like to tease you.”
Rolling my eyes, but with a very little pull of a corner of my mouth, I left for my room to get fresh clothes. And to do something about Adora’s scent that was still in my hair and all

over my body and that triggered my brain the whole time. It actually drove me mad to be so physically remembered of her every fucking second. Torn, I washed myself from head to toe and paid little attention to my wear as I dressed in some normal looking, courtly stuff. Then I fetched some spiced and buttered flatbreads from the kitchen, because my stomach grumbled very loud, and afterward, it was already noon. I pondered about drawing it out in purpose or just evading the announced meeting at all, but I was too curious — and I also wanted to see Adora.

The throne room was by no means full, but quite a number of people had gathered though. I saw Alexas, Sparkles, Bow, a few of the councilmen and advisors, general Palmedes, Rufio and so on. All the people that had a part in getting Cleopatra back on her throne and the most important officials that were under her rule now. My gaze fell on Adora, who stood before the few steps in front of the pedestal. On her one side, her uncle Caesar, on the other one, Hordak. His appearance felt weird, as if he didn't belong to here and even didn't want to be here, because he had better things to do. I found it a strange commonality there.
But Adora was entirely her patrician self. Her posture was composed, she was standing upright, and her hands were chastely clasped in front of her lap. She looked as beautiful as always, had it not been for the slight hint of tension on her face. I tried to catch her gaze from the side, but she just stared into nothing and didn't show any sign of being aware at all.

From behind, Cleopatra emerged through the entrance, walked by and took place on her throne gracefully, but without any fuss. She held a short hearing of her most important advisors, governors and generals, taking in the current situation of Alexandria and the status reports from the Two Lands. A lot of people wanted to be heard, and she absent-mindedly ordered a few measures to be taken. Meanwhile, I tried to not gnaw on my fingernails because of my bad feeling. I knew her. She was up to something that would not please me, given the fact that she hadn't looked at me even once.

Nevertheless, I wasn't prepared when she stood up, stepped to the front of the pedestal and said: "Regarding the union between the honored house of the Julii," she nodded towards Caesar and Adora, "and our trusted ally, the house of Psamtik IV, "she nodded at Hordak," we are pleased to inform you, that Adora Diana Minor of the Julii will leave Alexandria for Thēbais for the next months. After a commensurate time, a ceremony of marriage will be held in Thēbais, under the presence of Adora's family as well as the honored consul Gaius Julius Caesar. Egypt is grateful for the alliance that this bond will strengthen. It will help secure peace and prosperity of our both nations."

The edge of the axe was already visible, but it still hadn't swung down. I knew it, when I was looking into Cleo's eyes, that there was more she wanted to say, more she wanted to order. And because I knew her just too well, I wasn't too surprised, as she directly turned to me.
"Catra, my dear sister, you've been Adora's most important companion over the past few weeks. Both of you played an indispensable part during the recent events, and *We* have to thank you for your unrivaled service. That is why We have chosen you to accompany Adora on her journey to Thēbais and to guide her there safely. Afterward, you will resume your duties as governor of Buhen to continue your successful service in guarding our southern borders and making Buhen a striving city."

And so the axe swung down.

Without thinking, I rejected it. "I'm not up for this." My voice was perhaps pitching a tad too high.

And not a very good wording, obviously, because openly denying the Pharaoh's demands was *never* seen as very *clever* by the court, the Pharaoh, and history itself. I voiced it only half loud, not everyone perhaps heard it, but I noticed the mumbling and how more and more pairs of eyes focused on me. My vision darkened and the room narrowed, when Cleopatra straightened herself and turned her appearance into something a lot more formal, to the one of a sole sovereign. My blood pressure plummeted. I knew

this particular expression she had on her face. And I feared it. Like always, when Cleopatra got fully official, she immediately drew *all* the attention to her like a fucking vortex, and her appearance alone silenced everyone else just because she was *there, radiating*. Shivers ran down my spine, when she raised her commanding voice: "I am Cleopatra, Herald of the Glory of the thousand gods, Messenger of on High and Vanguard of the End times. I am the mistress of Sedge and Bee, the Lady of Upper and Lower Egypt! Where I go, I bring forth the infinity of the gods." She made an artificial pause to put the full emphasis on the second word of her next sentence. And she still sounded so friendly, so amicable.
"I *order* you, Catra Meritamun, my beloved sister, to securely accompany our admired Adora Diana Minor to Thēbais and her husband to be. She will be married to Psamtik IV. You will return to your post at Buhen afterward, and await my further orders." Another pause.
"Will you obey, like you always did, and continue to bring glory to your name and mine, sister?"

Now, finally, Adora stared at me, in shock, frozen, like a deer aware of the hunter's arrow. She'd known her fate. She'd expected what was going to happen. Nothing was new.
But not this. Not that I'd have to be the one to lead her to jail, lock her up and throw away the key. Maybe she'd arranged herself with her misery, but not with the possibility that it should be me to put her into it. I knew why Cleo was doing that. I fucking knew it. And couldn't do anything against it.
Almost imperceptible and with her mouth slightly agape, Adora shook her head at me, and I wasn't able to look into her eyes any longer. Instead, I stared at the ground, unable to move, hands fisted, my heart hammering, my mind a confused mess.
But I always knew I would've been a coward when it would come to this decision. I always knew, that, when judgement day came, I would not be worthy enough.

I didn't want to have to do this.

Choosing between Adora and Cleopatra. This sister I'd known for decades now. Trusted ally, familiar solid rock, guide in a world of insecurity and aimlessness.
On the other side, Adora, the woman I promised to protect. *The woman I loved.* The first woman I loved in my whole fucking life.

"Will you obey, Catra?" Cleopatra asked a second time, and I knew, there wouldn't be a third one. She'd never done that.

Were it the years of willful compliance? My allegiance and our sisterly bond? The fear of being removed from the amenities my position at her side provided? My cowardice? I didn't know. I knew that I would be dishonored, regardless of the decision I would make.
Slowly, I forced myself to nod. A single nod. It felt like tearing my heart apart. Like eating ash. Like being punched in the gut. I winced at it. I lost a part of myself in this very moment, a part of my humanity, of my dignitas, how Adora would put it. I had to, but I felt… dirty, besmudged. It hurt.

But nothing hurt as much as Adora's scream, which echoed in my head the whole day after. She perhaps yelled at me, sounding partly angry and partly something else, between afraid and disappointed, and for which I lacked a proper word. I didn't get it very good, because my mind twirled too much. While everyone around us pretended to overlook and overhear her, I did nothing but to stand and take it.

I'd broken my promise, and she was the one to suffer from it. I hated myself.

Our caravan meandered its way up the Nile, along the great lifeline of our kingdom, always in sight of its blue glint. The convoy of dozens of people was moving at an annoyingly slow

speed. It was exactly the reason, why I'd finally agreed to Adora's stupid idea of riding with her alone back then, on our first attempt to go for Thēbais. That little adventure seemed to have happened in another life. And somehow it was like that.
We'd traveled by a bark until Hermiopolis Magna, needing only a few days for that. But then, an unexpected harsh flood of the Nile made going on the river uncomfortable enough to force us to use the road for the last part of the journey. I didn't care anyway. It wasn't that I was of any use at this. Hordak had his own men organizing everything of importance to him, and my duty would have consisted of guarding or guiding Adora. She clearly didn't need or want that. As she was accompanied by Bow and his two contubernia, there was little to do for me on that behalf.

Also contributed the fact that she didn't speak with me.

I made a tentative attempt to talk to her the night before we left Alexandria. When I knocked at her door and she opened it, all I got was a brutal stare. She looked at me, ever so beautiful, but it was all her patrician self and a coldness I wasn't aware she could muster, then she closed the door again without a word. I felt… humiliated. Somewhere in the torn depths of my mind, I conceded her the right to do so, and did nothing in return.

Because I could've said 'No'. It wouldn't have mattered at all, given the circumstances. My service wasn't needed here. It had been a cool, unemotional calculation by Cleo, aimed to sever Adora's and mine bond. I could have said 'No'.
Only that I didn't.
She wouldn't have beheaded me for my refusal, but Cleo knew exactly how to get under my skin and made me do this, knowing that I would always comply to her demands. To prove myself worth her respect and approval, the respect of the Pharaoh, and the court alongside with it. All my status depended only on her. But I could've said no. I knew it, and couldn't act different anyway.

And it worked. Adora didn't speak to me anymore.

I made another approach the next day, when we already left Alexandria and were on the bark. She often sought the company of her companion Bow, or sat next to Hordak when meals were served, or when they tried to enter into a conversation. As the ever-friendly nature that she was, she visibly put in an effort to make the best out of the awkward situation, and Hordak wasn't unfriendly. They sometimes spoke, but more often, their talks fell dry quickly. He just seemed to be not very interested at all, only living up a little when it came to his building and engineering projects.

I caught her alone in the evening, when she stood at the railing of the bark and watched the river shore flowing by. It remembered me so much of our journey from Maidum back to Pelousion. She'd looked so strong then, in her green hunter's dress that suited her so well. Like Artemis on a hunt. And so enticing, with our kiss just hours before.
Now she wore a long sandy-colored dress, loosely hanging down from her waist, where a red purple-red belt held it in place. The sleeves were cut open and fluttered in the wind, as did some strands of her hair. Sometimes I could get a glimpse of her bare thighs, that I'd caressed so eagerly just nights before. She looked so beautiful that it hurt, and it only made me aware of what I might never get to touch again. The calm, nightly atmosphere only added to it.
I cleared my throat. "Can we speak?"
She didn't reply, but she also didn't move. She said nothing, but maybe she was willing to listen?
"I'm sorry." It wasn't as hard to admit as I thought. The words just tumbled out easily after I got over myself. "I'm sorry for not… acting different. I didn't know what she was up to, and I wasn't prepared. Never in my life I rejected her."
Adora propped her head on her palms, the elbows on the railing, and continued watching the shore. I took it as a sign to continue, but in fact, I didn't even know what to say. Saying sorry wasn't nearly enough, but what else could I put in words? How could I explain myself, how could I tell her about being unable to deny Cleopatra nearly anything? And would she understand it?

Seconds of quietness turned into minutes, and the silence between us grew uncomfortable. I leaned against the railing beside her, but with a palpable distance between us. Even that hurt, but I knew I had no right to get closer. Before me, the rampant fields and acres of the Nile delta passed by under a quickly rising moon. Daylight had turned to dusk, and dusk turned to night. And somewhere in between, Adora straightened up, said "That is not enough," and went away, under deck, where her cabin lay. I didn't dare to follow her, let alone knock at her door. Instead, I gripped the railing to not crumble down and tried to breathe. In, and out, in, and out, in, and out. It helped a little, but it wasn't enough either.

The two following days of travel floated by with little to none talk of us at all. For me, this whole journey went by in a blur. Our last but one conversation also wasn't that long. It happened the night after we'd left the bark, to take the last part of the journey by carts, horses, and foot. I caught her while she strolled around the camp we'd set up for the night. She sat beside a phoinix[101] on her own and nibbled at some dates that she'd somehow managed to fetch from the tree. A squad of Bows guards stood a few dozen meters away, for her protection, but out of earsight.
"Isn't Hordak feeding you good enough?" I tried to jest when I approached her, and I hoped to get even something, *anything* from her.
"Pfff."
At least, she didn't stand up and walk away. "Why are you here?" I asked.
She rolled her eyes and groaned in frustration, then she scoffed coolly: "Being on my own. Didn't work, obviously."
This cold and repellant version of her hurt to watch. She was still herself, but withdrawn, more like she'd been at the beginning of our acquaintance. Guarded, patrician, hyperaware.
And I tried, I really tried. "There…. There has to be something I can do, Adora. Something to make it up to you. If you… can't you…" I hated the begging sound of my voice and couldn't help

using it either. She threw some of her dates at me, not in anger, rather in disgust, it seemed. It was a weak throw, and the dates fell to my feet.
"Why does it even matter, Catra? It's all over. There's nothing you can do about it, even if you wanted to. You were — you were actually right to comply with your sister. Fuck." She ran a hand through her hair, searching for words. "It's… all of you just use me. And the longer I'm thinking about all of this, the more I'm coming to the conclusion, that I don't like being used. By no one. Neither by my family nor by your sister, nor by you, by the way."
"What?" I used her? That wasn't… she couldn't mean that, but she didn't pay any attention to me, as she glared around and continued rambling. "Everyone uses me, like a tool. My family is using me to secure the ties to an important ally, because it's for the greater good." She spat out, the anger clearly on her face. "Your sister uses me to bind the Republic and to support her reign through it. Hordak… I… I don't even know what he wants, but," she let out a single, desperate bark, "I surely will find out. And you just used me for whatever you think is needed to satisfy your bitch sister, to gain her oh-so-important attention. She's clearly more important to you than I. I got that."

The accusation actually needed a few moments to sink in. When it did, it hurt. More than her previous behavior or sayings. Was it that she was thinking of me? "That isn't… no, Adora, that is not true! How can you…" It drove me to tears, quickly, but it also constricted my throat and I could only let out a whimper.
It wasn't that she suddenly was too cold-hearted to recognize my struggle. But she also didn't look at me anymore, while she stood up and ignored it.
"Catra, whatever you think I wanna hear, I won't. I'm… I'm tired. Good night." She walked away, not fast, not slow, just as graceful as one could expect it from a noble woman. It was nearly convincing, hadn't it been for the little trembles in her hand that she tried to cover by gripping it with the other one. I hadn't the courage to go after her.

And then, the evening came when I had my last real conversation with Adora. Tomorrow morning, we would reach Thēbais, and

then it would all be over. Our mutual way would part. Maybe we would see each other at occasional crossings, at the frequent and formal festivities in Alexandria, or a chance meeting at the court. But besides that, we wouldn't meet each other again. I startled from my blurry ride, when suddenly Adora reached out for me for the first time on the whole journey.
Unnoticed, she'd put her horse beside mine and started talking, while I'd still been looking forward, dazed by the trot and my ever-circling mind.
"Will you be happy, Catra?"
"Huh?" I replied, too surprised from the abrupt address to actually reacting to her question. What was she asking about?
Adora turned to me, but her gaze brushed past my side. She sounded calm. "I want to grasp if you will be happy. Is this what you wanted? I… really need to understand, because I must know if handing me over on behalf of your sister and then going back to your assignment or whatever… will this make you happy? Is it worth it?"

It was hard not to scoff. *No? It obviously isn't! All of this is worth nothing if it is without you!* I knew the answer. I knew the answer since the moment I'd submitted to Cleopatra. Nothing ever since made me doubt it. I knew I wouldn't be happy in th the slightest. And though… "I… I… I think so?" I weakly replied.
Adora's voice was still firm, downright hard. "Is this a question or a statement, Catra? Because it would give me some deliverance, if at least one of us would come out of this fucked-up mess with a happy life. If at least you were to be happy, it would be a relief to know. To know that we didn't…" She seemed to trail off, but all of it sounded more like she was trying to affirm herself. I didn't answer for long as we trotted, but finally I was able to manage a reply: "I'll be good."
Adora eyed me for a long time, until she stated: "I hope so. Really. Because that's all I have."
With that being said, she spurred her horse and rode forward to the top of the caravan, steering her mare back at Hordak's side.
And that had been it. I lied to her so that she might find relieve in

the thought that there would a happy *me* out there. It was so laughable. My desperation nearly made me throw up.

We arrived in Thēbais and at Hordak's seat of government around noon the next day. Most of the caravan had already disassembled, Hordak had vanished into his weird villa or temple or whatever the intertwined looking building before our eyes that he'd called home should be. Bow took care of his men and the horses of his domina and his own one.
And so, when I looked around uncomfortably, useless like the entire journey, Adora and I stood in the large yard. It was surrounded by a wall and looked rather like a parade ground, while around us, nobody really cared about our doing.
Neither of us knew what to say — how to say goodbye, or farewell. Finally, I managed to raise my hand to take hers, to perhaps shake it in an embarrassing handshake, but I just wanted to touch her one last time. Just a final touch, out of longing, to feel her warm, soft skin a last time. But Adora snapped my wrist and pushed my arm back.
I flinched upon the harsh grip, but the coldness in her voice was even more cutting. "Just to make this clear. I don't believe you. We'll both have to live with that, I guess. But you will never touch me again." She heaved a deep breath. "I actually would be happy if I never have to see you in my life. Good riddance, Catra."
Every inch of her a patrician of the most powerful family of the Roman Republic, she turned on her heels and walked away, through the doors of Hordak's villa, which closed with a final sound behind her. It took me a minute to realize that I still stood there with my arm and hand half-raised to touch the woman who had just walked out of my life.

The yard had cleared in the meantime, only a few guards and servants were still bustling about, and nobody paid me any special

attention at all. Nobody needed me here. Nobody needed me anywhere.
I wiped my face and pondered about what to do. The sun burnt down from a sky that looked somehow merciless blue now. All was dull, the few noises around me dimmed like it had been after I blew up the Egyptian fleet. I scratched my arm and couldn't think of anything else than the feeling that I'd made the biggest mistake in my life.

There was no way to ever make amends.

What should I do now? Looking around, I slowly realized there was nothing holding me back. I'd fulfilled my laughable duty to bring Adora here, and Cleo wanted me back in Buhen. So, Buhen again. Really?

But… maybe going to Buhen wouldn't be so bad?
After all, I'd liked it there. It was peaceful. Abandoned. Quiet.

Far away from Adora.

I decided without thinking about it, mounted on my horse again, and was on my way out the gate, when a whistle made me look around.
Bow waved at me to wait, and I reined the stallion, but didn't get off. What did he want?

As always he looked compassionate, his friendly face ghosted with a slightly worrying look. "Hey Catra. Before you leave… I just wanted to thank you. I'm sorry how all this has played out in the end, but I don't think this is your fault. Just wanted you to know that, because, well, you've been a good companion."
It was nice of him, sure. And as the always goodhearted and friendly nature that he was, it didn't really surprise me. But after the last days, and with Adora making it clear to cut the bonds between us, I hadn't expected it. It was kind of him, anyway.
"Thank you. I know that we… don't part in good conscience, but I appreciate the gesture."
He pulled into a weak and sad smile. "As I said, I don't think any

of this is your fault. And Adora knows it too. She's just… trying to deal with all of this and honestly, she isn't doing very well. But you know that already, don't you?" He tilted his head slightly, searching for an answer.
I nodded, and tears started to fill my eyes. He closed the distance between us and laid a hand on my thigh. "I know everything looks bleak now, Catra. Adora's often crying when she thinks I don't notice. But I see how blubbery she is when she comes back from wherever she hides then. And I know that you…," he trailed off, leaving the ending of his sentence open, but I gathered my courage and completed, "…love her too."
He squeezed my thigh lightly and made a reluctant smile. "You might be feeling hopeless. You might be thinking, 'We don't stand a chance.' But that should not stop you. There's always hope, and I don't think this is the end of your story. So, this is rather a 'See you around' than a 'Farewell' from me, okay? Believe in it, Catra. Believe in it." And with that he squeezed me a last time, and turned to go after his friend.

Adora

I stepped through the large entrance doors of Hordak's weird villa — or temple or whatever it should be — and was barely able to keep walking straight. It took every ounce of strength I could muster. Inside the vestibule, I was immediately welcomed by several servants. A few corridors led off from the large room, a handful of broad steps in front of me curled up to a gallery from which further corridors branched off. It looked functional and not pompous. One of the servants stepped in front of the others and greeted me friendly.
"Domina, we are honored to welcome you in the house of our master. We are here to serve you upon your every wish." She spread her arms as she bowed head and upper body, the others repeating the gesture. As she turned back up again, I realized that

the woman was tall, about my size, with unexpectedly bright hair and a slender figure. Her smile was warm and open, but I hadn't any sense for it at this moment. *Every wish*, I inwardly huffed, *if you only knew.*

I felt the little strength I'd left vanishing like mist melting under the morning sun, and replied weakly: "Thank you for the kind welcome. I would be grateful to get to know everyone, but for now, may I be brought to my room? The journey had been demanding, and I need a rest, before being introduced to the household later."
Her look was a bit quizzical, but she didn't question my demand and quickly waved the others away, then leading me through several hallways to a large room at the back of the building. I didn't notice anything, and when she opened a pair of door wings, it might or might not have been a stunning sight. Tangled as I was, I had no eye for all of it, and just asked to be left alone. As soon as the door closed behind the tall woman, I sank down on the overly large bed, put my head into a pillow, and started to cry.
For some time. I didn't really stop crying. But I actually fell asleep from exhaustion, the sheet already soaked with tears. Sleep took over and put me to an uneasy rest.

I woke up at dawn, so, still on the same day. And I still felt draining, from not enough tears being shed. To my surprise, I'd been left undisturbed, for which I was unbelievably grateful. Because the last days had been a torture.

And shoving Catra away had cost me everything.

I didn't believe her in the slightest. She was lying, of course she was. She wasn't going to be happy, I'd seen it in her eyes. Maybe I was a bit dense sometimes, but I got to know her good enough to recognize when she wasn't telling the truth. She'd been lying. But… if I could make her believe, that I was ultimately done with her, she could, perhaps, move on, sometime. It was an impotent, powerless try, but it was all I could do. And playing the little

charade took every bit of strength out of me and left me in nothing but despair.

Rolling around, I came to rest laying with my back on the bed, and stared at the ceiling. *At some point you will have to get up, Adora. This is not like you.*
Yeah. And I dreaded it. I didn't want to. Or I wanted to but had no clue what to do. It would be better if I just stayed in the bed for as long as possible, assuming that I would be somehow safe in my room. Even if everything here belonged to Hordak, and I had only Bow and his few men at my side, in this room, I should be safe from unneeded and unwanted disturbances.
You didn't even say goodbye or farewell to her. You just shoved her away.
Yes, and that had been exactly what I had to do. To make it easier for *her*, not for me. A weak hope, but it was all I had.

I spent the rest of the day and evening in my bed, paralyzed, thinking, not thinking. Whenever I wanted to stand up, my body simply betrayed me and did just nothing. It was as if it didn't belong to me anymore, refusing to work on my command. Ugh… I closed my eyes again, and some time later I fell into another unedifying sleep.

Night had already fallen, when someone knocked at my door. I made a weak noise that could be taken as approval, and the tall, light-haired woman from before peeked in.
"I was only worrying, domina. Is there anything I can do for you?"
I wanted to mumble that she could bring Catra back to me, but Catra was already dozens of miles away and would have found the attempt to kidnap her rather unpleasant. In the absence of a better answer, I asked: "Some fresh water would be nice. And fruits?"
She bowed shortly, closed the door behind her, and I was grateful for the loneliness. Only minutes later, she reappeared with a slave behind her, who carried a jug of water and a bowl of several fruits. He put it down on the table beside the window and retreated even before I could say anything. The woman was still standing there, unsteady, obviously waiting for more orders. But I

hadn’t it in me to talk to anyone now, and so I just waved her off, and she left the room without a word. I looked at the fruits. Why had I even asked for them? I didn’t know.

I fell into a hole as the days went by. I did not leave my room, barely spoke to anyone, ignored every approach to talk to me, and must've given the weirdest impression. I barely ate anything and felt just miserable.
The blonde woman tried to talk to me.
I ignored it.
Bow sat beside me at the edge of my bed.
I turned away, curled up and ignored him.

Every morning and evening, fresh fruits and soft, small, buttered buns were standing at the table, and occasionally I chewed some down in a haze, when hunger got too strong. Some time, when I just stared outside the window, into the garden and at the Nile behind, I realized that Bow was petting my hair and striking my arm and shoulders from behind. We’d seldom touched each other, but very, very back in mind, I appreciated the gesture. I just hadn’t it in me to react.

But wallowing in my depression only got me so far and eventually, on the fifth or sixth morning, I felt a little lighter and mustered enough strength to get out of my haze. I was still lying in my bed, still feeling too melancholic to bear the thought to get up and walk around, still too exhausted to meet other people.
What should I even do here?
The household seemed to be well organized, and what did I even know about leading it — if I wanted to. Hordak hadn’t shown up since our arrival, seemingly perfectly fine minding his own business, which was perfectly fine with me. From the few talks we had during the travel, I hadn’t gotten the impression that our

marriage was of any importance to him. He would obey to Cleopatra's wishes, because there must've been something he gained from it, but that seemed to be the end of his courtesy or interest.

And all of this cast another shadow: according to Roman law, the *Patria potestas* would be transferred from my father — or rather uncle Julius — to him. He would have all the legal right to exert control over me, and that was unsettling. Because in the Republic, the *pater familias* was bound by a hell of restrictions to not abuse his powers, and this system usually worked. Not perfectly, but in general, it worked. Here, in Egypt, it would be different, missing our normal network and system of social control, given the much larger autonomy and separation with which the single governors and regional rulers reigned.

I spun the thought further, because… we weren't in the Republic. This was Egypt. Would this mean we would be married under… Egyptian rules? Because according to Egyptian law and manners, the situation would be different. I should be regarded as an equal to my husband — Ugh, how that even sounded let me shiver — and each one of us should be able to gather their own possessions. For once, I was grateful for all the lectures and education I had to endure. Because it told me, that I wouldn't be subordinate to him. In contrast to Rome, there had always been examples of women taking positions of the highest powers in Egypt, even becoming Pharaoh. We had the *fucking* evidence right before our eyes. I snickered cynically upon the continued usage of the previously eschewed word. It eased me a bit, that something of *Catra's* company had become a part of my personality.
Or maybe she'd unlocked it.
I liked it. I liked that our acquaintance had had such an effect on me.

So, given history, the Egyptians had always preferred having a female leader with royal blood rather than a man without, and the Ptolemaic dynasty had put hell of an effort into maintaining this belief. This would also work on my behalf here, and would allow me much more freedom than in my current social status in the

Roman world. It would be at least be interesting to discuss it with Hordak, how he envisioned our relationship to work out. Because legally, I should have as much saying as he would.

Again, I rolled around on the bed, laying on my stomach and bobbing with my legs now. The exhaustion had worn off a little, and I pondered if I was ready to face other people again. My ruminating was interjected by my stomach grumbling. I took it as a sign to prop myself up and look around, to take in my room, my *new home*, that I occupied for days now, but hadn't really noticed still.

It was… nice, actually. A typical women's room for someone of my class, it seemed. It had a bay window overlooking a large garden that lay behind and around the back of the villa and stretched down to the Nile. Palms, fruit trees, bushes, manifold sorts of flowers, even cacti were neatly and deliberately arranged and made up a lovely place of lush and colorful green along the otherwise often sand covered areas around. I wondered who was responsible for that, because I didn't envision Hordak caring for something mundane and simply beautiful as a garden.
My room was equipped with well-crafted furnishings, made of the finest and hardest woods and every piece was richly decorated with figures and scenes from Ancient Egypt tales, it seemed. There was a table before a smoothly hammered bronze mirror, my overly large bed where I was still laying, two wardrobes, a vanity with a gold-plated — or golden? — bowl for water and a large lounger that stood before the bay window, next to the low table where the fruit bowls had been put on.

Eventually I managed to stand up and went to the door. When I opened it and looked out into the hallway, my gaze immediately fell on the bright haired woman who sat at a slant on a bench which stood on the other side. She seemed to have napped, but shot up on hearing me and called: "Domina. Have you rested well?"
"Uhm. Yeah, thank you?" I drew the word out like an idiot and immediately scolded myself for that. She glanced at me with wide eyes, seemingly expecting me to say something.

“Did you… did you wait here the whole time?”
She sounded light. “Yes. Of course. I am your personal servant and shall be around you any time, to help and be of guidance.”
“Oh… Okay, I guess.” Not that I wasn't used to the presence of slaves and servants, but the local way of *not* integrating them into society and a household was quite different from ours. It looked like that they were rather seen as mere tools than actual people. In Rome, such a stance would’ve been seen as unworthy and degrading — for the owner. I wouldn’t give up on that habit, stepped before her and held out my hands to grab hers. “I’m sorry. I mustn’t have given the best impression until now. We maybe should make a fresh start. I am Adora, and your name is…?”
Her perplexed expression pulled a smile out of me. “My name is P — Thelxinoë.”
It made me giggle shortly. “Huh, so you are named after one of the later muses. That is beautiful, Thelxinoë. Is your family from Greece?”
She nodded eagerly. “Yes. My parents are nobles from one of the smaller Greek city states. You won’t even know the name. They had many children, and I had the luck to be put into the services of master Hordak, when we visited Cleopatra in Alexandria two years ago. It has been a very interesting time for me. And now I am serving you, domina.” [102]

There seemed to be a touch of homesickness in her words, just barely audible. She probably missed her family, but as one of many girls in her parent's household, they must have been happy to put her into the service of a powerful governor of an ally. Immediately, I felt compassion with her. Our fate wasn’t so different.
She seemed nice, and I felt it would be a good idea to have her as a friend here. “I am sure we will get along well, Thelxinoë. Where… I mean, where should we start?”
She looked a bit irritated, because maybe my pronunciation of the unusual Greek name wasn’t the best, and so I asked. “Is there something?”
She lightly bowed her head. “If you… If you don’t mind, domina, I

am mostly called Perfuma. Nobody calls me any other way." I looked puzzled because of this weird name, and she quickly elaborated on it. "That is, because I'm taking care of creating ointments and scented waters from the herbs and flowers of our garden. A lot of women in the household and beyond tend to use them."
Her happy yet slightly apologizing rambling made me smile. "Perfuma, hmm? That's even more fitting, I assume. So, Perfuma it is. Tell me, are there any plans for me, are there… any obligations to fulfill?"
Calling her look disconcerted would've been an understatement. "You are the mistress, domina. It is not upon us to tell you how to organize your day. It is rather…" she hesitated, but I nodded encouraging, "…the other way around?"

That was unexpected, but, weirdly enough, not unwelcomed. At least it freed me from any unwanted gatherings.
"I would like to get the house and area to know. And I would love to get to know the people who keep everything going here, maybe?"
Perfuma brightened. "Of course, domina. How about if I show you around first? Maybe we start with the household, then over to the workshops and yard, and finish with the garden? It's clearly my favorite place to be. I'm putting all my free time in it."
I was a bit overwhelmed by her friendliness. But a visit to the garden sounded not so bad, so I simply nodded, and she gratefully took the hint and gestured to me to follow her.
The bench where she'd waited drew my attention again. I pointed at it and asked: "How long have you been waiting there?"
She frowned, but replied: "Only for an hour. Of course not the whole night. There is another servant for that."
That didn't make me happier, it rather put a frown on my face. "So, you're saying that somebody always sits here and waits for me to… peek out?"
Perfuma vigorously shook her head: "No! I mean… I would never… uhm." Her face looked funny as she tried to compose herself. "Yes, domina. We wait for you."

“Hmm… and who ordered this?”
“Master Hordak of course.”

That was just ridiculous. To let people waste their time by waiting for me. What a stupid order. “I see. Let me… think loudly. What, if I would order something… different, because I’m uncomfortable with having someone lurking before my door the entire day,” I said with a lightly mocking voice.
“You are my domina, domina. Your wish is my command,” she replied with a smile, and bowed gracefully with extended arms, as she had when greeting me the first day.
“Oh, good,” I clapped in my hands for joy. “So, would you like to show me where your room is? So that I can find my way when I want something and when you aren’t sitting before my door?”
Her look was funnily puzzled. “I… I don’t understand.”
I snickered. Of course, she didn’t. “Show me how I can find you when I need you. Because you won’t waste your time with sitting before my room. I won’t accept it.”
She still didn’t really get it, but I decided that she would be able to get over it soon, so I just grabbed her right arm, hooked myself up and nudged her forward. “How about you show me around, and we look for your room at the end?”

The villa-temple Hordak called his home was weirdly advanced and equipped with manifold inventions. I appreciated some of them, found others strange, and some of them even frightening. There was a system of pipes running through the whole building and providing fresh water. They not only went into the several baths the building hosted, but also into the kitchen and a few normal rooms, even in the upper floors.[103] Perfuma explained its usage to me, and I quickly got how useful it was. “You can drink it,” she motioned. “It is filtered through several stages before it goes into our storage.” So I tried and scooped a bit of water that run out of one of the omnipresent fountains, and it was surprisingly fresh and cool. Perfuma looked at me expectantly, and I nodded in reply. That was a real welcomed surprise. Then there were some eerie mechanical apparatus standing around in some hallways which usage I couldn’t decipher in the slightest, and

even Perfuma was of no help. “We have no idea for what most of them are. But we don’t question his ideas, domina. That is not upon us,” she just said, and walked further. In the atrium, which lay just down a hallway from my room, a fountain joyfully gushed and sprinkled mist around. It provided the atrium with a pleasant chill air, and made it a delight to sit there, shielded from the heat of the day. Shortly, we just listened to the splashing water and took in the humid air, until a newly awakening restlessness drove me further.

Perfuma led me a few steps down into the garden, and I found myself engulfed in a riot of colors, buzzing and fragrances. Paths snaked through neatly trimmed bushes and palm trees, well-placed rocks and small ponds. A gurgling little stream seemed to flow from pond to pond, making its way down the different terraces. The entire atmosphere invited visitors to take a leisurely stroll and admire the meticulous landscaping. Absolutely not expecting such a beautiful and curated oasis, I just followed Perfuma, who led me forward, explaining something here and there I didn't really notice.
Each section of the garden featured a different set of flora, creating a diverse tapestry of colors, shapes, and textures. The flower beds were filled with a variety of blossoming plants, flowers in all colors, small olive and fig trees with their twisted branches and I found even more plants with juicy fruits from all over the Mediterranean world.[104]

As we walked further between the palms, a weird building came into sight. The basic structure was made of wood, with an alike roof, but the beams didn’t cover everything. Instead, they made only a frame, and I could see through the whole structure, like it was just some kind of open barn. But it wasn’t open, because there was a slightly milky substance clouding the view through it. And then I realized… “It is glass. This is a house made of glass? Unbelievable. But how?”
Perfuma snickered, obviously happy about having spared this surprise for the end of today’s tour. “He calls it window glass. I don’t understand the details, and I wouldn’t mind asking, but it

took him some time to invent a process to make flat panes of glass. And this," she gestured at the building, "is my glass house. It keeps the moisture in and the temperature up even during winter time, so my plants can grow the whole year and survive even cold days and, foremost, winds."
I circled the edifice.
Never had I seen so much glass in such a weird form before. Of course, I knew what glass was. It was produced in good quantities all over the Republic, but our main source for raw glass was… Egypt. Here, in the Wadi-an-Natrun, westwards of the Nile delta, large natural deposits of natron were mined and transported to the smelting plants around Alexandria to be refined. From there, the entire Mediterranean was supplied with raw glass. Manufactures all over the Republic used it to make bottles for perfumes and scented waters, plates, vases, and other tableware out of it. But all this glass was colored, mostly in a shady green or a sandy tone, and one couldn't look through at all. Our workshops had tried for more colorless and see-through-glass since some time, as far as I knew, but this… this was something else. I never saw planes of glass in such a quantity and size.

She snickered upon my obvious awe. "Honestly, I think this was just a mistake of the master to build. He said something about making 'lenses', but I didn't get that. Then he used the planes of glass he'd already made to build this, made some experiments, and when he didn't need it anymore, he just left it to me to use it."
She shrugged her shoulders. After a few more minutes, we walked back to the villa, and I recognized that some of the windows that overlooked the garden had also glass planes in them. It was an unusual sight. We'd only started to discover the possibilities to form glass into something else than bottles and such, but I'd never seen planes made of it so clear and so—
"*Transparent* is the word you're searching for, domina," Perfuma snickered again. She must have seen my bewilderment. "I was amazed by it, too, when I saw it the first time. Master Hordak is a great inventor. He taught the word to me."

Back in the villa, Perfuma guided me to the triclinium.[105] "You have to eat something, domina. I haven't seen you eat anything yet." As if he was approving her words, my stomach rumbled lowly, and I sheepishly looked back at her. "I assume you have a point. Show me the kitchen, it would be sufficient if I can catch something there."
Again, her eyes pulled wide. "But… in the kitchen, domina! That is… where the servants eat. It is below your dignitas."
"It is not below my dignitas", I cut in. "I'm sure, your kitchen has a fine stool and some nice snacks for me, and it will be fine. And I think we should cut the 'domina' as well. My name is Adora."
My casual approach made her clearly uncomfortable, but after all, I was just the domina here, and I didn't want to be treated as some kind of Pharaoh. This land already had one, I inwardly scoffed.
Perfuma glanced reluctantly at me: "Well, uhm… I suppose, if you… if you insist on it?"
"I do," I replied and asked again, "The kitchen?"

The sun had already started to set when I found Bow, who just came back from a training session with his contuberniae. I felt a little guilty about cutting him off for days, and wanted to apologize properly. I invited him to my room, and tried to find the right words, but instead, I just stood awkwardly around and rubbed my neck.
"How did your training go?" I finally asked. Bow frowned a little, but then he smiled and replied: "Very well. I mean, it's ridiculously hot outside and marching for 4 hours midday is torturing, but we really need the training, so what the heck." He shrugged his shoulders.
"That's… good." What a clever reply.
He threw me a piercing look. "Come on, Adora. What is really on your mind?"

I knew I was making a fool out of myself, but I stuttered though: "I am… It was… I'm sorry for—"
"Hiding in your room because of heartbreak?" he cut in, and it sounded amicable, understanding, but I was so shocked that I called: "What? No! Who says that?"
He snickered. "You don't need to fool me, Adora. I was in the throne room as well. And I have eyes. So, of course, I know." He stepped into my space and hugged me. I was tense at first, but after a moment, I returned the gesture.
"How do you feel now?", Bow asked after we parted again.
I tried a weak smile. "Like… shit?" My voice pitched high and he chuckled. "Huh, a forbidden word from you, Adora? I'm… impressed, actually. I didn't expect such a phrasing from you in my lifetime. She got you for real, didn't she?"

I sighed and slumped down on my bed. And I was too tired to deny it anymore. But I also couldn't speak it out loud. So I just nodded.
He tilted his head lightly. "You know, whatever you think, it's the same for her. I saw it."
It wasn't really surprising, rather a gentle affirmation. "Did you… speak about what I said to her?" I asked, too weak to be actually excited.
He shook his head. "No. But she knows that you still love her. She does it too, Adora."
That did not feel right anyway. "Hah… love. I know she thinks she does. But if she did, she would have acted differently. That wasn't love, it was… that was the action of someone closest to himself."

Bow frowned at me with a worried face. "Don't tell yourself that, Adora. She was scared and didn't react properly, yes, but actions out of the moment are not what we are. Cleopatra is… some kind of scary, actually. She holds all the power, even over Catra, and that can't be forgotten by both of them, regardless of their relationship. You saw yourself how she forced Catra's hand. This has not been her true self."
"Do I know, Bow? I don't know what I really know. Everything is blurred. And I think that she… she actually chose her sister over me. That's what I know."

He spread his arms and shrugged. “Yes, she did, maybe. And I think she regrets it.”
Ugh. Yeah, perhaps she regrets it. And? Does this change anything? No, it doesn’t. “Bow, I appreciate your attempt to lift me up. But does this lead to somewhere? Because even if, nonono, hear me out”, I called when he opened his mouth to interject. “Even if she regrets it, and would decide differently the next time, there is nothing we can do about this,” and I gestured wildly around me, and he clearly got the point. “I’m still trapped in the same damn cage and this leads us exactly nowhere. So, this is better than the alternative.”
Bow stared at me and after a long, long time, he shook his head. “You don't even believe that yourself, Adora.” Then he turned around and left the room without another word.

After he'd left my room, I still lay in the bed, looking out of the window and over the garden. He was right. I didn’t. But I had nothing else to hold on to.
Sunset was well underway, the orange disc touching the horizon now, bathing the landscape outside in a golden glow which mirrored in alike colors in my room. It was most beautiful, but my gaze was empty and without focus. I startled, when suddenly Perfuma lay a hand on my shoulder. I hadn’t even noticed that she was here. Now she gently squeezed it, and it went through my troubled mind, that she hadn’t done that ever before. Touching a domina without her explicit permission could have consequences, even serious ones. But she did it nonetheless. It was obviously a sign that she trusted me.
“Do you want to be alone, domina? I’ll surely leave, but perhaps, if you want to, I can just stay at your side. Please forgive me, but I don't like the thought of leaving you alone now. You’re looking like you could need someone here.”
I squeezed my eyes shut to hide my tears, but it didn’t work very well. When I did not answer for a while, she finally settled down on the bed beside, but said nothing.

When she put an arm around my shoulder, her embrace was unexpected, like her touch before. But I felt soothed, and without

hesitation, I curled into her arms, put my head against her side. It felt good, to have someone's warmth. Quietly, I started to sob into her gown. I did not register it when she petted my head, and how I wrapped my arms around her waits, clinging to her. “It is alright, Adora,” she muttered.
For a long tome, I cried into her collarbone, and she continued striking my back gently, while she spoke with a soft tone: “You miss her. You can. Allow it. Don't let your last words destroy all the good memories of her. Take your time. That is okay.”
Her calm words, her touch, it was… pacifying, to let my emotions spill out. But it was also an embarrassment, to show myself so vulnerable and weak. That wasn’t how a patrician should behave. I knew that some of my high-born fellows relied too much on their servants and slaves, made them their friends, sometimes lovers even. I had always found that completely inappropriate, overreaching, because it felt one-sided. Servants couldn’t really refuse the affection if they wanted to. I would’ve felt like a predator.

But here, Perfuma came on her own and without needing to do so, even crossing a boundary set by habit and society, and it felt good. She just stayed silent and went on to pet me while evening turned into night outside. The chirps of crickets and other wildlife were the only noises, aside from a few sobs coming out from me. At some point I had cried myself out, but Perfuma still held me. I did nothing to end it. Just having someone with me, not being alone, made everything seem a little more bearable. We didn't speak, but I felt a little more comforted now, and it was not so cold and sinister as before.

The morning after, I joined Hordak for breakfast. He hadn’t demanded it, but after not speaking or seeing him for at least several days, it felt like a move making sense or would be at least

appreciated. After all, we would need to get along in whatever way we thought fitting for us. And it wasn't like that he behaved ill-mannered or awful to me. If anything, I had been politely ignored, sidelined.
"Good morning, Hordak." Using his epithet still felt weird. But he had suggested it himself, and so I wanted to stick to it.
"Good morning, Adora. Have you rested well?" His question was polite, but it lacked a deeper concern.
"Everything is well and to my satisfaction, thank you," I gracefully replied.
"Very well." He took a sip of his grain beer that was the main drink all over Egypt, especially in the morning. It had barely any alcohol, but was considered healthier than just drinking water in most cases. "I am overlooking the works in Thēbais again, and won't be around until late. I hope you find some amenities to keep you occupied." He hadn't made any suggestions by himself so far, and I wondered if it was out of lack of interest or because he didn't want to dictate anything to me.
"Couldn't I… accompany you?" I asked, rather out of curiosity, than with an actual idea behind it.
Putting down the mug, he wiped his mouth clean with a towel and replied cordially: "I am afraid not. The building sites are dangerous, and I can't have you harmed or worse. My queen wouldn't forgive me, and your uncle—" He cut himself short, but I already knew. It wasn't that he really feared them, but he wanted to avoid any possible fallout. "He would not be pleased, to say the least. I am sorry, but I cannot let you wander around there."

I frowned. Everyone had been nice to me so far. Nothing really spoke 'Prison!' loudly. But beside the occasional strolls with Perfuma or Bow, it was starting to get boring, and I felt trapped more and more.
And I didn't know how to deal with that. Having no real duties was something new to me, and it almost made me miss the strict guidance of my stepmother and my father, who at least had provided a daily timetable for me to follow. With so much free time at my hand, and without any duties, I felt utter useless. The adventures of the last months had been new and wild, and they

brought up a side of me that I now understood had always been there, but which I didn't really notice. With all this newfound knowledge, it was even harder to behave like a well-mannered, idle patrician noblewoman. And now? I had nothing to do, and that felt nearly as bad as being imprisoned, if I was honest. Not really know how to respond, I nodded, and we parted ways for the day.

That it was — in fact — a prison, I discovered two days later. I was strolling around with Perfuma and decided that it was time to have a look at the surroundings of Hordak's seat of government. After all, there was a city to discover outside, and I could do it on my own.

Only that I could not.

The odd fusion between a temple and an oversized villa rustica served as his bureau of government. It was located at the front parts beside the main gate into the vast yard. The living spaces were at the back part, where his, my and all the other personal rooms were housed. Between the two parts lay the yard, that was used for exercises and larger gatherings in the open. Hordak seldom used it, because he was out at the building sites most of the time, but his troops as well as Bow's two contuberniae trained there regularly. Today, the soldiers were away, and only the usual people who went about their business could be seen.

When Perfuma and I approached the main gate of the outer wall, a guard appeared and stopped us. I glanced at the armed man with a quizzical look. His Greek wasn't very good, but good enough to understand. "Apologies domina. You not allowed leaving the grounds."
"On whose behest?" I asked, but knew the answer already.
He looked a bit uneasy. "The master ordered it."
I wasn't really surprised. I was rather annoyed. What did he think of me? That I wasn't capable of walking around in an Egyptian city? In company? Or that I would run away? I didn't want to put up an argument with a guard who only followed his orders, and so

I backed up, Perfuma in tow, and tried to hide my anger as good as I could.

And a two days later, a discussion occurred that would trigger events to come. We ate dinner together, one of the few occasions we did so. But he formally invited me, and of course I'd said yes. I assumed he wanted to talk about the next steps, but I wasn't prepared, when he dropped the words while letting them sound so naturally and minor that I needed some time to catch them. There were only the two of us, beside the usual servants that stood silently in the background of the triclinium. We lay across each other on the klinai, and were taking our meal together.
He'd spoken briefly about some of his works and was saying "I'm content with the progress of the construction works. At least, the new lifting crane is doing very well, and it increased speed. That is satisfactory."
I nodded, but didn't really pay attention. Instead, I poked around in my food. He must've noticed my mental absence because he shortly stopped speaking, then put up another, more serious tone.

"Adora, the reason why I asked you to join me is because I think we should discuss the matter of our relationship being consummated. If we are supposed to live up to the intentions of it, we should probably talk about this."
Again I just nodded eagerly, because the content of what he said hadn't registered, which made him continue: "Good. So, do you have any suggestions as to how we should address the matter, if you don't mind me asking so frankly? I am sure that you as a woman will have certain ideas about this."

Now it registered.

I was so startled when it did that I dropped a small bowl of olives I held in my hand. It scattered at the marble floor with a loud clank, and the following silence was all the more embarrassing.
"Uhm… sorry." I blushed furiously, but not because of the bowl. Did he really talk about what I thought he talked about? But… that just couldn't be.

“Have I upset you?” Hordak asked politely, while a servant hurried by, started to clean up the olives and pieces of the bowl that scattered around and backed up quickly after finishing. “I assumed that you were aware of the more delicate matters this union would bring with.”
Delicate matters? Oh bona dea, he was really talking about having *intercourse*, was he?
“Erm… my apologizes. I was just… surprised, yes, surprised. I didn’t… assume that this would be a topic to discuss before our… marriage.” I had to pull out every single word with special effort, and it was *hard*.

He didn’t get that I was panting too fast and too hard. “Well, I thought it was clear that we would have to put some endeavors into the actual consummation of our bond. The point of time seemed secondary to me.” His tone was neutral and his face was all about business, but I felt so run over and hadn’t expected this topic to come up even before the formal marriage. Or ever.
Just as before, it quickly dawned on me that I had been naive. A single question formed in my mind and I voiced it: “If you allow me the open question, but… why did you agree to this… union? It doesn't seem that you are very interested in our relationship, or even your own Pharaoh's matters. If you don't mind, of course. I’m just… curious.” It was perhaps a little bold and offensive to ask it like that, but on the other hand, he didn't strike me as caring about it.
His gaze wandered over me and took measure, a more on a par one than before, it seemed. “You aren't wrong.” He took a moment to wipe his mouth and weigh his answer. “I'm planning ahead. Whoever is king of this land, the governors are the ones to rule. I am building more than a new city here. I will improve our way of life, beyond the mundane struggles of her family. Or yours, by the way, and meaning no offense.”
“Oh, none taken,” I managed, “I find your intentions interesting, and they clearly occupy you. But again, why this marriage then?”
He'd taken a sip and put down his cup, folded his hands into each other before his chin and leaned into it. “My works will need time to show their full greatness. This bond will guarantee me

immunity from whoever reigns over Egypt. Whatever the Pharaoh thinks, Rome is the power to rule the Mediterranean for the coming decades. Either the Pharaoh will be my ally, or your Res Publica will, or even both. In any way, I will be safe, as will our descendants, to continue these works."

Descendants?

The word hit me like a slap, and my eyes pulled wide. "And what… what has come to your mind about this… matter?" I warily asked.
Hordak tilted his head and furrowed his thin eyebrows. "It has certainly not escaped your attention that more than just a formal coexistence is expected of us, or has it?" In my daze I made something like a slow nod, because actually I hadn't thought so far beside some shady, not articulated or well-formed fragments back in my nightmares.
He continued. "Therefore, and to consummate our bond even according to Roman law, we will have to think about our progeny as early as possible."
I screamed inside.

Progeny.

I wanted to run away, but my body was just frozen. "Progeny," I creaked.

He furrowed an eyebrow. "Of course. Your father and your uncle intended a cum manu marriage[106], and you are certainly aware what this means regarding your moral values." He raised his hands in a defensive gesture. "I am of course not intending to put you under my rule. The Roman concept of patrias potestas seems to lack a certain — how to put it — adequate balance, yes, regarding your gender, won't you say so? A civilized society like ours clearly sees us as equals. I'm sure you agree with that."

It was sort of nice to have these particular assumptions about the expected nature of our marriage confirmed, and his voice sounded honest. But I was completely distracted by what he said earlier.

Progeny. Descendants. The usage of my very body to bear his children.
"I am… grateful for this... progressive view of yours," I croaked, "I appreciate it. But, if you don't mind, what do you exactly mean with progeny?"
I was being an idiot. I knew what it meant. It was only that I could not accept the actual meaning. Because I was an idiot.
He glanced over from his klinē and eyed me, finally replying: "As I said, we need to talk about this. Even if I won't stick to these… archaic manners of your society, a consummated marriage that results in children is expected in both our cultures. And of course, I want to hand over my heritage to children of my own lineage. Do you not have the same desire?" He took another sip, taking this completely serious and casual in a way only a man could do.

This was getting too far. I thought I could handle it, but I couldn't. The idea alone of having, *ugh*, intercourse with him made me cringe, and I… I needed… I needed… air. "Sure. My apologies, I need to use the bathroom," I muttered and went for the mentioned. I stumbled, or rather ran through the hallway, and closed the door behind me. The bath was large and empty, only the low gushing of the ever running water at the fountain was audible. A large marble bowl standing on a table was supplied with it. I scooped some water into my face and tried to calm down my breathing. Still, my heart hammered and the thought of having… sex with him tortured my mind. To be touched by his skinny fingers, and look at him while he'd be working over me…

By the gracious bona dea. How could I have imagined that I was able to deal with it?

Standing in the bathroom, and with my worldview slowly crumbling, I realized that I'd been a pathetic idiot. Because this could not work out. I wasn't attracted to him in any way, and would never be. Laughing at my reflection in the water in the bowl, I realized, that I wasn't attracted to any men. And never had been. Never would be. I had to meet Catra - *sleep with damned Catra* - before realizing that.

And then I also realized, that I would never allow him to touch me in this certain way.
I would never.
I had tried to tag along, to fulfill the wishes and demands of my father and of uncle Gaius as pater familias.

I had tried. Only that I could not.

I
Could.
Not.

Shivers ran down my spine. My whole body was shaking. My reflection too. They would never let me get away with this kind of defection.
Never.

I watched the water running down the marble gully that led into the bowl. From there, it ran further through a notch and a pipe that led down the ground to vanish there. It was an interesting construction. Simple, elegant, efficient, without much fuss, and it provided the bathroom with the needed fresh water to wash and clean yourself at any time without the need of a servant or slave. I actually liked many of Hordak's inventions. He was good at it, and it took all his energy and time. Dealing with me was just some kind of necessity that had been imposed onto him. And he wanted descendants to carry on his name and heritage. I realized that I hadn't even for a moment really pictured myself with that. Not yet, not with him, maybe never.
But if I got pregnant from… ugh… having sex with this man, that would be it. I would be bound to him. To this place.
I would spend the next 20 years of my life raising children and finally, when I was old and wrinkled, sitting on a porch, having spent the last ten years trying to convince myself it was worth it, I might just think back to that crazy woman from my youth who had been on to something. That another life, wild and risky as it may be, could have offered the one thing that I could never have here: freedom.[107]

And that was the point when I realized: I neither wanted nor would deal with this. I could not, and I would not. I gritted my teeth, when realizing what that would mean: Freedom was not given.

It was taken.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"Sand and dust and two millennia"** and will be published on Friday, August 27, 2021.

[100] This is a part of a sentence from "Wicked Games" , chapter 5. ↕

[101] Phoinix or phoinikos is the Greek name for the date palm, and the term was used widespread in the ancient world. The "Phoenix dactylifera" originated in semi-arid regions like Mesopotamia or Egypt but near high groundwater levels, so rivers like the Nile or the Tigris-Euphrates river system. It was also a popular garden plant in Roman peristyle gardens. We know this from frescoes from Pompeii and others found in Italy. ↕

[102] Picture it in the context of this time: serving in the household of a member of the gens Julia could only be seen as a superb way of living, if you weren't rich or powerful in your own right. Beside your daily duties, you wouldn't have to worry about anything regarding your livelihood (beside the occasional mass murdering amongst the nobles, rich and powerful, of course, that would finally wipe out the old patrician families). Given the relatively small size of the upper class in comparison with all others, such a way of life was considered desirable. Perfuma is a servant, but not a slave. In Rome, she would be a citizen, serving in the household of the ruling family, be treated as a member of it and live a good life. ↕

[103] Despite the vast system of aqueducts that provided the city of Rome with large amounts of fresh water, direct water supply for private households via lead pipes only became a

thing around the time of the first principate (Octavian) and the subsequent imperial time, when Rome became the largest and most densely city in the world and new built insulae (apartment buildings and city blocks) with up to ten stories were built. We don't know the exact time of their emergence, but it can be assumed from the rise of the value of lead in sediments and the remains of bodies. ↥

[104] Please, keep in mind, that the climate of the Mediterranean world around that era was more humid and rainier than it is today. Especially, Northern Africa had a lot more rain and hosted more forests than today. It was a regional phenomenon, lasting from around 300 BCE to 400 CE, and is literally called "Roman Climatic Optimum" in some scientific researches. It is also believed that this special climate partially contributed to the rise and fall of the Roman Empire. It's also believed, that wide-ranging deforestation due to human activities contributed to the change of weather patterns at the end of it, but natural cycles could also play a role. ↥

[105] Triclinium ~ the formal dining room of every Roman Villa, that held the three Klinēs, couches, forming a U-shape and that were used to accommodate up to three guests each for dinner. The Roman room derived his name from the Greek word. ↥

[106] Cum manu - manus marriage, the form of marriage where the wife was placed under the control of the husband, but to a lesser extent than under patrias potestas. The husband lacked e.g. the legal right of life and death or sale over his wife, even if she wasn't able to gain her own property / possessions. Only with a manus marriage, the woman could be considered a materfamilias. Widowed or divorced, the woman became a sui iuris, "of her own right", and this term corresponds to the Greek 'αὐτόνομος', from which the English word *autonomy* is derived. ↥

[107] This paragraph is a wild modification of its origin in "She's a pirate", Chapter 4. ↥

Sand and dust and two millennia

Chapter Summary

> No one will lay a hand on me. This body and mind belong to me. To me only.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Nile, Egypt - June & July 47 BCE

Adora

No one will lay a hand on me. This body and mind belong to me. To me only.

The thought alone shouldn't have been such a great thing. No reasonable paterfamilias actually laid hand on his wife. Maybe a few slaps for his children, as a thoughtful mean of education, where even today the usage of a whip wasn't so uncommon. But this was different. This was taking control. Deep down in me, something had shifted, my attitude towards what I've been taught for more than 20 years, and my gut understood it without my mind to actually having processed it. So, when a plan formed in me at the glimpse of an eye, I decided to trust myself with it.

The decision was much easier than its realization though. I had to make various preparations for it to be executed, and it would take weeks to do so. I didn't want to make a overhasty step.

At first, I asked Perfuma if she could find me a teacher to lecture me in Demotic, the foremost spoken language of rural Egypt, outside the centers of the Ptolemaic and Hellenistic world, where Greek was more common.[108] The very next day, she introduced

me to my teacher, a short man with a bulging stomach and a weird, tousled hairstyle named Xanthos[109]. He had a gruffy attitude, but after I voiced my request, he quickly started to teach me the most important words and some phrases like "Thank you", "Can you help me?" or “Where do I find?”, before we went over to some more difficult sentences and grammar of the simplest forms. I explained my interest with my upcoming duties and liabilities regarding my role as materfamilias, which would also include some ceremonial and overseeing roles for the rural population and clients of Hordak’s lands. To my surprise, nobody questioned my demands. When I arranged two hours of class every day, Xanthos looked a bit puzzled at first, but then he smirked smugly and handed over some scrolls for me to learn until tomorrow. I glanced at the lot of words, back at him, then back at the scrolls and took up the challenge. Learning was something I could do - and it was the easy part of my preparations.

Next I resumed my routines with Bow again. Besides that it was important for my preparations, I'd neglected them for too long anyway, and so the next weeks were going to be excruciating. We went through all the usual exercises from earlier, but I had to take shortcuts, use lighter weights and smaller ropes, and ran fewer distances in the beginning. Only my targeting with bow and arrow was still as good as always, as I was pleased to discover.
On the third day, my thighs burned, my back ached, and my arms were sore. It was hell and I hated every second of training. On the fifth day, I wasn’t able to get out of my bed without Perfuma’s help. She took half an hour to massage my sore muscles and to get them loose and warm enough for me to actually stand up on my own. Her hands felt good on my back and arms. But when the blonde woman made a nearly raunchy comment about how good my abs and back were in shape while kneading them, I was really grateful that I faced the pillow. She didn't need to see my red cheeks.
A week later, every fiber of my body still hurt. But it was a welcomed pain, because I also felt how quickly my body adapted to the old habits of a regular training. I did morning runs around the yard within the walls, but placed our fighting exercises into

the garden between the palms and trees where nobody could see us. We trained with bow and arrow as well as with daggers at nightly hours. And I secretly practiced making arrows on my own with a small carving knife and some straight branches I gathered from the stock. It took me a while to get to know how to properly sharpen a shaft, putting an arrowhead on it and to equip it with fletchings. But after I discovered some tricks from watching Bow and his men, I made some better tools to work on them, and I found it actually a pleasant work to do and used some time to perfect my skills.

The more I got back into my old shape and the nearer the moment of truth came, the less I mulled about Catra. I neither forgot nor stopped longing for her. It was just that I didn't think about her all day, because I had stuff to do. I was… occupied, distracted enough, and that was actually pleasing. She was still lingering in the back of my mind, though, but not as omnipresent as before.

My surrounding took my newfound verve with delight. A few weeks after I made my decision, I caught Bow when we finished our training. "Bow, I need a favor from you," I simply said and dragged him into the shadow of a palm where we weren't even visible from the house. It was unnecessary, because even if someone saw us standing together, it would mean nothing to anyone because it was normal. This was just me being weird, because I was so zealous and giddy.
"A favor?" he smiled. "Of course. Why the… secrecy?"
"Because it's a huge one. And from Perfuma too, actually, but she mustn't know about my plan. I don't want her to be involved more than absolutely necessary."
He eyed me, scrutinizing. "Adora, I knew you were up to something, but now you're giving me goosebumps. What's going on with you."
"Oh, I'll tell you, and then you will have goosebumps, I promise," I humorlessly huffed. And I hadn't promised him too much, when I did. Even I could judge it from the way he gasped.

Another week of training and quiet preparations went by, and not to my surprise, Hordak didn't catch anything. I was still not too secretly guarded and still not being allowed to leave the walled area of his premises. But inside, I was free to go wherever I wanted, and I made use of it. Step by step I put together what I needed and four weeks after the triggering conversation with Hordak, I felt somehow ready.
When I had gone back to our meal that day, I was at least composed enough to bring our conversation to a somewhat cordial and non-committal ending. I promised to think about the matter of consummating our bond and give him an answer at the next opportunity. He seemed to be content enough with that, assuming that he had all the time in the world, and he didn't pick up on it again at the next dinner. The topic just loomed in the background for the following days, like the growing shadows upon sunset.

The final straw for my decision had been his revelation that Cleopatra and Caesar had left Alexandria for a tour along the Nile through all parts of Egypt — which would inevitably lead them to Thēbais within time. His words were that "we should expect them in no less than a month, maybe six weeks from now," then.

That wasn't what was most surprising. There were rumors. They crept amongst the servants and slaves and reached upwards the food chain like they always did. Nothing was official, no announcement being made. The whispers spoke for themselves. They told about Cleopatra, Pharaoh of Egypt, being pregnant. Pregnant witch a child from no other man than my uncle, Gaius Julius Caesar himself.

He was known for his fondness for women beyond his marriage, but I shook my head about that foolishness of him, if it was true. Because that… that was near madness, a grave mistake, and it would cause a tremendous amount of bad blood back in Rome.

For sure, Cleopatra was a desirable young woman, of course, and she would make up an intelligent and powerful ally in the future, clever like she was. But she was no Roman or someone even close enough to us. She would always be seen as one of these obscure and voluptuous Orientals - even given her Hellenic origin - and therefore being unable to fit into our most important customs and manners, that made up the cornerstones of our Republic. All the more because she was ambitious and fiercely independet, traits that would be seen as a menace by every single patrician of the old families. The women would hate her because she gave birth to Caesar's heir, and the men because of her power as a ruler. All of them would see her as a menace to their ways, even those on Caesar's side. They would not let him get away with it so easily and would never accept a male child of hers as his rightful heir.
This was madness. If Cleopatra was indeed pregnant with Caesar's child, it would be a turning point in history, one that would shape the future of Rome and Egypt for years to come.

But it fitted into the whole picture of both of them, not really caring about the opinions and objections of others.
And it was a strong reminder: their voyage along the Nile wasn’t only a pleasure trip.

They were coming for me also. For my marriage. If Cleopatra was willing of getting into bed with Gaius herself, she would not stop to put me into a similar fate. My time was running out. I had to take action.

I was ready. Four weeks after our crucial talk, and Caesar and Cleopatra presumably arriving within the coming days, I was ready. I had to be. My condition was almost back to the way it used to be, and my body felt better than in a long time.

Putting on the caligae[110] was the last step of getting into my new outfit. I wore the typical red tunica under the armor, and had put all my hair under the galea, so nothing of it was visible, which I checked at least five times. A good part of my face was covered by the strings and jaw protection of it also, making me illegible. A legionary was not an individual anyway. He was part of his unit, interchangeable and yet irreplaceable for the existence and success of the phalanx. At my side, the gladius[111] hung down from the cingulum[112.] It was never on the left, as Bow repeatedly impressed on me, because of the consistency of the phalanx. When he suggested that I might cut off my hair, I politely denied with "Like hell I am," and he rolled his eyes, but smiled. I would rather fight my way out than to cut it, and I had the helmet to hide it. It just had to be enough for that one day. Luckily, the contubernia didn't use the scutum[113] for the light training marches they went on, so I hadn't to deal with this heavy piece. I put the backpack on, and that was that.

"You're looking like being ready for a war, Adora," he said upon my sight, and hid his concern behind the light tone. The evening before, Bow had mixed a strong laxative under the meal of one of his soldiers, putting him out of action for today. He chose a man of my size and while I clearly wasn't as strong and muscular as him, the clothing, armor and helmet covered all the important parts. In their equipment, all legionaries looked alike, and their eyes were always looking forward. So it wasn't hard to take his place for the unsuspecting eye. None of Hordak's guards would call the difference, and Bow's men were soldiers, trained to follow orders.
He called his mates onto the yard for assembling. I had put down the galea as far as possible and laced the side protectors, while Bow issued his commands and paced back and forth in front of our two lines, demanding everyone's attention.
Bow instructed his longest serving soldier to lead today's march to Hermonthis, a few kilometers up the Nile and back. It was meant as routine exercise to keep them fit, without overexertion or any weapons training. In the meantime, he would stick his boring

routine training session with the zealous domina in the garden. He got a few chuckles from his men.

Just that it wouldn't be me, in the garden. Poor Perfuma would get some interesting lessons today, clearly putting her to the edge of her abilities, I mused. Her eyes had been glistening when I asked her to do some training with Bow in the garden today. She'd assumed that something was about to happen, but with a little willpower, I resisted the urge to tell her more or to answer her questioning look when I offered her to wear a copy of my green hunting dress in the morning. It had been no problem to have one of the household seamstresses make a second one. Perfuma'd tilted her head, frowned, opened her mouth, but I only lay a finger on her lips and continued to button it up. After she was ready, I sent her out in the garden and started to ready myself into the uniform.

Shortly after, Bow'd knocked at my door and gave me some last advice on my wearing. And after that'd been done, we just stood across from each other. "Are you sure you wanna do this, Adora? It's not too late to call it off," he asked quietly, and his worries were visibly written all over his face.
My nod was small, but firm, and my look told him everything he needed to know. I stepped forward and embraced him. "Thank you, Bow. For everything." He wrapped his arms around me too, and we shortly luxuriated in the feeling of mutuality.
"Anytime, Adora."
"Please tell Glimmer that I'm hoping to see both of you happy and together in some time." We both knew what I wanted to say but couldn't say because… because… maybe I wouldn't be able to carry out what had to be done otherwise.
"I'll tell her. And Adora?"
"Hmm?"
"I love you."
A surely awkward smile crept on my face, because I was a little off about his open declaration. He'd always been like that, munificent in his expressions of affection, while I was just as often stumbling over them. But I mustered the courage to reply: "I love you too, Bow."

He hugged me again in firm assurance, then we went to the yard, where his soldiers had assembled.

I joined the column at its back without a word, my helmet pulled far forward, my head bowed. On the sign of our leader, we started marching out of the gate, and the guards didn't even throw a second look. We were all the same to them, and our little column of ten rows with two soldiers each quickly left Hordak's site behind. I marched in the last row, alone, with no one at my side, because due to Bow's absence the leading soldier had to be on his own at the top, and so the numbers didn't even out.
Marches were taken as a strict drill by the legions, and the pace was always fast enough so that no one had any mind for talking or doing anything beside… marching. For the next three hours, we simply paced along a road parallel to the Nile, which wasn't surprising given the fact that only a few kilometers besides the great river only desert was. Nobody said anything beside a few muttered words about the length and direction of this march, as well as some grumbling about the heat and the occasional carriage impeding our steps.

We passed farms among reeds and palm trees, little villages here and there, with just a few houses gathered around a well. The troop made a short stop when we reached a place around a fountain before Hermonthis and where we rested for half an hour, then it would go back. I had distanced myself a little from the others and was resting under a palm tree just a few steps away, pretending to be asleep with my helmet on and my head down. Which wasn't hard, and also a skill every legionary learned within his first year in the legion: sleeping in an instant, everywhere, anytime, in every position. Sleep was the one thing that every legionary either missed or had too much, given the circumstances. But it was never the right amount.

When the column formed for the march back, I again lined up at the end and waited for an opportunity I'd already spied out on the way. Only a short while after our set-off, we walked through a small settlement and had some houses left and right, when I slowed down my speed. And as the column marched around a

corner, I just came to a halt and watched them vanishing before me. With a pounding heart, I ducked into a small alleyway for a few minutes and listened to the noises of the troop, quickly falling silent. No one'd looked back, and they hadn’t stopped, just as I hoped. After finally calming my breath, I steadied, took down the galea for the first time since I put it on, and wiped my forehead.

Follow the plan, Adora. I was good at following plans, I told myself.

("Sumeria (The Ancient Era"), Deezer / Spotify / YouTube)

My next task would be to walk down to the Nile and use a path that stretched along a canal, providing fields with water. This canal would lead me for most of the way up the Nile to a town called Atbô, and from there further to the city of Omboi. It would be a march of three or four days by foot, and Omboi was the central town of a larger area of farmland east of the Nile, with many small villages and settlements. From there, on one hand, Syene was in reach within another four days by foot or two days by boat, maybe. On the other hand, the shore of the irrigated land along the Nile opened into a depression to the east and was large enough to hide me for some time until I’d decided what to do next. If I'd be able to adapt to the locals, it could be a place to hide, if needed. I had no clue if a Roman woman would be seen as an alien, an enemy, or just as a curiosity — and talked about. Perhaps I should dye my hair, or hide it under a veil, because blonde obviously stood out. But I would find out, eventually.

And so I started walking, upwards the Nile, to an aim not yet defined. Since the day I decided to go, I also decided to not set up a specific goal beyond getting away. Instead, I would adapt to the circumstances until I fiddled out what to really do next. But I had something in the back of my mind, something I hadn't thought about yet, something I hadn't allowed to surface.

The sun had started to set, and in the last hours, I’d made good progress. But I was sweaty, and my feet hurt from the sandals chafing on my skin. Carrying a heavy backpack was surely

something different from just strolling around. By now, the troop would've been back in Thēbais, and they would also have reported that one of them was missing. And shortly later they would notice that it wasn't one of them, when they would discover their own mate in the barracks. Maybe Hordak himself wouldn’t realize my escape until tomorrow, but that was the most I could hope for.
However, I decided to take a short rest and to slip out of the uniform. I hadn't dared to do it until I was a good distance away, but the armor was heavy, and I wanted to get rid of it.



(Adora at the Nile, a commission by "Ooka")

A little group of palms standing along the canal and between the vast fields of grain spent me shade and cover while I slipped out of the armor. Sniffing at myself wasn't very pleasing, but I decided a bath had to wait. At least a few more hours of walking should bring more distance between me and possible pursuers.

Tomorrow would become hard, because riders could be swarming the area around late morning, and despite its enormous length, the Nile valley wasn't very wide. Two centuriae could sweep it like a rake. I wanted to cross the river to the eastern side as soon as possible, because that would lessen the risk of being discovered considerably. There surely were no bridges, so one could cross the broad stream by boat only, and I wanted to use my head start. Even if pursuers would expect such a move, there would be noticeable less presence of troops on the other side nonetheless. I hid the heavy armor between some undergrowth, but didn't really care about it. Even if someone found it in some time, it wouldn't tell them anything beside the fact that I'd been here, and that was something anyone could've guessed. After that, I wet myself with some water from the canal, thinking about tomorrow, about the next days, but not very much further.
Still, the rush of excitement about my successful escape fueled me with a nervous energy.

Driven by fear and angst as well, I walked further into the sunset for around two hours and made it for another part of the road towards Atbô, which I could reach tomorrow. Night had already fallen, when I finally came to rest. As it was summer in Egypt, even the nights were more than just warm. I found a little depression between the fields, that was surrounded by bushes, and which would shield me from being seen. The Nile wasn't far, and the next settlement was maybe a walk of a quarter of an hour away. The main road lay several hundreds of meters beside, and I would see anyone who approached me from there easily. On the other hand, my only escape route behind me was the large river

itself, and I knew that crocodiles were still populating the shores of it here and there. And despite they weren’t really known as man-eaters, I would rather not try them, if I had other options. Even the thought of an encounter with one of them made me shiver.

Under a cloudless sky, I put my backpack down, smoothed a piece of the sandy ground, and spread a thick sheet on it, then buried the purse with several tetradrachmas and drachmas in the sand a few feet away. Luckily, I got enough money with me to buy things like a passage or food, but I was aware of the possibility of being ravished. After all, a woman, alone, would make a good target for a robbery.

Should I be frightened because of my exposed situation?

Maybe.

But in fact… I wasn't. When I finally lay on my blanket and looked at the dark sky, I heard the rustling of little animals around me. A boat was audibly rowing down on the river, and a man yelled at his rowers. It was night, but the cloudless sky and a half moon spent enough light to see all the shades and outlines. The noises of the night presumably should’ve made me fearful, too. Only that they didn't. Instead, I felt calm and confident. Exhausted, too, but with a nervous energy.

Because this day I took my life into my own hands and I had the certainty, that I could handle this. And with these thoughts going through my mind, I fell asleep.

Oh, bona dea I can’t handle this. This is torture, madness, this is… horrifying.
I groaned. Loudly, and very, very unpatrician. I woke up with aching muscles and a sore back, and wasn’t really able to move in the first minutes. Every fiber of my torso hurt from the long walking under the heavy armor the day before. The hard ground, on which I’d slept not so well, only added to it. I hadn’t expected it to be so exhausting, and thought that my training should’ve helped in avoiding that, preparing me for it.

But now, while I tried to get myself up, I realized that I'd been naive. Walking for a whole day — most of it clad in armor and with heavy march baggage — was obviously something different. It hadn't hurt as much last night as it does now that my muscles had gone cold and stiff. Morning dawned, and it had been my plan to break up as early as possible for to seek for a fisherman or similar, whom I could pay a drachma to take me across the river. But now I had to deal with a body who betrayed me first.

It took me a ridiculous half an hour to loosen and warm my muscles enough, by massaging my thighs and slowly flexing and rolling my shoulders and back, until I was able to tell myself “Up with you, you lazy fool,” and to actually stand up. Very slowly, I cleared up my little camp and dressed in my green hunting dress. The sun was already a good bit in the sky and farmers had since long picked up work in the surrounding fields, making me aware how urgent it was to go. I tied my hair and hid it under a headscarf. Again I pondered if it had been a good idea to keep them, at least that long, and remembered the talk with Bow about it. But then again: they were part of what was me, and I was just too stubborn to let them go so easily. I dug out the purse, shouldered the backpack and groaned under its weight, nearly tumbling backwards when hoisting it. Maybe I should sort out some stuff I so well-chose selected to bring with me? With a little luck, some things were dispensable after all?

Even if was willed to do something to lighten the backpack, I decided to deal with that later, after I'd crossed the river and found a place for the next night. It could be clever to use the day

to think about what I really needed and what not. My first duty for today was to look out for boughs. I brought bowstrings, arrowheads, feathers, and a carving knife with me, but I would have to find fitting wood for making a bow and arrows. Or buy one from a hunter or at a market. I searched around in the undergrowth while aiming southwards, and after around an hour, I still had no luck with wood for the bow, but found some branches that I could use for making arrows.

Walking along a path near the glistening stream, I watched out for a little pier or fishermen that I could pay to ferry me across. The sun had made a good way to zenith when I discovered a few houses along the shore, that stood on an elevation several meters above the waterline. Behind them, a few pillars, crumbled walls and a still intact and lavishly decorated gate from a long abandoned temple overlooked the scenery. Although they were half buried under sand, the relics were still imposing to look at. Apparently the villagers did not dare to settle around or in the temple itself, but the position on the little hill seemed to offer protection from the annual floods of the Nile and so it hadn't been abandoned. It was understandable. Often, old temples and even pyramids had been used as quarries for later generations, but not here. This temple wasn’t in use any longer, but also no ruin.

Slowly, I ventured into the little village and looked for someone to ask about a passage, not assuming any pursuers Hordak sent out would have made it thus far. But the around dozen houses seemed empty, as if their residents had left them just in the morning. The door into one of them was open, and I dared to look into it, clearing my throat loudly in an attempt to not surprise anyone. But it stayed silent. I recognized plates and mugs on a table, and the remains of a meal still on them. One of the stools had tipped over. It was as if the occupants had been there a minute ago, but then suddenly just disappeared.

I got a bad feeling. Something was wrong here, I just couldn’t lay my finger on it. It was too quiet, and no-one was around, not even kids. Even if all the people were out working on fields, fishing or hunting, a few old people or little children would always

be there, guarding the house, doing housework or sitting around just because.
What would I have given for a bow and arrow now? I put my backpack down to the ground and fetched the short gladius out of it, that I'd still kept. It wasn't a weapon I was used to very well, but I had at least trained the basic attitudes and some moves with Bow, so that I wouldn't make an idiot of myself when using it.

Suddenly, in the distance, I heard a voice speaking loudly, and it came from the old temple. I silently crept between two houses, always keeping something in the line of sight, because my gut feeling worsened by the second. The voice sounded harsh. Before me was a wooden hut, presumably a stable for pigs or other livestock, and some tools were hanging around. It was open to one side, and I sneaked in and tried to peek through one of the gaps between the planks of the back wall. The sight wasn't good, but I got the most of what was important.

The backside of the hut and other buildings stood on a rock that elevated them around head high above the sandy ground beneath them. And one bowshot away, a muscular man with a large scimitar stood at the steps leading through the gate of the temple behind him. Beneath him, several old people and some children crouched on the ground in front of him. Between them and me and with their back heading in my direction, two other men stood, armed with short swords, but apparently no armor and their whole attitude was practically screaming *outlaws, bandits*. They'd obviously waited for the men and women of the little village to be away on the fields or else, then they rallied up the elders and children. One of the old men was bleeding, holding his side where a blade must've hit him. I didn't understand what they wanted, but it was clear that these men were villains.

My assumptions were underlined when the presumable leader called out in discontent to an old man, and after obviously not hearing what he wanted, because he drew his scimitar over his chest without hesitation. The wounded man fell down to earth with a groan and a few screams showed the other people's horror. Some kids started crying, others just hid into the laps of the

elders.
Anger boiled inside me, and I noticed that my fist had grabbed the gladius.
A bad idea, Adora, one against three.
But what could I do? The urge to do something, to help, festered in me, made me looking around on the search for…
A bow and a quiver full of arrows hung on the wall. The bow was well-made, not a war weapon, but clearly made for shooting gazelles, foxes or wild donkeys from the distance. Not really the weapon of a warrior, but in my case, much better than a sword. I fetched an arrow, eyed it carefully, then picked the bow and plucked at the string. It wasn't perfect, but I could try it.

Meanwhile, at the scene, the muscular man again yelled at the poor people, while the wounded lay on the ground. I made two practice shoots into the sandy ground behind me to test the firing characteristics of the bow. The bowstring was strong, the bow itself provided a good pull, but it seemed to tend to the left, and I desperately tried to estimate how this would work out over a larger distance.

Another scream and more shouts jostled me and made my blood rush. I decided that I had to work with what I had, and again peeked through the planks of the hut's back wall. Still, the two henchmen were standing with their back towards me, while the attention of their leader was drawn to someone laying before him in the sand.
You have to be quick and merciless, I told myself. *Take out the first, then maybe the two others will back down. You did that before.* A vague hope. I hadn't been on my own before, when I saved Catra's party, but I had to do something. Now. I just couldn't back down.
I fetched three arrows out of the quiver, held two of them with my little finger, while applying the third. Then I crept around the corner of the hut and aimed at the one of the thugs who was in sight, while still being hidden by the wall from the other two, with the corner a few meters away. The bandits swayed a little left and right, giddy because of all the action before them. I drew and

aimed — a *bit to the right, I reminded myself* — held my breath like Bow taught me to do, and fired.



Adora shoots, a commission by "JudeTheRagdoll" [114]

It was fucking luck.
The second I let loose, the man swayed a bit to the right, otherwise I would have missed him. Because the bow worked just perfect — it had been the arrow that had twisted leftwards earlier — and so I hit the guy straight in the back, between his shoulder blades. He groaned lowly, stumbled forward, crumbled down and didn't move anymore, while I'd already drawn and aimed the next arrow. Two to one, I smirked and waited.
The second henchmen wasn't very clever, because he came running straight around the corner. I immediately shot him in the face—only that I missed him by a whisker and had to step back, almost panicking. He swung his short sword at me that was a bit longer than my gladius and gave him a better range. I dropped the bow, drew my own sword, and just parried another strike while ducking. One more step backward, I stumbled.

Oh no! Not like that!

Just on instinct, my sword hand shot forward while I fell over on my back. The thug had closed the distance and towered over me, legs apart and maliciously grinning into my face upon his easy victory. I remembered another lesson with Bow.
Unbalance them, if you can't strike. Always keep the initiative, with whatever move.
I kicked his ankles with both feet and full force.
Apparently my lucky streak was not over yet. As the surprised man tumbled over at me, I still had the gladius, now in both hands, to parry his blows. And with a perplexed expression on his face, the man crashed into my stretched out sword as he toppled into me, sending the blade through his chest with a surprisingly silent noise.

It took me a few seconds to overcome my shock that an already dead person was lying on top of me. His head hung down at my side, his limp body splaying over mine. Only after a long moment, I started to push the heavy, smelly corpse off of me and tried to sit up. But apparently, my lucky streak was over now, as the leader of the little now gone pack approached me, while my legs were still buried below the dead thug. He yelled something in a

dialect I didn’t understand, but it wasn't necessary to know that he was after blood, when he drew a dagger from his belt and stepped over me. My gladius still stuck in the dead body, and I had nothing at hand to defend myself. A victorious and vicious grin appeared on the face of the man.

Was it that now?

A loud *Thumb* marked the end of the fight, as a wooden club hit the man at the side of his head, letting him crash against the hut and collapse. Behind him, one of the elders stood, panting heavily and with horror on his face.

I struggled to get up again, but finally I stood, also panting, and looked into the frightened visages. In my still broken Demotic I asked “Who were they?” and pointed at the two dead and one unconscious men. An elder man answered me slowly and with simple words, as he obviously got that I was a foreigner.
“They were bandits. They tried to rob us. But there are more of them.”
I grimaced when I got the implication. “You fear they will come for you?”
The elder nodded. “We are grateful for your help, lady, but this can have serious consequences.”
Biting on my lips, I pondered about his words. I had acted hot-headed when I saw the leader of the thugs wounding the old man. But what should I’ve done instead? Leaving? Not an option, no. And I couldn’t stay either to help these people when the comrades of the thieves would come for them.
But there was a possibility…
“Send one of your boys to the main road from Thēbais,” I said, while inwardly scolding myself for my stupid, stupid urge to help. “Riders from the governor are on their way from there. He should tell them that he saw a tall blonde woman, then they will follow. Then you have their help here, when the thugs come after you. Hand the bandit over.”

He eyed me carefully, and seemed to understand that I was on the run, while I pulled a corner of my mouth into a weak smile,

and continued: “Can someone row me to the other side?”
Again, I was ogled by him. But after a short moment of hesitation, he obviously came to a conclusion. “I’ll do it myself. Wait for me below the temple. Hide between the reed.” With that being said, he pointed at a place between the temple on the hill and the river shore down below, then he turned to his people and ushered them back to their houses, dragging the now bound and still unconscious thieve with them.

The reed stretched hundreds of meters to both sides, and two dozens into the river, and it was a perfect place to hide. I used the opportunity to drink something and to tuck a few loosened strands of my hair back under the headscarf.
Only a short while later, the old man reappeared, calling for me, then gesturing at me to follow him. He guided me to a row boat that was hidden at the end of a little path between the reed, and we were quickly on our way beyond the river. Passing the broad stream took some time, but he was obviously used to it, as I judged from his experienced oar strokes. It was a little awkward, as we didn’t speak, and so I just sat and clutched my backpack until we reached the other shore.
Arrived, I just jumped out of the boat and questioningly looked back at him. “The less I know, the better. I only saw you walking away from the temple, westwards,” he said while winking at me. “Thank you,” I silently replied, and waved at him while he was already on his way back to the western shore. It was only an hour later, when I realized that I’d kept their bow and quiver with the remaining arrows.

As I walked further up the Nile towards Atbô for the rest of the day, I fell back into my rumination. The events in the small village were quickly eclipsed by my sore muscles and the heat. Because the geographic circumstances — or rather the fucking coincidences — were of course not hidden from me. I was walking in the direction where Buhen lay, which wasn't surprising given the fact, the there were only two directions in Egypt; North and South, Lower and Upper Egypt, towards the Mediterranean Sea or towards Aethiopia.

Both of them presumably equally dangerous for me, but I obviously couldn't go North.

Catra should already be in Buhen again, as far as I knew. I'd heard nothing from her since we'd parted ways back at the yard — since I hissed at her and shoved her away, I recalled wincing, and which was something that seemed to have happened a lifetime ago. If I just kept walking long enough — and wasn't caught — then at some point I would inevitably get past Buhen. A month of travel, maybe more, as far as I knew.
I laughed at my own ridiculousness, as if it hadn't been me who told her to fuck off for the rest of my life. And now it was I who was on the way to her? *You pathetic idiot*, I grumbled, and didn't mean Catra.
But what good would it be? Going there? Seeing her again? For all I knew, she wasn't my friend. Perhaps she loved me, but also perhaps she loved her sister more. Or at least, would again want to prove herself worthy to her, handing me over, betraying me a second time. No, she wasn't reliable, I couldn't trust her. I should not.

But when I laid down to sleep that night, another half a day's march southwards from where the old men had dropped me off, I still mulled about it, couldn't shake the longing off. Could she be trusted or not? My determination to stay away from her was getting as weak as my legs as of now.

At the evening, I'd passed Atbô, a middle-sized town on the other side of the Nile, with a few larger temples towering over the other buildings and a busy little port. I remembered from talks that there was a ferry driving people forth and back, but I didn't want to risk it. The other shore must be swarming with Hordak's men. Even on my side, the eastern one, troops of riders, light cavalry, rushed by on the main road two times. Luckily, I heard them before I saw them and, more importantly, before they saw me, and in both cases I was able to hide myself in the middle of fields of grain, where the corn stood high. I crouched down on the ground and waited until they passed, both times with a little shaky legs and pounding heart. I could only imagine how many troops

would be looking for me on the west side, and hoped they still suspected I was there. Hopefully, the old man had kept quiet.

With that in mind, I decided that a visit to a larger town or city had to wait. Still, I had enough food and water wasn't a problem given the omnipresent wells that were fed by groundwater from the Nile. Every settlement and every farm had one, as it was just needed to dig a well hole for a few meters, wall it, and have a never-ending source of fresh, filtered, clean water for a lifetime. The more I took in from this part of Egypt, the more I started to understand what made this nation so productive and rich. Learning about these things hadn't really been a part of my education, but I'd picked up of my father's conversations with his subordinates. Despite that all life here depended on the Nile and took place just within a few stone throws from its shore, this was a blooming, prosperous nation on fertile land. Stretching over a thousand milia passuum along the Nile, it was home to millions of people that lived from this ever flowing, feeding, nurturing river that provided them with everything they needed: water, fertile mud, huntable wildlife, a rich flora and an excellent trade and travel route in the middle of it all. It was no wonder that Egypt inhabited a civilization since so long.[115] Mulling over these useless thoughts, I fell into an uneasy sleep.

The next day, I found a way to dye my green dress into a lighter, more sandy-green tone, when I bought some yellow weed from an old woman. While walking through a little village off the main street, I notice her dying her own wool and stopped on a whim. The settlement and her piece of land lay beneath a gently sloping hill that devolved into the elevated, deserted plateau eastwards of the irrigated valley. On the hill, a pyramid stood. It wasn't one of the largest I'd seen — not in comparison to the great ones of Tipersis — but it was a beautiful one nonetheless. Unlike most pyramids I'd seen, this one was much brighter, as if a layer of material made it glow in a whitish shine.

I paid the woman a few drachmas for the weed and the possibility to use her tub and to wait for my dress to discolor. It was too much, but she was kind and I didn't lack the money. We had a

faltering, bumpy conversation about the weather and her grandchildren, as I hesitated to offer too many details about myself, while I was always careful at hiding my hair under the headscarf. I had to look weird enough to her, but a *blonde* woman would be clearly remembered.
It hurt to see the former beautiful green being replaced by a much more uneven color, but the new shade matched more into the colors of the natural surrounding and would help a lot in hiding me. While I was folding the dress to store into my backpack, I asked her about the odd pyramid. "Can you tell me, why it's shining so bright?"

The old woman giggled and croaked: "Most pyramids originally looked like this, little one. The Pharaohs always coated them with white chalk, sometimes white limestone. But only this one has maintained its beauty over the last two thousand years. So be careful, little girl. Two millennia look upon you. "
Two thousand years. *What a way to cover sixty generations of man.*
"Why is that?" I asked, still curious.
She shrugged her shoulders lightly. "We care for it. It's a First Ones Pyramid, one of the oldest ever build. It's not large, but as long as we take care of it, the elders from the afterlife will protect our village, and no harm will come upon us."

Superstition, surely, I thought. But also… that superstition had kept the pyramid intact since two thousand years. Who was I to argue with that?

Two hours later and with a dress still a little damp, I threw myself again into a field of wheat as another troop of cavalry rushed by. It was only in the last second, as my attention had slipped. The constant nervousness was equally going on my nerves as it was tiring. My gaze wandered over to the hills east of me, a terrain slowly elevating mostly a few dozen, sometimes a hundred meters to the rocky desert-like plateaus beyond. Paths meandered there, above the Nile valley, I knew that. They were used by travelers sometimes, but mostly by local folk as a shortcut, or by rather dubious figures who wanted to avoid tax stations at the river and

main roads, or for worse reasons. Using them would be a risk, because hideouts were rare, given the fact that there wasn't any water or vegetation above the irrigated flats, but only sand, rocks and an occasional tomb or a quarry. On the other hand lay the possibility that nobody would be searching for me there at all, and that I could walk for a day straight without having to look over my shoulder every minute.

I decided to give it a try the next day, and to walk down to the southeast, using a dry river valley that would lead back to the west again before Omboi. I should be able to make it within two days, and so I wasn't feared about water, as I could carry enough for such a short time.

Maybe I'd been a bit too optimistic, when I slowly released my bow from its holder and fetched an arrow out of the quiver on my back, to aim at the stranger before me who decided to block my way.

After I'd climbed up the slope of the Nile valley while it was still dark the next morning, I walked into dawn for and must have taken a wrong turn at a crossing barely visible. I only realized it when the slope slowly turned into a low ravine and was heading directly eastwards, which wasn't like I remembered it to be on the map. I paused shortly to clear my head and was about to turn around and go back, when I suddenly found the trail being… blocked by a tall, muscular woman with a dark tanned skin. She sat on one of the rocks above me, her feet dangling down, giving me a casual look, obviously feeling superior and was certainly not afraid of me.

I warily stared at her until she asked: "Kid, what ar' yer doin' here?" And she sounded so arrogant that I would have loved to punch her in there. But my mouth must have fallen agape instead, because she barked out a few laughs, then hopped off the rock and stood in my way.
"Yer didn't know that's my territory, right?" she asked, flexing her

muscles, and clearly giving shits about the fact that I had already put the arrow on the string. At least I wasn't aiming yet, because I found her repulsive and attractive at the same time, and was confused rather than threatened.
"Noo?" I replied and cursed myself for such a weak answer. I knew I could do better and voiced, louder: "No, I didn't. And there was no sign, or was it?"
"Cocky, eh?" she smirked.
"Well, I can return the compliment," I mustered and straightened my stance.
"Why are yer here?" The woman was at least as tall as I, maybe a bit taller even, and was as self-assure as I would like to be right now.
"I'm just crossing, on the way to Omboi," I finally replied.
"And why would ya choose such a dumb path to do? Would've been shorter through the valley. Nicer, even."
"I like it here. It's more… lonely." I tilted my head when answering.
"There's no way a pretty girl like you enjoys walking through Huntara's desert just for the sake."
Was that her name? Huntara? Sounded like the name of a villain out of a fairy tale. "What a ridiculous kind of name is that?" I asked, and maybe our little banter would've turned into a serious argument, when we were interrupted by the sudden arrival of two soldiers behind me.
I turned around, but I still had the backpack on my shoulder, and it slowed me down. And holding bow and arrow kept me from letting it slide down easily. The guards had their swords already drawn, and their gazes were fixed on me.
"That is her!" the left one shouted and moved forward, while the other, taller one looked behind me at Huntara, trying to evaluate the situation between the two of us. His mate wasn't hesitant to threaten me: "Stand down, Adora. We know who you are, and the governor is expecting you to be brought back alive."
I drew the arrow and aimed at him. "No. You won't lay a hand on me. No one will." Both looked at each other, obviously trying to calculate their chances to take me down unharmed enough, and also how to deal with the strange woman behind me. I was

painfully aware of her presence *behind me* , but I couldn't pay any attention to her now. Not with two of Hordak's henchmen in front of me.

“What do you little fellas think yer doin in my territory?” the muscle lady called from behind.
“That’s not of your concern, woman. Withdraw, immediately!” the taller one shouted, and it earned him an angry “I’m deciding what is of my concern, and I don’t like yer attitude. What is this with ya and her?”
I still aimed at the nearer one of them both, and the effort to keep it started to pain my arm. “She belongs to the governor, and I order you to stand down.”
“I don’t belong to anyone,” I yelled and started to lose my temper. Both soldiers moved forward, quickly closing the distance between us, and I immediately fired the arrow, rather out of surprise than well-aimed. It hit the smaller one in his shoulder. That wasn’t deadly, but it made him crouch and fall back in his advance. His fellow stormed forward, trying to strike me down with a baton. I stumbled back a few paces, let go of the bow because it would’ve taken too long to fetch and attach a new arrow, and drew my gladius. Holding it before me in defense, the soldier hesitated only briefly, lunged to the side, got round my block with a trained move, and hit me at the right shoulder. The pain made me let go of the sword, which clearly showed the difference between me and a legionary when it came to a fight like that.

I winced and kept stumbling back while he called: “Stand down. We don’t want to hurt you, but you have to come with us.”
“No,” I grunted, straightening and drawing the dagger I still had on my belt with the left hand.
“Give up. Now,” the man demanded militant, and I felt pretty lost.
“NO!” I yelled, desperately, but nonetheless, and swung the dagger before me. The soldier shortly measured my movements, and I knew that I wouldn’t stand a chance against a fucking professional, when suddenly a spear hit his chest from behind. He stumbled, fell over and looked already dead, while my mouth was agape at the sudden rescue. The tall woman stomped past me, drew the spear out of his body and hurled it at the other,

wounded soldier, who had watched the scene in disbelief while still trying to pick himself up again. He fended it off with his sword in a quick move, but Huntara already approached him. He tried to kick her in her gut to fend her off.
She chuckled lowly and growled: "Please. This isn't a bar fight. Have some class."[116] And while distracting him like that, she already picked up her spear and threw it again. The weapon hit the man right in the chest, killing him in an instant.

I was far too shocked upon the bloodbath to thank her. The ease with which she'd just killed two soldiers unsettled me. She didn't do things by halves, that was clear. Was I next? While I was still standing around gawking, holding my dagger before me, she plucked her spear out of the body of the dead soldier, then quickly searched them. I watched her uneasily while she then dragged them over the rocks to a crevice and dropped the dead into it without hesitation.
Then she trudged over to me. I should've perhaps felt threatened. She just laid a hand on my shoulder and said: "Com' on, Blondie. We should get outta 'ere." She turned around and started walking away, along the path.
I blinked, needed a moment to get out of my freeze, but then I nodded slowly to someone who was already away, and started to follow her further into the desert.

The path-that-wasn't led slowly upwards to the southeast. Left and right yellow and sandy rocks elevated a few meters above to the plateau, so I didn't see much ahead, but at least we had occasional shade here. Now and then other branches went off from ours, but Huntara obviously knew her way and didn't hesitate once.
The hard ground was arduous for my feet. But I was too stubborn and vain to admit to the obviously unabashed hard woman that I was having trouble keeping up with her pace.
It turned out to be a not so very good idea, when my unawareness let me stumble and then to crash against a rock. In my haze, I wasn't fast enough to shield myself and cut my forearm on its sharp edge, while trying to keep from falling down.

The pain woke me from my indolence, and I yelped. “Ouch.” Huntara turned and eyed me scrutinizing, then said: “Yer don’t look good. Why didn’t yer say something? Bandage that, we’re almost there.”
I grimaced, but took out a piece of cloth I'd packed for exactly that purpose. After taking a few deep breaths, I got up again with a groan and continued walking behind her.

Huntara didn’t say a word while I followed. But a few minutes later — were it minutes? — the trail stretched to the left and finally opened into an elongated, slightly wider cut in the landscape, maybe a hundred passi long and two dozen wide in the middle. Something like a tent was set up under a ledge, surrounded by a few bushes and… a small water hole. She pointed at it and mentioned, “It's drinkable, but yer better boil it first, if yer not used to it. Don't wash yourself in it.” Then she scurried into the tent, that only seemed to work as an entrance to a cave behind it, because I heard her walking further into the dark.

I wasn’t sure what to do with myself, being not invited into the tent or offered *anything*. So I stopped under the ledge and put the backpack down, releasing an audible sigh of relief. Only now I realized how exhausted I was. Carrying the backpack under the bright and glaring sun had been exhausting, and I knew I wasn’t far away from a heat stroke. I scooped some water from the water hole and cooled me down, then I got to work to clean the wound on my arm while sitting beneath the outstanding ledge. It thankfully provided a good amount of shadow, and it was a little cooler here. It took me a little while, but finally I wrapped a clean soft cloth around the wound, to stop the last bit of bleeding, and leaned back against the rock wall behind me. Stretching my feet and rolling my arms and shoulders was pleasing, but otherwise, I had no idea what to do.

Huntara was not to be seen, and it stayed quiet inside the cave. I drank from my water bottle and allowed myself to relax.
The last hours had drained me beyond the usual. Being wounded had of course not helped. Together with my overall exhaustion

from the heat and all the marching, my eyes fell shut quickly, and I was fast asleep before I knew it.

It was still day when I woke with a light jolt. Judging from the position of the sun, evening was approaching, but it was still the same day. Somehow, I had been taken further into the cave and stretched out on a makeshift bed that stood behind the entrance. The sheets and towels in front of it had been turned aside and gave a view of the outside. I quickly looked around and, to my relief, saw the backpack lying next to me. Then I searched for the purse and found it as well, still hanging down from my waist. Whatever Huntara had done by putting me down on the bed, she obviously hadn't robbed me or done anything worse. A sigh of relief escaped me.

"I'd already thought that yer would be worried, if the purse were gone," her low voice chuckled from behind. My head spun around, and I found her sitting a few steps away, fumbling with a spearhead.
I cleared my throat, not really sure what to say, but she already got ahead of me.
"Yer can stay until tomorrow. Ye're not in the condition to walk further today."
Her words only registered slowly because I was still so dizzy.
"Uhmm, thank you," I finally managed to reply, and she just waved it off casually, proceeding in her workings.
"No, really," I insisted, after I propped myself up and swung my legs down. "Thank you for not… you know… preying on me."
"Huntara isn't a bandit," was all she commented on that when looking at me, then she went back to fumble on the spearhead, clearly not being in the mood for talk.

And despite having slept for a few hours, I was still tired, and decided to leave all my worries and troubles about her or the whole situation for future me to deal with. Tomorrow would be enough time for that, and after all — it wasn't like that I had a schedule to stick to. I could stay for a day if I wanted to.

After I undressed I made a cat lick at the water hole to get off the worst of my sweat, then laid down again and was gone again within a minute. In the background I heard Huntara grinding her spearhead, a noise that could or should've upset me.
I couldn't have cared less.

The sun was well up in the sky when I woke up again. My limbs were stiff, and my muscles hurt. I cursed myself for sleeping in, because I'd missed the cool time of day, but then I reminded myself that I hadn't a timetable to care for and relaxed a little. Huntara had apparently let me sleep. I pondered about the odd woman. She'd been as friendly as a complete stranger should or could've been to someone who practically stumbled over her home — or whatever this was — but I had a certain feeling that she would prefer it to be left alone as soon as possible. I had surely used her unspoken hospitality enough by now, and so I mentally readied myself to leave before afternoon. Maybe I'd overestimated my strengths when I'd considered running away. But I mustn't add being a burden to some stranger to my faults also.

Huntara was nowhere to be seen, though.

I took advantage of their absence, stripped down to my underwear, sat on a rock next to the waterhole and washed thoroughly. The cold water felt good on my skin. I realized how all this time in Egypt had slowly tanned the uncovered parts of my skin into a nice, bronze colored tone, which I actually liked. And the training of the last weeks got my figure and form back in shape. Beside my struggles, I felt good in my body and took my time to treat all the little wounds and cuts I'd gathered over the last days. After I finished, I proceeded to clean my formerly green dress and a few other clothes I needed to tend to, too. Putting

them on the hot rocks exposed them to the sun to dry fast. Then I redressed into fresh underwear and a skirt and went to examine my stuff. But I found nothing missing.

Suddenly, Huntara stood before me, and I hadn't even heard her approaching. "Yer need to pay more attention, Blondie, otherwise yer won't last long here," she commented with a light, one-sided pull of the corner of her mouth, but I spared me an answer and instead asked: "Where've you been?"
She looked at me like I'd said something very dumb, so I shrugged my shoulders. "What? I was just curious."
"Blondie, yer wanna eat, yer've ta hunt." That being said, she held out several dead jerboas[117] on their tails and grinned. "Got some food."

After she'd skinned and roasted the little rodents over the small campfire before the cave, she offered me two of them with a grunt. At first, I warily rejected. Watching her gutting them with her swift motions had been a bit too realistic for my taste, but then a loud rumble of my stomach convinced me to consider, so I finally tried it. And… it wasn't so bad at all. In return, I offered her some of my salt for seasoning the meat, and she gladly accepted with a smile: "Yer got a good idea to bring it with ya, kiddo. Salt is important, not just for the taste."
I shot her a quizzical look, and she shrugged: "Three things are of significance in the desert: water, salt, food. In this order. Ya body needs all of them to survive," she informed me. "Water is obvious. But because of the heat and yer sweating the whole time, yer body looses salt, and ya need to replenish it, otherwise you'll get sick. Yer can stay alive without food for days, maybe weeks, if yer don't do much. But yer'll die within days without water and salt," she explained. I filed that information. I'd packed the salt rather because I liked it, and it didn't weigh much.

After we finished our meal, we rested at her shelter while the sun was at its highest, making it a scorching hot day with a blue, cloudless sky. It was unbearable in the open, but I knew that I should leave in the late afternoon. Hopefully, the sun wasn't burning as hell then, but right now it was just too hot to do

anything. Huntara dozed on a colorful carpet with a blanket on it that she'd pulled beside the entrance to the cave, and which served as a place for her to lie. But occasionally, the buff woman woke up, then strode up to the plateau and kept an eye out, only to stroll back, flop down and doze again.

We didn’t speak anything while the sun slowly made her way over the sky. I used the time to mend a tear in my other tunic. Funny, that of all the now useless lessons back at home — from another life — that skill was getting useful now. Fumbling with the needle reminded me of the times when I was younger and so eager to learn skills from the woman I’d called *mother* back then. She hadn’t been a very willing teacher, but she’d done it well enough to teach a little girl, desperate for attention, for something. All of this was so far away now, it might as well happened to another person.

I pushed the thoughts away, finished my mending, and realized that the sun had gone down considerably. Groaning again when I moved my aching limbs, I started to shove my stuff into the backpack, then filled my bottles with water again. My rummaging earned me a quizzical look from Huntara, who had opened her eyes and blinked over while still lying.
“What yer think ya doin’ there, Blondie?” she asked, not letting go of her casual tone, yawning and stretching slowly.
“I’m moving on,” I informed her, my voice only a tad too cool. “I have certainly taken advantage of your hospitality long enough.”
She rolled her eyes dramatically and groaned, still stretching herself, then saying: “Just ask.”
I pressed my lips together, felt caught, knowing that I had been just too proud to simply do it. It was clearly an offer, even I got that.
Huntara sat up cross-legged and smirked. “Come on, yer highness can do it,” she teased again, watching how my movements stilled.
Still struggling with my pride, I decided that another day of rest in this secluded place would be worth it and gave in. “Ugh. I could… use another night of… you know, rest,” I muttered.
Huntara eyed me, chuckled lowly in her usual dark, low voice,

then said: “Barely audible, Blondie. But be my guest”. That being stated, she flopped back and closed her eyes again.
After feeling like an idiot for a while, I went back to my makeshift bed. It was still too hot outside to do anything without drowning in sweat, and the heat as well as my exhaustion did their parts so well that I nodded off again. It was a bit more comfortable now. I just had to noodle out why.

In the evening, I couldn’t resist eyeing Huntara more carefully. If I was honest to myself, I didn’t get her. Overall, she was reluctant to speak, and her whole attitude said “Leave me alone”. She clearly wasn't used to company. But when she decided to talk to me, she was up front and without being evasive. And she'd offered me to stay, at least another day. That counted for something, right?
So I asked about the most obvious topic: “Why do you live here? Why not, you know, down at the Nile? Someone like you should be well liked, given your… hunting abilities. You would be a win for every village, I would say.”
Huntara chuckled. “Don’t yer think I tried? I did, and it didn’t fit. I’m too… special, and I don't like being told what to do. That’s not a good fit when there are so many people who like to do exactly that.” There was something in her words that resonated in me. More so, when she continued. “If it isn't for the village chief who’s eyeing ya too close, then it’s the local tax collectors. Or it’s the governor who demands yer service, free of course, and if it’s not them, the Pharaoh needs yer for his next useless war and now there are these Romans as well. All of them want something from ya, and I don’t like it. What gives all of them the right to impose something on me, huh?”

She didn’t really sound bitter, it was rather annoyance that poured out of her. I didn’t know what or how to answer that. Her outbreak took me by surprise, but I also understand where it comes from. “Well… if you put it that way—”
Huntara caught my look and cut in: “And it’s not like ya aren’t doin the same, do ya?”
Play it down, Adora. After a short moment of hesitation, I retorted: “Don’t know what you’re talking about.”

This time, she didn't chuckle, instead her voice was hard as stone. "Don't play stupid, Blondie. I know who yer are."
"What?" Oh, fuck. Fuck.
She fiddled with her fingernails with the knife. "Wasn't that hard to figure out. Ya blonde hair and the guards gave it right away. And even I get to hear things from down the vale. Yer are big news and those travel fast, ya know?"
This was getting worse by the second, and I slowly reached out for my own dagger, shoving my hand back to the belt that lay beside me. If I could get it and then…

Huntara didn't even move or look in my direction, all her attention was glued to her fingernails where she poked around. "Don't be ridiculous. If I'd wanted to get that reward, I could've let the guards take ya. Or I could've done it on my own last night. Yer were so exhausted, I could've thrown ya over my shoulder and carry yer down to the next hunting party of Hordak, and yer wouldn't have noticed it. Get over yaself. I'm not interested in yer struggles with Hordak - or the Pharaoh. Not my business."
I stopped trying to catch the dagger and looked embarrassed at the ground. After a while, I asked: "Why? Why do you help me?"
She smirked and cocked her head. "Liked what ya said to them. That yer don't belong to anyone. That yer don't wanna let them lay a hand on ya. Reminded me of me myself, actually, so yeah, I helped ya. It's not that I like the governor's men. Or any men at all."

Ooof, that was a frank statement. Did she really mean what I thought she just implied? I hadn't the courage to ask her right away, and so I let it go for the moment. "And so you helped me and killed the guards of the governor, just like that?"
She grunted. "I face my problems head on. They wanted something I didn't want them to get. And given what I saw back there, yer look like someone who does the same."
I raised my eyebrows and smiled weakly. "I admire your stance, and I thank you for your help." Somehow I felt urged to explain more. My whole dire situation was so confusing and tangled, and I hadn't really sorted through all my thoughts. So, my next words just tumbled out: "It looks like sometimes, all you can do is to…

step aside and let the problems sort itself out. At least that's what I got to learn during the last months. I thought I could fix them if I just tried hard enough. But I always just worsened it, at least regarding myself, or I reached nothing at all. So now I'm just walking away from them. I don't want to be a part of…" I fell dry. What was it what I wanted to say?
Huntara took her time before answering, and I realized that she always thought about her words before she voiced them. "I understand what ya mean. So, now yer get why I'm here."

Our conversation fell silent for a moment, until she added. "Ya can stay here for a few days. I don't mind yer company."
I nodded gratefully, but we did not pick up talking, and soon, Huntara went for her sleeping place, while I still sat before the tent and cave and looked into the nightly sky. And I realized, that I liked it here. It was quiet. Calm. No struggles. No worries. And Huntara had turned out to be a weirdly good company.
And I? I had no aim. The last days had just consisted of running away from a cage that I couldn't bear anymore. But there was no place I had to go to. With making my decision to run away, I'd also made the decision to exclude myself from the circles and influence of a powerful family and a realm that I'd belonged to for… for my entire life. And now that was gone. Now I was a runaway, someone without anyone, someone without a family or allies. I had no one.
Now it was just me. Just Adora.

Sitting here, in the forsaken desert, I started to understand for the first time the significance of my decision. There was only one way for me. Forward. If I went back or be captured, they would never let me out, never let me go again, that much was for sure. I would lead the life of a princess in a golden cage and with chains around my ankles, guarded anytime. I knew it would drive me crazy. The mere thought made me feeling unwell and let me shiver.

Here, I was free. I laughed lowly when looking over to the sleeping woman. Huntara was obviously as free as one could be.

Maybe I would ask her tomorrow, if I could stay another day. Maybe.

We would go hunting, as Huntara informed me when she rattled me awake not too gently on the next morning and while it was still dark outside. I stopped my hand that was already moving down to the dagger below my pillow, which wasn't a pillow, but just some clothes clumped together, and drowsily blinked my eyes open to collect myself.
"Come on Blondie. The early bird catches the worm. If yer wanna eat, get up."
My muscles ached a little because of their stiffness, and I needed a while until I was able to move properly. But a day of rest had really helped, and half an hour later and with dawn arriving, we already crouched on the ground above a dry river valley and waited. We were a good walk from their cave and all around us was desert. Huntara had her spear ready, while I had an arrow attached to my bow, but not drawn. "What are we waiting for?" I whispered.
She shushed me by laying a finger on my lips, and I was a bit baffled about the sudden touch. It didn't feel displeasing, surprisingly, while I felt how my eyes squinted on her finger. I shook off the weird sensation and made a quizzical look, but she didn't look at me. Her gaze was fixed at a hole on the other side of the shallow depression.

Suddenly, two mongooses scurried out of the cave and watched the surrounding. Huntara pointed at me and then at the right one, while she was slowly raising her spear to aim at the other. I cautiously drew and waited for her sign. The mongooses still hadn't noticed us, were looking into another direction, when Huntara tsked and threw her spear. I let go of the arrow, and both weapons hit at the same time. Unluckily, my arrow missed the

lucky one by just an inch, while Huntara nailed her little carnivore at its center.
“Dammit,” I muttered. My miss earned me a chuckle and a hard pat on the back. “Better luck next time, Blondie.”

We repeated our ambush by just waiting and waiting until the other mongoose finally peeked out of the hole again and was also impaled by Huntara. I didn’t even manage to draw my arrow, so fast was she.
When we walked back to her shelter in the morning light, constantly hopping over little clefts and avoiding depressions filled with sand, I watched her from behind. She always knew exactly where to go, and didn’t hesitate a second to find her way.
“How do you even know where you are? Everything just looks the same here,” I finally asked.
She chuckled darkly. “This is my home turf. Huntara can track anything in the desert,” the buff woman said. Her manner to speak of herself in third person was irritating. Maybe living on her own out here just made her like that, I pondered. But then again, I found her whole presence and attitude weirdly captivating and noticing that, I had something else to ponder about on our way back.
At the cave again, and with the same, merciless sun weighing down from a blue, cloudless sky, the day became as hot as before. We didn't do much, beside gutting the mongooses and grilling them. Other than that, we just laid around lazily, only occasionally tending to our tools and weapons. I didn't even think about leaving.

The day after, we went hunting mongooses again, and this time I nailed down two of them in turn. Huntara whistled appreciatively. “Huh, not bad, Blondie. Give it some time, and you’ll do well here.”
I wave dismissively. “Haha, thanks. I appreciate your trust in me, but I would’ve been lost without you.”
“Don’t think so low of yaself,” was all she answered while eyeing me with an assessing look. At least I thought it was.

That routine continued for the next few days, as we settled in something like an amicable silence and mutual comfort after getting used to each other. We woke up, we went hunting, usually got something, then we dozed during the heat of midday and cooked a meal in the evening. I didn't neglect my exercises, made them in the morning before the heat of the day, and all in all it was uneventful, quiet and beside the occasional gathering of firewood, we hadn't much to do. Water was right in front of us, and I quickly understood why she kept it clear. Without the water hole, she, we could not have lived here.
Nobody discovered Huntara's little hideout and disturbed our silence, and so we were completely alone. It was weird to have so much time just for myself. Sometimes, I felt guilty while I just laid and dozed or when we played throwing games with stones and sticks before the ledge. But when I thought about the source of my uneasiness, I always landed back at a voice scolding me that I didn't want or had to hear anymore.

Today we had luck with the hunt as I shot down an antelope. It would feed us for more than only a day. While we sat at our small fire and roasted a good part of the meat, I again shared my salt with her, and she went off to rummage between her stocks.

"Look what I've found!" she called and held out a bottle. "What's this?" I asked.
Huntara chuckled. "Oh, some booze. It's a leftover from a trade. I'm not into drinking without company, yer know? Too depressing."
I wouldn't have thought she was a drinker anyway. She was much too composed for that. "Oh, yeah, I see." I peeked over at her. "I'm not so fond of drinking alone, too. But in good company?"
"Catch it," she laughed and threw the bottle over into my lap. I opened the wax cap and took in the smell of what obviously was the rich and sweet flavor of red wine.
"You like sweet wine?", I asked her after taking a small sip, offering it back to her.
Huntara poured a large gulp into her mouth, then wiped it. "Oh, I like a lot of sweet things."

I knew I tilted my head and had a frown on my face, while trying to make out what was behind her words. Then, suddenly, I remembered the evening with Catra, back at the tavern in Maidum. And all of it trembled down on me in a single strike. Back then when Catra got me drunk. When Catra kissed me. When I kissed Catra back. How her brown curls had been so near, so near, so near that they'd touched my face, with her pretty, pretty face right before me. When everything had been so bright and happy, so likeable… so Catra.
And suddenly, out of nowhere, I started crying.
The tears just poured out of me, because I realized that I hadn't thought of her for the whole day, every feeling had been clouded by the quiet routine that I'd adapted to so quick and easily. Deep, elongated sobs escaped my chest and I couldn't stop them.

I cried, and everything I knew was that I wanted her back.

Huntara looked at me and was blatantly astounded while witnessing my outbreak. She just sat nearby, the bottle still in her hand, and looked lost, unsure what to do with herself now — or with me.
I crouched down at the ground, buried my head between my hands and arms and sobbed against the fabric that turned wet to muffle my crying. The image of Catra, laying beside me after, before, during our mutual night back then in Alexandria, hit me with full force. She'd been so gentle with me, every move and every touch of her had been caring, showing her love for me. Beside our mutual awkwardness because of it being so fresh and new, the whole night had been pure bliss. In hindsight, I realized how big the part was that this played in opening a part of my personality, of my thinking, of my sexuality that I'd never even considered it was there until *her*.
Her hands had trailed my body, touched me in places nobody else had ever touched me before, and all of it had felt *right*. Gone had been the hesitation about her being a woman, about letting myself being touched by a woman, or at all. I hadn't questioned it or even the entire fact of finally letting myself go, handing me over to this woman for to take care of me. Her head had rested on my stomach afterward, and she'd kissed my tits while

snuggling, cuddling, feeling, taking me so well. The memory of her diving…

No! She'd done all that. All that.
Only to betray me the very day later.
Half a day later, I sneered to myself, while my tears still fell down. *To her bitch sister.*

Now, only now, I allowed myself to think of Cleopatra like that. From an outside perspective, I thoroughly understood her actions. But here, on my own, free of the influence of others and of all the pressure of the *expectations* of others, I cursed her for her plotty scheming and all the misery she'd brought upon my life.
Together with the rest of my family, I not too cheerfully reminded myself of. *It's not like that your father and your uncle hadn't had their hands in this game. Fucking patriarchy, selling me off like cattle. Damn bastards.*

Thinking that, *wanting* to think it, I realized how far my former restraints had been gone, lifted, washed away due to the effect of one simple night with Catra. *Or the entire time with her. But she wasn't there anymore. I drove her away. It had to be.*
Pulling myself out of my desperation, I straightened and called at Huntara: "Give me that bottle! We've got something to celebrate." I held out my hand, demanding her to hand over the jar with the alcohol. Getting lost was what I needed now. It was what I wanted now. Being able to forget about *her*.

Huntara hesitated, still bewildered about my sudden breakdown, and didn't follow. But after a while — and after we'd filled our gut with deliciously roasted and seasoned antelope — I snitched the bottle out of her hands and took several large gulps. The liquid burned like fire in my throat. "Uaagh! That is… disgusting, really," I spat out right before taking another large sip. She chuckled. "Hold back. This heavy wine isn't for the faint of the heart, Blondie. You're not used to it."
"Hah!" To underline my stupidity, I took another swig and gulped the awful stuff down.

Slowly, warmth spread in my stomach and only half an hour and a lot of passing-the-bottle later, I was completely drunk. Every now and then, I burst into a fit of laughter, as if whatever Huntara just said was the funniest thing I'd ever heard.
"You have some pretty impressive muscles, big lady," I slurred, and poked Huntara's upper arm. It was ridiculous to touch her like that, but I felt so nice, so easy, without all the usual restraints that would've made me stutter and behave oh-so-well-mannered. Nope! I grabbed her arm with both my hands and squeezed them. "Yup! Pretty strong! As I said. Feels good."
If I hadn't been so wasted, I might've noticed her assessing look. "I think yer've had enough," she finally said as she wriggled the bottle out of my clumsy hands. Hey! That was my bottle! "Give it baaack," I yelled and clung to her arm. When she withdrew, I fell forward and stumbled against her chest, sending us both down on the ground. Coming to rest on top of her, Huntara was frozen, looking at me with narrowed eyes, but didn't say any word. Her hands were at her side, raised defensively, but she didn't touch me and looked rather a bit helpless.
Somehow, the warmth of her body felt comforting. Her hard contours were in no way comparable to *her* softness, but the contact of another human body alone was so nice. "This is so nice," I mumbled, drunken, embarrassing myself, and still…

Catra.

"Sorry, sorry," I mumbled, rolled off and came to rest beside her, looking into the sky, and noticed the sound of someone who giggled dumbly. It was probably me. Everything was so fuzzy, and the stars seemed to draw circles. I barely noticed that Huntara got up and went into the cave without saying another word. For some time I just laid there, in the sand before the cave, her cave, sometimes giggling over myself, sometimes about the whole fucked-upness of my life that had completely and utterly gotten off track.
But somewhere, in the back of my mind, a thought lurked and sparked, spread out and occupied my mind until I fell asleep just where I laid.

Dawn was approaching, and unlike the days before, Huntara had not awakened me. Instead, she was not to be seen, and I found myself still lying in the sand in front of the cave with a bad taste in my mouth and a ghastly headache. Perhaps I had also drooled a little. Sitting up, I wiped my mouth, tried to wash down the bad taste with a little water. That only worked halfway.

But for the first time since weeks, there was clarity in my mind. It seemed that last night had given me the needed push to get over my still not fully processed feelings, intentions, my sulking even. Or the fuzziness. I knew I had to speak with Catra, that I needed a final talk, between us, and sincerity about what she would do. And what I would do when I saw her. Was she still loyal to her sister, or would she stick with me? I had no idea *how* to do it, *how* to speak to her without the danger of being captured, but at least I knew where I had to go from here. A plan I had not, but I should be able to improvise one along the way.
And despite being here — with Huntara — had given me a resemblance of peace, last evening had also been a strong reminder, that my feelings for Catra would always be in the way of getting further, getting over it.

Huntara wasn't in the cave and nowhere around, she'd obviously gone hunting while I was sleeping off my drunkenness. I decided to pack my stuff and wait until her return, owing her a proper apology and explanation before leaving. As it was her habit, she finished her hunt long before noon for to doze over the hottest hours of the day. When she approached the camp, she immediately stiffed when she saw me sitting before the cave, my backpack beside me, obviously dressed and prepared for leaving.

She came to a halt before me and eyed me with a reluctant smile. I just smiled back, sheepishly. "I'd already figured that out," she

finally growled. “There was always something going on in the back of yer mind. I just didn’t think that yer were in love.”
I felt quite caught, then tilted my head slightly. “You’re not the only one who’s surprised. I can assure you.” Surprisingly, it came out a lot lighter than I thought it would.
The buff woman huffed, and pulled a corner of her mouth. “Didn’t take you for the romantic one.” I only nodded with a weak smile, whereupon she shrugged her shoulders. “It is a pity that yer’e moving on. Ya’ve been a good companion.”
Out of a whim, I stepped forward and hugged the tall woman. It caught her off guard, but then she overcame herself and patted me on my back a few times while I muttered: “Thank you for everything.” Our parting was a little… awkward, but I finally managed to say: “I’m sorry for last evening,” I clumsily pressed out. “I know it was a bit too much.”
“It’s alright, Blondie.” Her face was calm, maybe with a hint of regret on it, and I saw how her jaw worked. She thought about more words, then said: “There’s a place for yer here. In case you need it.”
Her open words drove me to a few tears, but I didn’t want to fall into another awkward hug, and after a deep breath, I just held out my hand. “Thank you. Who knows the ways of the Parcae[118]. But, it… it means a lot to me.” She took my hand with her large paw, and we held the pressure for a moment, looking at each other.
This time, it wasn’t a game of power, but of assurance.

“Take care. I will miss you.”

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"Tired"** and will be published on Friday, September 3, 2021. With its more than 17,5k of words it will be the longest chapter of this fic.

[108] Egyptian Demotic should not be confused with Greek demotic. The latter one is written with lower case. Middle Demotic was spoken and written in Egypt - beside other languages - from around 400 BCE till Romanization of the

country after 30 BCE. ↕
[109] The name "Xanthos" is a nod to the children's book series "Detectives in Togas", where a teacher holds this name. I think it was reading these books when I was around 9 yo that sparked my interest in Ancient Rome. Now that I'm thinking of them again, I maybe should've read them before writing this story, because these books were rich with details about the actual life of Roman children in the early days of the empire. ↕
[110] Caligae were the heavy-soled and hobnailed sandals worn by the lower ranks amongst Roman legionaries. In colder regions than the Mediterranean, soldiers wore wool socks. It was stated that "the thunderous sound of an attack by a hobnailed army (caligati) must have been terrifying." ↕
[111] Gladius, the typical Roman short swort of the legion, being in use from the 3rd century BCE until the 3rd century CE. In Latin, gladius is a masculine noun and the nominative plural is gladii. ↕
[112] A cingulum militare was a belt on which soldiers could put the gladius and other stuff. ↕
[113] Scutum, the typical shield of a legionary. During the time of the Republic, it had an oval form and evolved into the rectangular form known most as of today at the beginning of the Empire. It weighed around 10kg and was made of two planks glued together. The outer surface was covered with canvas and calfskin, and the edges were strengthened with iron. ↕
[114] This wonderful drawing by JudeTheRagdoll is based on the story, but it has a model which you can see here. The excellent comic series "Yoko Tsuno" is from the Dutch author Roger Leloup, but the best albums have been translated into English (as well as French and German) also. The similarities to She-Ra are vast, as the stories are based on friendship, love and exploring new worlds. They are heavily technology driven. Things like robot dragons, underground civilizations, megacannons, suspended animation, time travel and an alien species called the Vineans are explored. She-Ra's animation reminded me of the Ligne claire style in which Yoko Tsuno is

drawn for more than 30 years as of now. ↥

[115] It is assumed that the population of Egypt of the late Ptolemaic era - around 50 BCE - did not exceed three millions. Around 0 BC, it is estimated for around four million. In comparison, the population of the late Roman Republic would be around 30 to 40 millions and the Roman Empire would reach its height at around 60 to 90 million people. Compared to the enormous land size of the Roman realm, Egypt was much more densely populated. It is also estimated, that at around 100 CE, around a fifth of the world population lived in the Roman Empire. ↥

[116] This is a citation from Alucard in "Castlevania", S01E02. ↥

[117] I'm referring to the Greater Egyptian Jerboa, which has been hunted and eaten by bedouins until recently. ↥

[118] In Roman mythology, the parcae were the female incarnations of destiny, fate. They controlled the metaphorical thread of life of all beings, mortal or immortal. Therefore, they held power even over the gods themselves. The three parcae were Nona, Decima and Morta. Nona spun the thread of life, Decima decided the fate of life and Morta cuts the thread in the end. ↥

Tired

Chapter Summary

"How pathetic, to die in this sordid way."

Chapter Notes

I apologize for upping the chapter count another time, despite I said otherwise. It would've been a 20k word count thing, and that's just too much. Furthermore, I would've exceeded the character max with my footnotes *facepalm*. In return, I will post the next chapter right tomorrow or on Sunday, sooo...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Nile & Buhen, Egypt - June to August 47 BCE

Adora

Although my hideout at Huntara's place had lasted no longer than perhaps two or three weeks — it occurred to me that I hadn't really counted the days and nights — it felt as if months or whole seasons had passed when I reached the Nile valley right before Omboi again. Walking down a path from the dry desert plateau to the lush, green and populated fields beside the great stream that gave Egypt life was the equivalent of a transition between two worlds, a stark contrast trying to overwhelm my eyes and mind. After getting used to seeing only sandy and orange-red shades for more than a fortnight, my eyes were overwhelmed by the myriad of vibrant colors of grain, trees, fruits, and flowers even. The Nile's waters were shimmering in the bright sun, reflecting the beauty of the surrounding landscape. A scent of jasmine and other fragrant flowers wafted in the air, and the sweet taste of ripe fruits that were abundant. It was like stepping into another world entirely.

My next aim would be Syene, but right now I was just happy to splash my feet into the water of the Nile, then shook off my clothes entirely and jumped in. I'd found shelter on a small sandbank between thick reed and wasn't scared to be seen at all. After paddling around for a little while, I got out and let myself dry in the sun, taking in the warmth. Just in my undergarments, I shoveled around some sand, starting to make a sandcastle like a nine-year-old. It was a delight to give in to my childish amusements, and I had to remind myself several times, that there wasn’t a schedule I had to stick to. No one would come and tell me that this was an inappropriate behavior for someone like me, for a patrician, a member of so oh-so-noble gens Julia. Instead and here, it was just me, Adora. Just myself. I could do as I liked, and I grinned like an idiot while I put together a little sand tower for my castle and carefully placed colorful pebbles on it as decoration. My castle needed a gate? I could build a gate too. All of this made me feel alive, awaken, like seeing the world after a fresh rain that swept off the dust.

After indulging in these shenanigans for a good hour, I found myself laid back, still at the sandbank on the shore of the river Nile, just looking into the bright blue sky, while a group of palms spent me a welcomed shadow. Beside the fact, that possibly half the Egyptian army was still going after me, I hadn’t a care in the world. And Catra could certainly wait an hour longer, couldn't she? I felt… happy, actually, and after a little nap, I was refreshed and eased, put on my backpack again, and went on, with all the weight on my shoulders feeling a little more lighter. Maybe a little rest was all I needed from time to time.

Syene was the last of the great Egyptian cities before the first cataract, and Lower Nubia, which marked the end of the current Kingdom of Egypt and of the more fertile parts of the valley. After

Syene, only a few settlements and ancient ruins scattered beside the Nile, and very few people lived there at all. It was often treated as part of Upper Egypt, but actually, Lower Nubia was rather its own kind of land. It wasn't really under the control of the Pharaohs these days, and Kush hadn't claimed or shown much interest either. I was expecting a rougher wilderness, but one I could handle, and where I would finally leave the constant patrols of soldiers behind me.
It would be safer and more dangerous at the same time to wander there, because fewer and more narrow green shores meant fewer places to hide. On the other side, fewer people meant fewer threats. All in all, I was both curious and a little scared of what to expect there.

But that was still a problem for future Adora, because today I strolled through a market in Syene. Colorful booths and stands of the merchants scattered all around the narrow streets in a purposefully crafted chaotic pattern. From my previous visits, I knew that these markets were managed with an extensive bureaucracy behind, keeping watch that everyone paid taxes and followed the rules — whatever these rules might say. It was a wonder it worked, but it did.

What I noticed thought, that so far in the south, the appearance of the people around me was now very different from in the delta. Fair-skinned people like me had been the predominant sight there, and Greeks and Romans had not been uncommon at all. Here, most of the people were tanned, many even dark-skinned, and I barely saw anyone of my origin. All the time, I hid most of my face behind a headscarf that was carefully wrapped around my hair and over my mouth, giving sight to my eyes only. As my skin had tanned visibly over the last weeks, I was relatively sure that I wouldn't be recognized as a Roman at first sight, but I had to be careful still. I was obviously not a local.

The market was overflowing with chatter and bawl by so many voices that I understood only few of them. But I bought two small knives from a blacksmith, and was sure to be ripped off by the merchant, because I wasn't really used to haggle with the

experienced folks. Then I acquired a pouch of salt, herbs, dried meat and fruit, and some oats and stuffed all of them into my noticeable lighter backpack. All the bumpy trades I made only reminded me to learn more of the damned barbarian language Catra spoke so well.
Catra. Gah!
How much I wanted her by my side. How much all of this reminded me of how we strolled around at the market in Pelousion. It had been—
Oh, for fucks sake. No, not again!
I willfully dragged my thoughts away from her and snickered to myself about how my swearing had become better as I adapted to the life I presumably now had. It still felt odd.

A little later I sat beside a ferry pier at the river shore. The sun had already started to set, and I listened to my stomach grumble. I decided to seek accommodation for the night at Elephantine[119], an island that lay in the middle of the Nile, right over there and below the first cataract. The island held a garrison in a fortress, but it was otherwise heavily populated with all kinds of housing — and it had a port. Several small ferry boats made from reeds and driven by young men scurried across the river forth and back, bringing people and goods from here to there.
As I still had enough money, I could easily pay for a room in a hospitia[120] and assumed that I should be safe enough from a discovery there for a night. Honestly, I just bet on my luck to vanish in the crowd of people. But I was so tired from the walk, my feet hurt, and really needed a good night of rest, so my judgement might've been biased.

Despite night had long fallen, I found a brawly tavern in the middle of Elephantine, between narrow alleyways and mostly two-storey buildings. Two women ran it, and judging from the looks and touches they shared every now and then, they seemed to be more than just colleagues. Sitting in a covert corner of the tavern room, my backpack already stored in my chamber for the night, I'd refreshened a little and was now mulling over my dinner. The taller one of the women had served me a delicious looking and

smelling stew, and after a first try, I started to shove it in like mad, even if it was still a little hot. But it tasted even better than it smelled, and so I just couldn't stop myself. The stew was fantastically well seasoned, the vegetables well done without being completely overcooked, and the meat was not just leftover fat but tender muscle one. It was the best dinner I'd had since I ran away, so it was no wonder that I hadn't realized that the tall, chubby woman with a kind face who'd brought me the first bowl stood before my table with another one. She placed it down with a not too hidden chuckle. "It looks like you can handle one more, kiddo?"
My head shot up, and I was still chewing, glancing at her with surely wide eyes. "It's okay," she said. "It's better than to throw the rest away. My pot was nearly empty anyway for today, and dinner time's over. Here, I'll be glad if you enjoy it."
Meanwhile, I'd munched down the stew and was able to reply: "Sorry. But yes, thank you. Your stew is… it's awesome. I seldom ate something better."

She sat down across me and smiled. "You don't look like you haven't eaten better, but thank you for the praise. What's your business at Elephantine, if you don't mind me asking?"
It was easy to tell her my made-up story: "Oh, I'm on a pilgrimage. I promised my ancestors and family to visit the great temples of Hathor along the Nile. It is an offering to the gods to make them merciful so that I can find a husband." It was the exact other way around.
The chubby woman gasped, bringing her hands to her cheeks, but I felt a little mocked by her too. "Don't talk shit, girl. A beauty like you mustn't have a problem to find a few strong and handsome admirers. You're kidding me, aren't you?"
I chuckled and continued with my telltale. "I have a lot of older and younger sisters, and one is more beautiful than the other. They already dug through the marriageable young men in my city before I could, sooo…" I shrugged and raised my hands palms upward to show my despair.

She giggled, obviously not believing me a word, but she also wasn't up to question my little story. It was just too funny. We

chitchatted a little while until her companion shouted something from over the bar, obviously wanting her to come back, but she waved it off. “She’s just being dramatic. And overly jealous sometimes.” The woman leaned forward, with a little mischief in her eyes, and whispered: “She doesn’t like it when I talk to beautiful strangers. I would never flirt with anyone, but it’s just too nice to tease her, you know? She's so easy to rile up.”
Sometimes I was a little slow on the uptake and didn't get what people were really saying when talking about such topics. But this time I understood it immediately. “Ooh. So, you two are…?”
The woman’d folded her hands with elbows propped on the table and put her chin into them. “Yes, we are. Is that so incomprehensible?”
That clearly wasn’t what stunned me. “No! I didn’t mean it like that. It’s just that… I’m not used to women being so… public about it. I’m… still learning…” I fell dry because I didn’t know how to end this sentence. It was a little embarrassing to talk about such a topic with a total stranger. Or anyone at all.
But she must’ve gotten it, because she laid a hand on mine with an understanding smile. “I know women aren’t allowed to be like we want to be everywhere. It isn’t always easy here, either. Sometimes we get hostility, or our choices are simply not accepted by fellows who overstep boundaries. But wherever you are from: no one has the right to force you to do something you don’t want to. It is just as simple as that. What you want is between you and whatever gods you pray to.”

After a moment, I nodded firmly, then the woman stood up and glanced at the bar. “I’ll better look after her, otherwise she’ll throw a tantrum and forces me to sleep behind the bar. That was… unpleasing the last time,” she shuddered. I giggled, but then I peeked at the other bowl, clearly embarrassing myself because of my greedy look, but she took the hint and chuckled amicably. “Go on, eat it while it’s warm.” She hesitated shortly, but added more seriously: “And you might want to hide that strand again.” With that, she turned and went away.
My hands shot to the sides of my face, and really, one of my strands had loosened under the headscarf and hung down behind

my ear. Due to the dying, they weren’t shining blonde anymore, but still bright enough to stand out in close distance. It made me nervous, and I quickly finished my meal. I didn't care too much about the bartender. If she were up to betray me, she wouldn’t have warned me either. She didn’t seem like such a sneaky person, and there was no use in getting paranoid. The loose atmosphere from before was gone, though, and I finished my meal quickly, going to bed right after.
Back in the chamber, it was a weirdly cozy yet lonesome feeling and atmosphere. I sat on the edge of the bed and, somehow, didn't know what to do with myself. I was tired, but the restless energy that'd filled me since…, well, since always if I was honest, didn't let me sleep right away. Too many thoughts twirled around in my head, and it felt pretty tight up there. Like there were too many things going on, over which I had not the slightest influence. My decision to free myself from the ties of my family and heritage had brought me true freedom, but it also brought lonesomeness with it. I was on my own now.
Down, in the tavern, people still laughed and drank with their friends. The noises from the crowd made me even more aware of how lonely I was. I couldn't even sit down with them and show myself. Someone would bring the strange woman already in connection in with the one searched by the governor's men, and that'd be it. Laying back and with these thoughts rumbling through my mind, gratefully the looming tiredness swept over me and put me to sleep.

I slept uneventful till the morning, and was ready to get up before sunrise. The somber mood had vanished with the morning sun, and I left Elephantine when its first rays hit the sandy street to the south, where I started my voyage into Lower Nubia. This part of the land began right behind the city and the cataracts under the always blue, cloudless sky. The Nile rippled and gurgled over boulders and around many rocky islets while I walked past the first cataract. I would need 20 days, that was what I had estimated for my travel until Buhen. It should be manageable, but I would have to walk around 25 kilometers a day, with a merciless burning sun over my head. Water shouldn't be my main problem,

having the largest and only source of fresh water in all of Egypt right beside me. But I would need to buy or gather food to resupply, and the possibilities to do both would shrink out there.

Yesterday, I'd briefly pondered about taking a boat for a faster, more comfortable trip. My conversation with a boy that strolled around at the port quickly convinced me otherwise. "Sure, lady," he squeaked. "There are boats leaving for the small towns upwards, and sometimes even for Kush every other day." He rubbed his head and ogled my covered face. I tossed him a drachma and asked: "Do you know how much it usually costs?"
"Hmm, a few tetradrachmas mostly. It depends on how far you want to travel, you know? Oh, and the fees for the garrison, of course."
"What?" And so my plan was gone.
"Passengers fees, for the garrison," he coughed amused. "The mighty Pharaoh devotes herself to the protection of all the trade routes with her utmost dedication, as my father always says. And of course, a small fee isn't asking too much for that service, is it?" [121] He winked at his words, and I understood immediately. "So, the boats leaving for the south are being searched by the garrison so that everyone pays…"
He nodded casually. "Sure. If not for passengers, then because of the export taxes. We don't want our benevolent government to lose any revenue, won't we?" His anew winking reminded me to be less tense so as not to draw attention to me. I huffed in a playful response, but also knew that I couldn't take a boat, at least not from here. Damned Egyptian bureaucracy. Despite, I asked: "Any recommendations about a boat? Do you know someone reliable? Such an observant kid as you clearly knows someone." He gave me two names, I thanked him and retreated, not intending to look for them, feeling his gaze wandering over me while I walked away for maybe a bit too long. But maybe I'd just been an interesting diversion during his day.

So, another walk it was, I'd thought, as I turned towards the street to the south.

It wasn’t as if everything changed suddenly after I passed the last foreshores of the cataract. The most visible difference of the surrounding was that the fertile shores of the Nile weren’t a broad, continuous tract of land stretching wide into the landscape anymore. Instead, only narrow strips, sometimes with a width of only a field was all that was. Again and again the desert reached right up to the river, the stony rock plateaus even touching into the water, where the stream had cut through them ages ago. Only small settlements, mostly just a few, sometimes up to two dozen houses were all what accounted for a village here.

While I walked and left the populated lands of Upper Egypt behind me, I pondered about what to do when I approached Buhen and — hopefully, fearfully — met Catra. How could I even be able to talk to her without being in danger to be captured? Buhen was heavily fortified, rather a fortress than a town, that much I knew from the stories she’d told me during our journeys. There wasn’t a possibility to enter the city or approach her house or wherever she lived without being noticed by the gate guards. And a tall, strange woman coming from the desert would clearly attain their attention, given the fact that maybe only one or two dozen travelers, merchants mostly, would reach the town over the course of a day at all.

And behind the problem of “How to reach her” lay the more terrifying “What to say to her?” I knew I wanted to ask her if she still stood by her decision she’d made back in Alexandria, when she so uselessly complied with her sister. Had it been worth it? Given her tries during the journey to Thēbais, she regretted it, and I felt a bit ashamed of how I'd treated her then. I knew I had been, at least somewhat, unfair to her, but I also still thought that her regret wasn’t enough. She could regret it all day long, if she would act exactly the same the next time. How could I trust her that she wouldn't take me prisoner and hand me over to her sister or my uncle again? How could I trust her at all?

I had no answers to all these questions while I made my way along the Nile. Before I realized it, Syene was already three days behind me, and the valley was just a narrow strip in the landscape of the surrounding, vast desert that stretched until the horizon. It only provided a few places to settle, mostly just a few acres of fertile land between the rocky shoreline. Not many people lived here, and the further I got, the fewer people I met.

("Pilgrims", Deezer / Spotify / YouTube)

The next day, the sky had gone cloudy, which alone was a rare view, and the humidity of the air seemed to have increased. A gentle breeze with an unusual chill had set in. And then, for the first time since I was in Egypt, I felt raindrops falling down on me. The gray clouds passed slowly, and it wasn't really raining. It was… drizzling. There were soft, fine raindrops, barely palpable on my skin.
Looking up, I held out my hands and tried to catch a bit of the welcomed wetness, to rub the water over my face and head. In a ridiculous attempt to taste the rain, I laid back my head and stuck out my tongue. Then I giggled to myself and wondered if I would get even more weird over time, with all the loneliness. I felt free, though, and it was a deeply satisfying sensation.
The drizzle lasted only for a quarter of an hour and wasn't even enough to soak the soil, but nonetheless, it was a refreshment to wash off the dust and sand from the day.

And the following night was marvelous. An absolute clear sky, devoid of any cloudiness and any human lights, showed the neverending vastness of the star-studded, nightly firmament. It was as astounding as it was intimidating.

My teacher in the natural phenomena and philosophy, back in Antiochia, had explained to me the different theories and ideas of the philosophers about what these lights and the sky itself should be.
His and mine favorite thought and theory was that they were stars like our sun, far, far away, maybe harboring worlds like ours. We knew about the spherical shape of our world for centuries, and

while the majority of the natural philosophers said that everything beyond evolved around the earth, in his opinion just one look in the night sky rendered this thought absurd, ridiculous even. “If all this would be revolving around our earth, that'd be unbelievably egocentric. I can't fathom that thought”, he said. I couldn’t even think about to contradict. The idea alone of other worlds, like ours, made me speechless every time when I looked above in the nightly sky.

Some ancient Greek philosophers explained the idea of the Earth revolving around the sun, together with the other nearby stars that behaved differently from the far away ones: Mars, Venus, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury. We’d discussed this topic more than once then. “Aristarchus of Samos was the first one to propose a model of something we can call a solar system. He placed the sun in the center of it, with earth and the other nearby stars evolving around her.”
“But Aristotle said—” I'd tried to interject and impress, but was cut short by him with a playfully arrogant tone: “I know what he said. But he wasn’t an explorer of the mechanics of heaven. He was a logician, and is rightfully mentioned to have laid the grounds for most of our modern sciences. But Aristarchus thought about the needed mechanics for a long time. According to Aristotle himself, he said, *that the fixed stars and the sun remain unmoved, that the earth revolves about the sun on the circumference of a circle, the sun lying in the middle of the orbit, and that the sphere of the fixed stars, situated about the same centre as the sun, is so great that the circle in which he supposes the earth to revolve bears such a proportion to the distance of the fixed stars as the centre of the sphere bears to its surface.”*

I laughed at my former self that had needed another hour and several drawings in the sand to get the full implication of these words. Because what Aristarchus had actually suggested — beside the Earth not being the center of our universe but revolving around the sun — was nothing less than the idea of a perhaps infinitely large universe, with all the sparkling stars above us being other suns, with maybe even other worlds. And that idea stuck to

me ever since. We were small beings, regarding that. It actually eased me a bit, despite not really knowing why.

The next days went by in a blur. All the walking slowly started to take a toll in my body and mind as well. I passed the little settlements and villages one by one, and seldom talked to anyone. Only when I wanted to buy some goods, a conversation was necessary, but beside that, I tried to keep a low profile and expose my face as few as possible.
My initial excitement over my escape and decision to look out for Catra had worn down to some mix of boredom and desperation, because this trip seemingly had no end. It was the same sight every day: a river in the middle, some fields left and right and beside that, desert. And nothing else.

"I'm so tired," my first thought was as I woke up. As always when I did now, the sun hadn't risen yet. It was dawning, just a slightly lighter line at the horizon. "Maybe I can stay here for a day, to rest and draw new strength," I talked to myself while fumbling with the laces of my boots.
And it was true. I had no schedule, no timetable to stick to. I could rest for a day if I just wanted to.
But deep down I feared that I would lose my courage to meet Catra, if I stopped now, and if only for one day. Marching kept me from pondering too much, the constant endeavor of putting one foot before another taking enough of my mind. Still, I had no clue how to safely approach her.
"Up with you, you lousy fool," I encouraged myself and met the same routine as before, not knowing that everything would change today.

I'd been walking on the outermost path along the western edge of the cultivated parts of the Nile dale. To my right side lay nothing

but the Sahara, the largest desert we knew, impenetrable for humans. Actually, I was a little frightened by the vastness of it. Before me lay another small settlement, only half a dozen houses made of the so common adobe bricks, scattered between a few fields. And I should've maybe paid more attention to them. They were in a desolate condition, some of them already half-covered by sand, swallowed by the ever-advancing desert. In hindsight, I also should've stuck to my usual behavior of having my bow and arrow ready when walking through something that looked like a possible ambush.

Only that I wasn't paying any attention at all, because of my fucking ruminating. The monotony of my hike had made me inattentive. The receipt for my inattentiveness came promptly, when I trudged around the corner of a ruined house and found myself being confronted by three rather messy and dangerously looking men with long knives in their hands. Their clothes were dirty, as if they hadn't washed them for some time, but their movements were trained. *Former soldiers, deserters perhaps.*

I was yelled at by one, two of them, and didn't understand any of it. The tallest one in the middle spoke a dialect I didn't even remotely knew. I raised my hands in a defensive gesture, and took a step back, but was only charged and yelled at all the louder.
Their intentions were of course clear. I cursed myself for running into such a stupid, totally avoidably ambush. My constant walking under the sun, without anything happening, had made me unwary. I was at a serious disadvantage, the bandits were much too close to be taken down by bow and arrow — even if I had them ready.
And a dagger fight with three attackers? Not a very good strategy. I wasn't trained enough for that.

My breathing fastened as my heartbeat had already, and the same moment all three charged forward. I took another step back, my hands still raised. "Okay, okay! I'll give you what you want," I called and fumbled at my belt where the purse hung. My felt my heart racing, while I loosened the knot with which it was tied. But

I didn’t dare to take my eyes off of the three men before me. One of them waved with the dagger, with a greedy look in his eyes and way too excited for my taste.
Finally, I handed the beautifully crafted leather pouch over by throwing it to the tall one who had yelled at me. Immediately, I raised my hands again and tried to assess if the outlaws were satisfied. Still, my heart pounded. *Please.*
The tall man looked into the pouch and grinned at the sight, while I tried to swallow my anger. Then his smile went even more devious as he pointed at my backpack, and then to the ground. The gesture was unmistakable, and it only drove me to make a few further steps back.
That was… just evil. They couldn’t have my backpack, with all my stuff. Food, water, knives, salt, my clothes.
No. “Wasn’t the money enough, you bastard?” I called out loud. “That’s stuff I need to survive here. What do you even want with women’s clothes?”
He didn’t understand my words, but of course what I meant. However, again, he pointed at the backpack and then down on the ground, and I began to panic. They couldn’t have it. Without my stuff *and* money, it would be close to a death sentence for me out here.

I was on the edge of turning around and running, when I felt a sharp pain hurting my left side from behind. Two of the bandits began laughing. I tried to turn, but my legs were suddenly so shaky. Touching my side with my left hand, while still looking at the grinning men, made me realize that it was smeared with red.

Blood. Shit.

It dripped from my fingers and a moment later, my legs gave in. Tumbling down to the ground, I fell to the side and came to rest, half-buried below my backpack. My side hurt. Only now I noticed the other man, standing behind, over me, holding a dagger in his hand. A bloody dagger. My blood. There were four of those bastards. Of course there'd been one in my back, I idiot.

The bastard had stabbed me from behind.

My vision got dizzy, and I felt so weak. The straps of my backpack kept me at the ground. When I pressed my hand against the side, the warmth of my own blood oozed between my fingers. That wasn’t good. Too much, too quick. My mind raced as fast as my heart. I had to press the wound shut, otherwise—

Something was pulling at me, and I rolled over and suddenly looked at the sky.
The sky is so gray, so dark, I thought while coming to a rest on the ground. *Why is the sky so dark? It had been so sunny.*
Someone yelled. At me? What? I should have pressed the wound, but my hand felt so limp.

Maybe it didn’t matter so much.
Maybe it wasn’t so important anymore.

My hand fell to my sides, all strength gone.

I spluttered, coughed. *Ow.* My body didn't listen anymore.
Making it thus far, only to be stabbed in the back. Never would've happened to Huntara. Ugh. That really hurts. It hurts. Hurts. How pathetic, to die in this sordid way. What a messed up… What an… Ugh. Ow!
My thoughts were so incoherent, as it went darker and darker.
At least, all my problems regarding Catra are solved.

It's… okay. Ugh. I'm tired anyway.

Catra

“Believe in it,” Bow had said.

On my way to Buhen, his words kept coming back to me again and again. I hadn’t been in a hurry to achieve my destination. Why the fuck would I even? On the contrary, I gave myself rather

plenty of time. Instead of taking a boat from one of the garrisons — I still had the Pharaonic seal and I still was a governor, even if only of a forsaken outpost at the end of the world that wasn't any longer needed by anyone and clearly not by Cleopatra — rode by horse and took my time. The most evenings found me in taverns, drinking too much and way too often. When I stumbled to wherever I'd found an accommodation, I was frequently wasted as shit. Every morning I wondered how many nights I could go on like this. The answer always was: one more night.
I more often than not got up late, sometimes only around noon, and all in all I needed two weeks to just reach Syene. On my way down from there on the boat — a lifetime ago as it seemed — we'd done that in two days. Had it been two days? My memory was a bit blurred, admittedly, because there were so few times when I wasn't drunk these days.

"Believe in it."

Laughable. Ridiculous. There was nothing to believe in. Adora was gone, she probably hated me, and was right to do. I was on my way to the end of the known world, and if Cleo would call me back some day — I didn't even know if I would have it in me to follow her call. Going to Buhen was actually an easy way to cope with all of that, to deal with the deeply settled feeling of what a mistake I'd made.
Maybe I was already doomed to spend the next 20 years of my life ruminating about the love of my life, trying to convince myself that giving in and not fighting Cleo back harder had been worth it. Because today, right now, I was convinced it hadn't been worth it.
And I hated myself for it.

I arrived at Buhen another week later, and lot less drunk. What perhaps saved me was my tiredness of another exhausting ride. When I finally reached Syene, I was so wasted that I quickly decided just to take a boat from here on. With the rise of my little settlement, every other day at least one ship sailed there, bringing goods and some travelers to my beautiful, yet very limited realm. I'd bartered with the load master of the captain for a transfer and

funnily, nobody on board the ship recognized me as the soon-to-be-again governor of the southernmost Egyptian outpost. One evening, I overheard a conversation of two passengers who talked about Buhen - and pricked up my ears when they crossed the matter of its crazy female governor and of settling there, because she was doing so well despite she was a weird bitch going for the throats of thugs and bandits. But she did her duty to the town.

Oh yeah, I did my duty. Just not to the woman for whom it would have been important.

We arrived at the port of Buhen in the morning under a cloudless sky, promising another scorching hot day. I trudged off the boat in relative clarity, because somewhere between Syene and Buhen the captain's supplies of booze had run dry. *Idiot*, I muttered to myself. *What a captain hasn't enough to drink on his boat?* Or maybe he'd just hidden his good stuff from me. Anyway, my head still hurt, and I was still exhausted.
When Buhen's port master saw me, he perked up with a frown and rushed to my side, bowing before me. The man served as master of the post office and as tax collector as well, because there really wasn't much to do about all three of the jobs I personally had handed over to him. His show of respect made the other passengers look strange, but I didn't care. This was my territory now, and that was all the more clear when he called: "My lady! Why— There was no word that we should expect you back!" I slowly waved him off. The sun was much too bright for my taste, and the man of course too excited about seeing me. "It's alright, Aahmes," I sighed and waved him off. "I hadn't informed anyone about my return, so just don't make a drama out of it." Behind me, my fellow travelers were waiting to check in with him for being allowed into the town. I just wanted to go somewhere inside, adding, "I'll find my way."

He threw me a quizzical look, not willing to let me go so easily. “Shall I call for someone? You don’t look… good, with all due respect, your grace.” Again, I noticed the quizzical glances from the other people that only now realized that the weird, messy, secluded and sometimes drunken woman they'd journeyed with had been someone important.

A weak smile formed on my mouth: “It’s fine. The trip from the delta was long. I’ll take a nap. Maybe two. We’ll see tomorrow.” He didn’t seem convinced, but was in no position to make me do anything, and so he just clapped his hands while turning to the other people, calling in a sing-song: “Welcome to Buhen! Clearance for goods and livestock, letters back to home and recommendations for our best and only guest house you’ll get from me! Come on, come on, line up here and show our benevolent ruler your most decent side! Yes, sir, I'm speaking to you!” He pointed at a middle-aged man who stood behind me with an open mouth, shooting glances between Aahmes and the grumpy woman in front of him.

I snickered lowly upon Aahmes' antics while I walked away. The lively man had truly been the perfect choice for this position here, and had proven my decision right every day since. He was just ideal to greet new citizens and travelers with his friendly and funny way. Again I was regarded with odd looks, now from the guards — my guards — when I approached the huge gates, but I wasn’t in the mood for a conversation and just nodded at them. As I walked through the city, I was clearly leaving a trail of amazed people behind me, but I couldn't care less.

Looking around made me aware how far all the works had flourished. Many more houses had been freed from sand and gotten back in use. Little gardens, watered via small canals that had been dug and bricked through the whole settlement, were flourishing, and there were even a few new palms here and there. People bustled about, the market was filled with merchants and visitors who came from far to trade. You could literally feel the small population bursting with energy to move this place forward.

All the progress should've made me proud of the work my people and I had made.

Only that I didn't really care.

Weaving through the market, I finally found the central yard before me. It was as sandy as before, but in pristine condition. Only a few people walked here and there, but before the governor's rooms on the other side and under the canopy where my table stood was a small line of attendee. One of my two advisors sat there, taking in the complaints and questions from our subjects. The middle-aged, muscular woman was reading a scroll, and I strolled over to her comfortably. "Well, well, are you missing me so much that you imitate me?" I teased. Her head shot up in surprise and her voice was way too high: "Your ladyship Catra! Whoa! I hadn't—" She stopped, cleared her throat and tried to continue much cooler: "Of course not. It's just nicer here outside."

I chuckled and smirked. "How are things going? It has been a while since I read the reports."
She frowned, then nodded at me with a knowing smile. "Or written back, not to mention that." Her answer held only the slightest hint of scolding. Normally, she was far too nice to say anything bad at all.
"Yeah, yeah, I know. The events down in the delta had been… strenuous, to say the least," I justified myself, even though I didn't have to.
"I assume, everything has sorted out in your… favor, then? Come on, tell me something!"
"How do you come to that conclusion, you clever woman?"
She shrugged her shoulders. "You're back. I mean, even we heard that Cleopatra has taken over the throne. And that she's sided with the Roman."
"Yeah, of course," I admitted. "So yes, she won. I'm back. Nice story, right?"

She tilted her head and eyed me carefully, then took me by me arm and pulled me a few steps to the side, out of hearing range

from the other bystanders. “You are looking… tired, to put it that way. How about if we continue this conversation after you took a handful of sleep?” Not waiting for my answer, she clapped her hands, whereupon a servant showed up and took my bag as Shoshan ordered: “Ready a bath for her ladyship. And her bed. She shall not be disturbed until evening.” Turning to me, she asked: “How about a little welcome-back-dinner tonight? Maybe I can even avert Amenemhet to partake,” and grinned.
Her kind care took me a little out of my self-pity, and I gratefully replied: “Gladly.” Then I followed the servant into the bath, went into my bed afterward, and fell asleep instantly.

The next few weeks went by in a dull but task-filled haze. My people'd done their jobs mostly well, Amenemhet had been busied with rebuilding his temple, our first harvest had been brought in and the populace of Buhen grew. The few hundred from the time of my first arrival had meanwhile grown to over fifteen hundred. Only one major raid by nomads had taken place, and the garrison had been able to fend it off without losing someone. All in all, I could’ve been content with my works. If it hadn’t been for the empty hole in my heart and the never-ending bleakness that covered my whole being since… since… since this special day back in Cleo’s fucking throne room.
Still, Adora’s scream echoed in my mind. Nothing had changed about that. Nothing’d really bettered my mood. And so my falling apart was a slow process.

In the evenings, I still drank too much — a behavior that didn’t stay unnoticed.

At an informal dinner with my councilmen, I ruined myself, got scolded by nearly everyone, yelled back and finally made an idiot out of me by threatening everyone with punishments beyond sanity. Embarrassment over puzzled looks and shaking heads drove me into my chamber where I collapsed, flopping down on the bed and found myself still drunken and fully clothed in the middle of the night. The next morning I was so ashamed by my behavior, that I took the entire day to patrol in the desert around Buhen. By now it was a completely unnecessary task, because the large watchtowers had been readied and manned weeks ago and let us see every attacker in this forsaken land an hour in advance. But it helped me to clear my mind so that I was nearly able to face other people again in the evening.

Shoshan awaited me in the courtyard on my return.

She grabbed the reigns of my horse when I came to a hold before the stable. Her look was… scrutinizing. "Was it a pleasant ride out there in the desert," she fake-friendly asked, and I daggered her just by staring angrily. Shame and anger were never a good combination, and yet she continued, while I dismounted. "How about a light meal at your desk? With plenty of water, of course." She sniffed, barely visible, and her facial expression went a bit sour. "Maybe after your grace has washed yourself. Thoroughly. You're… smelling."

I sighed, but after sulking and grumbling around for a while I did as recommended, because *even I* couldn't ignore the stink of *myself*. After I'd changed into fresh clothes, I sat down with her at the table before my office, and with a few mugs of water and date juice in my stomach, the whole world started to look a slight bit brighter.

Shoshan had her gaze fixed on the gate at the other side of the yard. After long moments of awkward silence, she spoke up. "You can't go on like this for long, your ladyship." I scoffed, but I did not interrupt, letting her continue. "Perhaps for a month, perhaps half a year. But at some time, your body will break, if your mind doesn't give in at first. Grieving about something you lost, without

setting borders for it, gets you only to a certain point." She pondered shortly. "Believe me, I know what I'm talking about."
I cocked my head and pursed my lips: "That's quite an insight for a simple advisor."
She chuckled lowly, and her voice was hoarse when she continued talking. "How do you think I've been selected for this post? Because of my excellent conduct and my immaculate manners?"
I had it not in me to ask, but my questioning look didn't go by unnoticed.
"Down in Alexandria—" she said, but I cut in because that was new.
"You've served in Alexandria? I had no clue."
A rumble escape her chest. "Ha, of course not, your grace."
I rolled my eyes for the umpteenth time, but I also knew how much of an idiot I'd already made out of myself for not knowing even such important things about someone with whom I'd worked together for so long. "Ugh… how many times must I order you to call me Catra? I'm really done with the *graces* and the *ladyships*."
"At least once more, your grace," she smirked, clearly not willing to give me anything. [122]

"Fine," I grumbled. "Go on. You served in Alexandria and got what, kicked out?"
She shrugged her shoulders and waved her hands, explaining: "Not far from the truth. See, I was a bureaucrat at the royal quarter, overseeing the tax collectors from most parts of Upper Egypt. My career went well, I had influence, a decent income, my prospects were good, and I had a wonderful wife."
I already knew where this story was going, the fuck.
"And one day, she just got sick and died a few days later. Simply that way. There hadn't been something dramatic, no overly cruel fate happening. She just got sick and Osiris took her away swiftly." She heaved a deep breath, but overall, the tonality of her words were composed and calm, like she'd mulled it over a long time ago. "The damn bastard. And after that, I started drinking. Only in the evenings, at the beginning. Quite okay, because I was sober in the morning and did my work still well. But beside work, my life was hollow, and I hadn't it in me to find something new. But I

found more occasions to get a sip. For lunch at noon, for example. And later on, in my office during pauses. And soon the day came when I spilled my meal over the treasurer himself, because I was drunk as fuck during a meeting at his office. He wasn't pleased, I can tell."

I actually chuckled upon the thought, because the treasurer had been a boring old dude who inherited the office from Cleo's father and who hadn't had even one original idea in his lifetime.

"Sorry," I apologized, "but he was…"

"Yeah, he was," Shoshan agreed, knowingly. "And my next station was this nice little position. I was pissed at first, because Buhen is a shithole, but I also knew I deserved it," she admitted and again shrugged her shoulders. "It took me some time to work through it, but finally, I did. And see, working with you, building something here, strengthening the borders of our kingdom… it was — is, actually — a pleasure to serve you. You're a good governor, your grace."

For this first time during this conversation, she turned her eyes to me and firmly said: "At least, when you're not drunk. So, think about how far you're going to go with your grief. Think about if — whoever it is you're mourning about — this person would want you to do so. My wife would not have wanted it for me, that much is sure. She would want me to be happy. What a wife would I be if I didn't honor her even now?"

It took a lot of willpower, but I stuck to water for next days. They went by uneventfully. In the morning, I trained with my men, but we kept it light. There was no sign of a Kushite aggression, we outnumbered every nomad tribe by a magnitude, and with the fortress rebuilt and ready to withstand even a siege, we really hadn't any worries. Our walls were strong, the towers were

manned, and the gates were closed during the night.
During noon, I did paperwork in front of my office, under the canopy as always, talked to the occasional passers-by or someone who complained about something and needed a decision from me. But with the town and people already adapting to it's steady growth, most things sorted themselves out, as always, when times were pretty good. Growth and optimism went hand in hand and despite Buhen was still the end of the Egyptian world, our thriving little community made people happy to live here.

At least, it worked like that for everyone else.

For the afternoons, I'd made it a habit to stroll around the town and stop by the port every few days to watch Aahmes greet newcomers, who unboarded the ships. Had there been one or two a day before, sometimes passing by on their way up and down the Nile, now half a dozen arrived every day, making Buhen a regular stop. After he'd dealt with the incoming travelers, we always went to his office, which also served as a post station, and sorted through the incoming correspondence. [123]
I walked over and leaned into the open door frame. He didn't look up when he said in a strangled voice: "There's a letter from your sister," and held out one formal looking roll with the seal of the Pharaoh on it. I was startled, because I hadn't expected to hear from her at all - and I hadn't written any report to her, leaving that matter to Shoshan, and ordered her to stick to the formalities. The woman neither needed nor deserved any personal talk from me at the moment. It was maybe childish and maybe sulking, but I couldn't care less about her feelings.

"Hmpf," I replied, and he rolled his eyes, waving with the roll a few times and making me grab after it. "Your ladyship is a bit too grumpy for my poor nerves."
"Don't talk to your ladyship like that. Just hand it over, you goofball." He smirked and let me finally fetch it.
I sat down at a stool in front of his office, broke the seal and unrolled the papyrus. As always, Cleopatra was strict to the point, only that the tonality wasn't as playful as it used to be. Instead,

there was nothing but harsh formality transporting the terrifying and exciting news.

Catra, meet me at the 1st of August in Coptos. If Adora is with you, bring her with you. That is an order.
Cleopatra VII.

While my heart started racing, the realization of her words needed a bit to trickle down into my conscience.
What? *If Adora is with me*…? What should that mean? How could she even? I personally delivered her to Hordak's, saw her walking away into his house, and she'd made it absolutely clear how she thought about our future relationship, which amounted to "*absolutely fucking none*". Had Adora somehow been lost? I let the scroll down and felt how my hands got sweaty as I mulled over the implications of Cleo's letter. Adora wasn't with Hordak anymore, that much was clear. And Cleo obviously had no clue of her whereabouts.

And then it dawned on me: *Adora must have run away.*

Before long, I cornered Shoshan in her office and dragged the puzzled woman out towards the southeastern wall for a talk. It face the Nile and because of lack of necessity, only very few guards were positioned here. A good place to speak in private.
"Cleopatra ordered me to meet her at Coptos," I started explaining, "so I'll leave tomorrow. But I have a special order for you during my absence."
Her look got as serious as it got worried as she furrowed her eyebrows, and crossed her arms before her huge chest and lamented: "I already know that I don't want to hear this, right? You're going to get yourself intro trouble, aren't you?"
"Oh, definitely," I laughed. "Because I'm about to explicitly violate a direct order of the Pharaoh. But you mustn't. You will just hide behind *my* order. If you will so."
She scoffed. "As if her grace wouldn't punish me nonetheless and send me on duty to the least forsaken place on the earth… oh, look! Yeah, we're already here. Hahaha. So, your ladyship, please tell me, what can I do to earn the wrath of your sister, so she can

put me on duty here for the rest of my life? I'm so eager to hear your ideas.”

I rolled my eyes, as so often in conversations with her. “Listen. While I’m away, there is a possibility that a tall, blonde woman, my age, is coming to Buhen. If she does, then keep her. Keep her safe and unharmed, but don’t let her go. Do you hear? me? You won’t let anyone catch her or take her away. Hide her from anyone, if necessary, but don’t let her go. Promise her that I will explain everything, if she just stays!"
She eyed me insistingly, and I wondered what went through her mind. “Does this mysterious woman have a name? Not that many blonde women come along here, but it would be…", she wiggled her hand, "you know, good not to imprison the false one.”
I shortly hesitated. I’d kept her name to me like a secret for so long, and couldn’t even remember when I had spoken it loud the last time. But Shoshan was right. “Adora,” I pressed out. “Her name is Adora. Keep her safe for me, if she appears. At all cost."
There was a heartbeat's pause before I pushed myself to beg. "Please.”
If there was a sign of recognition, she did a pretty good job in hiding it. She took her time to answer. “I see. She must be… precious to you, if you’re willing to go against the orders of our beloved and almighty ruler, Catra.”
This being the first time I heard her using my actual name, I was more than surprised. And I didn’t miss the meaning of it. “Thank you. If anyone questions your doing, rely on my order, do you hear me? Don’t play the hero, Shoshan. I command it.”
“Of course, your grace.” She bowed her head, and was blatantly willing to ignore my last order.

Again, I was on my way down the Nile, this time by ship. I hadn’t the intention to get to Coptos before the mentioned date, and if

Cleopatra had to wait one day or two, I wouldn't care, and so be it. So the journey took me one and a half week, because I really didn't try to be faster in any way. It was the 3rd of August, when I finally walked up the stairs of the not overly impressive governmental palace of Coptos, if one could use the word for it. By afternoon on a glaring hot day, and despite having spent half the day just hanging around on the boat that brought me here, I felt already exhausted, like something was draining on me. A few people scurried in and out, obviously flushed and scared by her almighty presence, but then I ran into the most unexpected encounter.
At the archway before the main hall and with my eyes fixed on the ground, I bumped into Adora's companion and beside him, Cleopatra's gentlewoman. Bow and… that Glimmer woman.
"Catra!" Bow yelped, while Glimmer stared at me with intense eyes. I nodded at both of them, but then turned my gaze to Bow, just half to avoid her staring. "I'm… surprised to see you here. How come that you aren't with Adora? When have you seen her?"
He hummed and hawed a little, until I said: "I know something happened. Cleopatra ordered me that I should bring her here, if she'd been with me. But I haven't seen, or let alone heard of her since… since…" I started stuttering when the memory of the last time we met — or rather parted — caught up with me. It was still ashaming.

Bow sighed and closed his eyes in an attempt to gather himself. Glimmer laid a hand on his shoulders while shooting me daggers with her eyes. Still, the guilt of betraying Adora back then was nagging on me. But I couldn't let this annoying girl get under my skin though, and so I held her gaze.
"Honestly, Catra, I don't know if I should trust you," Bow suddenly said. "She has fled Hordak around a month ago, and no one knows where she is."
She vanished a month ago, and I hadn't known? Holy shit, she could be anywhere by now. I studied his face attentively until I replied: "I assumed something like that. And do you know where she went or don't you."
He underlined his statement with a gesture by his hand meant to

calm me. “If I knew, I don’t know if I would tell you, to put it that way.”
“So you don’t,” I assessed. “But do you even have a clue where she might have gone, in which direction? Anything?”
He took his time to answer. “Why do you want to know, Catra? I mean, I remember what I said the last time we met, and that all of this isn’t your fault, but that doesn’t mean that I’m trusting you.”
“Exactly,” Glimmer added, and her cutting tone couldn’t be ignored. Of course, she was behind his wariness.

But I didn't want to fight them. Not here and now. So I sighed. “Fine. Don’t tell me. But maybe you idiots will listen. I haven’t seen her, but I won’t betray her to anyone. She can stay in Buhen as long as she likes, and Cleo would have to take her with force.”
“Which she absolutely will in the end,” Bow replied, “or don’t you think so?”
“Buhen is far away, and under my control. She wouldn’t even know.” It was a bold statement, given Cleo's extensive control over the Egyptian government.
He obviously thought that too, and pulled the corner of his mouth: “Don’t blind yourself. She will know, eventually. I’ve seldom seen or know someone with such an attention to details or more dedication like her. She will clearly keep an eye on you and your doing.”

I sighed. “Adora can’t run away forever, Bow. Egypt is large, but in the end, it’s a stripe of land around one river, and she’s recognizable. She will be caught and then brought back to my sister. Or worse.” I shuddered at the thought. “Do you even know why she did it?”
Bow looked me in the eyes for a long time. “Adora didn’t tell me exactly, but I judged it from some remarks and comments she made.” His face and voice were strangled when he spoke his next words, and I felt it too. “I assume that Hordak pushed her into… consummating their marriage, and it was that what drove her away. She obviously couldn’t stand the thought of being… touched by him. Not after your…” He fell dry, as if he said too much, and maybe he had.

But aside from the jumbling feelings in my stomach, a wave of relief washed over me. A weight was lifted that had sat on my soul ever since we'd parted back in Thēbais. Because despite I didn't know what had happened for real, I knew that Adora must've come to terms with what she wanted and what she was able to accept in the name of her family and her ancestors.
It became clearer and clearer that — maybe for the first time in her life — she'd stood up for herself and denied the demands of her family. And now, half of Egypt was on the hunt for the woman because of that. The woman wasn't stupid. She must've known what she did.
"Thank you," I finally said. "You may not believe me, but I promise you, that if she shows up at Buhen, I'll shelter her." I didn't want to extend the encounter more than necessary, and I also wanted to escape Glimmer's piercing look.

So I turned to the main hall, where Cleopatra sat in a basket chair and made conversation with two seemingly noblemen. And she was looking pregnant as hell. When Cleo noticed me entering the atrium, she quickly ended the talk and complimented her guests out, without getting up.
"Hello, sister," I reluctantly greeted her.
Despite the current state of our relationship, and her condition, her voice was as warm and promising as ever, when she smiled at me. "Catra. Thank you for coming." She gestured to the chair, inviting me to sit down. I pondered about denying it, but it would've been childish. And I was tired. I settled into the wicker chair and silence fell upon us. Cleopatra fumbled with some loose strands of her plaits and hefted her eyes into her lap. I placed my palms on my thighs and knew that I looked stiff and uncomfortable. Finally, I was tired of the quietness and said in a formal tone. "You insisted on my presence. Here I am." Putting an emphasis on my words, she had to get it was her order and not sisterly feelings making me oblige.

She started a little out of her thoughts, and for the first time in a long time she looked insecure. "How's it going in Buhen? I hear that the city is thriving."
Small talk? I could do small talk.

“We’re doing good, thank you for asking,” it came out curtly.
“No more nomad raids?”
“Nothing I would worry about,” and with that I realized, I couldn’t do small talk.
Gratefully, she didn’t press it further.
“Sorry for the short letter.” On a rare occasion, she pondered about her next words. “I know that our last… encounter hurt you.”
I only showed little emotion on my face when I replied: “And you summoned me all the way down here just to tell me that? You could’ve just written a longer letter, Cleo. It would’ve spared me the effort of another travel.” And of seeing you.

She shook her head in denial. “No. I wanted to see you, Catra. I know that it was hard for you. And now it must look like that I forced you to do something that turned out unnecessary in the end, given…”
She fell dry, but I picked up, and my voice was hard: “Given the fact that you even put yourself to the duty to strengthen the Egyptian bonds to Rome?”
Still, Cleopatra did not look me in the eyes, but she nodded. “Yes, I know what it looks like. But—”
“The fuck, Cleo. The fuck. You… Did you really crawl into Adora’s uncle's bed and let him impregnate you while, around us, Alexandria was ravaged in a war both of you ignited? How old is the man even? 50?”
She put her hands on her belly as if to protect it. “It wasn’t like that,” she quietly retorted. “I didn't throw myself around his neck to bunk his support, if that's what you mean. We have a lot in common.”
“In common? What by Pasht do you have in common with him?”
It took her a few moments to consider. Her words were calm when she finally explained. “He’s… he’s an equal to me, Catra, in a world, where only my own brothers are. Or have been. We… we’re pretty similar in that way. He rules the largest realm there is. I rule the second-largest.” Another short pause before she said. “And I actually like him.” [124]
“Of course you do,” I scoffed and didn’t want to dive into the possibility if she actually did it, because it would make it only

worse. “He helped you back on your throne, and Adora and I even helped you to achieve it. We’ve been such idiots to think we would possibly be rewarded with anything small and simple like having *a choice*.”
Now she looked up and caught my gaze for the first time. “You say it like you think I have one. But I don't. Do you really think I have a choice? This throne is nothing less than a burden, Catra. A fucking burden,” she silently said. “It’s not like that, I can just do what I want, when I want. If I let him bed me, then it's because my duty demands it. That I like him is just a bonus.”
“Sorry, *sister*,” and I emphasized the word, “but I don’t believe a word you say.” I got louder. “*You* rule. *You* rule over more than three million people. *Your* word is law. There’s no one in Egypt who’s even safe from you, if you throw a tantrum or just don’t like his nose.” I knew I was getting unfair. Cleo had never used her power on such stupid shit like petty revenges. She’d learned early that such an exertion of her might would only cause resentment and opposition in the long run. Being a god-like ruler had never kept one of her ancestors safe from being murdered, if the whole court was living in fear and wanted to get rid of him or her. The death of her not-so-beloved father was still a bit of a mystery.
To my actual surprise, she didn’t come back, but just bit her lips and looked at me, with her head still slightly bowed. It looked a bit stupid and teasing, nearly…
“Ugh, don’t try that on me. It won’t work,” I groaned when I got what she did.

And with that, the little moment of Cleopatra being shy and vulnerable ended, just like that.
She went all business and straight to the point when asking: “I don’t assume you’ve heard anything from her, have you?”
My answer was deliberately short. “No.”
“Hmm”, she nodded and followed up coolly, not letting me off the hook easily. “You wouldn’t lie to me about that, right?”
“No. And that was low, even for you.” I was starting to get pissed, and she had the nerve to look a bit embarrassed. She could of course send someone to Buhen to control and overlook me, but I could also easily get rid of him and make it look like an accident.

If she didn't want to relieve me of my duty, there was little she could do to get around me.
She knew, I knew, and that was that.
After all, she was still my sister, and I was still hers, and she didn't really believe that I would betray her easily. Only that I totally would.
A few tense moments of silence passed until I finally wanted to know. "Are you really surprised she did it?"
Cleo bobbed her head lightly. "Maybe I shouldn't, I'll give you that. I hadn't even thought about the possibility, to be honest. Nothing in her behavior or any hint anyone said about her indicated that."
I huffed. "Perhaps you should've talked to her a bit more. She clearly had it in her."
"And maybe you provided her with enough reason and confidence to pursue such childish and immature behavior," Cleo snarled back. She clearly made me responsible for Adora's behavior.
I held my head high. "If so, I'm proud of it," I replied and grinned viciously, pondering at which point I would've gone too far annoying her. After all, she was not only my sister, but also the woman who'd repeatedly punched Shait[125] in the face and not only survived it, but also came out of it back on the throne again. She was as dangerous and ruthless as she was capable to underline that with actual power.
"I see. Well, I think it would be for the best if you resume to your post at Buhen for some time. I will take care that the port and southern road of Syene are monitored for the next weeks, but maybe she already got through." Leaning forward, she narrowed her eyes and ordered. "Catra, if she appears in Buhen, you will inform me. We need to find her and remind her of her duties. This little game of hide-and-seek of hers has to stop, before we make a fool of ourselves in front of Rome."

In front of Rome, or in front of your lover, Cleo?

I had no intention to do so, and it was a premiere. In earlier times, I often altered or got around her sometimes too detailed orders and did things just my way. As I always reached the aims

set, she overlooked it, and trusted me to get the things done. This time, it was completely different. Basically, what I was up to, was simple disobedience, military spoken. Only that I wasn't part of her hierarchy and did everything I did just out of loyalty.

And now, I'd reached the end of this loyalty.

"Of course," I lied straight into her face, and didn't hesitate or flinch. If needed, I could be coldhearted to *just anyone*. She sounded relieved, and I felt only a slight hint of guilt. "Thank you, Catra. I know I ask much of you. But it is necessary and for the best of the realm, as pathetic as this may sound. The bond with the Julians will keep us safe and independent, and maybe, within some time, we won't depend on the goodwill of Rome anymore." Her right hand was balled to a fist upon these words.

Back in Syene, I didn't waste any time and went straight to the harbor. A vague unrest had taken hold of me since I left my si- the Pharaoh, and I needed to get back to Buhen. Looking for a ship, I went straight to the uncouth harbor master. As before, I walked by the little boy who earned some coin with guiding travelers and passers-by. I was just about to pass him when a thought struck my mind. *This little boy must've seen much.*
"Hey kid, do you remember the people who pass by?"
He shrugged his shoulders casually. "Sometimes. Some days are pretty busy, others are rather lazy, you know how it is."
"Well, how about you put this overly large head of yours to some good use, then." My words left him unimpressed, but when I started rolling a tetradrachma between my fingers, I quickly had his full attention. "Has a tall, blonde woman passed the harbor? She would've probably been on her way upwards the Nile, maybe

even asked for a passage to Buhen. Within the last four weeks, I would say."
He rolled his head. "Now that you mention it… it was around two weeks ago, perhaps a bit more, when a tall woman asked me for ships that would go upwards the Nile. She looked like she'd been traveling for some time, had a legionary's backpack on."
"How did she look. Did something stand out? What was her hair color?" I felt it, this was something more than lukewarm.
"I didn't catch her hair, because she hid it under a headscarf, as well as most of her face. But I remember her eye color, because they were so pretty." He made a dramatic pause, and I already knew what he was going to say. I knew and despite, I was frightened to ask. "Tell me."
"They were blue. The most beautiful blue eyes I ever saw."

I pressed my lips together. If that wasn't the worst luck in the universe, of all things, there was no doubt. Adora had been on her way to Buhen while I had travelled down the river. My heart pounded, pounded so fast upon the realization, that it made my hands tremble. I grabbed the railing before me to steady myself.
"More than two weeks, you say? She didn't take a boat, right?"
"Not as far as I know. At least not from Syene. She asked about the tax check from the garrison. I assumed that she lacked the money, but when I think about it now, she actually looked too well-dressed for being poor." He huffed. "Maybe she was just wary. The guards can be difficult sometimes, if you don't fit their expectations, you know?" He winked, but I didn't need that to catch the sarcasm.
Yeah, I knew too well. I didn't want to image the problems I would have to deal with, given my habit to travel on my own mostly, if being without the Pharaonic seal. A beautiful, stringy lady with heterochromatic eyes, a wild mane and my manners? I could also just ask for problems. My mind wandered back to the matter at hand. "I see. Any other details you might have? Just spit it out and don't be so sassy. That's my trait."

He smirked, but shook his head in denial. It wasn't that I didn't have enough clues. Tall woman, blue eyes, traveler, legionary's backpack, avoided the guards, on her way upwards the Nile.

There was no doubt. It was her. I had a trail. And I would follow it, without reporting anything to Cleo.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called **"The Forest of Forever"** and will be published tomorrow or the day after.

[119] The island Elephantine is 1,200 meters long and around 400 meters at its widest point. It lays with other islands in the Nile and is seen as the border between Upper Egypt and Lower Nubia. Its name may stem from its shape, which is similar to that of an elephant tusk. Several temples are still visitable. Elephantine or Syene itself may be the location of the “Well of Eratosthenes". With that, said Eratosthenes' is assumed to have made the first calculation of the Earth's circumference, in connection with Strabo’s assumption that Syene lies on the Tropic of Cancer. Have a look here for the whole thing. It’s ridiculous to assume that humankind didn’t know about the spherical shape of the world in the Antique. Of course, we did. ↑

[120] Hospitia is the term for a tavern that also had rooms for guests to stay overnight. Real hotels weren’t known in the Roman world, as only the rather poor folk tended to use them. Noble and rich Romans would seek accommodation with friends and relatives, while officials could just requisition any room of any house owner throughout the whole realm by law for a stay over. ↑

[121] The modern, globalized world has gotten rid of the most import and export taxes and tariffs. Agreements like GATT, the EU single market or the WTO were cornerstones of driving today’s international trade. Today, you can take a commodity from Lisbon in Portugal through Spain, France, Germany to Warszaw in Poland without paying a single border crossing tax. In the 17th century, bringing something

down the Rhine from Basel to Cologne, you would've crossed maybe 20 tax borders in a mere 500 kilometers, hence the high prices of traded goods. Trade taxes had been important incomes for governments until modern times, where they were replaced by income tax as well as the general sales tax (VAT). ↥

[122] You can figure out from where I stole this for yourself. I'm willing to give you a hint: it was Keira to whom it was said. ↥

[123] There was no real postal system in the republican times of Rome, and despite its excessive bureaucracy, even Ptolemaic Egypt only had it for governmental issues, where post was delivered by the police forces from station to station. Regarding this story and the time it is set in, we can assume, that governmental post above a certain level of importance was delivered by messengers from tax offices to tax offices within Upper and Lower Egypt. It is absolutely feasible to assume, that upwards from Syene, no such system was in place, as Lower Nubia was presumably no area where taxes were collected, or governmental services were provided. Single spots like Buhen or other important settlements would have been connected by irregular services, like ship captains or messengers.↥

[124] Given the timetable of Caesar's arrival in Alexandria (end of September 48 BCE) and the birth of Caesarion (23 June 47 BCE), their son, it couldn't have been much time between their first encounter and Cleopatra becoming pregnant. Use this information as you like.↥

[125] Shait is the female name form of an Egyptian goddess (or god, then called Shai) of fate. ↥

The Forest of Forever

Chapter Summary

What have the Pharaohs ever done for us?

Chapter Notes

As promised, here's the next chapter that was originally one with the previous.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Nile & Buhen, Egypt - July, August 47 BCE

This time, I had no difficulties in getting support from Syene's garrison. When I practically kicked in the door of the commander, loudly demanding an escort of four men, horses and supplies, my wishes were quickly fulfilled by an officer of the army who had still been employed by Cleo's father. Now, he was eager to prove his loyalty to the new Pharaoh. Despite what it had cost me, having Cleo's authority behind my every doing was still very satisfying. I smiled to myself with a not too kind attitude. Only an hour later, my little troop was on its way up the Nile. We rode along the narrow stripe of life on the western shore of the river, because it was the slightly more settled one. I assumed, hoped, that Adora would stick to the few scattered villages there, rather than to deal with the even more deserted eastern side. It was a risky assumption, but I had to start somewhere.

We rested for a handful of hours at a farm beside the Nile, and the next morning, we arrived in Pselqet. It was a small town with a temple to some god or goddess from a million years or so ago and some irrigated, fertile land around the town. Maybe two hundred people lived here, their houses and their meager fields spreading around the central temple, and we quickly found the place where the variety of a little market was held in the shadow

of said temple. It wasn't much, just five stands where farmers presented groceries and some of their self-made goods, using the occasional gathering for the talk of the day. When my little party of five dashed into the town in a whirlwind of dust, we certainly added to their talk.
Almost everyone eyed at us with wary looks.
Pselqet was a community of Lower Nubia that wasn't really under the reign of Egypt these days. It was rather self-governed by the occasional landlord — or worse, warlord — and every hundred years or so some precursor of my sister lashed out and occupied the area until the second cataract. Only for his successor to lose interest again, because the effort just wasn't worth it. Because it was a fucking desert. These were not the times of our ancient predecessors, when the realm reached until the fourth cataract so far in the south that it took two months to get there. The times of our great ancient empire were long gone.

I reined in my horse, came to a halt in the middle of the stands, took out a little pouch, held it high and called: "Citizens of Pselqet, listen to me! Pharaoh Cleopatra is sending me with greetings and a mission. I'm looking for a tall woman with blonde hair and blue eyes. Anyone who can tell me something about her will receive this purse of drachmae and earn the goodwill of the Queen of Egypt."
Of course, this was only a mediocre idea. People seldom talked to government officials such easily. I could hardly blame them, because usually, *government* meant *taxes* or *trouble*. So I found myself still at the other end of wary looks. The usual village idiot sauntered by, claiming he had only seen her the day before. A short interrogation revealed his lie which earned him several harsh pushes by one of my men, and after that, no one else spoke up.
I sighed. Maybe that would've been too easy. We made a short pause and I tried to talk to some farmers, but no one'd seen anything, and I didn't really ponder the idea of beating the truth out of them. Instead, I behaved like a decent human being, and we were quickly on our way further up the Nile. This one had been a bust.

An hour and a lot of red dust later, we arrived in a larger settlement that didn't even have a name. Here, I stumbled over a merchant with an interesting story.
When I again held up the purse after calling together the few townsfolk that weren't on the fields, he warily approached me and asked: "Your grace, I don't want to bother you, but may I ask about your intentions with the woman?" His dark-skinned face looked guarded and lacked any clue, when I studied it. He was a well-travelled man, that much was sure.
"Have you seen her?" I ignored his question and jingled with the purse, but he didn't take the bait or gave up easily. "What do you wanna do to her?" he insisted, and his tone carried a certain concern. I weighed the pros and cons about letting my men charge on him, but force was always the first resort of the weak. So I decided to dismount and approached him with open hands. "She's a friend of mine and I… kind of lost her. I know she's traveling towards Buhen, but I have to make sure she's well. This area is not exactly the safest, you know?"
The man scratched his beard and hummed in appreciation. "Yeah, the Pharaoh should really do something about this place. It has become a retreat for bandits and would-be rulers, because nobody cares about this land at all."
I approvingly bobbed my head. "I'm sure, Cleopatra is going to do something about it, when she's established enough — and when she has dealt with the Romans."
He huffed behind his hand he placed over his mouth. "Sure she will," he said, but it sounded sarcastic and disbelieving. "I know about her short-lived interest in Buhen. She only sent her sister there for a year or so, and for the first time in decades it looked like that place got a governor who cared. But as soon as Cleopatra got back on her throne, that woman was also gone again. That's the kind of concern we get from the top of the food chain."

It was kind of amusing and annoying at the same time, that he didn't know who I was. However, I was curious. "What did you hear about Buhen? Is it running well?" I followed up, trying to hide my smirk.
He shortly pondered about his answer. "I think so. It's the only

city until Syene that is secure and that attracts new people. I'm coming from the market there, and if it weren't for Buhen, I would have never gone that far up, I can tell."
I grinned and replied: "So, maybe she achieved what had to be done, and now it's up to the people who actually live here to take care of themselves?"
Again, he scratched his beard. "You're not really wrong, lady, but you're not right either. Buhen might be well now, but all the other towns down to Syene lack a proper government for decades. You've seen them on your way, haven't you?"
This amused me, and I chuckled. "This must be the first time I hear a merchant complaining about the lack of government. You know… that's the guys that make you pay taxes and stuff."
"I hate bureaucracy as much as anyone else", he stated, and looked outright annoyed. "I mean, what have the Pharaohs ever done for us?[126] But even I know that a smart government is necessary for a region to live. Otherwise, bandits and warlords take over and drain and crush everyone beneath them. Taking the trip here is always a risk, missy, and I can't afford an escort like you. Nor can anyone else."

Realizing that over the course of the talk I totally lost the original thread of this conversation, I was willing to cut it short. I reached under my blouse and took out the Pharaonic seal. His eyes pulled wide as he recognized it, then his gaze wandered to me. "And you are…?"
"Let's say, I'm someone on the other end of your taxpayer's money, okay? And my time is precious. So, can you tell me anything about the woman?" I asked, and added a final "Please?", in an attempt to keep it civil. I was on the edge already.
Again, he took his time to answer. "Hmm. On my way down from Buhen, I came through an abandoned village two days from here. Only one old woman lives there still, who bought a few herbs from me. She seemingly took care of an ill person laying inside her hut. I didn't see much, but I remember that her hair was golden. It didn't look like she was going to make it."

My heart fastened. Golden hair. How many blondes could there be in this forsaken place. It had to be Adora. But she was ill, wounded maybe? Oh Isis, please let her be okay.
"The old woman? What herbs did she buy?"
"The usual, to treat someone with fever and pain. They are some of my best-selling goods, actually," he grinned. "She looked like someone who knows how to treat a patient, if that's reassuring you. But keep your hopes low, though."
I made a lopsided grin while screaming inwardly. "Two days from here, you say? On this side of the Nile?"
"Yeah, sure. It's not like that there are any ferries around here. You can't really miss it. There are perhaps a dozen or more old huts and small houses around a meander that had fallen dry a long time ago. You'll know when you see it."
With implications occupying my mind, I pressed out slowly: "Thank you… for… telling me."
"Don't be mean to the old lady, do you hear? She seems to be a bit crazy, talks to herself, and has a really wild look. But she's harmless, and who can blame her for that when she lives there all alone."
I nodded, already turning to my horse again. "I'll do her no harm. I promise it."
The man returned the gesture, and I mounted, waved him a short goodbye and called for my companions to follow me, while I already spurred the stallion. We were out of the village in no time.

I had a goal. It had to be her. It just had to be.

In the afternoon of the next day, I had driven my men and horses to the point of what was barely justifiable in the desert. We were sweaty and tired, and our horses were exhausted. I knew I demanded much of them, maybe too much. But I couldn't contain myself, and instead pushed men and beasts forward for hour after hour under a glazing sun, with only a short night of rest behind us. Adora was ill, presumably wounded, perhaps dying. The thought alone drove me forward.
And so, we only needed one instead of two days to reach the abandoned village that now spread before us. From the viewpoint where we looked down on it, it became clear that the little

settlement had been really unlucky. In earlier times, the Nile had formed a large meander in the flat plain before us, giving life to the sheltered shores hugging the flat slopes of the shallow valley. But decades or maybe more ago, the meander had silted up and cut the village off of its fresh water supply. Today, the river flew more than two kilometers away through a lifeless cut in the landscape, and the once irrigated fields of this oasis had sanded up. The desert since long took back what was hers, and the village had died. Now, only ruins and dunes with an occasional dead palm tree were left. It was an eerie sight of abandonment and loneliness, where only the wind made some noise between the remnants.

We slowed down and fanned out a bit to search for signs of life among the ruins. It was very quiet. As we trudged between the rotten houses, I noticed that there had been much more of them than what we could actually see. Many were covered under dunes, their roofs crumbled under the weight long ago, their structures filled up with sand over the course of time. In a century or even earlier, there would be nothing left to remind you that there had once been a village here, and with it, life.

“Your grace!” one of the soldiers called, cutting into my moody ruminating. “Look!”
He pointed to a hut that lay a bit away, way more towards the Nile, with the rocks of the elevated plateau in its back, shielding it from the desert and most of its wind. Behind a low stone wall, that served as a blocker for sand and sight, a few bushes and two, three palms had survived, maybe because so much nearer to the river the groundwater still fed them. It looked a bit less abandoned than the rest of the ruins, and so I steered my horse over there. The nearer I came, the more it became clear that this lot was still maintained by someone. Inside the walled parcel of land, nearly invisible from the outside, a vegetable garden bloomed, hosting different sorts of plants, herbs, even a few little flowers that withstood the harsh surroundings being shielded by the wall. At the side of the little hut and under the shadow of one of the palms, a wooden bench stood. And on it sat an old woman,

obviously mending something and humming to herself. Her face was wrinkled and her hair ruffled.

I motioned to my men to stay back so as not to startle her.
"Hello?" I not really greeted her, but had no better wording as I approached her between all the vegetables.
She looked up and glanced at me, tilting her head questioningly. I cleared my throat: "Hello. I'm looking for a friend of mine. A blonde woman, on her way to Buhen. A merchant told me—"
"Who are you even? Don't you have any manners, kid?" she snarled. "In my time, strangers introduced themselves properly. And people say my memory is bad," she chuckled, and looked down on her work piece again.
This woman was weird, but she had a point. I stepped forward and crouched down before her. The seal would be of no help here, she clearly wouldn't know or care about.
"My name is Catra, I'm from the royal court of Pharaoh Cleopatra. And I'm looking for a friend. A woman. A merchant from whom you bought herbs a few days ago told me that you take care of a blonde woman. My friend is a blonde, and I worry about her. May I see her?"

The woman furrowed her eyebrows and had a guarded look.
"Catra? I've already heard your name. She often mumbles it when she's dreaming. It sounds that she's afraid of something. Is she afraid of you somehow?"
My heart suddenly pounded so fast that I nearly couldn't bear it. It wanted to jump out of my chest. "She? You mean… Adora? Is her name Adora?"
She knows my name. It is her. It is really her.
"What do you want from her?" the woman asked.
"I… She…" I stuttered and tarried. What did I want from Adora? What did I actually want from her? And what would happen, if I took her with me to Buhen, and then Cleopatra demanded to hand her over? Would I really resist? If I thought about the last weeks and how the guilt about letting Adora down had ripped me apart, I wanted to say 'Yes, of course I would resist'. But would I really go through with it if it came down to it?
"I've done her wrong. But I won't harm her. I… actually I want to

apologize to her. And then it's up to her, what will gonna happen. I won't force her to do anything she doesn't want," I said as earnest as I could.

"Hmm." The old hag set aside her stuff and stood up, using a broom next to her as a support. "She's not awake. The poor girl," she said, and swung the broom a few times to sweep aside the sand outside her doorstep. It looked like a completely mindless, trained action. "She was stabbed by bandits. I've been taking care of her since I found her half dead. Maybe she's still dying. The wound is deep, and my resources to treat them are… limited. This isn't exactly Alexandria." She giggled and continued mopping up. My patience got thinner in the meantime. "Please, I beg you, let me see her. I need… I just need to see her."
Her vivid look pierced me between old and wrinkled eyes. "This isn't only about an apology, dearie, isn't it?"
"What? What do you…" I felt caught out. How could she know? But then I lowered my head and gaze. "No, it isn't. But that's something between me and her."
Again, this piercing look that made me so uneasy. "We'll see, kid." She shoved the curtain hanging in the door frame aside and gestured for me to follow. The inside was only one room, subdivided with little furniture, for which I hadn't any eye.

Because to my left side, beneath the only window, stood a bed – and in it lay Adora, sleeping. As it was hot as hell here, she was only covered by bandages around her chest and abdomen, as well as around her lap and hip.
I let out a deep sigh, followed by a small whimper of tearful joy. Here she was, here she finally was. I had her back. I had her back, and I would never let her go again. Oh Hathor, thank you. Nothing…
I was already at her side, crouching down, and shook my head to compose myself. *Not now, Catra.*
Adora looked as weak as I'd never seen her before. The always so strong-willed jawline was sunken, her hair hung loosely around her face. This poor creature was far from the always so controlled, strong woman I knew. She winced a little in her sleep. Beside the

bed, beside her, I had completely forgotten about the old hag, and gently stroked over Adora's hair.
The touch alone was so soothing, so calming, that I let out a loud sob of relief. Without even knowing what I did, I lowered my head and laid it down on the sheet beside her, just drinking in her presence, just having her near me again after so long. Adora stilled. And I lost myself just being beside her. She still smelled like the meadow, only a bit less so.

Minutes went by until I was I able to rise my head again. I heard the old woman humming to herself outside. And I noticed that I should talk to my men who were waiting for me as well. Adora was calmly sleeping, and despite it being hard as fuck to leave her, I stood up and went out.
The elderly had sat down on the bench again for her sewing work. I trudged over to my little squad. "I found her. She'd been wounded and seems still not to be in the clear. I assume it would be best if we take her to Buhen, so that our physician can treat her there.[127] Can we make something like a stretcher to carry her?" I pondered loudly, racking my mind for an idea how to not hurt Adora.
But one of them answered: "Your grace, I assume it would be better if one of us rides to Buhen and gets a boat. Or if we watched out for a ship at the Nile. Even here, there are traders nearly every day. It would mean a much smoother journey for her."
I slapped my forehead, avoiding a groan at the last moment. "Of course! One of you will ride to Buhen, while we stay here and wait for your return. Be as fast as possible and come back quickly. Three days there, one day back. The others ride to the river and watch out for someone willing to take us to Buhen. Wave them and promise them any payment they want to get us there. Her life depends on it."
My soldiers were away quickly, and I went back to the old woman to tell her what was going to happen. After that, I again crouched down beside Adora, and hadn't any intention to move from her side for the rest of the day. Or ever.

We had luck. In the evening of the same, scorching hot day, a merchant ship was coming down from Buhen and approached the shore. The captain had already been informed by the rider I'd sent upwards, that a good reward could be earned if he took some passengers back there. I made short work of the negotiation, and without any fuss, handed him enough coins to pay for two full journeys down to Alexandria and back. Of course, I could've pressed and ordered him by the seal's authority, but I needed the man to do his work willingly. It drained my purse, but I really didn't care about Cleo's fucking money.

When my men carried Adora out of the hut on a stretcher, she was still unconscious, not having woken up even once. The elderly woman looked behind Adora with a vague expression on her face. It tugged on me, and so I strolled over and again, crouched down before her. "Thank you for taking care of her," I said, laying a hand on hers, squeezing her hand gently. "I can't express how much it means to me to have her back."

She ogled me through wide eyes, and I felt assessed. "You're welcome, dearie. I knew I couldn't keep her forever," she chuckled lightly, but also a with a bit of desperation audible. "It's been a long time since I've had someone to take care of, and I liked it. It reminded me of earlier times, when this place was a bit more lively, you know?"

I looked around at the deserted, abandoned land that stretched around her little parcel. I couldn't imagine it more lively, but I didn't want to just leave her behind, in this dying place. A snap decision tumbled out of me. "You could come with us. Living here must be… lonely. Wouldn't you want to see other people? Buhen isn't large, but it's growing, and we definitely would have a place for you. What do you think?"

I knew her answer before she voiced it. "It's a nice offer," the old hag croaked. "But I've been here for the last two decades, dearie. And I think I will keep it that way. Someone has to accompany this place on its way, you know? I think I will stay a little longer.

It’s not so bad at all, and I like the quiet.”
I nodded slowly. On some strange level, I understood her. “Good. But if you change your mind, my offer still stands. Buhen isn't far.”

The old woman looked after me, while I mounted on my horse, and followed my men to the river shore with a slow trot. But when I turned around to give her a final wave, she was already gone and everything just looked abandoned and lonesome. If I hadn't the proof of meeting her in the form of having Adora back, this whole encounter could've just been a fata morgana also.

The ship was on its way back to Buhen, cruising with the wind and making a good trip. The sun had already set, but it was still light outside. I requisitioned the best cabin, not giving a shit about the complaints of the passengers, this time using the seal without giving a fuck. And there I’d crouched into a chair beside Adora’s bed, and slipped into sleep now and then. When I glanced over her occasionally, it looked like she was dreaming. Her facial muscles kept twitching a little, and occasionally small groans escaped her. I’d sat up beside her, watched her, and pondered if I should try to wake her or let her sleep. Rather unconsciously, I put a hand on her arm in an attempt to calm her, murmuring, “I'm here.”

I was utterly unprepared for her immediate reaction: Adora opened her eyes, slowly, blinked several times to clear her sight, and suddenly she caught my gaze. Her look went wild, she shook, trembled, and screamed towards someone not here: “No! Don't let her take me! Don't let her!” Obviously, she wasn’t aware that she wasn’t with the old lady anymore as she tried to leap out of the bed. I jumped up, more out of shock, while Adora tried to rise and to get on her feet. She immediately stumbled over, fell to the ground and crawled further away, wincing and taking a hand to her side where her wound was.
“Adora! It’s okay, don’t—” I tried to calm her, but was interrupted by another scream of hers. As she reached the back of the cabin and crushed against it, she was still screaming “She will— Don't let her… don't… don’t…”

She panted heavily, and I stepped back one, two paces, not because I was clever enough to give her space, but because I was so mortified. I watched in horror as Adora winced again, fell back on the ground, overwhelmed by the fright of seeing… *me*. Her eyes fluttered close as the woman collapsed to the side and got unconscious again, pain on her face much too visible.

For a while, I stood there just frozen, ashamed, and didn’t know what to do. Adora obviously wasn't happy or even curious to see me. Instead, she was frightened to death, like a deer in the hunter’s trap. And now she lay on the hard floor, unconscious, and the once so glorious woman looked nothing but small and wounded.
Finally, I was able to call for help and to put Adora back into her bed again.
Maybe I deserved that reaction. And maybe I shouldn’t have wondered. This clearly wasn't the woman from back then, from our time in Alexandria. Aside from her state, she also looked different, had new lines in her face and her body had become remarkably more tanned. So, perhaps my assumption that Adora was coming to Buhen for me had been premature. Perhaps going south along the Nile had just been the only way Adora could've imagined to go. Who could blame her? Going northwards, to the delta, probably seemed too dangerous to her, because of the stronger presence of military and officials watching out for her. Her frightened reaction hurt, though.
Night had fallen, and I stood at the railing of the ship, looking at the nocturnal desert. It would be best if I stayed away from her and to give her time to heal and process, I thought. Then, maybe, in the future, she wouldn’t be scared of me anymore. If she was willing to stay at all. Maybe.

After an uncomfortable night and under a quickly rising red sun, we arrived at Buhen. I immediately handed Adora over to our

physician and put myself to my duties again. Given Adora's reaction upon seeing me, I really needed a distraction. And I had a city to run, even if it was only a small one. My first task consisted of handling my four companions. I couldn’t let them go back to Syene, because I feared they would report Adora’s finding to the commander there, maybe even just by boasting around with their adventures. I couldn't let that happen. My offer was to integrate them into my troops and pay them a bonus for at least one year and after that, we would see further. It bought me enough time, and that was what I needed most right now. To my relief, they accepted. The other solution would have been less humane, and I was happy to avoid it, after all.

For the next three days, I completed forgotten tasks and only let her doctor tell me about her condition. Adora had shortly woken up at noon the day we arrived, but stayed calm and composed and didn’t speak much, as he informed me. Or, according to him: “She mostly just stares in front of herself when she’s even awake, which is not so often. The wound is healing now, but she’s still weak – and something bothers her beside it. This old lady did a good job in treating her, I must say, but bringing her here probably saved her life, I humbly have to admit.” The little man wiped his hands dry, after he’d washed them in a bowl with fresh water, as he always did before and after taking care of a patient.
“Why are you doing this? Washing your hands the whole time? What a weird trait is this?” I asked, and looked at mine, which were still smeared with ink from writing letters the entire morning. As usual.
He looked at me condescendingly. “I never understood why we encourage washing our hands before we dine, but not before we fuss around in the innards or the wounds of people. I’m pretty surprised that the patients of my colleagues, who don’t take care of their cleanliness like I do, even survive sometimes. It doesn’t sound like a good idea to touch different patients one after another and maybe transfer whatever malevolent spirit plagues the first one to the next one.” The sarcasm in his voice was more than audible.[128]
I tilted my head at the education. “That sounds… actually clever, if

I’m honest.”
“Of course”, he smirked half-pleased, half-predominantly, and it made me grumble. “You may not value my services well enough, but my patients deserve the best treatment I can offer. Me not making their condition worse is probably part of it.” Despite I didn't like to be lectured, I’d seldom heard someone speaking with such utter seriousness.
“Sure,” I murmured, and was a bit abashed about the simple but effective lesson he’d given me.

“So?” he asked, taking me by surprise.
“So what?” I snarled back, still grumpy about the light scolding.
He rolled his eyes. “Are you going to visit her, or shall we just keep her in this room forever? I don’t question your command or orders, that’s just none of my business.” I tilted my head questioningly, and he started to declare something in a formal tone: “Whatever I see or hear in the course of my profession, as well as outside my profession in my intercourse with men, if it be what should not be published abroad, I will never divulge, holding such things to be holy secrets.”
I grinned lightly when I recognized it: “Oh, you actually know the Hippocratic Oath?”
Another obnoxious smirk met my gaze. This man wanted to be taken seriously. “So, your grace knows at least something. I’m slightly impressed.”
“And I’m impressed that such a lousy village doctor has even heard of Hippocrates,” I shot back. Two could play that game.
He shrugged his shoulders. “Not only your ladyship has a colorful and dazzling past. But that's not the point. The point is that my patient needs more than my excellent physical treatment to heal. Locking her up in a room, and not speaking about what will happen to her, isn’t for the best. And I’m not breaking my oath when I tell you that she’d asked for you.”
“I didn't lock her up!” I defended myself weakly.
He scoffed. “She clearly doesn’t see it that way, given the guards outside her door or the mere fact that you didn’t even visit her once since she’s here. And the uncertainty distresses her, which doesn’t contribute to her healing.” He sighed audibly and a little

too dramatic. How could I even explain to him the underlying reason for my reticence? The last time Adora saw me, she collapsed in fright and terror upon my sight. It left me behind in shame and embarrassment, and I feared approaching her again. It spoke for his knowledge of humans that he didn't press further, just informing me about his opinion without real judgement beside the tease.
"I'll take care. Thank you for your service," I replied, sighing.

It took me another day to finally make up my mind and go visit her. The two guards before Adora's door stood at attention when I approached them. Originally, I'd placed them to keep her safe and to prevent anyone beside the doctor or me from noticing that it was her – the most wanted person in Egypt – that was being treated here. But now, after not reaching out to her for days, I acknowledged that it might have given a false impression about my intentions. I knew I should've done this earlier, when I heaved a deep breath and laid my hand on the door doorknob. Then I opened the door and there she was.

Adora lay in her bed, and despite being pale and her face sunken, she looked absolutely bored. Hmpf. I should've taken care of that as well. Being tied to the bed was certainly hell for someone like her.
"Hey Adora," I said in a low voice and in an unnecessary attempt to not scare her another time, but also to hide my feelings. But she didn't look scared. Rather unnerved.
"It's nice that my presence doesn't make you scream again," I half-heartedly joked, but regretted it in an instant, when her facial expression closed, and she looked out of the window now. I immediately fell silent and didn't know what to say next. Adora stared outside, where absolutely nothing of interest could be seen.
Why couldn't I shut up my stupid face at least once?

Adora

Catra'd left an hour ago after I'd not responded to her first approach. Her comment ashamed me so much that my ability for any proper response just jumped out of the window. Yeah, I recognized how dumb I'd reacted when seeing her.

Sighing, I propped myself up, swung my legs out of the bed and put them on the ground. Then I tried to wiggle my toes, and to my surprise, they worked pretty well. After having not stood up for such a long time, it was at least encouraging and made me try. Leaning against the frame of the canopy, I pushed myself up into a half-standing position. It was a bit shaky, but I stood. Slowly, I tried a few steps and found that the side of my wound – where that bastard had stabbed me – still hurt. I was a little wobbly on my feet, but I didn't fall, which was quite a relief. While I made hesitant and small steps around the room, it knocked at the door, then someone opened it. A guard brought me my lunch, as always. He was surprised when seeing me standing, quickly put the tablet with a plate on the table beside the bed, and hurried outside.

Less than ten minutes later, Catra knocked on the door. She caught me sitting at the table, eating. "You got up. That's… that's good to see," she said, while I munched some weird porridge with fruits – or whatever it was that I wolfed down.
"The guard told me," she added.
"The guard, of course," I scoffed. "You… you actually don't need them, you know? I won't last half an hour on my feet. You got me, and I'm not going anywhere. I just can't."
Catra looked at me with an odd and inscrutable gaze.
Now she scoffed. "The guards are there for your protection, you idiot. I didn't want anyone to just barge in and discover you."

Finding it hard to believe just so, I shot her a wary glance, questioning, guarded. "They aren't there to keep me in?"
She shook her head in denial. "No? They shall protect you and make sure that nobody comes in without permission. It's still a secret that you're here, you know? Only I and Shoshan know

about it. And the doctor.”
“You mean, I can go outside?” I asked, not really sure what to make out of this development. Still, I didn’t trust her.

“Sure, why shouldn’t you? But I can't recommend it. You would have to cover you. Your hair is really… unmistakable in this part of the world. And your eyes.”
“I can go without being guarded?” I insisted.
“Not exactly without protection, I would say, but yeah, you can.” Catra nodded, and it sounded honest. I was still wary.
“I assumed…” I fell dry and couldn’t finish the sentence.

And Catra started to laugh at me. “What? You assumed I would hold you prisoner in this room? You're an idiot. More than I thought. This is Buhen. There is no place to go beside the desert. It’s the only settlement within 30 iteru. Where should you even be able to go?” Her joyful tone had taken a turn into an angry direction. “And by the way: you’re not my prisoner. I took you here to save your life. But you’re free to go anytime you want to leave. I’m not holding you back, you know? For all I care you can pack your stuff and be gone within an hour.”
She clearly talked herself into that, but yet, I looked down into my lap and was a bit embarrassed. All the time since my wound was nothing but blurry and unclear. There had been an old woman treating me, that much I knew. But I had seldom been awake, and even more seldom in my right mind. The last few days here at Buhen had been the first ones that I’d been clear again, with the fever gone and the wound finally healing for good.
A thank you would probably be appropriate.
“Thank you,” I murmured, and added: “Your doctor really seems to understand his job.”
She huffed. “Yeah, as long as he can contain his arrogant streak a little, he's not bad.”
I actually giggled. “Hihi. Must be a part of the job description. Our own physician back in Antiochia was exactly alike. He always lectured me to keep my trainings less strenuous. One time, when Bow taught me—”
What was I doing here? Instantly falling back into the so-well flowing talk with Catra? It wasn’t like that we were suddenly on

good terms again. Yes, I wanted to talk to her and yes, I wanted to clear things with her. But not like that, not in a situation where I was at her mercy, potentially trapped again and possibly handed over again to her bitch sister. Cleopatra of course wasn't acting out of cruelty, I gave her that. But she would do anything for her kingdom. Everything. And Catra already proved where her loyalty laid.

Catra eyed me warily, searching for an explanation why I fell silent. I took a breath. "Having guards in front of my room obviously steered my thoughts into a certain direction." It wasn't really an accusation, but came out like one. She certainly had none of it.
"You could have just asked them. I know that you've learned our language by now."
"Huh? How—"
She chuckled. "You talk in your sleep. And you said some demotic words only real speakers know."
"I talk in…" The implication struck me immediately. "So you've been here while I slept, but didn't care to speak to me for days when I was awake? What kind of cruel game is it that you're playing?"

Suddenly, there was a well-known uneasiness in Catra's face. I remembered it from earlier conversations, when something was plaguing her that she didn't want to admit. She started to pace around in the room, blatantly pondering about her answer.
"Oh bona dea, Catra. Just spit it out like a grown woman," I called at her.
She froze in her movements and her hands were fisted. "You were afraid of me, Adora. When you saw me on the boat, you screamed in horror. I didn't want to trigger that again. Or experience."
"I… I was just waking up, and you got me the wrong way."
"You didn't see yourself, Adora. It was the face of someone who was absolutely horrified. I… I didn't… I wanted…" She panted and retreated a few steps, looked wildly around, like on the search for an escape route.

I had to set this right. Now. “I didn’t mean you!” I shouted at her. She stopped and looked at me, trying to catch what I’d said.
“I didn’t mean you,” I repeated, more calm and continued. “I thought about your—”
Should I tell it?
“What?”
“It was your… sister.”
“Cleopatra.” She shortly frowned, but then she focused back on me. “Ah, I get it. That… makes sense.”
“I was waking up from a dream—”, I tried to explain.
“Or a nightmare,” she cut in.
It was embarrassing. But it'd been such a lively dream, so vivid.
“Yeah, well, a nightmare. Where you handed me over to her.” I felt my face twitching. “Another time.”
“I didn’t hand you over—”
“Eh, semantics. Does that really matter?”
She sighed. “Okay, I guess not.” She leaned back against the wall and put a hand over her eyes, squeezing and rubbing her forehead. “But… I won’t do it another time. I promise.”
I wasn’t able to reply, I just stared at her in disbelief, and a long time later she finally stood up to leave my room. “If you need anything, inform the guards outside. I’m not far away the whole time. Whenever you’re ready to talk, I’m there.”

The next day, she visited me again, but rather than walking in, she just crept into my room, sat down on a chair beside my bed and looked into her lap. I didn’t really know what to say to her, but I was actually grateful that she was just here. It made everything a little easier, while at the same time it made everything more complicated. We did so for a while, awkwardly sitting next to each other, she on a chair, me in the bed.

“Why did you come here, Adora?” she suddenly asked, and still looked into her lap, fumbling with her fingers. After thinking about an answer for a while, I found no use in denying the real reason and admitted: “There weren't many directions to choose from, you know? And… I wanted to talk to you.”
She huffed. “That much I already guessed, you genius. But why that?”

“Because I need an answer.”
“To what question?”
Maybe it was too much to ask of her as of now. And was I really ready for an answer? I hesitated shortly, and she sensed it. “You know, you could just spit it out like a grown woman”
I rolled my eyes, but her attempt of teasing actually lightened the mood a bit. “The whole way down to here, I rolled this question in my mind. It was always there. And now that you’re right here, I… I really can’t. It’s there, and I can’t say it out loud. I think I will need some time, okay? At least, if I have any time here?”

Catra understood what I was saying and firmly waved it off. “I won't tell Cleo anything. You are safe here as long as you want to stay. I already promised you that, but I understand that sounds like cheap talk. I know that I… that I don't deserve your forgiveness. It’s—”

She cut herself off and looked devastated, forlorn, broken. And while I studied her face and stance, I realized that I wasn't even angry anymore. Instead, ridiculous and pathetic enough, I just wanted to hold her in my arms and comfort her and think about everything else later.
Maybe… maybe it was time to let the past go? Maybe it was time to ignore the nagging feeling of anger and oh-so-righteous ire that’d befallen me for so long. And maybe, that here, this place – at the end of the world – was just as good a place for it as any other.

I gulped down my hesitation and the rest of my anger, sitting up and swinging my legs out of the bed. Then I held out my hand. Catra glanced at the gesture dumbly and with wide eyes.
“Come here,” I asked her.
She still was unable to catch the meaning of my gesture. “Just… just like that?” she asked quietly, disbelieving and looked all frozen.
“Just like that,” I replied earnestly. “I know I still—” I couldn’t say it, not this, not right now. It was too early, too little time had passed since I woke up in this environment, wounded and practically at her mercy. There was a barrier in me that forbade

me to say the word loud. It was there, deep in me, I knew it. But I wasn't able to say it out loud though.
Anyway, not being able to say "I love you" didn't mean that I didn't want to have her in my arms again. I still held out my hand. "I don't know if I will ever be able to trust you again. However, you saved my life, and it hurts me to see you hurting, Catra. Tomorrow will be another day with whatever disasters happening then. I will take them. But today: yes, just like that. So please, come here."
I opened both arms, and she made two, three trembling steps forward, and finally grabbed my hands. And then, this always so fierce and strong woman crouched down in front of me, lay her head into my lap, and began to cry. It started with quiet sobbing, which turned into deep, elongated sobs escaping her chest and bereaved her of her breath.
I felt a little overwhelmed, and had rarely seen anyone show relief so openly, but today she did, and I was ashamed of being the cause of so much pain. But this wasn't about me, but about her.

For a long time, I just petted Catra's head, until her tears stopped running. And occasionally I peppered a few little pecks on her hair, that smelled so much like her, still like lavender and cedarwood and the sweat of her day. I lost myself in reminiscence of our mutual night, back then in Alexandria on Cleopatra's *Heket*, where everything had been so perfect. It seemed so far away from today, and yet, so near.
My hands grabbed into her curls. To my surprise, arousal awoke in me. I felt how fast it took me over. Oh bona dea, this woman drove me crazy, made me lose every single piece of self-control and gravitas. I hooked my hands under Catra's arms and dragged the teary woman up to me. Slowly shuffling back on my bed made some place for her to rest on it, and I just dragged her further. She didn't resist, nor did she go along with it. She was just surprised, was glancing at me with watery eyes, when I pinned her down and hovered above her. With a gentle and caring move of my hand, I cupped her cheek, to which she leaned in.
"I know I want to forgive you, Catra." Kiss. True.
"I know I want to tell you what I feel." Kiss. True.

“And I know you love me.” Kiss. Not so true.
I pulled a corner of my mouth. “Of course you do. I’m adorable.”
A single sob escaped her throat, and it was mixed with laughter. “Ugh, get over yourself. You’re still an unbearable bossy Roman,” she croaked.
“Yeah, I am,” I smirked right into her face. “But that’s your fault.” I nudged her nose with mine. “If you can make the smartest and most beautiful woman in Egypt fall in love with you, this simply does it to you. Is that surprising?”
“It surprises me that I’m making such an idiot out of myself, yeah. Maybe I’m not so clever at all.”
Meanwhile, we lay side by side on the bed and just touched each other with our hands. Catra trailed my cheek and jawline, I stroked her side down to the hip, all of it was kind and full of restraint. But I wanted more, I wanted to go further, wanted to undress her and press her whole beautiful, stringy, lithe body against mine. Feel her sweat under me. I was making a fool out of myself, felt like a voluptuous barbarian, but the longing for her was ridiculously strong.

And though, the rest of the day went by in soft kindness. Nothing really happened, because I sensed that Catra would need time to adapt to this new me. But I fell asleep in her arms, and I felt home for the first time since back in Alexandria. This time, there was no nightmare, not even a dream. Just a quiet, restful sleep that carried me through the night and brought me peace. It wasn't that I understood myself.

The next few days went by relatively uneventfully. Catra spent time with me while my wound healed and I recovered. She fulfilled her duties to her post, but beside that, she often sat in my room, just reading or even taking a midday nap for good sometimes. It was adorable when tiredness took her over and her head fell down on her chest, while she was sitting in the basket

armchair beside my bed. Despite the scorching temperatures outside, I didn't feel drained. My enforced bed rest made me more restless the longer it lasted. So most times when she slept away, I tried to drag her over into my bed, and to curl around her, petting her softly and watching her sleep then. I somehow needed the physical closeness while I still couldn't make up my mind. She always glared at me when waking up a realizing what I'd done, but she also did nothing to avoid a repeat. Sometimes, in my sleep, I clung to her as hard as I could. Then she yelped and woke me up to remind me that she must be able to breathe.

I was so confused. I needed her near me, and still wasn't able to process all the feelings warring inside me. And despite my incoherent behavior, very slowly, we grew closer again. More frequently, she stayed for the night and slept beside me. We didn’t talk about it. It just happened the third night after I woke up, when she stood up to leave for the night, I stared at her and held out my hand. She needed a few moments to realize and accept the meaning of my gesture. But then she smiled a tiny smile, slipped out of her dress and neatly folded it to put it down on the chair. She sat on the edge of the bed with her back towards me, and waited. It didn't take me long, because I needed, I wanted, I urged to touch her and embrace the sleek woman. I grabbed her lithe figure from behind, drew her down and beside me, and she followed willingly. My wound was only throbbing a little, and I fought down and ignored the pain as well as my desire to splay myself over her. I needed the body contact so much. A deep sigh of relief and wellbeing escaped my chest, when she finally laid her arms around me and stroked my back softly.

And so it stayed.
Nothing more happened.

It was a few days later. One evening, Catra strolled by while I was sitting on the bench in the little garden. She just took my hand and said, “Follow me, I want to show you something.” It was a bit surprising, but I let her guide me to the stables, where two horses had been readied. She quickly mounted on the left, inviting me to

take the other one. On their sides hung saddlebags, neatly packed. I shot her a quizzical look that she didn’t repeat, but spurred her horse and fell into a very light trot. I had to make an effort to keep up with her. And asked myself what she was going to do with me, with us, when we rode into the desert beside the Nile.

An hour later, my wound was already puckering, when we seemed to arrive at our aim. We’d left the river a bit to the side and trotted into a flat valley. Before the end of this cleft lay a stone gate, an archway, with intricate ornaments that showed trees and flowers.

And behind the gate, the view opened to a… forest. It took my breath away, actually. Hundreds of beautifully crafted trees, made out of stone, stood beside the little tributary of the Nile. After dismounting from our horses, we walked into the formation, leaving stone trees left and right, and I felt like trotting through an actual wood, that was lost in time or had been turned into stone by the gods. Catra took my hand in hers, looked at me with a friendly and caring glance, and led me deeper.

After a few minutes, we reached a point that I thought was the center of it. There, two statues stood side-by-side, a man and woman. They were holding their hands, not looking at each other but forward, and it seemed they were facing a common goal or a mutual future. Their faces were expectant, light even, and they looked completely different from the usual stately and sketchy depiction of the Egyptian Pharaohs.
“What is this, Catra?” I asked in wonder. I couldn't shake off an eerie feeling of sensation and intrusion at the same time.
She took in the sight of the statues, actually looked admiringly at them, before she declared: “This is the Forest Of Forever.”
I wanted to ask her what that should mean, but her face had such a determined expression on it that I didn’t dare to break the silence. Only when I realized that tears slowly streamed down her cheeks, I placed myself behind her and took the woman in my arms. She shivered a little, but she neither drew back nor hesitated to lean into me.

“They have been here for more than a thousand years,” she finally explained. “More than a thousand years. The legend says that they ended their lives at it’s peak freely and that a powerful priest turned them into these statues, so that they both could be together, forever. They didn’t want to be buried in dark tombs under a large pyramid, but to be in the bright sunlight. And here, in the dryness of the eternal desert, their statues would endure until the end of time. Their souls wander through the forest at night, and only true lovers may have a chance to see them.
“You… you don’t actually believe that they’ve turned into stone, do you?” I asked incredulously, but wondered if the story might have a true core.

She pulled away from my embrace and nudged my shoulder. “Don’t be an idiot. Of course not. But I… I always liked the thought, you know? Being with someone, for forever. It's a calming feeling, that there might be someone out there, with whom you want to stay for your whole life, and even afterward.” She fell silent.
And I understood what she wanted to say, without saying it. This little trip here, and her short, precise explanation, it was more than just some sightseeing. It was Catra saying something I found easy to get. It was a silent, but unmistakable declaration of love and nothing less. She’d wanted to show me this to explain her feelings to me without using possibly worn-out words, words that she didn’t dare or feared to say anymore. And I understood she was still feeling guilty and tried to make for her mistake. This was a confession. And an apology. All of it was saying "I love you, and I want to be with you,” in a very loud way. I just had to listen. Catra looked at me with an expression on her face that wasn’t hard to read. It was heart-wrenching to see the woman search expectantly for a reaction from me, saying: “I want it too. I want you to be this being. It’s you. It has always been you. I love you.”

And I wanted it. I wanted to be able to say it back to her, that I loved her back. It was there, deep down. But there was also so much emptiness in me, so much shattered trust, still not healed. I couldn’t bring myself to trust her again. Still, her betrayal from the scene in the throne room echoed in the back of my mind. The

feeling of mistrust that'd been there since hadn't gone away. I still didn't know if I was safe with her. Maybe I was unfair, but something in me made it impossible to just let the deeply shattered trust in her heal.

And how was I supposed to teach Catra that?

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is called **"A promise that could not be kept."** and will be published on Friday, September 10, 2021.
> It's the penultimate chapter of this story.
> Let's put it this way: brace yourself for impact.

[126] I mean… this goes without comment. But sometimes I really like humanity. ↑

[127] Ancient Egypt medicine goes back since the beginning of their written history. During the time of this story, there were already specialists like dentists, proctologists or ophthalmologists. Despite the understanding of the body was still very limited, they knew about the pulse, it's connection to the heart and had an idea of the cardiac system, even if not differentiated. The function of the brain seemed not to be understood, but operations at the eyes or teeth were made since centuries. Pharmacology was widely based on plants and herbs, but even on feces from animals or metal ingredients. The recipes were often ineffective, but several pain treatments or the inhalation of herbs against cold were common knowledge. Religious beliefs prevented medics until modern times to properly investigate the human body. ↑

[128] The underlying reasons for good hygiene in medicine were not known or understood until the discovery of bacteria in modern times, particularly at the end of the 19th century. But despite many so-called medics and doctors throughout the ages that didn't care about hygiene, many of them had an instinctive understanding that filth didn't make the healing process easier. It was clear to everyone that wounds had to be cleaned, but not that you could transmit diseases with dirty hands.

You may look into the biography and works of Galenus to get a glimpse of the knowledge of medicine people had at the time of this story. Galenus was immensely productive, and his work so influential that it would be about 1,400 years before his insufficient knowledge and conclusions would be seriously questioned. Even Avicenna didn't really challenge Galen in his "Canon of Medicine", 800(!) years later, and none of all the medics throughout the millennia really understood the necessity of hygiene until around 200 years ago, despite many of them desperately tried to. ↑

A promise that could not be kept

Chapter Summary

No summary. This is the endgame.

Chapter Notes

The last chapter is published tomorrow. It is rather short, and belongs very much together with this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Buhen, Egypt - August 47 BCE

Adora

On our way back, Catra clearly noticed my hesitation to say anything back or to even talk. Not about my feelings or what I thought, about anything of real importance. The light-hearted mood of our ride was no longer there. We stayed mostly silent, and only a few shallow comments made it back and forth.
Night had already fallen when we arrived back in Buhen and went into her quarter. We stood before my room, as she laid a hand on mine and said: "I'm going to sleep in my own bed the night. I need a little time for myself." She didn't look happy. Her gaze was rather impenetrable, but something cheerless poured out of her.
I gulped down my feeling of disappointment. 'd expected her to stay with me like the nights before.
But she was right: all the nights that I clung to her, I stayed silent about my feelings, and said nothing more about the whirlwind of trouble that stormed inside me. And I was… making an idiot out of myself. Catra'd shown me nothing but kindness, understanding, and care since my rescue. She shielded me from curious eyes at day and soothed my craving for her to be close to me at night. And I had no idea what she got back in return from a woman that was still mostly lying around in bed and wasn't able to express what was of importance to someone who meant so much to her.

"I… I understand." The words left my lips and I scolded myself for being so stupid. "Thank you for showing me. I'm…"

I just stood there, without words but with water in my eyes, hoping that I hadn't ruined everything, wanting to say something meaningful to her, but I still could not – and then I let the moment pass. Catra face was still opaque as she tiptoed and placed a kiss on my forehead. "Sleep, Adora. Tomorrow will be a new day. For both of us."
I nearly burst out in tears because I didn't want a fucking new day. I wanted the nights, where she was by my side, where I could cuddle into her arms and felt some resemblance of the protection from earlier, from the days and nights on our way to Alexandria, when we stole Cleo's seal, when we were on the way to Thēbais and got ourselves drunk at the tavern, when she made a woman out of me on our night at the *Heket*. From a time when I still trusted her.

Oh bona dea, I was so pathetic in my longing. A disgrace to my ancestors. I did nothing right here, and had clearly reached the end of my wisdom, locked between a desire to be near to her and not being able to really open up and gift her with my trust again. Which Catra clearly got, because she wasn't an idiot like me.
So I just nodded, opened my door, walked into my room, closed the door again, sagged down against the wooden frame of it and started to sob.

A few more days passed, and my wound had healed so far. I picked up some light training again to get back in shape – which was clearly needed, judging from the wobbly flesh I felt when touching my upper arm. I had no sparring partner here, but most of the exercises actually didn't need one. But it was more motivating to do them together. Going for a run was only fine in the early morning hours, before the town woke up, because Catra

and I concurred that keeping my identity a secret would be for the best. My most distinctive feature here was my hair color, and so we dyed them down to a more muddy tone again. It was enough to not be recognized as a blonde on first sight. I still draped them under a headscarf, because meanwhile I've got used to it, but I let hang out some strands, just for the disguise. My skin was tanned so well by now that I didn't worry about it anymore. It nearly matched Catra's, and that was enough.

But my eyes were still unmistakable. So it was a good idea to keep a low profile, though, when I ran my rounds in the morning hours. After that, I sometimes strolled over to Catra's workplace, she'd set up under the canopy before her office and where she tended to receive petitioners, citizens, or messengers. I took place in the room in her back, and watched and listened from there, but today found her in a heated argument with someone looking like a priest.
"…enough to rebuild the temple. It's not like there are hundreds of worshipers of Horus here. Shoshan was absolutely right to withdraw the additional workers. The temple doesn't need to be expanded, Amenemhet."
The man with the sour face retorted: "With the expansion of the city, we should be ready for more. The current temple—"
She cut in fiercely. "Is absolutely fitting for our current needs. Inform me when the believers don't fit at the seats anymore."
"But then it will be too late! We need two years for the works, and by then—"
I saw Catra sighing, and it was actually cute to see her like that: Official, on duty, concentrated and capable, despite being clearly unnerved. It was… capturing.
"Ugh!" she let out with an angry snort. "I see where this is going. How about… how about you put together a list of material and men you need, and I'll take a look over it."
"I would actually need a master-builder to do that. I'm not an architect, as your grace might be aware of," the priest growled, but a lot less excited now.
"Consider it done," Catra replied in a definite voice that held

command. Amenemhet seemed to get the hint, took his scrolls and left the yard in a hurry.

"He looks like an eager man," I chuckled, strolling over to her. Nobody else was left besides us.
"He's a pesky and overachieving pain in my ass," she said and added smugly, "But that's nothing I'm not used to."
I rolled my eyes. "It's good that there are some people keeping *your ladyship Catra* grounded, I'd say. Your big ego doesn't need to get inflated even more."
"Ugh, don't call me that. It's enough that all these idiots around me don't stop with it." She lowered her voice to a whisper: "I'm actually guessing that Shoshan set up some scheme where they overbid each other by annoying me with their witty forms of address."
It made me laugh. "Your graceful Catrahood should take it as a token of admiration from your humble servants," I snickered while underlining it with a small curtsy.
We bickered and bantered amicably for some time, and were only interrupted now and then by someone who needed Catra's decision on anything. I'd settled in a whisker chair behind her, mostly covered as always and in the shadow, and tried to look as inconspicuous as possible.

I'd relaxed for a while, just taking in the calming routine, when I noticed noises approaching us from outside the yard.
I recognized them immediately: that was a marching contubernium, without any doubt. The sounds of the hobnailed sandals in lockstep were unmistakable. My reflexes still worked as I shot up from the chair and withdrew into Catra's office at once. There were several rooms inside, a reception room equipped with seating, and two doors, one to her personal workroom, which she rarely used, and one to another room for a secretary. From her own office, a door connected it with Catra's private living rooms behind them. I sneaked back into her personal office and tried to peek outside through the window of the reception room. The incoming contubernium marched over the place and consisted of its usual ten legionaries. But I noticed that it was led by a tribune instead of the usual eldest soldier, and that was an alarming sign.

A tribune in Buhen? Someone normally commanding a cohort, a legion even? That was a political demonstration and it was dangerous.

I heard Catra and the tribune talking to each other, while the contubernium had rallied up behind him. The wall between the door and the window blocked my view now, and so I couldn't see Catra, but her voice sounded firm, with only the slightest hint of annoyance. I couldn't understand them, but the purpose of their turn up was clear enough: these men were searching for me, and they asked Catra for information. Even here, at the end of the world, in the middle of the desert, at the gate to Aethiopia, my uncle Gaius was able to reach out and try to lay his hand on me.

Of course, he could!

He was the leader of the known world. His arms could reach anywhere. How could I've been so careless to let myself believe that I would be safe here? My heartbeat and my breathing fastened, and I felt the remains of the wound puckering, while it sent a dull ache into my body, making me wince. I balled my hands to stop them trembling, and wanted to get closer to them to hear them speaking. Why hadn't Catra said anything about that? Didn't she know?
No, of course she didn't, she didn't know. She said that she would hide and protect me, and nothing she'd done so far indicated something else.
But what if… what if she'd already told Cleopatra about me, and acted so just to lull me into a false sense of security, to keep me here until my jailers would arrive? She'd been so withdrawn in the recent days… Oh, no! She wouldn't do that, she wouldn't betray me like that. *She would not*, I assured myself repeatedly.

I panted heavily and realized that I'd retreated to Catra's private room, where I'd only been two or three times at all, and not ever since we'd parted after our visit to the Forest of Forever. Ever since, she'd kept me at arm's length, and we didn't ever sleep at each other's side again. I missed it, but now the feeling was pushed back by another one: fear. Fear of being betrayed in this

very moment.
And that… that was it, wasn't it? She'd tried to show me what she was feeling for me, and I did… just nothing. I just stared at her dumbly and sulked in my still not overcome mistrust. And that must've been the trigger for her betrayal.
Oh yes, betrayal!
She would hand me over, right now. These legionaries were here to take me with them. I had to flee!

But I only sagged against the frame of her bed, exhausted, trying to compose myself. And I was so weak. Still so tired. If they already knew about me, if they knew, I wouldn't stand a chance in running away. My resumed training was starting to take effect, but I was still a long way from being in shape. And I against ten legionaries? Ridiculous. What could I do? Catra was surely betraying me, and I had to—

"Adora!"

Oh! There was someone sitting right before me.

"Adora, I need you to breathe more steadily, okay? Please. You're panting, you sweat, and it frightens me." Catra spoke so softly and concerned. Why was she even talking to me so sweet if she was already selling me to her bitch sister again? But she stroked my back so nice and gentle, and *oh*, she smelled good, and it soothed me sooo much to smell her scent. I leaned into the touch instinctively, laying my head into her neck.

Only now I realized how far I'd talked myself into a panic attack that just slowly ebbed. While my breathing slowed, she continued to whisper soothingly to me. "It's okay, Adora. They're gone. Nothing will happen. Nothing will harm you. Nobody will take you away. It's okay. I sent them away. You can breathe normal now. Ouch!"
She yelped. "And you can let go of my arms, okay?"
"Oh!"
I wasn't so good with words right now, and had obviously clung to her way too hard.

Abruptly, I fell out of my panicking and let her loose, feeling embarrassed. “I’m… sorry.”
She shuffled back a bit and rubbed her forearms where my grip had hurt her, her face showing a grim grin.
“Never mind,” she said with gritted teeth. “Just do me a favor and calm down, Adora. It’s okay, really. I already sent them away, so please.” She sounded concerned – and a bit of hurt.

I was still leaning or rather slumping against her bed, and even the short panic attack had exhausted me. With closed eyes, I tried to soothe myself, to breathe in and out in a more steady state, until I was able to ask hoarsely: “What? What did they want? I saw a tribune, and that has to be a bad sign. Are there more legionaries coming?”

Catra tilted her head and frowned. “I actually didn’t get that. He asked me if I saw you and I denied. They obviously picked up your trail in Syene, where the little boy at the harbor must’ve spilled your description like he did to me. And so they deduced that you were on your way to Buhen. I mean, it isn’t that hard to judge, because there aren't many other settlements worth the journey out here, you know?” She made a short pause to give me some time to process it. She still crouched on her heels before me, and now she took my hands into hers. “As I didn’t report anything about you to Cleo – and because Cleo obviously doesn’t trust me anymore regarding… your matter – they are searching Lower Nubia for you now. But they don’t know that you’re here, Adora.”

That was… good? “But what if anyone talks. At least some people know that I’m here. Or that a strange woman had shown up.”
“New people show up here every day, Adora. Buhen is growing. And the only ones that know about you are absolutely loyal to me. I trust them, and they won’t talk to anyone, okay?” Then something went through her mind: “But I should take care of some distractions, if they try to question normal citizens. I’ll be back soon. I've got a few ideas on that.”

Catra stood up and held out her hand to drag me up as well. I hesitated, not willing to go anywhere soon, because I still felt so… weak.
"May I stay here for a while? Just… until I feel good again?" I asked with a shiver in my voice that I couldn't suppress.
I knew that she'd kept a distance since our visit at the Forest of Forever, and my request to be allowed to stay in her room was maybe too much. But I didn't want to go back to my room, where absolutely nothing was. Even Catra's chamber wasn't very personal, but at least it *smelled* like her.
She nodded, not without a slight tarrying, but she nodded, and her gaze held a bit of worry still.
"I won't touch anything, I promise!" I quickly tried to assure her. "I just want—"
She cut me short, actually chuckling: "I don't worry about you rummaging through my underwear, Adora. It's not like you haven't already seen everything of importance, dummy. But, can I leave you here? Alone?"
"I'm good. But… thank you. I just don't want to go outside or be in my…"
"Is okay," she just said, and hurried out of the chamber far too quick for my taste.

Another hour passed, and I lay on the ground of Catra's room with outstretched arms, looking at the ceiling. The chill of the tiles beneath me eased me and sent a welcomed cooling into my back. And, as always, so much went through my mind at once.
My ridiculous panic had washed away, and now there was an underlying current that I couldn't ignore any longer: Catra'd shielded me. She openly denied her knowledge of my whereabouts. Until now, she could've cloaked it somehow. But if Cleopatra – or my uncle – found out that she openly lied to them, there would be severe consequences. Not deadly perhaps, but still serious enough. And that… that had to be the answer I needed, actually, and the recognition made something in me crumble.

She'd kept her promise. She defied her sister. Perhaps made good for her former mistake. And hadn't it been my wish, my demand, my longing for exactly this reassurance that'd kept me from

admitting that I loved her back? It may not have meant so much to someone else, but to me, it meant everything.

The door opened and cut into my rumination. And there she was, Catra, a bit sweaty, tousled, so beautiful, looking down and frowning at me like so often, and the grumpy, but funny expression on her face made my heart so light. She took a stand before me and tapped with a foot. "You know… there is a bed in your room. You're safe there, the building is guarded. You don't have to lay on the stony floor here."
I tilted my head backwards so that I could see her better overhead, and then I smiled at her. After all the time, I finally knew what I wanted to say.
"Hey Catra."
She rolled her eyes, but after a moment of smirking, it morphed into a little a smile. "You look… happier. That's good." Then she looked slightly past me and scratched the back of her head in cute uncertainty. "Do you want to talk about what happened?"
I huffed, because I really did not. "Actually? No. I wasn't prepared for reality to jump into my face just like that. I… somehow managed to completely forget that they would look out for me, even here. Or rather, of course here as well. I mean, you said it, it's just logical, isn't it?"
She stood behind me, her feet were nearly touching my head, and she looked down on me, grinning. "You're so clever, when that tiny bit of a brain you have is not falling apart, you know?"
"Haha, very funny," I defended myself weakly, but her tone wasn't devious and mine wasn't defeated. Then we just looked into each other's eyes, I still laying on the floor, and she still droning over me with a smug grin.
Her gaze seemed searching, and I knew it was about time.

"Catraa?" I drew out the last vowel a bit, just to emphasize it.
"Hmm?"
"I love you."
That wiped the smug grin off her face. My arms were still outstretched to the side, I looked up at her with a big smirk on my lips and watched her face crumble. "Looks like you weren't prepared too," I added and raised a hand to reach out for her.

But Catra looked just frozen. And when I watched her closer, I saw the water in her eyes. I propped myself up quickly to embrace her. “Hey. That’s… that’s a good thing. It wasn’t intended to make you cry.”
She was frozen first, but after a moment, she nuzzled against my shoulder. I started to pet the back of her head.
“It’s… I… haven’t expected to actually hear it.” A single sob escaped her. “I’ve waited for these words for so long, Adora. For so long,” she whispered, her hands clinging into my back.
I petted her. “I know. I know. I’m sorry I’d been such an idiot. And that I wasn’t able to admit it earlier. The feeling was there the whole time. It was just that I couldn’t—”
“Yeah, trust me. I know,” she huffed.
“Let me finish. I couldn't forgive you the entire time. But I do now. I really do, Catra, I forgive you. I should've done it earlier.” I pushed a strand of her mane behind her ear and pecked a kiss on her cheek. And another one. Upon the third one she drew her head to meet my lips with hers, and afterward I lost my counting of time, while we kissed longingly. I laughed into her face while kissing her, because I felt so lucky. Maybe I kissed her tears away, maybe they were mine. Who would care?

Dawning evening found us on her bed, where we laid, staring into each other’s eyes, carefully petting our cheeks, shoulders, lips with our hands. I actually left several hickeys on her chest and got some on my tits in return, and I liked it. I liked how willingly, how demanding she was to mark me, and I replied the favor eagerly. It was nearly unsettling how much a wanted her to claim my body to be hers. It was so not like me.

But the day and my stupid panic had actually exhausted me, and a loud and very unpatrician yawn escaped my mouth, making me realize how tired I was. It reminded me that I should head to my bed. Propping myself up on my hands, I kissed Catra’s forehead. “I think I will catch some sleep”, I said, and got up, fetching my tunic - I must’ve lost it somehow during the last hour of making out with Catra - and started to fumble it over my head.
Behind me, the woman on the bed cleared her throat and asked with a rasp: “What… what do you think you’re doing?”

Somehow I felt caught doing something wrong, but I didn't know what it was. “Uhm? Going to my bed? I mean, I’m exhausted, and I could take some hours of sleep after all… this, you know?”
Catra sat up on her bed and actually started to *take off* her own tunic. When she was done with it, she just looked ridiculously hot, radiating nothing but seduction in her underwear, that fitted her tight body so well. My eyes were glued to her chest, as she patted softly with a hand to her side and grinned. “You’re still an idiot. Do you really think I would prefer to let you sleep in your bed than right beside me after *that* declaration? Come here, Adora, you’re not going anywhere.”

And I found it very easy to obey her command. I quickly and eagerly fired the tunic away, crawled back onto her side, and was embraced by the most wonderful woman in the world. After we stopped giggling to ourselves out of joy, Catra was loud, when I took her to her third high that night, and I was as well when she made me scream her name into her mattress in return. We became better at this and at some time, we finally found sleep in each other’s arms.

I never slept so well.

The next morning I went for my run later than usual. I blamed it on my need for sleep, but it may also had something to do with a certain, heterochromatic distraction that moaned and complained audibly when I tried to get up the first time. I found myself vigorously dragged back into the bed and needed a few more tries until I was finally able to escape her embrace. Not that I fought too hard, but I also needed to stretch my limbs and back after that night.
When I’d finished and was back on my way to Catra’s house, I stumbled over a group of little children in the streets, maybe in the age of five to ten years old. They were playing a ball game

where you had to knock over short branches of wood with a ball that you threw at them from a few paces away. I stopped and watched them for a short while, while the wild crowd squealed and whirled. It somehow tugged at me. It was nice to watch them, and made me ask myself when I'd had so much lighthearted and joyful fun in my life.

I didn't pick up my running for the last few meters back to my home – my home? I nearly halted in my steps, then continued strolling slowly while thinking. Was I already referring to this place as my new home? It felt… weird. Not really wrong, but also not really right. Like something in between, not yet defined. A place that-could-be-but-wasn't. Thoughtfully, I walked back to Catra after freshening up and mentioned me watching the children play. "It was… nice, you know, to watch them. They are so full of live, like back in Alexandria." And it was true. I really enjoyed watching the little ones, and wished I could've talked to them. "It's a shame that I have to hide like this. I'm feeling so useless, and it's more than getting on my nerves."

"I… see", Catra answered slowly, obviously thinking about something, and after a while of pondering while eating breakfast, she came back with an idea: "How about if you teach them? Latin? And writing. And some basic math. Their parents won't, I mean, the most of them are illiterate. You could use your education, and this place needs something like a school, you know?"
It sounded tempting, but it was also impossible. "That's too dangerous, Catra. I can't risk being recognized, and you know it's best that I stay as hidden as possible."
She didn't want to let the idea go so quickly. "We could set up a classroom here, in my office. So the only ones that will actually see you, are the children. And as long as we dye it regularly, and keeping your hair under the scarf, nobody will notice that it's blonde. We can't hide your eyes, but your skin is so tanned in the meantime, that nobody takes you for a Roman or Greek."
She smirked smugly: "I mean, you could get a little tan in certain places, but all in all, you'll soon look like someone from Lower Egypt." She grinned with lust and started to caress my thigh,

while her fingers slowly moved upwards as she spoke the last words of her sentence. It made me twitch, feeling aroused and giddy at the same time. Her touch and the accompanying grin had lost none of its effect on me, it was even the other way around. The more we got to know each other and became familiar with our bodies, the more we started to react immediately to each other's little touchings, teasing, and words even. It was… stimulating. Freeing.

I batted her hand away and grinned. "Nah nah nah, you greedy little barbarian. Keep your fingers to yourself. This," and I gestured to myself in all my glory, "is a holy Roman temple and not for such foul beasts."
She laughed vigorously at me. "Your Roman holiness didn't moan so last night, you know? I remember it was rather hmpff…
I shut her mouth when I pushed myself onto her, letting her scream and squirm beneath me when I tickled her mercilessly. Catra was too surprised in the first place, but she quickly started to defend herself and some time later, we again found ourselves in her bed, naked, panting, full of sweat and were both blissful senseless.

"Phew! If you continue to gain your condition back like this, I'm fearing for my life," Catra teased while she looked at the ceiling, still I bit out of breath. I giggled and sighed: "It's really a pity that we didn't do this… earlier." And right, sometimes I regretted that we hadn't had the courage to move on more energetic sooner. Catra laughed, half-joyful, half-teasing: "By the gracious Isis, who knew that the self-controlled and dignified Adora of the Julii would fall so easily for some barbarian woman—"
"Some lascivious and lewd barbarian woman!", I cut in, nudging her.
"—from the end of the world. If people knew that all it took would be some tits—"
"Some gorgeous tits!", I added.
"And ass—"
"And it's a pretty ass!"
"They would be ashamed, Adora. Ashamed! You've fallen." She playfully slapped my boob, I gasped at the arousing bolt of pain,

then got scolded. “Eh, don’t be such a wimp.”
She grinned, and I nuzzled into her neck, taking in her smell. Never would I get tired of this mixture, where her perfume mingled with her own scent and was now completed with all the smells from our *bedly* activities. She beguiled me, aroused me, made me washy, and I basked in the feeling of being *wanted* by her as much as I wanted her.

We still lay next to each other when she picked up the subject from before: “Will you think about my idea? They are kids, Adora. Nobody has ever questioned a child on a manhunt.”
I let the idea roll around in my mind quietly, then admitted: “That’s… actually a good point.” Indeed, when I would only see the children here, in the guarded area of the governor’s seat and given my current appearance, the little ones wouldn’t be able to draw any connection between me and some weird, pale, blonde Roman that was being searched by the grown-ups. If they even got any of it. And I wanted to be useful, to make something out of all the time I had. Having nothing to do sounded nice for a few precious days with Catra on my side – or above me, or under me – but it wasn’t something I could do for long. I was used to being useful, needed it even.

And so, the following days, I found myself teaching children words and sentences in the Latin and Greek language, and together with Catra, I noodled out how to teach them writing in Demotic too. We picked up basic math like adding and multiplying numbers, and we played with coins to get a little grip on money. I drew maps of Egypt and the Roman – or rather of the Mediterranean – world and showed them where the great cities lay. Describing the wonders of Alexandria, Rome, Corinth or Antiochia to them was met with fascinated, and sometimes frightened eyes, when I slipped into descriptions of the occasional uprisings, overthrows, and wars that marked the important historical times. As if the quiet and peaceful periods never happened in our memories, we always oriented at the troubled times.

The class was only for two hours a day, but I looked forward to it because it gave my life a purpose, and made me happy. Three

blissful weeks went by. During the day, I prepared my lessons, taught them and stuck to my exercises to get my body back into shape, and in the nights, I put my newfound shape to good use when I got Catra undone beneath me, above me, beside me. I healed, and slowly adapted to a life in the middle of the Egyptian nowhere. Those were wonderful weeks.

Of course, it couldn’t be like that forever.

The sun burnt down in it’s everglowing way, the sky was merciless blue as always and no cloud was to be seen. I relaxed in the chair next to Catra, under the canopy before her office, like always after the lecture with the kids had ended. It was scorching hot, and everyone in Buhen had sought shelter until late afternoon, when the sun wasn't that piercing anymore. I completely understood and adapted to the way of life that put work in early morning and later afternoon hours, and sought a long-stretched break over noon. We were silent, and just enjoyed our mutual presence while doing absolutely nothing.

The peace was disturbed, when one of Catra’s soldiers hurried through the front gate of the yard and approached her quickly. “You grace,” the exhausted man coughed, “there is news from Syene!” I glanced over to her and saw her head shooting up and her eyes widening. A spark of trepidation spread through me. The man handed over a small scroll, which Catra unfolded instantly. Her face got worried more and more.
“What happened?” I asked, and was already fearing the answer. Without a word, she gave me the scroll to read.

Your ladyship,
a Roman century has reached Syene and is embarking this evening to sail for Buhen. They are led by a tribune, and he knows about her presence. This message will reach you at least

one and a half day in advance, but not more than two. It is also said that her majesty and Caesar are sailing up the Nile for Syene as of now. Be prepared.
N.

Her presence. That… that had to be me, hasn't it? And only one day at max? That means… that means they could arrive tomorrow at evening. A whole century? They would and could turn every stone in search of me.
Catra was already giving out orders that troops should be looking out for the incoming ships. She called for her officers and I got… to my surprise, I became very calm and serene. I wasn't panicking at all.

Because this was clarity.

The blissful times we had, had come to an end. I knew I had to go, and Catra had to make her decision. And then we knew where we would stand. I got up and started to walk into the house, when she gripped my arm and held me back. "Where are you going, Adora?" A hint of fear was written over her face.
I didn't look back, instead I wiggled my arm out of her hold. "What do you think? I'm going to pack some stuff I'll need", I harshly replied.
She looked at me incredulously. "What? No! You don't… you don't need to!"
I scoffed, now staring back. "Of course I do. You read it for yourself. It's a whole century, and they will search every corner of Buhen. It's inevitable they find me. I can't stay."
Catra crossed her arms before her chest. "And I have 300 men ready, and I have a fortress", she huffed. "A fortress Cleo ordered me to rebuild. Hah, they won't even enter the town if I don't let them in. They are just Romans, and they have no jurisdiction here." Her voice got a bit over the top.
I shook my head, knowing how empty her words were. "Don't be ridiculous, Catra. They will surely have a personal order from your beloved sister with them to legitimize everything they want to do. They will take over your little town, and then they will take me. And I can't let that happen, you know that."

She radiated despair. “But I can hide you, Adora! They won’t be here for… like… forever. We can hide you for some days, and then they will be gone again, and we can go back to… to how we lived in the last weeks.” Her facial expression got worried more and more. “Didn’t you like it too?”

I placed myself directly before her and took her cheeks between my hands, looking into her eyes with all assurance I could muster. “Catra, I want nothing more than to be with you, please believe me. The last weeks have been… wonderful. Wonderful and strenuous,” I chuckled desperately, and she let out a similar huff that made us both blush a little. “But staying here is dangerous for me. Buhen is not a large place and hiding here… no, Catra. A hundred men can search this place in no time. I would be found. You know I have to go.”
I took her hands into mine and pressed them. “But I must not go alone. You can come with me, Catra. Come with me. Just one week of travel upwards the Nile, and we are out of their reach. All the power of the people that rule over us now is nothing but a pale memory there. Nobody cares about Caesar or Cleopatra or whatever there. We could… We could be together, just you and me. And then we’ll see what this world has in store for us.” Putting a lot of emphasis into my words, I really hoped it had an effect on her. That I was persuading enough.

Catra looked taken aback, her brows were ragged, and she sounded doubting. “And then what? Being refugees in some foreign, barbaric land, Adora?”
I chuckled. “Sounds fitting to me. I mean, you are actually a half-barbarian, so it would be like coming home, won't it?”
She batted my hand away. “Very funny. This isn't a nice road trip, Adora. Kush is… it’s not like here, it’s not a civilized place like the Mediterranean world. It’s little villages and a few larger towns, not to call them cities. Even Meroe is just something they call a capital, but it’s rather a place where their tribes gather, when they’re going on the warpath. And beyond that? Nobody knows for real. Some believe the world just ends behind the source of

the Nile, wherever that may be. Nothing might be behind Aethiopia.” [129]

I smiled gently. “And wouldn’t it be a journey to go there, to look for ourselves? It would be an adventure we do together. Just you and me, Catra. You and me and nothing but. Don't you want to be with me?” I sounded so pleading, but I didn’t care anymore. There had to be a way to get through her fears, to convince her.

Because… what should I do without her?

“Of course I want”, she shouted, a mixture of anger and desperation dripping from her voice. “But I don’t want to be on the run for the rest of our lives, either. Maybe, within some time, we can persuade Cleo and your uncle to call this stupid marriage off.”
I huffed. That was an illusion. “Nothing will stop them, Catra. They are determined, you’ve seen that when she ordered…”.
I wasn’t willing to go there again. “Just believe me when I say, that they will burn down everything in their struggle for power. Caesar doesn’t care that he destroys the old Republic and raises a dictatorship. He is blinded by his own glory, and the legions are following him willingly since years. And Cleopatra has fallen for him, she is blinded by him as much as he is by her. She is not the person you knew anymore. Their heads are filled with the thought that what they want is right and nothing but. They will do whatever they want to do and at all cost. I cannot be a part of this.” I got louder. “I don’t WANT to be a part of my father’s or uncle Julius’ doing anymore. And you can’t protect me or even yourself from them, as long as you stay under her rule. Don’t blind yourself, you can’t fix this.”
“But Adora! You don’t know—”
“I know! There’s no denying it, and the only question left is: will you come with me, Catra? Come with me!”

She buried her head in my collarbone and clung to me. “I just got you back, Adora. I could never let you go. Never!” That was desperation voiced loud, but I felt how my heart made a jump.
“Then come with me!”, I whispered. “We can… just walk away.

You and me. We can move on, Catra. Together.” With every word, I petted her hair and she stroked over my cheek, while I kissed her forehead in assurance. We sunk into each other's embrace and I tried to hope. Hope that she would finally choose me.

Catra silently replied: “I want us to have a place we can call home. And this place, as forsaken and forgotten as it may be, is something that feels alike. Don’t you get that?”

I felt my world shatter.

I understood her. She was frightened. Not only to leave Buhen, it wasn’t just like that. It was also the fear to cut the last ties with her sister. If she ran away now, with me, that would it be between them. Cleopatra would not forgive Catra another time, another disobedience, that much I knew. She was too determined and because she couldn’t hurt or punish me for real – beside persuading my uncle to go forth with their plans – she would take it out on Catra. Catra was replacable.

And Catra urged me. “Please, Adora, for once in your life: stay. Stay here, I will hide you. They won’t find you and I… I will protect you with all I have. They will be gone again, and then we’ll have our rest here. I promise.” She sounded desperate and her look flickered upon her plea. I stared into her eyes, unconvinced and torn between my desires. Raging disbelieve and my overwhelming desire to stay at her side warred in me. “Please, Adora,” she continued begging, and I couldn’t… I knew it was wrong to give in. It was just that I couldn’t resist her voice. She sounded so small and lost, and I couldn’t say ‘no’ to the woman I loved with an intensity that it was partly terrifying. So, without a word, I nodded, with a fist in my gut clenching my inners, not being able to voice it loud.

We spent the rest of the afternoon carefully examining a few hideouts Catra pointed out to me. During her previous time in Buhen she’d been able to investigate the fortress and buildings well enough. We finally decided upon one that seemed obscure and well-hidden to cache me for a few days. We stored water and

food in the little chamber that had only a small window to the outside, below a viewing platform of one of the watchtowers, invisible to everyone on the ground or inside Buhen. The only access was made through a trapdoor that was hidden beneath a well-made camouflage in a staircase. It was an excellent hiding place - Catra clapped her hands in excitement, and smiled when we closed the door. “No one will get this. That’s even better than I could image.”

But I didn’t feel any better. It was practically a trap with no other exit.

We returned to her quarter for dinner, and I warily eyed her while we ate, not willing to give away my troubled feelings that stormed inside me. I was… frightened, nearly trembling, so much that I overheard her talking to me.
“Adora?”
“What?” I was startled from my thinking.
“Where are you?” Her look was worried, I could tell.
“Uhmm… I just pondered about tomorrow, you know. It’s… unsettling.”
She tried to catch my gaze, but I avoided her look. “I know. But you'll stay, right?” she asked.
What should I say?
“I stay,” I pressed out between clenched teeth.
“Promise?”
“I promise.”

At this night, we clung together and did nothing but caress each other. There was no heated lovemaking, no sex to which I got so acquainted. Instead, Catra whispered assurances into my ears while she held me, and I just let it happen. I stroked her back, snuggled against her chest and let her pet me, already knowing that the next few days would be incredibly hard for both of us.

Catra

("The Burning Bush", Deezer / Spotify / YouTube)[130]

It was still dark, still in the middle of the night. But something woke me up. I blinked and when I touched my cheek I noticed the wetness. It was like small drops of water that had dripped on my face. Then my view adapted to the little starlight that fell into the room through the window and I saw Adora hovering over me, her upper body propped up on her elbows and one arm that embraced me from the other side. Her hair fell to the sides, and she looked beautiful like that. Beautiful and worried.
"Are you… crying? What happened, did you have a nightmare?" I sleepily asked, touching her sides softly.
Adora sniffled and touched my face with one of her hands. She stroked my cheek and whispered. "It's okay, my love. Everything's okay. I'm here. You're here."
I raised my hands to her head and drew her down on my chest, resting her face on my boobs. She still sobbed, but it eased slowly. "Why are you crying?" I asked quietly, while I petted her hair and cheek, drawing little circles with my hand around her nose.
"It's nothing," she muffled lowly into my breast. Her arms gripped around me and as always I was stunned about the strength Adora could muster. And while I still rubbed her back and she clung to me, I slowly fell asleep again. I felt loved by a goddess and was embraced by the most wonderful woman in the world.

If I had only listened to my gut feeling.

When I woke up in the morning, it wasn't quite light outside yet. Dawn rose and a cloudless blue sky heralded the heat of another day. Adora's meadowy scent still lingered around in the bed, and I allowed myself a few precious moments to bathe in her presence. But when I felt around next to me, I quickly realized that there was no Adora at my side. Only the air still carried the memory of the woman I loved. I wondered if she might have gone to the

bathrooms or if she was pilfering the kitchen on the hunt for food, like she'd done it so often. This woman could eat.
And it soon turned out that I wasn't entirely wrong with my second assumption. As I walked down, two of the cooks immediately started to complain that someone had stolen fresh bread and several sausages. Honey jars were missing too, as well as ingredients for baking and a pot of salt.

I suddenly had a terrible feeling and stormed back into my rooms, leaveing the cookies to their complaints. I ran through the bedroom, dressing room, balcony, bathroom, no Adora. Nowhere. But while searching around, I noticed that more of her items were missing. My gut only got more tight and fear gripped my heart now. What if she…
Only then I discovered the letter on my desk. It laid open and only one of the little stone seals I used for marking my letters with wax was put upon to hold it. I picked the papyrus up and with ever rising horror I began to read.

Dear Catra,
leaving your home and, most of all, you, doesn't come easy for me. Because without any doubt, I can say: you are the love of my life. These last few weeks have been everything I ever wanted. I thank you for all of it.

But I want you to make your own decision, and I gift you with the possibility to make it. I want you to choose me, because I need certainty.
You know I cannot sacrifice the freedom I discovered, and I can't ask you to sacrifice the love for your sister on my behalf.
And neither will I ever go back to my family, nor will I let myself be forced to do so. I would be abducted, locked up and eventually put into a forced marriage. If not with this one, then with another man that my uncle seems useful to him. And you can't hinder them.

I won't let myself be used as a tool. I am not a weapon, nor a slave. I am just Adora, and I belong to me. Being able to learn that because of you made me happy, and I am so so grateful for

this present. And beside having you, this is all that I want. So, I hope that you will be my family from now on, and I beg you to be. Because you're worth more than what you can give to other people! You deserve love, too!

But this also comes at a cost. If you'll come with me, I promise, you'll find peace. Make this choice, and we will live our lives together. We can have sons and daughters, and they will have children. And they will love you as much as I do. And when you're gone, and I'm gone, they will remember us. When our children are dead and their children after them, your name and mine will be lost in the sand of time. And it will be good.

If you stay on Cleopatra's side, immortal glory will be your fate. Generations will write stories about your victories for thousands of years to come. The world will remember your name for millennia. But if you do, you'll never come home. You'll never come home to me. Because this glory walks hand in hand with doom, and I cannot be a part of this. We shall never see again.

So, I beg you. From the third morning after today, I'll wait for you at the Temple of Nefertari for three days. Come with me!
You are the morning and the evening, my day and night. You are my everything.

I love you,
Adora. [131]

I didn't know how long I stood there, gripping at the table with my hands after I let go of the letter. Tears streamed down my cheeks and watered my dress and the desk. Conflicting feelings arose in me. Adora was gone. She'd left me. She left!
But she promised! She promised! She PROMISED to stay! I started crumbling her letter, but then quickly stopped it, tried to take in a deep breath. It was hard.

Breathe! She wants to give you a choice, you goddamn idiot. So now, you can choose. You can choose her over Cleopatra, actually, and finally. Make the right decision for once in your life. Don't be a coward. She loves you.

But she left. She just ran away and left me behind without saying a word. How could she?!

I slumped into the chair and my gaze wandered outside the window, where my eyes lay upon the desert. The unforgiving, never-ending and though so beautiful desert. Where Adora now was. What should I do? My hands clenched to fists and inside me a raging fire burned. I wanted to tear something down, to punch something. But I didn't.

Morning went by until I was able to form a coherent thought again. Then I quietly ordered a tracker to search for traces she'd left and while I still waited for his return, I scurried around in the yard and gnawed on my fingernails. What should I do now? All of me wanted to follow her, to run after her.
But I was honestly fearing the consequences which would inevitably follow that decision. I would lose Cleo forever, and all that came with being close to her. The amenities weren't my main concern, but the idea of losing them still nagged on me. Loosing access to this kind of power and influence, over my status as that untouchable sister of the almighty Pharaoh.

And then, when I tried to imagine a future where Adora was not there, I finally found what I always needed to know, but hadn't known: certainty.

Adora was certainty. Certainty I wanted.

And I wouldn't leave this certainty in my life for anything. This was it. This was my answer: I would follow her. Damn my duties. My people here were perfectly able to go on without me. Damn her uncle. And damn my sister that just couldn't get over herself.

Only minutes later, I was in the middle of packing my stuff into a backpack, when Shoshan rushed in and announced the incoming Roman century.
Shit! Fucking shit. Too early. Much too early.
It was still morning, and these bastards had been fast. I'd difficulties not to panic, while the fully armed unit rushed into the yard of the governor's seat, taking over the gates quickly and manning the most important places immediately. This was more than a strong reminder of how serious Caesar and Cleopatra were in getting Adora back. The already known tribune threw me a scrutinizing look, held out a scroll with his orders, and waved with it until I took it in a daze.
Cleo's orders were precise and without any leeway: *"Catra, hand over Adora. You are under arrest. Follow the tribune's orders."* She used a few more words, but that was the essence.

I hissed while I was ushered into my own office, and my only relief was that Adora was already far away. I apologized with a wicked grin, and lied that Adora had fled days ago. Then I laughed, and the tribune got angry, and after that, a vigorous womanhunt began. They searched everything, the whole settlement and fortress, turning every stone over and questioning as good as everyone. Even the children. Oh gracious goddess, had I been delusional about the children.
They found all the hideouts. And if there'd been a bit of anger about Adora's runaway left, it was wiped off my mind by the realization, that she'd been right: she would have been seized and taken away.
He sent out search parties into the desert and up and down the Nile on the hunt for Adora, while I was being watched carefully. My advisors were furious about the manners and demeanor with which the Romans treated them and me alike, but I had neither the strength nor the will to resist their impertinence. It would've been madness, and I didn't care about myself. Adora was on the run, and I was no longer in command either.
The tracker I sent out didn't come back for two days. Then, one of the search parties discovered his body and returned with the news of him being shot by an arrow on a rocky plateau only a few

hours northwest of Buhen. There, Adora's track directly led and vanished into the stony desert. Into the nothingness. I desperately chuckled: the bitch had become really dangerous and was ready to defend herself. It was a little relief.

And of course I hid Adora's letter and told them nothing about it, not willing to raise their chances to lay a hand on her. I was possessive. Nobody should read her thoughts and words to me, nobody besides me. Nobody. And of course not Cleo. She as the very last.

On the fourth day of the mad womanhunt, I broke down, because I knew, Adora was gone by now. She said she would wait for me three days, and three days had passed. Adora was gone.
While I crouched on the ground of my chamber, I tried to imagine how she must feel right now. She had to think that I'd made a decision, that I didn't want to follow her. That I had preferred my sister to her. I cried. *I'm so sorry, Adora. I should've gone with you in the first place. Without hesitation. Without fear. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.*

Another four days later, and with a town in uproar against the Roman overstepping of every line of decency, the tribune finally accepted that Adora wasn't to be found. He rallied his troops and ordered me to follow him to Dendera.[132] There I would have to answer to Cleopatra and Caesar personally.
And again, I didn't care at all, and I went willingly but also aphatically with him and his unit. The whole trip I was not sure whether I was rather a prisoner or still the governor of an Egyptian city, but I also had no strength left in me to worry about such trifles.

Adora was gone, and that was it. There was nothing left for me to care about. So, the travel to Dendara went by in a haze from

which I didn't remember anything. I was barely able to keep myself together, let alone keep coherent thoughts. The picture of Adora, alone at Nefertiri's temple, waiting for me, wiped everything else off my mind and within time, I hadn't even the strength left to cry.
I was a bit surprised when I was pushed through the gate of Hathor's temple of Dendera into the hypostyle.[133] A table and chairs had been set up there, shielded from the scorching sun by the large columns and the roof of the building. Large cloths for sun protection and against the desert sand fluttered on the sides, where guards also stood, looking grim.
And in one of the chairs set up in the middle of it all sat Cleo, with a worried face and very, very pregnant.

"Hello sister," she greeted me friendly, without getting up. "I'm a bit inconvenient, sorry." She touched her belly, but her gaze was guarded.
As was mine. "So… it won't be long until you're a mother, right?," I finally managed.
She pulled a one-sided grin. "Yes."
"When did this happen?" I blurted, and Cleo had the nerve to actually look a bit guilty.
"The Child?" She was blushing just lightly. "Uhm… during the Siege, of course. I mean, there hasn't been someone else with whom—"
She cut herself short upon the blatant confession, and I chuckled. "Never took you for someone to sleep around, sister. I just didn't expect you to go the whole way yourself to secure this… alliance. And if I'm counting right, then it must have happened fast, in October, early of November maybe, so..."
"Yeah, yeah, I know it happened fast for myself. I was there, duh?"

The thought was amusing and annoying at the same time. "You really jumped into his bed quickly, didn't you?". I came out harder than perhaps intended, but not by much.
She blushed a little more. I didn't care, because one question pestered me the whole time since the first rumors'd reached me.

“What I don’t understand: if you already got him, then why were you so persistent on getting Adora also?”

Cleo rolled her eyes. “Don’t be so stupid, Catra. In a few weeks, Gaius will be gone, and no one knows if he comes back. He has a war to fight, to win. The senate isn’t beaten, and even when it is, he will return to Rome. And then what? Shall I leave Alexandria and Egypt to go with him to Rome, to follow him? How long can I do that without losing my throne to some usurpator[134] here?”
“But with a child stemming from him…?”, I tried to interject, but she only scoffed: “As if that would be enough for a man not to leave a woman behind. You should really know better, sister. And it’s not that I had to force myself into his bed. Just like any other woman who shared the same. This,” she touched her belly again, “is only one more string to tie him to Egypt, to us, to me.” Her voice became firmer and firmer, almost manic as she spoke. “But the more ties there are, the better. We need them, as we can’t afford insecurities when it comes to Rome. The Julian's will stay a ruling force, whatever happens to a single one of them.” Her voice got pitched too high. “One of Caesar’s descendants might even lay claim to—” She stopped when realizing what she was just about to admit.

And as always, the amount of foresight and planning Cleo’d put into her considerations stunned me. *She is really thinking a generation ahead*, I mused, but it didn’t fill me with delight. Instead, another thought occupied my mind: “You’re using this pregnancy, this poor child, to bind him. Do you really think your child can rule over Rome and Egypt?”
“Who can say? But the chance is not bad.”
“You're using it. Just as you do with Adora.”
“Of course I do,” she snarled, but I wasn’t finished.
“You’re using anyone. Like a tool. Like a weapon,” I stated, and then: “Just as you did with me,” I finished half-loud, rather speaking to myself, but she got it nonetheless, and I continued more firmly: “You know what's funny? Now I understand Adora’s words better, you know? She wrote she didn’t want to be used as a weapon? All the girl wanted was some freedom of choice over

her own fate, and all of you, with all your power, weren't able to give her even that." I spat out the last words. "No wonder she ran away."
Then I huffed, nearly laughing, and grinned wickedly at her: "You'll never get her back. And you know what? I'm happy. Happy that you power-greedy morons can't lay your hands on her again. You'll never find her. Hah!"

And Cleopatra got angry, her voice was dripping with wrath: "You stupid cow, with your romantic ideas. What do you think it takes ruling a kingdom? It takes all of your determination, all your focus, your whole being. You can't be distracted anytime, because otherwise you'll be just dead. It takes EVERYTHING! You sleep in fear the whole time, frightened of assassins, of betrayal, of people you trusted turning against you." Now she screamed. "You can't afford romance when you're in my position. You can barely afford to trust someone you like. And the entire time everyone comes to you with their demands, with all their ridiculous whining" she sarcastically choked with a high-pitched voice upon her last words, "and all their complaints about how unfair life is. I'm so tired of this."
A strangled noise cut her off, then she got dead serious again, and her voice dropped an octave, her face grim. "Life is unfair, Catra. I learned it the hard way when I saw Berenice being beheaded in front of me on the order of the pig that was our father. And that night, when I shivered in your arms, I swore that I wouldn't go that way. I would take power on my own, without anyone droning over me, without anyone exerting power over me. And if one day I meet someone I cannot defeat, I will go on my own terms. Until then, I'm doing what's needed to bring our land to its old power, so that no one can force anything upon us."
And with "us", she very much included herself, that much I clearly understood.

It was silent for a few moments. Cleopatra panted a bit and needed to breathe, while I tried to process everything, just standing there without moving. One thing I already got: that my view of her'd irreconcilable changed.

I heaved a deep breath. "You really listened to Alexas, didn't you. Even if you pretended not to, you did, right?" He was the one using the 'Life is unfair'-phrase upon us very often. He also taught us to watch our back, to trust no one beside ourselves, and not to be frightened by anyone. Those'd been boring lessons so often, but now, more than a decade later, I understood them so much better.
"Do you remember, when we used to drive him crazy with us playing tricks on him. He must have aged at least one additional decade," Cleopatra chuckled, but it was a low and weak noise.

Of course, I remembered it.

Clearly. Vividly. My memory had always been excellent, pulling up all the good and bad ones with ease. So it wasn't hard to picture little Cleopatra and little Catra, playing hide-and-seek, sneaking into the kitchen, skipping lectures with our different tutors, throwing a bag of rice down into the yard just to see the grains splashing all over the ground, whispering in a closet where we hid from our angry mother when she tried to scold us for it.

I remembered it.

I recalled how I held the scared teenager that clung to me after her sister had been beheaded, and how he looked at Cleo afterwards. She was too young to be a proper queen and bearer of his children then, but it would've been a matter of just a few years, and she clearly knew, even back then. She fled into my room after the coronation ceremony that made her pharaoh the first time then, and I held her for a whole night.

I remembered all of it.

However, and despite my understanding, it also didn't escape my memory of what she'd done. To me, but foremost, to Adora. She'd pushed her until even Adora couldn't take it anymore. Adora, the always kind, always giving, always complying Adora. She drove her away because she'd fallen for her own and her lover's demands without counting the lives of others in. Without counting

my life in.
I had never asked her for anything until that day. And she'd denied me even that.

My look must have given it away. She may have sensed that something in our previous relationship was broken and that it would take more than time and a few nice words to fix it. If it was even possible.
I doubted it, to be honest, but Cleo was still Cleo, and she was none to give up.

"What should I have done instead? Give her to you, Catra?" Her eyes wandered over me, searching for something I couldn't place. The weird wording sent a shiver through me and I huffed. "Give her to me? Do you even listen to yourself? She's not a commodity, you damn idiot. And by the way: we are related, Cleo. You could've made me an equal to any governor, to any noble of this fucking kingdom of yours. But you haven't even given that option a thought, have you? You don't see me as someone worthy enough. And you don't care who suffers, as long as you win."

Cleopatra, sole ruler over millions of people, so familiar and so estranged at the same time, held my look for a long time, until she finally lowered her eyes and spoke with a suppressed voice. "*Fine*. Make me your villain. I do what I do for the best of Egypt. And you know you couldn't have handled it."
"It, Cleo? What do you mean with it? Isn't this about her? Unless… it isn't? It actually isn't about her, right? It's rather that you don't believe that I'm an equal to you. That I couldn't be as responsible and oh-so-mighty as you, queen Cleopatra, Pharaoh, the mistress of sedge and bee." My voice grew spiteful. "You really think that you're someone better than me." Looking down on the ground, she stayed silent. It told me everything I needed to know.

I chuckled lowly and chagrin filled my voice: "After all we've been through, Cleo? Ugh! And I stupid idiot didn't see it all the time. But you know, I'm honestly not even really offended anymore. I'm… I'm disappointed. And when I'm thinking about it, I don't

find it in me to believe that you're worthy of my services anymore, sister."
Her head snapped up, frowning, her gaze unsure, uneasy.
This was a break that we probably could never heal again, and it didn't need her always attentive manner for to realize that.

But she made her decision, and so I had to make mine.

In a more calm and quiet tone, I continued: "Just send me back to Buhen, Cleo, please. The funny thing is: I… I really like it there. I will keep it for you for the time being. It's actually not a bad assignment. After all, it's as far away from you as possible." I shortly hesitated to say the following words, but I wanted to give her a perspective, an incentive to accept my offer. "Maybe I'll be able to forgive you, when I don't have to see you for a few years. Who knows. Just… send me back until then."

And that was that. For the rest of the evening, I kept my distance and remained mostly silent, when we held dinner with a few other locale nobles. She glanced at me occasionally, but we didn't speak much more words beside some trivia. The father of her child, Adora's uncle, now-ruler of the Mediterranean world, eyed me suspiciously a few times, but didn't speak a word to me directly. I was grateful when I was allowed to withdraw and go to my bed not soon enough.

The next morning, Cleopatra and Caesar had mounted their horses and the legionaries had already gathered behind them, always four men to a row and ready to march at their signal. After the leading officers on their horses, several soldiers with tubas, flutes, drums and cornua made up the first lines of the convoy and were also waiting for the signal to commence.
I caught how Cleopatra shot me a wary last look, but she didn't say anything. And if there'd been some regret or an unspoken

question about our future in her eyes, I wouldn't have noticed that, because I just stared motionless to the side, not any longer responding to her. She agreed to send me back to Buhen, but I hadn't had to give her any concession for so little.

I was startled when Caesar put spurs to his horse and immediately the entire front formation fell into a practiced, steady stride.

(Gracchus, something more cheerful)[135]

The bandsman ordered a steady rhythm to be played, to which the cohort began moving in lockstep. Caesar turned to the side and called: "Gracchus, something more cheerful." The mentioned legionary waved a hand sign to his playing comrades, whereupon the tonality of the march changed accordingly.

The Aquilifer, the bearer of the standard of the legion, walked by. He held the Aquila of the 13th legion, a tall rod that had a golden Roman eagle mounted at the top, above other insignia. Beside him, two other standard-bearers held the banners of the first cohort, as well as a banner that showed Cleopatra's insignia, the crown of the two lands.
To the merry sounds of playing tubas, flutes and drums, the cohort left the garrison, taking my sister as well as her new ally and soon-to-be father of her first child with them like the sea the spume.
I quietly questioned for how long this alliance or relationship between the two of them would hold. Maybe long enough for me to do what was necessary.

It took the hundreds of men of the cohort a long time to leave the fort, every single one in step with his predecessor. I stood and listened to the uniform, hobnailed steps of the marching men under the blazing Egyptian sun. While the music silenced more and more in the distance, I pondered about my next steps.
My orders were clear, Buhen was again my aim to go, and my will to reconcile with Cleopatra in the future was… nothing I had to think about.

The whole scene of Cleopatra leaving me behind in the now emptying garrison reminded me very much of how Adora had walked out of my life, back then, at Hordak's villa. The memory still hurt.
The cohort slowly vanished between the houses and palms along the road.

I rubbed my temples and sighed heavily. Always. She was always in my mind, ever since, from the moment we'd met until today. I doubted that this would ever change.

Adora.

Please forgive me for not doing the right thing when it was time.

Adora

Like I said – or rather wrote – I waited for Catra for three days.

Deep in today's no man's land between Egypt and Kush lay the Temple of Nefertari[136]. Due to some detours that I had to take to cover my tracks, it took me two and half days to reach it. But now I was here, marching towards the site from the north. Nobody was to be seen.

The temple itself was a beauty. Erected beside the Nile in a part of the desert where nothing else was, only the more than a thousand-year-old building stood, unmoved, unimpressed by all the human struggles. Built by a Pharaoh and his slaves for his wife and co-regent thirteen centuries ago, it had every reason to. It was still there, while generations of man had passed. The largest part of the temple was carved out of a sandstone rock. The surface towards the front consisted of statues and large columns that stood before it. Every pillar was richly ornamented with ancient Egyptian hieroglyphs, depicting the weird graphic

language that was long forgotten and that no one was able to read and write anymore.[137]

Sometimes one could try to judge what the odd pictures meant, when they showed a little a figure holding an eagle, or waves above a snake. Because I had nothing else to do, I took my time trying to decipher the inscriptions on the columns, but my knowledge of the difficult signs was pretty much non-existent. However, the beauty of the carvings and the whole inscriptions were testament to their creators as well as their makers.
I spent hours strolling around the area, even walking into the already looted tombstones. That wasn't surprising. Ages of kingdoms and man had come and gone by since the building of the temples, and they would be there for further millennia. Of course, they wouldn't be left alone, during all these tides of humankind.

(Niobe's Fate) [138]

And I was alone. In all the days, no living soul had approached the site, and I didn't care about the unliving, presumably buried in the temple. Only a few boats passed by on the river, but I didn't want to be seen, and so I hid myself then every time.
It was quiet, and boring, and the waiting nagged at me. While the sun burnt down from a blue and cloudless sky, the third day passed, and I decided to wait a bit more. Sometimes the wind blew sand beyond the half-buried entrance of the temple, and it looked beautiful, in all its abandoned loneliness. All the scenery perfectly matched my own feelings.

Lonely.

Abandoned.

So, I waited for three more days.

And then I waited three more days.

I tried to persuade myself, that she would come around any day, any hour, any minute. That she had been hindered, that she had to wait to get away safely. That she had to prepare her departure, to deal with the Romans or whatever. But I also realized that I was slowly running out of food and the inevitable decision was forced on me on my tenth day at the temple.
The day had been boring, as every day since my arrival, and the supplies I'd stolen from Catra's kitchen fed me well enough, but the portions started to grow smaller and less frequent. The desert provided me with nothing – my knowledge and abilities were still just too little – and only the Nile helped in providing me with water. One of my most important tasks over the course of the day was to filter and cook water. I'd also stolen some salt, because I knew from Huntara that water, salt, and a bit of food were the main ingredients to keep someone alive in the heat of the Sahara. I collected driftwood from the shores of the river and found a dry bush here and there to make the needed campfire. Huntara taught me that drinking river water without boiling it before could make me sick. But boiled water, with a spoon of salt in it, kept you alive and well.

Much worse than my worries for food was that growing feeling of hopelessness. With every day passing, my hope crumbled a little more, leaving more room for doubt and fear. I'd always doubted that she would defy Cleopatra's will and come to me. And I feared that she would give in to her and my uncle's demands to capture me again. But I still hoped that she would choose otherwise. My decision to leave, to grant her with the possibility of a free choice, had been the hardest I'd ever made in my life. But I needed certainty. That she would choose me.

And I slowly realized, that Catra'd made her decision. But she'd not betrayed me either.

So, when I saw a caravan approaching around noon, I realized, that I also had to make a decision. It was time to face reality: Catra would not come at all.

I was leaning against one of the pillars of Nefertari's temple and needed to steady myself at it as the finality of the decision took my breath away. I gasped. Tears formed in the corners of my eyes and I desperately fought them down, trying to catch my breath again, to stop my hands from trembling.
A last time, I looked back into the inside of the temple, admiring the statue of Nefertari as Hathor. Catra called me *Hathor* too, one night, as she whispered *You are like if Hathor herself has stepped down to earth, willing to mortify us simple humans with your mere presence.* I'd only giggled upon her ridiculous words, not knowing what to say or reply upon the praise, and I quickly kissed her again then. That night had been wonderful. Wonderful, and passionate, and the memory of it made me want to cry.

I shook it off. The past. It was already in the past.

I picked up my backpack and trudged over to the river shore, where the caravan had made rest in the meantime, watering their camels. It consisted of only a dozen of them and some herders with their goats. In my still bumpy Demotic and underlining everything with gestures I thought helpful, I asked the leader of the trek if I could join them for a few days. And after a short negotiation, he allowed it. The middle-aged man clearly wasn't used to seeing a woman like me, on her own, in the middle of the Upper Egyptian desert. But after I demonstrated my abilities with bow and arrow, he took me as an asset rather than a liability and gave in.

So I started walking further southwards with the caravan, her ultimate goal being Medewi, far in the south. We slowly moved forward on a track that was just a path in the desert, mostly in visibility of the Nile. And with the Temple of Nefertari vanishing in the whirring desert air, I knew, the greater part of my life was vanishing too. I didn't even realize it until I felt it on my hands. Tears started to stream down my cheeks. Looking down at the ground, and putting one foot in front of the other, over and over again, I cried silently, while my mind was lost in thought.

My family.

My father.

My sister.

Bow.

Catra.

Most of all, Catra.

For all I knew, I would never see any of them again. While I walked, with some camels in front of me and the goat herders with their goats behind me, I mourned about my sister, whom I hadn’t seen for two years. I didn’t mourn for the rest of my family. Should they destroy themselves in their struggle for power, I didn’t care anymore. I mourned for Bow. For Catra. What kind of life would it be, without her, if I would never see her again.

I knew I could not survive the desert on my own. But here, at the river, I had water and now and then a traveler or a caravan would cross my way. I was already out of the reach of the authority and borders of the Roman World.[139] And so, I could go just a bit further, with every passing day. Just a little further. To discover the new, unknown world that lay before me. One last time, I looked back at the distant temple of Nefertari. Just a bit further away. Thirteen centuries had passed since its erection. I blinked and, for a moment, the scorching heat and the rising hot air bedazzled me. And when I looked again, the temple was no more to be seen. Gone. All was gone.
She was gone.

I turned my teary eyes back forward, looking towards the distant lands of the Kingdom of Kush. We would need nearly a week to reach the next village, not to call it a town. Here, everything was smaller and larger at the same time. The distances greater, the settlements smaller. And the settlement wouldn't be an Egyptian one. And behind that, who knew?

Maybe, I could have a life there too.
Maybe.
And, maybe, I could have another love there.
Maybe.

I cried.

I cried.

Chapter End Notes

The last chapter is called **"The beginning of a journey - an epilogue"** and will be published tomorrow, Saturday, September 11, 2021.
Yeah, I like it pathetic and melodramatic. I'm basking in it. Sue me.

[129] In the antiquity, the term "Aethiopia" refers to all land beyond the Sahara and up the Nile beyond Meroe. Sometimes the Kushites were named "Aethiopians", because it was coined for people with dark skin. The Greek word 'Aitiopia' is a compound from "aitho, I burn" and "ops, face" and translated to something like "burnt-face", which makes sense given the fact that "real black" people from beyond the Northern African provinces weren't common in the Mediterranean world. "Aethiopia" was therefore also a term for a distant, unknown world yet to discover. In the time of this story, the word applied to the dark-skinned people the Mediterranean world knew, which were mostly from Upper Nubia, i.e. Kush, which is today Sudan.↑
[130] Even if you never did, please, put on the music for once, because the following text is tailored to this.↑
[131] Parts of this letter draw their origin in Thetis' prophecy and doing in the Iliad. Thetis was described as a mythical creature, sometimes a goddess herself, and she was the mother of Achillas, the greatest warrior of the Greeks in the Trojan war. Thetis predicted Achillas a similar fate like I wrote it here for Catra, and, in extension, Caesar & Cleopatra. The Iliad and the whole Trojan war respectively is an unbelievable

dramatic story, full of death and tragedy. Modern adaptations made it very well readable, and I cannot recommend it highly enough to give it a try. ↥

[132] During her later reign, Cleopatra would initiate and oversee two large building projects of temples to stabilize the labor market, one of them in Dendera, where a temple complex already stood and was enlarged. Cleopatra had a relief put on it, depicting her and her son Caesarion making offerings to the gods. It is one of the few surviving images of her. ↥

[133] The Hypostyle is basically a roof supported by columns, mainly at the front entrance of imposing buildings and temples in Ancient architecture. The ancient Greek term hypóstȳlos means "under columns". ↥

[134] Usurpator, a usurper, stemming from the latin verb 'usurpare', which means 'to take into possession', which typically means someone who takes the power of government with force.
And Cleo actually would leave Egypt to follow Caesar to Rome. ↥

[135] "With a simple flick of this wrist, Gracchus managed to summon the sound of violin, keyboards, herps and the entirety of the London symphonic opera." > A comment on Youtube. ;-) Sorry, I just had to pull this. It's fitting, but also for relief and because I like "Rome" so much. ↥

[136] The temple of Nefertari is one of the two twin temples of Abu Simbel. They lay beside the Nile, but actually between Syene (Aswan) and Buhen (Wadi Halfa). For the sake of the story, I place Nefertari's temple upwards of Buhen towards Kush, because I wanted to use the location and Adora must flee in the right direction. Everything else is like it is in real. ↥

[137] Early and Old Egyptian hieroglyphs ceased being used around 2,000 BCE. ↥

[138] Just to mention it: like Catra's scene with "The Burning Bush", the following one is also tailored to this exact instrumental soundtrack piece, and it nails the mood perfectly. ↥

[139] At its height, the Roman Empire would formally reach to the first cataract of the Nile, that is, as far as Syene (Aswan). Its military and de facto control exerted partially beyond, maybe until the second cataract, and expeditions and military campaigns reached even further south. However, Lower Nubia stayed a wild and distant land, far from a real control through the empire and the Roman reign was only short, as the tides turned against the Roman influence soon enough again. ↥

The beginning of a journey - an epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Nubia, months later

Adora

This is my present. And it is a present in so many ways.

I've been at this oasis for a while, maybe a month, maybe longer. It is certainly the longest time since I left Egypt where I settle in one place. I don’t know for sure, because I don't count days and nights anymore. And why should I? They just mean nothing to me any longer, and to be honest, so much else doesn’t anymore too. I don't care about how many days went by since then and then or what day it is at all.
Today, I care about water. I care about food. I care about a safe place to sleep at night. I care about taking a bath now and then, because even in my current state, I don’t want to stink. I care about being healthy. And that's about it.

While staying here, this place has grown on me. I like it here. When I rest during the heat of the day, I listen to wind and the lessons it tells me. My assumptions that I won’t be able to survive on my own in the desert turned out to be premature.
In fact, I can. I can survive here, and it isn't actually so hard.

Actually, I can do so much I hadn’t thought I was able to. This oasis is small, but the water is always clear and cold, presumably being fed by a very weak, but also steady fountain or maybe a groundwater flow. The Nile is far from here, but who knows where his waters flow underground. There are some palms and few date trees, some annoying cacti that I really hate, and sometimes,

antelopes or fennecs come by and make up for a prey to hunt. I haven't starved a single day, and I have plenty of water to drink. I don’t even boil it anymore before drinking it. Just some filtering through a piece of fabric is quite enough to get rid of the dirt that doesn’t drop. Huntara’s little tricks do well here, and luckily, I remember most of them. And I invent my own. If I run out of certain things or if I need anything else, I know how to get it. Fennec furs are always in demand and I can sell one or two in return for my needed goods. I just have to seek human company, which I try not to for some time.

Every day, I completely undress myself and swim naked. I’d done this in our… in my father’s villa in the caldarium before, but never under the open sky, in the middle of the day and just on my own. But here? I’ve been alone for days now. The whole time, only one traveler had come by, and I’d been able to disguise myself as just another traveler that would leave the place soon enough. So I have no sorrow in stripping out of all my clothes, taking a nude swim and running around like this until I am dry again. It is an unbelievable, calming feeling of freedom. I enjoy drying in the sun, and my skin already got a nice brown tan. Beside a certain pain deep down, never in my entire life have I felt as good, as free as now. And I promised to myself that I never lose this feeling again. If it weren’t for this spike, this tug, this well-known nagging in my heart, I would be completely content with myself. It's the first time in my life I feel like that.

I sigh.
Soon it will be time to move further, because I don't know if my father, Caesar, Cleopatra or some of their allies – or even Catra - are still searching for me. They turned Buhen upside down and even crossed the second cataract upwards after with search parties. Presumably they have given up, but I’d rather not bet my freedom – or my life – on it. The old patrician families of the Roman Republic are annihilating each other, right now, in these very years. The old Republic, with all her virtues, is vanishing, and no one knows what will rise instead. Of course, uncle Julius will have his hand in the game, and his means are vast. With the sole power over the whole empire in his hands, he can do nearly

anything. And Cleopatra is on his side, willingly and dedicated to keep this alliance intact at all cost. And to raise their mutual son for taking power some day. She plays a very long and dedicated game.
But I won’t play anymore. Should they, but without me.

(The Way - Main Title Theme (Deezer / Spotify))

And Catra? She made her choice. I had reached out for her, I’d held out my hand, and she didn’t take it. It was her decision to stay as well as it was mine to leave. I wouldn’t change what I’d done, but still, my heart aches for her and still, I cry about the loss at least once a day. It always tugs at my heart, to go back, back to her, to surrender and hope for the best. There isn't one single day I don't ponder about that, to give in, to see her one single time again, to hold her, even for the price of everything I am now.

But then, on some evenings, when I lie on my blanket and look into the nightly, star-studded sky, I feel incredibly satisfied with my life. The lights on the firmament sparkle so beautiful, that it fills my heart with so much joy that it might burst. When the air cools down from the heat of the day, a light breeze gently brushes over my face. Here, deep in the Nubian desert and offside of caravan routes, I’m all on my own, alone, for the first time in my life.
And it soothes me so much.
Never have I been so calm and confident in myself. If it wasn't for the fact that I spend every day with hours reminiscing about the mutual days and nights with Catra, I would be completely happy here.

I do, though.

And only very slowly, very, very slowly, I make progress. I assure myself that I have time. Life lies before me. And I try to deceive myself of the fact that deep down in me, I know that the feeling of loss and longing will never go away.

It’s day. I sit at the water beneath a palm tree, on my blanket, and I am mending my tunic. The poor clothing has started to wear out. There are three tears in the fabric and I need to patch them. In some time, I will have to buy a new one, I realize and sigh to myself. All in all, the thought of going into a village or town doesn’t really please me. But I also need some other stuff, so my time at this wonderful place will come to an end soon. Maybe I can come back here again later?
And why not?
It isn't that I have any goals to achieve right now. The thought about coming back eases me, because I really like it here. It is quiet. It is peaceful.

It is nearly perfect.

Realizing that I’d been staring at the horizon for some time, I snap back to my mending. I catch myself doing this too often, just staring at the vast desert.
Not much time passes, when I can hear someone behind me. The person is walking down the dune in my back, but they are loud enough to make them heard. Ever since I'd been stabbed in the back on my way to Catra, I've become hyperaware of my surroundings. Nothing escapes my attention anymore, regardless how much I worry about whatever. Back in my mind, a little part of me is always on the watch, always awake, always *aware*. But this noise is neither hostile nor sneaky, I feel that. Too slow, too loud, too… familiar it is.
The noise ebbs away as the person comes to a halt, still a little away. They breathe, then a hoarse, raspy voice speaks up from behind: “I’ve heard rumors about a weird tall woman, that is living all alone, at oases in the desert. She shall be fierce and strong. I didn’t believe that, and had to look for myself. Just in case… you know… if she’s a threat to the realm. And we don't need bossy Romans living here and telling us what to do.”

The voice falls as dry as the joke, and it is silent for a while. I don’t turn around, because I already know everything I need. My hands shake a little, and I stop sewing. Previous me would’ve been giddy, maybe angsty, maybe fearsome. But today I’m a different person. I am someone I like. I'm confident of myself. And the shaking isn’t one because of fear. The person behind me audibly inhales. Her voice is something between angry and angsty now. “Do you even know how many fucking oases I had to search until I found you?” The person seems shaky. I still don’t look, but I also don’t need to.

I just smile, and finish my last few stitches, then I fold the tunic neatly and lay my tools aside.

Suddenly, my vision is blurry and my eyes are watery when I get up and turn around. Is it sweat? Or rather tears? I wipe the sweat out of my eyes and blink. I need a few times to be able to see, and when I do…

There she is, all alone, all herself.

She’s wearing the scarf I bought her, back in Alexandria, in another life that now is long gone for good. It's draped over her head to shield her from the sun. She looks beautiful, but there is also no way that she ever wouldn’t.

We look at each other. She has a few more marks and a new scar in her face that runs across her cheek, down to her jaw. But I've also not been unharmed, and I know I look different. But who cares. Spreading my arms, I smile. And the sweaty, dusty, tired-looking woman lights up and throws herself in. When her body touches mine, every fiber in me heats up like the glowing sun. She is real, I can smell her, I can feel her. I don't care about the sweat and dust. Her scent is like always. Cedarwood. Lavender. Herself. She smells like home, and I inhale her deeply as she whispers, “I love you. I always have.”

I whimper while embracing her, then I press her even closer to me. And I laugh. It just bubbles out of me without any restraint. I

laugh so much because of relief, of joy. A lifetime of weight falls off of me. “Y- You love me,” I say, no, I stutter because my breath is taken away, then I bury my face deeper into her neck and want to stay there forever. “You love me,” I repeat, more firmly. And now, finally, finally, I can believe it. There is no doubt anymore. She came for me, she found me. I have her in my arms. She is here.

I will never let her go again.

“You love me,” I say to the happily smiling woman in my arms, and I finally know it is true and it is so much more. It is more than a promise.
“I love you too.” I smile so much it’s making my face hurt. But I don’t care. “I love you too,” I say again. And again. I will do it many more times.

Now, we have all the time in the world ahead of us. It lays before us, and it is ours to discover. It is what we *decide* to make out of it.

Now, it is perfect.

Decades later

“Come here, Nashwa. Sit down with your grandfather.” The old man is cumbersome as he pats on his knee, looking at his still so little granddaughter. He likes to watch her while she plays. The dark-skinned girl's wild curls frame her round face, her appearance completely contrary to her personality. She is a wildfang, a tomgirl, a rough and untamed whirlwind, who brings nothing but chaos and disorder to his life, but she’s the light of his eyes.

“But grandpa! I want to—” the little rascal grumbles, not willing to be interrupt in whatever she has focused her short-lived attention now.
But he is experienced, and has his means. “Have I ever told you the adventurous story about Cat-Ra and She-Ra, little one?” he asks kindly, knowing that stories like that always catch her attention.
Looking up from her pastime, Nashwa glances at him with wide eyes and asks: “Nooo? Who is She-Ra? Is she a goddess? Like Pasht?”
He chuckles and knows he got her. “Oh, she is much more than that. Come, sit with me, and I’m gonna tell you. But you have to listen carefully, because their story is precious and full of wonders. You must know that the warrior goddess She-Ra is nothing like our other gods. She was born in another land, far, far away over the sea.” He makes a short, artificial pause, then asks: “Have I ever told you of the city of Rome—”

Nashwa eyes go even wider. “Ooohhh. Rome. Is that where Caesar Augustus reigns?”
“Oh good, you paid attention, didn’t you?” He ruffles her hair and is proud that she actually remembers some of his tellings. “And she was a Roman too. She and Cat-Ra fought for the people, for their friends, for their family for a long time, and their story is on the edge of greatness, little girl.” He takes a sip of water while Nashwa shuffles into his lap.
“But it’s a long story, and you must let me tell it from the beginning. Do you want some water first? Or a date?” The questions come out with a little smile.
“Grandpaaa”, the girl whines, clearly eager to hear the story and long familiar with his little tricks to increase the tension. But he has always been so, and that will never change. She knows her grandfather has the best stories to tell, and she's eager to hear this one.
He chuckles. “Good, good, sweetie. So, once upon a time…”

Afterword

(AO3's character limit for notes forced me to put this into the chapter text)

So, here we are. You didn't hear much from me during this story, now you have an overly lengthy afterword.

Thank you, dear reader, for coming this long way. I could've done a fluffy epilogue, but actually, I told everything I wanted to tell regarding their journey. I wrote this ending back in May and during all the the detours the plot of the story took, this never changed. I like it melodramatically, moody. Victories have many faces, and the girls won theirs in the end. It is, was counts.

When I started writing "The Siege of Alexandria" in the end of April, I expected a story of around 85,000 words in 12 chapters, given my oh-so-well-planned outline. In hindsight, I was naive. But that was good, because writing down around 190,000 words of a fan-fiction in an historic setting in four months as a hobby would have sounded a bit too much in advance. Luckily, I was. And I had a tremendously hard and educational time writing this beast, and I hope you had fun reading it. Because, actually, I wrote this for me, but I would also be glad if you enjoyed my work. Regardless if you have critique or praise, do not hesitate to comment.

Doing the research for this story, I found valuable insight in the subsequent sources. I read much of the stuff, and tried to stick to reality for most of the events - this being one of the reasons for this ending. But I deviated in minor routes and when the plot demanded it, I let some things out. I also condensed the actual Siege due to dramatic reasons. This is not a history book, and reality and fiction are interwoven. Writing a story like this is something I always wanted to do, and it is thanks to *She-Ra and*

Princesses of Power that I felt motivated to do it. I did it on my own, and all shortcomings, failures, inaccuracies and exaggerations are on me.

Finally, I want to say a few more words about Cleopatra, because I used her in many ways here and want to set some points right. I am not aware of any accurate pictorial representations of Cleo at the age of around 21, at which this story takes place. I also don't find any of her fictional portrayals in films, series, books or games that I know to be satisfactory, and in my head, she's more like I have described her here than anywhere else where I've seen her. However, I like this short animated movie, depicting a young female Pharaoh struggling with her duties. And if you think I portrayed Cleo in a conflicted way, complicated to understand, I managed to do it as I wanted to. As we know so little about Cleopatra for real, I leave it to your imagination.

However, you should know the following:

At the age of 13, young Cleopatra actually witnessed the beheading of her sister on behalf of their father. From the age of 18 on, Cleopatra reigned Egypt for 21 years, until she was 39 and took her own life when ultimately being defeated by the first long-lasting superpower of the ancient world. She was the first female Pharaoh of Egypt in centuries who successfully reigned on her own, enlarged her realm, and proved herself a capable leader of her nation. She stabilized the currency, expanded the Egyptian influence, captured the minds and hearts of two of the most important Romans of her time - and history - and used their power to support her own country. It’s obvious that Cleo was clever, strong-willed and dedicated.
However, she couldn’t prevail against the will of an emperor Octavian, whom she misjudged and who was dedicated to annihilate her at all cost, with the power of the far superior forces of the whole Roman Empire at his hands. He would need 13 years to get rid of her.

When she finally lost the war against Octavian alongside Marcus Antonius, she ended her life on her own, not willing to be used as a tool by Octavian for to be shown around as a defeated enemy and possibly strangled to death in the Colosseum like others. She was presumably buried next to Antonius in Egypt, because Octavian was as generous in victory as he was cruel and clever in war. The site of their mutual tomb remains unknown, if it still exists.
After her passing, Egypt became a province of the Roman Empire for centuries, ending the line of the Ptolemaic dynasty and of Egypt as an independent nation with her. Octavian killed her and Caesar's son, Caesarion, at the age of 17. The trace of her three surviving children with Marcus Antonius are lost in the haze of time, and no reliable accounts of their fate have made it until today.

Chapter End Notes

Sources:

- Caesar’s first-hand comments about the events in Commentaries on the Civil War/Book 3, Chapter 107 until the end and Commentarii de bello Alexandrino - Wikisource till chapter 34.
- http://www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus%3Atext%3A1999.02.0076%3Abook%3D3%3Achapter%3D106
- A hell of a bunch of Wikipedia articles about Cleopatra and her reign, Ptolemaic Egypt and all the real characters that appeared in this story.
- The “Stanford Geospatial Network Model of the Roman World” is a ridiculously feature rich and detailed map of the navigable road, river and sea routes network,

spanning three continents and provided me with valuable information regarding travel times.
- A nice drawing of Alexandria, as well as these https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Maps_of_ancient_Alexandria
- An essay on Buhen: https://yare.org/essays/fortresses.htm
- An interview / short talk about Sappho with a reading of one of her poems in ancient Greek: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pGq1mDYSDnQ

A livid imagination of Egypt under Cleopatra's rule is provided in these Youtube-Videos. Like everything which is said or written about her, take it with a grain of salt, as we know so little about her for sure.

- Misunderstood Moments in History - Cleopatra's Egypt
- Cleopatra & the Siege of Alexandria (48 to 47 B.C.E.)
- History Summarized: Cleopatra
- Cleopatra - women which wrote history, a well-made German documentation, the subtitles are working quite okay

You gone, why am I so alone?

Chapter Summary

> Come to me now, too, and free me from cruel
> cares, and do what my heart longs to
> see done, and you yourself
> be my ally.

Chapter Notes

> January 2022: During the recent days, I had the great pleasure of accompanying *MendhiSamadhi* through her reading of this story. She commented a lot in many chapters along the way, gave valuable feedback on many topics, and had a very kind approach overall. Her detailed and thoughtful comments are something every fanfiction author can only dream of. A truly wonderful and charming experience. I recommend paying her Twitter- and AO3-profiles a visit, because she writes cool stuff too, and makes adorable and sometimes nasty Catradora-drawings worth your time.
>
> Thus, because of our discussions, reading and thinking about parts of my story again, all of this sparked my imagination and the wish to add a little piece to it. It's partly a gift for her. So, here you have a glimpse into the near future (and of course more history stuff because I cannot not).
> Please, enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This place is so dead," Catra grumbles and pokes around at the shards and pieces of what must have been bowls or vases or just plates with her foot. Then she kicks a shard, or rather, she wants to kick it but gets stuck in the sand, and super, now she has sand in her boot, which is just the worst! She hates sand in her boot. Ugh!
She settles down on the edge of the remnants of a wall beside her

and unties the boot to empty the dirt from it. “I need a bath, really,” she says to herself, while scratching the little sand grains out. She hates sand in her boot, and between her toes, and so she keeps her boots very, very clean. Which is quite a challenge in the desert, because, huh, you guessed it, there is typically a lot of sand around.
As she puts it back on and lashes the leather straps around her lower thighs, she looks around between the few vestiges of human presence in this forsaken part of the world. Well, not really forsaken. It’s just that the desert isn’t very lively. It's vast, hot, bright, and no one lives here.
She feels a bit alone.
But Adora has vanished and is no more to be seen. “Why?”, Catra murmurs, and scratches her head, then repeats sighing, “Why me?” She knows she's a little dramatic, but well, nobody sees her and the ruins don’t have or give an answer to her pathetic antics. They just are.

“Yay!”, it sounds from wherever her exuberant companion, girlfriend, partner, wife or whatever they are today is, then the woman squeaks happily because she apparently discovered something new.
Or rather, something old.
A moment later, Catra hears a few stones crumbling, presumably bricks falling apart, then a cloud of dust emerges from a hole in the ground a few meters away. It is followed by coughing and then a merry sound as Adora pops her head out of said hole between two crumbled, low stone walls, waving with her hands. The frantic movement makes her ponytail swirl as she holds something dark up, beaming with joy. She’s still shoulder-deep in the sunken ruin, and she makes Catra smile even when the brunette is in a grumpy mood.

Like now.

Adora’s sight always makes Catra smile, she just can’t think of reacting any other way. Adora glances at her in the sunlight, and she smiles. Adora curls into her in the night, and she smiles. Adora nudges her shoulder when she thinks she has to underline

one of her goofy jokes with it, and Catra smiles. Adora looks out of a ruin in the sand like a meerkat, waving at her, and Catra smiles.
The woman is so annoyingly wonderful, and, throughout the last months of enjoying her freedom, became so lively and adventurous that it's nearly unbearable.

Sometimes, the richness of her feelings for Adora scare the shit out of Catra. In the morning hours, when it’s still dark, and they are still sleepy, when the mood is somber and full of fears, Catra cuddles – or rather clings – onto Adora, breathing in the meadowy scent of the sleeping woman. She sometimes still can’t believe that they are together, that they are free.

That Adora is here, beside her, under her. *Hers.* Catra often drapes herself over the other woman in a deep need to be as close to Adora as physically possible. When they are lying like that, Catra’s naked breasts touching Adora’s, it’s sometimes still not enough. Then she fists her hands into Adora’s hair, pulls a little so that Adora has to put her head in the neck, and Catra nuzzles her nose against Adora’s throat, sucks slowly and leaves hickeys all over it. Adora sleepily giggles when she does it, and the faint laughs and snorts that escape her are just adorable. They mostly end up making love with each other, then.

Now Adora tilts her head, a quizzical look in her eyes, and Catra knows she’s smiling. She loves the woman so much. It would be annoying and overly sweetish, if it weren't so wonderful.

It’s still surprising how well-oiled Adora reacts to Catra’s often needy, demanding manners with an ingrained patience and a hard willingness to satisfy her wishes. When they rest at an oasis and have bathed, they often don’t even care about getting dressed, instead they just run around naked until their bodies have dried and their skin got warm again. A loincloth for a bit of comfort when sitting is mostly all they dress in then. Catra doesn’t even want to put something on, because it’s nearly always a waste of time.
All it takes are some of her usual glances, roaming hungrily over

Adora's perfect body, then a soft kiss on her forehead. She then stands up and pretends to be disinterested, looking away into the desert, and finds herself being pressed against the next palm with a low and amused hum. Adora is soft and firm at the same time. It's also the first time in her life that she actually enjoys being the receiving partner. Letting herself being taken by the strong blonde is nothing but pure pleasure. Adora quickly found out that Catra really likes it when she fondles and teases a breast with one hand and her clit with the other one from behind. She whispers 'Love you' and 'Good girl' into Catra's ears, and over time, she even got the hang of using some more steamy phrases.

She's clearly no good girl anymore. Catra freaks out when Adora does it. And it's good they are in the desert, because no one besides them can hear it, when Catra screams Adora's and other goddesses name's loudly when she comes, swearing love to the woman who takes her so well. Adora has proven to be a fast learner and during their time together, she became the perfect lover. They got perfect for each other.

But now, Catra is sweaty and feels dirty.
She can feel the salty layer of dust on her skin, and needs a bath, even for hours before they stumbled upon these ruins. It seems to have been a tiny settlement around a small temple complex at a former oasis, somewhere in the great Descheret[140] of Kush, westwards of Tabo. Former, because the oasis of this depression must have fallen dry or just vanished into the ever moving dunes decades ago and was no more. A few shattered walls here, the trunk of a dead palm there, the far remainder of a house is all what is left from a place where humans lived a long time ago for whatever reason.
Descheret is filled with such places, and they remain sturdy tributes of the useless stubbornness of man to whatever being is laughing upon their antics and struggles. Because in the long run, Descheret always wins.

"Look! I found a book! Isn't that awesome?" Adora looks a bit dusty, with sand falling off her cape, and it's even in her hair.
"You're such a nerd," Catra replies while looking down at the

beaming woman, but her voice is full of warmth as she helps her out of the hole. Adora got used to Catra's antics well during the last months, and she snickers as she climbs up.
"Hey, it's actually interesting to look out for something not only for a purpose. The room must've been something like a library for the priests. There was a hidden shelf with a few scrolls and papyri and writings on leather behind a wall that crumbled. And they are still in good shape. They were stored in a stone box, so I assume the dry climate helped to preserve them well, huh?"

"A hidden shelf, huh? I get it, bookworm," Catra giggles, rolling her eyes amicably. "Wanna show me what you found?"
"Yeah. Some were clearly religious texts in a weird Demotic writing. We can't read it. But this here seems promising." Adora hands over a staple of bound pieces of something that looks like very old parchment. Catra picks up one of the folded pieces and opens it carefully. Several lines beneath lines are written over it with black ink, not too long, only several words per line, and they make up a… "It's a poem," she confirms. The letters are familiar, and both women know how to read them because it's written in Greek. Ancient Greek, but it's still understandable. She opens a few more of them, and it's all the same. Poems, some of them short to a few lines, others a little longer, there's even a text looking like a short story over two parchment pieces. Catra smiles back at Adora: "Well, I clearly haven't expected to stumble over some ancient Greek writings here. Good girl."

Adora grins at the tease, because yeah, she has been a *good girl*. But not now. "Well, I haven't either. But isn't it fascinating? Let me have a look at them, please? We have some time left, don't we? And we can even walk in the dark. The oasis isn't that far away, right? An hour?"
"Well, yeah," Catra has to nod. They aimed for a still fed oasis around half an iteru away and were halfway there when the stumbled upon this non-place. The oasis is only a little one, a small pond with a dozen of palms and much undergrowth around, lying in a depression between the dunes, shielded by a low rock formation to the west and south.
They've already been there two months ago, but came from

another direction. It seemed to be sparsely visited, and the perfect place for spending some time again, just to be alone and to enjoy their mutuality. Again and again, it turned out that this was what they really wanted.
Time, just for them. They didn't much else at the moment.

"Cool," Adora replies and starts pleasuring herself with reading Ancient Greek poems from an unknown author someone weird collected in this gods-forsaken place maybe a century ago. How good can it be? Catra rolls her eyes with fondness, because her companion is such a nerd, and she loves her for all of it. A glance at the sky assures her that they have time. It's not that they have any errands to run, she muses.

"I know this one!" Adora shouts excitedly, making Catra giggle again. "It's '*Ode to Aphrodite*', a poem written by Sappho. It is one of her few works of which we know. And the others are all similar in rhyme, so I assume, all these texts are from her. It's called the Sapphic stanza, a verse form of four lines Sappho created herself. It has three long lines followed by one shorter one." She looks at Catra expectantly, then shrugs her shoulders. "I was taught this during my lectures. Catullus, one of our… of the more expressive Roman poets admired her creation very much, and he even imitated her in his own poems. He made her a little prominent in Rome in the last decade. We had him at our house, on a few occasions, and he taught me how to make her texts work."
Catra listened to the serenade Adora holds with growing curiosity and warm admiration. Nothing was more enticing than Adora rambling about something she knew about, with her overflowing, unbridled energy she scooped from wherever.
"It's a pity that I don't have a lyre with me. But here, listen to this!", Adora says, settles down on the ground before Catra, clears her throat, holds the parchment before herself with outstretched arms, and then falls into a weird singsong.

To Catra's surprise, it turns out that, apparently, Sappho's poems were not for being recited. They were meant to be *sung*. Adora's voice is bright as a bell and enticing like the goddess of love.

Immortal Aphrodite on your golden throne,
daughter of Zeus, wile-weaver, I beg you,
don't crush my spirit, queen,
with anguish and pain:

but come here, if ever before,
hearing my cries from far away,
you left your father's golden house
and came here

with your chariot yoked, and beautiful
quick-winged birds led you over the dark earth,
fluttering their fast wings down from heaven
through midair.

Soon they arrived, and you, blessed one,
with a smile on your immortal face,
asked me what had happened now and
why I had called you

and what I wanted more than anything to happen
in my crazy heart. "Whom should I persuade now
to love you? Who, oh Sappho, is
doing you wrong?

For if she runs now, soon she'll follow,
and if she won't accept gifts, soon she'll give them,
and if she doesn't love now, soon she'll love you,
even reluctantly."

Come to me now, too, and free me from cruel
cares, and do what my heart longs to
see done, and you yourself
be my ally.

Adora's melodic singing[141] falls silent, and Catra needs a moment to snap out of her dreamy haze. She didn't really get how hypnotized she got by the sound of Adora's falling and rising voice. Then she frowns at the blonde. Why did she stop? This was

beautiful to listen to, and she wants to know how it continues.
"And?", she half begs, half demands.
"Sorry, the text ends there. I think it is all," Adora replies, shrugging, giving her an apologizing smile.
"Well, of course it is," Catra sighs. She plops down from her seat on the wall and scoops Adora up. "That was beautiful. How about you take them with you, and you sing them to me in the evening again?"
She gets eager nodding by a smiling, blonde woman. "Sure. At least we have something to read for a while. As far as my teacher told me, few of Sappho's poems made it, and who knows, maybe we found some long-lost. Wouldn't that be awesome?"

Two hours later, they've settled down at the oasis they wanted to reach today, and the sun has already set. Behind them, the red rock emanates the warmth of the days, and will keep them comfy and shielded for the night.
To Adora's luck, there is still enough light to read, but only for a few minutes. They made no fire, because why? They don't need it. Adora lies on her blanket and reads one of the parchments.
"Here, listen, it's just a sentence left: *'In the midst of night, time passes by, and I sleep alone.'* And here, another one reads: *'You gone, why am I so alone?'*
She cooks her head. "This sounds a bit sad. What was she thinking when she wrote it?"

Catra settles down beside her, stretching on her own cover. She's tired from the day, from the walking, and she feels how her body needs to rest, and yawns. "Yeah, it does. Maybe she mourned the loss of someone? Or maybe she just wants to tell us that she's no slut and doesn't sleep around."
Adora huffs. "Hehe. Maybe. It's often hard to understand her without any background. And one of her poems is just plain mockery of one of her brothers. Apparently he's allowed himself some rude jokes around the town hall, and she teases him about

it. It’s a bit nasty, actually.” Giggling softly, she adds: “I think she was funny to be around.”

Catra rests her head against Adora’s side, then on her chest, and stares into the clear sky where stars appear as dusk is advancing. She can sense Adora shifting behind her, then she feels how Adora’s chest rises and falls slowly as she breathes, while Adora scrawls her hair and head. It’s the most calming feeling Catra ever experienced. It makes her feel cozy, and comfortable, and so so secure.
“Well. I’m glad that I’m not sleeping alone,” Catra says earnestly. “I was okay to be alone for so long, and now I can’t imagine a life without you. It’s just the two of us, but it is enough, you know?”
Adora hums in approval, and after a few moments of silents, Catra adds sleepily: “You are enough for me, Adora. You are more than enough.” She wants to look into the eyes of the woman she loves and to lose herself in the blue orbs.
But she doesn’t need to because is Adora is here. It's enough to know, and feel, and sense her.
The sky is above and it is warm.
A gentle breeze comforts her skin.
The rise and fall of Adora's chest beneath her is all she needs.
Silence embraces them.

Adora still pets Catra’s curly and unruly hair with slow, long strikes for a while. The quiet sound of the wind moving sand around them accompanies her.
“I feel the same, my love. You are the best thing ever happened to me, Catra. Without you, I would’ve never found the courage to do what I wanted. Thank you.”
The other woman replies nothing, she just breathes calmly.
Adora looks down into Catra’s beautiful face. Her eyes are closed, and when she puts a curl aside, nothing happens. Catra has fallen asleep, and looks all calm. Nothing like the tense, composed women she was when she got to know her.
As it should be, Adora thinks and sighs, but she does it with a smile on her face and pulls a tip of the blanket over Catra, not because it got cold, but because she wants to comfort her.

Then she lays back, closes her own eyes, and is unbelievably satisfied. Next to her is the love of her life, around them is their freedom and an undetermined future ahead, above her is the star-studded sky, and it will still be there for them to watch over the course of their mutual life.
She can look at it tomorrow.
With her wife.
All is well.

Sappho 16

Some say a force of horsemen, some say infantry
and others say a fleet of ships is the loveliest
thing on the dark earth, but I say it is
the one you love.

It is altogether simple to make this understood
since she whose beauty outmatched all,
Helen, left her husband
a most noble man.

And went sailing to Troy
Without a thought for her child and dear parents
[Love] made her completely insane
And led her astray.

This reminds me of absent Anactoria
I would rather watch her lovely walk
and see the shining light of her face
than Lydian chariots followed by
infantrymen in arms. [142]

Chapter End Notes

About Sappho: Living from 630 to 570 BCE, the Greek poet *Psapphō* was an enormously productive and literate woman.

Even in her times and the centuries afterwards, she was regarded as one of the greatest lyric poets. She was highly appreciated because of her clear and expressive language and given names likes “Tenth Muse" and "The Poetess" in comparison to Homer as “The Poet” by influential ancient authors. In 1798, the great poet and philosopher Friedrich Schlegel even said: *"If we just had all Sapphic poems: perhaps nowhere would we be reminded of Homer."* Quite a statement, given Homer's status in the classical studies.
Little of her work has survived, unfortunately. Interesting is, that the connection of Sappho and her place of birth, Lesbos, to the common term “Lesbianism” for love between women is something that emerged only centuries after she died, in the Hellenistic period. Some authors regarding her as a *woman-lover* did it in slanderous intent.
Until today, Sappho's sexuality is debated and unknown. A part of the attribution stems from the fact that as of around 591 BCE, when she returned to Lesbos after a time of being away, and was already at the beginning of her forties, she started gathering a group of younger girls and women around her and taught them poetry, music, singing and dancing. In a time when schools were barely a thing, even more so for women, this would be regarded at least with curiosity and contributed to her perception more than 200 years later. We know she wanted to teach them, but not much more. She presumably had a husband and a daughter with him. However, due to the loss of her works and further evidence about her life, we know that we know little about her, and her story remains fascinating. Many of her poems can be read here.

[140] The word ‘descheret’ or 'deshret', written as ‘Dšr.t’ means the Red Land of Egypt, in opposition to ‘Kemet’, the Black Land which describes the fertile black soil near the Nile and along the Nile valley. Descheret is also pointing towards southern Egypt, where the Nile valley is narrow and flows through rocky, deserted lands, and where mostly desert is.

Beside that the English word ‘desert” origins from the Latin word “desertum”, which means an abandoned place, it is striking how similar it itself is to the much older ‘Dšr.t’, isn’t it? ↑

[141] Sappho’s poems were probably always meant to be recited by using a lyre or a cithara. In Ancient Greek, it may have sounded like this. And if you wanna hear how and listen to a lyre being played, you’re welcomed here. ↑

[142] Please read this for further explanation.↑

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